
spade brother
Chaotic
HARDBACK PART 1
USA TODAY & WALL STREET JOURNAL BESTSELLING AUTHOR
SHANTEL TESSIER

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Chaotic
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WARNING

For those of you who choose to go in blind, please remember that this dark romance is a work of fiction, and I do NOT condone any situations or actions that take place between these characters. This book is not to teach you BDSM, so please do not take it as a how-to. My FMCs (female main characters) love their Heroes as they are—unapologetic.

With that being said, every character does go through some kind of trauma (physical and emotional) at some point in this story. If you've read any of the previous Lords (highly suggested before reading *Chaotic* due to spoilers), then you have an idea of what their world is like. But I promise you, they have nothing on the Spade brothers. They wrote the book and then sold it to the devil. So buckle up and get ready for one hell of a ride.

Feel free to continue to the prologue if you're like me and have no triggers and like to be surprised, but just remember that I warned you. If you do NOT want to go in blind, please read the trigger warnings & kinks listed below.

Chaotic may contain triggers for some.

Trigger Warnings include but are not limited to: Murder and torture (both in graphic detail), forced branding/piercing, grooming, child loss/miscarriage, infertility, parental death, suicide, attempted suicide, self-harm, survivors guilt, human/sex trafficking, rape, incestual rape, forced drugging, sensory deprivation, predicament bondage, breath play, forced orgasm, forced sterilization, forced breeding, orgasm denial, humiliation, degradation, forced proximity,

drugs and alcohol abuse, torture bondage, pain slut, e-stimulation, flaying, child abuse/neglect.

If you have any questions, feel free to email me, and one of my assistants or I will get back to you. darkangelcreationsllc@gmail.com

AUTHOR'S NOTE:

Nothing about this is to be taken seriously. It is strictly a work of fiction and for your spicy pleasure.

Chaotic is an all-new dark romance within the Lords world from the *USA Today* & *Wall Street Journal* bestselling author Shantel Tessier. *Chaotic* is based in the #1 Amazon bestselling Lords world, and it is highly suggested to start with *The Ritual.* If you have not read any previous Lords book(s), *Chaotic* will contain spoilers for you.

The Lords reading order is as follows: The Ritual

The Sinner

The Sacrifice Sabotage (the H isn't a Lord, but he works for a Lord)
Carnage

Madness

Chaotic

Things to know about ***Chaotic***: Secret society MF

J/P (jealous/possessive) Hero OTT (over the top) Hero Dark romance

Told in dual POV

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PLAYLIST

"Coming Down" by Five Finger Death Punch "DOPAMINE" by Kami Kehoe
"Lullaby" by Niykee Heaton "Don't Let Me Down" by The Chainsmokers and Daya "THE PURGE" by In This Moment "Push" by Matchbox Twenty
"Wonderland" by Natalia Kills "So Called Life" by Three Days Grace "Crazy House" by Princess Nokia "Make Me (Cry)" by Noah Cyrus and Labrinth "Birthday Cake" by Rihanna "Wasteland" by 10 Years
"Call Me" by Shinedown
"Follow You Home" by Nickelback "Hallelujah" by No Resolve "angel" by Camylio
"Never Too Late" by Three Days Grace "I Found" by Amber Run
"Change (In the House of Flies)" by Deftones "The Red" by Chevelle
"Sorry" by Halsey
"Everything in My Mind" by Nevertel "Dance With The Devil" by Breaking Benjamin "Never Leave" by Seether
"Truly Madly Deeply" by Savage Garden "Hallelujah" by No Resolve "Hate Me" by Blue October
"Fall Back" by Lithe
"Apologize" by Timbaland and OneRepublic "Fire Up the Night" by New Medicine "Sweat" by Open Till L8
"Even If It Kills Me" by Papa Roach "Comedown" by Bush
"The Kill (Bury Me)" by Thirty Seconds To Mars "Power Over Me" by Dermot Kennedy "Hallelujah" by No Resolve "Where I Left You" by HOLLOWFRAME

“Lifetime” by Three Days Grace “Iris” by The Goo Goo Dolls “Whiskey Lullaby” by Brad Paisley and Alison Krauss “Hold On” by Chord Overstreet

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Part One

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PROLOGUE

L.O.R.D.

A Lord takes his oath seriously. Only blood will solidify their commitment to serve those who demand their complete devotion.

*He is a **Leader**, believes in **Order**, knows when to **Rule**, and is a **Deity**.*

A Lord must be initiated in order to become a member but can be removed at any time for any reason. If he makes it past the three trials of initiation, he will forever know power and wealth. But not all Lords are built the same. Some are stronger, smarter, hungrier than others.

*They are challenged just to see how far their **loyalty** will go.*

*They are pushed to their limits in order to prove their **devotion**.*

*They are willing to show their **commitment**.*

Nothing except their life will suffice.

Limits will be tested, and morals forgotten.

A Lord can be a judge, jury, and executioner. He holds power that is unmatched by anyone other than his brother.

Chosen one:

A Lord must remain celibate during his first three years at Barrington University. Once he is initiated into the Lords, he is gifted a chosen for his senior year.

A Lady:

After they graduate from Barrington, they are to marry a Lady—a wife to serve him. If he shall die before her, she is then gifted to another Lord to ensure the secrets are kept within the secret society.

A Spade brother:

A Lord is placed strategically out into the world. But no Lord is safe from their own if they break their oath. If you don't believe in hell, the Spade brothers will change your mind. They are a special kind of Lord. They will sit on their thrones and watch you burn to death for eternity with the fire they started. They give no fucks and have no limits. They collect the names they are given, and erase you from the world as if you never existed, and make you wish that was the truth.

Founder:

A founder is special to the Lords. Above the rest. A woman within the Lords' world who is a founder is sentenced to a life as a breeder if she fails her assignment for initiation.

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ONE



KASHTON

INITIATION

Loyalty

Freshman year at Barrington University

I sit in the corner of the cell, legs bent and forehead resting on my knees. I'm trying to stay present. Not live in the past.

It's the silence that gets me. The cold chill in my bones and the ghost that haunts this hell.

"Sometimes you have to hurt the one you love."

She speaks to me all the time. In my dreams, throughout the day. There's no escape.

Days I've been locked in here. Hours and hours of being left with my mind. My father wants me to be disoriented, second-guessing myself.

Weak and vulnerable.

It's a test that he wants to see me fail. He'd rather throw me away because I didn't pass than tell them I couldn't be the son he needs.

I have compassion for others, and for a Lord that's unacceptable. They beat it out of you. "All you have is yourself," my father once said, but I don't believe him. I have my brothers. Adam, Saint, and Haidyn are my family. It doesn't matter that we're not blood. I'd die for them.

"Eat up, boy," a distorted male voice calls out. "You're going to need your strength."

I raise my head to glare across the cell and see a Lord dressed in a cloak and mask standing outside the door. For a society that thinks they're invincible, they sure do hide their true identities a lot.

He slides a plate with nothing more than a chocolate chip cookie floating in milk on it. The milk sloshes over the edge of the dish and onto the concrete floor.

The irony isn't lost on me.

My father is a sick prick. He wants me to break before I even get to prove myself. I'm pretty sure the only reason he had me was because the Lords forced him to do so.

A Lord is required to produce an heir. You have to pay your debt to the society, and to them, there's nothing better than another body to pledge their loyalty.

"Son?"

I take a deep breath before I see my father now standing in the hallway outside my cell. His hands shoved into the pockets of his dress slacks.

"Eat," he commands.

I look away from him, and my eyes scan the concrete walls. Tallies cover the surface. More than I can count.

They make my chest ache. Years and years of being caged makes you go insane. I've been in here for maybe three days and I already feel my mind slipping.

My father takes a step back from the bars and whistles. A Lord steps forward, unlocks the door, and enters.

There's no use in fighting. I need to save what little energy I have. He storms over to me, grabs my hair, and yanks me to my feet, only to throw his fist into my face.

The blow knocks me into the wall, and I fall to my knees. The room tilts and I blink rapidly to get my vision to focus.

I refuse to fight back. That's what they want, and I know this isn't the main event.

No. It'll be a big show in front of other Lords. This is just to make me tired, and I won't give them the very little energy I have left.

"Take care of him," my father orders before I see his blurry shoes turn and disappear down the hall.

My breath is taken away when a boot kicks me in the side, knocking me to my back.

A sound that has my ears ringing makes me flinch. I groan, lifting my heavy head to see I'm center stage in the arena at Carnage. Two stories, the stadium seating on the upper level lined with Lords.

Knew it.

There's always a bigger picture with the Lords. The cell was to wear me down. Drain me of my energy. It was a mind game that my father wanted to use to his advantage.

I was beaten until I passed out and relocated. A quick assessment of my body tells me I'm in bad shape.

It's hard to breathe. Think I've got a broken rib. A collapsed lung?

Fuck, maybe I'm just being dramatic, and everything is intensified due to lack of food and dehydration.

I've never had that fighter mentality like my brothers. I'd rather just fuck. But no, that's not allowed. Three fucking years, I can't get my dick sucked because the Lords want to control every aspect of my life.

Leaning my head back, I look up to my bloody and cuffed wrists. At least I'm no longer naked like I was in the cell. I'm dressed in jeans and boots.

"Kashton Landon Pierce." A man's voice rings out through the arena. "You have been called to serve. Do you wish to proceed?"

I groan but manage a nod. "I do, sir." As if we have a choice. We don't. They want us to willingly submit—to be their fucking puppets. Nothing about our lives is by chance. Everything is by design. One that they make sure benefits them.

"You may proceed," he states.

The sound of rolling wheels gets closer to me, and Devin walks up the steps onto the platform I'm displayed on. The Lords are always putting on a performance. A Spade brother is no exception. If anything, ours is meant to be bigger. Bloodier.

We're their entertainment. Rich old bastards with too much time on their hands.

"If you wanted to give me a physical, all you had to do was ask," I try to joke, but my voice is hoarse from lack of communication dur-

ing the days I was locked in the cell.

The corner of his lips twitch as he starts to fill the syringe from the vial.

I tense, knowing exactly what it is. Adrenaline. It'll last about twenty minutes and then I'll fucking crash.

Looking up, I fist my hands to see if I even have feeling in them. Thankfully I do. I haven't been hanging here for long.

Devin grabs a hold of a rag and shoves it into my mouth. I have enough time to bite down on it before he stabs me in the chest, momentarily taking my breath away.

My wrists are freed, and I drop to the floor. Ripping the cloth from my mouth, I grind my teeth, kneeling on my hands and knees.

Fuck! I'm gasping for a breath when a knife is dropped in front of me. "This is all you get," a Lord announces. "Good luck."

I'm surprised they even gave me a weapon.

The side door opens and a man enters the arena. He's around my height, at six five, but he's bigger in overall size. Probably has fifty pounds on me. I learned at a young age that it's not the size that matters but the speed.

He doesn't waste a second and makes a run for me.

I take the opportunity and throw the knife, but my aim is off and it flies right past his face.

"Goddammit," I hiss.

My body is tingling, my heart is racing. I'm shaking. I've got to try and calm my breathing so I can gain some control.

He hits me like a freight train, picking my boots up off the floor and carrying me backward with his momentum.

We hit the stage, knocking the breath out of me since I softened his fall. He recovers quickly, rearing his fist back to hit me in the face, but I shove my fist into his windpipe. He grips his neck, gasping for breath, and I kick him off me.

Getting to my feet, I grab his shirt, yanking him off the stage and onto the floor. He goes to get to his feet, but I kick him in the face, knocking his head back. Blood splatters my boots, and I do it again.

He groans, rolling to his side. I try to get my vision to clear as I scan the arena for the knife they gave me, but I can't see shit.

It’s the adrenaline. Everything is intensified. The lights are blinding and I’m sweating profusely.

“Fucking bitch.” He groans, getting to his hands and knees while blood drips from his busted face.

I kick him again. And again. I’ve never done drugs, but I imagine this is how they make you feel—unstoppable.

My skin tingles and the blood rushes in my ears. I can hear the whispers from the Lords watching from the second story. They want me to lose. Until you wear their brand on your chest, they want to watch you fail.

Spotting a blurry figure on the floor, I make my way over to it while my opponent rolls around, spitting out teeth. I pick it up and I notice my father across the arena.

Fucking piece of shit. I want to let the bastard down, but I know winning will upset him more.

I turn to face the guy I’m supposed to kill to see he’s made it to his feet. He stands with his hands fisted by his sides. His chest and jeans are covered in blood. He pulls his busted lips back, trying to be intimidating, but it’s useless when all he has is a blood-covered gummy smile.

I tighten my grip on the handle of the knife and widen my stance. Giving him a smile, I wait. He’ll come to me. Why work so hard when he can do it for me?

Letting out a scream, he rushes for me like before. But this time I’m ready.

I slam the knife into his stomach, stopping him in his tracks. I pull it out and he falls to his knees at my feet. I grip his hair, yank his head back, and slice his neck from ear to ear.

Stepping away, I watch the blood gush from the open wound and splatter onto my boots and jeans. I don’t even wait to see him drop to the floor. Instead, I turn to look at my father.

I hope he sees the irony.

Blinking, I fall to my knees. I’m losing my energy and fast. All of a sudden, the lights seem to flash and my breathing becomes labored.

I’m grabbed on both sides and dragged out of the arena knowing I passed. But it’s not a victory. It just bought me another year.

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TWO



KASHTON

INITIATION

Devotion

Sophomore year at Barrington University

I groan at the gnawing pain in the back of my head. A pounding fucking headache.

"The fuck?" I get to my wobbly legs. Placing my hand on the wall, I run the other down my face to see if I'm bleeding. Nothing. Then why do I feel like I got the shit beaten out of me?

"Hello?" I call out and look around. I'm in the elevator at Carnage. Of course I'm fucking here. I hate this goddamn place, and my father knows it. I'm only here when the Spade brothers force me to be.

I notice it's descending, and the button controls inform me I'm headed to the basement. "Fuck."

It's my initiation. Last thing I remember is my father calling me to his office. I thought it was odd, but he's always doing things that don't make sense to me. He offered me a brandy snifter that I couldn't object to.

Now I know why—he drugged me. The headache confirms it.

The door slides open and the cold air rushes into the confined space, followed by the smell of blood. More than usual.

Stepping off the elevator, I see the plastic strip curtains. Blood is splattered all over them and dripping off the bottom onto the floor. This is supposed to be my greatest fear. But he better try harder than this. Blood? It doesn't faze me.

A blood-curdling scream echoes throughout the concrete room, making my heart leap in my chest. "No." A sob follows. "Please…

don't…" she continues to beg.

I rush through the curtains, letting them slap me in the face. The pits are filled with blood. "What?" I rush over to them, dropping to my knees and shoving my hands through the bars, sloshing the blood around, trying to feel for a body, but there's nothing in them. I do the same to the others. Also empty.

"Where did all this blood come from?" I grind out.

"Please, don't hurt me…" the female cries.

I know that voice. "Ashtyn?" I shout, getting to my feet and rushing down the hallway to the cells. "Ashtyn?" It's Adam's twin sister. We grew up with her. He would kill me if I allowed anything to happen to her. Same with Saint. He's one of my best friends, and he's in love with her.

"Pl-ease?" Her voice cracks and my breathing accelerates.

"I'm coming, Ash. Where are you?" I quickly scan each cell on the left and right as I frantically make my way down the hallway. "Ashtyn?" I shout, starting to panic.

Coming to the last one on the right, I see her inside. "Ash—"

"Oh, thank God, Kash. Please, Kash. Please save me," she begs through a sob.

There's a metal table in the center of the cell. She's bent over the side, arms out, with her wrists secured to the front legs. Her legs are spread wide and connected to the table legs as well.

"Help me," she screams, pulling on the restraints.

I try to open the cell, but it's locked. "Fuck," I shout. "Hang on. I've got to get a key."

"Wait. No. Don't leave…"

I'm already running down the hallway back toward the pits. I go over to the locker and quickly scan the keys hanging there. Finding the one I want, I rush back to her. "I'm here, Ash. I'm here." I try to unlock it, but it's not working.

"Goddammit," I grind out, knowing this is the correct key. It has to be. "I—" My eyes scan the cell, and my words trail off when I see she now has a gag in her mouth. It's an O-ring, secured tightly around her cheeks and shoved behind her teeth. It's old. Rusted and jagged. Blood runs from her pried-open mouth and drips to the floor.

She's sobbing and yanking on the restraints.

A man steps out of the dark corner. He's dressed in black jeans, a Lords mask covering his face. He's shirtless, and I can see the Lords crest branded on his chest. "Don't fucking touch her," I shout. "Hang on, Ash. I'm coming."

The lock shakes in my hand while I try and shove the key into it, but it doesn't work. "Fuck." I drop the key, and I watch the Lord walk over to the table. Her wide, red-rimmed eyes look at him over her shoulder in horror. I wrap my bloody hands around the bars and yank on them in a desperate attempt to get to her.

She sobs through the gag and her small body trembles. "Hang on, Ashtyn." I run down the hallway again. I rush back to the locker to grab more keys. Maybe I'm not thinking clearly. The drugs are fogging my brain, and I just grabbed the wrong one. But they're all gone. There's nothing there.

I run both blood-covered hands through my hair and sprint back down the hall. My heart racing at the possibility of what the Lord could do to her if I don't save her.

My steps slow as I approach her cell. She's lying across the table she's tied to. The Lord standing behind her. His jeans are undone, down by his ankles. The table rattles from his hard thrusts while he rapes her.

"I'm going to kill you," I shout, slamming my hand against the bars.

He leans over her trembling body, grabs a handful of her hair, and yanks her head back.

"No. No. No. No," I shout, wrapping my hands around the bars.

His free hand is holding a knife, and he places it up against her neck before he slices the blade across her throat from ear to ear. Blood gushes from the wound and her body goes slack before he lets go of her head.

I fall backward into the wall and bow my head. My fingers tighten in my hair, and I let out a scream of frustration. My chest begins to burn, and I slap a hand over my mouth to stop from vomiting. I failed her. Once again, I couldn't save a woman who needed me.

I might as well let the Lords kill me, too. My brothers will never forgive me for failing one of our own. She's from a Spade brother and

Saint has already claimed her as his.

Looking up from my place on the wall, I see the Lord is no longer in her cell. He left. I place my hands on the bars, and the door squeaks, opening.

I enter and walk over to her body. I untie her wrists and ankles and then pull her limp body off the edge of the table and pick her up in my arms.

"I'm sorry," I say through the knot in my throat.

Exiting the cell, I take a right, and my heavy boots guide me to an opening. I come to a stop to see my brothers.

My stomach drops when I see them all hanging side by side with their hands secured to the ceiling. Their heads are down, looking at the floor that their feet aren't able to touch.

I lay Ashtyn on a table to the left and rush to them. "Haidyn." I shove his head up, and blood runs from his neck and down his body.

I jump back as it splashes me. I begin to gag from the overwhelming smell. Rushing over to Saint, I find he's also had his neck slashed. My throat burns with bile as my brother's blood covers my hand and arm. I do the same with Adam.

I take a stumbling step back to see them all hanging there with their throats slit. Hearing a sound behind me, I turn just in time to see the Lord's fist hurtling at my face.

"Fuck," I groan.

I blink to clear my blurry vision. I'm still in the basement, now sitting in a chair, my hands cuffed behind it. My father sits on the edge of the table in front of me.

The chair rattles when I go to get up, but my hair is grabbed from behind, and I'm forced back into the seat. They pull my head back at an extreme angle, pinching the back of my neck. I bare my teeth at my father. "You fucking piece of shit." I spit on him.

He glances down at it but makes no move to wipe it off.

His silence makes my anger grow. "Why?" I demand, my muscles tense and my breathing erratic. I'm all alone. My brothers and Ashtyn are gone.

"Why what?" he asks, checking his watch. A sign that I'm keeping him from something important. As if his brothers' sons being dead isn't his main priority.

"Why kill them? They didn't do anything wrong." They could have failed their initiations. But that still wouldn't explain Ashtyn. She didn't have one. A female Spade has never run Carnage, as far as I know. Unless she was collateral damage.

"I don't know what you're talking about."

His nonchalant attitude makes me fucking livid. "You killed them," I shout, and the fingers in my hair tighten, holding my head in place. "Adam, Saint, Haidyn, and Ashtyn. You killed them all." I give a manic laugh. "Your brothers are going to make you suffer." That's something I don't want to miss. My father deserved death long before now. But what's that saying? The good die young. Evil lives for fucking ever.

"No," he argues. "They're going to make you suffer."

"Don't fucking put this shit on me," I scream, yanking on the cuffs that dig into my wrists. "You—"

"You did this, Kashton." His voice is much calmer than mine. "You didn't get to them in time."

What? He can't be serious. "You didn't even let me try." Panic grips my chest and my breathing becomes labored. He set me up. My father has always hated me. I was never going to be good enough for him.

Now he's gone and done the unspeakable. He's killed his brothers' only sons and framed me for it.

He stands from the table and removes a revolver from the inside of his suit jacket. Opening up the cylinder, he empties all the bullets into his free hand and pockets them. Then he places one on the table next to the gun and moves to stand in front of me. He nods to the man behind me, who lets go of my hair and then undoes the cuffs.

I jump to my feet, and the force kicks the chair over. "Going to fucking kill me, Father?" I challenge. "Then run to your brothers and blame me for you killing their children?"

"I'm not going to do anything, son. You're going to do it yourself."

"No—"

He punches me in the face, and it sends me falling to the floor. I'm off balance from the drugs. Getting to my hands and knees, I spit blood onto the concrete.

"I wanted to teach you a lesson, Kashton. Your mother…" He pauses. "She was too soft with you. Wanted you to be a 'good boy.' It's pathetic and embarrassing," he shouts. After taking a deep breath, he huffs. "I left you one bullet, son. As you said, your brothers are dead and so is Ashtyn. You failed them. You let them die. Suffer. Now it's your turn to do the same."

I get to my feet and sway. My vision is a little blurry from the hard hit to the side of my face. I'm so tired. All the anger has left my body and it's drained me. I'm like a balloon deflated.

"You have sixty seconds." He pulls the cuff back on his suit jacket and watches the seconds on his Breitling.

My eyes fall to the revolver that is sitting on the table. I'm all alone. My brothers made this horrible life tolerable.

The thought of suicide has never crossed my mind, but I've never thought about living alone, either. My brothers and I were in this life together. I had their backs and they had mine. I let them down. They needed me and I didn't help.

I've got one more initiation to pass before I have any power in our world. Right now, I'm just a son of a Spade brother, and my best friends are dead.

Their deaths are on me. My father was right. It doesn't matter that he rigged the game. He set me up and I fell right into his trap.

"Twenty seconds," he warns.

Stepping forward, I pick up the gun with shaking hands and open the cylinder. I slip the bullet in, lining it up with the barrel and close it.

"Fifteen," he calls out.

I lift the gun and point it at his chest. His eyes find mine and the corner of his lips twitch. I hate myself even more. He knew I'd make this move. He fucking knows everything.

"Going to kill me?" He snorts. "Just like you did your brothers?"

"I didn't kill them," I scream in his face. "I was trying to save them."

"Time's up, Kash." He steps into the gun, and it trembles in my hand. "You or me?"

As much as I want to kill him, it won't solve anything. My father deserves to be miserable; he deserves to know what it feels like to suffer, and I'm the only one who can do that. There's no one left to punish him.

I move the gun to the right of him and fire. "Fuck you," I shout over the ringing in my ears.

He begins to laugh as he pulls my cell phone from his suit jacket. "You've always been weak, Kashton. Not killing yourself proves just how much." Placing it on the table, he shakes his head before he disappears through the plastic strip curtains.

"Goddammit." I slam the gun down on the table.

I'm shaking and tears sting my eyes. I fucking hate the Lords. Everything about them. My father, most of all. He wants me to hate life. We're tested to see just how low we'll go, and I will not give him the satisfaction of killing myself. I'd rather live and disappoint him. No matter how alone I am.

My cell begins to vibrate next to the gun, and I tense seeing **Haidyn** flash across the screen. "Hell-hello?" I stammer.

"Hey, man. Where the fuck are you?" Haidyn asks. "You were supposed to meet us at the House of Lords twenty minutes ago."

"I—" Scanning the basement, I notice the plastic curtains aren't covered in blood like they were before. Maybe they cleaned them. I glance at the pits and they are empty.

"Kash?"

I make my way down the hallway and see the cell that Ashtyn was in is also clear of any blood, and there's no table in the center. I continue on to see the room where my brothers' dead bodies were hanging. Nothing.

I clear my throat. My heart is hammering in my chest. What the fuck is happening? I saw them. The blood, the sound of Ashtyn screaming for help.

"Us? Who are you with?"

"Saint is here with me. Adam is on his way with Ashtyn."

I run a shaking hand down my face. "I'll be right there." Hanging up, I place my cell in my pocket and pick up the revolver on my way to leave.

My father is standing next to the elevator with a scowl on his face.

"What did you do to me?" I demand. "They were dead. I…I saw them."

"I gave you a hallucinogen," he answers. "This isn't on me, Kashton. That was your mind. Your hallucination. You told me your brothers and Ashtyn were dead. I just twisted it to make you believe that it was your fault."

"I can't…no." I shake my head. "I know what I saw," I shout.

His eyes drop to the revolver still gripped in my hand. His demeanor is much calmer than mine. I think I'm having an out-of-body experience. "Keep it," he says, referring to the gun. "Maybe one day, you'll grow some balls and decide to put it to good use."

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THREE



KASHTON

INITIATION

Commitment

Junior year at Barrington University

I'm nauseous. The gum the older woman offered me was working, but I think it's wearing off. That was hours ago.

I don't care how big this yacht is; I feel us rocking back and forth out here on the Atlantic Ocean. We've been on this mega yacht longer than I'd like. We were supposed to get in and get out.

It's a joke. The four of us can't do anything on time.

"Where the fuck did Haidyn go?" Saint growls, checking his cell.

"He said he had to use the restroom," Adam reminds him. "Maybe he had to take a shit."

Saint gives him a doubtful look just as his phone vibrates in his hand. "Fuck," he hisses.

"What?" I wonder, digging in my suit jacket for mine as well.

"Haidyn's doing his alone."

"That's not the plan," Adam growls.

"Let's go," Saint snaps. We exit the poker room, taking the elevator down to the main level. "Split up. Message the group as soon as you find him."

We all go our separate ways, but he could be anywhere on this mega yacht. I look out over the ocean and see the lights from the shore. The yacht isn't supposed to go too far. Just cruise out here for an all-night party.

I slow to a normal pace when I enter the public view. I fix my suit jacket, buttoning it and taking a quick look to make sure I don't have any blood on me.

Nodding, I mumble, "Good evening," and "Hello," making my way through a crowd of people. So far, we're down two dead guys—both of which are now shark food—taking out one more than we were ordered to for Saint. And we still have our three to go. We can't let any of them be seen. That would ruin our plan and our initiation.

If you ask me, this was a stupid idea. Putting us all together in one place out in the ocean can only end in disaster. Or with me puking all over myself. I've been chewing away on the gum the old lady gave me in hopes that it would calm me down. I'd say it's helping, but I still feel a little uneasy.

I decide to swallow it. Maybe that will help. It was old anyway. Should have spit it out hours ago.

I'm looking down at my cell when it continues to vibrate in my hand. It's the group chat. They're blowing it up, looking for Haidyn, but he's not responding. I'm not surprised. We all prefer to work alone. The Lords are forcing this initiation to be a group activity.

I run into a soft surface, knocking my phone to the deck. "Fuck," I hiss, bending down to pick it up. But they get to it first.

"I'm sorry." Someone giggles. "I'm so clumsy." Green eyes gaze up to mine through a set of dark painted lashes.

"I, uh… Sorry. It was my fault," I tell her. "I wasn't paying attention." But I am now.

It's the woman I saw earlier. The one Saint wouldn't let me play with. Bleached-blond hair in a tight bun at the nape of her neck. Her small body is wrapped in a red silk dress that dips low in the front, showing me a set of perfect tits. They're on the smaller side. The thin fabric might as well be a fucking bow—a present that I can unwrap and play with. She has a dainty nose ring—septum piercing—that I hadn't noticed from a distance earlier.

She gives me a nervous smile and holds out my cell. It's vibrating in her hand when I take it and shove it into the pocket of my dress slacks without even bothering to look at it. Haidyn's a big boy; he can handle himself.

"I—"

"I've been looking for you." A man comes up behind the woman, and I watch her stiffen at the sound of his voice. It belongs to the

same man she was standing with when I first saw her.

She clears her throat and faces him. "I'm right here." Her voice is now flat, all playfulness gone.

His dark eyes meet mine, and he reaches out, grabbing her hand. "Quit playing around. That's not what you're here for." He pulls her forward, and she trips in her expensive designer heels, but his hand in hers keeps her upright.

"Hey, man. Take it easy," I say, stepping forward to follow them. She was drinking a glass of champagne earlier. Who knows how many she's had. It's a party. Maybe she's drunk and unsteady.

He jerks her to a stop and spins around to glare at me. Her eyes quickly glance at mine before they drop to the deck. It's clear she's afraid of him. "I didn't mean—"

"Shut up," he barks at her, and her exposed shoulders begin to tremble.

I step into him, bumping my chest into his. "Watch your fucking tone." I'm six five. He's maybe six foot, by the way I have to look down at him. I still feel a little seasick, but I will whoop his ass.

He gives me a cruel smile that shows off his paid-for mouth. He's a Lord, of course. If I had to guess, I'd say very high up on the food chain, but I don't know him personally. That's not surprising. So many of them from all over the world are attending this party tonight.

"Listen, boy, when you pay for it, you can treat it however you want." He turns and yanks her away once more, pulling her through a door to the right.

I shouldn't get involved. It's none of my business. I'm here for an initiation…

"Fuck," I curse, pulling out my cell. Thirty unread messages in the group chat between Adam and Saint. Still nothing from Haidyn.

The newest message pops up.

SAINT: Where the fuck are you, Kash?

I type back a quick response.

ME: Main deck forward.

And I start walking. As I pass the door on the right, I hear the girl crying out from inside. I don't even give it a second thought. I shove

the door open and rush into the owner's suite.

Cream-colored silk bedding and gold trim. The chocolate-colored drapes are open, allowing the dark water to be visible. The carpet is a crisp white. The room is fit for royalty.

The woman gets my attention. She's in the process of trying to crawl off the king-size bed, and he's leaning over the edge, hands around her ankles, dragging her back to him as she kicks and screams. His hand slips, ripping one of her heels off in the process.

"Fucking cunt," the man growls. "You'll pay for that."

I walk up behind the Lord, gripping the back of his suit jacket, and pull him off her.

"What the fuck?" He turns to look at me, and I punch him in the face, knocking him back onto the bed before he rolls to the floor. I bend down, grab the collar of his button-down to pull his head up off the floor, and punch him again. Blood splatters across the pristine carpet. I hit him once more and feel his cheek break under my splitting knuckles.

He rolls onto his stomach and starts to crawl away. "Where are you going?" I taunt, feeling better already.

"Fucking bitch." He groans, moving at the pace of a sloth. I clocked him pretty good.

I turn to look for something I can use and see a phone charger on the nightstand. I rip the cord from the wall and wrap it around his neck from behind over and over, then yank on it. I bend his head back at an odd angle while I plant my Tom Ford loafers on either side of his waist. He flails, hands digging, body thrashing, but he can't get it off. I have it pulled so tight that blood runs down his neck from where it's ripping his skin open. Once his body goes limp, I let go, and it falls to the floor.

I take a deep breath, adrenaline coursing through me, and step over his body. The girl is softly crying, huddling in the opposite corner of the room. Making my way to the en suite bathroom to wash up, I pick up the red dress off the floor and toss it to her without looking.

I might have wanted to fuck her when I first spotted her on the deck earlier, but the poor thing was almost raped. The least I can do

is give her privacy.

Removing my suit jacket, I move on to the onyx-and-diamond striped Bergdorf Goodman cuff links, plucking them from my bloody sleeves. I undo my tie and the top couple of buttons on my dress shirt as well. Then I wash my hands, arms, face, and neck. Once done, I shut off the water and dry off. I pull my vibrating cell out and see I've missed another twenty-five messages.

I don't even bother reading them, just type out and send.

Coming.

When I turn around, I'm startled to see the blonde standing in the doorway to the bathroom. Still very naked. I clear my throat, averting my eyes. "I gave you your dress."

"He ripped it," comes her soft voice.

"Here." I pick up my suit jacket from the bathroom floor and hold it out to her, making sure to look away while she slips it on. It's a little bloody, but better than nothing.

"Thank you," she mumbles.

After a second, I glance up to see she has my suit jacket draped over her shoulders. It's open down the front. It reaches her thighs and barely covers her breasts. I can see from her delicate neck, down her sternum, over her stomach and her shaved pussy. She's got her legs crossed, but she makes no move to button it.

My eyes find hers, and she gives me a nervous smile before wiping the black mascara from her flushed cheeks. "Thank you," she repeats.

I nod while yelling at myself. *Leave, Kash.* My brothers are going to kill me.

She steps into me, placing her hands on my hips, and I stiffen.

"I want to repay you." She bites her red-painted lip nervously. Her hands move to my belt.

Fuck me.

I run a hand through my hair to keep myself from picking her up and tossing her to the floor. "I just killed a man who was going to rape you, and you want to repay me by letting me fuck you?" I want to make sure I understand where this situation is headed and that we're both on the same page.

"I wasn't in the mood." She shrugs. "But now I am." Her hands work slowly and steadily, undoing my buckle and then the button on my slacks, followed by my zipper.

My cell vibrates in my pocket, and I wish I had shut it off. "I can't." I grab her tiny wrists, stopping her, but my slacks have already fallen open and hang around my upper thighs.

Her green eyes drop to my cock. "Looks like you can."

There's no missing the outline of how hard I am in my gray boxer briefs. "I can't," I repeat, but make no move to push her away. This is what I wanted, her on her knees staring up at me while I fuck those pouty red lips. Hell, it looks like I already have by the way her makeup is smeared. All that's missing is her drool and my cum on her flawless face.

"You're a Lord. You can do whatever you want." She scans my left hand to look for a wedding ring. When she meets my eyes again, she smiles at the lack of one.

"Not yet," I add stupidly.

"Ah, I see." She nods, taking a step back, and I release her wrists.

Thank God she understands, because I don't know if I could turn her down one more time.

"Correct me if I'm wrong, but a Lord going through initiations can't stick his dick in a woman's pussy, ass, or mouth." Reaching up, she slowly grabs the collar of my suit jacket and shrugs it off, exposing her body to me before it falls to her bare feet, but I keep my eyes on hers. "But we can still play." She walks backward into the room and scoots onto the bed, spreading her legs.

I can't help but look over her body—I only have so much restraint—spread open and ready to be played with. She's leaning back on her hands, chest pushed out, showing off her breasts, pink nipples hard and begging for me to suck on them. If I had time, I'd tie her to the bed and lick every inch of her while she begged me to let her get off.

She falls onto her back, spreads her legs wider, and lifts her hips, letting me have a better view of her pussy. I can see how wet she is from here, and my cock begs to fuck her cunt until she's coming all over it and then let her lick it clean.

"Goddamn." The word falls from my lips like a prayer, and she smiles. Wars have been started over pussy because of weak men like me.

She's not wrong. If we "play," I'm not breaking any rules. The question is, can I stop myself?

"I saw you staring at me earlier." She smiles. "It's okay. You can gag me if I get too loud." Her eyes flicker to the closed door quickly before returning to mine.

Goddammit.

I stay where I am, unsure of what to do or unable to move. My slacks are undone and about to fall down my legs while my cock strains against my boxer briefs. My heart pounds just thinking about holding her down while watching my cock slide in and out of her greedy cunt.

The moment I saw her earlier, I wanted nothing more than to strip her naked and fuck her. Even though I knew I couldn't.

"Fuck me," I exclaim loudly when I spot a woman on the deck, sipping a glass of champagne.

"I apologize," Saint says to an old lady glaring at me for my language. "First time on the water. He's feeling ill."

Her face softens, and she opens her small purse. "I understand. This will help. I always carry them for my husband." She hands me a piece of gum for nausea, and I pop it into my mouth, mumbling my thanks.

She walks off into a crowd, and Saint turns to me. "Keep it down."

I ignore him as I watch her look in our direction. "Goddamn…"

"Like Adam said, you can't use your dick right now," he reminds me, grabbing my suit jacket and pulling me up a set of stairs and out of sight of the woman.

"I can jack off while I watch her fuck herself," I ramble, trying to look over my shoulder. "I can fuck her with things other than my cock. Record it and watch it over and over."

"Well, here I am. What are you going to do about it?" She arches a dark brow while playfully biting her bottom lip.

"Fuck it," I say, and she giggles softly.

I grab a tube of hand lotion off the counter in the bathroom and walk over to the end of the bed. She sits up, shoving my slacks the rest of the way down my legs and then my boxer briefs. My dick springs to attention, and she licks her lips.

"Don't," I growl. My body is wound so tight I'm about to burst or vomit from the seasickness. "I can't think of my cock in your mouth," I warn her.

Her lying on her back, her head hanging off the edge with her pouty red lips wrapped around my dick and my hands tightening on her neck—pre-cum leaks from my dick just imagining her gagging on it.

She gazes up at me through her dark-painted lashes, and her lips part when she whispers, "Play with me."

My hand drops between her legs, and I touch her pussy. I run my fingers along her lips, and she's soaked.

I take a shaky breath. "We shouldn't." I try to convince myself that I could ever deny this woman in front of me. She's every man's wet dream.

She picks up the lotion, pops the lid, and squeezes some into her hand. Then she gets to her knees at the edge of the bed. "Then stop me," she tells me.

"I don't even know your name." I want to roll my eyes at myself. I'm just trying to come up with reasons as to why I shouldn't be here with her right now. Like her name fucking matters. It didn't when I first saw her out on the deck.

"Eve."

Of course it is. Wasn't Eve the one who did something forbidden… something about an apple? Fuck, I've never wished that I was religious until now. I don't think that story ended well. She's the *something* forbidden that I shouldn't be touching, but I'm going to anyway.

"What's yours?" She runs her lotion-covered hand slowly up my shaft, and my hips press forward, wanting more.

"Kash," I breathe.

She smiles. "Kash, I want to come all over your fingers as you come on me."

"Goddamn." We're going to do this, and there's no going back.

Fuck the Lords. Fuck my brothers and fuck the dead guy who lies on the floor beside the bed. I did a good deed, and she's my reward.

Her hand quickens on my cock, and I push her back to lying on the bed. I crawl on top of her, spreading her legs open with mine. My fingers play with her pussy for a second before I slide one in.

Her eyes glass over, and her hand begins to slow on my dick. Removing my finger, I slap her cunt, and she cries out. Blinking, her now focused eyes meet mine. Her legs try to close, but I keep them open with my knees.

"Eyes on me, Eve," I order.

That man who was just about to rape her wasn't the first. She's been used before. I've seen this at Carnage. The abused tune their abusers out—dissociate.

I scan her body, looking closely, and notice she has faint scars dotted on her inner thighs and wrists. Has she been beaten, or were they self-inflicted? I've seen those abused self-harm due to the trauma they've endured.

She also has several small bruises on her upper arms. Fingerprints maybe? Are they fresh from the guy I just stopped from raping her? At first glance out on the deck, she looked thin, but the way her ribs protrude through her skin tells another story. She looks frail—breakable. Possibly from starvation or use of drugs.

I look over her hip and see three short vertical lines—they're not fresh but they don't seem old either. I run my finger over them, and she flinches.

"Tell me to stop, Eve." I drop my hand back to her pussy, loving how red and swollen it is now from when I slapped it. "And I will."

"No." She sucks in a deep breath. "Please don't. I want you to touch me."

I slide two fingers into her this time, and her green eyes stare into mine. I can see them more clearly. They're the prettiest green I've ever seen. She's got them enhanced with black liner and mascara that still remains on her cheeks from crying earlier.

"Good girl," I praise, and she whimpers. Pulling them out, I slide them in again.

Her hand starts to run up and down my shaft on autopilot, and I watch her eyes grow heavy when I add a third finger. "That's it. You're doing so good, Eve."

She arches her neck, and her hips buck when my fingers get rough. "Please…oh, God…" Her hand falls from my dick, and I don't even care about myself. She's mesmerizing.

"Look at me, Eve," I command. "Eyes on mine."

She swallows and lowers her head, and her pretty green eyes find me once again. "Fuck, you're goddamn perfect," I tell her.

Her body rocks back and forth on the bed, and I work a fourth into her. She cries out as I shove them all the way in to my knuckles. "How many can you take, Eve? Hmm? Can you take them all?"

She's gasping, body wiggling under mine, and I've never seen anything sexier.

"Angel," I decide to call her.

If I believed in heaven, she'd be what I imagine it would look like. Her once tight bun has come loose, and her hair now fans out on the disheveled comforter and around her perfect face. Even with smeared makeup, she's breathtaking.

"Please?" she begs, her tear-filled eyes searching mine, and just when I think she couldn't get any more gorgeous, she does.

Her hands find their way to my hair. Nails scrape my scalp while her hips ride my fingers. "Fuucckkk…" Her lashes fall closed, and I push my hand farther into her cunt, feeling it stretch against her resistance.

Her eyes pop open in panic, and she gasps.

"Relax, Eve," I tell her, working them in and out. I'm moving more slowly than I'd like, but I don't want to hurt her.

She screams out my name, her hands fisting my hair, and I smile. "You can take it, angel." You'd be surprised what a body can endure.

Fresh tears fall from the corner of her eyes, and I watch with fascination when she nods her head once. "I…I can take it."

"Good girl." I push my hand against the pressure of her body wanting to keep it out. "You're so fucking soaked."

Her legs tremble and her breathing becomes labored. "Just relax for me, angel. Let me in."

"O-kay." She sniffs.

"That's it. You're doing so good for me." My eyes drop to watch my fingers work in and out of her tight pussy. "Come for me, Eve. I want to see how pretty you are when you get off."

She cries out. I slap my free hand over her mouth and watch her eyes roll back into her head.

"That's it, angel. I wish you could see how pretty you look right now."

Her wet lashes fan her cheeks, and I smile when her soaked cunt tightens around my fingers. She arches her back, her chest swelling when she sucks in a long breath and holds it while she comes.

I gently remove my fingers and my hand from her mouth.

She gasps in a breath, and I stand, allowing her to close her legs. Rolling over, she curls into a ball, and I bring my fingers to my lips, licking them. Closing my eyes, I hum my appreciation for how fucking good she tastes.

I yank my slacks up to fasten them before buckling my belt, then return to the bathroom to wash my hands. My cell vibrates nonstop in my pocket, and I quickly dry my hands off to answer it. "Hey—"

"Where the fuck are you?" Adam snaps.

"I'm coming." I wish that was the case. I'm so fucking hard right now.

"Haidyn has taken out his Lord. Have you done the same?"

Uh… "No."

"Then what the fuck have you been doing? We've been texting you." He's lowered his voice, so I know he's around a crowd of people.

"I said I'm coming. Chill." I turn to look at the angel lying on the bed, but there's nothing other than a disheveled bed. "Be right there." I hang up and rush into the room. "Eve?" I bark, looking around, but she's gone. Her ripped dress is still on the floor and so are her heels. My jacket is also MIA, and the door to the suite is closed. "Fuck." She ran.

My cell vibrates again, and I grind my teeth. "What the fuck do you want?" I demand, looking at the dead guy on the floor.

"For you to do your fucking job." This time, it's Saint. "Where are you? We're coming to you."

"I'm in the owner's suite, and I have a body."

"Your initiation?"

"No." I bend down and start to dig through his pockets so I can put a name to the Lord I murdered.

"What in the fuck are you doing killing random people?" Saint demands. "You're going to get us in trouble." He didn't feel that way when we killed his plus-one in the poker room.

I ignore Saint and pull out the wallet. Opening it up, I scan his license and frown. "It's him."

"What?" Saint snaps, barging into the room.

I look up to see Adam behind him. Ending the call, I put my cell away. Haidyn enters, slamming the door shut. He glances around the room. "What the fuck happened in here?"

"I killed him. My Lord." I frown. "But this isn't the picture I was given." I stand, remove the card from my wallet, and show it to Saint.

Haidyn snatches the license from my hand and places it next to the card Saint holds. "Name matches, but the guy doesn't look the same."

"Old picture." Adam shrugs. "His license photo could be over twenty years old. He's just gained thirty pounds and grew a beard. I think he looks like the Lord."

"Whatever." Saint hands me back the card. "It's done. Let's toss him over the private balcony. We've got to move on to Adam's."

"What's up with the dress?" Adam asks, picking up the ripped material. He stares at the silk in his hands as if he's seen it before.

"Did you kill his wife too?" Haidyn glances around, spotting her high heels as well. "Where's the body?"

She definitely wasn't his wife. He was paying to rape her. "Gone," I answer, refusing to give them any details about my angel. The less they know, the better.

I help my brothers throw the Lord into the Atlantic Ocean over the private balcony. Placing my arms on the railing, I watch the deep sea

that's lit up from the lights under the yacht, feeling the nausea returning and trying to make sense of the night.

Who the fuck was that Lord and why was he with my girl? Was it meant to go down this way? Was she supposed to have led him to me? I have to find her.

"Let's go." Adam claps his hands.

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FOUR



KASHTON

INITIATION

One of them

Senior year at Barrington University

It's hot. I'm sweating and my skin is blazing from the heat coming from the nearby fire.

I've been tied to this wooden post for quite some time. The slightest movement feels like splinters in my back.

My arms are secured behind me. I've tried to untie it, but it's useless. My ankles are tied to the post and so is my neck.

They're either going to burn me at the stake or brand me.

The hood is yanked from my head, and I blink rapidly to adjust to the sun beating down on me. A quick glance tells me that I'm in the courtyard with my three brothers. And the firepit before me tells me we're about to be branded.

"Lords," a man says. "Today is the day that you take your oath. And with that oath comes great responsibility."

I look up, scanning the balconies, and see all the Lords gathered to watch. Not a single one in a cloak or mask. They get to be seen today. To watch the next generation take their spot in the society.

"As a Spade brother, you will be the ones who must punish those who disobey their oath. You will show them that we do not take our life for granted. You are their jury and executioner. Do you understand?"

"Yes, sir," the four of us answer.

The Lord nods and steps away from the firepit. The smoke makes my eyes burn, and I hear Adam coughing as he chokes on it.

My father appears in front of me, and he looks just as disappointed as he does angry. He never wanted me to make it this far. "Kashton Landon Pierce, you have completed all your trials of initiation. Do you wish to proceed?"

I want to laugh in his face, but that wouldn't accomplish anything. "I do, Father," I answer through gritted teeth. It's the closest to acceptance he's going to get from me.

His face tightens when he speaks. "A Lord must be willing to go above and beyond for his title. He must show strength and have what it takes. If you fail your position as a Lord, your brother will take what you earned."

They're the only ones I'd allow to kill me.

He turns and walks to the firepit, picking up one of the brands. When he returns, he shoves a rag into my mouth, forcing the back of my head into the wooden post I'm tied to.

"Kashton Landon Pierce," he begins, "welcome to the Lords. For you shall reap the benefits of your sacrifice."

My entire body tenses as he shoves the hot brand into my sweat-covered chest, and I bite down on the rag in my mouth.

If my existence makes him angry, then I will vow my life to make him miserable.

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Part Two

FOUR YEARS LATER...

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FIVE



EVERETT

Eight years old

My father ushers me into the room with his fingers digging into my upper arm. He shoves me into a seat and orders, "Stay."

Where am I going to go? I don't even have shoes on.

Sometimes I think he talks just to hear his own voice, or maybe he's trying to convince his friends that he owns me. Not sure why. Everyone in this room knows he does.

I drop my eyes to my hands resting in my lap and see a piece of fuzz on my nightgown. It's the most I've gotten to wear these past few days. It's high up on my neck and falls to my knees. I might as well be naked, considering it's sheer. You can see right through it. And it's really itchy. I'd rather be naked.

I start to pick at it when the door opens.

I'm not allowed to speak. I'm to be seen, not heard.

"Hello, darlings," the woman's voice calls out. It sounds nice and comforting. Much different from the gruff and commanding ones I'm used to here at home.

Keeping my head down, I peek up at her through my lashes. She's standing with her back to me, hugging my father in greeting. I'm surprised he gives her the time of day. He hates everyone. Especially me.

She wears a pair of black heels with red bottoms. They're really tall and skinny and come to a point at the end of her toes. I would think that they're hard to walk in, but she seems to do it flawlessly.

Turning around, I avert my eyes to my hands quickly, but I know I was too slow when her pointy shoes turn to face me.

A hand grips my chin and yanks my head back. Her eyes scan my face, neck, and nightgown. "Pretty little thing." She smiles at me, and I no longer like the sound of her voice. It went from comforting to threatening with one compliment.

"Well, you would know." One of my father's friends laughs.

"I suppose." She lets go and steps away from me.

Something out of the corner of my eye gets my attention, and I glance to see what it is. I sit up straighter when I see it's a girl. Like me. That's new. "Hi," I whisper, so as not to get the others' attention.

She stands in the corner with her back straight, hands gripping a vibrant red purse. It matches the bottoms of the older woman's shoes and stands out against her black dress. Her hair is the color of the sun. Bright and big curls. I wish I could do mine like that. It looks so pretty on her.

"Hey," I whisper, unable to contain the smile on my face. "What's your—"

"Everett," my father snaps.

I slump over, and my pulse races. "Yes, sir?" I ask with my eyes now on the floor.

"Who the fuck are you talking to?" he demands.

I frown, looking up at him. All eyes are on mine, and I look to my right to see the girl standing there as still as a statue.

"Well?" he barks, and I jump.

"It's okay." The woman walks back to me and gives me a smile that she's trying to play off as nice. I'm not buying it. I know what the devil looks like, and he's in the room with us. "Who were you talking to, dear?"

"Uh." My eyes shoot back to the girl again, and she's not paying me any attention. I watch to see if her chest moves in her black dress, and I can't even tell if she's breathing.

"It's okay," the woman assures me. "You may speak."

I lick my lips nervously. "The…the girl."

She frowns and looks around the room. "You're the only girl I see, Everett."

No. "She's right there." I point at her in the corner.

"Quit fucking around," my father snaps at me. "You're wasting our time."

I rub my sweaty hands on my thighs, causing my nightgown to ride up. The woman leans over and pulls it down, fixing it for me. Then she faces my father. "Have you had her tested?" she asks.

"For what?" he barks.

"Schizophrenia," the woman answers, and I wish I knew what she was talking about. "The poor girl is clearly seeing things."

I stand on the second-floor balcony of the cathedral, looking down over the pews filled with Lords. All of them in black cloaks and masks.

It's a confessional.

I'm not even sure what the bastard did to fuck them over, but he's paying for it.

A woman walks down the center aisle, passing around a glass bowl full of razor blades. They're going to cut him for his sins.

He must bleed for his betrayal.

The Lords take payment in various ways, but it's always the same—your life.

Once they are finished, I'll sew him up and he will be collected. He'll be dead to the world, but his heart will still beat. I don't know where he will end up, nor do I fucking care.

Not my problem. I'm just here to do my job.

The woman glances up at me, and I make sure to keep my stare blank, giving nothing away. They can smell fucking fear, and I'm not afraid of her. Not anymore.

Those who don't know about our secret society wouldn't know who she really is. She's as evil as they come. Men worship her. Think she's the most beautiful creature they've ever seen. A goddess. Even my father fell for her, and he hates women.

It's all a lie.

I've seen their version of hell, and although I survived, a part of me died as well. I've never been tied to the altar for a confessional, but I've been an offering to some. They take and take until there is nothing left for you to give. Then they call you cynical and unappreciative.

They strip you naked, tie you down, and fill you with drugs. "It's what's best for you," they say. "You vowed your life to them." The fuck I did. I never had a choice.

The Lord screams into his gag as blood pours from his freshly cut skin. He's also pissed himself. They act so tough until payment is due. Then they're all the same.

Pathetic.

I've been there. I thought it would help. It didn't. They don't care. Bodily fluids won't stop them from getting what they want.

My cell vibrates in my pocket, and I pull it out to see who is calling me. **Fuckface**. I hit ignore and pocket it. I'll call him back later.

After everyone clears out, I make my way down to the altar. The Lord strapped to it and I are the only two here in the cathedral.

I softly hum a lullaby while the man lies tied down, spread eagle and naked, to the Lords' altar. The sounds of the double doors squeaking alert me that the bastard's ride has arrived.

My back is to the doors as I dunk the sponge into the bowl of water to start cleaning the man off. He's bleeding from shallow cuts. His peers took it easy on him, if you ask me. I've seen much worse.

He screams into the gag secured in his mouth by the leather harness wrapped around his head. The man's eyes go from mine to behind me to whoever has come to collect him. He's going to hell. That's where all of us will end up. It's what we deserve. A life full of sin isn't rewarded.

I continue to hum over his mumbled pleas as I feel eyes on me from behind. Heat rushes up my legs and over my back, and my face flushes at the butterflies that flutter in my stomach. My voice grows louder to drown whoever it is out, and I sing the words of "Hush, Little Baby."

I take my time cleaning the Lord, trying to look unfazed when I really want to run. My heart pounds and my pulse is racing. I'm never affected like this. I drop the sponge into the bucket and feel the water splash my fishnet-covered legs.

Taking a deep breath, I turn around to face whoever is here for the Lord. My breath gets caught in my lungs at who I see. Not one, but two Lords.

Spade brothers. And both of them have seen me naked.

A moment of panic makes me tremble. Are they here for me? Do they know what I do? That I'm betraying the Lords?

No. They can't. If they were here for me, they would have gone unnoticed and taken me from my bed in the middle of the night, not shown up here. They're here for him—the Lord who has been cut open like a fish by their peers.

I place my attention on the one I see as less threatening. "A little help, please?" I hold out my left hand to Kashton Landon Pierce to see how he reacts. *Does he remember me?*

Probably not. That was a long time ago.

He gets up and walks over to the Lords' altar. His eyes are on mine, and it takes everything in me not to look away and show him that one night with him changed my life.

Taking my hand, he helps me get up onto the altar where I straddle the man's waist. "Hand me that basket." I point at a wicker basket on the floor next to the stairs.

Breathe, Eve. He's just a man. Like all the others who only want one thing—my body.

Kashton picks it up for me and places it next to the Lord's head. He steps back, shoving his hands into the pocket of his hoodie, and watches me closely.

I'm sweating, and the blood rushes in my ears. My hands are fucking shaking. I haven't felt like this in years.

I undo the buckle to the man's gag, ripping it from his mouth and tossing it to the floor, allowing him to scream. Let him have the focus of their attention for a second.

"You fucking crazy bitch!" He yanks on the ropes and tries to buck me off, but I hold steady, my thighs tightening to secure my position while digging into the basket.

I secure duct tape over his mouth, making sure to wrap it completely around his head several times before I lean over and tear it with my teeth.

Then I pull out my trusty little handheld blowtorch and place the flame against the tape while his muffled screams fill the large space. "That should keep it in place." I smile as if I'm proud of myself and tap the side of his face. "Those who spill secrets will be silenced." It's a Lords motto.

We've all got something to hide, and I will take several secrets to my grave.

I go to move, and Kashton gets my attention as he rushes over to me. I allow him to grab my waist and help me down off the altar. I mumble a *thank you* before walking around the altar and facing the other Lord. I meet his intense stare before I look over my shoulder at Kashton as well. "He's ready for you." I give them a chilling smile, attempting not to panic.

The man's screams grow louder, and he fights the rope harder. I look down at him, still smiling, and touch his cheek as he tries to pull away from me.

"Nice work," Haidyn states, looking over the hack job I did stitching the Lord up.

"Practice makes perfect." I grab the pleats of my black skirt and curtsy. I look at Kashton and wink at him. Fuck, I'm trembling, but trying my best to play it off. Reaching up, I tap the side of the tied-down Lord's face and say, "If you're lucky, I'll come visit you in hell." With that, I walk across the cathedral and out the side door into the hallway.

Rushing into the office, I close the door behind me and take a deep breath, finally able to breathe.

Fuck. Fuck. Fuck.

This can't be happening. The past always catches up with you. If I've learned anything from the Lords, it's that we're all on borrowed time.

I lock the door and rush over to the desk, picking up my cell with trembling hands. I call the number that I ignored earlier. He's the only one who could be connected to the two Lords who are on the other side of the door.

"Eve?" he answers immediately. "Everything okay? I called you—"

"Kashton and Haidyn just showed up at the cathedral," I explain, falling into the chair with my eyes on the office door, waiting for one of them to kick it down.

"Why?" he asks.

"To pick up a Lord." He doesn't say anything about that. "Did you send them?" I demand. Maybe that's why he was calling me earlier. To give me a heads-up.

"No. Of course not." There's a long pause. "Did either one say anything to you?"

"No." I sigh. Thank God. "But I have a feeling one of them will be back."

KASHTON

Twelve years old

I step off the elevator and shiver. It's always so cold down here. I hate being cold.

Moans and whimpers hit my ears, but I'm used to that. It scares me when it's quiet. That's when your mind makes you think you hear things that don't exist.

Walking past the pits, I look around to make sure my father isn't down here. He's usually in his office at this time of day.

Coming up to the first cell on the right, I stop and sit down, crossing my legs. I look through the bars to see the woman lying on her side. Her back is to me, and she's curled up in a ball. She has to be freezing. I tried to give her my jacket last week, but she refused it. Said I needed it more than her.

There's one old dingy light bulb that gives the room a little light. It has four concrete walls. They're all covered with white lines—four run up and down, and then a fifth one is diagonal through the center.

"I brought you something to eat," I whisper, placing the plate next to me. I pick up the cookie and squeeze it between the bars, holding it in my hand. "Are you hungry?"

She doesn't move or answer.

I look around nervously, making sure my father or the other brothers aren't down here. My dad will be furious if he catches me. And the others will definitely tell on me.

I tap my free hand on the cold concrete floor, trying to get her attention, and she groans, shifting. "Kashton?" she whispers.

I smile. "Yeah. It's me. Are you hungry?"

She rolls over before she sits up. Her hands go to her face, and she pushes her matted hair back. I notice that she has a new bruise on her cheek. It wasn't there when I visited her two nights ago.

"What happened?" I ask, frowning.

She gives me a small smile, scooting closer to the door. The metal bars are close together so I have to bring her things that can fit between them. "What did you bring me?" she asks, ignoring my question. She never answers.

"Chocolate chip cookie," I say, holding it out to her.

She takes it in her frail hands and brings it to her cracked lips. Taking a small bite, she nods. "Mmm. It's good."

I drop my head and whisper, "It's all I could get."

"It's perfect, Kashton," she assures me.

Looking up, I give her a smile, and she takes another nibble. "I tried to get you some milk, but there wasn't any." I'm not sure how I'd be able to get her a glass through the bars, but I'd try for her.

"Why aren't you at school?" she asks me.

I shrug, not wanting to tell her the truth. I got sent home yesterday for starting a fight. My father was irritated about spending two days with me rather than the fact that I hit a kid. "It's closed today," I lie, and she frowns. How does she even know what day it is? She has no windows. No clock. No sense of time.

"You should get going." She begins to pull away.

I wrap my fingers around the cool metal bars, not wanting her to go. "But—"

"Leave, Kashton," she interrupts me. "Before you get in trouble for being down here."

Not wanting to upset her, I let go and get to my knees. "I'll come visit you tomorrow," I promise her.

"I don't think—"

"What in the fuck are you doing?" a voice yells.

I jump to my feet and turn to see my father standing in the hallway, hands on his hips, glaring at me. I take a step back. "Dad—"

"Leave him alone," she says from the cell.

"Shut the fuck up," he snaps at her and then stomps toward me. He grabs my upper arm and begins to drag me away.

"Please…no." I reach out for the bars, but he's too fast, and I get nothing but air. "She's hungry," I tell him. "I brought her a cookie."

"She'll eat when I say she can," he growls.

"Don't you fucking touch him," she shouts. "I mean it, don't you—"

"I'll be back for you." He cuts her off, shoving me into the elevator.

I wrap my arms around myself and press my back into the wall as the door closes on us. My father huffs before turning to face me. "I told you to quit coming down here unless I tell you to."

Looking away from him, I stare at the floor. I just want to help her. She's all alone. I know what that feels like, and I hate it. I want her to know that she has me.

"Kashton?" he barks. "Do you fucking hear me, son? I'm tired of you disobeying me." Giving me his back, he checks his watch and huffs.

I slump against the wall, trying not to cry. I hate him so much because of what he does to her. I'm all she has, and I promised her that I'd take care of her. No matter what.

I sit with my McLaren Senna turned off, back in the dark corner parking lot of the cathedral, hidden under some trees. Haidyn and I took the Lord back to Carnage, strung him up, removed his brand, and threw him in a cage. Then without a word, Haidyn went to his room to be with his latest fuck, and I went to mine.

I'm fighting with my brothers. Haidyn has been MIA, apparently fucking his therapist. Then he pops up with her after someone breaks into the place he's been staying at. I don't think he plans on keeping her at Carnage. He's going to go back into hiding.

I took a shower, put on clean clothes, and found myself driving back to the cathedral. Six years I've been looking for my girl, and she's right here.

Has she been in front of me all this time? Something tells me no. There's no way she would have been this close and I missed it.

I sit up when she exits the front double doors. She's still dressed in her fishnet tights, pleated black miniskirt, and tank top. Her hair re-

mains up in a messy bun. Fuck, she's stunning. More so than I remember.

There's only one other car—a blacked-out M4. I could put a tracker on it, but I'm more of a hands-on type of man. I want to see firsthand where she goes. What she does. Who she sees.

After popping her trunk, she tosses a black duffel bag into it, then falls into the driver's seat. I stay parked until she pulls out onto the road, giving her a head start.

Eve knew it was me and pretended I hadn't seen her naked. Like I didn't get her off that night on the *Isabella*. Was it because she didn't want Haidyn to know we have a past, or was it because she didn't remember it? No. I refuse to believe she doesn't remember me. She had been drinking, but she wasn't drunk by any means.

It's late, so there aren't many cars on the winding two-lane road. I make sure to stay far back enough to go unseen while following her. My car isn't the most inconspicuous.

Twenty minutes later, she pulls up to a gated community, and I pull over to the side with my lights off until she enters. After a second, I follow and make my way through the neighborhood.

My first thought is that it took too long for the gate to close behind her. Anyone could be waiting, watching, and slide right in.

The second is that the community seems nice, with a golf course and pool house. Houses sit on at least two-acre lots. People who live here aren't up this late at night. They're home by six, have dinner by eight, and are in bed by nine thirty.

I catch sight of the back of her car before the garage door shuts. Once again, I come to a stop and look over the house. It's a large one-story with a fenced-in yard and four-car garage.

The thought of walking up to her door and knocking enters my mind, but I don't. Instead, something across the street catches my attention, and I smile to myself.

Just another sign that it's meant to be.

I've always prided myself on my patience. A Lord is nothing without it. It's part of the reason they make us go three years without pussy.

To push us. To see just how much restraint we have.

It's to weed out the weak.

I'm a lot of things, but weak isn't one of them.

My father would disagree, but he was wrong about a lot of things.

He was evil and determined to make me into another version of him. My main goal in life was not to let him succeed. But life had different plans for me. No matter how much you try to change, sometimes you've seen too much.

I look out the window wall. I'm going to have to invest in some thick drapes. Black this bitch out. My childhood home was in a neighborhood, and the neighbors were so fucking nosy. My father was rarely ever home, but when he was, I heard the rumors and watched them drive by slowly to see which whore he had at his house on the nights his car was in the driveway. The nights that he wasn't home, they'd knock on the door to see if I was okay, knowing I was home alone. I got good at lying at such a young age.

"Thank you for being able to meet us on such short notice," Amber says to the real estate agent.

"Of course." He beams at her. "It just came on the market a few weeks ago. Lots of buzz on the street. This gated community has its own hundred-acre lake and private school. It's so safe that most children walk. The Willington spans three thousand acres."

"Honey, do you want to look around?" Amber asks me.

I turn and smile at her over my shoulder. "You go ahead."

She slides her arm through the crook of the realtor's and drags him out of the living room with a bounce in her step, leaving me alone.

The sight of the matte-black BMW M4 has me focusing my attention back out the windows. It turns into the driveway across the street, idling for a few minutes before the brake lights turn off and the driver's side door opens. A blonde steps out, dressed in a pair of black high heels. They accentuate her long legs that are wrapped in black latex, sitting high on her thin waist and showcasing her plump ass. A black tube top is wrapped around her large breasts.

Her hair is up in a high ponytail, highlighting her tan shoulders and fragile neck, with a pair of designer shades covering her face. Her lips are the color of blood, and they make my cock hard. I can't wait

to have them wrapped around my dick until I pull out and come all over her face.

She's got an iced coffee in one hand and her large YSL purse in the other. I check my watch to see it's seven thirty in the morning. Pretty late—or early—to just be getting home. Which tells me she was out all night.

The way she's dressed makes me think she just spent the night at Kink—a members-only BDSM club—but there isn't one located here in Pennsylvania. The thought of another man tying her up and whipping her makes me as red as her lips.

So that begs the question, where the fuck has she been all night?

If she was with a man, I hope he knows that's the last woman he'll ever fuck. The moment I find out who he is, he's dead. I refuse to share my girl with anyone else. I've waited six years to find her, and the Lords placed her in my hands.

I had to move fast, since she saw me a couple of days ago at the cathedral. I can't give her the luxury of time to run from me again. I'm not going to let her slip away. Six years is too long.

I almost fell over when I saw her there, washing the unlucky bastard. She knew it was me. I don't look the same as I did back at Barrington. I've put on more muscle and am covered in ink, and my mind is even darker than it was. But she knew who I was. I heard it in the way her breathing picked up and by the way her skin broke out in goose bumps when I touched her. If Haidyn hadn't been with me, I would have said something, but I kept my mouth shut because now I know she's here.

She looks a little different now than she did then, too. Her breasts are bigger; she's put on some weight. She was so tiny and frail-looking then. She's still on the smaller side but looks healthier. This time when her green eyes met mine, they looked brighter. More confident.

"Miss Everett Sinclair." The real estate agent speaks, coming to stand next to me while watching my future wife enter her home through the front door. "I sold her that house." He turns and smiles proudly at me. "She's lovely." His face falls. "No kids that I know of. She was single when she purchased that house. I showed her nu-

merous locations and lots. She looked for three months until she found what she wanted."

I would normally tell someone rambling to shut the fuck up, but he's giving me information that I won't be able to find anywhere else. "Single, huh?"

"Yes. But she did have a daddy."

I turn to face him. "What do you mean by *daddy*?"

"You know…" He wiggles his eyebrows.

"No. I don't." I cross my tatted arms over my chest. What an odd thing to tell me, but again, it's something I'll need to know. I'm also not surprised after our first encounter. She's moved up from a man trying to rape her on a yacht to having some bastard buy her a six-thousand-square-foot house.

"She, uh"—he lowers his voice—"I showed her the house. She called him and told him she wanted it. And he purchased it for her. Wire transfer."

"Who was he?" This is interesting.

He shrugs. "No name was ever given. Everything was done in hers." He winks at me like some secret guy code for "she's a whore who sucks dick good enough for some pathetic married man to buy her a house where he can fuck her whenever he wants."

Or maybe that's just my jealousy talking and thinking the worst. Six years is a long time. A lot can happen in that amount of time. But it doesn't matter if she's married. He's dead. If she has a boyfriend, he's dead. If she has a sugar daddy, he's dead.

My angel will rely on me for everything.

"I love it," Amber shouts, entering the living room once more, interrupting our conversation.

"We'll take it," I tell the man.

He smiles, looking at Amber as she jumps up and down with her tits bouncing to the point they're about to fall out of her top.

They begin to talk about interior decorators in the area, and I place my attention back on the house across the street.

My girl exits the front door, locking it behind her. She's changed into a short-sleeved crop top, yoga pants, and tennis shoes. Her hair is

up in a messy bun, and her shades still cover half her face, but her red lips are gone.

She pauses with her hand on the door handle of her car, but doesn't look up. She can feel me.

I smile to myself.

Hello, angel. It's been too long.

Yanking her door open, she falls inside, starts it up, and backs out before driving away.

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SIX



EVERETT

I ’ve been kept hidden all my life. I was always supposed to be a secret—a no one. And I’ve always been okay with that. The Lords have shown me that you’re the only person you can count on. Hell, let’s face it, that can go for anyone, Lords world or not.

But I’ve been seen. The one person I’ve wanted to avoid has come back into my life, and all I can do is hope he doesn’t want to reminisce.

Last week, Kashton Landon Pierce walked into my life, just like he did six years ago, and he had me just as flustered as he did back then. But this time, I couldn’t show it, because he wasn’t alone.

It’s been one week since Kashton and Haidyn were at the cathedral, and one of them is following me.

He thinks I haven’t noticed him, but I see everything. I’m always watching my surroundings. A woman can never be too careful. We’re targets. No matter whether it’s someone we know or not.

I can feel him.

That same heat rushes over my skin, as if I’ve been lit on fire. Those butterflies flutter in my stomach so violently I think I’m going to get sick, and it has nothing to do with why I’m here tonight.

It hasn’t stopped me from living my life though. I have a job to do, and I’m not going to let a man dictate that. Men already have too much power over women.

“May I buy you a drink?”

I look up from the glass of bourbon sitting on the bar to see a man standing next to me under the neon lights. “Of course.” I give him a shy smile.

Who the fuck turns down free drinks? Definitely not a woman sitting alone at a bar.

He pulls out the barstool next to me and gestures to the bartender. "I'll have a scotch, and the lady will have another."

I readjust my position at the way he calls me *lady*. I know the man was being polite, but it's something I'll never be in our world.

I'll never belong to a Lord. No one would want me. Not long-term anyway. A one-night stand? Absolutely, but that's not a compliment or reassuring. A man will fuck anything. Literally.

"So what brings you to this place?" the man asks, turning his attention to me.

I pick up the glass and down what's left since I have another one coming. "Just needed a night out," I answer.

"Oh no. Boy trouble?" His eyes drop to my left hand to see if I'm married. The thought makes me want to vomit. Or is that those damn butterflies from the man sitting in the darkly lit booth back in the corner?

Marriage is overrated and pointless. Like look at this man sitting next to me. He's married. He didn't even bother to take his ring off before he offered to buy me a drink. I know what some would think…he's just a nice guy offering a woman a drink while we share a pointless conversation. It's harmless.

Wrong. The way his eyes are glued to my chest tells me all I need to know about him. He's definitely thinking about fucking me, and if given the chance, he'd jump on top of that. Or me.

Sucks for him. I'm not letting a dick anywhere near me.

"Here you go." The bartender sets our glasses down, and I turn to the man who bought my new drink, thanking him.

He clanks his glass into mine. "What do you say we finish these and get out of here?"

I shouldn't be surprised by how quickly he offered that. Pathetic, really. He pays for a twelve-dollar drink, and I'm supposed to kneel before him and open my mouth so he can fuck it while I pretend to enjoy it.

"A place a little quieter?"

"I have a motel room next door." I give him that shy smile that makes him squirm on his barstool. He can't wait to pin me down and fuck me. I can't wait to put a knife in his fucking throat and watch the life drain out of his eyes. "I'm just in town for the night," I add. Let him know that he'll never have to see me again. No strings attached.

He tosses back his drink and slams his glass on the bar top, calling the bartender over to pay for the two drinks.

I sip on mine, ignoring the man who watches me from across the run-down bar. He may be a problem in more ways than one. Hopefully he stays out of my way. I'd hate to have to kill them both.

"Ready?" The man gets up from his seat and places his wallet inside his suit jacket. He stands out among the crowd that hangs out here.

His three-piece suit screams money. I'm sure he has a Maserati parked outside and a Lords crest branded on his chest.

I'm wearing a pair of black fishnet tights, a black leather miniskirt, and a matching corset, with my hair up in a high pony. I dressed like a two-dollar hooker for a reason. Easy target. He won't pay enough attention to notice that I'm wearing Louboutins. My over-the-top makeup is done with black shadow that I purposely smeared to make it look like I've been on a three-day binge, and my red lipstick is meant to draw attention.

I fall off the side of my heel, so he places his hands on my waist to try to steady me.

"Been here for a while?" he asks, hopeful.

Men consider a drunk woman an easy conquest. "Guess I had more than I thought." I lean into his side, and he smiles down at me.

He helps me out of the bar and walks me across the parking lot.

"Room 111," I inform him, removing the cheap plastic key chain from my clutch. Anyone who says I'm not sentimental doesn't know me very well.

He's a gentleman and opens it for me since I can't seem to do it myself. Stepping into the room, I shut and lock it behind me, hoping that the Spade brother stays the fuck out.

KASHTON

I watch her shut the door to her motel room the moment I step out of the bar. The thought of her being alone with him makes my blood boil. I'm going to storm in, yank her off him, and force her to watch me cut off his dick.

My hands shook with rage. Just sitting there watching him look her over like a piece of meat had my hand on my gun.

After removing the pack of cigarettes from my pocket, I light one up, needing a quick hit to calm my nerves before I rush inside the room. I don't want to hurt her. Just teach her a lesson that she won't forget—she belongs to me.

Bringing it to my lips, I take in a long drag as the door to the motel room opens, and she walks out, closing it behind her.

I frown, taking a quick step to the right to hide in the shadows. Well, that wasn't enough time to have sex. Not sex worth having anyway.

Maybe I had this all wrong. Was she buying drugs? Selling him drugs?

The only plausible answer is that they were exchanging something that couldn't be done in public.

She pulls a trench coat tightly closed, tying it off, and her designer heels slap the water puddles that litter the abandoned parking lot. She doesn't seem nearly as drunk as she looked a couple of minutes ago. Was she faking it? If so, why? Eve walks to her car parked right by the door of the motel room. Getting in, she starts it, and the reverse lights come on.

I watch her pull out onto the road and remain where I'm at until her taillights fade into the darkness.

Throwing the cigarette down, I make my way across the parking lot and glance around. It's an old, practically abandoned one-story motel. Half the letters on the sign don't work and the paint has faded from countless years of sun damage. The number on the door reads 111. But it's different from the others. It's been carved with a knife and seems oddly familiar. Like the three lines that were on her hip when I finger-fucked her on the yacht. Now that she's left, there are no other cars other than what's at the bar.

I touch the knob and twist it, opening the door to the room she vacated.

Stepping inside, I look over the man who lies in the center of the bed. He's naked except for the dress slacks bunched around his ankles.

His throat is slashed from ear to ear. The visual gives me a feeling of unease. Blood covers the already dingy sheets, along with his chest, neck, and parts of his face.

I'm equally impressed and confused.

Was this a job? If so, what kind? Was she robbing him? Blackmailing him?

Surely, some sort of exchange was involved, and it went south, requiring her to defend herself. Or she knew she was bringing him in here to kill him. But why him and why here, of all places?

Walking to the bathroom, I grab a towel and wet it. Then I go over to the body and run it over his blood-covered chest. What I see makes me pause. He has a Lords crest branded on his chest—a circle with three horizontal lines through it.

Was she targeting him, or was he targeting her? I watched her clean up a Lord at the cathedral. He had been part of a confessional, so I know she wasn't the one to torture him. So why this Lord? Was she supposed to deliver him to the cathedral, and things escalated so quickly that she had to take care of him here?

She knew what she was doing. She was prepared. There's no other reason she would have sat at the bar for over an hour, speaking to no one, then suddenly engage with him as soon as he sat down. Within five minutes, they had walked over to a motel room. One she was conveniently parked in front of.

Her trench coat? Where did it come from? It had to have already been here in the room; she didn't have it at the bar.

Everett set this up. Her appearance and actions screamed *I'm drunk and a cheap fuck*. But it was a façade. Part of her game. She lures men in and seduces them in order to kill.

It makes me wonder if I killed the guy for her on the *Isabella* because she wanted me to or because he really was going to rape her. After seeing what's in front of me, I'm thinking the former.

I smile to myself. She did good, but I'm not surprised. She's a pro. Been doing it for years. That night on the *Isabella* all those years ago wasn't a cry for help. Everett didn't need me to save her.

It was just another job. She wanted to play, switch it up. So she pretended to be a whore for that Lord. What man would pass up doing whatever the fuck he wanted to a woman because he's paying for it? Not a Lord. Money can buy you anything you want, and the Lords have plenty of it.

That also explains why she willingly threw herself at me after I saved her that night. She had fallen off her heels. Eve was pretending that night too. Letting him think she was weak and easy.

But he was my initiation. Was I supposed to kill him before or after he'd raped her? It doesn't make any sense.

I glance around the room for a murder weapon. Other than a small purse, she wasn't carrying anything on her body when we arrived at the bar, and she didn't walk out with a knife when she left this motel room.

Glancing around, nothing stands out. I open the nightstand, and what I see makes me pause.

A Bible.

I'm sure each motel room has one, but the sight of it has my pulse racing. I slam the drawer shut and walk to the small closet over by the corner and open the door to see that it's empty. Rubbing my chin, I make my way back to the bed and pull up the corner of the comforter.

Bingo.

I yank the black duffel bag from underneath the bed and unzip it. Inside, there's a hammer, some rope, a gun with a suppressor, and a knife. It's been cleaned because the handle is still wet.

Fuck, she works fast. In and out before I could even walk across the parking lot. Was she afraid I'd intervene like last time? That I'd fuck up her plan?

I hear a buzzing sound and zip up the bag, shoving it back where I found it before looking around the run-down motel room. It's old and in the middle of nowhere next to a biker bar. The carpet is stained and smells of cigarette smoke and body odor. A single

queen-size bed, an old TV that sits on top of a dresser, and a small bench at the foot of the bed are all that are in here.

That buzzing continues, and I crouch down and start digging through the pockets of his slacks around his ankles.

Pulling a cell out, I see **WIFE** lit up, and I smile to myself. Pocketing the phone, I exit the room and head back to my car, leaving her goody bag behind. I need to get home. I have some research to do on my angel.

"Coming Down" by Five Finger Death Punch fills the speakers in my car as I drive away.

I pull up to Carnage thirty minutes later and make my way down to the basement. Haidyn hasn't been here lately. He's too attached to Charlotte's pussy, I guess, to come home. Not sure what's going on with them because he doesn't talk to Saint or me about it.

Things have been crazy around here. We found out where Ashtyn was hiding, and I went to Vegas to drag her back with Saint. Then she and Haidyn were kidnapped. We thought he'd died, and once again, Ashtyn returned. Then we find out Adam was involved. Afterward, Haidyn left, and now he shows back up with the woman Saint and I hired to be his therapist. And now Eve is back in my life.

I'm losing my mind trying to keep up.

Saint stands by the pits, washing blood off his hands. "Where have you been?" he asks, looking up at me.

"Out," I say. I haven't told him about Eve, and I don't plan to. Not until she's officially mine. They're both wrapped up in their own lives.

He goes to open his mouth, but my cell rings, and I remove it from my pocket to see it's Haidyn. *Speak of the devil.* "Hello?" I answer.

"Hey," he greets me.

"What's up, man?"

Saint mouths, "Haidyn?" and I nod. Glad to know I'm not the only one he's choosing to ignore. There's been tension there since Saint found out that Haidyn knew where Ashtyn had been and that he'd had contact with Adam.

"Where the fuck are you? I tried calling you last night."

"I was at Charlotte's," he answers, like I'm supposed to know where that's at. He's not the one I've been following. "I need a favor."

I place him on speakerphone. "Name it."

"I need you to come get Charlotte. She's at her house."

I look at Saint, and we both frown. "And where are you?" I dig. Why is he being so vague?

"I have somewhere to be," he answers.

"Haidyn—"

"Tell Saint I'm sorry," he interrupts me, and my heart begins to race at his words. What the fuck is he about to do?

"What the fuck is going on, Haidyn?" Saint barks, stepping closer to me and speaking into my cell. He also knows something is up.

"Nothing," he lies. "I just need you to understand that I'm sorry for what I did."

Fuck. Fuck. What the hell has happened? Who is this Charlotte anyway? We don't know who this bitch is. I didn't even know he had been fucking her. The Lords gave us a roster to choose from to get him help or else, so we picked her.

"Haidyn," Saint snaps.

"Charlotte is at her house. I'll send you the address." He hangs up on me.

"Fuck," Saint shouts. "What in the fuck is he doing?"

"I don't know," I snap defensively. "He's been ignoring me too."

My cell beeps with an incoming message from Haidyn with her address. "Let's go." I turn, and we race toward the elevator.

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SEVEN



EVERETT

I get out of the shower and wring out my hair with the towel while "DOPAMINE" by Kami Kehoe echoes off my bathroom walls. Then I run the soft material over my chest and stomach. When I get to my legs, I pause with my fingers hovering over my pussy.

I've never touched myself sexually, but the urge to do it is strong. It can only be for one reason—Kashton. I saw him standing in the parking lot when I left the motel. A part of me wanted him to burst into the room and watch me kill that guy.

It turned me on just like it did on the *Isabella*…when he fingered me while the man he killed lay on the floor. I've been able to push it to the back of my mind because of how disgusted I was with myself for letting him get me off that night.

Now, here he is again, making me feel things, and he hasn't even spoken directly to me. I need to make sure I don't let him get close.

I won't be the woman they tried to train me to be. I have an entire box full of things taped shut in my closet that reminds me of who I once was, and it makes me physically ill to even think about opening it. The part of me that begged to be used.

I was in a dark place for a very long time, but I pulled myself out of that.

Dropping the towel, I place my hands on the counter and bow my head. Closing my eyes, I count to ten slowly while I take deep breaths. My pussy is wet, and my clit throbs with need.

"No," I say out loud, as if that word matters. It doesn't.

People are taken advantage of every day. Words are just that. You hear things like *She was asking for it with the way she dressed,* and

She shouldn't have been showing it off, or the insane *She never said no*. Meanwhile, the woman was far too intoxicated to consent or too young to know what consent was.

If the Lords had their way, they would only produce men. The women would be locked in cages and only used for sex. I don't think some of them do it to get off. It's just the fact that they can hold you down and listen to you scream.

It's all about power. The ones with the dicks get to control everything.

My virginity was taken when I was just fourteen by multiple men. Drugs were involved, but I didn't willingly take them. No. Over the course of several hours, I was forced to become a woman.

If I'm being honest with myself, I'd say I'm glad they drugged me because I don't remember much of it. Just the foggy pieces that float in the back of my mind.

The aftermath hit me the hardest, when the drugs wore off and I found myself sitting on the shower floor crying. Even if my body didn't have a chance at fighting the drugs, I still hated myself. I cried so hard that I ended up making myself sick.

What once made me break, I'm now numb to. I'm not sure if that's a flex or a sign that I need help. Either way, it's a part of my life that I've spent years trying to block out.

It's a reminder that I'll never be her again. I've come too far to allow someone to make me feel helpless. Especially some Spade brother who wants to prove to himself he can have whatever he wants.

Lifting my head, I meet my stare in the mirror. No. I won't be that woman again. I've gone years without sex; I can do this.

My cell beeps, and I look down to read the text that makes the hairs on the back of my neck rise.

We've got a problem.

It's been almost a week since Kashton watched me walk out of my motel room. I haven't left my house. There's no need when you can get anything delivered. Thankfully, I haven't been called into either

job. I can go for a couple of weeks without anything to do and then have to be at both the bar and the cathedral in the same night.

Lying in bed, I stare at the TV. Some reality show is playing, but I'm not paying any attention.

It's crazy how fast your situation can change. That night on the *Isabella* was the first time in my life that I felt like a human. The wind in my hair while we were at sea—I had never experienced anything like that before. For so many years, I had been chained and collared, and I was finally free. But it was just a lie I was telling myself, because I was nowhere near free.

It was just another form of training. Kashton had to rush in and save me, and it fucked up everything. I let him touch me, and I was ready to end it all for a little attention.

Now he's back, but he's not playing fair. He's going to follow my every move.

My phone gets my attention when it vibrates next to me in bed. I see I have a text message from an unknown number, and I open it up.



The text is followed by a video. My pulse begins to race, and my hands shake as I hover over Play. I have an idea of what I'm going to see. If it's what I think it is, he's right. I'll owe him, and the thought of him coming to collect terrifies me, but a deal is a deal. And I made one with the devil.

I sit, paralyzed, watching the ten second video, knowing I have to do something after it ends.

I have little control over my shaking hands as I call the one person I know can help. I owe the man in the video everything. He saved my life once. The least I can do is save him too.

KASHTON

I haven't had a chance to follow Eve. Too much has been going on here—Haidyn had been gone; he turned himself over to the very bitch who trained us after Ashtyn shot Saint and left him for dead. I still haven't forgiven her for that, and I'm not sure I ever will.

I'm tired of losing people I love. Tired of feeling left out and alone. Eve is my answer, but I had to make her wait. We had to save Hai-

dyn first.

We finally got him back. He's in rough shape, but he's home at Carnage where he belongs. Isabella is also here in a cell. A part of me can finally breathe. A chapter of my life is closed.

For so long, I've lived with the thought that she would return to Carnage and take over again. I couldn't care less about what happened to me, but my brothers? I hate to think of them being tortured. Being prisoners in the very place where we enslave those who betray the Lords.

Who have we betrayed? No one. We've held up our end. Done what our fathers taught us. Ashtyn is the one who left us. She's the one who tried to kill my brother, the man who was just protecting her. The domino effect from that led to Adam killing our fathers. Saint and I had always thought it was Haidyn, but Adam admitted it when everything was coming out.

But saving Haidyn cost us something. We lost another brother. Again.

Adam is dead. And the worst part is that one of my friends killed him.

I'm soaked. We went ahead with Adam's funeral today, even though it's raining outside. It didn't matter; we needed to lay him to rest.

Saint and Haidyn aren't going to do anything about it, but I am. I feel betrayed. I've just left Adam's funeral, and I need to do this now.

After bringing my car to a screeching halt, I get out and rush toward the house as the rain drenches me. My fists bang on the door before I cross my arms over my chest.

It opens after a few seconds, and Easton Sinnett—Sin—stands there with a smile on his face. "Kash Daddy." The moment his eyes meet mine, the smile drops, and he sighs, looking over my rain-covered suit. "Sorry we didn't make it to the funeral—"

I punch him in the face. Striking him so hard it shoves him back into the grand foyer of his house. When I step inside, I hit him again.

"What the fuck, Easton?" I shout. Grabbing his shirt, I yank him toward me, slamming my face into his. I barely feel the pain from the contact. I'm too worked up. I'm fucking shaking. We saved Haidyn, only to lose Adam. Sin walked into our office at Carnage and changed our lives in the worst way.

"Hey, Sinny." I smile up at Easton as he enters the office, making him snort. "Have you decided to come home?" He'd make a great Spade brother. I'm determined to recruit him. What he did for Elli just proves that he will do whatever it takes.

"I'm here on Lords' orders," Sin states, and the air in the room instantly shifts from light to heavy.

I get to my feet, and so does Haidyn.

"What kind of orders?" Saint questions.

"I was given an assignment last night to deliver a Lord to Carnage," he answers, his eyes on Saint's. "I have an hour left."

"Who?" I demand.

Sin looks from Saint to Adam and speaks to him. "You."

Sin doesn't even try to fight me, which pisses me off even more. "You had plenty of time to come to us." Letting go of his shirt, I shove him backward.

He stumbles, disoriented, before he stands to his full height, rubbing his hand down his now bloody face, and squares his shoulders. "I'm sorry." Sin holds his arms out wide to show he's not going to retaliate.

"Sorry?" I give a rough laugh. "Sorry won't bring him back." I hit him again. And again.

Adam just returned to our lives after four years of being MIA, and now he's gone forever. So many questions are still unanswered, and so much time has been lost. The Lords wanted us to imprison him in our basement. Instead, he killed himself.

"Wait. Wait." I raise my hands. "Let's think about this for a second. We've got an hour."

"That's not enough time," Saint growls. "You should have come sooner," he barks at Sin.

"It's fine," Adam assures him. "I'll go downstairs."

"We're not putting you in a cell." Haidyn shakes his head.

"We will if it'll buy us time," I argue. We were raised to do whatever needs to be done, and this is no different. I'd rather lock up a brother than lose him.

"I'll go downstairs for now, and we'll figure it out. Sin…" Adam picks up the gun, hands it back to Easton, and nods to the door. He and Sin exit the office.

We found Adam lying dead in the basement with a self-inflicted gunshot wound. He had hit Sin over the head and taken his gun. Then he'd taken his own life.

"What the fuck are you doing?" a pregnant Ellington squeals, running into the living room.

I take a step back, trying to catch my breath as Sin falls to the floor. His wife drops down beside him. "What the fuck did you do?" she cries out, her tear-filled eyes meeting mine before they go to her husband. With shaking hands, she gently touches his bloody face.

"I'm…fine, Elli." He spits blood onto the rug, getting to his knees. She tries to help him to his feet, but he ends up helping her, given her large belly.

"What the fuck is wrong with you?" Elli turns to face me, and he pulls her back when she yells, "Get out!"

I throw my arms out to my sides and take a step back, looking over his busted face. "I'm leaving." I look him up and down with disgust, trying to figure out why he would betray me like this. Why wouldn't he come to us…or at the very least me? We could have saved Adam if we'd only had a little more time. Hell, the full fucking hour would have helped us. Instead, Adam was dead minutes after Easton entered our office.

"Elli—"

"Get the fuck out of my house," she screams at me, interrupting Sin.

Spinning around, I exit, slamming the door shut on my way out. I fall into the driver's seat of my car. Taking a deep breath, I wrap my busted knuckles around the steering wheel, letting out a scream of frustration. I lost a brother and a friend in a matter of twenty-four hours.

My cell beeps, and I close my eyes for a brief second before picking it up and reading over the message.

UNKNOWN: Midnight tonight. Airfield.

Huffing, I toss it onto the passenger seat and head back to Carnage.

After I left Sin's house, I went back to Carnage and took a shower. The text I received said I had to be at the airfield at midnight. I was surprised to see that Haidyn and Saint both got the same message.

We board the private jet, finding Bill and a detective waiting for us. The fact that they even know one another is setting off alarms. Saint huffs. "Okay. What the fuck are we—"

The back door opens, and we all jump to our feet.

"No fucking way!" I gasp at what I see.

"What the fuck?" Saint demands.

"Brothers." The man spreads his arms out wide with a smile on his face.

I'm the first to embrace him in a tight hug, slapping his back. "What in the fuck, Adam?" I laugh, shoving him. "How many lives do you have?"

"I'm like a cat," he jokes.

The fucker knows I hate those things.

Adam's alive. Dollhouse is an operation for human trafficking. Breeders…Lords selling their children outside of the secret society.

My mind is reeling, but there's one thing I have to take care of right now. Haidyn and Saint are on their way back to Carnage, but I have somewhere I need to be.

I bring my bike to a stop and set my helmet on the seat. A quick look at my watch tells me it's almost two a.m. They're probably asleep. Or fucking. Either way, this can't wait. I have to do this now.

I ring the doorbell and, for safe measure, bang on the door a couple of times before shoving my hands into the pockets of my jeans.

Sin answers the door, dressed in a pair of black sweatpants, and his heavy eyes look around the front porch and driveway before they

meet mine. "You okay?" His voice is rough, and his hair is a disheveled mess. He was definitely asleep.

I rock back on my heels. "May I come in for a second?"

"Of course." He steps aside, and I enter the silent house, coming to a stop in the grand foyer for the second time tonight. I turn to him as he shuts the front door and faces me. He's got a cut on his left cheek and another across his upper lip, and his right eye is bruised from my fists. "What's going on, Kash?"

"I—"

"No. Get the fuck out."

I turn to see Elli standing a few feet from me, wearing what looks like an oversize white T-shirt of Sin's. She holds a SIG P220 in her hands, with the barrel pointed right at my face. It's Sin's favorite gun. He carries it with him daily. He likely keeps it on his nightstand or under his pillow, and she grabbed it when she heard me speak.

I raise my hands. "I'm not here to fight," I inform her.

"Get the fuck out of my house," she screams, hands shaking.

"Elli." Sin moves to stand between us, and she lowers the gun to her side so she doesn't accidentally shoot her husband. "Give me the gun," he orders, holding his hand out.

She just stands there, hard eyes on mine. I understand she hates me. I came into her house earlier and hurt her husband. I'm an enemy. The woman never liked me anyway. Not since Sin turned himself over to us. We strung him up, removed his Lords brand, and gave him a new one. She came to his rescue with Tyson and her father.

"I say we keep the kid and let her come visit him," I say, stepping closer to her. "We'll let him watch us fuck her. I bet they'd both get off on that. I know I would." Another step closer, and I think she stops breathing. "Starve a man for a few days, he'll eat anything. We'll each take our turns filling your cunt with our cum, then lay you out for him like a feast. He'll eat every drop of us out of you."

Carnage is all about mind games, and I was fucking with hers.

Sin was going to rot in Carnage for her. He was willing to give his life so she could have a better one, and I was going to take all he had left to give until he finally gave up.

He steps into her and takes the gun. Tucking it into the back of his sweatpants, he kisses her forehead. "Go back to bed, Elli. I'll be in there soon."

She sniffs. "But Easton—"

"I'll be right there," he promises, and she throws me one last go-to-hell look before she turns and retreats to their room. The sound of her slamming the door further illustrates how pissed she is.

Sin grabs the gun from his sweatpants and pulls back the slide. Chuckling, he removes the chambered bullet. "It was loaded and the safety was off. She was for sure going to blow your head off." Placing the gun on the coffee table, he sits down on the couch and gestures for me to do the same in the chair across from him. "What's up? Need something? Is everything okay?" He places his tatted arms along the back cushions, getting comfortable.

Even though I was here earlier tonight, beating the shit out of him, he still wants to be my friend. I run a hand over my hair nervously. "I just wanted to come and apologize in person," I say.

"It's fine." He waves it off. "Think you're the first man to hit me?" His laughter follows.

I get to my feet and let out a sigh. "I know, Sin."

His body stiffens, and his face grows tight. Silence covers the large room as he gets up and walks over to a rolling cart next to the fireplace that has a decanter and glasses. He pours himself a drink and takes a sip. Then he turns to face me. "I don't know what you're talking about." His voice has gone cold. Detached.

"I'm not doing this." I shake my head. "Lying to each other—"

He turns, throwing his glass of bourbon against the wall. The crystal shatters, and the rest of the liquor runs down the wall to puddle on the floor. "Get out," he growls.

"Sin—"

"Get the fuck out of my house." He repeats his wife's words, turning to face me.

I frown, stepping closer to him. "You'd rather I think you killed my brother than tell me the truth?"

"I don't know what you're talking about." He runs his hand through his already messy hair. His body tenses as he tries to catch his

breath. “Adam is dead.”

“Sin, I just saw him,” I argue.

“Goddammit, Kash!” he snaps.

Elli rushes out into the living room once again with her hand on her pregnant belly. “Sin—”

“Go back to fucking bed, Elli,” he shouts at her. She looks from me to him, her face tight and pissed off. He turns to face her and lets out a long breath, softening his voice. “Elli—”

She storms out of the room once again and slams the door. I’m sure this time she locked him out.

“Why?” I ask, needing to know. This isn’t how I saw this conversation going. “Why did you let me hit you? You knew he was still alive.”

“And Sin?” I ask, sitting on the plane with Adam, Bill, and the detective. “What about his assignment?”

Adam nods. “That’s another reason we have to keep quiet about my existence. Sin knows I’m not dead…”

“Now I feel bad for beating the shit out of him,” I mumble. “FUCK!”

“It was for show.” Saint gives a humorless laugh. “You guys set us up.”

“We had very little time and very limited options.” Adam doesn’t agree or disagree. Or elaborate on how he managed to get a body that would make us believe it. “I’m trying to do the right thing. The one thing I couldn’t do for Ash…” Adam trails off. “I just…wanted you guys to know that I’m still here.”

“It’s better than the alternative,” Sin whispers, answering my question.

“I’m not going to turn you in.” He was given an assignment that, technically, he failed. The Lords can punish him for that. They can send him to Carnage if they find out. They can have him killed right here in his house in front of his pregnant wife. He’s betrayed them.

Sin gives a rough laugh. “You think I give a fuck about me?” Shaking his head, he walks over to the cart once more, giving me his back, and pours another glass. It’s the most I’ve ever seen him drink.

“Then what’s it about?”

After downing it, he turns to face me. "The Lords made me put Elli through hell. Her entire life has been fucking hell. I bought her this house so she has a place to feel safe. To know that no matter what her days are like, she can come home, and I'll protect her. If the Lords find out what I didn't do, they will kill me and regift her to another Lord who will most likely put her through more fucking hell. And the babies…" He shakes his head. "I'd rather you think I killed your entire family than put my wife through that."

I swallow nervously. "I'll never tell anyone." He's become one of my best friends. Hell, I consider him a brother. Sin and I didn't have a good start, but we've grown close over a very short amount of time. I'd do anything for him or Elli.

"But you know," he growls. "And that's enough." Walking past me, he goes over to the front door. When he opens it, I take the hint and walk toward him.

Stepping outside, I turn to face him, my chest tightening as I look over his busted face, and I clench my cracked knuckles. "Sin—"

"Goodbye, Kashton." He shuts the door in my face, and I feel like I've lost another brother. A soul-crushing loneliness that whispers *You're not enough*.

Being a Spade brother who lives at Carnage limits my interaction with the world. Most don't even know we exist. So to lose another friend is a hard pill to swallow. Especially when I only have myself to blame.

It takes everything in me not to knock on the door again. To beg him to forgive me. To apologize for what I did.

Why do I lose everyone I love? Nothing in this life is guaranteed, but at some point, you have to understand that you're the problem. I just wish I knew how to fix myself.

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EIGHT



EVERETT

When you spend most of your life in total isolation, you start to see things that aren't there. I wasn't allowed to have friends or go to school. I didn't need to have a brain. That would lead to me having ideas and opinions, and no Lord wants that from a woman.

I was eight years old when I started seeing my make-believe friend. I knew she wasn't real, but I didn't care. She didn't speak to me at first, but her presence was enough. She wasn't beaten or raped. She was different, a figment of my imagination.

She was who I wished I was—a kid who got to have a life. Who always had her hair done and got to wear cute outfits.

I was lonely, and she was there for me, always hovering in the corner, willing to listen to me talk or cry. I told her everything. Who the fuck was she going to tell? No one else could see her.

Eleven years old

It's one of those rare days when I get to walk the halls. My father didn't lock me in my room, and I'm taking full advantage of it. I push open the door to the staircase and start to walk up them. I like to go to the upper level and look out the window.

Getting to the top floor, I push open the door to the large room. It's got an entire wall of windows. I make my way over to them and place my hands on the glass, staring out.

This is the best view in the whole place. It makes me think that there is something other than this hell. I can see for miles. So many trees, nothing but woods. It's the prettiest when it's wintertime and covered in snow. If I look closely, I can see animal tracks.

But it's currently summertime. The sun is out, and everything is green. No clouds to be seen.

The glass is warm on my fingers, and I press my forehead to it. Closing my eyes, I imagine what it'd be like to go outside and breathe fresh air. It's not allowed. I'm not sure why. Where would I go? What would I do?

A sound has me spinning around, expecting my father to be standing there, but he's not. It's my imaginary friend. She comes and goes. Sometimes I dream of her. And we're playing tag outside. Or having a tea party. I've never gotten to have one of those.

"Hi." I smile at her. I love it when she visits me.

The first time I saw her, my father's friend called me crazy and said I needed professional help. Thankfully, my father blew her off, and I've learned to keep my mouth shut about what I see.

To my surprise, she steps forward and smiles at me. She's always pretending I don't exist, and that's okay. Her presence is enough. "Want to play with me?" the girl asks.

"Yeah," I answer without hesitation. Unable to contain my excitement, I smile so wide my cheeks hurt. "What do you want to do?"

"Let's go downstairs," she suggests.

My face falls. "I'm not allowed to go down there," I tell her sadly. I knew it was too good to be true. "I'll get in trouble."

She tilts her head to the side. Her long blond hair is in two braids that hang down her shoulders and chest, only stopping at her stomach. So pretty.

I wish mine looked like hers. I only get to wash mine twice a week. It remains dirty and short. Pieces are always breaking off, and my father said it needs to be cut.

Her vibrant eyes glance at my clothes, and her lips pull back with disgust. I wrap my arms around myself, instantly insecure. "Why are you dressed like that?" she asks.

"It's what my father laid out for me today." I don't get to choose what I wear.

"Why?"

I shrug. "It's what he likes me to wear." It's as simple as that. I've never questioned it. At least I get to wear clothes today.

"Come on." She waves her arm and turns toward the door.

I stay where I'm at, with my arms folded across my chest, biting my lip nervously. "I shouldn't…"

She rolls her eyes. "No one will see you. It'll be fun. Come on."

Fun? I've never had fun. "Someone is always watching," I decide to say. It's not worth getting beaten over. Especially since she's not even real. Turning my back to the window, I hear the door open, and I know she's left me.

"Talking to yourself again?"

I spin back around to see that my father has entered and my imaginary friend is long gone. Poof. Like magic. Because she doesn't exist.

My father isn't alone. He has that same woman with him. The brunette who's always dressed in a tight-fitting dress and heels.

"Did you ever get her—"

"Don't start," he interrupts her.

"Seriously." She places her hands on her narrow hips. "The girl could be a danger to herself. I have someone she can talk to."

"I already know who you're going to suggest, so save it." He places his attention on me and orders, "Get back to your room."

My shoulders drop, and I let out a long breath. "Yes, sir," I say through the knot forming in my throat as I pass by him and through the door.

I decide to take the stairs because the elevator will be too quick. I hate my room. It's too quiet.

Pushing open the door on my level, I step into the hall and come to a stop. The girl stands outside my door, staring at me with a blank look on her face. "Maybe next time, we can play," I tell her, but just like all the other times, she ignores me.

Entering my room, I climb onto the bed and curl up into a ball. I have a bathroom, but there are no mirrors. There are no towels or toilet paper. My father brings those things in when he decides I need to bathe or use the restroom.

I'm a prisoner here. The worst part is I hate being alone. I just wish there was someone for me to talk to. Someone to play with. I just want to be seen and heard.

KASHTON

Twelve years old

I sit on the concrete floor with my legs crossed. It's late. The sun will be up soon, and I'll have to go home, but I needed to see her. To see how she's doing.

"I brought you some milk," I tell her. This time I came prepared.

She sits in the corner with her knees pulled to her chest. She rests her head on them, and her matted dark hair covers her face.

I turn the plate long ways to slide it through the bars and set it on the floor as close to them as I can. Then take the cup of milk and pour it onto the ceramic dish.

"I had to pour it onto a plate, but I got you a straw." I pull it out of my pocket. "Sorry, I must have smashed it," I say, trying to straighten it out.

"You shouldn't be down here," she whispers.

I wrap my fingers around the cold bars and press my face to it, smashing my cheeks. I'm thankful she's not dead. I've been here for several minutes, and she hasn't moved. I can't even hear her breathing. "I wanted to see you."

She looks up, and I smile at her. Slowly, she gets to her hands and knees, and I hold my breath while she crawls across the concrete floor. When she gets to the plate, her shaking hands pick it up, and some spills over the edge before she can get it to her cracked lips. She tilts the plate and drinks the milk, spilling more on her naked body than she actually swallows. Once done, she gasps and pushes it back under the bottom bar. "Thank you."

I feel bad that I didn't bring her more. Silence falls over us, and my eyes scan the cell, not wanting to leave her yet. "What are all the lines?"

She looks over her shoulder and answers, "Those are tallies."

"What are they for?" I inquire.

"I make one every time I think of you," she tells me.

My wide eyes meet hers. "That's…a lot."

"You're always on my mind, Kashton."

I'm lying on my stomach, butt-ass naked, in my bedroom at Carnage. The curtains are pulled closed, and the covers are shoved to the foot of the bed. My TV is on some random channel. I'm trying to

go back to sleep after I had to crawl out of bed to piss an hour ago. I'm tired and hungover.

So much has happened in the past few weeks, and I'm still trying to comprehend what I refuse to believe. Adam is gone. Again. Dead to the world, but not really. He faked his death. Haidyn is married, and his wife is expecting triplets, and the woman of my dreams has been right here under my nose for God knows how long. And she's possibly a trained assassin.

Since I started following her, I haven't seen her with another man. Not one she hasn't killed, anyway.

If she's in a relationship, it doesn't make a difference. If I even think there's someone in her life, they're dead. My future wife can't have someone on the side. All she'll ever need is me.

And then there's Sin. I've ruined my relationship with him, and he'll probably never speak to me again. I get that. I fucked up.

On days like this, I just want to stay in bed and do nothing.

The lock on my door clicks, and I groan at being bothered. It's either Haidyn or Saint. Their wives don't know the access code to get in.

"What do you want?" I ask, not even bothering to turn my head to see who it is.

"It's noon," Haidyn says.

"And?" I ask, pulling the pillow over my head to cover my eyes when he flips on the light.

"Why are you naked in bed this late in the day?" he asks.

Because after I found out Adam was still alive, I tried to fix my relationship with Sin, and when he pretty much told me to go fuck myself, I went and got hammered. Not the smartest thing, but drowning my sorrows sounded good. Plus, I was hoping my girl would show up at the biker bar. She never did. Guess she didn't have a job last night. Probably a good thing. Otherwise, I would have made a fool of myself.

"Kash?" Haidyn barks, getting my attention.

He's not going to go away.

Letting out a growl, I shove the pillow away and flip onto my back. "Why are you holding a cat?" I ask. He stands next to my bed with

Charlotte's pussy cradled in his arm like a football. His free hand slowly rubs over it like it's a lamp with a genie inside to grant him three wishes.

Haidyn ignores my question and runs his blue eyes over my naked body. I rolled onto my back hoping it would make him uncomfortable, and he'd leave. Wishful thinking. We've seen enough dicks in our lives. Especially each other's.

"Saint asked if I had seen you today." He frowns, meeting my stare.

I fold my hands under my head, propping it up and giving him a smile. "Now you can say you've seen *all* of me."

He rolls his eyes. "Get up. Shower and put some clothes on. Then get your ass down to the basement." With that, he turns and exits with the damn cat.

Jesus Christ, his wife has turned him into a pussy lover. All he needs is one of those clear backpacks that women carry around with their cats stuffed into them.

I debate going back to sleep, but he left the light on, so I have to get up anyway to at least turn it off.

Fuck it.

I pick up my cell off the nightstand and see it's almost dead. I didn't even bother plugging it in last night. I hate how much it hurts that I don't have any missed calls or texts from Easton. He's mad at me, and for good reason.

I fucked up. I seem to do that a lot.

I have a text, though, so I open it up. It's from Mr. Fells.

It gives me a time and place for closing on my new house. It's taken longer than I wanted, but it still moved more quickly than what is common.

I was willing to pay significantly over the asking price. Nothing is too much when it comes to my girl and our future.

Plugging my cell in to the charger, I get up.

Taking a cold shower doesn't make me feel any better. But if I don't go see what Haidyn and Saint want, they'll come up to my room. Together. And I can't escape them both. Less than fifteen minutes later, I'm pulling on a T-shirt as I shut my bedroom door, making my way down to the basement.

"What do you need?" I ask, entering the pits.

Saint has some guy strapped to the metal table in the center of the room while Haidyn stands next to it.

"Where the fuck have you been?" Saint barks at me.

Going over to the counter, I pick up Haidyn's pack of cigarettes and remove the Zippo from my pocket, lighting one up. I left mine up in my room. "Why the fuck does it matter?" I turn to face them, leaning my ass against the edge, and take a drag from the cigarette, feeling the nicotine fill my lungs. Since when do they care what I do with my time? They don't give me a play-by-play of what they do with theirs.

The guy on the table fights the restraints as Saint adds another over his neck.

Saint's eyes narrow on mine, but he doesn't say anything. Mine go to Haidyn, and he frowns at my attitude. "I see you lost the furry pussy. No longer babysitting?" His frown deepens, and I ignore it.

I'm usually the one who cuts up and keeps everyone laughing. I'm over it. I'm mad at them. Even if it's my fault.

"What's wrong?" Saint asks me.

"Nothing." I turn to leave, realizing they don't need me for anything. I could have stayed in bed and wallowed in my own pity.

"Kashton."

"What?" I spin around and step toward him.

Saint looks at Haidyn, who shrugs as if they've already had several conversations about me today.

"You have something you want to say?" I come out and ask.

"What the hell is wrong with you?" Saint frowns.

I begin to laugh. That's a dumbass question. "If you haven't figured it out by now, then quit trying."

"What the fuck?" He throws his arms out wide. "You're making fun of Haidyn and a cat, but you're the one being a little bitch with an attitude."

My brows rise to my hairline.

"So whatever the fuck it is, get it out. Right now." He crosses his arms over his chest.

My gaze drops to the guy who is naked and strapped to the table. His wide eyes go back and forth between us. I find it ironic that it's the man we picked up from the cathedral the night I found the woman I've spent years searching for. Eve was right there. So close all this time. It's time to show my face. To remind her of who I am.

"Doesn't matter," I say, giving them my back once again.

"Things are fine. Back to normal," Saint states, making me stop.

I turn to face them once again, and he looks at Haidyn. "We've talked it out…"

"You two talked it out." I nod to myself. "No one has spoken to me." I still haven't had a chance to finish the conversation that Haidyn and I started when we rescued him.

"How many times do I have to think you've killed yourself? Hmm? How many times do I have to lose a brother?" I ask, looking at him lying in the hospital bed here at Carnage.

I step closer to it and shove my hands into the pockets of my bloody jeans. I haven't had a chance to change since we pulled him from Dollhouse. "We've already said bye to Adam twice. And we're going to have to do it again. But how many times are you going to leave us?" In order for Adam to help us find Haidyn, he made us promise to let him walk away from us afterward with no questions asked.

"I'm not going anywhere."

I snort. "You've been MIA and got married. FUCKING MARRIED!" I scream. "You had Adam there. What about us, huh? What about me?" How could he do something so important without me? I thought we were closer than that.

"I made you her guardian."

"How was that possible, Haidyn? Hmm? Because I wasn't fucking there to sign off on that."

He runs a hand down his face. "I had Adam sign your name."

I throw my arms out to my sides and then let them fall, slapping my thighs. Of course Adam was there for him. Haidyn's been hiding him from us for years. "You should have just had Adam sign his."

"I wanted you."

"I—" The sound of the door opening cuts him off, and Charlotte steps into the room.

"What the fuck happened?" His wide eyes go to mine when he sees her condition.

I ignore his question. His wife can answer it. "We'll finish this conversation later," I tell him and walk over to her. I place my hands on either side of her bruised face. "Give him hell, love," I tell her and release her. Reaching into my pocket, I pull out his wedding ring and hand it to her, leaving them alone.

If I can't get through to him, maybe she can.

Saint frowns at my previous statement, and it just pisses me off even more. "You don't even know why I'm mad at you guys."

"You guys?" He points at himself. "What did I do?"

Seriously? "You cheated at the vow ceremony."

Saint throws his head back, laughing like I've told a joke. "That was four years ago."

"That was a big fucking secret!" I shout, getting more and more irritated with him. "It's literally when everything started going to shit. Had you told us, maybe we could have prepared. Done something different. Fuck, Saint. Maybe your wife wouldn't have shot you." His laughter stops. "Perhaps she wouldn't have ran away and lost her baby. Maybe we wouldn't have been sentenced to six months of hell. Who knows?"

He opens his mouth, but I continue, "And you…" I look at Haidyn. He widens his stance and crosses his tatted arms over his chest. Ready for a fight. "What the fuck, man? You kept Adam from us for four years?" I don't care that much that he married Charlotte behind our backs.

He says nothing.

"Now because of Adam, I've lost Sin as well," I ramble.

They both frown and look at one another. "What happened to Easton?" Saint asks.

"After Adam's funeral, I went to his house and beat the shit out of him in his living room."

Saint sighs and runs his hand down in his face. "Was Elli there?"

"Of course his wife was there," I shout. "And then after we had our meeting with Adam on the plane, I went back to apologize, and she pointed a loaded gun at my face."

"Kash—"

"Don't bother," I interrupt Haidyn. "You guys have kept to yourselves for this long, just keep doing that." With that, I turn and storm through the plastic strip curtains and get on the elevator. Fuck, I need a drink and to see her.

She is the only thing that can make this day better. I'm already relying on her as a crutch. I used to have my brothers, but I've lost them one by one. So I'm going to replace them with her.

Eve doesn't know it yet, but she's exactly what I need.

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NINE



EVERETT

Do you know what it feels like not to get to say goodbye to the one you love?

People die every day in freak accidents or from suicide or natural causes. I know there are a lot of people who don't get to say goodbye to a loved one. Who aren't aware when they kiss them goodbye as they leave for work that it might be their last.

I hate that I've had to say goodbye to someone I never even got to meet.

I sit cross-legged at the grave. It should have two headstones, but that wasn't offered. The single headstone represents two people I love. Two deaths due to two different circumstances. Not getting to know them doesn't make the pain or loss any easier.

Each one put a fresh hole in my heart. The tears did eventually stop, but it changed me. Made me colder.

I look over the unmarked grave. You don't get to be remembered when you screw the Lords. There are two people who I never got to say goodbye to here. One brought me into this world, and the second, I refused to let end up with the same fate as me.

I learned at a very young age that I would rather swim with the sharks than surround myself with the people who tried to drown me.

I only had myself then, and I only have myself now. That will never change. One day, they'll get rid of me. No one will show up for my funeral because there won't even be one. Not like I will have friends to attend it anyway. I want to be cremated and dumped here, but that won't happen. You don't get to choose how you die when the Lords decide your time is up.

As I sit here, the wind picks up, but heat covers my skin. I can feel him. I haven't been able to pinpoint where he comes from or what it is he wants, but he's been there.

Tonight is different. I can hear the sound of his boots on the muddy ground behind me, and I can smell him. It's a cool night with a strong breeze. It's on purpose. For some reason, tonight is the night he wants to be seen.

"I thought stalkers were supposed to go unnoticed," I say, keeping my back to him.

A dark chuckle caresses my ears, and the breeze blows my hair around my face. Getting to my feet, I turn, and it gets caught in my lip gloss, slapping my face. I take a second to push it back, tucking it behind my ear.

The cemetery is dark at this time of night, with only one light, and even it's on its last leg—flickering on and off. But the moon is out in full, giving me enough light to see the man leaning against the large tree. He's got his right black combat boot against the tree, knee bent. He stands over six feet tall, dressed in a black hoodie and light-wash jeans. He pulls a pack of cigarettes out of one pocket and a Zippo out of the other. Lighting it up, he flips the lighter shut and puts them both away.

"Aren't there enough things that'll kill a Lord?" I wonder, filling the silence. "Why put yourself in an early grave?"

The end of the cigarette burns as red as a cherry before he blows it out. "Speaking of graves…" Kashton looks around. "Why the fuck are we out here at three in the morning?"

"Why are you stalking me?" I counter, pushing my hip out. I was here first.

"Doubling my odds."

I snort, not understanding nor caring enough to ask what he means by that. He pushes off the tree, getting my attention, and I take a step back.

His lips curl up slightly with amusement. "Nothing to be afraid of."

I laugh at that absurd observation. "Oh, I'm not afraid of you." I've come a long way in the past six years. I will fuck a man up without thought.

He takes another step toward me, and I match it.

"Your actions say otherwise," he muses. Putting the cigarette between his lips, he takes in another drag as his gaze drops to my black platform boots. I had to sew up another Lord after a confessional tonight, and I haven't changed yet, though I at least had the chance to wash up afterward.

"Maybe I'm pretending." I shrug. "To throw you off." You have to bait the hook before you can cast the rod.

"Pretending?" he repeats, taking another pull before blowing it out. "Is that what this is, Eve? Are we going to pretend that I haven't seen you naked?" I swallow at the way his blue eyes graze over my chest. Those butterflies that I can't seem to shake take flight in my stomach. "That I never heard my name on your lips while cum leaked from your pussy?"

"Kash—"

"You remember that, right? Before you ran away from me?"

I roll my eyes to feign annoyance and ignore the way my pussy clenches at the memory. "It was one time."

"It was the first time," he promises. "You won't get away from me this time, Eve."

He takes another step closer, and I match it once more. I won't let him touch me. "What we did was a mistake. We both know it." I wasn't aware of who he was that night, but I am now, and I want nothing to do with him.

"Want me to save you from a rapist? Then you can reward me by letting me have my way with you while you beg me like a good whore?" He smiles at me. "That's what you're into, right?"

"Fuck you, Kash," I say through gritted teeth, hating that I ever let him get me off.

The man turns and makes his way to the bathroom. I blink, trying to calm my racing heart. I came all over myself. Like a trained whore. I can't say no. It's not a word we're allowed to use.

But I wanted him. He looked at me like I was the prettiest thing he'd ever seen. He saved me.

I glance down at the dead guy on the floor and get to my feet, even though my legs are shaking. A quick look at Kash, and he's still

in the bathroom, washing his hands. I grab his suit jacket, rush to the door, and softly close it behind me.

I run, pushing people out of my way, tears rolling down my face. I feel sick, my stomach turning and a sour taste filling my mouth.

"Whoa—"

My upper arm is grabbed, and I'm spun around.

I try to push him off, but the grip just tightens. "Don't." My voice cracks.

He looks me up and down. "Christ. What the fuck happened to you?" He pulls me into a bathroom, and I immediately drop to my knees, gasping for breath.

"I…uh…he…"

"What the fuck did you do?" he growls, grabbing my hair.

"I didn't—" I choke, gripping the toilet. "He's dead," I manage to get out before the first wave hits me and I'm vomiting all the champagne I had tonight.

"You fucking killed him?" He yanks me back by my hair as I get sick all over myself. "Fucking bitch." Hissing, he shoves me to the side, and I curl into myself.

I was disgusted afterward. That I'd allowed this man to touch me. By how easily I'd thrown myself at him.

Kashton's smile just grows, as if he knows how much he affected me. "You were so wet…begging me to fuck you."

My nails dig into my palms.

"You were so loud. I had to place my hand over your mouth so no one would hear you. But I'm more than willing to let the world hear you scream my name now."

"Kashton," I say, trying to calm my racing heart. I should have never let him find me here.

"Yeah, angel?"

I whimper at the mention of the nickname he gave me all those years ago, and it grants me a winning smile. His perfectly straight white teeth glow under the light. He knows what he does to me. "I'm not the same person I was," I warn him.

Then, I had no choice. Didn't know any better. Now, I understand I'm not some bitch a man can use. I'm a fucking storm and can de-

stroy anything in my path.

"Neither am I." He takes a long pull of the cigarette. "See, I wasn't able to do anything about it then, but I can now."

Literal butterflies flutter in my stomach at his choice of words. He wasn't a Lord then. He was going through initiations. Now, he's free and clear and can fuck whoever he wants. "Haven't you married by now?" I drop my eyes to his left hand, hoping he's wearing a ring. There has to be some unlucky woman out there chained to him for the rest of her life. Not like it would matter. They all cheat. Marriage means nothing to them.

Laughter follows once more. "Let's just say I've been looking for the right one."

"Well, most women aren't thrilled to be treated like a pet."

He takes another step closer, and I don't retreat this time. "You want to be collared, angel? Want me to walk you around on a leash?"

I place my hand on my chest and speak. "Yes, please, my Lord. It's my dream to bark for you." I bat my fake lashes like a doting bitch.

A cruel smile graces his face under the moonlight, and it makes him look as handsome as I remember. He's wearing a hoodie, but I can see the ink that covers his hands. He didn't have any tattoos before. Not that I remember anyway. He gave me his suit jacket, but he never removed his dress shirt. "How did you know I prefer bitches over pussycats?"

"Call it a woman's intuition." I roll my eyes, avoiding eye contact.

He steps into me, and I tilt my head, unable to stop myself, and meet his stare. My heart is hammering in my chest at our closeness. He lifts his free hand and pushes the hair back from my face, his fingertips grazing my skin. My body shivers from the contact, but I'm going to blame it on the cool night air.

Blood rushes in my ears and the wind picks up, whipping my hair. He cups my face, and I hold my breath when he leans down. He's no different from any other john. Let them get close and then attack.

"I've been looking for you, Eve."

My skin tingles with excitement at the threat. I whisper, "You found me." I search his pretty blue eyes. "What are you going to do to

me?”

The corner of his lips twitch. “Whatever I want.”

His words send heat running up my spine. When his eyes drop to my lips, I know what’s coming. He’s going to kiss me, and I’m going to let him.

I lick my lips, a silent invitation, as I reach into the pocket of my hoodie. I’ve been prepared for this very moment since he walked into the cathedral with Haidyn to collect their prisoner. I knew he’d make his move, and I vowed to be ready.

Closing my eyes, I let him kiss me. I expect him to be rough and needy, but instead, it’s slow and savory. My hips push into his, and I moan into his mouth as my pussy throbs.

It’s a natural reaction.

He must drop his cigarette onto the ground, because his other hand cups my face as well, and he deepens the kiss, taking my breath away. His tongue dances with mine, and I follow his lead, letting him have control.

I push back the urge to wrap my arms around his neck and instead grip the object in my hoodie before I remove it. My free hand scrapes his scalp, and he moans into my mouth. It’s a shock straight to my pussy, making it tingle.

No. No. No. No, my head screams. Not this again. I will not go back to the old me. I will not let him drag me back to the hell I crawled my way out of.

Opening my eyes, I see his are closed. Ignoring my racing heart, I silently count to three before I yank his head back by his hair, separating our lips, and stab the tip of the syringe into his neck, emptying the contents before yanking it out.

I step back, and one of his hands falls to his side while the other slaps his neck, as if killing a bug that just bit him. “Wh-what?”

“You look unwell.” I step closer to him.

“Eve…” He blinks rapidly.

“I’ve known you’ve been following me, Kash. And like an idiotic man, you took the bait.” I smile, the feeling of control he had over me fading away fast.

He falls to his knees, his body rocking back and forth.

"As much as I love watching a man crumble, I must be going."

He gives a rough laugh as he leans over with his hands now on the ground. "I'll…be seeing you soon, angel," he whispers.

I crouch down, pick his cigarette up off the dirty ground, and take a hit myself before I blow smoke in his face. "No, you won't," I say, and he gives another rough laugh. "Stop following me, Kashton. This will be your only warning."

He blinks rapidly, fighting the sedative, but it's inevitable. When his eyelids finally fall, so does his body—face down onto the ground. I walk over to my bag, unzip it, and get what I want. Then I grab the hem of his hoodie, pushing the thick material to his neck, exposing his inked back.

KASHTON

I blink, groaning at the harsh sun beating down on me while the side of my face is buried in dirt. My mouth feels like sandpaper. "Fu-ucckkk." I roll over onto my back and something sharp pinches between my shoulder blades.

Sitting up slowly, I reach over my head and slide my hand into my hoodie, feeling around for the pesky sting. There's something there… I wrap my fingers around it and yank. Bringing it before my face, I blink a few times to clear the haze in my vision, leaning back against the tree.

It's a ripped piece of paper that I wrinkled. I try to flatten it out the best I can, running my fingers over it to see there are seven words written in red ink.



I chuckle. My future wife has a sense of humor. It's adorable.

Getting to my feet, I stumble, making my way down the hill and toward my car that's parked in front of the cathedral, spitting out the foul taste that lingers in my mouth a few times.

I get to Carnage and park in the circle drive before dragging my ass into the building and up to the office.

Saint and Haidyn both look up at me. Saint opens his mouth as if he's going to continue our argument from the basement, but then he closes his lips, frowning. "What the fuck happened to you?" he asks instead.

Haidyn sits back in his seat. "Looks like you slept outside." His eyes sweep over the dirt, leaves, and stains on my jeans. "This have to do with you and Sin?"

I ignore that. One thing at a time, and right now it's Eve.

"Where have you been?" Saint goes on at my silence. "We've been calling you."

I had my cell off. My girl deserved my undivided attention. "The cemetery." If they were so worried about me, they could have checked my tracker.

"Did you fuck in a grave?" They both laugh at Saint's joke.

I grunt and reach over my head, yanking my hoodie off. Then do the same with my T-shirt. "Is there a tick on my back?" I ask, my voice still thick from the sedative. Fuck, I'm dying of thirst. "Something is biting me." I face away from them so they can take a look.

"What the fuck?" Saint wonders.

"What is it?" I look at them over my shoulder. "Spider bite?" Who knows what the fuck crawled all over me while I lay there on the ground, passed out.

They both ignore me while Haidyn reaches into his pocket and removes his pocketknife. He slaps it open. "Lean over your desk," he orders.

"What?"

Saint presses on the back of my neck, shoving me over the side of my desk. I'm too weak from whatever that shit was Eve gave me to fight him. I know it was a sedative. I'm just wondering how she got a hold of it and why the fuck she had it on her. I highly doubt she sedates her victims before she kills them. A woman like that enjoys the rush. She wants her victims to be awake and look her in the eye when she takes their lives.

Haidyn starts counting. "Three…"

"What the fuck, man?"

"Two…" He yanks something out of my back. Saint lets go of me, and I jump up, spinning around to rub the sensitive spot.

"It's…a staple? Looks like one we use in the basement when we need to put someone back together after we're done playing." Haidyn holds the bloody metal in front of my face. "Why the fuck was this in your back?"

I chuckle. "I'm guessing it was what kept this in place." I pull the wrinkled note out of my jeans pocket and hold it out to them.

Haidyn takes it and frowns, reading it. "Don't fuck with me. I fuck back."

I fall into my chair, lean back, and toss my muddy boots onto my desk. Chunks fall onto the surface.

"Is this some new kink you're trying out?" Saint asks.

"Maybe." I shrug. "If that's what she's into."

"Who?" Haidyn says.

Saint rolls his eyes. "Of course you were out all night with a woman. What does she look like?" He glances over my disheveled hair, dirty jeans, and smiling face. "She's not buried alive in a casket right now, is she? Do we need to dig her out before she dies due to lack of oxygen?"

"Most likely chained in the basement." Haidyn chuckles.

"Not yet." I smile. The chase is half the fun, and something tells me my girl is going to put up one hell of a fight. But I'll win. She will belong to me forever.

I spent most of the day lying in bed, sleeping off the drugs, which pretty much made me useless. I was exhausted, but the IV Devin gave me has helped immensely. Always nice to have a doctor around.

Tonight, I want to go out. Get away from Saint and Haidyn. I'm still not in the mood to talk to them. I ride around town for a couple of hours until I find myself at Blackout.

I walk into Tyson's office and see Sin sitting on the couch. I knew he was here because I saw his bike in the parking lot.

His blue eyes meet mine, and his still bruised face tightens. "I have to run, Ty," he says, getting to his feet.

Ryat silently watches the exchange, noticing Sin's change of mood.

Tyson frowns. "You just got here."

"Yeah, well, something came up," he lies, pulling Tyson in for a handshake hug.

"Okay. I'll see you later," Tyson tells him as he exits.

I go to follow when Ty speaks to me. "Don't make a scene in my club," he warns, knowing something is going on between us.

Ignoring him, I exit his office. The elevator is already closing, so I rush down the stairs and out the back door. "Sin?" I call out, seeing

him headed to his R1. "Easton Bradley Sinnett," I yell, like I'm hollering at my unruly son. It does the trick.

"What the fuck do you want, Kashton?" he barks, turning to face me.

"I want to talk to you." I place my hands in the pockets of my jeans, showing him I'm not a threat. I'm not in the mood to fight him.

"I heard all I needed to hear, and I said all I needed to say."

"We would never rat you out," I assure him.

"We?" he growls.

Fuck.

"Who all fucking knows?" he demands.

I rub the back of my neck but won't lie to him. "Me, Haidyn, and Saint." He already knows Bill is aware because he made the deal with Adam.

"Goddammit. Just fucking great." He gives a humorless laugh.

"Nothing will happen—"

"You can't fucking make that promise," he interrupts me. "And you can't protect Elli if someone talks."

"Move into Carnage."

He snorts.

"I'm serious," I say. "We can protect both of you there."

He shakes his head. "Yesterday I took my wife shopping. We picked out paint for the babies' rooms. Afterward, I took her out to lunch. She finally has the life she deserves. She's a different person…happy. And I can't—I won't—take that from her. I will not force her to hide… to live a life like *he* had in hopes of survival. Plus, he could be on the run for another fifty years."

"You're right." I hate admitting that Adam may never be free again. "But I can protect Ellington if something happens to you."

"No. You can't," he argues. "If I'm dead, she's regifted—"

"Make me her guardian." I'm Charlotte's guardian, but there's no limit to how many brothers can leave me in charge of their wives after they die.

"What the fuck, Kashton?" he barks. "No!"

"It's not like that." I sigh. Sin would die before he willingly let another man touch his wife—romantically or to harm her.

"I'm not a fucking Spade brother." He gives me his back, heading to his bike once again, our conversation over.

I step forward, and my question makes him pause. "What if I can make you one?"

The number of seconds that pass has me thinking I've gotten through to him. And then, finally, he shakes his head. "No. I won't take that chance with her. Even if I could, it would make her invisible. The world would assume she's dead."

"What's better, Sin, huh? The world thinking she no longer exists, or the Lords regifting her to another Lord who passes her around to his friends? And what about the babies—"

His fist connects with my face before I even know he's turned around. I wouldn't fight him anyway. I owe him for what I did when I thought he helped take Adam from us.

"Fuck you, Kash," he shouts, his fists slamming into my chest, knocking me back even farther. "Stay away from me and stay the fuck away from my wife." With that, he gets on his bike, starts it up, revs his engine, and tears out of the parking lot, leaving a fresh black mark.

I make my way back up to Tyson's office, and when I enter, their chatter comes to an abrupt stop. My eyes go to the TV that hangs on the wall, and I see they've got the cameras showing the back parking lot without audio. I look at Ryat, and he smirks as Tyson tosses him a hundred-dollar bill. "I bet Ty that Sin would be the first to throw a punch. The fact that you didn't hit back tells me you deserved it."

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TEN



EVERETT

I guess you could say that I live two lives. The one the Lords want me to have and one that they would kill me for.

It's no secret that the Lords will fuck over whoever they can. They purposely seek out those who betray their oath. They love to make examples of them.

Punishment is key.

It's another night, and I find myself walking up to the cemetery behind the cathedral. I'm here every night. I came to terms with my life years ago.

You're probably wondering why I'd choose this life over death. I asked myself that same question for a very long time.

I used to pray to any god that would listen to kill me. I begged my body to give up and just let go. Certain it'd be better than this hell. Then one day, I had the opportunity to end it myself.

Eighteen years old

I'm officially eighteen. An adult. So they say. It doesn't change who I am or where I've been.

Hell.

Burning in fucking hell.

My father woke me up in the middle of the night, dragged me out of my bed, and threw me into the passenger seat of a car. After he slammed the door shut, he stood outside of it, talking to a man I'd never seen before.

Now, he turns and goes inside while the guy gets in the driver's seat.

"Seat belt," he demands, pulling out of the gates.

"Where…where are we going?" I ask, rubbing my sweaty hands down my thighs.

The guy remains silent, which only raises my concern. My father never lets me leave home. He keeps me secluded and isolated.

My chest hurts from how violently my heart is beating. I'm shaking, my nose running, and my heart is broken. I never thought it would get this bad. A part of me knew, but I never wanted to believe it.

Why me? Why now?

No one can help me. I'm on my own.

My father expects me to just take it. Lie down and accept whatever he wants from me.

Well, lie down isn't the right word. A woman tied down can't run. A woman gagged can't scream for help.

The Lords want us helpless, not compliant. No. The fucking bastards get off on the fight. They feel the most powerful when they hold you down.

"Where are we going?" I manage to control my voice better this time.

The man who's driving begins to whistle.

Fresh tears run down my face, and my stomach knots, thinking about what they did to me. What they're going to do to me. What else is there? They've taken everything I have. My mind, my body, my will. There's nothing left for me to give.

I feel sick and need to vomit again. It's on my shirt and my jeans. I couldn't swallow it anymore.

I can't do this. I won't do this.

The man's phone begins to ring, and he picks it up, placing it to his ear. "Yes, sir," he says. "I understand." He goes back to his fucking whistling.

I know what I have to do. I have no other option. My father has a tracker on me just in case something like this happens. He was afraid I'd run away, but I had nowhere to go.

So why let me leave now? I don't even know how to drive a car to run away. I'm not allowed to have a life. No friends or family other than him. I never got to go to school. Forget college. He controls when and what I eat. When I sleep. He rules everything.

My life is a prison sentence, and he's the warden.

I see the curve coming up ahead as the headlights shine on the road sign signaling to slow down. I take a quick look at the guy who stares straight ahead.

"I'm sorry," I whisper to the one I can't save. We're both doomed. A fate that will only destroy us in the end. "I can't…" My voice trails off as my throat tightens.

"Who the fuck are you talking to? Your father said you were crazy." He's finally speaking to me, but I ignore him.

I won't give my father what he wants. I refuse to allow him to win. Not this time. Not like this.

The turn approaches, and I fist my hands on my lap. This is it. It's my only chance. "Now or never," I whisper.

"What are you—"

I reach over, grab the wheel, and jerk on it, making sure we don't make the curve.

Life is shit, and nothing ever turns out how you plan. My life was already worthless, but my father proved to me that it could only get worse from there. I expected to die that night. Instead, it became my first attempt at suicide.

I've seen a lot of dead bodies. I've heard grown men plead for their lives, knowing it wouldn't do them any good.

I've always thought about death.

How will I die? It's going to happen eventually. No one lives forever. It's the one thing that money can't buy you. Maybe a little more time, but death is inevitable. It comes to collect for all the sins you've committed. And I'm not innocent. So why didn't it take me then? What did I ever do to deserve to survive that night? At least the bastard driving died. And it felt good to know that I rid the world of one more Lord.

Of course, my father found me. When I woke up, I was in a hospital bed, and I remember feeling numb. The one face I never wanted to see again was in mine, yelling at me. He knew I'd done it on purpose, and he used that against me. Told me how pathetic I was. How he'd make sure that I'd live forever. I wanted to laugh because

that's not possible. No one is invincible. Even the ones with the founders' enhancement still die.

"You're useless, Eve." He gripped my face, digging his fingers into my bruised cheeks. *"You're a danger to yourself, Eve."* I wanted to fight him, but my arms were tied to the hospital bed. *"I have to protect you from yourself."* I wanted to laugh. He had never protected me before, but all of a sudden, I meant something to him.

Things got worse before they got better. It's taken me a long time to heal and accept who I was. Thankfully, the past few years have actually been quiet. Until now. The Lords have put Kashton back in my life. They did it on purpose. Now I just need to know why.

What have I done? What did I do wrong? Are they mad at me? I've kept up my end of the deal.

I stay low and keep to myself. I still have no friends. Literally.

It doesn't bother me. I've always been a loner. Not like I had a choice in how I lived my life.

But just because I've seen death all of my life doesn't mean that when someone innocent dies, it doesn't affect me. As coldhearted as I tell myself I am, I know that I'm not.

"When did you notice the body?" the man asks me as he writes in his notebook.

I cross my arms over my chest to protect myself from the night breeze. "However long it took you to get here."

The homicide detective nods. "We'll have to have you come to the station. So we can get a statement."

"You mean interrogate me," I correct him, and he finally glances up from his notebook. "You're getting my *statement* now."

"It's standard procedure, miss."

I shrug it off. They can run my fingerprints and swab the inside of my cheek. They can take a fucking blood sample. It won't matter. I don't exist. They won't find anything.

He continues to ask me questions and writes things down as I watch the crime scene investigators look over the woman's body that was dumped in the middle of the cemetery behind the cathedral. They're gagging at the smell and how mutilated she is.

From what I can tell, she looks young. I could be wrong. I've seen enough bodies to know that she's been dead for a while now. Her body decomposed. Probably left out for days in the sun at another location before she was dumped here.

It's a threat. Even I can see that. No one is ever here. Someone wanted me to find her, but the question is, what did they want me to do with her? I know it wasn't to call the cops. If this is a test, I've already failed.

Did they want me to bury her? Set her on fire? She deserved more than that. Her story isn't going to end like that. She went through hell while she was alive and deserves some peace.

"Okay. Officer Anders will escort you to his car and take you to the station."

The young officer walks over to join us, and I'm guessing he's Anders. His dark eyes run over my skinny jeans, high heels, and T-shirt in a way that makes me want to roll mine. Lord or not, they're all the fucking same.

"Am I under arrest?" I arch a brow.

The young officer places his hands on his duty belt and smirks. My eyes drop to his handcuffs, and I bet the bastard will try to place me in them. They think I'm just some dumb bleached blonde who has to obey their every word.

"Not at the moment, miss," the homicide detective answers before turning to speak to the young officer in a hushed voice.

I remove my cell from my back pocket. I pull up the number of the only person I know can help me. "Hello?" he answers, yawning. "Eve?"

I woke him. "I'm headed to the station."

"Huh?" He clears his throat, and I imagine him sitting up and turning on his bedside lamp. "Train station? Don't be silly. Take the jet. I'll call and have it ready for you. Where would you like to go?"

"Police station," I correct him. "I'm going to be questioned regarding a dead body I found."

"Don't say a word. I'm on my way." He hangs up, and I pocket my cell to see both men staring at me.

I'm not a suspect here, so I'm free to call whoever the fuck I want. "My attorney will meet us there."

The younger one huffs, irritated because he can't take advantage of the situation, and the older one nods. "Good. Good."

Not really. My attorney will eat him alive. He's a Lord, and they're nobodies.

KASHTON

I haven't spoken much to the guys other than when I returned and was in the office. I'm still keeping my distance from them. Nothing got solved, and they obviously don't see an issue with what went down. *Everything is fine with them now*, Saint had told me.

Another bag of IV fluids later, and I'm back to myself. More determined than ever to get the girl.

I decided to go out again tonight. I'm avoiding Carnage, and I don't think the guys even notice. Not like they should. They've got lives beyond that place now. Even if they are still living there.

I'm walking through Blackout when I spot Haidyn and Charlotte heading toward me as the crowd parts for them. It's weird to see them together, him holding her hand, them both wearing wedding rings. Not because I never thought he'd settle down, but because I just never saw it happening with her. Especially after I found out who she really was. I thought it had to be some kind of trick. A fucked-up joke.

Surely, he would have told me that he had fallen in love. That he'd found the one he wanted to spend the rest of his life with. The one he was willing to give up his life for.

I was in denial.

Haidyn made Charlotte that video of him sitting in her living room, and I watched her listen to him tell her that he loved her while also explaining that he had to leave her. She broke down. Right there in front of our eyes. And I knew she loved him too.

I was being a selfish bitch. We have been through so much shit together—initiations and training. It was such a dark time in our lives—we only had each other for so long. I hated having to miss seeing him be happy. And that I hadn't gotten to see him fall in love.

I was going to bring my brother back, and I was going to make sure that the love of his life was alive and well. No matter how mad I was that he didn't include me in such an important part of his life. He made me her guardian, and I had to swallow my pride no matter how hard it was. He gave me a job, and I wouldn't let him down like everyone else in our lives has.

It's different with Saint. We always knew he'd marry Ashtyn. And I knew deep down he'd bring her back to Carnage one day. It didn't matter whether it was four years or twenty, he was going to find his Lady.

"Hi, Kashton." Charlotte speaks over the music, getting my attention, with a smile on her face. She's got this sweet and innocent look to her. It's cute. Especially knowing what kind of man Haidyn is. He's given so much up for everyone else. I'm glad he finally found *the one*.

"Hey." I nod to her and then look at Haidyn. "What are you guys doing here?"

I'm surprised he lets her set foot inside Blackout, knowing she's pregnant. I mean, he can protect her, but still, anything could happen. This place went up in flames not long ago. Though I guess at some point, you have to understand that you can't control everything.

He shoves his left hand into the pocket of his jeans. "What do you mean? Didn't you read the text?"

"Text?" I question. I'm just here to have a drink.

"Tyson included you in the group chat."

Digging into my pocket, I pull out my cell and see that I've got several messages. I didn't hear it go off over the music. Scrolling through the chat, I see a response in the group that makes me sigh.

This will be fun.

"I'm going to escort Charlotte upstairs. The girls are up in the apartment," Haidyn tells me, and I nod to him.

I make my way to Tyson's office and pile inside. Ryat stands over by Ty's desk, arms crossed over his chest. Saint is already here, slouching in a chair.

Sin sits on the couch. He doesn't even glance my way, and I hate how much I care. He's getting ready to be a dad. Devin and Gavin are going to deliver the babies any day now, and I hate that I won't get to be there for him. That is another happy moment for a friend that I'd be honored to be a part of. But of course, I fucked it up and will have to miss it.

A man I've never seen before sits next to Sin. Makes me wonder what the fuck is going on and why we're all here.

The door opens behind me, and I step to the side as four men enter—Ty's minions. They help him run this place and bury his bodies. "What's up, boss?" Alex asks.

Tyson stands from his desk, buttoning his suit jacket, and gestures to the couch on the opposite side of the room. "Have a seat, boys. We're waiting on one more."

While everyone gets comfortable, I choose to stand by the door, leaning up against the wall as it opens.

When Haidyn enters, Tyson claps his hands. "Okay. This is homicide detective Haynes." He points to the man sitting next to Sin, and everyone looks at Tyson, wondering what the fuck is going on. The Lords don't deal with law enforcement. Of any kind. "You're up." Ty nods to him.

The detective gets to his feet and opens up a backpack. He then starts to pass out manila envelopes to each of us. I already know what it's going to be. I feel like I'm having déjà vu. It's like the night on the jet with Adam, Bill, and the detective.

Reaching in, I pull out the stack of papers. The one on top is a profile picture of a naked woman, hanging upside down. The barbed wire wrapped around her ankles is what keeps her hanging from the tree limb. Her skin has ripped open from her struggle and the weight of her body. Her arms are secured behind her back with the wire as well. Blood runs down her bruised skin into a puddle on the ground. Her once short golden hair now looks strawberry blond. She's covered in bruises, and short cuts run horizontally across both thighs.

"Fuck," Alex hisses. "How many were found this time?"

"Seven," the detective answers. "One recovered each day of the week."

"Lords related?" Sin is the one who asks, putting his attention on the second photo, this one of another woman.

The man sighs. "Not that we've found, but the investigation just started." Haynes looks at Ty. "Tyson and I have an…understanding. I bring him information about cases like these."

"I'm confused about what you want us to do." Colton is the one who speaks, running his hand down his face, looking stressed. "Are we supposed to be stepping in? Working with the police?"

"No." Tyson shakes his head. "We thought this ended with Luke, but it didn't. Then, when Haidyn married Charlotte, Dollhouse was brought to our attention."

I feel Haidyn's body stiffen next to mine at the mention of his wife. He drops his envelope onto the coffee table, not even bothering to look through the rest of it. He's seen enough.

"Everyone that we know of, or who we thought was involved, is now at Carnage, and these seven girls have been raped, tortured, and mutilated…" Ty goes on, shaking his head. "It can't be a coincidence. Someone is still running the show."

"LeAnne?" Ryat offers, slamming his envelope onto Tyson's desk as well. "It makes sense. The bitch was able to go under the radar for a long time before Matt thought he killed her. Now she's supposedly moving here. She still has no clue that we're aware she and Isabella are twins, but surely she knows her sister is no longer running Dollhouse."

"Has Blakely spoken to her lately?" Finn asks Ryat.

"Fuck no," he barks. "And she won't be. I've got that bitch blocked everywhere I can. And if she shows up at our house again, I'll blow her fucking head off her shoulders."

The detective adjusts himself in his seat at Ryat's confession, and I wonder just how much Tyson has told him about us. I mean, the guy has to feel threatened just being in the room with this many Lords.

"What if this happened before we found Dollhouse, and this is them getting rid of what they had?" Haidyn suggests.

"Autopsy results aren't back yet, but estimated times of death puts them dead long before they were found," the detective adds.

Colton shakes his head and looks at Haidyn. "We were at Dollhouse with the others to save you, and you were the only person on the property other than Hudson and Isabella. We checked every inch of that place. So if they were at Dollhouse, then someone gave them a heads-up and moved them before we arrived."

"Bill," Sin says. "When Saint asked him how he could be so sure that Haidyn was at Dollhouse, he said he had someone on the inside. But there was no one else there to 'help' us." He sits back and crosses his tatted arms over his chest. "I thought it was too easy how we were able to get Haidyn out of there. But I figured that for once, luck was on our side. Maybe Bill gave them a heads-up that we were coming and gave whoever else was there plenty of time to run so we couldn't question them. They could have held these women somewhere else and then killed them."

"Thought you trusted Bill?" Haidyn asks Sin, and I feel like I've missed out on a conversation they've had.

"Honestly…" Sin sighs, "I don't think I trust anyone anymore."

Me. He means he no longer trusts me. I have the urge to explain myself, but now is not the time.

"What is happening with Dollhouse?" Tyson asks Haidyn.

"Nothing. Charlotte doesn't want anything to do with that place. And as far as I know, since Isabella was a Lady—Bill's wife—everything was left to him."

"What would Bill want with it?" Ty growls.

"I haven't spoken to Bill, and I know Charlotte hasn't." Haidyn shrugs. "So your guess is as good as mine."

When someone is brought into Carnage, they're dead to the world. On paper, they've been given a death certificate with a date and cause of death. Isabella no longer exists, which means whatever she has is given to her spouse unless specified.

"Maybe it was left to LeAnne," Ryat offers.

"Doesn't make sense," Colton speaks up. "Let's say LeAnne is aware we know Dollhouse exists. She had to know that Haidyn was there. And that Bill knows about it as well. If he is on our side, no one would be operating out of there now, because what's to keep any of us from just dropping by on any given day? No. They would steer

clear of there right now. But…" Colton snaps his fingers and sits up straighter. "What about the house?"

"What about it?" Haidyn inquires.

"We never went into the house that night. You were in an entirely different location on the property. What if while we were rescuing you, they moved everyone to the house. Then when we left, they moved them back?" He shrugs. "Because it was like a week later that you guys went to the house, right? Looking for the founders' enhancements? They could have just shuffled the women around while we went from one location to another. Because each time, Bill knew you were going and could have given them the heads-up."

"It's possible." Haidyn nods to himself.

"I think it's dumb of us to assume they only operate out of one location," Ryat says with a shrug. "Surely they have multiple sites for situations like this…to move them."

"What is this Dollhouse?" the detective asks, reminding us that he's still in the room. "I need its address so I can get a warrant—"

"Stay the fuck away from it. We don't need one," Tyson interrupts him and adds, "It's for us. Not for you." The detective sighs.

"So what do we do about Bill?" Ryat goes on.

"Nothing," I rush out, and everyone looks at me. "We need proof." I try to think rationally.

There are four of us in this room who know why we can't hand over Bill. Adam made a deal with him. If we kill Bill, what happens to our brother? Who protects him? He's been on the run for four years. I won't have his blood on my hands. Maybe this was Bill's plan all along. To get wrapped up with Adam so we couldn't take him down. He knows we're loyal to each other and would do whatever we need to do for one another.

"You're close with him." Tyson looks at Sin. "Can you get in touch with Bill? See what you can find out without making it look like you're digging for information?"

"He's practically Haidyn's father-in-law," Sin states, pointing at Haidyn. "Have him do it."

Sin doesn't want to get involved. He thinks I've betrayed him, and now that there's a possibility Bill is no good, he doesn't want him

around Elli or his unborn children. I hate that he can even think I'd put his family in danger.

"We haven't had any contact with him since he was at Carnage last." Haidyn shrugs.

Lie. But for good reason. None of them need to know about our midnight flight in his private jet after Adam's pretend funeral.

"But it doesn't add up," I say. "Dollhouse is about human trafficking and sex slavery. Torture and rape make sense due to the nature of that god-awful place, but why kill them when they could be useful to their business? Why waste your product?" It's Business 101. You don't smoke your stash, because then you don't have any product to sell. Why kill the women they could make money off of?"

Tyson rubs his chin, and the detective just scratches the back of his neck. No one has an answer for that.

"What about the bodies?" Ryat asks, looking at the detective. "Seven bodies in seven days? Seems like a game to me. How did you know where they were?"

"We got calls."

"From whom? Have you vetted them?" Ryat goes on.

"Yeah." He crouches down and digs into his backpack again. Pulling out a notebook, he lays it on the coffee table and licks the tips of his fingers before riffling through the pages until he finds what he wants. "All were found in places they died except for one. Random calls from campers, hikers, passersby."

"How do you know they were found where they were killed?" I ask.

"The scene…and blood." Haynes looks at me. "They were tortured where they were found, except for this one." He looks through the pictures on the table and then pushes one out of the pile. It's of a woman lying naked in the middle of a cemetery. She lies across a grave, face down, hands secured behind her back with barbed wire, her ankles bound as well. It's wrapped around her neck and all around her face. Several fingers are missing and she's covered in bruises and old scars, and what looks like burn marks cover her thighs.

I've seen this grave before.

"What's up with the burn marks?" Ryat asks. "Think they tortured her for information? Maybe it wasn't about selling them; maybe they knew something."

"She was burned in three places and had several fingers removed. All while still alive." The detective looks up at him. "As far as we can tell, they were removing tattoos…birthmarks. Anything that would stand out. Her parents had pictures of her all over the news when they reported her missing three months ago. If, for whatever reason, she had to be moved and a civilian spotted her, they wouldn't want her to have any distinguishing marks."

"I feel like a woman with missing fingers would cause more of a scene than a birthmark," Alex observes and shrugs. "But that's just me."

Ryat glances away, running a hand down his face.

"What's…carved into her back?" Sin asks, leaning forward to get a better look.

"*You're next*," the detective answers. "That was also done while she was still alive." Standing up, he places his hands on his hips. "She was the last one found, but we think she was the first to be killed because she had been dead for quite some time. And she was the only one who appeared to be dumped."

"Where?" Ryat growls when he doesn't explain the exact location.

"A cemetery." He checks his notes. "It was behind a cathedral—"

Everyone starts talking at once, and Tyson holds up his hands. "Whoa," he hollers, shushing all of us as he looks at the detective and barks, "You said none are related to the Lords."

"They aren't."

"Then how the fuck do you explain where she was dumped?" Haidyn snaps. "Sounds pretty close to the Lords to me. Not many civilians know the cathedral is there, let alone the abandoned cemetery behind it where so many Lords are buried."

The detective shakes his head. "None of the women have any family relation to the Lords."

How the fuck does he know? He's not a Lord, and it's not like a Lord will tell you he's one. Any of these parents could have chosen to keep that bit of information to themselves.

"Doesn't mean she wasn't fucking one," Alex says with a shrug. "They're all over. Barrington and House of Lords. This is a college town. She could have met one here at Blackout. Been fucking him for weeks and not even known who he truly was."

"Who reported the body?" Saint demands. It's the first time he's spoken since we started.

The detective looks at the paper once again and reads off the name. "Everett. Everett Sinclair."

Sometimes I hate it when I'm right.

Haynes goes on, "But she was cleared. Her story checked out. It was just a wrong-place-wrong-time sort of thing."

Bullshit. My girl goes there every night. At least she had been since I started following her.

"Who the fuck is in an abandoned cemetery that belongs to the Lords?" Saint demands. "Doesn't seem like 'wrong place wrong time' to me."

I look over at Haidyn to see if he's catching on. He gives me a soft nod, and my teeth grind. He's thinking exactly what I already know. About five ten, green eyes, bleached blond, and likes to play with a torch. "I'll look into it," I tell everyone.

All eyes are on me now. "What do you mean, you'll look into it?"

I'm surprised Sin is speaking directly to me, but the way he rises to his feet and shoves his hands into the pockets of his jeans tells me he thinks I'm up to something. Like I said, he no longer trusts me. "I mean I'll look into it," I repeat. That's all anyone in this room is getting out of me.

Saint and Haidyn don't know who the woman was that stapled the threat to my back, and now I'm glad I kept that to myself.

"Sorry if that doesn't give me any reassurance. We recently find out there's a fucking sex trafficking ring that involves the Lords, and some of us in here have wives with children on the way." He steps closer to me.

"Sin—"

He lifts his hand to cut off Haidyn, then continues to speak to me. "I don't know about the others, but when it comes to my pregnant wife, I don't trust anyone to do what's best for her. And when it

comes down to it, you sure as fuck can't protect her." With that, his cold stare moves to Haidyn. Then he rips the door open and storms out of Tyson's office.

A silence falls over the room before it's interrupted when a member of the Blackout staff comes over Tyson's speaker from the phone on his desk. "Fight. Three guys."

"Go," Tyson orders, pointing to the door, and his four men jump up and rush out of the room.

"Well, I'll keep you updated." The detective picks up his backpack and nods to Ty, who does the same.

Once he leaves, Haidyn pushes off the wall. "Off the record?" he asks.

Tyson sits back in his chair. "Of course." His eyes going to each of us.

"I don't think these women were at Dollhouse," Haidyn states.

Ty frowns. "What makes you say that?"

I plop down on the couch opposite Saint, in the spot Sin just vacated, and pick up the photos scattered across the table. "We recently found out some information…" I trail off, looking over the seven girls. Each one had their fair share of torture and I'm sure were raped. Who knows what they endured or for how long.

One is lying by a creek bed, her throat slashed. My stomach tightens at how familiar it looks. Some might think that's a quick death, but the bruising to her sunburned skin tells a different story. They strung her up outside for days, leaving her to rot. By the cuts on her chest and stomach, they probably cut her enough to bleed but not die. The blood would attract animals to feed off her. Until someone came along and decided her life was over and ended it.

"I'm listening," Ty says.

I pick up a few pictures and drop them on his desk. He lowers his eyes to scan them once again.

"What am I looking for, exactly?"

"No barcodes."

He frowns. Looking back up at me. "What do you mean barcodes?"

"We recently found out that Adam's chosen was a victim at Dollhouse. She had a barcode on her inner thigh. None of these women

have them. Nowhere on their bodies that I can see, anyway."

"Is it a tattoo or like something they can actually scan?"

I tilt my head to the side and Haidyn runs a hand down his face. "I…we don't know," he responds.

"What does it matter?" Saint growls. "It's definitely a mark of some kind."

"I gave my guys a tattoo that has a certain type of ink that can be traced. It scans and grants them access to Blackout at all times," Tyson explains.

I get a sickening feeling in my gut.

"So if it's the same kind of ink…maybe members of Dollhouse scan it," Tyson offers.

"Can you track it?" Haidyn asks.

"Like GPS? No." Ty turns on his computer. His fingers fly over the keys before a screen pops up on the TV hanging on the wall, showing us a schedule that has names and time stamps. "But it does log every time someone uses it to enter."

"Maybe that's why she had it. To keep track of who they use and when they use them. Can it be linked to an account?"

"What do you mean by account?" Tyson wonders.

"Like payment. You pick a girl. Scan the code, automatic payment to use her."

"I don't see why not. It would depend on what type of program they use." He shrugs. "But I don't know why they'd want a trail. It would be too easy to find who paid for each girl and when. There's no disputing something like that."

I nod in understanding and get to my feet. But why would they have to dispute it? I'm sure they've been getting away with this for years.

"You know he's in way over his head, right?" Haidyn says to Tyson, referring to the detective feeding us information.

"Yeah." He sighs, sitting back in his chair. "The guy is going to end up dead, but at least he'll be useful while he's still breathing."

"Do you think he's telling you everything?" Saint asks.

"I think he's telling me enough."

"He has no clue what he's looking for," Saint adds.

"Obviously." He taps the photo of one of the women. "You guys know more by just looking at them than he does. But I'll make sure he continues to show us what he has, and we'll do our own investigating."

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ELEVEN



EVERETT

“Lullaby” by Niykee Heaton blares from the speaker that I have sitting on the floor by the stairs that lead up to the balcony.

The song carries through the large cathedral as I stand next to the Lords’ altar, taking my time on the guy who lies on it. His arms are tied above his head, and his legs are spread wide.

He’s sobbing behind his gag while I thread the needle through his ashen skin. He’s lost a lot of blood from the razor blades. The Lords did a number on him tonight.

I find it ironic that they torture themselves. Maybe they’ll eventually kill all the Lords off.

A few times, I’ve thought about setting the place on fire while they have a confessional. If I locked all the exits, I could probably kill over a hundred at once. Including myself. But every time I think about it, I tell myself to wait. Another time, another day. Why settle for a hundred when you can kill a hundred and one? I just need the right opportunity.

The sound of the double doors creaking lets me know someone is here. I don’t bother looking up, but the naked Lord starts screaming into his gag as if they’ve returned to cut on him again. Demanding more blood in payment.

I tie off the thread and cut it before setting aside the needle and scissors.

Looking up, I see a Lord sitting in the front pew. He’s leaning back, arms spread wide and a smirk on his handsome face. I remove the bloody gloves from my hands and pause the song before I speak. “Two visits in the same week. Why am I all of a sudden so unlucky?”

Kashton's smile grows. "Angel." He winks at me, and I want to shove my needle and thread through his lips and sew his mouth shut so he can't call me that ever again.

"Come back for more drugs?" I tease.

"Careful, Eve. Fool me once… Next time, you'll be the one drugged." His eyes lazily look over my body. "But I won't leave you all alone. When you wake up, you'll be naked and hog-tied."

I almost trip off the side of my heels but manage to stay upright. That's what he wants. To see me kneel for him. "What do you want, Kash?" I walk around the altar, ignoring the sobbing Lord, and come to stand in front of Kashton. I pop a hip out and place my hands on them.

His blue eyes drop to my heeled lace-up ankle boots and slowly run up over my fishnet tights and miniskirt before lingering on the black halter that has my breasts shoved up to my neck. He tilts his head to the side, looking over my high pony before meeting my gaze. I try to look unfazed, but my body is tingling.

"Look at me, Eve. Eyes on mine…fuck, you're goddamn perfect."

It was like he knew what I needed to hear. I hadn't felt like that with a man…not willingly, anyway. And it was just his fingers. I'd had a few drinks that night, but I wasn't on any drugs. There was no reason for me to be that worked up for him.

His face grows serious and his eyes dart to the naked Lord behind me. "May we speak in private?"

I give a rough laugh. "You'll have to try harder than that to get me alone."

He stands, and I have to look up at him through my lashes. Even with my boots on, he's still quite a bit taller than me.

"It's important, Everett." He places his hands inside his hoodie.

As far as I know, he's only ever known me as Eve. How does he know my name is Everett? I get a sickening feeling in my gut. "Sure," I say and walk toward the side door.

He beats me to it and holds it open. "Ladies first."

I want to roll my eyes but instead mumble a *thank you* and enter the hallway. He follows me to the office where he again opens the door for me. Once we enter, I whirl around on him. "What's so im-

portant that you're here at three in the morning, Kashton?" Not like the Lord tied and gagged on the altar is going to tell anyone his secret.

Kashton unzips his backpack and tosses something onto the desk.

I pick it up and stiffen when I see what it is. "Where did you get this?" It's a picture of the dead woman I found.

"Do you know Tyson Crawford?"

Of course I know of him. "He owns Blackout." We're not friends or anything, and he has no idea who I am.

Kashton nods, sitting on the couch. "He has a deal with a detective. We had a meeting earlier this evening, and everyone there was given these reports." My eyes meet his. "And your name was mentioned."

Well that explains *Everett*. I frown. "What do you mean my name was mentioned?"

"He announced to the room that Everett Sinclair found the body that was dumped in the cemetery behind the cathedral."

Fuck! Since when do the cops work with the Lords? I try to calm my breathing so he doesn't see I'm now on alert. Does this have to do with the phone call I made after I received that text? Surely those aren't connected to the body I found.

He leans forward, placing his elbows on his knees. "Tell me everything you know about her."

I give a rough laugh and toss the papers next to him on the couch. "I know nothing."

"Bullshit." He stands and I take a step back. "Whoever did this to her carved *You're next* into her back, then dumped her in the middle of an abandoned cemetery that you seem to visit. A lot. I mean, sure, you can call that a coincidence, but…I don't believe in those." His eyes hold mine when he adds. "And she just so happened to be left on the very same grave I see you sit at."

I knew it was a sign, but this confirms it. "What are you implying?" I cross my arms over my chest.

"That warning is for you," he says matter-of-factly.

I swallow nervously. "It's not—"

"What do you know about Dollhouse?" he interrupts me.

"Nothing."

His hand reaches out and wraps around my neck so quickly I don't have time to react before he's yanking me toward him.

"Kash—"

He cuts off my air, and my hands grip his tatted arms to try and rip free with no success because of the sleeves of his hoodie. His blue eyes darken as they search mine. "I can't help you if you lie to me, angel. So I'm going to ask you one…last…time…" He lets go, shoving me backward, and my ass hits the desk, making it rattle. "What do you know about Dollhouse?"

I rub my sore neck, taking a deep breath. "I know it hasn't been in operation for several years."

He frowns. "Not true."

I snort. "You calling me a liar?"

He nods. "I am."

I huff, looking away from him, unable to meet his stare as I lie. "No one has been there in a long time."

"How much do you know about Isabella?" he questions.

"I don't—"

"I did meet you at her party." He's referring to the night on her and her husband's mega yacht. When I let this monster touch me. "The man I killed was paying you—"

"He was going to rape me," I correct him through gritted teeth.

He tilts his head to the side. "Someone was getting paid for it. So he was either your job or you were his whore. Which was it?"

My pulse races. "My life is none of your business, Kash." I will not let him know about my past. That will open too many doors for him.

"Were you one of her *dolls*?"

My knees threaten to buckle at his question, and it makes me want to vomit. *"You're going to be such a pretty dolly."*

He goes on, stepping closer to me. "Maybe you were a prisoner of Dollhouse, and she was pimping you out that night?" He reaches out and runs his hand through my ponytail. "A beautiful whore, wrapped in silk. Who wouldn't want to fuck you, Eve?"

"You don't know anything about me," I say through gritted teeth. *Breathe, Eve. Get your shit together.*

"I know that the moment I saved you, you threw yourself at me like a drunk woman on a Saturday night." He smirks. "You wanted to repay me…and like a good whore, you spread your legs for me—"

I slap him across the face so hard my hand instantly stings. "How dare you."

He grips my throat again and tosses me onto the couch. Straddling my hips, he pins me down, giving him the advantage. I slap at his face, but he stretches his arm out, and I'm unable to make contact with his reach. I yank on his hoodie, but it doesn't do any good.

"Let me tell you something, angel." His eyes are soft, but his words are as hard as the muscular body he's holding me down with. "A room full of Lords think you're part of the problem. And if I don't bring them answers, they'll come after you for them. Do you understand that?"

My lungs burn, and I squirm in his grip, trying to get a breath. Where are my drugs when I need them? I try and buck my hips, but it does no good. All of his weight is pinning me to the leather cushions.

Panic grips my chest, and my face throbs from the lack of oxygen. I kick my legs, the heels of my boots digging into the couch, and try to twist and turn to get a breath, but it does no good.

His hand tightens more on my throat while he lifts his hips off my waist, and his free hand shoves my miniskirt up before gripping my fishnets and ripping them. His eyes scan my exposed thigh before he does the same to the other. Once he's done looking at them, he places his weight back on them and his eyes find mine. My vision is fading in and out as my eyes grow heavy.

"These Lords have wives, babies on the way. And I promise, they won't think twice about dangling you as bait to make sure that their families go untouched." Letting go of my neck, he gets off me, and I roll off the edge of the couch, landing on my side, coughing and sputtering.

As I get to my hands and knees, he crouches in front of me and cups my chin, forcing my watery eyes up to his. His free hand gently pushes away the loose strands of hair that fell from my ponytail dur-

ing our fight. "I'm the only ally you have right now, Eve. I can protect you."

I give a rough laugh, still trying to breathe. "I…don't need your protection."

His eyes roam my face and linger on my parted lips. I'm gasping, sucking in deep breaths, my chest burning. "You're not untouchable, Everett. All I had to do was get you alone in a room and wrap my hand around your pretty neck." He gently runs his tatted knuckles down my burning throat, and I lift my chin higher at the touch. "And within seconds, you were on your back with ripped stockings. Imagine what a room full of Lords could do to you. It won't take much for them to strip you naked, tie you down, and make you the offering they need."

If only he knew how close he is to my past. I've been there, and I refuse to go back. "Are you going to protect me or lead them to me?" I arch a brow. *Don't trust anyone* is what I've learned along the way.

"They already know where you are, angel. It's a matter of time before they show up at your door." With that, he gets to his feet, grabs his backpack, and exits the office, leaving me on all fours.

KASHTON

Junior year at Barrington University

I enter my father's office to find him and his brothers all at their desks. I walk over to my father's. "I know who I want for my chosen."

"You don't get to choose." Garrett, Haidyn's dad, speaks as if I was talking to him. The thing about the Spade brothers is that they all think they're your dad.

My father looks up at me from his computer and sits back in his chair. "Name," he asks, picking up his pen.

"Eve," I answer.

His pen pauses on the piece of paper, and he looks up at me. "Eve what?"

"That's all I know," I say honestly.

He drops his pen. "Does she go to Barrington?"

"Not that I know of." I've never seen her there before. I would have remembered her, but it's a huge college. So it's always a possibility.

He sighs, and I hear the others laugh. "Well…how the fuck do you know her?" my father demands.

I think about that for a second and decide I can't lie to him. Not about this. I want her more than anything for my senior year. "During my initiation. On the Isabella." That was last month, and I can't get her out of my head. Where the fuck did she go? We were on a yacht. Did she jump off it after she left me? I searched everywhere for her, only to come up empty. The only thing she was wearing was my suit jacket. She didn't even take her heels. No purse. No phone. Nothing. Did she get killed for what I did to the Lord she was with? She probably had a pimp and was punished for not doing her job.

My father frowns.

Garrett's laugh gets my attention. "Son, if she was on the Isabella*, then she's a prostitute…"*

"Meaning she's not a virgin," my father adds.

My teeth grind. I already knew this. All Lords get a chosen their senior year at Barrington University. After we're initiated into the Lords. But only the Spade brothers are required to take a virgin. "I want her." I don't give a shit who she's fucked.

"If she was on that yacht, then we've probably all fucked her." My father shakes his head, and I fist my hands at the thought of them raping her like that Lord was going to do. "The answer is no."

"Dad—"

"No, Kashton," he snaps. "You will not take a whore. She will be a virgin, and I will pick her out." He places his attention on his computer. Conversation over.

I lie in my bed back at Carnage, staring at the TV, but I don't hear it. Eve is heavy on my mind.

She doesn't have the barcode. Could that mean she was telling the truth? I don't know. Just because Adam's chosen had one doesn't mean they all get one. What if that barcode was a breadcrumb for Adam and not Dollhouse itself, and we're just wrong?

A conversation that night on Bill's jet comes to mind. *"What's on her inner thigh? What does it say?" Saint asks, looking at the photo*

of Adam's chosen tied to the chair.

"It's a barcode. All slaves at Dollhouse have them," Bill answers.

Haidyn and I were both forced to kill our chosens. I say forced because it was either that or a life of rape and torture. Sometimes death is all you have.

I made the decision to end her life. Was I wrong? I'll never know. I remember begging my father for Eve to be my chosen. I've never been more thankful that he said no. I don't know if I would have been able to kill her when Isabella took us in for training.

It's easy for me to say yes. That I want to think I would save her from such a horrific life, but she wasn't the bleeding woman who was tied up and naked, begging me to help her.

I've been looking for Eve for years, and now here she is. Dropped in my lap like an answered prayer. The only thing is, a Lord doesn't pray.

I want to question it, but I want her more.

Everett Sinclair will not get away from me this time. If I have to drag her to the basement and leave her chained there like a dog, she will not slip through my fingers. She'll wear my ring and have my last name.

My father raised me to be a Spade brother, and I will treat her as a prisoner if I have to.

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TWELVE



EVERETT

Do you ever feel like you're supposed to be someone else? I was meant to be a boy. Even the doctors said I'd be a boy. So my father named me Everett.

It's predominantly a male name. When I was born with a pussy, he decided to keep it.

I've gone by Eve for as long as I can remember. It was a hard pill to swallow to find out that I'd never live up to my name's expectations. Who I was supposed to be. Someone who'd make my father proud. The sad thing is that I wanted to for the longest time. To be what he wanted. To be accepted. I've never belonged to someone. I was born for a purpose but ended up being useless. Then I was tossed to the side and raised for evil reasons.

My life would have been different had I been born with a dick. Easier.

At least I like to think so. A woman can dream, can't she?

There's a lot of my childhood that I've blocked out. Chosen not to remember. But after I tried to end my life the first time, I became useless to our world. So my father gave me away. No, *threw* me away is more like it.

I spent a year in hell before a man came along and saved me. I've called him *Dad* ever since. He saved my life more than once. I'm lucky he came along when he did. Who knows where I'd be if not for him?

Dead. No questions asked. Because I would have done it differently the next time, and I would have made sure it worked. A person can

only take so much before they break. And I've been so close to broken that death was the only alternative.

Acceptance is such a weird word. Like why do you need to be accepted? Why do you want to be loved? It's overrated. Love comes and goes and so do my mood swings. One moment I want to cry my eyes out to an Adele song, thinking I'll be single the rest of my life, and the next I'm thanking my lucky stars I don't have to answer to anyone.

Life is all about balance.

Good and evil. Heaven and hell. Crazy and sane.

Why not be both?

Statistics show that more than thirty-six murderers walk past you during your lifetime. Do you ever wonder why they don't choose you? I do. All the time. Do they choose victims by their looks? How they act? Is it someone they know, or do they pick at random?

I'm a loner. I stick to myself. I'd be an easy choice, honestly. No one would go looking for me. Well, that's not true. My dad would notice. But other than that, no one would care.

That's why I agreed to join him for dinner tonight. Something we never do. I stay away from him because he had another family that I had to hide from. Story of my life. It never bothered me before. But now he's married another woman and wants us all to be one big, happy family.

I pull my car up to the mansion and get out, straightening my dress. It makes me uncomfortable being here. I'm not used to this part of their world.

The money.

The class.

I'm used to the basements, chains, and blood.

I grew up differently from most of the women in the society. I've watched behind the scenes for years as women became chosens and Ladies. The sad part is, I was jealous.

I wanted to be a chosen—belong to one man. But I was born for a purpose that I can't even fulfill. Not anymore. It was a decision I had to make, and I've come to terms with it.

The front double doors open, and I sigh when I see the pretty blonde stepping outside onto the porch. "Everett, I thought that was you. Please come in."

Giving her a fake smile, I walk up the stone steps in a pair of black spiked Louboutins. They were a gift from my dad. Said he saw them and instantly thought of me using them to kick a man in the balls. Have to love a father who encourages your rage.

"Hello, Janice. It smells lovely," I tell her, entering the house, though I know she didn't make it. Her staff did. I can't be mean to her, though. She's been so nice and welcoming to me and the man I choose to call Dad.

"Thank you. Please make yourself comfortable. Can I get you a drink?"

"Yes, please." I'd take a whole bottle of whatever she has, but that would make me look like a lush. One drink can't hurt. She did offer.

Janice walks off toward the kitchen, her heels clapping on the marble floor, and I nervously slide my hand down my dress. A bad habit that I wish I could break. I hate looking weak or nervous, but I'm not a family type of girl. Yet here I am, willingly accepting an offer to have dinner with my family. At least, that's what my dad called it when he phoned me yesterday. I couldn't resist. He wants everything to be perfect for his new *wife*.

So I obliged and promised to indulge him by showing up to this dinner. I wish I had someone who cared about me as much.

The doors open behind me, and I hear laughter as I turn around to see two familiar faces. They don't know who I am, but I know them.

"Oh, hello." The bleached blonde smiles at me.

The man holding her hand looks me up and down with apprehension. He knows I don't belong. That I'm no one. "Who the hell are you?" he asks. His hard tone mirrors what I'm thinking.

The woman softly slaps his chest in a warning to be nice, but I don't act bothered. It's only fair that he asks that question. Since this is his mother's house.

"Everett, but, please, call me Eve." I hold out my right hand to her because that's what you do when you want to get to know someone.

The woman smiles, taking her hand from his in order to shake mine. "Ellington," she introduces herself. "But you can call me Elli." Then she places her hand on the man's chest, smiling proudly. "This is my husband, Easton."

His eyes narrow on mine, as if he's heard of me. Then he looks me up and down again, but this time he's sizing me up. Seeing how hard it'll be for him to snap my neck. After how easily Kashton took me to my knees, I know it wouldn't take this man much.

Elli drops her hand to her growing belly, and I look over her halo wedding ring. This is one of the families that Kashton warned me about. Easton is one of the men who will throw me into the fire to save his loved ones. I can't blame them for that. I wish I had someone who loved me enough to sacrifice someone else.

But as I learned at a young age, not everyone deserves to know what it feels like to be loved.

KASHTON

I sit in the office with Haidyn and Saint. We're still not on the best terms. We all seem to be ignoring the elephant in the room, and I'm allowing it. If they don't want to talk to me, I'm not going to force them.

The door to the office opens and Jessie enters, clearing his throat. "You guys have a visitor," he announces and then steps to the side.

We all sit up straighter when Sin walks in behind him. Last time he was in this room, he was here on official Lords business—to kill Adam.

"What's up, man?" Haidyn asks, giving him a handshake hug. I stay where I'm at because he's still not speaking to me. "How's Elli doing?"

"Good," he answers with a faint smile.

"Why do I have a bad feeling about this?" Saint asks, falling into his seat.

I point to the chair across my desk, and Sin takes it, running a hand through his hair. "As I'm guessing, you all know Kash came to see me about Adam. You're all aware that I didn't kill him."

I frown, wondering why he's here wanting to discuss it now. I've tried to talk to him about it, and he's done nothing but blown me off.

"Have you heard from him?" Saint asks, sounding hopeful. Placing his elbow on his desk, he leans forward.

"No," Sin answers. "I haven't had any communication with Adam. I don't even know…" He trails off and then sighs. "I didn't know any of you even existed until Ryat overheard that Elli's dad was at Carnage." He rubs the back of his neck. "But I know Bill."

Haidyn nods, and I wonder why he's telling us this. We were just talking about Bill in Tyson's office. Maybe he didn't want to give too much information away with so many people in the room.

"I trusted him. Bill helped me with Elli. I was going to marry her but knew our families wouldn't allow it. I went to Bill; he came to our house and snuck a marriage license into the stack of paperwork she was signing to add her to the house. Deal done. We were married. Husband and wife. The Lords found out…"

"You think Bill told them?" I wonder, cutting him off. He said he *trusted* him. Something tells me he doesn't anymore.

He sighs. "I don't know." He stands and starts to pace the large office. "A Lady getting an assignment to prove her loyalty isn't anything to think twice about. But no one knew other than Bill and me. Not even Elli knew at that point."

"What about Chance?" Haidyn asks.

"I…I called her my wife once to him, but he didn't know it was official. He knew that was the plan, but I kept it a secret." He takes a deep breath. "The Lords made me put her through hell. She didn't have to kill someone or do anything for them. However, they pretty much wrote her off, said she couldn't be a Lady, but that if she proved herself to be faithful to me, I could 'keep' her," he growls, walking to the floor-to-ceiling windows. Crossing his arms over his chest, he continues, "It didn't matter what they wanted me to do; I was going to make sure she stayed my wife. Even if that meant making her think I didn't love her." He turns to face us. "They made Chance test her and she passed. She was mine. Forever. But I knew there was a timeline for how long I got to keep her. Before I gave myself over to you guys, I went to see Bill again. He set me up with papers to make sure Elli was taken care of. Since I'd be *dead*." We all remain silent as we let him get whatever is bothering him off his

chest. “I was in his office a few weeks ago getting stuff together for the babies. Elli and I want them to be twins on paper…from birth. No adoption. No bullshit. In case something happens to me. He was setting it all up when I got a text. An assignment…”

“Adam,” Haidyn guesses when he trails off.

Sin nods and confirms. “Adam. I’m reading the text and thinking *what the fuck?* I didn’t even know the Spade brothers existed six months ago, and now they want me to kill one of you? Bill could tell I was stressed. Asked what was wrong. I told him, and he said he could help.”

I stiffen and Haidyn stretches his neck while Saint lets out a growl. We’re starting to understand why he’s so confused.

“He calls Adam up right then and there and puts him on speaker. I sat there while they put together this plan for me to make it look like I killed him.”

Saint stands and runs a hand down his face.

“How did Adam know Bill?” I wonder.

“Through his boss?” Haidyn guesses. “Bill and the detective seemed very close on the private jet that night. And then there was that sketchy phone call the detective got…” He shrugs.

“It’s fishy. Adam’s been hiding for four years, then makes an appearance, and all of a sudden Bill wants to help him.” Saint shakes his head. “I’m not buying it.”

“I didn’t think much about it at first,” Sin goes on. “I just knew I didn’t want three Spade brothers on my family because I killed one of them.”

“And now?” Saint questions. “Why come to us about this now? What’s changed that’s got you questioning Bill?”

“My father and mother-in-law are both prisoners here at Carnage. My father-in-law and Tyson traded them for me.”

“You’re not getting anyone back,” Saint reminds him. “What we did for you was a one-time thing.”

“I—”

Saint goes on. “You can choose one thing when it comes to Laura, but that’s it. She stays here. She remains ours after she delivers, and so does your father.”

"No." Sin raises his hand. "I don't want either of them. You can bury them both alive for all I fucking care."

Haidyn leans back in his chair. "Then what do you want?"

"My mother called me yesterday, wanted to have Elli and me over for dinner. We've kept our distance…after we found out what my father did to my wife…" He swallows. "But Elli urged me to go. Said she wants the babies to have a family. One that she never had. So we went. And Bill was there."

Haidyn frowns. "Why the fuck would he be at your mother's house?"

Sin sits across from me once again and his knees begin to bounce. "Elli recognized him, of course, because he was at our house when she signed the papers, but after we left my mom's, she said she remembered him from her mother's house…the night she married Lincoln."

"He was friends with Laura or Lincoln?" Saint asks.

"I don't know." Sin sighs. "But it got me thinking. What if Bill set all this up?"

"You're going to have to be more specific." Saint lets out a long breath.

Sin turns to look at Haidyn. "Bill knew Charlotte's future at Dollhouse because of Isabella. Bill also knew that you had a deal with Isabella for Adam. What if Bill wanted you to fall in love with Charlotte, knowing you'd leave her with your brothers, who would then go after you, knowing you'd lead them to Dollhouse?"

Haidyn scratches the back of his head.

"Bill did tamper with Charlotte's IV treatments to make sure you knocked her up." Saint nods at Haidyn.

"He could have burned Dollhouse to the ground at any time but chose to let you sit there for a week," Sin growls.

Saint shakes his head. "No. Bill said he thought he knew where Haidyn was, but that he was waiting for confirmation he was there."

"Maybe he lied." Sin gives a humorless laugh. "Not the first time a Lord has lied for his own benefit. Besides, who is the inside *someone* that he was awaiting confirmation from?"

The room falls silent, and Haidyn leans forward, placing his head in his hands. "What does any of this have to do with Bill being at your mother's last night?"

Sin sighs heavily. "Like I said, my father is here. He's dead to the world and to the Lords." He turns to face Haidyn once again. "And so is Isabella—Bill's wife—Charlotte's mother."

Haidyn slowly gets to his feet, his face sharper, his jaw harder. "Get to the fucking point, Sin," he growls, not liking the fact that Sin brought up his wife.

"While at my mom's last night, she announced that she's been regifted…to Bill."

Fuck.

The room falls silent, but everyone might as well be screaming with the way you can hear our minds working.

"Sin—"

"How much do you trust him?" Sin demands. "Because I thought I could, and now…" He jumps up and shoves his hands through his hair. "Now he's my…stepdad? Putting himself in my mother's life. And Elli—what the fuck is he doing?"

"Lords don't get to choose who they are gifted," Saint says softly.

"He chose Isabella, didn't he?" Sin snaps, glancing at Haidyn. "After you murdered his best friend. Her husband." Haidyn says nothing to that. "We just found out weeks ago that our wives are founders…so I'm not sure what the truth is anymore."

"I…I don't know." Haidyn exhales.

"We know that Bill is high up. Maybe he pulled some strings to get to marry my mother," Sin suggests.

"Why would he chance his rankings with Adam?" Saint frowns. "If the Lords find out he's helping him…he's as good as dead."

"Adam didn't seem to trust him, and it made me second-guess why he took the deal," I add.

"What do you mean Adam didn't trust him?" Haidyn wonders.

"We weren't the nicest to Charlotte," Saint informs him.

"What?" he snaps.

I wave him off. "Adam was protective of Charlotte. Told her to stay away from Bill because he didn't trust him. Then not much later,

we're on a private jet, Adam is *dead,* and he's made a deal with Bill."

"What do you mean, you weren't nice to my wife?" he demands, getting to his feet. "I left her with you to take care of."

"You have to see it from our point of view," Saint growls. "She was the daughter of the woman who tortured us."

"She's my wife," Haidyn barks.

"Can you guys figure your shit out later?" Sin snaps. "You're no longer at Dollhouse," he points out to Haidyn. "And your wife is safe. It's my wife I'm worried about."

Saint snorts. "I can't see him going after Elli. What would he benefit from it?"

"What about Kira?" I dig, trying to look at it from all angles.

Sin shakes his head. "Although I love my sister, I'm not that concerned about her. She's moved out of the house, engaged to my friend. I don't see why Bill would want anything to do with her."

"How did your mother act?"

"She seemed happy with him. It was awkward how comfortable they were." He shivers. "Like she had been seeing him. They got married last weekend on some beach but are planning a big reception at the house in a few weeks with friends and family."

"Did you speak to her about it?" I ask.

"No. I didn't get the chance. We didn't even stay to eat. I could tell Elli wasn't comfortable. So I made up an excuse as to why we had to go, and we left. I planned on going back later but didn't get the chance." He sighs. "But there was also a woman there."

"A woman other than your mother?" Saint frowns. "Who was she?"

"She introduced herself as Everett."

I stiffen.

"As in Everett Sinclair?" Saint's eyes widen. "The woman the detective was talking about?"

"That's the first thought I had." Sin nods but doesn't say anything more.

"And?" I ask nervously.

"And she's Bill's daughter."

Haidyn shakes his head. "Bill doesn't have a daughter."

"He does," Sin argues.

"No. You're mistaken. He practically raised Charlotte these past six years—after I killed her father that night on the *Isabella*. If Bill had another child, Charlotte would have mentioned that. She would have been in their lives."

Sin opens his mouth to argue, but Saint speaks first. "After what we've learned, I don't see it as that far of a stretch that he has a child no one knows about. But it is weird that all of a sudden, we hear her name twice in the same week."

Haidyn picks up his cell and brings it to his ear. "Can you come to the office? … Okay." Setting it down, he speaks to us. "Charlotte will be here in a second. We'll ask her."

"I'm going to get eyes on her," Sin states. "I want to know every move this Everett makes."

Fuck.

"See what I can find out and what she knows," he adds.

"About what?" I ask, getting to my feet, needing the movement.

"About my wife. The dead bodies that were found. Hell, for all we know, she works for Isabella or LeAnne." He shakes his head. "I'm not taking any chances."

I run a hand nervously through my hair, trying to figure out what the fuck to do about this. I've asked her all these questions, and she told me no, but she could easily have been lying. Saving her ass.

"All I know right now is that she's popped up too many times for it to be a coincidence."

I can't argue with that, but I say, "I'll handle it."

Sin narrows his eyes on mine. "That sounds like your 'I'll look into it,' and I don't believe it any more now than that bullshit."

I lean my ass up against the edge of my desk and cross my arms over my chest. If I want them to trust me, I have to tell them. No better time than the present. "I know her."

"Everett?" Saint inquires.

I nod.

"Of course you do." Sin gives a rough laugh. As if somehow, I'm involved in a conspiracy to hurt his wife.

"Actually, we all do."

Saint and Haidyn both shake their heads.

"Yes. You do. Well, you might not have met her in person, but you've seen her." I look at Saint. "She was the bleached blonde on the *Isabella* the night of our junior initiation."

"The one you were drooling all over when the old lady gave you the gum?"

"That's the one." Then I look to Haidyn. "She's the woman from the cathedral."

He runs a hand through his hair and sighs. I just confirmed what he assumed at the meeting at Blackout.

"She was on the *Isabella*?" Sin growls. I ignore that since I just told them as much. "And you've been fucking her," he assumes with a snort. "That's just great."

Technically, I haven't fucked her yet…but that would be splitting hairs, so I don't deny it. "Like I said, I'll take care of it. Understand?"

Silence falls over the room. No one better touch her. If she's been planted in our lives, I'll find out the reason. And if that's the case, I'll also take care of her. How I want.

The door opens and Charlotte steps inside the office. "What do you need?" She looks at her husband.

He walks over to her and pushes her dark hair off her shoulder. "Did Bill have other kids?"

She frowns. "No. Why?"

Haidyn looks at Easton. "Because Sin swears that Bill has a daughter by the name of Everett Sinclair."

Charlotte shakes her head. "That name doesn't sound familiar."

"Their last names aren't the same," Haidyn points out the obvious.

"If he's been hiding her, it makes sense to not give her his last name," Saint offers. "Charlotte had a fake name. Plus, Isabella and LeAnne legally changed their names to hide the fact that they are twins."

"I'm telling you, she's his daughter. She called him *Dad*. My mother introduced her to me and Elli as my stepsister. She belongs to him," Sin argues.

She does have a daddy, the realtor had said. Was Bill the man who'd bought her house? If so, why would he do that for her?

Charlotte nibbles on her bottom lip. "I guess she could be." She looks up at Haidyn. "I mean, my mother has a twin sister, and I thought she was her best friend all my life." Shrugging, she looks at Sin. "What did she look like?"

"Bleached blond with green eyes. Maybe five ten and around our age." He shrugs.

"I have a picture of her," I say, removing my cell from my pocket and pulling up one I took of her one night outside the cathedral.

Showing it to Charlotte, she nods. "Yeah, I've seen her at the cathedral."

Everyone turns to me.

"Blowtorch girl." Haidyn nods, then looks at his wife. "When were you at the cathedral?"

"It was a long time ago. Before my father died. She was sitting in the very back of the pews with us. I thought it was weird because she wasn't wearing a cloak or mask like the rest of us."

"Who else was there?" Saint demands.

"It was full of Lords," she answers. "It was an offering."

"What the fuck was she doing at an offering?" Sin snaps, looking at me as if I know her life story.

But it makes sense, considering she was sewing up the man that Haidyn and I were there to collect after a confessional. So I don't necessarily see that as a red flag. Confessional and an offering are pretty much the same thing. Either way, you've betrayed a Lord.

"LeAnne was there," Charlotte adds, and I run a hand down my face. "She was running the offering."

Fuck. Fuck. Fuck.

Sin looks at me, and before he opens his mouth, I raise my hand. "I'll fucking handle it. Do not lay one hand on her."

Without another word, Sin turns and storms out of the office, slamming the door shut behind him.

"Was this the woman who stapled the letter to your back after you spent the night in a cemetery?" Saint asks.

My silence is all the answer he needs.

"Fuck, Kash," he growls. "I'm guessing it's the same cemetery where the body was found. You had to have recognized it. Why

didn’t you say anything?”

I walk around my desk and sit back down, ignoring him. Haidyn takes Charlotte’s hand, exiting the room.

I try and think of my next move. If she’s Bill’s daughter, how long will it take for word to get out? Why hide her all these years? Why bring her out now? Maybe LeAnne is her mom? I mean, she was gone for years. I wouldn’t be surprised if she had a child with Bill.

Lords share their wives with anyone who wants a taste. It makes sense that they have illegitimate children with one another.

“Kash—”

“I’m not in the mood, Saint.” I cut him off and stand from my desk. Exiting the office, I head up to my room. I’ve got to make my move. Too many people want her head on a platter, and if that’s going to happen, I’ll be the one to do it after I’m done with her.

I’ve waited too long for my chance with her to give up now.

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THIRTEEN



EVERETT

Fifteen years old

I sit on my bed, tightly strapped inside the straitjacket. I've lost count of how long I've been like this.

It just makes it easier for them. They don't like it when I fight back. There's nothing but silence. No TV, no music. They want me to go insane. Lose my mind. A woman doesn't need an opinion or to have thoughts of her own. She just needs a functioning body.

The door opens, and my father enters, followed by a woman I've never seen before. You would think she's here to help me. But I know that's wishful thinking.

She looks at me and frowns. "How long has she been like this?"

"Keep your questions to yourself. You're here because you owe me," my father growls.

She turns to face him. And their size difference is almost comical. My father is six six, and she doesn't even come to his shoulders. It's interesting, though, because she's dressed in a business suit and heels.

She must be important. Like the other bitch who comes and goes. The one who thinks something is wrong with me.

"This is not healthy," the woman states.

"Are you telling me how to raise my kid?" He arches a brow.

I want to laugh at that. This has been my life, and even I know that this isn't how you should treat your child.

"You asked me to help. This is me giving my help."

He crosses his arms over his chest, staring her down.

She's unfazed, which makes my curiosity pique. Who is she and why is she so important? What kind of help could she possibly give? "A woman is like a garden."

He laughs at that, and I find it odd. I've never heard him laugh before.

"I'm serious. You want to grow a garden; it takes time and care. It needs water and sunlight."

"What are you suggesting?" he asks, but his tone suggests he doesn't care. "Put her outside under a sprinkler?"

"Look at her." She turns to me. "Hair thinning, cheeks sunken in, skin splotchy. She's too young to look this…frail. She needs to be well fed and taking vitamins." The woman turns back to him. "She's young and fertile, but there are still factors you must take into consideration."

I shove myself into the headboard at the mention of fertile and bring my legs to my chest. I struggle in the restraints, wishing I could wrap my arms around them, but I can't. The straitjacket has them secured to my chest.

They both look at me when they hear movement.

"It's okay." She gives me a toothy smile. There's nothing comforting about it. "I'm here to help you."

I shake my head and glare at my father. "I will not—"

"You'll do whatever I fucking tell you to do," he barks, stepping closer to my bed.

The woman reaches out, placing her hand on his upper arm, and he stops to look at her. She quickly scribbles something down on a piece of paper and holds it out to him. "A list of things she needs. You should get her started on them as soon as possible. It will help you get the results you want," she assures him.

He reads over the list and nods his head a few times. "I'll see what I can do."

"Fuck you," I scream. I'm so tired of no one being on my side. No one caring about me. Tears sting my eyes, and I sink into the bed, trying to look smaller, wishing it would swallow me up.

"Watch your tone, or I'll gag you," my father growls.

"Leave me with her," the woman suggests softly.

My father looks her up and down, and I know he's fucking her. Not a doubt in my mind that he uses her. "She remains in her restraints."

"Of course." She nods. The thought of releasing me never even entered her mind.

Satisfied, he turns and walks out of my room, slamming the door behind him with the list in his hand.

"I fear we've gotten off on the wrong foot." The woman's smile is still in place.

"Don't pretend you're here for me." I drop my head on my knees and mumble. "You're here for them."

"I am here for you, Everett." She sighs and walks over to where she sits on the side of the bed. "That's a pretty name." Reaching out, she grabs a piece of my hair and runs her fingers through it, sighing. "You're beautiful, Eve."

Fresh tears sting my eyes.

"You look just like your mother."

Hope fills my chest, and my wide eyes find hers. My mom is never mentioned. My father didn't even know her. He was just the highest bidder, and I was the result. "You knew my mother?"

"I did." She smiles. "And she wouldn't want to see you hurting yourself like this."

My stomach drops. She's trying to manipulate me. Make me think my mother would want me to be a whore. "My father raped my mother, and then she was forced to have me. I should not exist."

She chooses to ignore that. "I have a daughter. Around your age. And—"

"And you'd let men rape her?" I interrupt.

She drops her eyes to my bed and sighs heavily. "Women have a purpose, Eve. And if you're no longer able to fulfill that purpose, you are no longer useful to a Lord. Your mom is a testament to that."

I flinch at the way she speaks of my mother. Like she's trash, thrown away when she could no longer serve what this woman calls a purpose. No. I refuse to believe anything she says. "I don't want to be useful," I whisper.

She gently grabs my chin and lifts my head so I have to meet her stare. "I'm trying to help you." Her eyes search my watery ones. "I

suggest you let me."

I jerk my face from her hold and narrow my eyes on hers. "I'd rather you fucking kill me." This woman is delusional. If my father is fucking her, then so are his friends. I'm sure they pass her around. Take their turns. Just like they do with me. I'm nothing special. The only difference is I'm currently restrained and she's not. She's given into her fate. Accepted it. That's why she's not tied up or gagged right now. But I bet she is when they use her.

"I will never be like you," I tell her, shaking my head. "You're a disgrace to all women. My mother would be ashamed—"

She slaps me across the face, cutting me off.

I give a rough laugh as the sting feels like a thousand knives to my cheek. Typical response when they don't like what you have to say.

The woman gets off the bed and removes her cell from her pocket before furiously typing away on it.

I look up at her through narrowed eyes, and she gives me a smile. It reminds me of my father's. The one I receive when I'm going to hate what's on his mind. She pulls her sleeve of her suit jacket up and bites her own arm, sinking her teeth into her skin while she closes her eyes tightly.

Removing it from her mouth, blood drips from the broken skin. She runs her hand through it and then rushes over to me, smearing it across my face.

"The fuck?" I spit it onto the bed when some gets in my mouth. I spit again, gagging, trying to get the nasty taste off my tongue.

The door is shoved open and my father rushes in. "What happened?" he barks, looking at me.

"She attacked me," the bitch cries, lifting her arm. "Look. She bit me." Removing her hand, she shows him the bite mark she gave herself.

His face grows tight when he glances over my blood-smeared face, and he spins around, leaving as fast as he entered.

"Lying bitch," I sneer.

She drops her arm and smiles at me. "I have a purpose, Eve, and until you decide you want to fulfill yours, I'll make mine all about you. You will not be the reason I fail."

My father enters once more, and my stomach drops when I see what he's holding.

I try to scramble off the bed, but I can't use my arms and there's nowhere to go.

He grabs my hair, fisting it, making me scream at the pain. She helps him, taking the opportunity to shove the rubber ball into my mouth, and he holds me in place while she fastens it behind my head, securing the gag in my mouth. He then shoves me onto the bed, face-first, and I sink my teeth into the rubber, imagining it's the bitch's arm. A mumbled scream of frustration makes tears burn my eyes.

"Let me know if she gives you any more problems," he tells her.

Sitting up, I turn with my back to the headboard and my knees to my chest. It's not because I'm modest. I'm used to being naked.

She rises up on her tiptoes, kissing his cheek. "Thank you."

I want to roll my eyes and stab her at the same time. This bitch has got to go. He leaves us once again, closing the door softly behind him.

She sits down on the side of the bed, returning to the place she sat before, and smiles at me. "See, Eve? I'm a woman who understands her purpose and knows how to succeed in a world run by men."

By using others.

"Here." She reaches over to the nightstand and grabs a tissue. Then she begins to blot my chin. "You're drooling all over yourself like a rabid dog." Her actions suggest she cares, but her condescending tone tells me otherwise.

My mouth is held wide open, there's a rubber ball shoved behind my teeth, and my jaw already hurts. I blink back the tears I want to cry. They don't get you anywhere. They're a waste.

"Now where were we? Oh, yeah." She begins to play with my hair. "I think you'd look stunning with a bob. Cut all the dead ends off. I'll talk to your father. Have him set up an appointment. I know someone who will come here to do it for you." She grips my shoulders that are restrained in the straitjacket and gives me a warm smile. "See, Eve? Your father brought me in to help you. There's no reason why we can't be friends."

I mumble around the massive gag.

"What's that?" She leans into me, dropping her head to try and understand what I'm saying, just like I was hoping. I take the opportunity and slam my head into hers, knocking her back.

She begins to scream for my father, and I can't help but smile around the gag when he rushes into the room. If I'm going to be punished, I'm going to fucking earn it.

Bitch.

"What happened, for fuck's sake?" he barks.

"She…she hit me," the woman cries, her bloody hand covering her face.

A man comes running in, and my stomach drops. He's the worst. "What the fuck is going on?" he demands.

"Take care of her." My father nods toward me.

Panic grips my chest when the man grabs a hold of my hair and yanks me off the bed by it. I'm screaming around the gag while he rips pieces out. He shoves me into a room, and I trip over my feet. "Fucking bitch," he hisses. "I don't know why he chose to keep you."

As I'm trying to catch my breath, he picks me up and places my body on the spanking bench. I've been here a lot lately. More than usual. I wish they'd go too far and just kill me.

"More fucking trouble than you're worth."

My arms are smashed underneath me since he's got me face down on the bench. He picks up the rope that's secured to the floor and wraps it around my neck to keep me from going anywhere. Then he straps my legs down with my ass up in the air.

I hear the swoosh of his belt being removed from his slacks seconds before it hits my ass. I bite down on the rubber ball gag, my breath momentarily taken away from the pain. He does it three more times, and then I see the black leather fall to the floor through my tear-filled eyes.

His heavy breathing fills the room, and I know what's coming. He gets excited when my father puts him in charge of me. It's a power trip for him.

"I'm not removing that gag to fuck your face because you'll just bite my dick. And your cunt is proving to be useless lately, but your

ass isn't."

I fight the restraints, feeling the rope tighten around my neck when I try to pull away.

The sound of him hawking a loogie makes me gag before I feel wetness on my ass. Tears run down my face, and I sob into the restricting ball shoved into my mouth.

I fucking hate them. All of them.

"You'll break eventually, bitch. They all do."

I'm standing in the office at the cathedral, going through files. I document everything.

The Lords don't give a shit about what happens once the Lord is dead and the body collected, but I do. I keep records of who comes in and why, as well as whether they survive or have to be buried.

My cell vibrates on the desk, and I pick it up to read over the text.

Don't be late.

Rolling my eyes, I lock my phone without responding. I'll get there when I get there.

Turning back to the filing cabinet, I place the picture of the dead Lord into the file as the door opens and closes. "I don't need an escort." I turn, smiling, but it drops off my face when I see who it is. "Kash?" I say, hating the way my voice squeaks. "What are you doing here?"

He doesn't answer. Instead, he leans his back against the door, crosses one ankle over the other, and shoves his hands into the pockets of his leather jacket. His gaze drops to my black Gucci heels before slowly running up my freshly shaved legs and white minidress. It's got long sleeves and a high neckline. There's nothing revealing about it other than it's tight fitting and short.

His blue eyes linger on my neck for a few seconds before they roam my face and finally find mine. Pushing off the door, he doesn't look away from me as he reaches back and locks it.

I swallow nervously, trying to calm my racing heart. "I have somewhere to be," I inform him, rubbing my sweaty hands down my thighs.

He smirks at me, and it makes my knees weak. "This won't take long." Striding over to the desk, he removes something from his

back pocket, and my pulse races when he drops a set of handcuffs on the desk. "Get undressed and put these on."

"Kashton," I breathe, trying to think of a way to get the fuck out of here.

He shoves his leather jacket off his shoulders and tosses it over the armrest before sitting in the center of the couch. His tatted arms span the back of the cushions, and he sinks down into it as his legs fall open.

It's the first time I've gotten a look at him without a jacket or hoodie on. He's covered in ink, but the one that stands out the most is on his arm. A woman dressed in a nun costume, hiding everything but her face. A ball gag is in her mouth, with drool dripping from her bottom lip and running down her chin, makeup smeared, and an upside down cross on her cheek.

It makes the hairs on the back of my neck rise.

"I'm waiting, Eve." His eyes devour me in a way that makes my pussy tighten. "I'd hate to have to rip it off you."

"I don't have time for this." I storm to the door. Unlocking it, I yank it open and yelp in surprise when I see a man standing in the way of my exit.

He steps into the doorway and places both hands up on the top of the doorframe. "You were right," he says to Kashton before his stare drops to my chest. He licks his lips. "Is this an invitation to watch?" His gaze meets mine and he smirks. "Or do I get to join?" Dropping his hands, he starts to step into the office, but I slam the door shut in his face and lock it.

I can hear his laughter through the door as I rest my forehead against the cool wood, trying to get my erratic breathing under control before I face Kashton.

He has me cornered. I can't escape him. And he was right; there are Lords who want me dead. Sin and Elli didn't even stay for dinner last night. Her demeanor changed the moment Bill walked into the dining room. Sin noticed, and they left. I felt bad for Janice because she was so confused about why they left without eating, but I was also happy for Elli. Sin knew she didn't feel safe and Sin removed her from the situation.

I don’t consider myself weak anymore, but I can’t fight off multiple Lords. Kashton is all I have. And that thought is unsettling. I know what it feels like to be helpless, and I’m terrified to feel that again.

My heart hammers in my chest and I swallow the excess saliva in my mouth. I push off the door and turn to face Kashton. He still sits on the couch, looking relaxed as can be. Patiently waiting for me to give in to his demands.

I rush over to the desk and yank open the top drawer. My stomach drops when I notice what’s missing.

“Looking for this?”

My head snaps up to see he’s holding my gun in his hand. My teeth grind, and I slam the drawer shut. He must have snuck in here when I was cleaning up the Lord. “Here to kill me?” I cross my arms over my chest.

He pushes back the slide, removing the chambered bullet, then unloads the magazine. “I’m not here to hurt you, Eve.”

Like I believe that shit. “Then what do you want?” I growl.

“To play with you.”

I look away and try to think of a way out. If I give him an inch, he’ll take a mile. This is what they do.

“You know…” He trails off, and I glance back at him to see him pulling something out of the pocket of his jacket that still lies over the armrest. My breath catches when he leans forward, placing his elbows on his knees while looking at the item between his fingers. “I’m not leaving until I get what I want, angel.”

I swallow nervously when he glances up at me.

“We can do it your way or mine.” He shrugs carelessly. “Your way will take longer, though.”

“What…what is my way?” I stammer with a heavy tongue.

He smirks. “Your way is I get up, bend you over that desk, and insert this into your neck.” He holds up the syringe. “Returning the favor. Thanks, by the way. That was the best sleep I’ve had in a while.” I roll my eyes when he smiles. “You’ll be out anywhere from two to four hours, and when you wake up, you’ll be naked and hogtied on the floor.”

Butterflies swirl in my stomach, and he sits back on the couch. "Or we do it my way."

"What's your way?" I whisper breathlessly. I can't afford to be out that long. I have plans tonight, and if I don't show up, they will come here looking for me. The last thing I need is them finding me naked and hog-tied at this Lord's feet.

"Come here," he commands, and I know it's the only answer I'm going to get. He wants me to submit. Willingly.

The two words are like a shot of adrenaline to my body. I can't fight it. I slowly walk over to him, and he gets to his feet. His eyes are on mine as he reaches up and slides his finger into the collar of my dress, softly caressing my heated skin.

I drop my gaze to his chest, unable to look at him. It's been so long since I've been touched, but my body remembers what it felt like.

"Eyes on mine, Eve."

I meet his intent stare, and he runs his free hand over my racing pulse. "When I'm touching you, you look at me. Do you understand?"

"Yes, sir." The words are automatic, and they disgust me. What he's able to do in a matter of seconds… I've become the old me. The one who sits, crawls, and begs for attention. The one who was helpless and trapped.

I swore I'd never go back to that, yet here I am. I guess no amount of time can change someone. I'll be his whore, and he'll use me however he wants.

"Go get the handcuffs." He drops his hands from my body.

I turn and close the small distance between me and the desk, picking them up. Walking back to him, I hold them out. He takes them and says, "Get undressed."

I'm on autopilot. He's in full control. I'm just a willing servant at this point. A light switch flipped on, and a sour taste fills my mouth at what I'm about to let him do.

Reaching down, I grab the hem of my dress and pull it up and over my head before tossing it to the side. I hook my fingers into the waistband of my thong and push it down.

"Leave the heels on," he orders, and I clear my throat. "Turn around."

I'm glad to oblige and take a shaky breath when I have a second to look at anything but him. I place my hands behind my back without being told—I know what he wants.

"Good girl," he praises me, securing my wrists in the cuffs. The sound of them clicking in place is deafening as they secure my hands behind my back. There's no going back. No escaping them. I hate that it feels like home. I spent so much time like this and have allowed him to knock me back years in a matter of seconds.

I should be ashamed. Pathetic and weak.

"Face me."

I bow my head, doing as I'm told. He's sitting down on the couch once more, and I stare at his jeans. My body shakes, my breathing is labored, and my heart is pounding.

He leans forward, dropping his hand to my ankle, and gently touches his tatted knuckles to my skin. I jump from the initial contact. I immediately find his eyes, remembering his rule. *When I'm touching you, you look at me.* He doesn't look surprised or amused by my unease. He slowly runs his knuckles up the inside of my thigh while staring up at me.

My legs tremble at the softness. The tenderness in his touch. I'm waiting for a slap or to be thrown onto the floor. He glances over my heaving chest, my hard nipples.

"Kashton," I whisper, though I'm not even sure why I said it or what I want to say.

"Yeah, angel?" He runs two fingers over my pussy, and my hips rock forward on their own.

That burning sensation covers my skin. As if I've been doused with gasoline and lit on fire. I'm fucking sweating standing here in nothing other than my heels while trying to catch my breath.

"You're soaked, Eve." He pushes two fingers between my legs but doesn't enter my pussy. He doesn't have to. "Just like the last time I had you naked." Pulling his hand back, he runs his fingers down my inner thigh, leaving a trail of wetness, almost daring me to deny it.

Dropping his hand, he undoes his belt and slides it free from his jeans in a full, smooth swoop.

"Straddle my legs," he orders, and I slide onto the couch, forcing my shaking legs farther apart to do as he says. I'm embarrassed by how sweaty my legs are against the roughness of his jeans. "Why are you shaking, Eve?" he asks.

I can't answer. My tongue is too heavy.

"Hmm? I'm not going to hurt you. I just want to play with you."

I whimper, and he smiles, placing the belt around my neck and looping it through the buckle before pulling it tight. I swallow to see how much space he leaves me to breathe. Not much, and it makes me moan.

"You're gorgeous, Eve," he says in awe as his fingers slowly circle my hard nipple. "Every inch of you is perfect."

He's going to ruin me, and I'm going to let him. Why? Because it feels good to be wanted. The way those butterflies flutter in my stomach has me dripping for him. Literally. My pussy is staining his jeans while I straddle him.

This is what we're groomed for. Sex. Even he was raised to be this way. Dominant and controlling. To think with his dick. I haven't had sex in years, and I wouldn't be surprised if he got his dick sucked this morning.

Taking the excess belt that hangs down my exposed chest and stomach, he positions it so the warm leather lies down my bare back. The buckle is now at the nape of my neck. "Up on your knees." He slaps the side of my shaking thigh.

I wiggle my way up onto my knees so my head is above his, and he lowers his body into the couch. He's practically lying down in the new position. One hand grips my ass while the other fists the belt around my neck. It forces me to look up at the ceiling as it tightens.

My lips part and I suck in a ragged breath.

Then I feel his tongue on my pussy. My hips rock forward, and a shudder runs through me. "Kash—"

The belt tightens more, and it takes away my ability to breathe, let alone speak. My cuffed hands fist and my eyes close, but my hips

rock back and forth as his tongue slowly licks at me like I'm a sucker he wants to savor.

KASHTON

I hold on to the belt while my other hand releases her ass and moves between her legs. I finger her soaked cunt while my mouth sucks on her clit. She makes unintelligible noises while she rides my face.

Fuck, she tastes so good.

I saw the look in her eyes. The fear of what I was going to do to her and her *yes, sir* response. It was the same on the *Isabella*. I knew she had been abused in the past. I'm not saying that I'm not going to use her for my own pleasure, but I want her to enjoy it too.

Her thighs squeeze my head as she pushes her hips forward and I pull her back with my belt wrapped around her neck. I let go and she gasps, sucking in a deep breath.

"Tell me how you feel, Eve," I order, wanting to make sure she's present. The last thing I want is for her to wander off somewhere else.

"So…good," she moans, her hips rocking once more.

I'm so hard for her. Have been for weeks. I'm just waiting… "Do you want to come?"

"Yes, please," she answers. "I want you to make me come."

I tilt my head to the side and gently kiss her shaking thigh. Then I sink my teeth into it, making her cry out before sucking her skin into my mouth, making sure to leave not only teeth marks but a bruise as well. She'll remember me when I leave her here on the couch, naked, with cum leaking from her pussy.

Pulling away, I smile, satisfied, and move to her other thigh. Again, she's screaming, and I wish I could fuck her. But I'm not going to. Not tonight. She might think this is all about her, but it's not. It's me marking my territory. I might as well tattoo my name on her.

I pick her up and toss her onto her back on the couch. She cries out once more when she lands on her cuffed wrists, and I grip her thighs in my hands, shoving them wide open so I can see her pussy. It's a pretty pink color and glistening. Just begging for my cock to fuck it.

Kneeling next to the couch, I pull her closer to me and throw her legs over my shoulders, burying my face between them.

I don't stop. I finger, suck, lick, and bite every inch of her while she begs, screams, and pleads to come. And she does. All over my face.

"Good girl," I praise her when I stand to my full height.

She's gasping and trembling more than before while she lies there spent before me. Six years I've dreamed of this, and the reality is better than I ever imagined.

I run my hands down her sternum, loving the way she looks. Out of breath, cum covering her swollen cunt, while wearing nothing but her heels. The tips of my fingers run over a butterfly tattoo on her hip. It covers up the three lines I remember her having. She flinches at the touch. Just like she did before. There's a story there that I'll save for later.

"You did good, angel," I tell her. Then I roll her to her side, facing the couch, remove the key from my pocket, and undo the cuffs. "Next time I'll make you work for it."

She whimpers, rolling onto her back, bringing her hands to rest on her chest.

"I'll see you soon." I give her a kiss on the forehead and then unlock the door.

Exiting, I see Alex in the hallway. He looks up from his phone when he hears me and tries to glance into the room, but I shut the door quickly so he doesn't see her naked on the couch.

"Thanks for the help. Now go home," I tell him. I knew she'd unlock the door and try to run. I needed her to think she was cornered, and it worked.

He nods with a chuckle. "Let me know if you need me again."

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FOURTEEN



EVERETT

My legs are still fucking shaking, and my thong is soaked. Fuck.

I got off with nothing more than his fingers and tongue. Most men can't even do that with their dicks.

I wobble in my heels up the stone steps and into the house. The large open space is quiet. My heels clap on the floor as I make my way down the hallway to the study.

Opening the double doors, I enter to see my dad and his new protégé already present. I hold in a sigh when a set of green eyes meet mine.

"Eve." My dad stands and greets me with a kiss on each cheek.

He's the kind of father every child deserves. I might not have his DNA, but this man saved me.

Twenty years old

I must be dead. It's the only reason I feel warm and wrapped in something soft. Maybe it's a hallucination. Either way, it's heaven compared to the hell I've lived in.

"Everett?" a man's voice calls out to me. "Everett? Can you hear me?"

My right eye is forced open, and a bright light shines into it—back and forth. I look ahead while it blinds what little sight I have.

"Everett?" The man to my right touches my shoulder, and I cower in the large bed. He sighs heavily, sitting in a chair close by my side. "Everett, my name is William, but you can call me Bill. Bill Marks. I'm here to help you, Eve. May I call you Eve?"

I blink rapidly, wondering why I can only see with my right eye and look to the man who wears a white doctor's coat on my left.

"This is Doctor Gavin. He's going to take care of you. Get you feeling better," the man, Bill, informs me.

I say nothing. I'm not even sure I could talk if I wanted to. My body is heavy, and my mind is foggy. Where am I? Why is it so bright? And my chest…it hurts. Like a tugging pain with each breath I take.

"Is she blind in her left eye?" Bill asks the doctor at my silence.

"She had a hyphema. I drained it and am keeping it covered with an eye patch between administering drops."

"What causes that?" Bill wonders.

"Blunt force trauma to the head or direct hit to the eye. I'm optimistic that she'll regain her sight shortly."

Something itches my face, and I go to lift my right hand to scratch it, but I can't move. The lack of movement causes me to panic, and I yank on my arms.

"Whoa. It's okay, Eve. You're okay," the man by the name of Bill rushes out, getting to his feet next to my bed.

My chest tightens as the panic rises, and I can't breathe. A rapid beeping sound starts ringing in my ears.

"Do something," Bill barks at the doctor.

Suddenly my body is freezing, and I shiver before it relaxes back into the bed. I hate drugs. "Nooo," I manage to croak out through my cracked lips.

"Here you go. It's fresh and warm." Bill places a new blanket over me, and my heavy eye blinks. "I promise, Eve. It's okay. We're here to help you. The restraints are for your safety."

Help me? Restrained for my safety? That's what my father told me after I tried to commit suicide the first time. Did I try again? I can't remember how I got here. Or where here *is. Where is my father? Did he send these two guys to punish me?*

My head lolls to the side before blackness takes me under, but I don't get to enjoy it for long before the voices pull me back to the surface.

"Vaginal tearing was evident. There's scarring, implying it's happened more than once but also very recently. She's extremely dehydrated and malnourished. The feeding tube and IV will help immensely. I will need to call in a plastic surgeon. I could fix her nose from the septum piercing, but with it being on her face, I'd like to get her the best."

"I agree," Bill says. "But I wasn't aware that a piercing can alter a nose."

"Not usually, but in extreme cases such as Eve's, it can and has. I believe that the piercing was more of a punishment then an aesthetic preference," the doctor goes on. "Her blood work has come back, and there were drugs in her system."

"What kind of drugs?" Bill snaps.

"Sedatives and GHB along with GBL, methamphetamine, and mephedrone. Those are highly addictive. She also tested positive for poppers."

"What the fuck are those?"

"It's known as Liquid Gold Rush in Australia. A chemical that can enhance sexual desire and make orgasming more intense. My guess is that she was forced to inhale it. Within seconds, it sends a rush of blood to your head, causing your muscles to relax. For a man, it can kill an erection, so I'm assuming they use it on the dolls for training."

"Christ." Bill sighs. "What else did you find?"

"She also has a few bruised ribs. A collapsed lung. That's why she needed the chest tube. Her MRI and X-rays show an old fracture to her right wrist—I'd say six months ago—that didn't heal properly."

"I'm guessing that was due to lack of treatment. What do you suggest?" Bill asks.

"Surgery. I go in, break the bone, and reset it."

"And that will correct it?"

"Yes."

"Any organs missing?" Bill wonders. "I know organs are worth a lot on the black market. I'm not a doctor, but I'm aware there're several we can live without, and I wouldn't be surprised if they were taking those too."

"All I can find from my testing is that she's had a hysterectomy," Gavin responds.

"Interesting. I wonder why. She's so young."

"I'll put in a call to my brother and see if he can find any information that we don't already know," Gavin states.

"What about STDs? I'm assuming her status prevents her from contracting them."

"You're correct." He sighs. "But honestly…"

"What?" Bill growls impatiently.

"I can't say for sure that she's had intercourse with a man recently."

He huffs, sounding frustrated. "Meaning?"

"By the sizes of tears and trauma, both vaginally and anally, I'd say there were…instruments used. She hadn't been sold to anyone yet. So I'm assuming they trained her in other ways…"

They're silent for a long moment, or maybe I black out again, but then I hear Bill say, "Do the surgery on her wrist. Today. Whatever she needs, make sure she gets it. I want her back on her feet and feeling good ASAP."

Gavin clears his throat. "There's more than just the surgery to correct some broken bones and much-needed time for recovery."

"Meaning?"

"Medication. Therapy. The poor girl has been severely abused. Sexually and mentally. Her body and brain have been manipulated…altered. She may never be more than a shell of herself again. She's also most likely been kept drugged around the clock. It's amazing she's not dead from an overdose due to her size and the amount that was in her system. Even if she wakes up and wants to fight to survive, there is still a long road to recovery. There can still be complications from withdrawals. Suicidal tendencies. She's already tried twice—"

"I'll get her the best therapist there is. Do your job and make her feel better physically. Then we'll get her the help she needs mentally."

"Glad you could finally join us," the other Lord states, taking a drink of his scotch, pulling me out of that memory.

My usual fuck-you attitude is actually gone right now, replaced with doubt and shame for letting Kashton get me off. Again. I should have made him drug me. At least then I would have woken up naked and hog-tied. And when he *played* with me, I wouldn't have had a say. That's what my body is used to. Being used. To give it up willingly makes me ashamed of myself.

The Lord frowns, noticing. "What's wrong with you?" His green eyes look me up and down, reading my body language.

I sit in a chair and cross my legs. This dress is shorter than I thought, and I take a quick look to make sure the bruises and bite marks Kash gave me aren't noticeable. "Nothing."

"Well, I'm about to fuck your mood up." He makes it sound like it's a challenge.

"You can try." I take the glass of whiskey that Bill is holding out to me and take a sip. *Don't throw it up.*

"The police ran your prints. They're going to question you."

I frown. They already did, but I ask. "Why?"

Bill shakes his head. "She's not in the system."

Right. Because I'm a no one. Never have been and never will be.

"They find it suspicious that you found the woman in the cemetery." His green eyes meet mine. "You should have burned her body and buried her ashes."

Yep. One sentence was all it took to fuck up my already bad mood. I slam the drink down on Bill's desk, making him flinch. "She had a family." I don't know if she was a mother, a sister, or wife, but she was someone's daughter. "She deserved something…more." That's the problem with the Lords. Nothing is sacred. A living soul is nothing more than an inconvenience. Something to be thrown away and never thought of again. They don't value life.

He gives a dark chuckle. "Now that family is seeking justice."

"Good." I give him a smile.

His eyes narrow on mine. "They think you did it."

I snort. "They can think whatever they want. I didn't kill that poor woman." And why the hell would the killer call the police? That doesn't make any sense.

He buries his head in his hands. I wonder when the last time he slept was. He looks tired. Adam and I go way back. It's not a love-hate friendship, just a mutual hatred for one another. He's like the big brother I never wanted.

"You don't understand. The public is ramming these bodies down the authorities' throats. It's all over the fucking news, just like it was years ago. Random people are picking it up on social media just to get views, and it's working. The authorities will pin it on someone to get the families off their backs."

"So you're saying I'm going to be the fall guy?" I shake my head. "Even the police can't twist a story that much."

"They can do whatever the fuck they want," Adam snaps before lowering his voice. "I've been there. They can make the innocent look guilty, and once you're locked away, you won't have a fucking voice to argue your side. The media alone will make sure you are painted as the villain they want you to be."

"What do you suggest?" Bill asks him, and I roll my eyes.

This Lord is his new favorite toy. Bill hangs on his every word. But even I know it's for his own gain. I am very thankful for Bill, but at the end of the day, he's just another Lord who is out for himself and world domination. No amount of money or power will ever be enough for them.

"I suggest you get the hell out of town and hide."

"No. That makes me look guilty as fuck," I argue. "I'm not going anywhere." He's only suggesting that because he's hiding. Has been for four years now. That's how we met. I'm not calling him a coward, but I refuse to live that life. I'm already a nobody. I don't need to hide. No one knows I exist.

"Eve—"

"No." I get to my feet, interrupting Bill. "I'm not going to run. I did nothing wrong." Not to the woman anyway. If I believed in an after-life, then I'd one day have to answer for everything I've done, but I helped that woman in the only way I could. I returned her to her family, where she belonged. "Let them take me in *again* and ask me as many questions as they want. I'll—"

"The Lords will fuck you over," Adam shouts. He throws his glass against the wall, and it shatters. He steps into me, and I brace myself to knock his fucking lights out if he places his hands on me. "The police start hanging out around the cathedral and your house, the Lords will see that, and they will throw you under the bus so fast to keep the police from sniffing around."

"You make it sound like she has no choice." Bill sighs.

He looks over at Bill for a quick second. "There's another option…" Adam's eyes meet mine when he speaks again. "Carnage…"

"Fuck no." I shake my head, giving a rough laugh. "I'm not going near there." The thought alone makes me break out in hives.

"I can make a call. My brothers can protect you."

I give a manic laugh. "They don't give two shits about me." At least they won't when they find out who I really am. "The answer is no." Shoving my finger into Adam's chest, I add, "The only way I go to Carnage is if someone drags me against my will."

Bill stands, buttoning his suit jacket, and looks at me. "We don't have to make a decision right now."

"Time isn't on her side," Adam growls at him. "I'd say maybe three weeks. A month at the most." He looks at me. "When they come for you—and they will—they will already have everything they need to set you up to take the fall. There will be nothing left to argue on their end."

I ignore him and look at my dad. "This isn't a *we* situation. This is me…my life, and I say no." With that, I turn and exit the study, slamming the doors shut on my way out.

Storming out to my car, I start it up and squeal my tires. I drive, not sure where I'm going or what I'm doing.

Why the fuck should I have to hide?

What do you know about Dollhouse? Kashton's words come to mind.

I know things about that place that would give grown men nightmares. I know adults and kids of all ages are run in and out of there. They do not discriminate against race, age, or gender. Everyone has a price. Some are worth more than others, but it's all about their check, nonetheless.

I made them money. My body was sold to the highest bidder because that's all I was good for. A hole to fuck. Bill saved me from that. But he can only save me from so much.

Carnage is not the answer. It is the problem.

I've come too far to allow someone to make me feel helpless… though I was naked and cuffed just an hour ago.

Kashton is going to be a problem. He's made that very clear. My only thing is, do I let him in? He'll want something in return. I don't doubt Adam. The cops can pin whatever they want on whoever they want to take the fall, and the Lords won't have my back.

Does that mean Kashton is my only hope? *Fuck, I hope not.*

What choice do I have? Life in jail or life on the run?

I refuse to run. Look at what happened to Ashtyn. I know more about her than her husband does. It's easy to watch when no one sees you there. I know everyone's secrets. But that makes me wonder…who knows mine?

Have I paid enough attention to my surroundings, or have I gotten too comfortable thinking I don't exist?

No. I'm jumping the gun. I just need to sit back and look at it from all angles. There's always another way. Placing my life in Kashton's hands is like willingly walking into the lion's den.

That sour taste burns my throat, and I pull my car over, slamming on my brakes. I open my driver's side door just in time to vomit onto the gravel. Once I'm done, I sit back in my seat and wipe my chin with my hand.

I could go to the police on my own. Speak to them again before they reach out to me. Innocent people don't volunteer to give information, right?

They probably wouldn't see it that way. Bill is an attorney, and he was hanging on Adam's every word. Which tells me Bill thinks I have no chance of fighting this.

I'm fucked.

KASHTON

Senior year at Barrington

I groan, rolling onto my back. There's something cold and hard underneath me. My heavy eyes open, and it takes a few seconds for

my vision to focus on nothing but darkness. Then my memory starts to return.

Alarms sounding at Carnage woke me up…our fathers dead… Ashtyn broke my nose and kneed me in the balls…then she shot Saint…a woman arrived at Carnage…her minions threw Haidyn and me into the arena…we fought eight prisoners who were all on adrenaline…I collapsed afterward…

I grunt and instantly regret it. That's why I'm so sore.

Sitting up, I run a bloody hand down my face. "Fuck." My tongue is swollen. I must have bitten it, because the taste of blood still lingers.

"What the…" I trail off when a light shines from my left.

"Good morning, sunshine."

I look over to see the fucking bitch standing on the other side of the prison door.

My chest rises when I take a deep breath. "Who the fuck are you and why are you here?" I demand.

She laughs, and the irritating sound makes my skin crawl. "I'm here to teach you all a lesson."

"Fucking bitch." I get to my feet but stumble back into the wall, my legs are wobbly and feet unsteady. Placing my head in my hands, I grip my hair. Fuck, did she drug me? Or am I just that weak from the fight?

Her laughter grows. "I bet when you woke up this morning you didn't think you'd be the only Spade brother left."

My head snaps up and my pulse quickens. "No—"

"Funny how one annoying cunt can ruin everything."

Ashtyn? She must be talking about Ashtyn. Because she's the reason all this is happening. What the fuck is she into that she would shoot Saint? All we've done is protect her. Saint has done things to her that I don't agree with, but she's not my wife.

Pushing myself off the wall, I drag my left leg as I hobble to the door. I wrap my hands around the bars. "I'm going to kill you, you fucking bitch."

She just smiles at me. "Promises. Promises."

"Haidyn?" I call out into the hallway, hoping he responds. I just need to know he's not dead. "HAIDYN?" And Saint? Ashtyn shot him.

Did he not survive surgery? If he's dead, I'll make it my life's mission to hunt Ashtyn down and kill her with my bare hands. I will gladly watch the life drain out of her eyes with no remorse.

Fucking bitch.

"Hai-dyn?" My voice cracks, and I start to cough.

The woman reaches through the bars and pushes something up against my sweat-covered chest, and it knocks me on my back.

"Christ," I say through gritted teeth. Every muscle in my body is tight. Did she tase me?

"Get used to this room, Kashton. It's your home until I say otherwise."

A bright light turns on, and I place my hands over my face to shield my eyes. "Goddammit." I scramble to the nearest wall and push my back against it.

Opening my eyes, I hold up my hand like a visor and blink rapidly in order to get my vision to adjust.

I wish I was blind.

My hand falls to my side, and I swallow the knot in my throat when I take in my home*. I'm not surprised to see that I'm in the basement of Carnage, locked in a cell. That was a given.*

What does surprise me is that all the walls and floor are covered in tallies. This is my punishment. A reminder that I'm all alone.

I don't know how long I was in there. At least a couple of weeks. The light never turned off, and the silence was deafening. All I had was my imagination, and that's never a good thing.

Isabella let me believe Saint and Haidyn were both dead. Adam had left us. I had no one.

I convinced myself I was going insane when I could see Eve in there with me. My mind always wandered back to her and that night on the *Isabella*. But it ended differently.

She didn't run from me. I wasn't a Lord, and she wasn't a woman who'd almost been raped by one. We were husband and wife, and the *Isabella* was our home. We stayed out in the middle of the ocean where no one could harm us. The world didn't even know we existed.

It was perfect.

Just when I'd get to the good part, one of Isabella's guards would come to feed me. I refused for a while, but then remembered I didn't want to die.

I needed to stay healthy. I was the only Spade brother left. It was up to me to catch Ashtyn and make her pay for what she caused. What she cost me. My family.

The only people I ever cared about. A life for a life. And that bitch owed me several.

You don't know hell until you don't know what day or time it is. Time moves slowly when all you have are your thoughts. There was no mattress or toilet in that cell with me. It got to the point where I thought I imagined Eve altogether. That she was a part of my imagination and never existed. But she does. I've found my way to her, and I will do everything in my power to make sure it stays that way.

I've given her two days to herself since I got her off in the office at the cathedral. There's nothing scarier than your own thoughts. I want to be on her mind twenty-four seven. Always looking over her shoulder for me. I want her confused and constantly wondering if I'm there.

A knock comes on my bedroom door. Opening it, I find Jessie standing in the hallway. "Come in, man." I hold it so he can enter.

"You had some packages arrive, sir."

"Thank you."

Smiling, I grab everything and exit my room. Walking across the hallway, I begin to open the door but stop myself and knock instead.

It cracks open just a bit and blue eyes meet mine. "Kashton?" She frowns as she hides her body behind the door. Her wet hair tells me she just got out of the shower. She's either naked or only has a towel on. "Haidyn isn't in here."

"I'm here to see you." I smile at her.

"Oh, okay. Can you give me a minute?"

"Of course."

She closes the door, and I stand silently in the hallway while she gets dressed. After a few short minutes, she fully opens the door, now dressed in sweatpants and a T-shirt. Her wet hair is up in some kind of clip. Charlotte gestures for me to enter.

“What can I do for you?” she wonders.

I hold out the boxes to her. “I brought you some gifts.”

Placing them on the bed, she picks up the one on the top. She tries to open it, but it’s taped. “Here.” I remove my pocketknife, slap it open, and take the box from her. I cut the tape across the top and both sides before handing it back.

“Thank you,” she mumbles awkwardly and begins to open it while I cut the other two open for her.

I watch her eyes light up when she drops the box to her feet. “Oh my gosh, I’ve been wanting one of these.” She gives me a bright smile.

The sound of the door unlocking has me looking up before Haidyn enters. He comes to a stop when his eyes meet mine. They narrow on me. “What are you doing in here?”

I frown at the accusation in his tone. Does he not trust me with his wife? He made me her guardian.

“Look what Kashton got us.” She holds it up for him to see.

Walking over to her, he frowns, looking it over. “What is it?”

“It’s a backpack,” I inform him.

“A cat carrier backpack,” she corrects me. “It’s for Muffin.” She beams, handing it over to him. “We can take her for walks. She’ll love it.”

His eyes go to mine, and he looks very unpleased about his future outdoor adventures with the hairy pussy. I can see him wearing it while Charlotte takes pictures of them bird-watching out in the woods.

“Oh, don’t think I forgot about you, big guy.” I hand him the second box. When he makes no attempt to open it, she rips it from his hands and does the job.

She laughs. “It’s perfect.” Then she holds it up to his chest and reads the T-shirt out loud. “I love her Muffin.”

“Get it?” I wiggle my eyebrows. “It could mean—”

“I get it,” he interrupts, not amused in the slightest.

Just then, the cat jumps up on the bed and meows. Charlotte picks her up. “Want to go for a walk?” She kisses the cat and smiles over at her husband.

Haidyn looks like he wants to deny her, but after a second, he nods. "I have an hour."

Charlotte holds Muffin out to him, and he takes her without hesitation before she rises up on her tiptoes and kisses his cheek. "Let me change." Spinning around, she practically skips off to the bathroom.

I clap my hands. *My work is done.* "Have fun," I sing, exiting his room. Just as the door goes to shut, he rips it open and spins me around.

"What the fuck are you doing, Kash?" he demands, setting the cat down on the floor.

"I can't give your wife gifts?" I cross my arms over my chest.

His face tightens. He knows I'm buttering her up for selfish reasons. Charlotte might not know Eve, but she knows of her, and I want all the girl talk she'll offer—teatime, girls' night, spa days. Whatever it'll fucking take. Even if that means spoiling the damn cat that I hate. But I can't just come right out and ask Charlotte a million questions about Everett. I'm a patient man. I've waited this long to find Eve. I'll take the time to get the information I want. Charlotte acted like she didn't know who she was, but something tells me there's more there. I can't not try. Even if it ends up being a dead end.

Sighing, I say, "I wasn't the nicest person to Charlotte." He already knows this, but I've never apologized for it. To her or to him. "I just want her to know that I'm here for her."

He eyes me skeptically as Muffin meows, curling herself around his ankle.

"I'm ready," Charlotte calls out from behind him, exiting the bathroom.

I give him a big smile and look over his shoulder at her. "You guys have fun. I want to see lots of pictures of Muffin's adventure." With that, I turn and enter my room, holding in my laughter. Oh, he's going to make me pay for that one.

I grab my cell and my Zippo before making my way down to the basement to see what Saint is up to.

He's standing over the pits while a guy is locked inside just as I hear the elevator ding behind me. I turn to see Sin and a very preg-

nant Elli walking into the basement hand in hand.

Sin looks disappointed to see me. We haven't spoken since he was here last time to tell us that Bill had married his mother and that Eve is Bill's daughter.

"What's up, man?" Saint gives him a handshake hug. "How did the appointment go?" he asks Elli, pulling away from Sin.

I hate that Saint is more aware of Elli's pregnancy than me. I didn't even know she had a checkup with Devin today. But I think she and Ashtyn have gotten close, so I shouldn't be all that surprised.

Elli rubs her huge belly. "Everything looks good and we're right on track." Smiling, she places her hand back in Sin's.

Easton's phone beeps, and he digs into his pocket. Letting go of her hand once again, he reads over a text, and his face tightens.

"What's wrong?" she asks nervously.

"It's nothing." He waves off his wife's concern.

"Sin?" She grabs his arm and pulls him to face her. She knows him well enough to question him.

"It was the Lords," he tells her. "I have an assignment tomorrow."

"What?" Her wide eyes search his. "No."

"It'll be fine," he assures her. "I will only be gone for the day."

"Okay." Elli nods to herself, trying to accept what he's telling her. She knows that she can't keep him from the Lords. They call and you go running.

"Shit." He sighs. "I forgot you have an appointment."

"It's fine," she speaks. "I'll reschedule."

"No." He frowns. "She was able to fit you in."

"She can get me in another day."

"No, Elli," he tells his wife sternly. "You need to see her."

Bowing her head, she bites her lip.

"I can take you," I offer.

Her head snaps up, eyes narrowing on mine. "No."

"That would be great." Sin rubs her arm, and I bite back a smile that he's allowing me to be alone with her. It must be really important for him to let me help.

"Sin—"

"It's fine, Elli. I won't let you miss it because of me." Then he looks at me. "I'll text you the time and address." With that, he grabs her hand and leads her back to the elevator, making Saint and me both wonder what that was about.

Guess I'll find out in the morning.

My girl has a job tonight. We're once again at the run-down biker bar that sits in the same parking lot as the motel.

I didn't even try to hide as I followed her on my bike. She checked into her room first, dropped off her bag of goodies, and then walked across the parking lot in her eight-inch heels. They're ankle height with black chains that wrap around the back. In those, along with a pair of tight-fitting jeans and a top that shows off her perfectly sized tits and thin waist, my dick is so hard.

I'm going to fuck her tonight.

It's been two days since she came on my face at the cathedral, but the time has come for my own cum to leak from her cunt.

I take a sip of my scotch as I watch her throw her head back and hear her laughter grow from where she sits at the bar. She's talking to two different men—she sits in the center.

The one on the right keeps reaching out and touching her thigh. I want to cut his hand off, but I know my girl can handle herself. She's playing a part. I'll step in if she needs me; right now, I'd just make a scene. I want to see what she plans on doing. How this is going to play out.

"Would you like another one, sir?"

I look up at the waitress who stands at my booth. She's got light-brown hair that she has pulled back to show off her petite face. She wears large black-rimmed glasses low on her nose that she's constantly pushing up. Her outfit consists of flared jeans and a T-shirt that reads Help Yourself across her chest. Which is ironic, considering she's a waitress. She looks young, barely old enough to legally be working here. She wears a silver necklace that has a wedding band hanging from it.

"Yes, please." I pull out my wallet and drop a hundred.

She picks it up and walks over to the side of the bar to place my order. My eyes go back to Eve. The guy on her right is showing her something on his phone. Probably his kids. Proud father who is about to cheat on his loving wife.

People are so predictable.

"Here you go, sir." The waitress sets down my new glass along with my change.

"Thank you," I tell her, and she walks away without another word.

Eve gets up and I lift my drink, taking a sip when she grabs her purse and the one guy's hand.

Setting the glass down, I pocket my cell but remain where I'm at until they exit. I notice they both follow her, and I don't like it. Two against one is never good odds.

I get up, leaving my full drink and change for the waitress. I slide on my jacket and step outside just as I see the door to her motel room close.

Reaching into my jacket, I remove the pack of cigarettes and my Zippo. I'll have a smoke while making my way across the parking lot to get my girl. I'll give both those men a show before I slit their throats.

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FIFTEEN



EVERETT

I place my purse and cell down on the dresser that the TV sits on as Leo goes to the restroom. Leroy removes condoms from his jacket. He drops four onto the bed. I want to laugh. Four? The guy has high hopes for himself.

"I'm on birth control," I say, twirling a small piece of hair around my finger while biting my lip.

His face lights up at my lie. Men don't want to wear condoms because it doesn't feel the same—especially when they're paying for it. They want the best experience they can get. But the inner urge to not knock me up and the possibility of knocking me up is a fine line. Breeding kink is a thing, and men pay big money to fuck you raw in hopes of getting you pregnant.

But there are also STDs. I can't get them, but who the hell knows about them. Then again, I'm not actually going to fuck them.

Leo exits the restroom and tells his brother, "Bathroom is free."

Leroy looks at me, and his eyes drop to my mouth. "How much will that cost me?" he asks.

I want to vomit at the thought of being his urinal. But instead, I drop my eyes to the floor shyly and whisper, "I've never done that…"

He adjusts his jeans, as if proud to be the first one to piss down my throat. I will sink my teeth into his dick like a hot dog on opening day at Fenway Park. Hell, I'll even swallow it just to shit it out later.

"I'm ready." Leroy grabs his belt and undoes it, followed by his jeans.

I walk over to the dresser that the TV sits on and open the bottle of wine. It allows them to get undressed. A naked man is more vulner-

able than one fully clothed.

A hand touches the back of my neck, pulling my hair to the side as I begin to pour the wine into a Dixie cup.

I've got to make this quick. I know Kashton is right outside. Can't get away from him, and I don't doubt that he'll come in here to fuck it up.

"Drink?" I turn to face Leroy.

He goes to lean in to kiss me, but I dodge it and step around him to see Leo ripping the pillows and sheets off the bed.

This place is cheap as shit, and they don't question when you pay by the hour. These men are both millionaires, but they want to pay the bare minimum to fuck a whore in the middle of nowhere so their wives won't see the charges on the credit cards. God forbid they wine and dine me before they violate me.

"What's the rush? You paid for the night." I bring the cup of wine to my lips, but I pause when he gives me a chilling smile.

"Yeah, but we only have an hour with you."

The Dixie cup is knocked out of my hand as an arm wraps around me from behind, tightening around my neck.

"An hour isn't nearly enough for us both to fuck all your holes."

I'm picked up off my feet and I kick them out, gripping Leroy's arm and digging my nails into it. He growls in my ear, and his hand relaxes, so I dig my teeth into his skin. He tastes like sweat and the peanuts he was eating at the bar.

As I yank his arm away, he drops me. I spin around to face him just as he backhands me hard enough that I stumble back and fall onto the bed.

Leo jumps on top of me, and I punch him, my knuckles ramming into his windpipe as hard as I can. He sits up, kneeling over me, and grabs his neck, choking.

I crawl out from underneath him, pushing my back into the headboard before ramming my heel into his face. It cuts the side of his cheek and knocks him off the bed.

I jump up and drop to the floor. Reaching under the bed, I grab my bag, but I'm yanked back by my ankle. "Fucking bitch," Leroy growls

while Leo lies unconscious on the floor next to me. "We were told you'd be a handful."

"Let go," I grind out, slamming my other heel into his thigh, forcing him to release me. But he recovers quicker than his brother.

He goes to kick me in the side, but I roll away just in time and kick in the back of his knees, knocking his legs out from under him.

He hits the floor with a thud and a groan. I take the opportunity and grab the knife from my bag and stab him in the chest just as the door is shoved open.

KASHTON

I step into the room and slam the door shut. Eve jumps up from the floor on the other side of the bed with a knife in her hand, blood dripping from it. "Kashton? What the fuck are you doing here?" she hisses. Her breathing is heavy, her hair is a disheveled mess, and her shirt is ripped.

"What the fuck are you doing, Eve?" I demand.

Walking over to the opposite side of the bed, I see a naked man passed out and another one bleeding from a stab wound to the chest.

"Leave," she snaps.

"Are you a prostitute?" I growl and she rolls her eyes. The only reason I ask is because I took the phone from the last dead guy I found in here, and he had message threads with multiple women. Each consisted of how much they cost, what they would and wouldn't do, and times and places to meet. "Are you trying to get yourself killed?" Knowing it and seeing it are two very different things. I run a hand through my hair. "I'll call the guys and clean this up."

She gives a rough laugh, "I don't need your brothers, Kash. Just leave." Standing next to the unconscious man, she looks down at him with a frown. Digging through her bag, she removes a gun before screwing on a suppressor and dropping to a squat in her heels. She grabs a pillow that's already on the floor, places it over his head and shoots two rounds through it into his head. "You deserved worse," she tells him and stands.

I've never been more turned on in my life. She's such an angry angel.

I reach out and grab her hand as she goes to step by me. "Eve," I snap and whip her to face me. "What the fuck are you doing? Tell me right now what this is."

Maybe she did kill that woman in the cemetery. Maybe she's deeper into Dollhouse than I thought. Charlotte said she saw her years ago with LeAnne at the cathedral. All the connected dots are too hard to ignore.

"Do you work for David?"

Maybe he's her pimp. That would be the better scenario of the two. I've asked him before about her, but maybe she's started working for him since then. It was a long time ago. After I killed that man on the *Isabella* for her.

Her green eyes look away from me as she clenches her jaw. My fingers tighten around her wrist, and she swings the gun toward me. I lift my free arm up, hitting her forearm and knocking it out of her hand as she gets another round off.

Then I toss her onto the bed and straddle her hips. She screams, trying to buck me off, and it lifts me up off the bed. Fuck, she's stronger than she looks. Her adrenaline is pumping after fighting off two men. I know the rush. It's addictive.

Her fist connects with my jaw before making contact with my side, knocking the wind out of me. *Fuck.* She's feisty.

She's crawling off the bed when I grab her hair. It's the closest thing I can reach. She screams in frustration when I spin her around and yank her over to the side. Her legs are hanging off as I pin her front against the bed with my hand gripped around the back of her neck.

"Kashton," she growls, panting. "Get off me."

I ignore her, undoing my belt with my free hand before yanking it from my loops. Then I let go of her neck, grab her arms, and tie her wrists together behind her back with my belt.

"Fucking bastard," she hisses. "Get the fuck off me."

I pick her up and toss her onto the bed so hard she bounces before I flip her onto her back.

She's gasping, lying in the center, with her wild hair covering her pretty face. I return to straddling her narrow hips and softly push

her hair out of the way. Wild green eyes look up at me.

"You can't beat me, Eve." I'm not one of these guys lying dead on the floor. I'm not under the assumption that she's a weak woman. They willingly walk in here thinking they're going to get to fuck her and then toss her some money afterward. I know the truth. I'm prepared for my angel to show all her cards.

Arching her back, she lets out a blood-curdling scream, and I slap my hand over her mouth, silencing her. Her eyes meet mine once more, and she breathes deeply through her nose.

"Calm down, angel." She mumbles into my hand, and I just smile. "You want to know what I think…" I don't remove my hand for her to answer. "I think you work for Dollhouse."

Her body goes rigid under mine.

"I don't think you killed that woman in the cemetery, but I think you know who did." I gently let up on her mouth. "So tell me what you know, and I won't hand you over to the Lords myself."

"Go ahead, Kash. Hand me over to them," she challenges. "I'll make sure to take you down with me."

"Me?" I laugh. "What have I done?"

"You were in the cemetery the other night, unconscious…for hours. Who knows what I did to you while you laid there." She just smiles at me as if she's the one pinning me down.

Is she setting me up? Is that why she's all of a sudden in my life? It makes sense. Charlotte had a double life when she was sent to go after Haidyn.

She wiggles side to side, trying to relieve the pressure of her body on her arms pinned underneath her. "Who are these men?" I demand. I have no clue who the two dead guys on the floor are. Maybe they're Lords. Even if they are, why them?

"Fuck you, Kash," she spits venomously in my face.

I laugh. "Okay, angel. You want to play. Let's play." I get up off her and stand next to the bed. I grip her shoulder and drag her to where her head hangs off the side.

"Kashton," she swallows nervously.

Her fear is showing. She's tied up and at my mercy. What shall I do with her?

"I'm going to put that mouth to good use, Eve." I unzip my jeans and undo my button.

She moans, squirming, and I smile.

"I knew you'd be all worked up."

I drop my jeans around my thighs and reach into my boxer briefs to pull my hard cock out. I wrap my hand around the base and run it up and down the pierced shaft a couple of times before I let it go.

Leaning over her, I undo her jeans and lower her zipper. I shove my hand down into her pants and rub her pussy. She bucks her hips, gasping. "Just like old times, huh?"

She tries to spread her legs farther apart for me, but she can't because she's still dressed. I push a finger into her, and she whimpers.

I look down at her, and she turns her head to the side, licking along my Jacob's ladder. I chuckle at how desperate she is.

Inserting a second finger, I'm rough with her cunt as I fuck her a few times and remove them. She slumps on the bed, and I bring my wet fingers to her face and grip her cheeks. "Open wide, Eve. I'm going to make you drool all over that pretty face."

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SIXTEEN



EVERETT

I ’m shaking uncontrollably. My adrenaline is pumping, and it has nothing to do with the dead men on the floor.

Kashton adjusts my body so my head hangs off the bed farther and runs the tip of his dick along my lips. I want to please him. My body knows what to do. This is what it’s been trained for—to be used.

He slides the tip of his pierced dick into my mouth as he rips my shirt more than it already was. His hands shove my bra out of the way, and he grabs a hold of my breast, rough and needy, as his cock invades my mouth.

He’s so big. I try to adjust my head more at an angle so he slides in, but his muscular thighs are on either side, pinning me in place. So I open wider, my jaw already aching in this position, and the cold metal makes saliva gather in my mouth. I try to swallow it, but I can’t.

My hips rise, needing him to remove my jeans and touch me, but I know he’s not going to when he laughs at my desperation. This is about him.

His cock pushes farther down my throat, and he groans when my air is taken away. My body jerks involuntarily, and he pulls out.

I cough, and spit covers my lips when I gasp in a breath. “Not used to getting face fucked?” he asks, smiling down at me. “I’ll teach you, angel,” he assures me. “You’ll learn really quick just how I like it.”

Before I can say anything, he shoves his cock back into my mouth. I open wide, closing my eyes. His hand drops to my nape, and he grips my skin, pulling pieces of my hair caught between his tatted

fingers, and lifts my neck to arch it more so he can slide down my throat once more.

I gag when he hits the back of my throat. I'm nowhere close to taking all of him. My legs kick out and I arch my back, trying to twist and breathe.

"Fuck, Eve." His free hand slaps my breast, and the lingering sting makes my pussy throb. "Relax your throat and breathe through your nose; your mouth is busy," he instructs me.

My nose? How? He's blocking it every time he pushes down my throat, smashing my face into him. I think I'm about to pass out when he pulls out. I cough again, and more saliva lands on my face.

"You're doing so good, Eve." His one hand remains on the back of my neck while the other rubs the side of my face, smearing my drool. "Look at me."

I open my heavy eyes and suck in breath after breath, glancing at him upside down. He moves to sit down on the bed beside me and lifts my head with his hand still in place.

"I'm sorry," I breathe and flinch at my own words. I tense, waiting for him to hit me for not doing what he wants.

Instead, he frowns as his eyes take in my messy face. "Don't apologize, angel. You're doing great," he assures me, and my cheeks flush at his lie. "Open wide and stick out your tongue."

I do as I'm told, and he places two fingers in my mouth. He rubs them along my tongue at first and then pushes them to the back of my throat.

I gag, my body jerking at the intrusion, but my underwear is soaked and I'm desperate for him to fuck me.

"Breathe," he commands. "Through your nose." He holds his fingers there, and my watery eyes close. "Eyes on me." He removes his fingers and gently taps the side of my face.

My pussy clenches, and I groan. My body remembers this from before, and it couldn't be more turned on. "Please?" I beg shamelessly.

He smiles at me and shoves his fingers back into my mouth. I blink rapidly while he holds them in place, pinning my tongue captive.

I arch my neck and try to loosen his hold, but it's useless. "You're being a good girl for me, Eve. So good." He starts to move his fin-

gers back and forth, but then he adds a third, and my eyes widen at the extra intrusion. "You'll be able to take my cock down your throat in no time."

It's a promise that I'm going to be his fuck toy, and I wrap my lips the best I can around his fingers to suck on them, showing him that like a dog, I, too, can be trained.

"Fuck," he groans, pulling them out.

"Fuck me," I plead. It's been years, and as much as I've denied myself the pleasure of sex, I need him right now.

He gets up and crawls onto the bed, yanking my jeans down. I help him by kicking off my heels before lifting my hips. Then he's kneeling between my shaking legs.

"Watch me fuck you, Eve." He wraps his hand around my throat and pushes it off the side of the bed once more so I can see myself on the mirrored wall a couple of feet from us. He grabs his cock and watches while he slides into my soaked pussy. "Fuck," he groans as my cunt stretches for him. "Goddammit, angel. You're so tight."

My heavy eyes fall closed, and his hand flexes around my throat, restricting my air. "Eyes open and on the mirror. Watch me fuck you, angel."

My hips buck on their own, and I arch my back more, trying to get my neck free so I can breathe, but it doesn't help.

Tears cloud my vision and the sound of his cock fucking my wet pussy fills the room.

"That's my girl." He pulls his dick from my cunt and lets go of my neck to slap my pussy.

I choke out a gasp and flinch at the pain. It just makes me wetter.

"Beautiful." He runs his fingers between my lips and then sits up. Gripping my hips, he flips me over onto my stomach.

My head hangs off the edge and my hair sticks to my slick face. His knees spread my legs, forcing me to arch my back and I groan when his pierced dick slides back into me. I'm so sore already. It's been too long.

He grabs a handful of my hair and yanks my head up. I cry out, but he slides his free arm around my exposed neck and flexes, cutting

me off. Lowering his lips to my ear, he smiles at me in the mirrored wall before us.

I fight my tied arms, but his weight is on top of my back, crushing them between us. I can't move and my pussy clenches down on his cock.

His smile grows at the feel of it. "I want you to see what I do when you get off." His hips start to move back and forth while his tatted muscular arm holds me captive.

My lips are parted, eyes heavy, and drool starts to fall from the corner of my mouth.

"Gorgeous." He kisses the side of my slick face while thrusting his hips back and forth, fucking my pussy. "See yourself, angel?" His deep voice sends a shiver down my arched spine. "How good you're doing. Your cunt is taking my cock so well."

My face tingles and my heavy lashes blink. Dots start to cloud my vision.

"Don't pass out on me, angel. Not yet." He loosens his arm just enough that I'm able to suck in a ragged breath.

"Pl-ease?" I beg desperately, squirming under his body. I need to come.

"You can have anything you want, Eve. All you have to do is ask for it." He pulls back and slams forward, his cock making my eyes roll into the back of my head.

I'm so close. "I need…please, Kash, I need to come."

His arm tightens around my neck once again, and his hips thrust harder.

By the sound of his body slapping mine, I know he's not going to give up this time. I'd smile if I could. My body heats up with pleasure as his cock slams into me. It hurts like it's my first time. A burning feeling due to his large size stretching me. My body tries to fight, to pull away, but he holds me in place. Allowing no escape.

His eyes are on mine while dots start to cover the mirror in front of my face. I blink and he speaks. "Beautiful…" Kashton's voice trails off, or maybe I lose my hearing over the blood rushing in my ears.

The light in the room grows brighter before it seems to explode in front of my heavy eyes. Heat rushes over my sweat-covered skin

and my pussy clenches down on him.

"That's a good girl," I hear him faintly say before everything fades away.

I groan, lifting my head, and realize I'm still in the motel. I'm lying on my stomach, head hanging off the edge and drool running from my parted lips. Blinking, I scan the floor and see the dead guy that I shot in the head.

Scrambling to sit up, I push my hair from my face and look around quickly to see that Kashton has left. I passed out. Well, he choked me out as I came all over his dick. He must have removed his belt from around my wrists, gotten dressed, and left me here.

What a gentleman.

I get off the bed slowly because my body is so sore. Between the fight with the two guys and the sex with Kashton, I'm exhausted and still shaking.

Looking for my phone, I see a Post-it on the mirrored wall by what seems to be a small bullet hole. Squinting, I walk over to it and read the writing.



"Fucking bastard." I rip it off and wad it up, throwing it into my bag and collecting my things. I remember getting off a shot before he took the gun from me. I wasn't really aiming for him, but if he wants to think that, then that's fine.

I get dressed the best I can because Kash ripped my shirt, toss my bag in my car, and send a text before I drive off.

Done.

I'm pulling into my driveway thirty minutes later, still trembling at what I did.

I had sex. The thought hits me like a punch to the face. Shame enters my mind, and I feel disgusted. I begged to suck his dick. Begged to be fucked. I fucking apologized. For what? Not being a good whore for him?

"You'll be such a good dolly."

I park my car, not even bothering to close my garage door, and rush inside. I make it to the bathroom just in time to fall in front of

the toilet. I throw up all the alcohol I had tonight because that's all that's in my system.

KASHTON

I left her there to see what she would do afterward. To see where she would go.

She went home. I park my bike in my garage across the street. It's late and no one is awake at this time of night. Not in a neighborhood like this. Then I walk over to her place. It's easy, considering she left her garage door open.

I walk past her car and frown. She was in a hurry to get inside. Didn't even close the car door. I bump it with my hip, shutting it, and then press the button on the wall to close the garage.

Stepping inside, I lock the door behind me to see I'm in a laundry room. I quietly look around the next door to see a hallway. The sound of her gagging has me hurrying my step.

Is some unlucky bastard fucking my girl's face? If so, I'll rip out his tongue and shove it down his throat. I've let her play around for too long. I've claimed her. She's mine. There's no going back now.

Storming into what I'm guessing is her bedroom, I hear a toilet flush, and I stop.

Then she's gagging again followed by the sound of her vomiting.

She's sick? She seemed fine earlier. Maybe she had too much to drink and I didn't notice?

She flushes the toilet once more, and then the bathtub starts running. I quickly hide in a side room as she exits the primary suite at the end of the hall and walks to her kitchen. Slowly, I step out and make my way down the hall and to her bedroom before sliding into her bathroom. I slip into what I'm hoping is her closet, shut off the light, and close the door, leaving it cracked for me to look out with one eye. I've got to get cameras installed in her house ASAP.

Eve enters a few minutes later with a bottle of Jack Daniel's. She checks the temperature of the water filling the bathtub first and then turns on the sink and splashes her face before brushing her teeth and rinsing with mouthwash. I watch her face in the mirror, and I don't see any visible signs of being impaired.

She bows her head, her disheveled hair falling to shield her face from me, and takes in a deep breath. Picking up her phone, she taps on the screen a few times, and "Don't Let Me Down" by The Chainsmokers and Daya begins to fill the large bathroom. She puts her hair up in a messy bun and slowly begins to undress.

She unbuttons and unzips her jeans, her hips softly swaying back and forth while she pushes them down her lean legs. She's not wearing any underwear because I took them back at the motel.

Bruises dot her tan skin. Most appear fresh from tonight. Some from those two men and a few from me, I'm sure. The ones I made with my teeth two nights ago in the cathedral office are prominent. She places her cell and the bottle of Jack on the side of the bathtub before she sinks into it.

The music is interrupted by her phone ringing. She looks at it and her finger hovers over the Decline button. Sighing, she answers and puts the call on speaker, leaving the device sitting on the edge of the tub. "Yes?"

"What the fuck happened tonight?" a familiar voice barks, and every muscle in my body tenses while my pulse begins to race.

What the fuck?

"I'm good, thanks for asking." She rolls her eyes, sliding farther into the bathtub, getting comfortable.

"Eve," he growls, "you weren't supposed to kill them both."

I grip the closet door's knob, wanting nothing more than to rush out there, take her phone, and demand to know what the fuck is going on.

"How was I supposed to have known he was bringing his brother? They were expecting a two-for-one special." She closes her eyes. "You're lucky I'm committed to my job."

He gives a humorless laugh. "Fuck, Eve. This is not—"

"So next time just let them rape me." She nods to herself. "Got it."

The man sighs heavily. "You know that's not what I want."

"One of them wanted to piss down my throat," Eve adds, shivering. "No thanks."

After a long second of silence on her end, he says, "You did good."

She huffs before opening her eyes and taking a swig from the bottle of Jack. "Thanks."

"What about the third guy?"

She frowns. "What third guy? Another brother? There were only the two."

"Missy said she saw a third guy. He's been hanging around the bar lately and followed you over to your room."

Eve chuckles. "Of course she's a tattling bitch," she mumbles to herself and then adds, "It was no one."

"Eve. Who the fuck was it?" he demands.

She drops her head back onto the fluffy pink pillow behind her and closes her eyes once more. My girl looks exhausted. She's coming down off her high, whereas my adrenaline is pumping at everything I'm hearing. "Kashton."

"What?" he barks. "Kash…Kashton? My brother?" His voice rises. "What the fuck was he doing there?"

Her eyes open and narrow at his harsh tone. "He's been following me since you sent him and Haidyn to pick up the prisoner at the cathedral."

"For the second time, that wasn't me. Why would I send them there? I have nothing to do with the Lords," he snaps and then adds, "Maybe Bill did."

"No"—her gaze drops to the bubbles, and her voice softens—"he wouldn't do that to me. Bill knows I want nothing to do with them."

Nothing to do with *them*? As in Saint, Haidyn, and me?

I can't speak for Saint and Haidyn, but she didn't act that way when my cock was inside her an hour ago. She was begging me for it. Her pretty pink cunt was soaked, and her mouth was greedy. She wanted me.

"I'm boarding the jet now. I'll be landing in about three hours. Meet me—"

"No," she interrupts him. "I'm going to down a bottle of Jack and pass out."

"Still self-medicating, I see."

"Careful," she warns. "That tone sounds a little judgy coming from a man who fucks any woman who will spread her legs."

He laughs softly and then clears his throat. “Be careful, Eve.”

She stiffens but says, “I’m always careful.”

“No. You’re not. Kashton is not someone you should fuck with.”

“I can handle him.” She squares her shoulders as if he’s looking right at her.

I love her confidence. That she thinks she can take me on and win. The woman has no clue how persistent I can be. She can bring her stapler or a gun to fight with me, and I’ll still win. Every time.

“He’s bored, and that’s never a good thing.”

“What the fuck do you mean by bored?” She takes another drink, and some of it runs down her chin and onto her chest before it disappears into the bubbles.

“Saint has Ashtyn, Haidyn is busy with Charlotte, and I’m gone. He needs something to take up his time.”

“Well, that won’t be me.” She shakes her head in denial, and a few strands fall loose from her messy bun.

He’s quiet for a second before he makes a suggestion. “Maybe… maybe you should get away for a while.”

“Not this again.” Her teeth grind. “I’m not running. I like it here.” Her green eyes slowly take in the bathroom, as if she’s proud of what she has.

“Everett, you have no friends, no true family other than Bill. Pack up your shit and get the fuck out of this state.”

She sits up, water splashing off the edges at her harsh movement, and huffs. “I said no, Adam. I’m not fucking leaving my home. And I’m pretty fucking tired of you thinking you can order me around.”

“You work for me,” he says matter-of-factly. “I’m telling you now that you need to leave. Especially if you’ve got Kashton’s attention. Nothing good could come from that.”

“I can think of something.” Her eyes widen and she slaps a hand over her mouth, surprised she said that.

“Wait. You let him fuck you?” he asks, surprised. Her hand still remains over her mouth while her wide eyes stare straight ahead at nothing. “I’m proud of you, Eve.”

Slowly removing her hand, her eyes drop to the bubbles, and she whispers, “Yeah, well, it’s just sex. Everyone does it at some point.”

He ignores that and asks, "How do you feel?"

I frown, confused by the change in conversation and why he cares so much. But she lays her head back on the little pillow and looks up at the ceiling as she swallows, softening her voice. "Sick. It was a mistake and won't be happening again."

Is that why she vomited? Because we had sex? I made her physically ill? Like…she was disgusted with me? She didn't act that way at the motel.

"What did you tell him?" Adam asks.

"Nothing. Not like we talked about our previous sexual partners." She snorts. "And I'm sure there's another dumb bitch licking my cum off his dick right now."

Never, angel.

"No. I mean about the two dead guys he saw."

"Oh. He asked some questions, and when I didn't answer, he made some assumptions. I just let his mind run with it. I didn't confirm or deny anything."

Adam sighs heavily. "I'll reach out—"

"No." She sits up quickly and water splashes over the side of the tub once more. "You promised me that if I worked for you, I would get revenge. Kashton will go to the Spades—"

"No. He won't."

"You don't know that. You've been out of their lives for too long. They no longer trust you."

"Be that as it may," Adam growls, "like I said earlier, Saint and Haidyn are both married now. Their wives are pregnant. Kashton wouldn't bring them into this."

She bows her head in surrender. "He'll want to get involved."

"It sounds like he already is. I'm not going to risk your life because he decides to follow you one night and fuck shit up because he has no clue what's going on. One second." Adam speaks softly, ordering a drink on the private jet. "Hey, I just got a text that the scene is cleared, but the guys didn't have their phones on them. Did you take them?"

That's why she told me that she didn't need my brothers' help. They have a whole system down.

"Fuck," she hisses.

"What?"

Biting her lip nervously, she answers, "I… We…"

"Spit it out," he barks.

"I passed out for a second." *You mean I choked you out, angel.* "When I woke up, Kashton was already gone. He must have searched the bodies and taken them."

"Goddammit, Eve," he shouts.

"Hey. I did my job. You're welcome, by the way." He's still shouting when she hangs up the phone. Music begins coming from it once again. She tosses it to the floor, and it lands on the white rug in the center of the room.

I remain hidden, watching her drink while she stares into nothing. It's the same blank look on her face that I saw that night on the *Isabella.*

That night and the conversation she just had with Adam makes me rethink the notion that she was at Dollhouse. He said he was proud of her for having sex, and she got sick afterward.

She's been used before. Groomed. And she hated herself after I fucked her because she liked it.

It makes me wonder if he's fucked her, and I hate the idea of them together. That he could have had something that I wanted. I had her first, right? That night on the yacht. I met her before he did.

I've never been jealous, but the thought of her being with anyone else makes me see red. Even if it was before me.

Or the fact that she was used as a sex slave. What did they do to her? Obviously, she remembers at least a little bit of it, otherwise she wouldn't have gotten sick because she allowed me to touch her.

I'll show my girl that it's okay to be fucked. That it's okay to want to feel good. And I'll make sure Adam understands she belongs to me.

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SEVENTEEN



EVERETT

Twenty years old

I can't see anything. Nothing but darkness. They say that when one sense is taken away, the others intensify.

I can't give an opinion, because right now, I can't see, feel, or hear anything. I can't move.

I'm wrapped in something tight, my arms crossed over my chest, and there's something covering my head. Rubber in my mouth. I've been here before. A straitjacket and a ball gag. So I can't fight and bite.

There's a gnawing at the back of my mind that I'm lying down or maybe I'm standing up. I can't tell. My pussy and ass are full of… something. They softly vibrate. Enough to feel it but not enough to have any pleasure from it. It's irritating, to say the least. To be kept right on the edge.

I fight the restraints but get nowhere. It's strapped too tight. My arms have gone numb and my body tired.

I'm grabbed roughly, and then the hood over my head is removed. I blink rapidly at the harsh light.

"Hello, dolly. How are you feeling?"

I try to talk, but the large rubber ball in my mouth prevents it. My jaw is sore, and saliva pours from my cracked lips.

He slaps the side of my face, and my eyes spring open, the harsh light blinding me.

"Wake up, Eve. This isn't nap time."

That buzzing between my legs gets more intense, and I arch my back, moaning.

Heat licks my skin as if I'm outside sitting under the sun. It's so hot. Almost unbearable.

"You're close, Eve. I can tell."

I hate proving him right. No matter how much I fight, he always wins because he cheats.

"You just need a little help to get there."

I start to fight with all I have and scream into the gag when he pinches my thigh. Then I feel the prick of the needle, and my body melts into the floor. I moan, and he reaches out, pushes my hair down my sweat-covered face, and smiles at me. "That's it. Come all over it, Eve. Show me that you can be trained to be a good girl."

That feeling intensifies, and my eyes roll back into my head as a wave washes over me. I'm drowning, the feeling taking my breath away.

"That's a good whore. You've got another hour, and then I'll let you free."

When I'm able to open my eyes, I see nothing but blackness, and I know the bastard either turned off the light or put the hood back over my head.

I blink, the memory fading away, and I realize my bathwater has gone cold. Pulling the drain cap, I stand, grab my towel, and dry off.

I'm proud of you, Eve, Adam had told me.

Who is proud of someone for being a whore? That's what I was for Kashton tonight. A slut who needed to be fucked. It was like muscle memory. I mean, obviously I couldn't deep throat like I was trained to do, but that's like anything else. You have to use it or lose it.

Something tells me Kash will prefer me on my knees. Every man has a preference on what hole they like to fuck. And it makes my stomach turn to think about how willingly I keep giving my body over to him.

Killing provokes an adrenaline rush like no other. The odds that I might not survive get me all excited. Then to know that Kash had been following me…I was weak in the knees for him.

Bile churns in my stomach, and I place my hand over my mouth, gagging. Fuck. Not again. I try to swallow it down, but I find myself running to the toilet once more and getting sick.

Sitting back on my heels, I flush the toilet and catch my breath. Standing up, I brush my teeth for the second time, scrubbing so hard I make my gums bleed, and gag when I run it aggressively over the back of my tongue. Trying to remove any trace that Kashton was there and the lingering taste of acid.

Grabbing my cell, I turn off the bathroom light and place my phone in the cradle on my nightstand, turning on music. Needing noise. I spent too many years in silence, and I can't do it tonight. I hear voices that aren't there. Well, they were there once. It's the screams of those of us being tortured and trained. Someone was always crying. Even if they were gagged, you could still hear mumbled sobs.

It was terrifying, but it also had to do with the drugs. They altered and magnified emotions. It was always a struggle—in the back of my mind, I knew it was wrong, but my body craved it.

"THE PURGE" by In This Moment fills my room. It's not loud enough to shake the walls, but loud enough to drown out anything Kashton related.

I crawl into bed naked and pull the covers up to my chin, leaving the light on. Yawning, I settle into the mattress, the bottle of Jack doing its job. I might not be addicted to drugs, but I rely heavily on alcohol. Neither one is good for me. But it's not like it'll kill me. If it were up to me, I'd already be dead.

KASHTON

Music fills the bathroom, and I frown, wondering what the fuck she's doing. I thought she was going to bed.

I close the closet door and flip on the light, turning to confirm I have been in her closet. One wall's filled with designer bags; another has various sizes and shapes of high heels. Some even look like something a stripper would wear.

Opening her drawers, I find her underwear—thongs, boy shorts, and G-strings. She didn't come in here to get dressed, making me think she went to bed naked.

My cock was inside her less than an hour ago, and I'm already hard for her again. Especially after what she said to Adam. She thinks she can just fuck me and I'll walk away from her?

I can handle him.

No. You can't, angel. You think you're sick now? Just wait. I'll make you disgusted by the sight of me. I'm going to be everywhere in your life. All-consuming.

She's going to be mine in every way. Including my wife.

I come to a section that is nothing but black clothes. Studded belts, black leather pants, and matching tops. I see something that catches my attention, making me frown. I pick up the hanger and look over the material.

It's a bulletproof vest.

Looks to be custom made. More feminine than any I've ever seen before. It's got plates in the front and back, Velcro over both the shoulders and across the waist but tailored to fit a smaller frame. And it feels lighter than most.

What the fuck does Adam have her do that requires a bulletproof vest? This isn't something she can hide under a crop top when she's trying to seduce a man in a bar.

This is something you wear under a hoodie when you're prepared to get shot at.

Is she a cop? I know Adam works with them.

"We buried you," I state the obvious, sitting on the private jet. "Your body…It was cold. It wasn't like Haidyn's fake death where he sat in a morgue. You fucking shot yourself…you had no face."

Adam runs a hand over his dark hair. "Yeah." His green eyes meet mine. "Although it wasn't my body. We had to pull some strings."

"We?" Haidyn asks, shooting a look at the other two men on the plane with us. They say nothing.

"So, what…you're a detective or a cop?" I wonder, looking at Adam. "CIA?" Then I joke, "Hitman?" Fuck, I feel like anything is possible right now.

"Not necessarily." He shakes his head, chuckling.

"Then what the fuck are you?" Saint growls, tired of fake deaths and games.

Adam slaps the detective on the back. "He's my boss. For the past four years, I've been undercover, working in a top-secret division that specializes in human trafficking."

I've seen it with my own eyes that she kills men. And the dead woman found in the cemetery…she has to be on the inside. She knows too much, and they've planted that body to take her down.

I return the vest and get back to going through her things. All her drawers are full of clothes or accessories. Not sex toys. Not a single one. Which I find suspicious. What kind of woman doesn't have some sort of toys?

Does she not even touch herself?

Turning, I spot a box in the far corner. It's hidden underneath some jeans hanging up, so it's easy to miss.

I walk over to it and pull it out to find it's taped shut. Removing my pocketknife, I flick the blade out and run it along the top of the tape, slicing it open. Putting it back in my pocket, I free the lid. "Bingo."

Tipping it on its side, a dildo falls out. It's on the smaller side, no more than five inches long. It doesn't vibrate or anything. Next thing is a large red ball gag. "Now we're talking," I say, pulling out a straitjacket.

We have one at Carnage, and this one is almost identical. It's legit. Grade A. Not some fake knockoff, and I wonder if Adam had this made for her too.

The thought has me fisting the material in my hands. I wad it up and shove it to the side. There's also a blindfold, handcuffs, and a set of nipple clamps.

I place everything back in the box, closing the lid and shoving it back under the jeans. Mr. Fells said she bought this house a few years back, and this box was taped, so that tells me she hasn't been in it in a long time.

That makes me feel a little better, but not much.

I crack open the closet door. The song has changed to "Push" by Matchbox Twenty, and I slowly make my way through the darkly lit bathroom and peek into her bedroom. She's facing me, an arm stretched out under her pillow, eyes closed, and plump lips parted.

She's passed out. Walking over to her bed, I pick up her cell, exit the playlist, and go to her recent calls. **Fuckface** pops up. I'm not sure if his contact name is a good or bad thing.

I text Adam from her cell that I'll meet him after all.

He answers immediately.

Meet me at the house. You remember the address, right?

Fuck. What house? I'm about to respond with a *no* when he sends another one with the address.

Just in case.

I read it over and delete the text. I put it back and open up her playlist, making sure it's just how she left it. Then I turn to leave but pause. Very gently, I run the tip of my fingers over a bruise on her cheek, pushing her hair out of her face. One of those fucking bastards in the motel room hit her. I should have busted in there sooner.

She doesn't move. I lean down and hover with my face over hers before I softly kiss it, needing to feel her skin on mine. She feels warm on my lips.

Fuck, I want to crawl into bed with her right now. Would she fight me? Tell me no? Something says no. She'd let me do whatever I wanted to her. But she's had a rough night. The empty bottle of Jack on her nightstand proves it.

So instead, I whisper, "Sweet dreams, angel. I'll see you soon." Then I pick up her phone to do one last thing before I leave her house.

I figured three in the morning would be the best time to meet up with Adam. She'd be home in bed, sound asleep for the night. He said he was on the jet and would be back in a few hours.

Eve is still heavy on my mind when I find myself pulling into a gated driveway. Thankfully it's already open. Otherwise, I'd have to use the call button and tell on myself.

I want to turn around, rush back to her house, and wake her up with my head between her legs. But this is important. I need information, and he can give it to me.

I pull up to the modern black house and get out of my car. This must be the house Haidyn gave to Adam. He mentioned it on the private jet when Adam revealed he was still alive.

Haidyn stands and digs into his pocket, pulling out a set of keys. He removes one from the ring and holds it out to Adam. "Here."

"No…"

"Take it. I bought that house for you. It's always been yours."

I enter the double doors, and he must hear me, because he calls out from a room down the hallway.

"I'm in the office."

Walking down the hallway, I take the first door on the left and enter.

"Eve—" Adam looks up from the desk. "I should have known." He sits back, shaking his head. "Let me guess…you bugged her phone."

"I was hiding in her closet."

He sighs.

"And since I'm so *bored*, I thought I'd come and get some answers."

Adam runs a hand through his hair. He's frustrated and nervous. Which just pisses me off. "I—"

"How the fuck do you know her?" I demand, getting to the point.

He glances away, jaw sharpening.

"You saved her from Dollhouse, right?"

"No," he says immediately, eyes finding mine again. "I didn't even know where Dollhouse was located until Bill took us there to save Haidyn."

"But she was there," I go on.

"She…" He pauses and slams his elbows onto the desk. Leaning over, he runs his hands through his hair again.

Yep. I caught you, motherfucker. "Adam," I snap.

"Yes," he growls, slapping his palms on the surface. "But Bill was the one who removed her from Dollhouse."

"And by Bill, you mean her *daddy*." That has to be the man the realtor was telling me about. The one who bought her house.

He doubles down. "I don't know what you're talking about."

"Christ, Adam. Why are you lying to me? Bill had her over for dinner the other night. Sin and Elli were there since Bill married his mother. He called Eve his daughter, but when Sin brought this to our attention, Haidyn got Charlotte involved, and she was unaware he had other kids. So why now? Why show her off to everyone now?"

"Because Isabella was his wife," he shouts, and then takes a deep breath. "Now Isabella is a prisoner at Carnage and Bill is free of that

bitch. Bill wants Everett to have a life. As close to a normal one as she can. This is him giving her that."

Normal? She's killing men. That's nothing close to normal. "How long was she there for?" I ask, sitting on a couch.

"I don't know." He shakes his head, and I narrow my eyes on him. "I swear." He throws his hands up. "She doesn't talk about it, and neither does Bill."

"How was he able to get her out?" I ask softly, bowing my head, believing him.

"I don't know."

I lift my head, grinding my teeth.

"I'm telling you the truth. Bill and I are not close. Well, weren't close. I don't know what he paid or who he bribed. Hell, maybe it was Isabella herself he talked into letting her go. Because as far as I know, he was married to Isabella when Bill pulled Eve out of Dollhouse. But I promise, I have no clue. That's something you'll have to ask Eve or Bill."

If that timeline is correct, that means she *was* a doll that night on the *Isabella*.

"What revenge did you promise her?" I try, remembering everything that was mentioned on their phone call.

He shrugs. "Eve hates men. Rightfully so. I promised her she could rid the world of them."

I snort. "At the cost of her life. Those guys tonight both got hits on her."

He looks away from me, unable to make eye contact. They both know the risk when she takes a job.

"And what do you get from this?"

He frowns. "What do you mean?"

I hate that I'm even going to ask this because I already know the answer. "Are you fucking her? Is that what you get? You give her jobs, and she has to fuck you in return?"

"No."

He answers fast. Too fast. As if he knew I'd ask him. "But you have fucked her."

He bows his head and sighs. "Yes."

I jump up from the couch, and he stands from the chair behind the desk. “It’s not like that. It was one time, and we were both drunk—”

“So you took advantage of her?” I snap.

“No,” he growls. “Look. I need you to understand…fuck! Telling you it meant nothing makes me look like an ass, but telling you it meant something makes it a lie.” He falls back down into the chair and glances at me. “You can’t say that you haven’t done the same.”

I rub the back of my neck because he’s right. I just fucked her hours ago with two guys she killed in the same room. I went into the motel knowing I was going to fuck my girl. No matter what I had to do to get it. “I went through her things tonight while at her place.”

His brows pull together. “And?” He places his elbows on the desk and leans forward. His interest tells me he hasn’t done the same. He wants to know what I found, which just furthers my point that my girl is closed off. Keeps to herself. I’m going to knock down every wall she has.

“She had a box of…items. Straitjacket, blindfold, handcuffs, dildo… but other than that, there were no other toys I could find.” He tilts his head to the side. “I just find it odd, ya know? We had sex tonight, and she gets sick to her stomach afterward…” Sex is a weapon when it comes to the Lords. You either take it or you receive it.

He runs a hand down his face. “Eve doesn’t…have sex,” he finishes.

“With anyone?” I clarify.

“No one.” He leans back in his seat. “Obviously, you overheard her tell me that you two had sex, but I’m going to tell you the same thing I told her. Be careful.”

“Careful with what?”

“Eve. If she doesn’t fall in love with you, she’ll most likely kill you,” he says matter-of-factly.

I smile at that. “If you’re not on the verge of death, are you even living?”

He shakes his head and chuckles.

“There was one other item I found in her closet.” He arches a brow. “She had a bulletproof vest.” He looks away from me, and I know I

was right. "Eve got it from you. The question is, why the fuck does she need one?"

"It's just a precaution."

"For what?" I demand.

"Eve wants to be more involved—"

"Pull her back," I interrupt him, hearing enough. "She's going to get killed. You're going to get her killed."

"She's saving women, Kash," he whispers. "I understand that it's hard to see from your point of view, but she's doing what others can't."

I fist my hands on my thighs. "She's putting her life in danger."

"It's her life," he argues, as if that's a good enough reason. "And until she comes to me and tells me herself that she wants to pull back, I'm going to continue letting her do what she wants."

It just proves that I need to step in. Make sure that she has someone to protect her when things get hard. She's going to get in too deep and won't be able to pull herself out. I can do it.

Sighing, I lean back against the couch and tell him, "I saw her on the *Isabella*."

He frowns at my change in subject. "When…? The night of our junior initiation?"

I nod. "Yeah. I saw her when Saint and I were headed to the poker room before we killed his mark. She was standing with an older man. Then after we killed Saint's men, I saw her again when you guys were blowing up my cell looking for Haidyn." I run a hand through my hair. "She ran into me. The man said he was 'paying' for her, and he took her into a room. I heard her screaming and I burst in and killed him. Then she ran." I leave out the part where I fingered her. It's none of his business.

"Wait." He holds up a hand. "The ripped dress…the heels? Those were hers in the owner's suite?"

I nod.

"And the guy who was 'paying' for her…"

"Was my initiation, but I didn't know that when I killed him."

He frowns, rubbing the back of his neck. "You think she was working for Dollhouse then? If she was there with him?"

"Seems so. You said Bill didn't save Eve until after he was already married to Isabella. Haidyn killed her husband that night on the yacht. It makes sense." I shrug. "But you know more about Everett than I do." I don't know how Dollhouse works. Do they allow the slaves to leave? I would think they'd be afraid one would talk. Then again, I guess when you're brainwashed, it's hard to think for yourself. The victims could be too terrified to speak out and tell someone what is happening to them for fear of being punished if they don't end up escaping.

Shaking his head, he says. "I didn't meet Eve until a year later…our senior year. After I went into hiding."

"She was in hiding as well?"

He leans back in his chair. "My boss introduced me to Bill, who introduced me to Eve."

By *boss*, I'm guessing he means the detective we met on the private jet. "And?" I demand.

"And she went to Vegas with me for a little bit."

"With you? As in you two lived together?" I growl. That's more than fucking one time.

"No. She helped me."

"With what, Adam?"

He looks away and sighs. "With Ashtyn."

"Are you fucking kidding me?" Of course she did.

His eyes narrow on mine. "I couldn't just walk up to my sister. I needed someone who could keep an eye on her without throwing up red flags. By that time, Bill was married to Isabella, and Eve wanted to be as far away from here as possible. So she went with me."

I shake my head. "So you're saying that if Ashtyn sees her, she's going to know who she is? They were friends?"

"No." He frowns. "Eve doesn't have any friends."

That's the second time I've heard him say that. "What about Bill? You didn't trust him with Charlotte, yet you trust him with Everett?" I had my doubts about Bill, and I'm still not sure how much we can trust him.

"I knew Isabella had a daughter, but I didn't know who she was until Haidyn had me dig into Charlotte. When I found out who Char-

lotte really was and that she was Isabella's daughter, it immediately threw up red flags. I knew a little of what Eve had been through, so I thought Isabella was setting up Charlotte for the same fate. And I wasn't sure how much I could trust Bill, since they were married."

It sounds reasonable, but I'm not sure I believe it. "So now that Ashtyn is back at Carnage, you and Eve have returned to Pennsylvania?"

"Eve went back and forth between here and Vegas. She works for the Lords at the cathedral. She needed to keep up appearances."

The confessionals and offerings. I nod in understanding.

I get up, remove the two dead guys' cell phones from my pocket, and drop them on his desk before I turn to walk toward the door. As my hand wraps around the handle, I turn to him and say, "Don't tell her to run away again. She's not going anywhere." I open the door to leave.

"Kash?" I turn once again to give him my full attention. "If you decide to…pursue her. Then you better be damn sure she's what you want. She's been through a lot."

I want to know everything about my angel, so I ask, "What aren't you telling me, Adam?"

He fixes his already straight tie. "Since Isabella is finally gone, Bill and I have been trying to gain access to Dollhouse."

"What do you mean *gain access*? The guys walked right in for the founders' enhancements after Haidyn was out." I'm the only one who hasn't taken them. No reason to. I don't want to fucking live longer than I have to. Not for the Lords—to serve them. I'd rather die with dignity than continue to be their little bitch.

"There are so many hidden places across that land. Rumor has it, there're tapes and files about every victim who spent time at Dollhouse."

I grind my teeth, but honestly, I'm not surprised. It's Lords 101. You record everything you do. Either to brag about later or to use as blackmail. "Find them."

"I'm trying," he grinds out.

"And when you do, I want everything on her." I'll destroy anything that includes her name or face from that god-awful place.

He gives a nod. "You have my word."

I snort. "Your word is shit lately, Adam." With that, I yank open the door.

"I suggest you keep this conversation between us."

Slamming the door shut, I turn to face him. "Excuse me?"

"Eve is against running right now, but if she finds out you know too much, that will be the only thing on her mind. And it won't be a situation like Saint and Ashtyn…" He shakes his head. "You'll never find her."

"Are you threatening me?" I growl. "Going to try and take her from me?"

"I'm telling you she has resources."

"You're telling me that you'd help her hide?" I'm not surprised. He kept Ashtyn from Saint, knowing where she was. "I'm not as forgiving as Saint is." I'll cut his fucking hands off and sew his lips shut before I let him take her.

He holds his hands out wide. "Bill wants to keep her safe just like you, but he's willing to ship her off in order to do that."

I scratch the back of my head, getting an idea. "I'll go with her. If that's what will get her away from here…the job…" *You.*

He smiles as if he's reading my mind. Turning, he opens a filing cabinet and pulls out a few folders. He drops one on the desk. "Angela Morrow."

"Am I supposed to know who that is?" I rub my temples. Fuck, I'm getting a headache. I should have crawled into bed with Eve.

"You should." He nods to the folder. "Everyone should know her name."

I step up to his desk, pick up the file, and read over the information. My stomach drops when I see that she's twelve. Found naked in a field. Decapitated—

"Christ." I close it and toss it onto the table.

He slaps the second folder down. "This one was sixteen. Car found abandoned on the side of the road. She was on her way home from her boyfriend's house. Body was never found." Then the third. "This one was twenty-five. Husband reported her missing when she didn't arrive at work one morning after dropping their three-year-old off at

daycare. She was six months pregnant." I get a sickening feeling in my stomach. His next words confirm my suspicion. "Her body was recovered three months later. The baby had been cut from her. She also had no organs."

My narrowed eyes meet his, and he leans forward, placing his forearms on the desk. "This is why Eve does what she does. She can't save these women, but with every man involved in this ring she kills, she helps prevent another person from being raped, taken, or murdered."

It's noble. I won't lie. I'm proud of my girl. Most wouldn't be as strong as she is after what she's been through, but it doesn't change anything. "I don't care how many she wants to save. I will not allow her to risk her life for theirs."

He chuckles, and I want to slam his face into the desk. "I wish you luck, man. I do. You're going to need it."

With that, I storm out of his office, slamming the front door behind me when I leave the house.

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EIGHTEEN



EVERETT

I wake up the following morning hungover and feeling like absolute shit. Everything hurts and I'm no longer ashamed. Just pissed off at myself for sleeping with Kashton. One second, and I folded like a chair for him.

Pathetic. It can't happen again. I won't allow it. Next time I fire a gun at him, I'll make sure to hit him where it hurts.

Crawling out of bed, I pull on a T-shirt before making my way to the kitchen for some Advil.

Turning on the light to the living room, I jump, slapping my chest when I see the man sitting on my couch. "Fuck." I let out a breath. "What the fuck are you doing here?" I snap, getting pissy. I'm irritated for several reasons. I knew this day would be shit too.

He lazily looks over my shirt. I'm glad I at least put something on, because I crawled into bed naked last night. I wish I had put underwear on, though. "We need to talk," he says, not even bothering to meet my eyes.

"Call me. It's easier for me to ignore," I say and walk to my kitchen. I grab a bottle of water out of the fridge, but it's snatched from my hands the next second. "Hey," I snap, turning around.

He pushes my back into the counter, and I glare up at him. "I got a call."

I huff. I don't know who the fuck called him, and I know he won't tell me if I ask. "I have it under control."

He lifts his hand and runs his knuckles down my exposed neck. "I don't think you do."

I stiffen. Did Kashton leave marks? I mean, I'm covered in bruises, but that's nothing new. Fighting off grown men will leave evidence. "Your concern isn't needed. Leave."

"You know he's going to be a problem, right?"

I want to ask who the *he* is he's talking about exactly, but I don't. If I ask that, then he'll definitely know I don't have anything under control.

"You can't fuck your way out of this, Eve."

He's got to be talking about Kashton; no way is he referring to Adam. "Maybe I should try it. Always seems to work for the Lords." Sex is their answer to everything.

He grabs my upper arm and spins me around, forcing me to face the counter. He slides my hair off my shoulder and gently twists his fist around it, pulling my head to the side. I suck in a deep breath, and he pushes his body into my back and lowers his lips to my ear. "I need to release some tension. Bend over and spread your legs," he whispers.

A sour taste fills my mouth. I want to blame it on the alcohol, but I know it's from him touching me in such an intimate way. "I'm not into incest," I tell him.

He chuckles, and when his free hand slides between my legs, I close my eyes and clench my thighs shut to keep him out. "You can act as tough as you want, Eve. But we both know you have no control over who fucks this cunt. I was the one who trained you, after all."

Opening my eyes, I see a knife stabbed into the wooden block to my right. Close enough to…

I reach to grab it from the block to stab him, but he's faster. He yanks me back from the counter with his fist still in my hair and shoves me away. I trip over my wobbly legs and fall so hard that I drop the knife, and he kicks it across the room.

I scramble to stand, my heart pounding, breathing erratic. He stands there staring at me with a vacant look in his eyes, though there's a smile on his face. "You're too predictable, Eve. That's why he'd never fall for your shit."

"Get the fuck out of my house," I shout.

"Do I need to remind you of where you came from? What you were made for?"

I swallow, trying to not lose my shit. That's what he wants. A reason to drag me back to hell. No one escapes Dollhouse. Not to have the life that I do.

"No, sir," I say, trying to sound appreciative. All Lords are the same. They want to be powerful.

That smile appears back on his face, and I feel nauseated. What he's done to me. What I know he's capable of. He is why I drink so much. It helps me forget what I wasn't lucky enough to block out. Thankfully, he also talks a lot of shit. He may have trained me, but he's never fucked me.

He steps into me, his hand cupping my chin, and I hold my breath as he leans down and gently kisses my forehead. "I'll see you soon, sis."

When I hear the door close, I close my eyes and fist my hands. The Lords are setting me up. It has to be them. They want to see me gone. I know too much. I knew this day would come.

I know Isabella and LeAnne.

I know about Dollhouse.

I know Adam is still alive.

I know a lot of secrets about others that they want to make sure don't get out.

You're next was carved into the woman's body that was dropped where I spend most of my nights. It might as well have been a neon sign with my name on it.

The only question is, do I lie down and take it, or fight back? Either way requires me to spread my legs, because that's all I have to give.

My doorbell rings, and I frown. I never have visitors, and if I do, they show up unannounced like the one I just had to fight off. I pick the knife up off the floor so I don't step on or trip over it, making my way to the front door.

Yanking it open, I stare at a set of brown eyes. They widen when they get a look at my messy hair and half-dressed, bruised body. They drop to the knife in my hand, and he holds out a massive bou-

quet of flowers. It probably looks like I have a cheating boyfriend trying to apologize without having to say the actual words *I'm sorry*.

"Delivery." He swallows nervously.

"From whom?" I ask but have an idea.

"Umm…there's a card." He shakes the black velvet hat box that's full of red roses at me. I take it from his hands, trying not to stab him with my knife.

"Thanks." I slam the front door shut, make my way back to the kitchen, return the knife to where it belongs, and rip the card from the flowers as I read the logo on the box. Venus et Fleur.

Opening up the card, it reads:



"Bastard."

KASHTON

I pull up to Sin and Elli's house at ten o'clock on the dot. I take a gulp of my Red Bull before getting out. After meeting with Adam this morning, I managed to get about three hours of sleep.

Eve is heavy on my mind. What she's been through. What she's seen. Why does she hate Haidyn, Saint, and me so much? Is it because she hates all men? She mentioned the Spade brothers specifically, but she likes Adam.

Why him? Is it because he helped her escape to Vegas?

The front door opens, and I jump out of the Cadillac Escalade V and rush to the passenger door for Elli. She mumbles a *thank you* and slides into the seat.

I'm not sure if Sin is here, but he sent me the information I needed earlier this morning. I'm driving her an hour out of town for an ap-

pointment.

She remains silent, and I don't try to talk to her. I don't want to make her uncomfortable by asking the wrong questions.

An hour later, I'm pulling into a parking lot and then helping her out of the SUV. I hold her elbow as we make our way up a set of steps and into a brick building. I am not taking my chances with Sin's wife. The fact that he trusts me with her means a lot to me.

There's an empty waiting room. She signs her name on a clipboard and then sits in a chair.

I plop down next to her, looking around. I still have no clue where we're at or who she's here to see. It's obviously not for the baby. She sees Gavin and Devin for that, and she just had an appointment at Carnage yesterday.

"Mrs. Sinnett?" a woman calls out from a door.

I stand, helping Elli to her feet, and then rub my hands on my jeans. "Do you want me…?"

"I'll be an hour," she informs me.

"Okay." I nod. She's telling me to sit the fuck down and wait.

Falling back into my seat, I rest my head on the back of the chair and close my eyes, thinking about Eve and Dollhouse. I'm not sure what to do.

The Lords are after her. That was evident when the body showed up at the cemetery. But why? What does she know that they want to bury her for? She needs to tell me everything. That's the only way I can protect her. I won't fail like I did in the past.

Twelve years old

I find myself down in the basement at Carnage. I've been hiding down here for the past week. We're on summer break, so I'm able to spend more time with her.

Coming up to the cell, I sit down and look through the bars. It's darker than usual. The single light bulb she has is broken, and pieces of glass litter the concrete floor. "What happened?" I ask, pushing my face to the bars. "Are you okay?"

"You shouldn't be down here," she whispers brokenly, but I don't see her.

"But…I always come visit you." I blink, trying to adjust my eyes to the darkness and huff when it doesn't work.

"You need to stop, Kashton."

"No." I move to my knees and try to squeeze through the bars, even though I know it's impossible. "I brought you a brownie." I dig into my pocket and pull it out. "Sorry, it's a little smashed, but I bet it will still taste good."

She doesn't say anything, and I place it between the bars right by the door. I don't want it covered in glass.

"Please?" I beg her, and she sighs before I hear movement.

The light from the hallway shines into the front of the cell, and I watch as she crawls closer to the door on all fours with her head down. "You're bleeding," I say when I catch sight of the blood on her hands and knees.

"I'm fine," she lies.

Why? She's never lied to me before. "I'll go get you some Band-Aids." I jump to my feet.

"No. Don't. Just stay here…with me?"

I fall down onto my butt, thankful she wants to see me. That's unlike her. She's always telling me to go. To be careful and that I shouldn't be down here. "Okay."

"I…I want to tell you how proud of you I am, Kashton."

I frown. "But I haven't done anything."

"You've done everything. You've fed me and offered to keep me warm," she whispers, making no attempt to pick up the brownie. "But sometimes you have to hurt the one you love."

I don't like that. "You've never hurt me." She loves me, right? She's never told me before, but I know she does.

"I will. It's life…inevitable."

The sound of a door slamming has me jumping up. I blink rapidly, wiping drool off my chin. I had fallen asleep.

Has an hour already passed by?

A crying Ellington rushes past me and out the front door. I look around aimlessly, trying to get my bearings, then grab a box of Kleenex off a round table to my right before I rush after her.

"Elli?" I call out, running up next to her. She can't move very fast with her pregnancy. I take her elbow like earlier and help her down the steps before putting her in the passenger seat of the SUV.

Once I fall into the driver's seat, I hand her the box, and she starts blowing her nose, sobbing uncontrollably.

"What can I do?" I ask nervously. Shit. Easton is going to kill me. "Need me to call Sin?"

She shakes her head, wiping her eyes. "He…won't answer."

Right. Fuck. He's on an assignment. "Need me—"

"Just…let's just go." She hiccups. "Please."

"Are you hungry?" I ask. I know women get emotional when they're hungry. Especially pregnant women. Don't they have insane cravings?

She nods and speaks softly. "I could eat."

Okay, we're getting somewhere. "What would you like?" I never venture this far out, so I don't know what's around here, but I'll drive another hour out of my way if I need to in order to get her what she wants.

Blowing her nose again, she takes a deep breath, trying to calm down. "Ice cream," she answers.

Ice cream it is.

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NINETEEN



EVERETT

Sixteen years old

I'm dragged into a room and shoved onto a metal chair that's bolted to the floor. I rub my hands up and down my arms, trying to warm myself up, but they're grabbed and brought behind my back. The sound of the zip tie fills the room as the hard nylon cuts into my skin.

I wish they'd at least give me a jacket. I hate it down here. It's always freezing.

"Hello, Eve." The woman enters with a smile, and I groan. Not this bitch again. I'm going to bite her for real next time she touches me. "How are you feeling today?"

I look away, refusing to answer, and a hand fists my hair, forcing my face down onto the table. Smashing my cheek into the steel. "You speak when you're spoken to," the man orders.

"Yes, sir," I growl through gritted teeth. I'm so tired of them thinking they can control everything I do.

He lets go of me and I sit up, wishing I could push the hair from my face but settling for trying to blow it out of my way instead. "I'm feeling good." I tell her what she wants to hear.

"Wonderful." She beams, and the door opens.

I tense when my father joins the party. "A word. Now," he orders the woman.

She gets up and goes to the back of the room while I remain seated.

"Still nothing?" I hear her speak softly.

"No." My father's friend snaps. "What's with all that garden shit? It should have worked by now."

She sighs. "There are many reasons as to why…" Her voice lowers, and I can't make out what she says.

"If you're no use to me, then why the fuck are you here?" my father snaps, not caring that I can hear him.

The woman mumbles softly, and again, I can't hear her.

"Isn't that like a test tube thing?" His friend laughs. "What's the point of knocking up a woman if you can't use your dick to get the job done?"

I wiggle in the cold seat, trying to fight the zip tie, but it's no use. I've come to like the pain they make me feel.

"You have to start considering other options. Her health isn't… ideal." The woman goes on whispering. "She may technically be a woman, but she's still a child. She's malnourished and irregular…her body is telling you it's not ready."

"So you're suggesting that we try shooting her up with hormones?" My father sounds skeptical.

"I'm saying don't put all your eggs in one basket," she insists.

His friend laughs. "Isn't that the point?"

"Unbelievable," she mutters softly.

The door opens and a third man enters. He looks over my head at the back of the room. "Your son is looking for you." He glances at me. "I told him to wait for you upstairs."

"Christ," the man hisses. "I'll be right back."

My eyes open, pulling me out of that nightmare, and I stare at the ceiling. Reaching over, I pick up my cell and see it is almost midnight. I get up and walk to the kitchen. Grabbing a bottle of Jack and a shot glass out of the freezer, I fill it to the brim and throw it back, hissing in a breath.

My eyes catch sight of the flowers sitting in the center of the kitchen table.

They mock me.

I let Kashton fuck me, and he sends me flowers? What the fuck is up with that?

I've never received flowers in my life. What do I do with them?

You water them so they can grow.

I want to vomit at the ironic metaphor.

Why would I want to water them? They're just going to die. Like everything else in this world. You're just prolonging the inevitable.

Grabbing the bottle, I leave the shot glass and stomp my way to my bathroom. I need to break some shit, but first I have to get ready.

I spend the next couple of hours shaving my entire body, doing my skin care routine, hair, and makeup, as if I'm planning on going out to the bar to take a man home to fuck.

You've got to give them something to stare at. While their hands are on your ass and their eyes are on your tits, your finger should be on the trigger. They'll never see it coming.

Once ready, I return to the kitchen, grab another two bottles of liquor, and make my way down to my basement.

I unlock the door and descend the stairs, my heels clapping on the hardwood. Flipping on the light, I smile, looking around at all the stuff that was once beautiful before I destroyed it. I pick up the mallet that hangs on the wall that has **FUCK WITH ME** written in red lipstick on the handle.

Throwing back a drink of the liquor, I set the bottle down on the counter to my right and pull up something to listen to on my phone, and "Wonderland" by Natalia Kills fills the large space.

KASHTON

I wanted to see my girl tonight. After my talk with Adam and how upset she was after we had sex, I needed to see her.

Push her a little more.

Pulling up to her house, I enter like I've been here a million times.

No more hiding in her closet. No more letting her think she can get away. I'll chain her up before I allow her to leave me.

The sound of thundering bass hits my ears as I walk through her living room. I catch sight of the flowers I sent her on the kitchen table and smile.

Following the sound of the music, I make my way to the back of the house and come to a door that's cracked. Shoving it open, I hear

her scream over the music, and I rush down the stairs, only to slow when she comes into view.

"So Called Life" by Three Days Grace blares while she adjusts her grip on the handle of a mallet before she swings it at a glass vase that sits on a wooden table in the center of the room, letting out another scream.

I drop my bag at my feet, cross my arms over my chest, and lean against the wall, letting my eyes devour her. I've never seen anything more stunning.

My woman is such an angry angel. This is what my version of heaven would look like if I ever had the chance to see it—beautiful chaos.

She's got on a pair of black high heels that could be used as weapons on their own, each covered in little black spikes about an inch long with a silver chain that drapes across the back of the heels.

Her lean legs are wrapped in black fishnet tights, and her black leotard dips low in the front, showcasing her perfect tits. And she tops it all off with a matching studded belt that sits at an angle on her hips.

Her bleached-blond hair is down and in big curls, and she's got a lot of makeup layered on her face, like she does when she meets men at the biker bar.

She looks like the best fucking wet dream I could ever have. The song comes to an end, and I speak before the next one begins. "Bad night?"

She spins around, her hair slapping her in the face. She slides one high heel out and drops the mallet to her side, resting the tip on the floor. "What in the fuck are you doing here?" Her wide green eyes meet mine as the song changes to "Crazy House" by Princess Nokia.

"Came to see you."

"How do you know where I live?" Throwing her head back, she gives a manic laugh at her own question. "Don't even bother answering that."

I wasn't going to.

Picking up the mallet, she holds it out in front of her, pointing to the stairs. "Leave."

"I think I'll stay," I inform her, my lips twitching to keep from smiling at her.

She huffs, eyes dropping to the bag at my feet before they meet mine again. "When will this end?"

"When I die," I respond truthfully.

Her eyes narrow for a brief second. "I won't miss this time."

I hold my arms out wide. "Go ahead. Give it a second try." She doesn't have a gun on her at the moment, otherwise I know she would do it. That mallet can do some damage, though.

Huffing, she growls, "Goddammit, Kash." Pinching the bridge of her nose, she adds, "There has to be something. Name it." Her hand falls, and she peers at me. "What can I do to get you to go away?"

"Nothing."

Rolling her eyes, she runs a hand through her hair, pushing it off her face. Then she struts over to me. When she leans in, I think she's going to kiss me. Instead, she grabs the bottle of Jack Daniel's from behind me.

Stepping away from me, she wraps her red-painted lips around the bottle and tosses it back. I watch her throat work as she swallows the liquor. Some drips from her red-painted lips, falling down her neck and between her breasts.

I'm so fucking hard, imagining my cock being the reason she drools all over herself.

"How much have you had to drink?" I look around, noticing the other empty bottles lying around. Who knows how old they are. My eyes go back to her.

Taking a few more steps backward, she pulls the bottle from her lips. Gasping, she rubs her chin before dropping the bottle to her side. "You"—she points the bottle at me—"are a problem."

"I take that as a compliment." I smirk at her.

Spinning around, she gives me her back, and my eyes fall to her perfectly round ass covered in her fishnet tights. The leotard doesn't cover much more than a thong does, and I imagine ripping it off her.

"Kash," she growls.

"Angel," I say.

"Fuck me." Her tone is clearly pissed, but the invitation is there.

"That's my plan."

Turning back to face me, she bares her teeth, tosses up the bottle, and swings the mallet at it. Glass shatters and what liquor was left splatters across the room, getting in her hair and on her clothes.

I reach down, grab my bag, and walk over to her, deciding now is a good time to show her there are other ways to let out aggression.

"What are you really doing here, Kash?" she demands. "You here to fuck? You want sex? Go get it from a whore. I'm sure you've got several lined up."

I ignore her. "I came to play with you." I toss my bag onto the wooden table. I rip the mallet from her hand and toss it on there too. "Turn around," I order, getting a better look at her.

She's got her bottle-green eyes lined with thick black liner on the top and bottom. It makes them look bigger.

Her hard eyes hold mine. I let her have the inner battle with herself—should she fight me, make me force her, or should she just give in?

I smile when she turns around. I unzip my bag and grab what I need, then brush her long curls off her back and out of my way to rest over her shoulder. "Hands behind your back."

She crosses them at the wrists, and I slide the black leather belt around her upper arms and tighten it in place. Then I place another shorter one around her forearms before I turn her to face me.

She lifts her chin. "What's the matter, Kashton? Afraid I'm going to hurt you?" Her pretty green eyes glance around the basement before they find mine again. "I don't have any sedatives on me at the moment. Feel free to search me if you want."

I reach up and run my thumb over her red-painted lips. "You can do whatever you want to me, angel," I tell her honestly.

She swallows at my confession. I've waited my whole life for this woman—the one I'd die for. The one who makes it all worth it.

"Make Me (Cry)" by Noah Cyrus and Labrinth fills the room, and I drop my hand, picking up a broken piece of glass stuck to her alcohol-covered chest. "You should pick a new hobby. One less…hazar-

dous. May I suggest knitting? At the very least, you should wear face protection."

She graces me with a white-toothed smile. It's condescending and abso-fucking-lutely adorable. "I've bled before, Kash, and I'm still alive." Then she leans forward, sticks out her tongue, and slowly licks the whiskey off the thick piece of glass that I hold between my fingers…all while her eyes hold mine.

I didn't think my dick could get any harder, but she's just proved me wrong. Although I know it's a front. She's fucking with me. After I'm done with her tonight, she'll be on her knees in the bathroom hating herself for letting me fuck her.

If I was a good man, I would leave her alone. But I'm not and I won't. I can help her. Show her it's okay to be mine.

I also never walk away from a challenge.

"Is that what you want, Eve? Want me to make you bleed?" I ask, placing the tip of the sharp glass to her racing pulse.

She arches her neck, giving me easier access to her throat. "If that's what gets you off." She bats her long fake lashes. "We all need something to make us feel alive."

I drop my hand, and she lowers her head to meet my stare. Her eyes hold so many secrets. I wish I could force them from her lips. My hand drops to my side, and I run the tip of the glass up her thigh, hooking it into her fishnet tights, making sure I don't cut her while I let the glass slice through the thin material.

Her eyes soften and her breathing picks up, no doubt at the realization of how easily I could cut her if I choose to.

I tilt my head to the side. "You like pain, angel?"

"You want to hurt me, Kash?" Another challenge.

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TWENTY



EVERETT

What in the fuck is he doing here, and why the fuck am I indulging him? He scared the shit out of me when I saw him standing down here. But I'm not surprised. I knew he wouldn't go away.

I don't care if I look crazy, but I refuse to back down or appear weak. Once they smell your fear, they feast on it. Use it against you. I'm a pro at calling someone's bluff. But I can't deny I'm wet for him.

My shoulders are burning because of how he's got my arms secured behind my back. He showed up tonight for a reason—to prove he has the upper hand. That I'm just another bitch he's going to use however he wants until the next one comes along.

"What if I said yes?"

Lifting my chin, I say, "Try your best."

Pushing his body flush with mine, he gently brushes my hair off my chest so it falls down my back before his hands slide into it. His tatted fingers tighten in my curled strands, and I hiss in a breath when it makes my scalp sting.

He yanks my head back, making my lips part as he stares down at me. My heart is hammering, my pussy throbbing.

He uses his hands in my hair to tilt my head to the side before he lowers his face to my neck. He licks along my racing pulse, and my heavy eyes fall closed.

"You taste amazing, Eve," he whispers, placing featherlight kisses along my neck.

My legs threaten to buckle. "Kash," I breathe, shuffling in my heels.

He's going to fuck me, and I'm going to hate myself tomorrow for letting him. I tell myself that alcohol can help. I'll just drink until I pass out.

Releasing my hair, his hands drop to my ass, and he digs his fingers into it as he lifts me off my heels. He sets me down on the table, and pieces of glass cut into my skin while I sit in a puddle of alcohol. The pain feels good.

I part my legs for him, and he steps between them. He rips my leotard down the center to expose my chest. I'm not wearing a bra. I didn't plan on seeing anyone tonight. It's why I didn't put any type of pants on.

"Tell me to stop, Eve," he orders.

I can't make myself say the words, so I moan instead, leaning into him.

He chuckles as his hands massage my breasts. "You want me to fuck you, you're going to have to beg me for it."

Fuck. Of course he's going to make me do that. "Please."

"Please what, angel?"

I swallow nervously and whisper, "Please fuck me."

"You're so timid." He drops his gaze to my heaving chest. "What happened to the feisty woman who likes a challenge, huh?"

He's playing with me, and I hate losing.

Leaning forward, I hold his stare. "Please fuck me. Any way you want, Kash. I'm your whore to play with."

He yanks me off the table, and I wobble in my heels on the shards of broken glass that cover the floor. His hands drop to my hips, and he undoes my belt before he drapes it around his neck. Then he spins me around so he's behind me.

I drop my head to look at my legs when I feel him wrapping my belt around my thighs, but it's inside out. "What are you doing?" I ask breathlessly.

"Fucking you however I want," he answers, pulling it tight, forcing me to close my legs. He buckles it in place, and I hiss in a breath as I feel the spikes dig into my skin.

He wants to hurt me, cause me pain because he knows I enjoy it.

Grabbing a handful of my hair, he bends me over the side of the table, pushing my ass out, and his hand moves my leotard to the side.

My breath gets caught and I try to pull my legs apart when I feel his cock pushing its way into my soaked pussy.

"Fuck, you're wet, angel."

I'm having a hard time catching my breath due to the position I'm in. His pierced cock stretches my cunt, and I cry out. All I want to do is spread my legs for him, let him fuck me deep, but it's impossible.

"That's it, Eve. Scream for me while I fuck you."

He begins to move, his hips thrusting hard and quick, forcing the front of my legs to hit the side of the table, which shoves the spikes farther into my thighs. My stomach and chest are on the table, my arms still tied behind my back. I can't move. All I can do is take it, and my body loves it.

"Fuck," I moan. "Kashton…" My heavy eyes fall shut.

He lets go of my hair, and one hand slaps my ass while the other grips my hip.

"Talk to me, angel." His voice is calm. He's not nearly as worked up as I am. "What do you need?" He slows, and I groan in desperation. His hand moves from my hip to my back, and he holds me down to the alcohol-covered wooden table.

"More," I gasp, trying to bounce up and down in my heels. "I need more…"

Pulling out, he slams forward, and I whimper when my body digs into the edge. He does it again. And again. Each thrust is harder than the last. "Kash—" I suck in a ragged breath, trying to get control of my body, but I'm losing. He's getting exactly what he came here for—to use me.

"I can feel your body tensing. It's okay, angel. Let it go. Come for me." He urges me. "Show me how much you enjoy it."

My legs tingle from lack of blood flow and my thighs are screaming from the spikes on my belt. It feels so good. My eyes grow heavy, and I'm having trouble breathing.

Fuck him for making it feel good. And fuck me for letting him have it. My body stiffens as my pussy clenches down on him when I come all over his dick just like he wanted.

"Good girl, angel." He slows his movements, and I imagine he's looking down at his dick sliding in and out of my pussy. "My cock is covered in your cum."

I want to cry. I'm not sure if it's from coming, confusion, or embarrassment.

He pulls out, and I slump against the table, taking a second to catch my breath. Then I feel him undoing the belt around my upper arms, followed by the one around my forearms.

They fall to my sides while he undoes the one around my legs. I moan, silently begging him to fuck me more. Throw me onto the glass-covered table, shove my knees to my chest, and fuck my soaked pussy.

Instead, he grips my hair, and I cry out when he yanks me off the table and spins me around to face him. I trip off the side of my heel, but he catches me before I fall on my face.

The blood rushes back to my arms and down my legs, making all my limbs tingle, rendering them useless for the moment. They're just heavy weight, and I'm having a hard time remaining upright.

His eyes are on mine as his free hand falls between my shaking thighs and he runs his fingers over my swollen pussy. I rock my hips back and forth, riding his hand, wanting more than the quickie he just gave me. Pulling his hand back, he brings his fingers to his mouth, parts his lips, and licks them clean.

Heat rushes over my already hot skin, and I glance down at his still hard dick. It's covered in my cum. I lick my lips, and he chuckles.

Gripping my hair, he pulls my head back and leans in, whispering against my lips. "Next time, angel." With that, he lets go, grabs his bag, then makes his way up the stairs, slamming the door shut.

I raise my trembling hands and run them through my wet and matted hair.

What the fuck just happened? He got me off and then just…left? He didn't even come. Did he? No. I would have known that. Did he not enjoy it?

Was this him proving to me that I liked it, but he didn't?

This is the opposite of being used. Usually, they fuck you to get what *they* want. Their happy ending. He just wanted me to like it to

prove a point.

That's how they all are.

It's all about fucking with your mind. Leaving you confused and dependent on them.

My mouth starts to water, and I run up the stairs, knowing I'm going to get sick.

KASHTON

It's been two days since I took Ellington to her appointment. After I got her ice cream, I drove her home and dropped her off. Sin wasn't there yet, and I hated to leave her alone. She was obviously still upset, but she assured me she'd be fine.

I didn't want to make her uncomfortable by hanging around if she didn't want me there.

I've wanted to text Sin to see if she's okay, but I've left him alone. He let me do something for his wife, and I'll take that as a win.

But I wish he'd call me. Hell, I'd settle for a text at this point.

Is this what going through a breakup feels like? Where you hang out every day, always texting and calling…then *bam,* you no longer exist to them? I've never been in any sort of meaningful relationship. I had a chosen, but we were both forced into that. She hated me, and I tolerated her. And then, like everything else in my life, I was forced to make a decision. I chose to kill her. Save her from a much worse fate.

Sin and I had gotten just as close as I am to Saint and Haidyn. It's my fault. I get attached quickly. I'm afraid of being alone, and my brothers have both moved on. So I clung to Sin. I know he's married too, but it's different. Maybe because he hasn't betrayed me like my brothers. Instead, I'm the one who's hurt him.

Now that Haidyn and Saint have married, everything feels…off, and I'm lonely.

So like any other night, I find myself walking into Blackout. Spotting a few guys from Barrington, I sit down at their table to shoot the shit. Why not? Haidyn is busy with Charlotte, and Saint's with Ashtyn. They've both got someone, and what was once the three of us is now the four of them.

I've been replaced. Forgotten.

I plan on going to the cemetery afterward to see my girl. The flowers were a gift, but my visit to her house the other night was a warning. I'm not going to walk away. She'll have to kill me.

I stayed away from her yesterday. On purpose. I wanted to give her some time to come to terms with the fact we had sex again and that we're going to continue doing it.

There won't be an inch of her skin that I won't touch. She will belong to me in every way a woman can belong to a Lord. That includes being my Lady.

But I've got to take my time. She knows I'm following her every move. She's questioning whether I'm watching her or not. And when I'm going to collect what she owes me. I wasn't lying when I said the guys want answers. If they find out she's connected to Isabella, things could get messy. The guys won't hesitate to string her up, strip her naked, and wait for the wolves to attack. A confessional. Wouldn't that be ironic? That's what she does for the Lords. Something tells me they'd be willing to let her be the one strapped to the altar, no problem.

But I want her. Since the moment I saw her, this is what I've wanted. Does she owe me for saving her that night six years ago? No. But if that's what gets me the girl, then I'll take it. After my talk with Adam, I know that Eve finds herself in sticky situations all the time.

I don't mind putting a collar on her and throwing her into a cell in the basement. But I want to see who she goes to first. Who tries to save her from me. There's always a Lord behind the show. A puppet master, if you will. She might be someone else's puppet, but she'll be my whore.

I know that she's connected to Bill. Do I believe they're blood related? No. But there is definitely something there that needs to be answered. Adam only knew enough to make me have more questions. And at this point, I don't even trust what he told me.

I give Sin a week before he comes to me demanding answers, wanting to know what I've found out from her.

A bleached blonde gets my attention, walking through the crowd, headed toward the bar. You can't miss her under the flashing lights.

It's my lucky night. "One sec," I tell the guys, getting up and making my way across the dance floor to the main bar while "Birthday Cake" by Rihanna blasts through the club.

Coming up behind her, my eyes drop to her red heels and slowly run up her black leggings. They look to be leather and reveal every curve of her lean legs up and over her round ass. Fuck, I want my cock inside it. They sit high on her thin waist, and she wears a white crop top that shows a sliver of her back. Her hair is up in a high ponytail, showing off her delicate neck. I step up to the bar beside her and remove my wallet from my back pocket.

"Her tab is on me tonight," I inform the bartender, sliding my card to him.

She glances at me and rolls her pretty eyes. They light up under the neon lights. "I don't need your money, Kash." She reaches out and shoves my card across the bar, and it falls off the edge at my feet.

Bending down to pick it up, I chuckle. "Eve—"

She huffs, turning to face me, placing her hand on her hip. "Starting to think you're obsessed with me."

I smirk. "Oh, I am." There is no denying her.

Stepping into me, her hand touches my chest as she tilts her head to the side. "Want to throw me onto the bar and fuck me right here?"

Her words catch me off guard. She was sick to her stomach after I fucked her at the run-down motel. I didn't stick around the other night in her basement to see how she reacted once she came down, but if I had to guess, I'd say it was no different.

Now she's willing to let me fuck her in front of an audience? She's either trying to throw me off or she's starting to come around to being my whore. I place my hand on her lower back, pulling her into me.

That grants me a tight smile. "Honestly," I begin, and her smile falters, like she's wondering what I'm about to say. "I'd never fuck you in front of others." Her eyes search mine, but she'll find no lie. "I won't be sharing what's mine."

"Yours?" Her brows rise and she gives a rough laugh. "I don't belong to you, Kashton." She pushes me away and I allow it.

"It was my cum that leaked from your cunt, angel," I remind her. "You don't get any more *mine* than that."

She looks away from me, swallowing. I'm going to push her past her limits. She's going to learn there's nothing to be ashamed of. Even if I have to make her uncomfortable.

Turning, she goes to walk away, but I grab her hand, yanking her back to me. Her green eyes glance up at me. "I need a second," she says, licking her lips.

The tenderness in her words makes me pause. I can only imagine what she's been through. I know what Saint and Haidyn and I went through when Isabella trained us. The thought of what Eve must have endured at Dollhouse makes my chest tighten.

I reach up and cup her cheek, but she pulls away. This time I don't stop her when she walks toward the hallway that leads to the restrooms.

I return to my seat. The moment I sit down, the guys start laughing. "What's so funny?" I ask, wondering what I missed. Picking up my beer, I go to take a sip when Grant answers.

"Dude, please tell me you're not chasing that."

I pause, the drink against my lips. "What?" I ask, giving him a chance to rephrase what he just said before he pisses me off.

"Everett," he announces, and the sound of her name on his lips makes my hand tighten on the cold bottle. "She's a fucking whore."

The friend sitting next to him, Porter, slaps his shoulder. "Whores get paid, man. She's free."

"Who cares who she's slept with?" Spencer says. "She's useless."

"What the fuck does that mean?" I slam the bottle down onto the table so hard that the beer foams over the top and onto my hand.

"He's joking." Porter laughs it off. "If you've got a wife, she's the perfect kind of fuck on the side."

I swing the beer bottle, meaning to hit him in the side of the head, but it's slick from the alcohol, so I end up hitting the side of his face instead, knocking him back.

Spencer jumps out of the booth, grabs my shirt, and yanks me from my seat. He goes to hit me in the face, but I'm faster and ram my beer-covered fist into his nose.

Out of the corner of my eye, I see Grant jump as he leaps onto my back. He slams me into the table. My arm knocks over a glass of beer. I grab a hold of it, spin around, and knock him on the side of the head with it.

A hand touches me, and I turn around, ready to swing, only to see Colt, Finn, Alex, and Jenks standing there. They break up fights, but they weren't going to touch me.

"The fuck?" Tyson barks, heading toward me. The bartender caught it and called up to him. Fights happen all the time here. They're always on the lookout. "Kashton," Tyson growls, looking over at the three men bleeding and rolling around on the floor. "Get them the fuck out of here," he barks at his minions.

"Where is she?" I snap, glancing around the club, trying to get my eyes to focus. The flashing lights make it hard to see.

"Who?" Tyson grabs my arm, but I yank it from his hold and storm toward the hallway that leads to the bathroom. "Kash, don't—"

I shove open the women's restroom door, and two girls standing at the counter turn and scream when they see me rush in.

"What the fuck are you doing?" Tyson growls, entering behind me.

A quick look tells me all the stall doors are open; she's not in here. I spin around and leave as quickly as I entered.

"What in the fuck are you doing, Kash?" Tyson demands, running up behind me. "Do the guys know you're here?"

I snort at his question. As if I need a fucking babysitter. Making my way to the back door, I walk outside and scan the parking lot for her car, but I don't see it. She bailed. I wasn't going to leave without her after that, but I can't stay here now.

"Kash?" I hear Tyson call out. The bastard is still following me.

"I'm leaving," I throw over my shoulder, walking up to my bike.

My adrenaline is running, my breathing erratic. Fuck, the fact that they even know her name pisses me off. How do they know her? Have they paid to fuck her? Did they rape her? I should have fucking stabbed them to death right there and then.

"Kash, wait—"

Straddling my Ninja H2R, I turn it on, rev the engine, and squeal the back tire as I exit the parking lot. I need some fresh air.

I come to a stoplight and pull out my cell, connecting it to my earbuds, and "Wasteland" by 10 Years begins to play. When the light turns green, I take off, racing to get onto the highway.

The cool night air hits my face, and I weave in and out of the light traffic, not caring how fast I'm going. My cell ringing pauses the song a few times, and I know it's my brothers. Tyson is the father we all deserved to have, but right now, he's tattling on me. Calling Haidyn and Saint to fill them in on what I did.

I adjust myself, sitting back on the bike, slow and shift into first gear, then open up the throttle. I pop a wheelie in the fast lane before slamming it down and taking the next exit. I take a quick look at the intersection coming up, ensuring no one is there, and run the red light, taking a right and speeding down the road.

A few minutes later, I'm taking curves faster than I should be down a two-lane road when I see headlights coming up fast behind me.

They flash a few times, but I ignore them. If it's a cop, I'm prepared to outrun him. Not because I'm afraid of them but because I'm not in the mood to put up with one tonight. I'm still on edge and need to fight. I'd rather run from a cop than beat the shit out of one. That will definitely piss off the guys.

After about a mile, they finally pass me and slam on their brakes.

Fuck.

I yank on my front brake so hard that it brings my rear end up while the nose goes down into a stoppie position. I place both boots on the ground as the back tire slams onto the road.

The car pulls off the two-lane road onto a gravel one and I decide to follow. Coming to a stop, I slam down my kickstand and yank my earbuds out, strolling toward the car. "What the fuck?" I shout. My blood was already pumping, but now I'm in the mood to finish what I wanted to do to those guys at Blackout. I fist my blood-covered knuckles.

The driver's side door opens suicide style, and a man in a black hoodie steps out.

"You have a fucking problem?" The words I'm about to say next trail off when I look into a set of green eyes. "Adam?" I demand. "Fuck, man. If you needed something, you could have called me." He knows I have his number, since I stole it from Eve's phone. He's also in a different car than when I saw him at his house.

His eyes fall to my bike before they glance back to mine. "You have a minute?"

"Yeah." I nod, knowing this can't be good. "What do you need?"

"Your cell." He reaches out his hand, and I remove it from my pocket and hand it to him.

He pitches it off the side of the gravel road, and I watch it disappear into the woods.

Okay.

"Get in," he orders, giving me his back, and I follow and fall into the passenger seat, hearing "Call Me" by Shinedown softly playing from his speakers.

"You know I have a tracker in my neck, right?" The guys are no doubt looking at my location since Tyson called them.

"I just need a few minutes." He pulls out onto the two-lane road and then tosses a folder into my lap.

"Were you able to find Everett's videos from Dollhouse?" I ask, my heart now racing at what's in here. I open it up to find a police report. I frown. That wasn't what I expected. "How the fuck did you get this?" I ask, but I already know. He told us that he's been working on the inside. He's got reach within the police. Not like we need it, but he sees the paperwork behind the cases.

"She's in trouble." He ignores my question.

My eyes shoot to his. "What kind of trouble?"

"She called the police…"

"Yeah, over the body she found in the cemetery. The detective Ty has on payroll told us." I fill him in. "He also informed us that she was cleared."

He sighs. "It's bigger than that. They are going to make sure she goes down for the murders."

I laugh. "They think she committed all seven murders? That's ridiculous." I've seen her kill three men, but seven women? Some-

thing tells me that it wasn't my girl.

"They've got her DNA." He glances at me quickly before looking back at the road.

The detective didn't mention that to us. "Well, maybe she touched the body—"

"Jesus. Does anyone fucking listen?" he barks out, slamming his palm on his steering wheel. "I tried to tell her—"

"Wait. When?" He doesn't answer, and I grind my teeth. "Did you know this the other night when we spoke at your house?"

He ignores that question too. "Her life is on the line right now, and she's not taking it seriously. I thought you would."

"I am," I bark, dropping my eyes to the report.

"Good. I told her to run—"

"Not happening," I interrupt him. I've been looking for her for too long to let her go now. But now I understand why he was adamant that she leave town the other night on the phone.

He tightens his grip on the steering wheel. "Then you'll have to hide her at Carnage."

"Done," I say easily.

He gives a soft laugh. "She's not going to go willingly."

"You say that like it'll be a problem." I scan the paperwork that gives details of her explaining how she found the body. It also states that she had an attorney present—William Marks. A.k.a. Bill. "How long do I have?" I'll have to come up with a plan.

"I'd say three weeks. A month at most. They want to wrap it up pretty quickly. But they need to get everything set up first. When they come to arrest her, there will be nothing left to dispute."

I nod. "I'll be ready." But as much as I'd love to make her my pet at Carnage, I add, "I could go to Tyson's detective. Tell him—"

"Don't trust him." He shakes his head. "She either has you or no one."

Me. She has me.

"What about your boss? The detective on the plane?"

He sighs heavily before he answers. "This isn't his department."

How is this not his department? I'm not sure what the fuck he means by that, but I understand it's a dead end. He's no help.

"She probably shouldn't be going out in public to party if she's being set up," I mumble to myself. She can get drunk at home.

"What do you mean?" he asks, and I consider ignoring him like he does some of my questions, but this is about Eve.

"I just saw her at Blackout."

He frowns. "When?"

"Tonight." I glance at his clock lighting up on his dash. "About twenty minutes ago. I just came from there."

"Are you sure?"

I grind my teeth. "Yes. I spoke to her." Fisting my busted knuckles, I add, "Some guys were talking shit about Eve. After I beat the fuck out of them, I looked for her. Was going to drag her ass out of there, but she had already left."

He shifts in his seat, bringing the car to a stop, and I see that he's parked back by my bike. I glance over at him, and he's staring out the windshield as if he can't look at me.

"Why are you helping her?" He said they'd had sex, but is it more than that? Does he love her? Or is he just wanting her to lie low for now so she can keep working for him? Either way, it has to be for his benefit.

Adam swallows before glancing at me. His eyes are void of any emotion when he speaks. "I know what it feels like to be framed when you're innocent. I had someone help me. And I can only do so much. After our talk the other night, I know you're that someone for her." With that, he looks back out the windshield, and I know it's all I'm going to get.

I shut the folder and set it on his lap. When I close the passenger door, he pulls out, and his taillights disappear down the curvy two-lane road.

My phone lights up as Haidyn calls me, helping me spot it in the dark night. I pick it up out of the bushes, ignore the call, and pull up my Spotify. "Follow You Home" by Nickelback fills my ears as I try to figure out how I'm going to make the pretty blonde become my prisoner. Because I know she will not come to Carnage willingly. She's too independent for that.

I'll have to force my angel to live in hell.

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TWENTY-ONE



KASHTON

I return to Carnage a couple of hours later. The ride did nothing but fuck me up more. The way the men talked about Eve and then the conversation I had with Adam…it's giving me a headache.

At least Saint and Haidyn quit blowing up my phone.

I need to talk to them in person. Fill them in on what's going on. I can't just bring her here without giving them a heads-up. Especially if Ashtyn and Eve have a past. Adam said they weren't friends, but will Ashtyn recognize her? If so, how will that go down? I haven't been a fan of Ashtyn since she shot my brother. We put too much trust in her, thought she was one of us, and she betrayed Saint. I see that as a betrayal toward all of us. My brother loves her, and I respect that, but I don't have to accept her.

The moment the elevator door slides open in the basement, "Hallelujah" by No Resolve hits my ears, informing me that Haidyn is in a mood.

A quick look at my watch tells me it's a quarter till four in the morning. He's down here later than usual. Pushing the plastic strip curtains out of the way, I come face-to-face with Saint.

"Good luck." He nods to me, walking by.

"What's going on?" I ask, turning to face him.

"He's been down here for two hours with that song on repeat." Then Saint disappears, walking toward the elevator.

I continue through the basement and pass the pits, headed to the hallway where the cells are. I come up to the fourth on the right and see the door open.

The song blares from the concrete room. My brother's bloody white T-shirt is wadded up on the floor while he stands in the center with a lit cigarette between his lips. Hudson lies on the floor, curled up in a ball, soaking wet with blood covering his trembling, naked body.

"Haidyn?" I call out.

Reaching up, he removes the cigarette and turns to look at me. He appears calm as can be, and that kind of scares me a little. I'm not sure why. I've seen my brothers throw some temper tantrums and fuck shit up. But this is…different. He arches a brow at me.

"Everything okay?" I shout over the music.

Bringing the cigarette back to his lips, he takes in a drag, the end glowing in the darkly lit room. Once done, he flicks it down onto Hudson. He whimpers when it lands on his neck, and his hands flail to push it off. The man has no eyes. Haidyn ripped them out after he bragged that he watched videos of Haidyn fucking Charlotte. I would have done the same.

"Yeah, why?" he asks as the song comes to an end.

"Just wondering." I glance at my Hublot. "It's late. Or early…"

"We're having a good day, aren't we, Hudson?" He kicks the bastard in the stomach, and he rolls away, cradling his arms around himself in a protective posture.

The song starts once again, and Haidyn removes the pack of cigarettes from his jeans, lighting up another one.

"Haidyn?"

I spin around to see a sleepy-looking Charlotte standing outside the cell in the hallway, wearing a T-shirt, cotton shorts, and a pair of fuzzy pink slippers, her heavy eyes on her husband.

"Hey, doll face." He exits the cell and leans down, kissing her.

She pulls away, her eyes now showing concern as they search his. "Come back to bed."

"I'll be right there."

Taking his bloody hand, she gives him a small smile. "I want you to come with me now." Her eyes go from Hudson to him. "This can wait until later."

"Charlotte—"

"I want you," she interrupts him.

After a second, he kisses her forehead. “Head upstairs. I’ll be right behind you.” She goes to argue when he says, “Get undressed and crawl into bed for me.”

With one last look at Hudson, she turns and disappears down the hallway, headed back to the elevator and up to their room.

Haidyn walks into the cell, turns off the music, and tells Hudson, “This isn’t your lucky day. I’ll be back to play with you after I fuck my wife.”

Hudson rolls over, giving us his back, and I follow Haidyn out of the cell as he closes the door and locks the bastard inside. “Want to talk about it?” I ask. Our talk about Eve will have to wait until another day. Adam said I had a few weeks. That gives me plenty of time to come up with a plan and then fill the guys in on it.

Haidyn comes to a stop, runs a bloody hand through his hair, and sighs. “While I was at Dollhouse, I hallucinated.”

I nod, remembering him telling the guys that they might have side effects from the founders’ enhancement.

“Are you still having side effects?” It’s only been a few weeks, but I wonder if that’s something he’ll have forever.

He shakes his head. “No. Yes…” Trailing off, he looks over at the cell and then back at me. “I got a call from Ryat around midnight. He hallucinated and needed someone to talk to.”

I cross my arms over my chest. “Is he okay?”

“As well as a man who sees his wife and children getting tortured and murdered in front of him can be. It feels so real. No matter how much you tell yourself it’s a hallucination.” He widens his stance and goes on. “After his call, I went back to sleep, and well…”

“Had a nightmare?” I guess when he trails off.

He doesn’t respond, and I know that his call with Ryat brought Haidyn’s worst fear to life for him.

“She’s safe, man,” I assure him. I never asked him what he saw happening to Charlotte when he was at Dollhouse. I didn’t need to.

“For now,” he growls. “But that doesn’t change what that motherfucker was going to do to her.”

I slap his bare shoulder. “Go upstairs and fuck your wife. He’ll still be down here when you’re done.” The bastard isn’t going anywhere.

He can't see, for fuck's sake. Devin made him a special mask for his face that covers the holes where his eyes once were. Haidyn didn't want him to die from an infection—too easy, he said. No. He wants his death to be slow and dragged out over years. But at this rate, I'm not sure he'll make it another week.

Haidyn turns to walk away but stops and faces me once more. "Have you spoken to Sin?"

I shake my head.

"Give him a call."

If it was only that easy. I would just show up at his house again, but I don't want to upset Ellington. She's been through enough, and she's pregnant. I don't want to put any more stress on her. Especially after how much she cried when I took her to that appointment. "He wants nothing to do with me."

Haidyn moves again, and I follow him down the hall and into the open room where the pits are. He goes over to the sink in the corner and turns on the faucet before pouring soap into his hands. "Sin seemed pretty upset at Blackout the other day when Tyson called that meeting." As he begins to wash his bloody arms, the remnants of his rage splash into the sink. "If Ryat's having hallucinations, I can guarantee Sin is too." Rinsing off all the suds, he turns off the water and grabs some towels before turning to face me. "And no matter how mad he is at you, I promise…he could use a friend." With that, he tosses the wadded-up paper towels and walks away, headed to the elevator to go upstairs to shower and fuck his wife.

I have no doubt that afterward, he'll be right back down here torturing Hudson with that damn song on repeat.

I pull my cell out and go to Sin's contact. I type out a message but then delete it. It's four in the morning. My meeting with Adam replays in my mind, and I debate about what to do. I can't just ask Eve about her past. She's not the type of woman to open up about her life. Not to someone like me anyway.

But sex? You can tell a lot about someone by how they like to fuck. Or be fucked. In our world, you're either the Dom or the sub, and I promise you, 99.9 percent of the time, the woman is the sub. And if Eve's going to be someone's toy, she'll be mine.

I run up to my room, change my T-shirt, grab a hat, and pack a bag. I'm going to go see my girl for the second time tonight.

EVERETT

Sixteen years old

The door to my bedroom swings open with a bang, and I quickly sit up in bed.

"Get up," my father orders.

Swallowing, I push the covers off and get to my feet. I want to ask where I'm going, but I already know. I've been going to the same appointment for the past couple of months.

They say I'm a woman, and a woman has responsibilities. Whatever that means.

I slide on my shoes and follow him out of my room. My feet are heavy, and my heart is broken. This life isn't worth living. Not like it was before, but I refuse to believe this is all I get. And if it is, then I might as well just end it.

We come to a stop at the end of the hall, and he opens the door for me. He always stays. It's to guarantee that I won't attack the doctor. I tried once. Managed to hit her in the face before my father grabbed me by the neck and slammed me against the wall. It knocked me unconscious. When I woke up, I was strapped to the table with him looking over me. Afterward, I was placed in a straitjacket for three days—punishment for my violent behavior.

"Hello, Eve." The woman smiles at me as if she's friendly. No one here is. "Come." She pats the table. "Lie down for me."

I know the routine, so I remove my shoes, sweatpants, and underwear, and then I crawl up on the table and lie down with my arms down by my sides, palms up. This position makes her feel safe. Who the fuck cares how I feel?

She straps my wrists to the table so I can't fight her, then does another over my upper chest and stomach. "Just a precaution," she tells me. "You won't feel any pain."

I swallow nervously, staring up at the ceiling. I'm always put in humiliating situations.

"Small poke," she informs me before the IV is inserted into my arm. Then a cold sensation runs through my veins, making me shiver.

It only takes seconds before my eyes get heavy and my body relaxes into the table. I hate the drugs. It feels like cheating. I'd rather kick and scream and make them fight me than succumb to drugs that pull me under and make me weak.

"I'm going to begin."

I run my hand through my hair. This is why I choose to drink myself into a coma every night. To quiet the demons that remind me every day of who I once was.

How I had no say or control over my own body. I'm not sure what it was she did. Everything was always foggy after that. I would wake up in my room, hurting and sore for a few days. My father would come in and force pain pills down my throat. Just when I thought I was feeling like myself, the time would come to visit her again. It was an endless cycle.

If I were lucky, my addiction would have killed me, but that's not possible.

Taking a swig, I gasp at the burn and rub away the alcohol that runs down my chin. I sit in the cemetery, like any other night, in front of the unmarked grave with a bottle of Jack in my hand. It's cold outside. More so than it's been.

I haven't fallen into a black hole, but I'm teetering on the edge. The thought of diving off headfirst sounds good. Maybe the drop will kill me. But I'm never that lucky in life. Why would I be in a fictional scenario?

Tipping the bottle back again, I down what's left of it and toss it aside.

I lie down on the uneven ground and close my heavy eyelids. I just want to sleep my life away. It'll help pass the time.

The sound of branches has me jolting up. I slam my back into the unmarked headstone when I see someone step into the dim cemetery lighting.

"Goddammit, Kash," I hiss when he makes himself comfortable against the same tree as the last time he followed me here.

"I went looking for you earlier."

Even though it's a cool night, he's wearing a T-shirt and jeans with a backward baseball hat. He drops a black duffel bag by his feet,

and it instantly makes me nervous. Mainly because I don't have mine with me this time. I've let my guard down and allowed him to fuck me twice now.

"Don't you have a life?"

"I'm looking at it," he answers, eyes on mine.

I glance away, ignoring the butterflies in my stomach when he comes around. Instead, I get to my feet, brush off my jeans, and slap my hands together to dust off the dirt. "Go home, Kash. Quit following me." I give him my back and start walking through the cemetery, deeper into the woods. I need to clear my head, and I don't have my bag on me, so I don't have any drugs to knock him out with.

"I'm bored."

His choice of words stops me. A cold chill makes the hairs on the back of my neck rise. Adam said he'd be bored. That I needed to be careful. Is this a coincidence?

The sound of the branches breaking under his boots swirls around the abandoned cemetery with the wind, but I stay grounded where I'm at. It gets louder before it comes to a stop, and I can feel the heat from his body on my back.

"I want to play with you," he declares, making me shiver. His hands tangle in my wind-blown hair as he gathers it from around my shoulders and holds it captive at the nape of my neck. "Will you play with me?"

I've never had any friends to *play* with.

Swallowing nervously, I keep my back to him and ask. My curiosity is getting the best of me. "What do you have in mind?"

"Hide-and-seek," he suggests, and it makes me smile.

I turn around, my hair sliding through his fingers, to glance up at him. "Hide-and-seek?" I arch a brow.

"What?"

I reach out, resting my hands on his hard chest. I can feel his heart beating slow and steady under the thin material of his shirt. "That… sounds a little below you. Childish."

The corner of his lips twitch. "I have an adult version in mind."

The smile drops off my face, and I whisper, "Meaning?"

"You hide, but when I find you, you belong to me."

My stomach twists, but wetness drips from my pussy. Belong to Kashton Landon Pierce? Never in my wildest dreams did I think that'd be an option. But as he stands here in the flesh, the thought doesn't sound so bad. Dropping my hands, I take a step back from him. "What are you going to do, brand me or something?" I give a rough laugh to try and play off the fact that my pulse is racing.

He runs his tatted knuckles over my collarbone before wrapping his hand around my throat. I don't fight him when he steps into me. "Once I find you, you'll be mine to play with for the next forty-eight hours."

Disappointment washes over me. I thought he wanted me forever, but I push it out of my mind. Maybe it's the bottle of liquor I downed making me crazy.

He's a man—the thing I hate most in the world. Since when do I want to let any man play with me? "I'm not interested in being your toy, Kashton," I decide to say.

His hand tightens a little more, but still not to the point of cutting off my air. "You can lie to yourself, angel, but you can't lie to me. I know what you want."

Oh really? "What is that?" This will be good.

"Someone to control you." He tilts his head to the side and my heart leaps in my chest. "You need a man to tell you what to do and how to do it."

My eyes narrow up at him because his words have my body humming with need. I've done so good for years, and he wrecks it within a week. I let him fuck me twice, and all of a sudden, my body wants him. It's like having a first hit and always chasing that same high.

He gives my throat a warning squeeze, as if to shut my mind up and place my attention back on him.

"I'll control when you eat and when you sleep." His hand pulls me closer to his body, and I have to arch to keep eye contact. I grip the soft material of his shirt as he continues. "How you're fucked and when you can come."

I swallow, and it grants me a devious smirk; he knows his words are getting to me.

"I bet you're wet right now just thinking about it."

I lick my lips.

"It's okay to want to be my whore, Eve." He frowns as if he can't fathom why I wouldn't want to be a toy for him. "There's nothing wrong with wanting to be used."

But there is. It's not who I've worked so hard to be. "Go to hell," I tell him.

His frown deepens at my rejection. "It'll just be me and you, Eve."

My knees threaten to buckle. Does he know about my past? That I've been used and passed around? I've never had someone who only wanted me to themselves. I've never been enough.

"No one watching. Just us."

What's one more time? We've already been here twice. Even though I hated myself afterward, it felt good in the moment.

"Okay." The single word slips from my trembling lips before my mind can even process what I said. My body wants him. Even now, it's leaning into him. I'm having an internal battle, wanting to slam a knife into his chest as badly as I want to fall to my knees to let him fuck my face however he likes.

My mind knows right from wrong, but my body…she's only ever known what he described.

"Okay what, angel? You're going to have to tell me what you want."

I glance up at him through my lashes, taking in a shaky breath. "I'll play hide-and-seek. If you find me, I'll be yours for forty-eight hours."

"*When* I find you," he corrects me.

"What do I get if you don't?" The thought of him not finding me is what scares me. What if this is a trick? What if he wants to see me hide and he doesn't even come after me? A way to set me up. To see how desperate I am.

He removes his hand from my neck, and I shiver from the coldness. Kashton chuckles at my question and glances at his watch. "You've got sixty seconds and then I'm coming to get you."

"I can't get very far in sixty seconds." I smile playfully. My adrenaline is already pumping. He was right the last time we stood here in

the cemetery, when he said saving me from the guy on the *Isabella* turned me on.

He was there when I needed him, and he's the first guy to never disappoint me. So far.

"This isn't about running, Eve. It's about hiding," he clarifies. "And you're wasting valuable time. Run and hide."

I turn around and rush through the cemetery, stepping on old graves and dodging unmarked headstones in my chunky boots. There's a mausoleum in the far back that I can hide inside of.

Looking over my shoulder, I no longer see him and smile at myself. The old concrete structure comes into view, and I take a sharp right. Walking up the two steps, I push open one of the heavy doors and step inside.

Pressing my back against it, I blink, giving my eyes a second to adjust while I catch my breath. Drinking and running are not two things I suggest be done together.

It has three stained-glass windows that run across the top of the opposite end, but they don't allow much light to filter in. Especially on a night like tonight. The lingering musty smell has me turning up my nose. You can hear the wind outside. It's so strong it makes the tree limbs rustle against the side of the building.

Pulling my cell out of my back pocket, I turn on the flashlight to see better.

It's on the smaller side. Built from nothing other than concrete. Both the right and left walls contain past Lords concealed in their tombs. Each side is stacked four high and three deep.

There's a small bench in the center of the room so you can sit and pay your respects or cry for the Lord who's been tucked away from the world they betrayed.

There are dirt and dead leaves all over the floor. My boots crunch them as I walk to the back. Two concrete pillars stand tall on either side, and two more Lords lie between them in concrete tomb-like structures.

They must be really important. Lords are allowed to be buried wherever they want—with their families. It's the ones who betray their oaths that are brought and dumped here in the cemetery be-

hind the cathedral. So for these Lords to have been placed in the mausoleum—a private burial within concrete—means they were very respected. Founders, maybe? Even those, I've known to be burned and tossed away with the wind if they've fucked over the society.

Stepping up on the platform, I run my hand over the dirt-covered crypts. There are no names carved that I can see, just bodies forgotten and left to rot.

This will be me one day. Once I'm gone, no one will come and visit me. I'm not mad about it. I've just learned it's the way of life. No one cares about you when you're alive or when you're dead.

It makes me think of the woman I found in the cemetery. Left to rot all alone after she spent God knows how long being tortured. Her family deserved to know what happened to her. She deserved to rest in peace.

The sound of the doors opening behind me is a reminder that I was supposed to be hiding. But deep down, I really want to be found. I've spent so many years alone; what's forty-eight hours belonging to someone? Even if it is just as a toy for him to play with.

The liquor has my blood warming, and the thought of Kashton fucking me has my pussy clenching. It's going to be a good night after all.

"Found you, angel. Know what that means?"

I hide my smile before I turn around to face him, shining my flashlight in order to see. He's standing in front of the closed doors, his tatted arms crossed over his chest and his duffel bag on the dirty concrete floor at his combat boots. His hat is still on and turned backward. His chiseled jaw and pretty blue eyes make me weak in the knees.

My flashlight makes him look evil and hauntingly devilish. Like a god coming to take me away. But I'm not going to heaven. None of us do in our world. It's a one-way trip to hell.

My eyes meet his when I say, "I'm all yours for the next forty-eight hours." I've tried to kill myself twice. I might as well live my life while I'm alive.

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TWENTY-TWO



KASHTON

She stands there staring at me. I'm not surprised my girl agreed to my terms. I knew she would.

Eve is guarded, but she's also not one to back down from a challenge. I'm going to push her to see how far she'll go. Sexually and mentally. I want to see just how much of her past still controls her life now.

Adam said she's on a revenge murdering spree because she hates men. What did they do to her that she hates them that much?

I've seen pictures and read reports of women who spent time at Dollhouse, but none of them survived. What did she do differently? I can tell she's strong. The woman is also hardheaded and infuriating, but she's going to be all mine. Even if I have to keep her locked in my basement until she comes around to the idea of being my wife.

It doesn't matter what happened in her past. I'm her future. I'm going to be her Lord. "Get undressed."

Her eyes widen and her cell begins to shake in her hand at that thought of being so vulnerable out here. "But—"

"I give you an order, you follow," I remind her. It's that easy.

She nods and places her cell on the crypt behind her, flashlight up. Slowly, she grips the hem of her shirt and pulls it up and over her head, her hair cascading down over her back in the process.

"Bra and underwear. I want to see what's mine," I inform her, and her hand pauses before she reaches around and unclasps her bra.

Then she's undoing her jeans, slipping out of her boots and pushing the denim down her perfectly toned legs. I'm salivating as I

imagine them wrapped around my head like that night in the cathedral office.

I pick up my duffel bag and walk across the mausoleum, closing the small space, and place the bag on top of the opposite crypt.

Once she's removed her socks and underwear, she turns to face me, her arms crossed over her chest. Her breathing has picked up, and her shoulders begin to shake. It's rather cold outside, but even more so in here.

A gust of wind howls and tree branches scratch the outside of the structure and windows, making her jump.

I bend down and gather her clothes, tossing them onto the tomb next to my bag. "Turn around," I command, and she quickly does so without arguing.

She rubs her hands up and down her arms, trying to warm herself as I unzip my bag and pull out a few things before putting her clothes in it.

"Place your hands behind your back."

She takes a shaky breath before doing as she's told. I tie her wrists together with a small leather belt and then grab my next item. I reach over the top of her head, gently setting the thick leather around her delicate neck, and move her hair to the side while I buckle the collar in place.

Placing my hands on her shoulders, I turn her to face me. Heavy green eyes glance up at me. I hook my finger into the collar's silver ring and pull her body flush with mine. My free hand comes up and brushes my knuckles along her cold cheek.

"Beautiful," I praise her. She's fucking stunning. From the moment I saw her on the *Isabella* that night, I wanted this woman to be mine in every way.

"Kash?" she whispers.

"Yeah, angel?" My thumb runs over her trembling lips.

She parts them for me and wraps them around my thumb. I push it into her mouth, groaning when she sucks on it. I'm so fucking hard for her. I knew I'd find her at the cemetery. My girl is so predictable.

Pulling it free, she says, "Play with me."

"On your knees," I command, stepping back from her.

Without hesitation, she drops to the cold concrete and tilts her head back, glancing up at me. She looks like a fallen angel. A beautiful woman kneeling on a dirty floor with her mouth open and hands tied. Her chest is pushed forward and her nipples are hard. She's sitting and waiting patiently to be used. My pretty angel has been trained to do so.

Instead of undoing my jeans, I just unzip them and pull my hard cock through the opening, freeing it from the constricting material.

She parts her lips, leaning forward, and I smile down at her, pushing her hair from her face. Then I slide two fingers into her waiting mouth. I push them to the back of her throat, and she gags. Pulling away, she breathes. "I'm sorry." Her eyes are wide with fear that she's disappointed me.

"No need to apologize, angel." I give her a soft smile. "We're going to work on that." Forty-eight uninterrupted hours of my girl on her knees has pre-cum dripping from my dick.

Eve nods. "Yes, sir."

I slap the side of her face gently and cut off her moan as I shove my fingers back into her mouth. "Open wide. Show me how much you want me to fuck your mouth, Eve."

Adjusting herself on her knees, she parts her lips wider and sticks her tongue out farther while her eyes remain looking up at me. They look as desperate as her mouth is needy.

I stick a third finger in, and she blinks rapidly. "Come on, Eve. I want to see that pretty face covered with drool and tears. You want to make me proud, don't you?"

"Mm-hmm," she mumbles as I rub them against the inside of her cheeks and the roof of her mouth, exploring, letting her get used to the invasion.

"Such a pretty pet on your knees. Tell me you want to be used." I remove them and slap her face again.

"Ple-ase," she begs desperately.

I slap her once more, her other cheek this time. She responds beautifully to pain. My plan isn't to hurt her. Just test how much she can take. And I can tell she likes it because she's not pulling away or even flinching when I do it. "Please what?"

"Please," she whines, shuffling on her knees. The poor thing can't sit still. "Please fuck me. I need you to fuck me." Her shoulders tremble. "I want you to play with me."

I smile, shoving my fingers back into her mouth, and she gags once more. I give her a *tsking* sound. "You're going to spend a lot of time with your mouth full for the next two days, angel."

She tries to nod, but she can't with my fingers down her throat. I pull them out, and drool drips down her chin, hitting her heaving chest. I grab a hold of my dick, and her eyes grow heavier at the thought of me fucking her face.

I slide into her mouth, and she wraps her lips around me, hungry and needy for it.

I grab a hold of her hair while I force my cock down her throat. "Goddamn," I hiss. It's so fucking tight. "Open wide," I tell her. "I'll do all the work, angel. Just kneel and let me fuck you."

Her pretty green eyes blink rapidly while she stares up at me. The sound of her gagging makes me smile. I'm going to train my girl to be such a good whore. She's going to love to kneel for me.

I slide out, loving the way her drool drips to her heaving chest. She closes her mouth to swallow, and I slap the side of her face once more. "Leave it open, Eve. You can close it when I tell you to. The more you drool, the easier it'll be."

Leaning forward, she opens again for me, and I widen my stance, placing a boot on either side of her thighs. My hand in her hair pulls her head back farther, and I watch her swallow my cock like it was made for her mouth. "You look so pretty on your knees for me, angel." I smile down at her, loving the tears that fill her green eyes. She blinks rapidly, but she doesn't pull away. "That's it." I watch my drool-covered dick slide out of her plump lips and groan when I slide back into her obedient mouth. "Good girl," I praise her. "It feels so good." I push to the back, the head of my cock blocking her air, and her eyes widen in panic. Desperate for air. "Swallow, Eve," I order, and her head fights my hold. "Swallow it. Come on. I know you can do it."

As she closes her eyes tightly, tears fall from her bottom lashes, but her throat tightens around my cock even more when she manages

to swallow. "Fuck," I say, breathless while pulling out. She coughs and sputters, body shaking. "Just like that," I tell her. "Again." I push my way past her plump lips and slowly slide down her throat, listening to her gag while my pierced dick slowly disappears until there's nothing left. "Swallow."

She does so once more, and my dick twitches from the tightness she creates. It was already amazing, but the motion of her throat constricting around me is incredible. I pull out again as spit flies from her mouth and the room fills with her gasp. "Nice and easy," I tell her, repeating the process. "You're doing great, angel. Sucking my cock just how I like it."

The point isn't to fuck her throat fast and hard. It's to train her to take all of me. And that will take time. Lots of practice.

When I push down her throat once more, spit flies out from the corner of her lips before she swallows. "See." I smile down at her, pulling my hips back and letting my cock slide out. "Look at you. You're doing so well."

My dick is painfully hard, and I crave my release. I've denied myself long enough when it comes to her. It's my turn to get what I want, and I'm not far from it.

EVERETT

He pulls his cock free of my mouth, and I leave it open, coughing and gasping for air while his cum and my drool drips from my lips.

"Good girl," he praises, and I whimper, trying to get air into my lungs.

He wasn't rough like when he's fucked my pussy before. Instead, he took his time, and I think that was worse. His heated eyes were fixed on mine with a smile on his face.

My pussy is soaked and my body is begging for him. *Just like old times.*

No. This is different, I remind myself.

I wanted this. Him to control me. To turn my brain off and let him have his way with me. I want to be his toy.

His finger hooks into the ring on my collar, pulling me out of my thoughts. He helps me to stand on my shaking legs, and I fall into him, unable to hold myself up. They're numb from kneeling on the

cold concrete, and I feel the blood rushing to them, making them tingle.

"Please?" I beg with tear-filled eyes. My thighs are soaked from my own wetness. My body likes to serve, but right now I need him to reward me.

"I know, angel." He wipes my face with both hands and kisses my forehead tenderly. Just as soft as he was with my mouth. Which is screaming right now. My jaw is so sore.

He reaches into his duffel bag and removes a chain and two more leather belts. I stand waiting like a good girl while he wraps one around my upper arms and chest to rest above my breasts. The second one is placed right below my breasts.

I moan at the added restrictiveness it provides to my arms that are still secured behind my back with the belt around my wrists.

"Does that feel good?" he questions, cupping my face.

I try to pull away, but he forces my head back, and I glance up at him.

His eyes search mine. "Answer me, Eve. Does that feel good?"

I nod.

"Words," he commands.

"Yes." I sniff as my nose continues to run from the face-fucking he just gave me. "It feels good." It's as if he's hugging me. Did he know I would like it, or is he just guessing, trying different things on me?

His hands run down over my heaving chest and begin to massage my breasts. I lean into him, unable to stop myself. My nipples are hard and aching to be touched.

I stand up on my tiptoes, wanting him to kiss me, and as his lips touch mine, his fingers pinch my nipples. I let out a cry, but he swallows it when he deepens the kiss.

At first, he's rough—pinching and pulling while he kisses me sweet and lovingly.

He pulls away too soon, and his hands fall from my breasts. Turning, he goes back to his bag and grabs a pair of nipple clamps. I bounce on the balls of my feet, wanting him to toss me down on this floor and fuck my pussy. Hell, he can tell me to spit on his dick so he

can fuck my ass with no prep, and I'd do it. He can make it hurt if that's what he wants. I need something, but he's just teasing me.

That's what you do with a toy. You play with it.

He grabs a hold of my left nipple and places the clamp on it. The sharp teeth make me hiss in a breath. "Kashton," I cry when he does the other and allows the short chain to drop. There's a small weight in the center of the chain that rests against my heated skin, pulling the clamps down.

He ignores me as he grabs another chain and hooks it to the ring of the collar, He holds it with one hand while the other picks up the duffel bag and starts to walk toward the door. "Come on."

"Wait." I stop, and he yanks me toward him. The movement has the nipple clamps biting, and it makes my pussy throb.

"Forty-eight hours, Eve," he reminds me. "I control everything you do, and right now, you're going to follow me. Do you understand?"

Swallowing, I nod softly. "I understand."

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TWENTY-THREE



KASHTON

Twelve years old

I step off the elevator and whistle while making my way through the pits to the hallway that leads to the cells.

My heart begins to race when I see the first one on the right is open. I rush into it, looking around. My tennis shoes crunch the broken glass that still remains on the floor from last night when I visited. Why haven't they cleaned it? And the blood? The floor is covered in it. Something has been dragged through it. Smearing it across the concrete floor.

"Why are you down here?"

I turn around to see my father following me and step into the cell. "Where is she?" I demand.

"She's gone, Kashton."

"You moved her?" I shove him out of the way and rush out of her cell. I go to the one across from her. Wrapping my hands around the bars, I scream into it. "Mom?" A frail woman sits in the far corner, her arms wrapped around her bony legs with her head down, trying to hide her naked body. "Where is she?" I shout, and the person flinches.

"Kashton."

"Mom?" I scream, starting to panic. I run down the hallway, scanning each cell. There are a few that don't have bars, just concrete doors, and I slam my fists on them as I call to her, hoping she answers from the other side.

"She's gone, Kashton." My father yanks me back by my shirt and spins me around to face him.

"You killed her." I punch him, and he pushes me away. "Why? Why would you do that?" Tears sting my eyes.

"She killed herself."

"No." I refuse to believe that. "She wouldn't leave me."

"Come on." He grabs my upper arm and pulls me through the basement and to the morgue.

We enter a cold room that has rows and rows of drawers stacked three high. It's where they keep the bodies. There's a metal table in the center with a white sheet over it that's soaked in blood.

A knot gets lodged in my throat when my father walks over to it and yanks it back.

It's my mother, but I refuse to believe it. "No." My tear-filled eyes go to his.

"She took a piece of glass and slit her throat," he explains, running his finger across her neck, following the open wound. It looks almost fake. Like a Halloween costume with its uneven line.

"This is your fault," I scream. My chest is squeezing. I can't breathe. "You…you didn't clean up the shattered glass." It was from the light bulb that had broken. It was all over the floor. "It was cutting her." She had blood on her hands and knees last night from crawling around her cell.

He says nothing, and I walk over to her and place my hands on her arm. I've never been able to touch her before. Even in her cell, she never tried to reach out to me or get close enough to hold my hand. That's all I ever wanted. To show her how much she meant to me. How much I love her.

"No." I shake my head. "She wouldn't leave me. She loves me…" Tears roll down my face. "Please…Mom." I sniff when my nose begins to run, digging my fingers into her cold skin. "No."

"Sometimes you have to hurt the one you love."

"You've never hurt me."

"I will. It's life…inevitable."

She knew last night what she was going to do. That she was going to leave me. End her life. I bow my head and close my eyes tightly to try and keep the tears from falling in front of my father. He'll see me as weak. "Please, God—"

I'm ripped from her, and my father digs his fingers into my upper arms. "Are you fucking praying?" he snaps, and I try to pull away, but he just tightens his grip. "God doesn't exist, boy. You are the god."

I shake my head.

"Yes. You are judge, jury, and executioner. You decide who lives, suffers, and dies."

"I will never be like you," I scream.

"Sir, we're ready," a voice says from behind me.

My father lets me go and nods to them. "Then get it done."

The man starts to roll my mother to a door on the opposite side of the room. "Where is she going?" I demand, looking at him. "What are you going to do?"

"Cremating her. Then I'm throwing her ashes out with the trash."

I wake up to my cell ringing, and for a second, I just lie in bed, staring up at the ceiling. Eve has brought back memories I've tried to forget, and I know why. A part of me wants to save her from herself. I failed my mother. The saying goes *history repeats itself*, and I won't do the same when it comes to Eve.

But it's different with my future Lady. I knew I wanted her before I even knew who she was, before I knew about her past.

It rings again and I think about ignoring it. Maybe trying to go back to sleep dreaming of Eve and the future we're going to have.

When it rings once more, I decide to answer it. I need to get up anyway. If I stay in bed all day, the guys will be in here asking too many questions. "Hello?"

"Hey," comes Sin's voice. "You busy right now?"

"Depends," I say and roll my eyes. I sound like a bitch playing hard to get.

"I thought about going for a ride."

"Give me twenty." I hang up and jump in the shower. I'm a little slower than usual because of the two days I spent with Eve. My cock is still hard thinking about what we did. How I played with my angel.

I'm standing in the garage at Carnage with one of the doors up when I hear his bike coming down the road. He's got a loud muffler on it.

Seeing him pull up, I take a helmet off the wall. Between the three of us here, we've got a large collection. "Put this on." I shove it into his chest. "We both know Elli only married you because she thinks you're pretty."

He laughs and shoves the helmet over his head, fastening it underneath his chin. I'm not going to be the reason he crashes and dies. I don't want Elli coming after me because of his stupidity.

I put my earbuds in, turn on Spotify, and blast music. We ride for I don't know how long, taking curves too fast, lane splitting, and popping wheelies. We're just two guys out being dumbasses and not caring. Cars honk and flip us off. We just wave and nod at them.

Man, I'd hate to have a life like theirs. Live a little. You're going to die eventually. Some much sooner than others. Why not enjoy it?

One woman flashes us while her friend laughs from the driver's seat.

It does nothing for me. She isn't my girl. Before Eve, I'd have given her my number since it'd be an easy lay. Not anymore. All I need is my angry angel.

We're at a stoplight when Sin waves to me. I turn my music down and raise my visor.

"I need gas," he calls out, and I nod, slamming my face shield down at the same time.

We pull into a gas station and get off the bikes. Removing our helmets, he starts fueling and leans up against the side of his bike while he texts away on his cell.

I might as well top mine off too. Once I'm done, I look over at him, and he's staring at me. "What?" I knew this was too good to be true. "The guys tell you to call me? Tell you to take me on a playdate?" I'm half joking but also expect him to say yes.

"No. Tyson called me and said you beat the shit out of three guys at the club the other night." He shrugs. "Not that I care about them, but I thought you could use some fresh air."

I look away. Did Ty call everyone? I know I made a scene, but damn.

"What happened?" he asks at my silence.

"Doesn't matter."

He chuckles. “I’m sure it was over a woman, and that matters.”

I look back at him, and he arches a brow, daring me to argue.

“Is this the ‘I’ll take care of it’ girl?” He brings up the conversation we had in the office at Carnage.

I’ve been waiting for him to ask me if I’ve handled it. This is probably his way of wanting to know what I’ve found out about her.

I look away and sigh heavily. “Yes. It’s Eve.” I run a hand through my helmet hair.

“And?” he urges.

“And she was there that night.” I shrug.

“With another man?”

I laugh at that thought. “No.” If my girl were with another man, I’d have killed him. Not just beaten the shit out of him. “Some guys I know from Barrington were talking about her.”

He frowns. “What were they saying?”

“Called her a whore.” The conversation she had with Adam in the bathtub comes to mind. *Not like we’ve discussed past sexual partners.* It doesn’t matter how many men she’s been with, as long as she understands I’ll be the only one from here on out.

Sin’s jaw sharpens at my words. We all know Elli’s past. What her family did to her. They tried to devalue her. They physically and mentally abused her, tried to push her over the edge. To make her look insane. All because of money. They wanted what had been left to her. And the Lords took advantage of her as well. They knew how much Sin loves her, so they sent him on a mission to break her. But she was stronger than any of them could have imagined.

“It was more than that,” I go on at his silence. “Called her useless—”

“Useless?” he repeats.

“She can’t have children.” I shrug. “At least that’s what I got of out it.” He tilts his head to the side, wondering how I came to that conclusion. “They said she was the perfect bitch that you fuck on the side when you’re married. I just put two and two together that they couldn’t knock her up.”

“Have you asked her?”

“We’re not there…yet.”

He laughs. “So she doesn’t know you exist.”

“Oh, she knows.” I chuckle to myself.

He looks away, dropping his arms from his chest and burying his hands in his jeans pockets.

“She was a doll,” I tell him.

His wide eyes meet mine. “Maybe…maybe they sterilize them?” he offers softly. “Like you guys do with women at Carnage.”

“Maybe.” Honestly, I don’t know enough for that not to be an option. “What about Elli?” I ask. Changing the subject. I still don’t know enough about Eve to answer all the questions I know he has.

“What about my wife?” he growls, as if I’m implying something.

“How’s she doing?” I clarify. “She was pretty upset after her *appointment*.”

He nods, looking away. “She’s good. Does it every time. Calls it a cleansing cry.”

“Ice cream seemed to have done the trick.”

He laughs softly. “Yeah. Thank you, by the way. For taking her.”

“I can help anytime,” I tell him. Still not sure what she had an appointment for, but it’s none of my business anyway. If they need me, I’ll do whatever, no questions asked.

“How are you doing?” I haven’t seen him in a while, so I’m going to get as much information out of him as possible.

“Fine,” he answers too quickly.

“Are you having hallucinations from the founders’ enhancements?”

He drops his head, looking down at the ground, and sighs. “They come and go.”

“Want to talk about it?” I’ve always been the single Spade brother who is willing to talk about his feelings. The others never have. I get it. We’re raised to not have any. I just never understood why it was better to not show them.

“I—”

“You two going to fucking move or what?”

We both glance over to see a truck now parked behind me. “Excuse me?”

“Fucking move! You’ve been sitting talking like two bitches for ten minutes.”

"There are other pumps you can use," I say, gesturing around to the other available pumps.

"If you don't move in five seconds, I'm going to run your fucking bike over." He slaps the side of his door as if to prove a point.

"Go ahead. I'll shove the leftover pieces up your ass," Sin tells him with a smile.

The driver's door opens, and the man jumps out. He could be Haidyn's twin in size and height, if not a little taller. Wearing denim overalls and a hat that says Try Me.

Careful what you wish for.

The passenger door opens, and another man jumps out with a fucking baseball bat.

Sin glances at me, his smile growing. "Knew this would come in handy." He picks up the helmet that sits on the seat of his bike and swings at the guy who is now running toward him.

I don't get to see the rest because the second guy knocks me to the ground.

Sirens blare in the distance.

"Thanks for making my day, fucker." Sin kicks the one at his feet.

I remove my cell from my back pocket and make a quick call.

"Is this you calling to apologize?" he asks in greeting.

"Sin and I are about to get arrested," I tell Tyson as the sirens grow closer. The clerk came out a minute ago and screamed for us to stop before he ran back inside to hide and call the cops.

"Jesus Christ. You two—"

"Call your detective," I interrupt him.

"Kash—"

"See you soon." I hang up when the flashing lights pull into the gas station. Three police cars come to a screeching halt. Sin and I raise our hands while both guys whine, rolling around on the dirty ground.

I could pull the Lords card, but I'm not in the mood for that. Not when Tyson has a connection that could get us out of it.

All officers exit their cars with guns trained right at us. "Lie on the ground. Face down," one orders.

"Can I have my phone call before you take us in?" I joke.

"On the ground. Hands behind your back," he commands.

"Guess that's a no." Sin chuckles.

We both slowly get to our knees, lie down, and do as they say. We're cuffed and shoved into different cop cars.

I watch the man in uniform pull out his cell as he walks around our bikes.

EVERETT

The two days I spent with Kashton fucked me up. Physically, I've got bruises. Mentally, I'm drained and confused.

I've tried to talk myself down. Given myself every reason in the book as to why it was okay, but it's not enough.

It was disgusting how desperate I was. How much I begged to be treated like a dog. I even had a collar and leash to complete the act. All I was missing was a butt plug with a tail and a dog bowl that said Good Girl on it. But I didn't need that because he hand-fed me.

Degradation is a kink we learned to crave at Dollhouse. No one can understand the extent they went to in order to make us need something so bad we feared we may die without it.

Then the drugs. Fuck, the drugs controlled our thoughts and bodies. There's no winning against them.

Everything was stacked against us. Stripped of not only our clothes but also our dignity—body and mind. We were no longer ourselves. We were who they wanted us to be—sex slaves.

I sit in my bathtub, sipping on a bottle of Jack Daniel's Sinatra Century Tennessee Whiskey, trying to recover from Kashton. His hands, his cock, his words…they all controlled me for those forty-eight hours.

He steps out of the mausoleum, holding the door for me. In my bare feet, I walk down the two steps and onto the dead grass littered with small twigs. They dig into my feet, but it's my throbbing pussy that has me whimpering.

I shiver when the cold wind blows my hair around. He drops his bag and the leash to my collar. I wait patiently like a good, trained pet while he digs through his bag and then stands when he finds what he needs. Stepping behind me, he gathers my hair and ties it

at the nape of my neck with a rubber band, getting it out of my face the best he can.

Then he picks up the bag and the leash.

"Kashton." I lick my lips nervously. "Where are we going?" I never thought of asking where we're going to spend these next forty-eight hours, but I can't move my arms, and I'm standing naked outside in the middle of the night. Where could we possibly be going?

"To the cathedral," he answers. "Lead the way, angel."

He followed behind me, leash in hand, while I walked through the cemetery, down the hill, and back to the cathedral. He let me lead him like an obedient pet. My head was high, and my clamped nipples pushed out like I was a proud dog whose owner was taking her out for an evening walk. The only thing I didn't do was squat and piss in the grass.

A single tear runs down my cheek, and I take another swig from the whiskey bottle as my mind reminds me of who I really am. Pathetic.

We enter the cathedral and he leads me up the stairs at the back. My legs still shake, and my arms have gone numb. I can't feel anything but my throbbing pussy, and it aches for him. I'll take anything. His mouth, his dick, or his fingers. I just need to come.

He pushes a big wooden door open and allows me to enter first. It's a bedroom. The only one in the cathedral. It's massive. Big four-poster bed, old wooden floors, and stained-glass windows.

It'd be beautiful if not for the story behind it. "Are you going to fuck me now?" I ask, unable to hide the longing in my voice.

He drops his bag and turns to face me. Slowly he reaches around and removes the rubber band and lets my hair fall over my back. Hooking his pointer finger into the chain of the nipple clamps, he gently pulls me forward.

I trip over my own feet, hissing in a breath at the sting when I step forward.

"Fuck you?" He frowns, but his eyes tell a different story. They're amused. He's silently laughing at me.

My pulse races at the thought of him not letting me get off. Is this a punishment? "Please, Kash. I need—"

"I told you I was going to play with you, Eve." He interrupts my pleas. "This isn't about your needs." I whimper, and it grants me a smirk that I would do anything for. "It's about mine. The only hole of yours I'm going to be fucking is your pretty face. Over and over. You will wear as much of my cum as you will swallow."

I part my lips at the mention of him fucking my throat. It's still so sore, but I'm ready to go again. To show him how good I can be.

He rewards me with a smile and continues. "Right now, I need you to be a good little pet." I rub my shaking thighs together, knowing that's probably all I'm going to get for the next two days. "Kneel," he orders. His tone is authoritative, leaving no room to argue or disobey.

I fall to my knees on the old hardwood floor, my head hanging as angry tears fill my eyes. But my head is lifted when he pulls my collar. I see him wrap the end of the leash around a hook on the wall. It forces me to keep my head up.

He steps away, picks up his bag, and starts going through it while he leaves me here to wait for him. And I will, because that's what I was trained to do.

I take another drink from the bottle. A bigger one than last time.

Fuck, I'm such a stupid bitch.

Have you ever hated someone with all you have? You don't even know why you dislike them, just that you can't stand the sight of them. The sound of their voice makes you cringe and the way they laugh makes your ears bleed.

That's how I feel about myself.

I don't even know who I am anymore. I knew on the *Isabella* that Kashton would fuck my life up if given the chance, and I gave him one. Forty-eight uninterrupted hours with me, and he tore every piece of me away that I've spent building up over the past six years.

Tipping back the whiskey, I go to take another drink, but it's empty. Sitting up, I throw it across the bathroom, and it hits the wall, shattering across my floor.

"Fuck!" I scream.

Falling back into the tub, I stare up at my ceiling, trying to gain my composure and slow my racing heart. I can't see him again. That's

all there is to it. I have to cut him out of my life. But how? He's made it very clear that he won't leave me alone. And why would he? I'm giving him everything he wants. My body, my mind. I'm sure he's out fucking another stupid bitch right now. Or he's at Carnage laughing with his brothers about what I did for him while I'm here, unable to get him out of my mind.

Sitting up once again, I grab a towel and dry my hands. Then I pick up my cell and call the one person who can help me. I place it on speakerphone and set it down when it starts to ring.

"Hey, I'll probably lose you," Adam greets me.

"I—"

"I was going to call you as soon as I got service, but I'll go ahead and tell you now. You've got a job tonight. You should be getting the info within the hour," he rushes out.

I was going to take him up on his offer. Ask him to get me out of town. To take me as far away from here as he can. I can work anywhere. There are shit people all over this world who need to be killed for the disgusting shit they do to those they see as easy targets.

"Eve?" he barks. "Everything okay? You there?" When I don't answer fast enough, I hear him talking to someone else. "I think I lost her…my service sucks."

"I'm here," I say roughly, clearing my sore throat.

"Eve? Can you hear me?"

I blink rapidly to keep the angry tears at bay. "Yeah. I can hear you."

"Okay. Perfect. The information is on its way. Good luck and be safe. Text me when it's done." *Click.*

He hangs up, and I slide farther down into the tub, feeling my chest tighten. The thought of drowning myself enters my mind. But it could be days before I'm found, and I just don't want to lie in cold bathwater until someone comes looking for me. By *someone*, I mean either Adam or Bill. No one else will care.

That's not true. Kashton knows where I live. He made that very clear when he showed up in my basement and fucked me. He wants me to know that I can't escape him.

My phone beeps, signaling a text, and I know it's my job. The information I need for tonight. I decide I might as well do something productive rather than lie here wallowing in self-pity. One more night and one less bastard in this world.

I'm the one who did this to myself. I could have told Kashton no. Made him force me to be his whore if he wanted to watch me beg to be fucked that badly.

I hate that the thought excites me. That not having a choice turns me on more than anything. Even as I kneeled at his feet, tied up and collared while he fucked my mouth, my pussy was dripping for him. Forty-eight hours later, I could take his large, pierced cock down my throat like I had been doing it for years.

"That's it…good girl…fuck, angel…look at how well you're doing."

He praised me while I drooled all over myself like a dog forced to stare at their food while they wait for their owner to give them permission to eat it. And fuck, did I eat it. Swallowed it whole.

My phone beeps again, and I ignore it, sliding into the hot bathwater until it's up to my chin. Closing my eyes, I bend my knees and slide under it to wet my hair. I'll do my job and then I'll get the hell out of town.

Decision made.

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TWENTY-FOUR



KASHTON

To my surprise, Sin and I are ushered into the same room at the station, hands still cuffed behind our backs. The door opens a minute later, and the familiar detective enters. I want to talk to him about Eve and the report that Adam showed me, but I bite my tongue. If Adam thinks I'm all she has, I believe him. She seems to be the one thing he cares about right now.

The detective plops down across from us. "Assault and battery? Where the fuck did you get a bat? You were on your bikes." He doesn't let us answer. "Reckless driving, slowing traffic on the highway in order to pop wheelies, lane splitting…guess it's appropriate to assume that was the two of you the station was receiving calls about."

We say nothing.

Haynes runs a hand down his face. "I'm only doing this because of Tyson," he states.

Ty has this guy wrapped around his little finger, and it makes me wonder what Tyson has on him to get this kind of treatment.

He stands and walks behind me. Grabbing my shirt, he yanks me from the seat and undoes the cuffs. Then he removes Sin's as well. "Get the fuck out of here," he orders.

We walk outside, both laughing, but it dies when three people at the curb at the bottom of the steps turn to face us.

"Fuck," Sin sighs softly under his breath. Then he plasters a big smile on his face. "Little—"

"Don't you *little demon* me right now, Easton," his wife shouts.

"It was my fault," I say, placing my hand on my heart with sympathy. "I'm so…"

"Shut the fuck up, Kashton," she screams at me.

Tyson's lips curl up, trying not to laugh, but Lake pops a hip out, obviously on her friend's side.

Sin rubs his jaw. "How did you…?" He trails off.

"Find out that you were arrested?" Elli finishes for him. "I was with Lake when Tyson called her and said he was headed to the station. What in the fuck were you thinking?" She puts her hands on her hips.

He doesn't answer.

"Did you hit him with a helmet or a bat? You know what? It doesn't matter what you used. What if you had killed him?"

"I'll fight dirty." Sin shrugs. "I'm about to be a father. Can't pick your kids up with two broken hands." He chuckles.

I didn't think Elli's face could get any redder than it already was, but she practically has smoke rolling from her ears.

"An assault with a deadly weapon constitutes aggravated assault, Easton. It's a felony in the state of Pennsylvania. You could have gone to prison."

His laughter grows.

"This is not an assignment," she screams.

"Elli." He softens his voice.

"Get in the fucking car," she barks.

"I've got to get my bike out of impound," he argues.

"Leave it. We're selling that death trap." Elli shakes her head. "You will not make me a widow because of your stupid, idiotic actions." Her hard eyes meet mine before she spins around and waddles off to her SUV.

"Sorry, man," I tell him.

Sin reaches out and pulls me in for a man handshake hug. "You're fine. Pregnancy hormones. She gets pissed at me more times a day than I can count. In an hour, it'll be something else." He chuckles. "I'll call you later." With that, he walks slowly down the steps and nods to Tyson as he passes. He goes over to their SUV and opens the passenger door for her. Elli looks like she wants to argue and

drive but just rolls her eyes and gets in. He shuts the door and makes his way to the driver's seat.

As Sin pulls away, I walk down the steps, and Tyson speaks to me. "Get in. I'll take you to Carnage."

"I need to get my bike." I'll ride mine, he can ride Sin's, and Laikyn can follow us to Carnage to drop them off before taking him home. Sin can come get his tomorrow or the next day because I know he won't be selling it.

"They're already at Carnage," he informs me, and when I frown, he explains. "I called Haynes to inform him of what was going on, and I asked him to leave them there. Then I called Saint and Haidyn. They had the girls drive them to the gas station, where they picked them up."

Great. Now I have to explain to my brothers what the fuck I was doing fighting two idiots at a gas station with Sin.

I enter Carnage and rush to my room. Before I jump in the shower, I check my phone to see if I have any missed calls.

Nothing.

I'm not sure what I expected. Everett isn't going to call or text me. I'm not even sure she knows I saved my number in her phone. I knew she'd never ask for it.

I made sure to get hers when I went through her phone for Adam's. I just haven't used it. No need to. I know where she lives and where she hangs out.

Her life is pretty simple if you remove the fact that she kills men for a living and works for the Lords. She's got a double life that is going to catch up to her eventually, and I'm going to have to save her from it.

Entering my bathroom, I remove my clothes and turn on the shower. I'm covered in dirt and loose gravel from lying face down in a gas station parking lot.

I begin to rinse off and grab the soap. As I wash my cock, it hardens in my hands, and I can't help but think of my girl and what she did for me the past two days. She was exceptional.

God, I've never experienced something like that before. I've paid for sex and of course taken women home from the club—one-night stands have been my thing. But this was something different. More intimate.

She kneels by the wall, her leash connected to the hook above her head. She quietly sits there, waiting for me to use her.

I finish grabbing some things out of my bag before I toss it to the side. Then I go and grab her leash, pull her to stand, and walk her over to the four-poster bed that sits up against the wall of stained-glass windows.

Turning to face her, I gently unclasp her nipple clamps, and a small cry comes from her lips. I rub them tenderly, causing her to push into me and turning her cry into a moan.

"Crawl into bed. Lie on your stomach," I order.

She does as she's told as gracefully as she can. Her arms are still secured behind her back, and that's where they're going to stay until I'm done with her.

I grab what I need and then wrap the last remaining belts around her ankles and thighs, buckling them in place. She can't move an inch. Nor can she try and rub her legs together. I've seen her try to get some sort of friction where she needs it most.

Once she's secure, I pull the sashes on the drapes to close the curtains. It's been a long night. The sun will be rising soon, and my girl needs her sleep if I'm going to use her how I plan.

"Get some rest, angel," I tell her, pulling the covers up and over her body. "I'll wake you in the morning." With that, I walk away, leaving her in bed whimpering while I go and sit at the table. I have some emails I need to go over before I can take a nap.

I turn off the shower and get out, drying off. I never ended up getting that nap. It didn't take her long to pass out from exhaustion. I let Eve sleep for two hours before I woke her up, dragged her head to hang off the side of the bed, and started to fuck her mouth again.

She didn't disappoint. She was willing to give me everything I wanted and more. But the point was to leave her needy. To push her to see just what she would do in order to get what she wanted.

Begging was at the top of her list. Her desperate voice still sings in my ears.

"Please…Kash…please fuck me…I need you."

It was a glorious sight to see. Hearing her beg was even better. It took every bit of willpower I had to not give her what she begged so sweetly for.

My angel has no clue, but I'm going to give her what she wants tonight. I'm going to lie down, pass the fuck out for the day, and then go out tonight. I'm going to surprise her at her house and bring the bag full of goodies I ordered just for her. This time she'll be begging me to stop making her come.

It's all about balance.

EVERETT

It's late. The clock on my dash reads almost midnight. I'm driving home after killing another unlucky bastard at the motel. My face is throbbing and my side hurts.

I didn't realize how much my two days with Kashton had weakened me. All the alcohol I consumed probably didn't help. I almost gave up; the guy was over two hours late and then gave me some bullshit line that his wife wouldn't let him leave and he had to wait for her to pass out before he could sneak out.

These bastards' wives should thank me for taking care of their problems. Their husbands die and they get to reap the rewards of their life insurance.

Pulling into my driveway, I park my car in the garage. I get out and drag myself into my home. I'm not even in the mood to shower. I just want to pass out. But I'm covered in blood and need one.

It got messy. Normally I'd be into that, but tonight I wasn't. I'm just emotionally drained and physically exhausted. This is when I wish I took pills to help me sleep, but I know not to trust myself with them. I'd take an entire bottle and then not wake up. Or worse, take pills to sleep and then need medication to wake up. I refuse to alter my mind and body like that. I spent too many years on them already.

Turning on the living room light, I jump back when I see a man sitting on my couch.

"I've been waiting—" He stops when his blue eyes get a good look at me. "What in the fuck happened to you?" Kashton jumps up from the couch.

"Stop." I place my hands up to keep him back. I'm not in the mood. "Go home. Leave me alone, Kash." I don't even bother asking how in the fuck he got in my house again or how long he's waited for me to show up.

"Everett," he barks, rushing over to me. "Who fucking did this to you?"

I take a stumbling step back, but my vison blurs for a second and I fall off the side of my heels.

"Whoa." He grabs my arms to steady me. "Talk to me, Eve. What's going on?" His pretty blue eyes frantically search my face and body. His hands glide down my arms and over my waist, and all I can think about is him ripping off my jeans, bending me over the couch, and fucking me. "Where are you hurt?" he demands.

Hurt? Am I hurt? Just my pride after I crawled on all fours for him. I literally did everything but bark for him. For fucking dick. I'm the problem. Women like me are why guys like him exist. We give them what they want, and it's never enough.

"I'm…fine," I answer, blinking rapidly. "Just need some rest." I try to push him away, but he doesn't budge.

"You're bleeding," he growls.

"Maybe." I shrug.

"What?" Kashton snaps.

Is he talking to me? "Hmm?" I ask, looking up at him. He's got two heads. Both of them floating around like you see in a cartoon. There's even a ringing in my ears that might or might not be birds chirping. Whatever the fuck it is, it's annoying. I pull on my ears, thinking that will help. "Make it stop," I mumble.

He places his hands on either side of my face, holding it in place, and I shuffle from foot to foot on my heels. My feet hurt. "Look at me," he orders.

I try to say *I am*, but nothing comes out.

"Everett," he barks, and I feel his hands leave my face. One wraps around my neck, and I moan at the way his fingers tighten.

Is he going to fuck me? Choke me out? That sounds nice. At least I'll get a good night's sleep. I faintly hear his voice in the distance, but I can't make out what he's saying, so I just close my eyes. Maybe I'll get lucky and he'll let me come this time.

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TWENTY-FIVE



KASHTON

"Eve? Angel, talk to me. What hurts?" I frantically roam my hands over her body. One is on her neck, checking her pulse, and it's thready. The other is yanking her shirt up to see if she's been stabbed or shot.

She's covered in blood, but I can't tell if it's hers or not.

I run my hands over her thighs and ass, looking to see if her jeans have any holes or cuts.

"Eve—" Her heavy eyes roll into the back of her head as her knees give out. "Fuck." I catch her before she falls and pick her up, cradling her in my arms.

I carry her down the hall and kick open her bedroom door, placing her on her bed as I pull out my cell phone. I immediately call Gavin and rattle off her address, letting him know I need him now.

Then I grab her phone from her back pocket and dial Adam's number. He'll answer her call before he'll take mine.

"Hey, how'd it go?" he asks in greeting.

"Adam," I growl, ripping her shirt off her chest and using it to try and clean her neck and arms free of the blood.

"Why the fuck are you calling me from Eve's phone, Kash?" he demands, immediately on the defensive.

"Because she just passed out in my arms." I look over her chest and stomach, searching for some kind of entrance wound. When I don't see anything, my hands go to her hair, feeling around for bumps or lacerations.

"What?" he demands. "What the fuck is wrong with her?"

"I don't know, but I've got Gavin on his way to look at her." As the words leave my mouth, she opens her heavy eyes, blinking and looking around aimlessly.

"Wh-at?"

"Where are you?" he questions, interrupting her.

"Her house," I answer, gently pushing her to lie down when she tries to sit up.

"Keep her there. I'm on my way." He hangs up, and I decide now is not the time to dwell on the fact that he didn't ask for her address. Of course he fucking knows where she lives.

He made it sound like I'm letting her go somewhere.

"Kash?" She licks her lips and blinks. She glances up at me, and I can tell she actually sees me this time, unlike in the living room.

Her eyes are heavy but focused. I let out a deep breath and run my hand down the side of her bruised face. "What happened, Eve?" I ask her. She did a job tonight. That's the only explanation for the blood and Adam asking *How'd it go?* "Did he hit you?" Her cheek has a light-colored bruise she didn't have when I left her yesterday at the cathedral.

"I'm fine." She puts her hand on the bed and pushes herself to sit. Groaning, her head hangs forward, and I stand.

"Stay in bed. I'll get you a water." I make my way to her kitchen, grab one out of the fridge, and rush back to her. My teeth grind when I see the bed empty. "Goddammit, Eve. You need to be in bed," I growl when I see her standing in her bathroom.

"I need a shower." She looks herself over in the mirror. "You ripped my top." Turning to face me, her eyes harden.

"I was trying to see what was wrong with you," I snap angrily.

She huffs. "Funny, coming from you."

"What the fuck does that mean?" I haven't physically hurt her.

She opens her mouth to no doubt tell me to leave, but the doorbell rings. "I'll get it."

I set the bottle of water on the counter and then make my way to the door, letting Gavin in. "She's awake," I inform him, and he follows me down the hallway, through her primary suite, and then into her bathroom.

"Kash—" She turns around to yell at me but stops when she sees Gavin is with me. Her eyes widen for a brief second before they narrow on me. "What is he doing here?"

"This is Gavin." The way she can't meet his eyes tells me that she already knows who he is. I'm not sure if that's a good or bad thing. "He's going to look at you. Give you an exam to see what happened and why you fainted."

"I keep telling you I'm fine. I'm just tired." She runs a hand through her tangled, bloody hair.

"Let me decide that," Gavin says, stepping forward.

She looks between me and him. Trying to decide whether the fight is worth it. It's not.

"I'm—"

"If you say *fine* one more time, I will tie you to your bed so Gavin can examine you," I interrupt her. "And you can fight me all you want, but we both know you're not strong enough to beat me." Not even on her best day, but definitely not tonight. She's exhausted and weak.

She huffs, looking away.

I would smile if I wasn't so worried about her. "I'll give you guys a minute." I exit, letting them have their time together.

As I'm returning to the living room, her front door bursts open, and Adam enters. "Where the fuck is she?" he demands.

EVERETT

"Have you ever passed out before?" Gavin asks me.

I want to laugh but instead say, "Yes."

"How long ago?" He places the stethoscope on my chest to listen to my heart.

"I don't know. It's been a while." Last time I actually passed out, I was choked out by Kashton. Is that the same? I'm not sure, but I'm not in the mood to get into it with him.

"Everything sounds good." He places his hands on my neck, and I arch it so he can feel around for whatever it is he's looking for. "Any drugs?"

"Just alcohol," I answer as he pulls away.

"Today?" he wonders.

"Every day."

He sighs heavily. "Eve—"

"Don't," I cut him off. "I don't even know why you're here."

"Kashton called me. He was really worried about you."

I snort and then flinch. My head is still pounding more than it was before.

"I would like to give you a prescription—"

"No drugs." I shake my head. "I don't need them."

His jaw sharpens. "Can you promise to take it easy?"

"Sure." I shrug.

"But will you?"

"No."

"Goddammit, Eve." He turns and softly shuts my bathroom door, and I raise my brows in question. I like where we pretend that we don't know each other. "Just because I don't see any physical signs of a concussion doesn't mean you don't have one."

"I don't."

"Let me give you an IV. Fluids can help—"

"No." I know what he's wanting to do. He wants to flush my system, and it won't do any good.

He looks away, and I can tell he's debating pushing it. Is it worth forcing me and pissing me off? The answer is never. "I'm going to suggest that Kash stay the night with you tonight."

My teeth grind. "Absolutely not."

"It's either that or you come with me back to the clinic and I put you under a twenty-four-hour watch," he says matter-of-factly. "And as worried as he is, I'm guessing he would follow you there."

I fist my hands at my options. I'm getting really tired of this shit.

He steps into me and softens his voice. "I don't know what's going on between the two of you, but I promise Kashton staying here with you is the better option. Especially after I call your *father* and inform him of why I had to make a house visit in the middle of the night." With that, he gathers his things, opens the door, and exits my room.

I want to scream my head off right now, but it'll just make my headache worse. Stepping out into the hallway, I hear Gavin speaking. "You need to stay with her tonight."

"I'm not going anywhere," Kashton says, confirming what I was dreading.

"Her vitals are good, but I'd rather be safe than sorry," Gavin goes on.

"Of course. Thanks for coming." Then I hear the front door open and close.

I make my way down the hallway and to the kitchen. Opening the cabinet, I grab a bottle of whiskey and then a glass out of the freezer.

"Not sure that's a wise decision," Kashton says from the living room.

I keep my back to him. "Pretty sure I didn't ask your opinion."

As I pour the alcohol into the glass, it's ripped from the counter, making the liquor cover the white marble. "What the fuck?" I spin around to give Kashton a piece of my mind but laugh when I see a set of green eyes holding the frosted glass. "Is there anyone you didn't call?" I look around Adam to where Kashton sits on the couch.

He's leaning forward, elbows on his dark-wash jeans. He's in a white hoodie, with that fucking baseball hat on backward. His eyes are on mine, but they give nothing away. It's that same look he gave me when I kneeled at his feet, begging him to fuck my face.

I glance away and let out a deep breath.

"What the fuck happened?" Adam growls and pours the glass into the sink. "Did he rape you?" He looks over my disheveled hair, bruised face, and blood-covered jeans. My shirt is lying on my bedroom floor because Kashton ripped it off me. They don't seem to care that I'm in my bra.

"No." I run a hand through my hair, trying to tame it the best I can. I've seen myself in the mirror. I look like shit.

"Are you sure?" Kashton asks.

I slam my eyes on him. "Of course I'm sure."

"You passed out in my arms. It's not a stretch to think that you passed out during the job as well." Kashton sits back into my couch, his legs opening wide while his tatted hands rest on his thighs. His tan skin and black ink up against the white hoodie make him look mouthwateringly good.

Fuck, I've got to get myself a chastity belt. I'm never having sex again. Something so innocent shouldn't turn me on.

"Did Gavin examine you?" Adam digs.

"No," I growl, knowing what he's asking. The last thing I was going to do was get undressed and spread my legs. I've had to do that before for Gavin, but it was warranted. I know there was no reason to tonight. "There was no need. I didn't let it get that far. My clothes never came off."

Adam nods, as if that's enough information to satisfy him, but one look at Kashton tells me he's skeptical. He probably just doesn't like the idea of sharing his toy.

"I'm giving you a week off," Adam states, turning away.

"Actually," I say, and he stops, turning back to face me, "I want you to relocate me."

"Absolutely not." Kashton jumps to his feet.

I narrow my eyes on him. "This is not your decision to make." I put my attention back on Adam. "I want to move. Send me somewhere else." When he just stares at me, I frown. "This is what you told me to do. You told me to run."

"Are you running?" He arches a brow.

I look away.

"If so, who are you running from?" Adam goes on at my silence.

I can't say his brother because then he'll ask what we did that I need to run from. "I—"

Adam's phone ringing interrupts me. He pulls it out of his pocket and answers. "Hello…yeah…I'll be right there." He hangs up. "I have to go. We'll finish this conversation later." He starts walking toward the front door. "Get some rest. And quit fucking drinking. You're going to give yourself liver damage and kill yourself."

Kashton follows him out the door and I turn, picking up the bottle.

Fuck them both.

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TWENTY-SIX



KASHTON

"What was that about?" I bark at Adam once her door closes behind me.

"I have to go. Three bodies were found dumped by Barrington. All match the same MO—"

"I'm talking about Eve moving," I interrupt him. "You're going to tell her no. That you can't do it."

He stops and turns to face me. His eyes focus on her front door and then on mine. "Look." He steps forward and lowers his voice. "I love Eve like a sister." I don't like how he says it, because I've seen how he's treated Ashtyn and because I know that he's fucked my girl. "I really do, but you're not going to win this. She's going to do whatever she wants. Just like you're going to do whatever the fuck you want."

"You told me that I had to help protect her, and I think tonight proves that I need to protect her from you as well."

He's giving her these jobs all on her own. All they have to do is drug her drink or overpower her for a second, and she's dead. I pinned her down to the couch in the office at the cathedral and ripped her fishnet tights. So I know that it can easily be done. She's tough but not physically as strong as a man. The only reason she's made it this far is because she has them at a disadvantage. She catches them off guard. They're vulnerable, thinking that they're paying a hooker for sex. Eventually, they're going to start talking and wondering where these guys are disappearing to.

Adam's phone starts ringing, and he sighs heavily. "I have to go. Keep an eye on her, and I'll check back tomorrow." With that, he

turns, answering his phone as he dips into the driver's side of his car.

I enter her house and don't see her in the living room or kitchen, so I go to her bedroom. The sound of running water has me walking into her bathroom.

She sits in the tub with that bottle of whiskey in her hand. Her head is back on the pillow, eyes closed.

I rip the Jack from her hands and place it on the counter by her sink. Then I turn back to face her. She's staring up at me with her heavy eyes. "I don't want a lecture," she whispers.

My girl looks exhausted. "I don't plan on giving you one." Adam is right. She's going to do whatever she wants to do unless I stop her. Words aren't going to change her mind, but actions will keep her here.

I sit on the side of the tub and order, "Sit up."

She slowly gets to a sitting position and pulls her knees to her chest. The tub is filled about halfway and there are no bubbles, so I can see her tan skin through the water. She's got bruises on her knees and around her arms and neck. They're from me and the belts I used on her. What I did to her the past two days.

The one on her cheek is new. And I notice she's got a large one on her thigh. Also not from my hands.

"I'm going to wash you, then tuck you into bed," I inform her. "Your body needs to rest."

"Not going to make me sleep on the floor like a dog?" She snorts. "How thoughtful of you."

Ignoring that, I grab a cup that she has sitting on the side of the tub and fill it with water and begin to wash her hair. She sighs, running her hands down her face.

Less than twenty minutes later, as I pull the plug to her bathwater, she can't keep her eyes open. I help her out, wipe her off, and wrap her in a towel. She allows me to pick her up and carry her to her bed, where I place her under the covers.

"This is your fault, you know."

I frown. "How so?"

"Doesn't matter." She rolls over, but I sit down next to her, turning her onto her back so she has to face me.

"It does," I assure her. "Tell me what I did."

She licks her lips. "It's what you didn't do." My frown deepens and she yawns. "It's your fault I was off my game tonight. I was weak and distracted."

"I'm still not understanding how you putting yourself in danger is my fault. You should have called me." I know she's seen my number saved in her phone. "I would have gone with you." Haidyn used to pay for his sex all the time. I know that some have bodyguards. The smart ones do anyway. I don't give a fuck what a woman chooses to do with her body, but she should always protect herself. Anything can happen. I could have pretended to be that for her.

She blinks, her heavy eyes having trouble staying open. "You didn't let me get off."

"You didn't get yourself off when you got home?"

Her brows pull down at my question. "Was that what you wanted?" she asks, though I don't answer. "Were…were you testing me?"

"If I was, it sounds like you failed."

"Unbelievable," she mumbles.

I reach out and push a few strands of wet hair behind her ear and search her heated eyes. "Why didn't you get yourself off, angel?"

She looks away, refusing to answer me.

"When was the last time you allowed yourself to come?" I ask instead.

"That's…none of your business."

I cup her warm face and run my thumb over her lips. I helped her wash her face clear of her makeup, and she looks just as gorgeous without it. Her skin is soft and her lips pouty. Her big green eyes seem brighter than they were the night on the yacht all those years ago. "You're my business, Everett. Everything you do is my business. That includes touching yourself."

She licks her lips. "So what? You're going to deny me orgasms now?"

"Sounds to me like you're denying yourself of them." That grants me an eye roll. I was setting her up to see if she would get herself off. I know how she feels about sex with men, but to not even please herself? "Why?"

Her pretty green eyes fall to the bed, and she takes a long breath, but she doesn't answer.

She was a doll. Maybe they used orgasms as a punishment? Or made her beg for a release that she was never allowed to have? "There's nothing wrong with getting off, angel." I go on. "To feel good."

Meeting my stare once more, she whispers, "You make me feel good."

I lean in and gently kiss her lips, unable to stop myself. She surprises me by kissing me back.

"Come on. You need to rest." I've got a big day planned for her tomorrow.

She closes her eyes, and I crawl in next to her, letting mine wander her body as she sleeps on her side, facing me. I run the pad of my fingers gently over her upper arm, caressing the bruises the belts left.

Her eyes flutter open before they fall closed once more and she yawns.

"Get some sleep, angel. I'll be here when you wake up."

"Why?" she asks sleepily, her dark lashes fanning her cheeks.

"To take care of you," I say simply.

"I can take care of myself," she mumbles. "I'd rather you just fuck me."

I smirk at that and promise, "I'll do that too. Just not tonight."

Moments later, her breathing evens out and her body relaxes into the mattress. She's sound asleep.

I get up, find the remote, and turn her TV on, making sure to put the volume on low so it doesn't wake her. Then I get undressed and climb back into bed, pull her body flush with mine and close my eyes.

It feels good to be needed. For someone to depend on me. It's been a long time since I took care of someone.

EVERETT

I wake up with a groan. Rolling over onto my side, I open my eyes to look around and see I'm alone.

Finally. A little peace and quiet.

My head is pounding, and my body hurts. The guy I killed last night put up a fight.

"Fucking bitch." He scowls, grabs my hair, and yanks my head back. "I'm on to you."

As he shoves my face into the dirty comforter, his voice is muffled from the blood rushing in my ears.

When he pulls my head up, I twist my body around, feeling his hand tighten in my hair in the process, and I slam my fist into his throat. "Bastard," I growl.

Coughing and sputtering, he lets go and stumbles back. I take the opportunity and jump off the bed, barreling into him, and the momentum pushes him back so he hits the glass wall, and it shatters before we fall to the floor.

I get up on my hands and knees, crawling to my bag, but he grabs my ankle and yanks me back. "Not this time."

I slam my free foot into his face over and over until he lets go of my ankle. I'm gasping for breath as I reach into my bag and pull out my knife. He jumps on me as I spin around and stab him, splattering myself with his blood.

"Fuck," I growl, shoving his dead weight off me, trying to catch my breath.

I ended up stabbing him in the chest twice. I made sure he was dead before I left him there.

Entering my bathroom, I use the restroom, wash my hands, and then splash my face with cold water to wake up. I need some Advil, a drink, and a nap. In that order.

I'm naked, so I grab an oversized T-shirt and slide the soft fabric over my head before placing my hair up in a messy bun to get it out of my face. I swear I'm losing hair from all the men who fist it.

Why is it the first thing any man grabs a hold of when they are trying to rape or kill you?

Deciding I can't do anything else with myself, I make my way to the kitchen but come to a stop when I see the back of a man. "I knew it was too good to be true," I mumble.

Kashton turns around and gives me a smile. "Good morning, angel. How did you sleep?"

I don’t answer because I was hoping today would be better than yesterday. It won’t be.

The doorbell rings and he smiles. “Perfect timing.”

Walking over to my front door, he opens it for who I assume to be Adam, but it’s Gavin. They greet one another and then Kashton points him to me for my follow-up appointment.

Fuck this day.

“Here.” Kashton walks over to me in the living room, grabs my hand, and helps me sit at the dining room table as if I’m incapable of doing so on my own.

Did he not hear Gavin? I’m fine. Passed whatever test he gave me with flying colors. I, of course, didn’t tell him about my headache or the fact that I’m feeling a little dizzy. I’ve been through this before. It’ll pass. Just has to run its course.

“What are you doing, Kash?” I place my head in my hands, rubbing my throbbing temples.

“Making you breakfast. You don’t have much food here,” he accuses. “But I was able to make some pancakes. I hope that’s okay. If not, I can order whatever you’d like.” His blue eyes look at me expectantly.

My stomach rumbles at the thought of food. “Yeah.” I nod. “Sounds good. Thank you.”

He’s moving around the kitchen like he lives here, and it makes me wonder how many times he’s been in my house that I’m not aware of.

“Did you sleep with me in my bed last night?” I wonder. After I got home, parts are blurry.

“Nope. I didn’t go to sleep,” he answers, turning to place a plate in front of me, along with a knife and fork. Pancakes stacked five high. He then sets out the butter, peanut butter, and syrup.

“Thank you,” I say and inhale the scent. “It smells amazing.”

“Of course.” He leans down and kisses my forehead.

It makes me pause. He’s playing house. Like we’re a married couple and this is a common occurrence.

"Eat up, Eve." Turning, he goes over to my cabinets, pulls out my Advil, and then places two by my plate before giving me a glass of orange juice.

I pick them up and toss them into my mouth as I drink half the glass. I'm so thirsty, and I want this headache to go away.

"Bill's reception is this weekend."

His words have me glancing up at him. The way he said it makes me think he knows something that I don't. "And?"

"I'm assuming you're going."

Sin and Elli were at our family dinner, and he's close to Sin. So I know he's aware that Bill is my *father*. The question is, how much does he know? "I am."

He pulls a seat out, sits down, and reaches across the table to take my hand. He slowly rubs his thumb over my knuckles, and my pulse races. His eyes search mine when he asks. "Will you be my date?"

I swallow nervously. *A date?* I've never been on one of those before. A woman like me isn't seen out in public with a man like Kashton. Any man, for that matter. "I can't." I pull my hand from his and stand, grabbing my untouched plate.

"Can't or won't?" he questions, following me to the sink.

I keep my back to him, bowing my head and closing my eyes. If he's going, then that means his brothers are going as well. I'm not ready to see them. Or Ashtyn. Not like she'll notice me or anything. But I'll know, and I'm just not ready.

He grabs my hips and spins me around. His hands come to my face, and he holds it in place, forcing me to look at him. "I'm going to pick you up at five—"

"Kashton," I protest. "We shouldn't."

"What are you hiding, Eve?"

My heart races. "Nothing." I try to pull away, but he has my back against the counter.

"Prove it," he challenges me.

My breathing picks up, and I try to think of a lie, but I have nothing. He's got me flustered. Or maybe it's the pounding headache. Gavin could be right, and I have a concussion. It's messing with me. Making me crazy.

"Prove to me that you have nothing to hide and be my date." His hands fall from my face and slowly glide down my shirt until he reaches the hem. He grabs a hold of the material and pulls it up.

I lift my arms on instinct to allow him to remove it. Tossing it to the side, I stand naked in front of him while he's dressed.

My heart hammers in my chest, and my knees start to shake as his eyes take in my body. My skin heats up, and I feel lightheaded.

His hands come back to my face, and his eyes meet mine before he leans into me. My eyelids fall closed when our lips touch. I let him take my breath away as he kisses me—deep and passionately.

I push my body into him, letting my hands fall to his jeans. I begin to unbuckle his belt, but his hands grip my wrists, stopping me. He pulls his lips from mine, and I open my heavy eyes. "Come on." He pulls me away and back to my bedroom.

We enter my bathroom, and he starts running the tub. "What are you doing?" I thought he was going to fuck me.

"I'm going to play with you," he answers, popping open the bubbles and pouring some into the water.

That excitement returns, but my eyes drop to the water. "In the bathtub?" I ask, taking a step back.

He turns to face me, kisses my forehead, and ignores my question. "I'll be right back." Then he exits the bathroom, shutting the door behind him.

I begin to pace, nibbling on my nails. I'm a functioning alcoholic. I don't go to group therapy like Bill and Adam have both suggested, but I do know I have a problem.

The only thing is, I have lived alone for the better part of the past six years, so I don't have to hide alcohol from anyone. And there's no way Kashton is going to allow me to drink this early.

I start going through cabinets under the sinks, opening drawers, hoping that I have something somewhere. But I have no luck.

With one last Hail Mary, I walk into the closet and start looking through my dressers. I catch sight of a backpack on the floor and kneel. Unzipping it, I find a mini bottle of vodka from one of many private jet rides that Adam and I were on.

"Thank God." I toss the backpack into place, and it hits the box that hides in the corner. Taking a quick look over at the closet door, I can hear the bathtub running but don't think he's back yet. I pull the box out and my heart races when I see the tape has been cut down the middle and the sides.

My hands start to shake. I haven't opened this. It had to be Kashton. When was he in here? He said he hadn't slept last night. He could have been all over this place. Or when he was here last night waiting for me to get home.

Shoving it back into the corner, I stand and make my way to the bathroom, closing the closet door behind me. I sink into the scalding-hot water and quickly unscrew the lid, tossing it back. I swallow the contents in one gulp just as the bathroom door opens.

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TWENTY-SEVEN



KASHTON

I enter the bathroom and sit down on the edge of the tub. Her eyes are on the bubbles, unable to meet mine. Reaching over, I turn off the water. "Give it to me," I order.

She glances up at me. "Give you what?"

I reach out my hand in front of her and motion with my fingers. "Whatever was in your hand."

"It was nothing." She raises both of hers from the water, and I smile, shoving mine into it.

Fuck, it's so goddamn hot, but feeling around the bottom, I find what I'm looking for and pull it out. "Then what's this?" I ask, looking at the empty mini bottle of vodka. I saw her down it in the mirror when I opened the door.

"I wasn't doing anything wrong." She shrugs.

"Then why were you hiding it?" I counter.

Sure, I drink here and there, though I could go without picking up another drink if I had to quit.

We all choose to feed our demons differently.

"I want you sober today," I tell her.

She looks up at me through her lashes, and I can't wait to bury myself inside her.

I grab the soap and washcloth she has hanging over the faucet. "Turn around," I tell her. She pulls her knees to her chest and spins to face the other way, giving me her back. I start to wash it, taking my time, letting my hands learn her body, the way it flexes as she moves, and the way she moans when I reach around to wash her neck.

My girl is desperate, and so am I.

"Fuucckkk," she groans, dropping her head back while my tatted fingers tighten. I feel her swallow against them.

"Feel good?" I ask, smirking.

Her heavy lashes open, and she looks up at me through them while I smile down at her. I reach my free hand around and start to play with her breast as her hips rock back and forth, causing the water to slosh around.

"What do you want, Eve?" I ask, dropping my hand from her neck.

She sucks in a breath and answers, "You."

I smile but continue washing her. I enjoyed giving her a bath late last night, getting to take care of her. She didn't need another one this morning, but I wanted to touch her again to see just how worked up I can get her.

After rinsing her off, I help her out of the tub, and she spots my bag on the counter. She was too busy downing her vodka to realize I brought it in here with me.

"What's in there?" she asks.

I turn her to face me. "How do you like to be fucked?"

She blinks, her wet lashes fanning her cheeks at my question. "I, uh…" She looks around, caught off guard by my question.

"Tell me, Eve. What do you like?" I want her to think she has a little control over what I'm about to do to her. I've controlled every other encounter we've had, and this will be no different, but I also want her to trust me. I'm not here to hurt her.

Licking her lips, she whispers, "I like how you play with me."

"And when I restrain you. What do you like?"

She blushes, dropping her gaze to the floor. This woman is a fucking hurricane, but when it comes to the bedroom, she's a timid little animal. She's ashamed to enjoy sex. I'm going to show her how good it can be.

"Rope, chains, cuffs? What is it, Eve?" I urge, pushing some loose strands behind her ear.

She glances up at me, and I step into her. "This isn't about punishment or degrading you, angel. It's about pleasing you. So tell me what you like."

I want her to feel safe with me, even if I have bad intentions. Because when it comes down to it, I will do whatever it takes to make her mine. Eve thinks this is all about sex—and sex is a part of it—but I'm looking at our future, planning out the rest of our lives.

"I like it when it hurts," she says softly.

I'm well aware that my girl is a pain slut. "I like it when you beg," I tell her, wanting her to realize if she opens up to me, I'll open up to her. She gives; I give.

There's a reason she doesn't want to go to Bill's wedding reception with me, and I'll let her think she won by not revealing that secret, but I will get what I want. She will be my date.

Her green eyes meet mine, and there isn't an ounce of doubt or fear in them when she says, "I like how good you make me feel. When you touch me, my mind is quiet."

She likes to follow. Be told what to do. I'm not surprised, but to hear her say that gives me pride. Especially after Adam told me she doesn't have sex.

"Good girl," I tell her. "For being honest."

I turn and unzip my bag and pull out the set of handcuffs. Her breathing accelerates in the quiet bathroom when I tell her to turn around. As she does what she's told, I secure her dainty wrists inside the cold metal and then turn her back to face me.

"Close your eyes." Her eyelids fall closed without hesitation as she takes a shaky breath. "Feel my hands, Eve?" I ask, running them over her chest and neck, slowly moving them up to cup her face.

"Yes," she whispers.

I run them down her back and pull her into me as I place my lips to her racing pulse. "Feel my lips?" I gently kiss her soft skin up to the shell of her ear.

"Ye-ah." She's panting now, her hips pushing into mine, and I have to refrain from smiling when I make my way to her lips. When she parts them for me, I kiss her deeply, swallowing her moan before I pull away.

"Eyes on me now, Eve."

They flutter open and I give her a smile. "You're doing so good, angel." She whimpers at my praise, her arms fighting the cuffs, and I bet she's soaked.

"I'm going to put a hood over your head and gag you."

Her eyes widen at my confession. "Kash—"

"You'll be okay," I assure her.

There's no telling how many sick bastards took advantage of her at Dollhouse. I want her to feel safe with me. To know that no other man on this planet will ever touch her again. No one other than me.

"I'm going to lay you down in bed, tied up. I'm going to take away your sight, your hearing, and your voice." She swallows nervously, but her eyes grow heavy. "It'll be my hands, my mouth, and my cock—only—that touches you. No one else, do you understand?"

She nods.

"Words, Eve." I need her to tell me she understands. I don't know what she's endured, but this is part of my plan to push her. I need to show her she can trust me. That I'm who she needs.

"Yes, sir. I understand."

I hate that she calls me *sir*. I have never been a fan, but I'm not going to correct her. I'm about lifting my woman up, not making her feel bad about herself.

Leaning in, I kiss her forehead. "Go lie on the bed. Arms underneath you."

She walks off, and I enter her closet. I see she's moved the box, which means she knows I've opened it. I wonder why she hasn't asked me about it. Maybe she doesn't want to bring it up and then have me ask questions about why she has it and where the items came from.

I'll save that for another day.

I grab a pair of her high heels and then pick up my bag from the countertop in the bathroom before I walk into her bedroom.

She lies in bed, her secured wrists underneath her, struggling to get comfortable. I'm going to make it worse. She's going to be crying desperate tears by the time I'm done playing with her.

My pretty little toy.

I slide each heel on and then remove the spreader bar that I slipped under her bed last night after she fell asleep. I've done a lot of shopping for my angel since I saw her at the cathedral.

Grabbing rope from my bag, I wrap it around the heel and up her ankle, then around the bar to make sure she can't kick her shoes off. Then I do the other one, forcing her legs far apart. I want her to be wide open for me.

"Kashton…please," she pants, arching her back. Like this, unable to move her legs, she's even more uncomfortable.

I lean over her face and pull her messy bun out, letting her hair fan the pillow. Her green eyes search mine. "Just me and you," I remind her, and she nods. "I'm going to sit you up." I reach underneath her shoulders and pull her to a sitting position, and she quickly adjusts her arms.

Digging my AirPods out of my pocket, I place them in my ears and go to a song on my cell. When I adjust the volume to my liking, I pull the buds out and stop the song.

I slide them into her ears and then gather her hair at the nape of her neck, securing it in a loose ponytail. Then I slide the spandex hood over her head, and her body begins to tremble in my hands.

I didn't want to use latex; I figured that it would be too much too soon. This is flexible and has no zippers, so her hair won't get caught in it. It covers her chin and down to her neck. There's a hole for her mouth and two small ones for her to breathe through her nose. But the material itself is pretty breathable.

Grabbing the next item I want out of the bag, I rub it against her lips, and she parts them for me. "That's my good girl," I praise, though I'm sure my voice is muffled by the AirPods, even though I haven't started the song yet.

I fasten the ball gag at the back of her head and then gently press on her shoulders for her to lie down.

She whimpers, wiggling on the bed and arching her neck, trying to adjust herself.

I let my eyes take in her body. Her chest is heaving, and her skin already has a sheen to it. I reach over and turn on the pedestal fan, making sure to help cool her down. I was being honest when I told

her this is about pleasing her. I remove the lip gloss that I took from her bathroom, run my fingers through it and then rub it over her pouty lips. It said it has a tingling effect.

I want her confused, overwhelmed with need. Taking away certain senses will heighten others.

Picking up the rubber bands I brought, I open my knife and slice through two of them, cutting them in half. Then I slide one under her left thigh, bringing it around her leg and tying it off.

She whimpers, her leg now shaking as the rubber band pulls tightly on her skin. I repeat it with her other thigh before I trail my fingertips up her trembling leg, making my way to her pussy. My fingers brush her soaked cunt, and I smile. She's ready.

Picking up my cell, I go to the song I want her to listen to, and then I get started.

EVERETT

My lips are burning, and I have the urge to lick them, but I can't because of the gag that fills my mouth. The silence is deafening while I lie here squirming, unable to see, talk, or hear. Hell, I can barely move. I concentrate on getting my breathing under control so I don't panic. The sad part is that I do trust him.

He's different. Yeah, but for how long? He'll eventually show his true colors. Some are just better at hiding it than others.

"Angel" by Camylio starts playing in my ears, and I try to close my legs, fighting against the restraints.

Drool has gathered at the back of my throat, and I swallow it, wishing I could at least beg him to fuck me.

I jump when he touches my stomach, slowly running down over my hips and between my wide-open legs. I suck in a ragged breath when his fingers begin to play with my pussy. I'm dripping for him.

My arms ache and my jaw already hurts from the gag, but I can't help but lift my hips, trying to move my body closer to his touch. Needing more. Why is he being slow? He wasn't the other times. He was rough and needy. That's what I want now.

My legs…something is wrapped around my thighs. It hurts. Pinching me? My hands itch to touch it. To see what it is.

The song begins to play again, and I realize it's on repeat. Is it a sign? Is he trying to tell me something?

I feel his lips on my neck, and I arch it to give him better access, but they're gone too soon. Frustration has my body trembling.

I try to roll my ankles, but he's got them strapped in a set of heels. He likes when I wear them for him.

A finger slides into me, and my breath catches when he pushes in a second at an agonizingly slow rate. When a third enters, I'm begging through the gag, mumbling nonsense. My legs flex against the uncomfortable thing wrapped around my thighs.

I gasp when I feel his teeth bite my nipple, the sting making my pussy clench, but I realize it's not his teeth when the other one stings as well. The cold metal falls to my chest when he links the nipple clamps together.

A cry is ripped from my gagged lips when he slaps my pussy, and I arch my back, twisting and turning in the restraint when he hits it again.

My breath gets stuck in my lungs when he thrusts his fingers into me once again. I want to cry; I need him so badly. The rope pulls on my skin as I fight to close my legs, and my arms have gone numb. If my eyes were open, I'm pretty sure they'd roll back into my head when I feel the vibration on my clit.

A mumbled yelp comes from my burning lips when something pinches my thigh. I gasp for breath when I feel it on the other. A lasting burn lingers, and I wait for it to come again.

I buck my hips, my clit riding the vibration at the same time my legs are stung once more.

There is no warning. Just an orgasm that takes over as my entire body stiffens, and flashes of light blind my covered eyes.

The vibration stops and I try and catch my breath. His hand wraps around my throat, holding my neck down to the bed, and spit flies from the corners of the gag, landing on the mask that covers my face.

I don't care how pathetic I look right now. I'm his desperate angel, begging for a taste of hell. His hand leaves my neck, and then he's grabbing the chain off my chest, pulling on my nipples.

A mumbling sob is all I can give when I arch my back to try and ease the pressure. The vibrating returns between my tied legs and once again, I can't hold back the orgasm that takes my breath away.

I wait for it to stop so I can suck in a ragged breath, but it doesn't. Instead, it slips inside me, and I shake uncontrollably. My thighs tighten and my pussy clenches on the toy.

I can't…not again…

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TWENTY-EIGHT



KASHTON

"Such a good angel," I praise her after she comes a third time.

I lift her head, and it lolls in my hand when I unfasten the buckle, pulling the gag from her lips. Drool drips from it as I toss it to the floor. Then I pull the hood up off her head and lay her back down.

Her eyes are closed, and she's gasping for breath while her body trembles. Removing the AirPods, I hear the song still playing as I throw them onto the bed.

"Hey, pretty angel," I say, running my knuckles down her flushed cheek, over the indentation the strap from the ball gag left. "Open your eyes, Eve. Look at me."

Her heavy lashes flutter a couple of times, trying to open.

"Good girl." I smile at her. "You did so good."

Licking her lips, she tries to readjust herself, but I've still got her arms cuffed behind her back and her legs in the spreader bar. "Please," she begs softly and her heavy eyes fall closed.

She's worn out. Exhausted from coming so hard for me.

I pick up the chain lying across her chest and pull on it, and she cries out. "Want me to stop, angel?"

She nods, sniffling.

"Words." I pull on it more, and her back rises off the bed.

"Please…I can't, Kash…please." Her tear-filled eyes are on mine.

Letting go of the chain, I undo the nipple clamps and then reach between her legs. I turn the vibrator slowly, and she whimpers, her breath hitching. "Know what I want, Eve?"

"Anything," she gasps.

I smile. I always get what I want. "For you to be my date this weekend."

She nods. "Ok-ay."

"Okay what?" I use my free hand and lift the rubber band around her left thigh and let it go. The knotted section where I tied it slaps against her skin, and she cries out. I do it again, and she's trembling. "Okay what?"

"I'll"—deep breath—"be your date."

"Good girl." I lean down and press my lips to hers, and as I expected, she parts them, rising up to meet me with need.

I let go of the vibrator and cup her face, deepening the kiss. Our tongues dance while she moans into my mouth. Fuck, she tastes so good. Like every dark fantasy I've ever had and a shot of hope that maybe I won't have to live this life all alone. That she'll be my forever.

I pull away and remove the vibrator from her pussy. She slumps into the bed with a soft cry, and then I undo her ankles from the spreader bar but leave her heels on.

Quickly, I undress and crawl back between her shaking legs. I spread them wide with mine and slide my hard cock into her with a groan. Lowering my body to hers, I hook my arms behind her knees. "Who do you belong to, angel?" I whisper, slowly rocking my hips back and forth, fucking her soaked cunt.

"You," she answers breathlessly, arching her back.

I lower my lips and gently kiss her neck, feeling her pulse race. "Mine," I promise her. "Come again for me, Eve."

She sucks in a ragged breath. "I can't."

"Yes, you can." I sit up and run my hands over her shaking legs. Grabbing both rubber bands, I pull them from her thighs and let them go.

She cries out, and I smile, loving the bruises already forming on her perfect skin.

"I want my cock covered in my girl's cum," I tell her. Pulling out of her pussy, I slap it, and her body shudders. "Beg me, angel." I do it again, and she's gasping. "Beg me to let you come."

"Please," she whimpers, thrashing underneath me.

"Please what?" I wrap my hand around her throat and gently squeeze.

"Let…me come. I need—"

I cut off her air and slam into her cunt. Her lips part, but her heavy eyes remain on mine as I pick up my pace and fuck her. Our bodies slap and my breathing picks up. She arches her neck, trying to breathe when her pussy clenches down on my pierced cock.

"Good girl." I drop my eyes to watch my cum-covered cock slide from her pussy.

As I release her neck, she gasps and chokes out a cry.

I lean down, sliding my hands into her hair. Grabbing a handful, I yank her head back and lower my lips to her neck. "There's nothing wrong with coming, angel."

Her body continues to shudder underneath mine from her recent orgasm.

"Say it," I demand, pulling back and forcing her heavy eyes on mine. "Tell me you like to come."

"I like"—she sucks in a breath—"to come."

"Tell me you like it when I make you come." I dot soft kisses along her jaw.

"Kash," she gasps, and I smile, dragging my lips down her neck.

Fuck, I will never get enough of her. "Say it," I command. "You will come for me, Eve. Whenever I want, however I want."

"Y-es." She sucks in a deep breath. "However you want."

I slam into her, and she arches her back. This time I don't slow down. I'm so fucking close anyway. Watching my girl get off turns me on so much.

Sitting up, I spread her legs wide and watch my cock fuck her hard and fast. The sound of her cries fills the room, along with the slapping of our bodies and her headboard hitting the wall with each thrust.

"Fuck, angel," I growl when she clenches down on me. Sucking me in when I pull back.

I'm gasping and she's trembling when I slam forward one last time and come inside her. I kiss her parted lips before I slide out and get out of bed to grab the key to the handcuffs.

She immediately pulls her legs up, bending her knees and rolling to her side to relieve her arms. I pull the key to the cuffs from my pocket and undo them. Then I cut both rubber bands around her thighs before jumping back on the bed and pulling her onto my lap while I lean up against the headboard.

She begins to softly cry, and I cradle her to me, pushing her wild hair from her slick face. "You did so good, angel. So fucking good for me. I'm so proud of you."

Her body trembles in my arms, and I lean down, kissing her head. "You're okay." I try soothing her. "You're beautiful, Eve. My angel." I want to keep her here with me because this is when she's going to doubt herself and what she felt. This is where she'll drop, and it'll be hard to pull her back up.

"Look at me." I push her hair from her face. "Come on, Eve. Eyes on me," I order more forcefully.

Her watery lashes flutter open and she glances up at me. "There are those pretty eyes. How do you feel?"

"Cold," she whispers, shivering.

Coming down off that high can be rough. She's covered in sweat, and I have the fan on. I reach over and yank the end of the comforter and pull it up to cover her. "Better?" I ask.

"Thank you."

"Get some rest, angel," I tell her and watch her lashes fall to her cheeks once more.

EVERETT

I open my eyes to see I'm in my bed alone. The comforter has been ripped away, but I'm covered in a warm blanket.

Everything hurts. I feel like I've been on a three-day drinking bender and have woken up in a back alleyway by the dumpsters. Very specific, I know. I've been there before in Vegas. I had to call Adam to come get me. He said it was amazing that I hadn't been kidnapped and killed. I didn't tell him that I had tried before and was unsuccessful. I'm pretty sure he already knew about my past by that time.

Sitting up, I look around and see it's light outside. How long have I been out? Minutes? Hours? Days?

There's a bottle of water on the nightstand with two Advil and a note that says Take these and drink this.

I want to write back and tell him to go to hell. Instead, I guzzle the water and take the pills. Getting to my feet, I stumble to the bathroom. Fuck, places on my body I didn't even know existed hurt.

After using the bathroom, I push my back into the wall and slide down it to sit by the toilet.

I feel sick.

Disgusted with myself. Why can't I control it?

I don't blame Kashton. I blame myself. It's my body. I should be able to deny it what it wants. I've done it for years now. I shouldn't want to be his pathetic plaything.

My eyeline drops to my thighs, and I see the bruises. They wrap all the way around, and then there's a bigger one in the center. What did he have on my legs? I see the ones wrapped around my wrists, and they look just as bad.

You're a fucking whore.

That bile rises, and I swallow it down as my eyes begin to sting.

You're nothing but a fucking useless whore.

"No," I say, leaning forward to bring my knees up and place my head on them. My fingers dig into my hair, pinching my scalp, trying to drown out his voice, but it's no use.

The devil demands to be heard. Even if he whispers into your ear for only you to hear.

Sixteen years old

I'm sitting in my bed when my bedroom door opens. I scramble to my feet when I see who enters. He slams the door shut and locks it.

"No…please." I run for my bathroom door, trying to put more space between us, but he's faster.

Just as my hand wraps around the doorknob, his fingers fist in my hair, and he yanks me back against his front.

I scream, kicking my legs out and digging my nails into his forearm. His other hand slaps over my mouth and nose, cutting off my air as his fingers dig into my skin.

"You think they give a fuck if you scream?" He laughs, dragging me back over to the bed. "They're just waiting for their turn."

He throws me onto the mattress, and I suck in a burning breath as I crawl across it. He yanks me back by my ankle and pins me down with his heavy weight, shoving my face into the bed.

When I no longer have the strength to fight him, he turns me over, and I blink my blurry vision away while I cough and choke, sucking in air.

He stands at the end of the bed, unzipping his jeans. "Now let's see if the hormones that bitch has you on are working." He slaps me, and I lie before him, taking it, knowing there is no escape from this hell.

He's the roughest. He just likes to beat women. They are nothing to him. Grabbing my ankle, he pulls me off the bed and onto the floor, knocking what little wind I had left out of me.

"Whores get fucked on the floor." He chuckles. Then he flips me over onto my stomach and pulls my arms behind my back, where he holds them in a tight grip that will leave me bruised. "Don't you dare fucking come. This isn't about you, you stupid bitch."

Silent tears fall down my face when he spreads my legs with his and the sound of my screaming fills the room over his grunts.

"Eve?"

My hands are grabbed and pulled from my hair. "No." I kick my legs out, shoving him away.

"Eve." Hands grip my face and force me to focus on what's in front of me. "Hey, angel." Kashton speaks softly; his pretty blue eyes are full of concern while they search mine. "You're okay. I'm here."

My shoulders fall, and I bury my face in my hands, trying to hide from him. Unable to look him in the eyes.

In a perfect world, he would love me.

In a perfect world, the Lords wouldn't exist.

In a perfect world, I'd get to know what it feels like to be special.

But this isn't a perfect world. Monsters do exist. They drive expensive cars and have a crest branded into their chests, and I will never know what it feels like to be loved.

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TWENTY-NINE



KASHTON

I ’ve spent the last two days with Eve at her house. She’s been quiet. Standoffish. But it doesn’t bother me. After I found her sitting on the bathroom floor, I picked her up and carried her to bed. She let me hold her for an hour while she cried, then it was like a switch had been flipped, and she wanted nothing to do with me.

Saint and Haidyn have been blowing up my phone. I told them I’m away taking care of something and that I’ll see them at the reception tonight.

Eve seems to be herself again—hating me. Like I give a fuck. I feel a little hatred is a good foundation for a relationship. If she doesn’t want to kill me daily, then I don’t want it.

A woman like Everett needs to be challenged, and I’m more than willing to do that. I can get her past the hatred and self-doubt she hides when no one is looking.

It will just take time and reassurance. She spent last night downstairs in the basement in her rage room breaking shit, and I let her. I haven’t tried to touch her sexually since I found her crying. Even I know you can’t rush these things. She needs to work through her feelings. It was the first time she hadn’t thrown up after I fucked her. Baby steps.

I pull up to her house and get out of my car, grabbing what I need from my passenger seat. I left this morning to go pick up some things she’s going to need. Entering, I hear “Never Too Late” by Three Days Grace blaring from her bedroom.

Making my way down the hall, I walk in, placing the bags on her bed, and stop in the doorway of her bathroom, silently watching her

stand at the counter, looking at herself in the mirror. She didn't hear me enter over the music.

She's getting ready for our date. It's my first time announcing her as mine to our world. No one knows that we're going together. I want to see how they react to my girl. That way I can make sure to keep her from the ones who seem threatened after what they've been told.

I openly gawk at what's mine without shame. Her hair is fixed in a bun at the nape of her neck, just like it was the night I saw her on the *Isabella*. Seeing it gives me a pain in my chest. Those six years without her feel wasted. Would things be different if I had not let her run from me that night? I'll never know. But a part of me tells me that what we could have had and what our future holds are two very different things.

The song comes to an end and "Wonderland" by Natalia Kills begins to play. She turns to walk into her bedroom but stops when she sees me blocking the doorway.

Her eyes immediately drop to the floor, and my hands fist at how her reaction is to avert her gaze. I want to put a posture collar around her delicate neck so she has to keep her head up and eyes on mine at all times. She makes herself small, and I don't understand why.

The woman is a walking contradiction. She's so strong and feisty in some aspects of her life and the complete opposite in others.

It's her training. Something that was probably beaten into her. No amount of time can change that mentality.

I enter the bathroom and place my hand under her chin, forcing her head up. My eyes look over her perfect face. She's got thin black liner around her gorgeous eyes, making the green pop. Her lips are a nude glossy color and her cheeks a light pink. Her lashes are painted black with a shimmering shadow.

She's stunning.

"How long have you been standing there?" she asks.

"Long enough." I answer

She huffs, looking away, and I drop my hand. "Come here." I pull her into the bedroom.

She glances at the garment bag lying across her bed, and I pick up her phone, turning off the music so we can hear each other talk. "What is this for?"

"It's your dress for tonight."

Looking up at me, she gives me a death glare that I much prefer to the sadness. "Kashton, I don't need you to get me a dress."

"I know." I couldn't resist. I want everyone to know she's my girl tonight. She'll be on my arm, wearing my dress. Soon she'll have my last name and will be wearing my ring.

Reaching down, I unzip the bag and remove the contents, holding it out for her to see.

She swallows nervously while looking over it.

"I'll give you a moment." I lay the dress down and then kiss her forehead before stepping out of her room and closing the door behind me.

EVERETT

I stare down at the royal-blue dress, conflicted. It's beautiful, but it's a way of making me his doll—dressing me how he wants. Just to parade me around to his brothers. Show off what he's been playing with.

It makes me want to vomit. But isn't this what I've wanted? To belong to someone?

I'm confused. Torn between wanting to be alone and wanting to be someone's world.

I keep reminding myself that he's not like the others. He holds me afterward. He assures me that he's proud of me. But then again, it could simply be another form of manipulation. I feel like I'm going insane with my intense mood swings and inconsistent thoughts.

Sitting down next to it, I run my sweaty hands over my shaking thighs. I could skip the reception. I mean, they're already married; why even have this party?

But my father deserves my attention. He's done so much for me. I owe him. He doesn't want to hide me—his words. And although I'm proud of being his daughter, it's still hard to accept.

Deciding, I know what I have to do. I tell myself that this has to be done. Kashton told me his friends think I'm the one putting their

wives in danger.

I might be a lot of things, but I'm not a threat to their Ladies.

If I hide, it'll be like telling them they're right. I refuse to let them believe that. I'd never hurt them. I've been the innocent one forced into a world that only saw me as a toy to use.

Therefore, I'm going to show my face, hold my head high, and let them see who the fuck I am. No more hiding. No more being known as a nobody.

I'm a fucking somebody. *Yeah, Kashton's toy.*

Picking up the dress, I pull it on and stand in front of the mirror. I run my hands down the silk fabric and feel a sense of pride.

I'll be *his*, but also, there will be no going back after this.

I want to laugh at that thought. Like I ever stood a chance of getting away from him. Maybe I don't want to. I like that he plays with me. That he can't get enough of me.

Being Kashton's toy and being a doll are two different things, right? One feels good and the other was a death sentence.

It's just afterward that I've got to train my mind to understand. The doubt and falling back into my own head. It's a dark place that I can't dig myself out of sometimes. I was raised to not enjoy sex—it was only for the men's pleasure. Then my father sold me to Dollhouse, and that was an entirely different type of hell. You're forced to enjoy it. They want your body to turn on you.

I wasn't lying to Kashton. I love when he forces me to come. It takes away having to think about it. But afterward, shame fills me because I enjoy it.

The door opens and I turn to face him. Kashton comes to a stop, shoving his hands into his dress slacks. He looks so handsome in a black suit and royal-blue silk tie. It matches the color of my dress perfectly. He's what dreams are made of. If I were a princess and he were a prince, we'd sail off into the sunset and live happily ever after. But I'm well aware that's not how our story will go. Although I'm willing to pretend for him.

His blue eyes rake over my body, and when they meet mine, he walks toward me. "It's missing something."

My stomach drops, and I nervously shuffle from foot to foot. He's changed his mind. He no longer wants to be seen with me. Kashton's finally realized I'm too damaged. Even for him. And he doesn't even know the real me…what I've been through.

Fuck, I need a drink. Picking up the dress, I go to step out of the room, but he grabs my arms and stops me with a frown. I let go of my dress and stay where I'm at, waiting to see what he meant.

He removes a box from the top of my dresser, and I wonder how long it's been there. He hands it to me.

I glance at him, and his eyes give nothing away. Just a blank canvas of blue sky. They're pretty enough to get lost in. I've never gotten to stand on a beach and look over the ocean with the sun shining down on me, but when I look into his eyes, I imagine it'd be the same. I'm just missing the sand between my toes and the smell of saltwater.

Taking the box, my fingers shake as I nervously untie the GRAFF ribbon and open it to reveal a diamond necklace. It sparkles against the black felt that it lies on. "It's beautiful."

"The Classic Butterfly Diamond necklace." He smiles proudly.

"Butterfly?" My wide eyes meet his.

"You have a butterfly tattoo." His smile falters with doubt. "I just figured you liked them."

Swallowing the knot in my throat, I nod. "I do."

"Allow me." He holds his hand out, and I turn, giving him my back. He fastens it around my neck before I face him.

"Is this a way for you to claim me?" I ask, reaching up and running my fingers over the diamonds. "Collar me for all to see?"

He tilts his head to the side in thought. "Is that such a bad thing? To belong to me?"

"No," I say breathlessly, hating how good that sounds. I have a feeling this will mean more than the forty-eight hours he made me his.

Kashton picks up another sack that's on the dresser, and I see *Beauvince* written on it. I swallow nervously. "You didn't—"

"I did," he interrupts me, giving me a smile that lights up his handsome face and shows off two dimples. Fuck, it makes me weak in

the knees. Pulling a box out, he opens it for me, and I gasp.

"Kashton." My eyes go from the diamonds to his and then back to it.

"Beauvince Eloise diamond bracelet," he explains, removing it from the box. "It consists of round, marquise, and pear-shaped diamonds." Kashton then wraps it around my wrist, fastening the two locks. I blink as he goes back to the sack. "There's more?"

"Two. One for each wrist." He places the second one on and slides them over the bruises that the handcuffs left from the last time I let him touch me. "Our little secret," he whispers.

I swallow against the knot that returns and look away from him. "Why?" I can't help but whisper.

"I just want to spoil you."

His words are innocent, and I hate that I believe him. That he may not have an agenda. Maybe he does want to spoil me. The thought also enters my mind that his love language is gift giving and I'm nothing special—he gives every woman he fucks gifts.

"You look stunning, Eve." Kashton takes in my appearance with a long, slow once-over. His heated eyes burn my skin.

I hate that butterflies fill my stomach. Life isn't supposed to be like this for me. I'm not the girl someone marries. Or loves, for that matter. I'm the whore they fuck. The one they use. I don't receive gifts. No one puts in that kind of effort for me. I don't want to be the stupid girl who gets attached only for him to leave me. I've survived a lot, but I'm not sure I could survive that kind of loss.

He places his fingers under my chin and lifts my head. His lips softly touch mine, and I kiss him back before he pulls away. "Ready?"

I take a shaky breath at the loaded question. This is more than us hiding out in my house where no one can find us. "Yeah. I just need to grab my purse."

He nods, letting go of me, and I walk into my bathroom and closet, trying to calm my breathing. I take a second to collect my thoughts before I grab my Christian Louboutin clutch off the shelf, ready to go.

This is it.

We pull up to the valet in front of the mansion, and a man opens his door and another gets mine. I step out and wait for Kashton to walk around to me. He keeps my hand in his as we make our way up the steps and inside. There are two men dressed in tuxedos standing in the grand foyer. They greet us as two more enter, telling us to follow them.

We walk through the house and to the ballroom. I spot his brothers at a round table immediately. You can't miss them. They're the outcasts of the Lords. The majority of Lords run multibillion-dollar companies. The Spade brothers run their hell—a dungeon full of torture devices.

I keep my head high, but my heart is pounding at the feeling of so many eyes on me. I see Ashtyn leaning into Saint, speaking into his ear. I bet she's asking, *Who is that woman with Kashton?*

Saint shakes his head, not having an answer, and she sits back in her chair. She looks me up and down, eyes full of judgment. I want to laugh. She's the last one who should judge anyone.

Haidyn and Saint both stand as we approach the table. Kashton releases my hand as he brings each of the guys in for a hug. I straighten my shoulders and take a deep breath. I'm not someone who makes themselves small in a room full of people; not anymore. I demand to be seen and heard. So I'm going to make sure they know who the fuck I am.

Saint turns to me first and Kashton introduces me. "Guys, this is Everett. Eve, these are my brothers, Haidyn and Saint."

"Hello. It's nice to meet you." I shake Saint's hand.

He looks me up and down before I turn my attention to Haidyn. He also shakes my hand, and I wish the floor would swallow me up. "Nice to meet you." He nods and then turns to sit down next to his wife, dismissing me.

He doesn't recognize you, Eve. It's in your head.

Kashton pulls out my seat and takes my hand to help me sit. I take a deep breath as the guys introduce me to their wives. Charlotte

looks so innocent and sweet. Just like she is. Ashtyn looks like she wants to murder me. The feeling is mutual.

She had everything. Four men who loved and would do anything for her, and she threw it away. In the end, she lost the baby anyway. Even I know that the Spade brothers would have protected it just like they did her. If you ask me, she had choices and she chose wrong.

Saint deserves better.

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THIRTY



KASHTON

I hold Eve's hand under the table, resting on her thigh. I can feel her crossed legs bounce.

She's not used to getting out. Eve prefers to be in the dark cemetery or a smoky bar. She's front and center here with me. A woman on display in the middle of a crowd. I might as well have tied her to this table and branded my name across her forehead.

Everyone keeps looking our way, staring at her. Probably trying to figure out who the fuck this gorgeous woman is.

Mine.

That's all they need to fucking know. I saw her staring at the bruises that the handcuffs left, so I bought her something to cover them up. It turns me on that we're the only two who know they exist and how they got there. Same goes for the ones on her thighs from the rubber bands. No one knows my girl needs a little pain to get off, and I will keep it that way.

She sips her champagne, and I know she's dying for a shot of vodka or whiskey.

"Anyone seen Tyson?" Saint asks the table.

"No," Haidyn answers before turning to say something to his wife.

"They're running a little late." I feel Eve stiffen when Ashtyn speaks. "Lake messaged me twenty minutes ago."

Adam told me that Eve was in Vegas helping him spy on Ashtyn, but Eve doesn't know that I'm aware of that.

I know what I saw the few weeks that Saint and I were there spying on Ashtyn. It makes me wonder what Eve saw. Did she dance at Glass? Was she working as a Queen at Kingdom?

Adam is so deep in another world that I can't help but think Eve was too. Especially now that I know what she does for Adam. He asked her if the guy the other night had raped her. How many have succeeded? How close has she been to death because she's willing to put her life on the line to take out one piece of shit?

She has to quit. There's no ifs, ands, or buts about it. I love how fierce she is, but at some point, she's got to step back. I can't have her out here risking her life.

My wife will be at home, waiting for me to return from a long day of work. Not out and half naked in a run-down motel with another man who thinks he's going to get lucky.

Call it sexist if you want; it is what it is. She's fucking mine. I've claimed her, and I will take care of mine in every aspect of her life. I don't want her sexting another Lord in hopes of setting him up so she can shoot the bastard.

"There you are," Saint says, and I look up to see Tyson and Laikyn step up to the table.

"Sorry." Lake gives a nervous smile, dropping her hand to her growing belly.

"What's up, bitches?" Sin walks up to the table with Ellington, and I let go of Eve's hand to greet him.

Elli glares at me like I'm still the most hated person on her long list. I introduce her to Eve when she says. "We've met." Her voice is flat, but she smiles at Eve as they strike up a conversation about their dresses.

At least she likes her.

We've been here for over an hour. Bill made a toast to his wife and thanked us all for coming. I kept my eyes on Sin the entire time. He seems to be accepting his new stepfather better than he was when he first found out. Either he's decided to kill the man in his sleep or he's going to let his mother be happy. Only time will tell.

Everett gets my attention when she stands from her seat. I do the same, taking her hand. "Everything okay?"

She frowns but answers. "I need to use the restroom."

"I'll take you." I escort her out of the ballroom and down the hallway.

"Kash, I know where the restroom is." Eve gives a small laugh, and I ignore her.

She's my girl. My responsibility. I'm not going to leave her alone here. Or anywhere, for that matter. Bill kept it on the smaller side and only invited around a hundred Lords to the reception. How many among those here have seen her on the Dollhouse videos that Adam and Bill are searching for? How many have raped her that she doesn't remember? I won't take that chance.

Stopping in front of the door, I push it open for her.

She places her hands on my face and leans in, giving me a quick thank-you kiss, then disappears into the women's restroom.

I don't think she meant to do it, but I'll take it. She's coming around to the idea of us.

Leaning against the wall next to the door, I shove my hands into the pockets of my dress slacks. A Lord walks down the hallway and nods at me, and I do the same. His dark eyes slide to the women's bathroom before he enters the door across from me for the men's.

Everett exits and I push away. I take her hand, and we return to the ballroom in silence. The only people at our table are Saint and Ashtyn. They're in their chairs facing one another and look like they are in a deep conversation.

I feel Eve slow down, and I decide to head to the dance floor instead. I don't know anything about her and Ashtyn, but I want to keep them separated until I do. I'm going to defend my girl, no matter the situation between them.

"What are we doing?" she whispers in my ear.

Pulling her to the center, I turn to face her. "Dancing," I answer.

She lets out a huff before her green eyes quickly scan the room.

EVERETT

"I Found" by Amber Run filters through the speakers in the ballroom as Kashton takes my hands.

I'm nervous. Afraid all eyes will be on us.

"Eyes on me, angel," Kashton says softly in my ear.

Looking at him, a calmness washes over me. It shouldn't be like this. Him and me. I tell myself I'm supposed to hate him, but even I know my past isn't his fault.

Every woman here tonight is a Lord's whore. Each one might church it up as a Lady, but she still belongs to him. He'll decide tonight if his cock is the only one that fucks her.

I have to remind myself that I'm not Kashton's Lady. I can walk away at any time if I want. This isn't a death sentence. It's fun and harmless.

For now.

How long until it turns deadly? Everything with the Lords does eventually. I'm not new to this.

"Eve?"

"Hmm?" I blink.

Kashton gives me a smile, pulling me closer with his arm tightening around my waist. Goose bumps break out along my exposed skin. "Let it go, angel," he whispers in my ear. "Whatever it is…I'm right here."

He reads me so well. I was never able to hide. My face shows my emotions all too well. Is "I'm right here" supposed to mean something? I can't allow myself to let my guard down. Not like he wants. It's not who I am. Too many years of abuse and manipulation have taught me to never trust another person. No matter how much I crave that.

I've always wanted someone to put me first. To let me shut off my mind and lead me. But I know how that ends—me in chains and drugged. I'm an adult, so I have to step up and do it myself.

The song comes to an end, and he kisses my cheek before he pulls me off the dance floor. He strikes up a conversation with Sin while we make our way back to the table, but I spot my father. "I'll be right there," I announce and pull away from Kashton before he can stop me.

"Eve." Bill smiles at me as I approach.

I walk right into his open arms and feel a knot form in my throat. *They're not all bad.*

"Hello, Dad," I say, pulling away. "Where is Janice?" I ask quickly, glancing around. I notice that Kashton didn't return to the table. Instead, he's standing right where I left him, still talking to Sin. His eyes on me.

"She went to the restroom."

I frown. Must have just missed her.

"I know she'd love to speak to you," he adds. "She also wants to get some photos of all of us together."

Photos? I've never taken family photos before. It feels so weird to be a part of this. To be included in something so simple yet important at the same time. "Of course," I tell him.

"I see you're here with Kashton," he says, looking over my shoulder at him behind me.

"Yeah," I say nervously. Not like I can hide it. This is what Kash wanted to do—parade me around as his. Show me off.

Bill's eyes find mine and his smile grows. "It's okay to be happy, Eve."

My pulse races at his words, but a man walks up behind him, and my dad turns to greet him.

"Father." My body goes rigid at the sound of the voice, and I drop my eyes to the floor.

"What the fuck are you doing here?" Bill growls softly, stepping in front of me.

"I'm assuming my invitation was lost in the mail."

"You're assuming wrong. Leave."

"Hey, sis." I look up at him as he sidesteps Bill. "It's been too long." The Lord goes to step toward me, but Bill places a hand on his chest, stopping him.

"Get the fuck out of here, or I'll have you killed where you stand," Bill threatens. When the Lord doesn't respond, he adds, "We had a deal."

I frown. What deal is he talking about?

His dark eyes go from mine to Bill's before returning to mine. "I'll be seeing you." With that, he turns and walks off the dance floor.

Bill faces me, placing his hands on my upper arms, and I jump. He drops them immediately. "Eve, I didn't know—"

"It's fine," I interrupt him. My dad has no clue that the Lord made an appearance at my house the other night, and I want to keep it that way.

Taking a quick look over my shoulder, I see Kashton heading straight for us. His eyes on the back of the Lord disappearing into the crowd. I look at my dad and speak quickly. "I need a favor."

"Anything."

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THIRTY-ONE



KASHTON

Eve sits next to me at the table. She's gone silent. I was deep in conversation with Sin when I looked up to see a man walking away from Bill and Eve. It was the same one I saw outside the bathroom while I was waiting on her.

Her father was standing in front of her in a protective way, and I rushed over to them. She hasn't said one word to me since. I haven't asked what happened, but I will as soon as we get back to her place.

My phone is sitting on the table by my plate when I see it light up.

UNKNOWN: 911. Meeting at Blackout afterward.

It's a group chat text. Even if I didn't see Saint pull his cell out of his suit jacket or Haidyn reading his, all of their numbers are included.

It must be serious, but there's no specific time. How do they know when we're done here?

I lean back in my chair and reach out, throwing my arm over Eve's shoulders and don't miss the fuck-you look Ashtyn is giving my girl from across the round table. I just stare at her, and after a few seconds, her eyes find mine. She straightens her shoulders and puts her attention on Ellington, striking up a conversation.

It makes me wonder if what Adam said was wrong and Ashtyn does know Eve. What other reason would she have for the death stare?

I don't know what's going on there, but I'm going to take care of it.

"Everett." Janice comes up to the table and greets her.

"Hi, Janice." Eve stands and pulls her in for a hug. No one but me can tell Eve's uncomfortable. She's not used to affection of any kind, and I hate that. I'm going to shower my girl with it. "You look stunning. Your dress is gorgeous."

"Thank you. Bill said he told you I wanted to take some photos." She takes Eve's hand. A sign she's not going to take no for an answer. "The photographer is ready, if you have a moment."

"Of course." Eve gives her a nod, but I know that's the last thing she wants to do right now.

I stand, and she frowns. There's no way I'm not getting in on these pictures. I'm going to marry into this family, after all.

"Easton, Ellington," Janice calls to them. "We're ready."

I open the passenger door for her, and as she goes to get in, I grab the hem of her dress to help her. "Thank you," she says before I shut her door.

I get into the driver's side and start up the car. "We've got to stop by Blackout. But it shouldn't take long."

"Okay." She nods, looking out the window.

We took some pictures and then went back to the table and sat there. Everyone laughed and held conversations except for her.

She remains quiet while we make our way to the club. Ryat is driving Blakely's SUV in front of me, and I can see Haidyn in his car behind us. Something is going on, but we still don't know what it is.

We pull into the back parking lot as everyone else joins us. Making our way into Blackout, the Lords kiss their wives and tell them this shouldn't take long as they leave them on the first floor to mingle and talk.

I turn to face Eve to tell her I'll be right back, but she speaks before I can.

"I'm going to use the restroom." Then she turns and walks off down the hall, and I make my way to Ty's office.

EVERETT

I enter the bathroom, pull out my lipstick, and reapply it. Taking a piece of paper towel, I blot my lips and then run my fingers over the

necklace, knowing what it represents. That I'm the property of a Spade brother.

Taking a deep breath, I tell myself they need to see the real me. The one who isn't afraid to be in a room full of men. I won't bow my head again for a Lord. No matter who he is.

Making my way up in the elevator, I exit and walk across the breezeway and enter the room.

The chatter comes to a halt and all eyes land on mine.

"The Ladies are downstairs," Alex says with a laugh.

I hold up my left hand to show I'm not wearing a wedding ring. "Good thing I'm no one's Lady." Slamming the door shut, I lean back against it.

Every man in the room looks at Tyson, who's sitting at his desk. They expect him to tell me to leave, but he's staring at Kashton. It's comical how all heads swivel to look at him next. The silence lingers. They're waiting to see if the guy I'm fucking is going to pick me up, throw me over his shoulder, and carry me out of the room. Kash sits back and smirks. He's curious to see how this plays out.

"Well, speak up," Tyson starts. "Who called this meeting?"

"I did," I answer.

"You?" Saint frowns and then looks at Kashton, but he doesn't say anything. He didn't know. "How did you manage to get us all here?"

"Called in a favor." It's that easy. Bill was more than willing to help me out after he saw how stressed I was over our encounter. "There was a man there tonight, and you guys need to be aware of him."

"Old boyfriend?" Alex asks with a chuckle. "I'm sure Kash can take care of him."

"His name is Evan. About six three, jet-black hair, dark eyes."

"Do you know him?" Saint wonders. "Personally?"

This is my chance to be honest. What I know and what I'm going to tell them will ruin any chance I have with Kashton. Maybe it's what I should have done from the beginning to get him out of my life. Self-sabotage. It was fun while it lasted. "He's Bill's son. And my brother."

Silence once again as everyone looks at me like I've got two heads.

"Your father is Bill?" Ryat finally asks.

Guess Sin has kept my secret from most of the Lords. "Yes…no."

He scratches the back of his neck. "I'm confused. You just said—"

"Do you think Isabella was Bill's first wife?" I interrupt Ryat, shaking my head. "Sin's mother is his third."

"Wait." Tyson holds up his hand. "I'm getting confused too. Make it simple and explain it to us."

I inhale. "My mother got pregnant with Evan—Bill's son—their senior year of high school. He went into initiations the following year at Barrington. They ended up marrying their senior year after he was officially a Lord. That's when she was given her assignment, and she failed."

"So what happened to her?" Saint asks.

"She became a breeder."

"What's a breeder?" Finn asks.

I look at Haidyn. "Do you want to explain it, or would you rather I do it?"

He narrows his eyes on me, and I give him a smile, turning my attention to the rest of the Lords in the room. "My mother was a founder. And when a founder fails her assignment, she is given to the Lords as a breeder."

"You're a founder." Saint's words are more of a surprise than a question.

I look at Kashton and confirm. "Yes." And I don't miss the way his jaw sharpens. He wants to know things about me? Here's a little something.

"What's your assignment?" Saint demands.

"I don't have one."

"Bullshit." He stands.

Kashton jumps to his feet, grabbing Saint's arm. "Sit the fuck down," Kashton warns him.

Saint huffs, rips his arm from Kashton's hold, and falls back onto the couch. "Charlotte had an assignment, and it was Haidyn." He barks at Kashton. "Sorry if I don't believe her."

Ryat leans forward, placing his elbows on his knees. "Bill told us that nothing is set in stone and the Lords can change the course of a founder. That's why some of our wives didn't have to complete an

assignment for their initiation." He nods to me. "So why do the Lords not want to give you one?"

"Because I'm useless to them." My simple answer makes everyone frown. "We all must serve," I go on, knowing I'll have to explain myself. I'm in a room full of grown-ass men who kill without question but can't understand what a woman has to say. "Their logic behind making you go without sex for three years is because they don't want you knocking up random women who aren't approved by their standards. That's why, for the most part, your parents designated your chosen and your marriages are arranged. It's to guarantee those at the top remain at the top. Forged empires." They all look at me without an ounce of understanding. I want to roll my eyes, but instead I add, "I can't have children."

"Did Gavin or Devin tell you that? I'd get a second opinion." Alex looks over at Kashton. "I have faith in you, Kash. Try harder." He laughs at his own words.

"I was sterilized at the age of eighteen."

Alex's laugher dies and his face goes pale. "I'm sor—"

"There is no 'try harder' or 'second opinion.' I can't contribute to the society. Therefore, I'm useless and will not be given an assignment to prove I'm worthy of a Lord." Especially a Spade brother. They are too important to be given a useless Lady.

"What does Evan do for the Lords?" Saint asks, moving on. He knows that what his brother and I are doing is just temporary.

This is where things are going to get tricky. If I tell them what he does, I'll have to explain it to them, but I already knew I'd have to tell them everything. "He's a trainer."

"Like a gym rat?" Alex chuckles. "Maybe Haidyn can show him a few things."

Everyone laughs, and I shake my head. "No, he trains men and women for Dollhouse."

The room falls silent at the mention of Dollhouse.

"He worked for Isabella?" Haidyn growls.

I nod. "He did."

"Not to sound insensitive, but what kind of training could a sex slave need?" Colton wonders.

"They pride themselves on having the best, and in order to achieve that…he takes them in—around-the-clock training is required."

"So he fucks them?"

I shake my head. "He doesn't need to."

"I don't understand," Tyson growls, obviously confused and irritated.

"Give us an example," Saint says.

I let out a sigh, hoping they don't see my discomfort. I walked into this room knowing how it would go. I'm fully committed. They need to know to stay the fuck away from him. To keep their wives away from him. I may be placing myself on a chopping block here, but it's for the greater good. The women they marry are the ones I fight to protect. "He takes a woman, places a dildo in her ass and a vibrator in her pussy. He ties her to a chair and plays the most depraved porn you can think of."

"I don't understand. How is this training?" Finn scratches his head.

"He shoots them up with hormones as they watch women get fucked while they are forced to come all over themselves. It's making them think that what they see and feel is okay. It makes them crave to serve."

"He grooms them," Kashton states, and I can't make eye contact with him.

"It is a process with intermittent reinforcements. Submissive and cerebral conditioning," I add. They don't just want your body begging; they want your mind to beg as well.

"So brainwashing," Kashton says, correcting his previous statement.

"And he makes money by doing this?" Sin observes.

I nod. "Yes. He is given the victims. Then is paid once they are sold."

"How do you know all this?" Haidyn asks me.

"I told you—Bill is our dad, and Evan's been working with Isabella for years." I shrug. "I know Isabella is now *gone* and women are showing up tortured and dead. I'm not saying he's involved, but common sense tells me he might know who is."

"You think he's running Dollhouse?" Haidyn is the one who asks. "Took over for Isabella?"

"No. It's shut down," Sin answers before I can speak.

"Maybe we should go look for ourselves." Ryat shrugs and glances at me. "Are you guys close?"

"No," I lie. Closer than I'd like to be. "And neither is Bill. They haven't spoken in years as far as I know."

"But he was there tonight," Ryat reminds us.

I nibble on my lip as if in thought, trying to decide how to respond to that. "Word gets around fast, and there were about a hundred people there tonight. He could have been informed of the party by anyone."

"It was invite only," Haidyn says skeptically.

"Maybe he is still in contact with him and he was the guy who helped Bill locate you at Dollhouse. Bill said he had someone on the inside," Sin says to Haidyn, and I drop my eyes to my heels.

"I guess it's possible," Haidyn nods. "But why would he help Bill get me out of there?"

"Do you ever see him? Other than tonight?" Ryat looks at me.

"No."

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THIRTY-TWO



KASHTON

We ride back to her house in silence. I let everything she said back at Blackout sink in.

She's a founder and admitted to being sterilized. Sex training and grooming. My girl revealed a lot about herself, but the question is, why now? Why did she do it in front of a room full of Lords before telling me personally? Does she think they'll try and keep me from her? If so, she doesn't know me at all.

Pulling up to her house, I get out, and she waits to let me open the car door for her. Once we get to her porch, I take her keys and unlock the front door.

She mumbles a *thank you*, and I enter the house behind her, shutting the door. "Why did you lie to them?"

Eve comes to a stop, her back to me, and I watch her stiffen in her tight dress. "Excuse me?" She turns to face me.

I take the few steps, closing the short distance, and cup her face. "You lied to them." My girl is so easy to read when you know what to look for. "You've seen him recently. So one last time: Why did you lie?"

Her eyes search mine before she takes a step back, and my hand falls to my side. "I didn't."

"Eve," I growl.

She turns to walk away from me, but I grab her upper arm and spin her around once again. This time I hold her in place with both hands wrapped around her upper arms. "You know how he trains them because you were one of them, right?"

She swallows, and I feel her body start to shake against mine.

"You were on the *Isabella* that night I saw you. That man was going to rape you. You were trained to be a whore." I'm not going to tell her that Adam has filled me in on her past. As much as he knew anyway. I want her to tell me. To open up to me on a personal level. My girl needs to trust me with her life.

Her eyes harden, and she rips her arms from my hold. "Leave, Kashton."

"Eve—"

"Fucking leave," she screams.

"Did Evan rape you or did he wait for you to beg him to fuck you?"

She slaps me across the face and then slams her fists into my chest, pushing me a step back. "Get the fuck out." Eve shoves me again.

I raise my hands and take a step back. Her reaction tells me all I need to know. Why she acted the way she did after we had sex. Why Adam told her he was proud of her when he found out she'd had sex with me. Evan trained her and made her feel good, and she hates herself because he's her half brother.

"Eve, I can protect you." Who knows what he's done to her or how often he does it.

"I don't need you, Kashton." She gives a rough laugh.

"Then tell me what you need, and I'll give it to you." Knowing about her past doesn't change a damn thing. If anything, it shows me how much she needs me.

She turns, grabs a half-empty bottle of whiskey, and throws it at my head.

I duck and it hits the wall, shattering, "Get the fuck out of my house!" she screams, charging toward me.

I allow her to push me out because I have somewhere else to be right now. Something important that I need to take care of.

She slams the door in my face as I stand on the brightly lit porch, and I hear the front door lock. Turning, I scan the neighborhood, wondering if he's watching her. Does he know I'm fucking her? Does he punish her for sleeping with me? Is that part of his plan? Why won't she talk to me? She told a room full of Lords about Evan and

what he does. Why? She had to have known I'd catch on. That I knew enough to connect the dots.

I get in my car, turn it on, and rev my engine before I take off.

I pull up to Sin's parents' house and see Bill's Rolls-Royce Wraith in the driveway. They took a two-week honeymoon and traveled the world before their reception tonight. I don't know if he's trying to wine and dine her or what, but the woman came from money. And since we took in her husband at Carnage, she was left everything.

I enter the house without knocking on the door and slam it shut. The reception is over, and cleaners are working on removing everything from the party.

A short woman in a traditional black-and-white maid uniform runs toward me. "Sir? Sir, may I help you?"

"Kashton." Sin's mother smiles at me, also entering the grand foyer.

"I'm looking for Bill," I say, not bothering with chitchat.

"He's in the study with Easton," Janice says.

"Thanks." I nod and walk down the hallway. Opening up the double doors, I enter without asking permission.

Sin jumps up from his chair and spins around. His hand instantly going to the gun tucked into the inside of his suit jacket, but he frowns when he sees me. It makes me wonder why he came back here after our meeting at Blackout. "Everything okay?"

"Kashton—"

"Are you fucking kidding me?" I hiss, interrupting Bill when I see Adam standing off to the right. Can this night get any worse?

Bill pulls on the collar of his tux and clears his throat.

"We need to talk," I say, ignoring the others in the room.

"I can't tell you anything about Adam." Bill glances at my brother and then back at me.

"I'm not here for him."

Sin says, "We'll give you two a minute—"

"You can both stay," I tell Easton. I don't care if they are here or not.

"What, or shall I ask *who,* is this about?" Bill asks, sitting in his chair behind his desk.

He knows exactly why I'm here. "Everett Sinclair."

He frowns and relaxes into his chair. "What about her?" He didn't say anything to me when I took the photos with the family, but he knew I was there with her. He didn't seem all that surprised that I've claimed her as mine.

"What do I have to do to make her my Lady?"

He sits up straighter and glances at Adam. Does Bill know that Adam and I have talked about her? That I've been following her? That I've inserted myself into her life? "I don't know why you'd come to me—"

"You once told me and my brothers that you could be whoever you need to be. I can too." His face sharpens. "I want her. Tell me what I need to do."

"Kashton, this isn't something that can be negotiated."

"Bullshit." I slam my hands on his desk. "We all know that you're her *daddy*. I also know you have influence. I've seen you pull strings. Otherwise you wouldn't have been able to make a deal with Adam. So make one with me."

His eyes narrow on mine before he rises to his feet. After a second, they slide to Sin, who still stands off to my left. Bill turns, giving me his back, and shoves his hands into the pockets of his dress slacks.

"I don't think it's a bad idea," Adam says.

I snort. "I don't need your permission or blessing to marry Eve." I didn't come here to speak to him.

Bill's shoulders rise and fall on a heavy sigh. "She's been through hell, boy. Why would you willingly want to put her through that again?"

"Kash?" Sin grabs my arm and turns me to face him. His eyes search mine before he says, "They will make you hurt her."

"She can handle it." Eve is the strongest woman I know. Whatever it is, we can get through it. It might take a couple of days of sitting on the floor with her cradled in my arms, but I'll pull her through it.

"But can you? Look." Sin drops to a brown leather couch. "I was like you; I thought Elli could handle it. I took a Sharpie to her body,

making tallies right before she was to have her pretend wedding to Chance. Told her that if he found out she was cheating, he'd make her an offering. My sister found her on the floor in her shower with bleach."

"Sin—"

"My wife was going to douse herself in bleach to try and erase what I did so another man wouldn't see that she had been with me." He swallows and looks down at his wedding ring. "Putting her through that was hard on her, but it was also hard on me." He looks up at me. "Bill is right. They will make you break her." He stands. "What if you go too far and she's not the same person? Or worse, what if she can't forgive you?"

I run a hand down my face. "What if you had broken Elli?"

He doesn't hesitate. Instead, he gives me a soft smile. "Wouldn't have mattered. She was going to be mine no matter what, and I still would have loved her just as much."

"This situation is not the same," Bill says, and my jaw clenches. "Everett is a founder."

"So is Ellington," I argue.

"Eve—"

"Is different," Bill snaps, interrupting Adam.

"I'm not sure why you make the fact that she's a founder sound like a problem." I act like I have no clue where he's going with this.

Bill sighs. "They won't give her an assignment because they can't punish her if she fails."

"I don't understand," I continue to play along.

"She can't have children." He squares his shoulders and shoves his hand into his pocket. "As a founder, if she fails her assignment, she will become a breeder. But that's not possible for her."

"If she fails, I'll take her punishment." If for some reason I don't get to marry her, then nothing else will matter anyway.

"What?" Sin spins around. "Kash, that's not—"

"You'd do it for Elli," I interrupt him, and he curses under his breath, knowing I'm right.

Bill growls my name. "Kash…"

"Adam showed me the police report. I know they are trying to frame her for the deaths of those women. I'm the only other option she has for protection." If he knows how serious I am, maybe he'll think twice the next time he suggests shipping her off. Adam said she had resources, and Bill is it.

Bill glares at Adam, who shows no sign of remorse. "He's not wrong," Adam agrees.

"Why would they want to pin Everett for the murders?" Sin wonders.

"We don't know." Bill falls into his seat and buries his head in his hands. "But I think it has to do with Adam."

I turn to face him. "Why the fuck are the Lords targeting her for you?"

His jaw sharpens when he answers. "Hell if I know."

"Adam's supposed to be dead," Sin guesses. "I killed him. Maybe they don't believe it?"

"I'm pretty sure the Lords still believe he's dead," Bill says.

"Then what does it have to do with him?" I bark. Fuck, we're going around in circles. I turn my attention to Bill. "Make Eve my Lady."

"I can't guarantee—"

"I'm a fucking Spade brother," I shout. "I've never asked them for anything. But this…her. I want her. No matter what it costs me. I have to be 'useful' to them somehow." His narrowed eyes meet mine. Hell, even his ex-wife Isabella was going to use Haidyn, from what we guessed. "Make this happen, William." I use his real name, and his face tightens. "Or I will make sure the world knows the truth about you." He's got a secret son who trained sex slaves. He knows about Dollhouse. Made a deal with Adam. I know there's more about him that we don't know, but I will die fucking finding whatever I need.

He walks around his desk, and I meet him halfway. "Do you think threatening me is in your best interest?"

"It should show you how serious I am and that I'll do whatever needs to be done in order to get what I want. Make it happen." Then I turn and head for the double doors to exit his study. "I expect to hear from you by noon tomorrow."

I storm through the house and out the front door. I get into my car, where I squeal my tires as I take off before Adam or Sin can stop me.

I have the urge to go back to Eve's house, but there's one more thing I need to do first.

I never really had any plans for my future, but now I know what I want and how long I want it for.

Her name is Everett Sinclair, and I want her forever.

Pulling up to Carnage, I run up the steps and into the building, heading for the hospital. I need to see Devin.

EVERETT

Nineteen years old

A gush of air leaves my lungs when I'm dropped to a hard floor. I groan, rolling over onto my side, and curl into a ball.

"Name?" a woman's voice asks. It sounds familiar, but my foggy mind can't place it.

"Everett Sinclair," a man answers. "Founder. One suicide attempt. One pregnancy but no children—miscarriage and has been sterilized."

"Mm-hmm," she states as if she already knows these things about me.

My teeth chatter, and I grab at the thick metal collar around my neck. It's pinching my skin, but at least the hood is gone.

"What do you want to do with her?" the man goes on at her silence. "She's pretty much useless to us. Not sure why you even considered accepting her."

"Men are useless," she counters.

"Eve?" a new voice says.

A boot kicks my side, forcing me onto my back. I try to fight, but I'm too weak. My heavy eyes open, and I see a man kneeling next to me. He runs his fingers over my exposed chest and down my stomach before they slide between my trembling legs.

I close them tightly, and he laughs, standing to his full height. "She'll make the perfect whore," he assures the woman.

I'm unable to make out her face, but I can see movement as she checks her watch. "She's all yours. I'm leaving. I've got dinner plans

with my husband in twenty." She pats his back. "I'll check in on her in a week to see how she's doing." Her heels clap when she exits the room.

"Here," one of the male voices says and then my collar is gone. I almost cry in relief.

Then I'm picked up. He carries me out of the room and down a brightly lit hallway. It hurts my sensitive eyes. I've been wearing a hood for the past few days, so any light seems to be too much.

"Pl-ease." My voice cracks. I'm so thirsty and my throat is sore, my skin rubbed raw.

His chest rumbles with laughter. "I always knew you'd end up here, Eve."

I don't know who this man is. How does he know me?

My head hangs off his arm and lolls side to side while he carries me, and I see little glimpses of red lights above doors as we pass by before we enter one of the rooms. He sets me down in a cold, unforgiving chair, and I shiver.

"There's usually a series of events that must take place before this, but I think she'll understand. We'll go ahead and get started. I can clean you up later. You're just going to get dirty again anyway."

She? Who is she? The woman in the heels who handed me over to him? I didn't get a look at her face.

He kneels down in front of me, spreading my legs, and wraps something rough around each ankle, then does the same to my thighs.

"What—" I try to look around, but my vision is too blurry, my body too weak.

Another belt is placed across my lower waist. Followed by my wrists. I can't keep up with his movements.

He walks behind the chair I'm strapped to and places something over my face. I mumble into a mask that covers my mouth, nose and cheeks. It pinches my skin as cold air hits my face.

I'm blinking rapidly when he comes to stand in front of me. He grips my chin, pushing my head back and forcing my watery eyes to meet his. "Breathe, Everett. Deep breaths. In through your nose and out through your mouth."

I try to shake my head, but I can't move it.

"Breathe. Come on…deep breath in through your nose." I do as he says because I can't not breathe. "That's good. Out through your mouth."

As I breathe out, a tingling feeling starts in my toes and the tips of my fingers. "Good girl." He praises me, and his hand drops from my chin and runs down my sternum. "Again."

I repeat the breathing, and that tingling intensifies, spreading along my arms and legs.

"That's it." His hand drops lower and moves between my legs. He begins to rub my pussy, and I can't pull away. I'm strapped too tight. "You're doing so good. I'm going to make you the best whore for them. You're going to make such a pretty dolly."

I sit straight up in bed. I'm gasping as my hand goes to my racing heart. My eyes dart around my bedroom and then to the bed. I'm home. Alone. My cell sits on my nightstand playing "Change (In the House of Flies)" by Deftones. Reaching over, I turn it off, needing a second to clear my mind.

Falling back on my mattress, I run a hand down my face, trying to calm my racing pulse while my heavy breathing fills my now quiet room.

Kashton dropped me off at home two days ago, and this is the second night I've woken up having the same dream.

He spent a couple of days here with me, and now I can't sleep without him. His presence makes me feel safe, and I hate that I'm dependent on that. Since when do I need a man to take care of me? I can do that myself.

But I feel like there's a ghost in my room, standing in the corner staring at me. Trying to tell me something that I don't understand. I'm a sitting duck just waiting for Evan to show up. I actually find it odd that he hasn't come by to visit since the reception. He and Bill aren't close, but my father told Evan to leave for my benefit. He'll be back. He had already warned me that Kashton would be a problem once, and then he saw me there with him. Hand in hand, kissing, dancing. Evan will make sure to show his face soon.

But he's not stupid. He'll lie low for a couple of weeks and then pop back up when he thinks Kashton will toss me to the side. He's relentless and I owe him. He'll come to collect payment when I least expect it.

Getting up, I see the clock showing it's a little after noon. I've been in bed rotting since Kashton dropped me off after our meeting at Blackout. I could grab a bottle and drink until I pass back out, but I'm actually hungry. I make my way to the kitchen and see I'm out of alcohol and anything to eat.

So I throw on a T-shirt and yoga pants and toss my hair up in a bun. Guess I'm going to the store.

I'm pushing the cart down an aisle when I hear my name.

"Miss Sinclair?"

Turning, I see a man I recognize. "Mr. Fells." I give him a smile. "How have you been?"

He pulls me in for a hug and then smiles up at me. I'm five ten, and he's maybe five eight. On the shorter side for a man and balding, but he's so nice.

"I was just talking about you not too long ago."

"Oh?" I arch a brow. Odd thing for him to say, but okay.

"Yeah. To your new neighbors. Have you met them yet?"

I shake my head. I've never met any of them. I stick to myself. "I saw that the For Sale sign was gone, but I haven't seen anyone move in yet."

"It sold to the Pierce family. You'll love them."

"Pierce?" I repeat, making sure I heard him right.

He nods. "Yes, Mr. And Mrs. Pierce. Such a lovely couple."

I tilt my head to the side and nibble on my lip for a second. "What-what were their first names?"

"Kashton and Amber." He smiles, proud of himself for remembering that information.

Motherfucker.

"Their children—"

"It was great seeing you, Mr. Fells. I must be going."

"Oh, yes. Yes. You have a great day, Miss Sinclair. It was great seeing you too."

I wave him off and spend the next twenty minutes pushing the cart around the grocery store like I'm a mad woman, adding a few things to my shopping list that I didn't have on it before. And then I'm hitting the liquor store on the way home to restock.

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THIRTY-THREE



KASHTON

I stand in the kitchen at my house with my phone plugged in to charge. I officially own this house as of last week. Thankfully the family wanted to get rid of this as fast as I wanted to move in.

I've been staying here every night that I'm not with Eve. I've got eyes on her house at all times, watching over my girl. I'm giving her space. Or so she thinks.

Eve arrived home about three hours ago, returning from the grocery store.

Bill sent me a text yesterday that said it was done. Now all we do is wait for her to get her assignment, and she's mine.

I pause the YouTube video I'm watching while I look over the three clothespins that are lined up on my counter. I've written on each one—



I'm in the middle of a DIY project when my doorbell rings.

I lock my cell and pick everything up off the counter, shoving it into a drawer before going over to answer it. Probably some kid wanting to mow my lawn this summer. The neighbors next door to me waved last night while I was pulling into my garage. No doubt word is starting to spread, and the HOA is going to be a bitch to keep up with when it comes to what they expect my house to look like. They gave me a pamphlet of the rules that I threw into the trash.

Twisting the knob, I pull open the door and come face-to-face with a gorgeous blonde. "Fuck—"

"Welcome to the neighborhood." She shoves something soft and warm in my face.

EVERETT

I step back to keep the cake from dripping on me, but it's on my hand, so I try to fling as much off as I can on his front porch before I rub my hand across the front of his shirt. I turn and give him my back, but he surprises me by grabbing my upper arm and yanking me into the house. I trip over my own feet as he slams the door shut.

"What the hell, Eve?" He pulls me into the kitchen and lets go of me to turn on the sink. "Fuck," he hisses when he realizes there's no running water. Reaching up, he pulls his T-shirt over his head. My eyes drop to the way his abs flex as he uses it to clean the cake off his face.

I have the urge to clean up my mess but bite my tongue instead, remembering why I'm here and pissed at him.

"'What the hell, *Eve*?'" I snap. *The nerve.* "What in the fuck, Kashton? You bought the house across the street from me?"

"Yes."

My teeth grind. How long has the house been for sale? How long ago did he buy it? "And you're married?" I'm not surprised. Lords cheat all the time. It's my fault for thinking he was different.

"No." He slaps his cake-covered shirt onto the counter. "I am not married."

I huff, crossing my arms over my chest. "Like I believe anything you say."

"She was a hooker that I paid to be my wife."

I roll my eyes. "Let me guess, you paid kids to call you Daddy too?"

He walks around the kitchen island and comes to stand in front of me. "No. They were make-believe. But you can call me *Daddy*."

I punch him right in the stomach, forcing him to double over with a grunt. The suggestion makes me sick.

Turning to look over the bare kitchen, living room, and formal dining room, I frown. "You really just sit here and watch me all day?" Was this what I was feeling when I couldn't sleep? How long has he been here?

"Yeah," he says in a *duh* voice.

"That's…pathetic."

He steps into my back, his arms wrapping around me from behind, and I know there's going to be cake in my hair. "Some would call it romantic." I can hear the smile in his voice.

I turn in his arms, and he drops them to his sides. "Did you bake me a cake?" His blue eyes search mine before glancing at my lips.

"I poisoned it." I give him an innocent smile, batting my lashes. Spending my afternoon baking him a cake just to shove it in his face was totally worth it.

Lifting his hand, he licks the icing off the ends of his tatted fingers. "Hmm. It's delicious, angel. Poison and all."

I can't help but smile as I push away from him.

"So how did you know I was here?" he asks curiously.

"I woke up craving pancakes, so I went to the store and ran into Mr. Fells. He couldn't stop talking about you and your *lovely family*." I roll my eyes. The thought of Kashton having a wife and kids irritates me, but I'm not sure why. Maybe it's because I know I can't give him that.

"Aw, is that jealousy I hear in your voice?" He smirks.

"No. It's revulsion."

"Yet you took the time to bake me a cake to welcome me to the neighborhood."

"Yeah, well, if the part where I shoved it in your face wasn't clear enough, you're not welcome here. Go home, Kash." I give him my back. "Your real home."

He grabs my arm, spinning me around. "I want to show you something."

"I…" I'm about to say that I don't have the time, but that's all I have. "What is it?"

He takes my hand, and I follow after him through the silent house. My heels clap on the floor, the sound echoing throughout. The house is empty, with bare walls, and it magnifies even the softest sound. I hate that I dressed up for him—skinny jeans, a tight top, and Gucci heels. Even took the time to fix my hair and do my makeup. Wanted to make a lasting impression and give him something to look at while I walked back over to my house.

Guess the joke is on me.

Coming to a door, Kashton opens it up and steps to the side. Removing his hand from mine, he places it on my lower back. "After you."

I peek inside and see a set of stairs leading down to a basement. "You're not going to push me down them, are you?" I half joke. Making me break my legs is a sure way to keep me from running away.

"Here." He turns to face me, grips my hips, and lifts my heels off the floor.

I yelp in surprise even as my legs wrap around his waist instinctively, and I lock my heels together at his back. Then he's turning us so he can walk down the stairs while I cling to him. His hands are on my ass, and I spot a piece of icing smeared on his neck and have the urge to lick off the sweet sugar but refrain. I can bake myself a cake anytime.

My hands are on his back, and I feel his muscles flex as he carries me down the stairs. I imagine myself naked, underneath him, with his weight on top of me. His cock in my pussy and his lips on mine…

Fuck, I should have paid for a clown to deliver the cake and just watched it from my front porch, dressed in lingerie while drinking a bottle of whiskey. I let my emotions get the best of me when it comes to him.

I knew he wasn't married, but the thought was too much. To think he had a Lady and children made me jealous, and I had to say *fuck you* to his face. I wanted him to see me. For fuck's sake, I spent time

getting ready while the cake was in the oven. I've never cooked or baked for a man.

He hits the last step, and with reluctance, I lower my legs while he helps me to stand. He grabs my hand, lifts it up over my head, and spins me around like we're dancing.

I laugh, but it cuts off when I see the basement is just as empty as the house. "What am I looking at, Kashton?" I ask. "There's nothing down here."

He flips on a light and walks past me over to the far wall. Bending down, he picks up what I can only assume is a collar that is chained to the wall. I take an instinctive step back, and my heels hit the stairs behind me.

"This is for you, angel." His eyes meet mine.

I've seen what evil looks like. How black and empty someone's eyes can be when you beg them to help you, and instead, they hurt you. Kashton's look nothing like that.

His tattoos may make someone walk in the opposite direction if they meet him on the street, but his eyes—they're kind and inviting. But even they can't calm the fear that overtakes me.

My heart slams against my chest, and my pulse races. Fear crawls up my spine, but butterflies of excitement take flight in my stomach. "I…I don't understand." I swallow the knot in my throat. "You want to chain me to the wall?" I whisper.

He drops the collar and chain to the floor and the loud clank of metal on concrete makes me flinch. He slowly strolls back to me, and I stay frozen where I am as he cups my face with both of his tatted hands.

"Kash." His name is heavy on my dry tongue.

"I want you to be mine, Eve. All mine."

Most men would give flowers or diamonds, and he has done both of those things, but it was just for show. He wanted other Lords to think there was something between us. But in private, he wants to tie me up and keep me as a pet. "Meaning?" My voice is soft, and the blood rushes in my ears. The thought of being his is as scary as it is exciting.

"I want to take care of you."

He knows no different. It's how he was raised. What he was taught. It's not his fault. "Chaining someone up isn't taking care of them," I argue.

Kashton frowns as if that's the stupidest thing he's ever heard.

I take a step back from him and swallow nervously. "I have to go." Giving him my back, I stomp up the stairs and shove the door open so hard that it hits the interior wall with a loud bang.

I'm running through the living room when I hear him behind me. "Eve? Eve, wait."

"Quit fucking watching me, Kash. Get a life," I throw over my shoulder.

"You are my life."

I spin around, and my hair slaps me in the face. "Quit fucking saying that," I shout, fisting my hands down by my sides.

He shoves his hands into the pockets of his jeans and rocks back on his heels. His abs flex at the simple movement. "I don't want to hurt you, Eve."

"Just imprison me," I snap.

I'm shaking. I've come so far from who I was.

Would it be so bad if I let him take care of me? To belong to him? To a Lord, that can mean many things. And from my experience, none of them are good. Chaining someone to the wall means they get to decide when you eat and drink. This isn't love we're talking about. This is an obsession. An imprisonment.

But to be his pet? Kashton has been the nicest Lord I've ever met, but when will that end? He'll chain me up and get tired of me. Eventually. He'll forget to feed me. Bathe me. I'll rot in there and no one will know where I'm at. Or worse…he'll start beating me. This is simply him buttering me up to get what he wants. And what happens when he finds his Lady? I'm forgotten about and left to die.

I'm shaking I'm so fucking mad…or confused, maybe? I don't know what to think right now. "I worked too hard to get where I'm at." I shake my head. "I won't let you take me back there."

"Where?" He steps forward. "Dollhouse?"

I flinch at the word.

"I know you were a doll, Eve. Even if you don't want to admit it." He takes another step.

"Kashton," I warn. His name trembles on my lips. "Don't."

"It's okay, angel. You can tell me. It won't make me love you any less."

Love? Him wanting to chain me up like a dog in his basement isn't love. Not the kind a girl dreams of anyway. Then again, I've never had the option of dreaming. It's always been nothing but nightmares.

"You don't love me," I say, and tears sting my eyes at the thought that no one ever could. "You don't even know me."

He tilts his head to the side. "Angel, I've been in love with you since the moment I saw you that night on the yacht. And if you think I'm going to just let you walk away from me, well…I'll prove to you that's not an option."

I swallow at the threat because I know it's true. The chain and collar bolted to the wall in the basement prove he's prepared to drag me down there and make me his pet.

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THIRTY-FOUR



KASHTON

I allowed Eve to leave me this afternoon. I professed my love for her, and she gave me her back. Walked out of my house and over to hers.

She'll return. It will just take time. I know it's a lot for her to process. To open up to me. But she will.

I find myself at Carnage tonight. It's weird. I haven't been here much lately. Now I understand why Haidyn chose to stay away with Charlotte.

I make my way down to the basement and see a petite brunette standing in the middle of the room. She looks over her shoulder at me when she hears me approaching. Charlotte gives me a smile that I don't return, causing hers to fall.

It's not her. I'm just in a shit mood that I can't seem to shake. I'm not sure what the fuck to do about Eve. Do I force her hand, kidnap her, and put her in my basement? Or do I let her come willingly? The second may never happen. How much time do I give her? When do I decide for her? Adam said I had a timeline before the cops show up and arrest her. I'll have to make my move before then if she doesn't come around. Plus, now I'm waiting for the Lords to give her an assignment. That may come before the cops do.

"What do you want to do?" Haidyn asks Saint when I come to stand next to Charlotte. His blue eyes meet mine and he nods in greeting.

Again, I don't acknowledge him. I'm trying to decide why I even crawled out of bed this morning.

Saint runs a hand down his face and sighs, keeping his attention on the man lying on the metal table.

"You killed him," I say, noticing the body.

Saint turns to look at me. "He killed himself."

"Suicide?" I clarify.

"Seems so," Haidyn answers, walking from the table to come stand next to his wife.

"With what?"

"Knife. Stabbed himself."

I snort. "No way did he get a hold of a knife down here. I call bullshit."

I only know about one suicide that has ever happened down here, and it was my mother who used a broken piece of a light bulb. We don't leave things lying around for the prisoners to use as weapons. Carnage is all about torture, and letting prisoners kill themselves defeats the purpose.

"He was in his cell last night, and I found him with it in his neck this morning. How else do you explain it?" Saint snaps at me.

"Why would he stab himself in the neck?" Charlotte wonders. "I feel like there are ways to do it other than…that."

Again, how my mother killed herself. Is it a sign? Is someone fucking with me inside of Carnage? Isabella maybe? I can't speak to her in front of the guys, because I don't want them to find out about Eve. If I start questioning her, then she could question me.

I nod, agreeing with her, and Haidyn looks to Saint, as if to also agree with his wife.

"When you're desperate, you use what you have on hand. He obviously had a knife, so that's what he chose to use," Saint argues.

Just then, the sound of the elevator dinging has us all looking over as the plastic strip curtains split and a familiar Lord enters the basement. "What are you doing here, man?" I ask, reaching out my right hand.

"Thought I'd stop by for a little visit." He pulls me in for a handshake hug and slaps my back, then pulls away to do the same to Haidyn before walking over to Saint.

He glances at Charlotte and then to Haidyn. "Can we talk in the office?"

"Sure," he answers, and then turns to his wife. She's glaring up at him. I don't think Haidyn understands that the Lord doesn't want to talk business around his Lady. "I'll only be a minute. I'll meet you upstairs." He kisses her forehead and then turns to follow the Lord out of the basement. "Saint…Kash? You guys coming?" Haidyn calls out, and Saint follows after them. Leaving the dead man unattended on the metal table.

"I'll be right there," I say and turn to Charlotte. "What was that about?" I ask, being nosy once the guys leave.

She huffs, crossing her arms over her chest. "He came by Haidyn's house."

I frown. "Who?"

"The guy…that Lord. He was at Haidyn's house while we were staying there."

She means when he was hiding her from Saint and me. "You sure it was him?"

"Yes," she snaps when her blue eyes meet mine. "I answered the door for him."

"Come on." I grab her hand and drag her toward the elevator.

"I know where I'm going," Charlotte growls, putting her back against the wall when I push the floor for the office.

I ignore her. I'm not going to leave her down here in the basement. If something happens to her, it would be my fault. The elevator stops on the floor for our office. I press the button for the birdcage and order, "Wait for Haidyn in his room."

She lets out a huff, and I'm not sure if it's because I told her what to do or if it's because I called their room *his*.

Making my way down the hallway, I shove the office door open so hard it hits the interior wall, and they all three look up at me. "Kash—"

"He knew where you were the entire time?" I bark at Haidyn.

His eyes go from mine to the Lord standing next to him. Then back to me. The Lord steps forward. "Kashton—"

"Save it, Hooke." He's not the one I want to hear from. "Charlotte, Saint, Adam, and Hooke all knew where you were when you left here. Everyone except me?" I demand, but Haidyn doesn't answer.

Instead, he straightens his back and crosses his tatted arms over his chest. I know I'm not getting shit from him. No surprise there. For some reason, he's locked me out. What the fuck did I do that he chose to keep everything from me? I've never betrayed him. Not that I know of anyway. And if for some reason he felt I had, I would do everything I could to make it up to him.

Turning, I make my way up to my room and grab a baseball hat. Just as I pick one up off the dresser, my door opens.

"We need to talk."

"Too late," I say, turning to face Haidyn.

"Why are you being a little bitch?" he barks at me. Then he sighs. "Look, when I left here, I went to Las Vegas."

I nod, already knowing that. When he finally decided to come around, he told Saint and me that.

"I ran into Hooke at the Airport, and he asked me to help him."

I give a rough laugh. "Let me guess, you can't tell me what it was about." He looks away, and I roll my eyes. "Thought so."

"Kash—"

"It's fine, Haidyn." I know where I stand with him. At the fucking bottom. There was a time that we both thought Saint was dead and Adam was gone. It was just the two of us left, caged here in this hell with that crazy bitch. We only had one another. There were nights I thought that he was dead too, thinking that I was the only Spade brother left, and it was fucking terrifying. Not because of what that meant regarding the Lords but because it meant I was left in this world alone. Now I realize that's exactly what I am. Alone.

I shoulder past him out of my room and pull the hat on, heading back to the elevator to the garage. I need to go for a ride.

EVERETT

Twenty years old

I roll over and open my eyes to a set of dark ones staring at me. "Fuck," I hiss, jumping out of bed. "What the fuck, Evan?" I push my wild hair from my face. "What are you doing here?"

He doesn't answer. Instead, he lies back in my bed, placing his hands under his head to prop it up. "Leave," I order, yanking a T-shirt off a chair and sliding it on. I shouldn't be sleeping naked. "Get the fuck out of my house."

He laughs. "Your house?"

"Yes. It's my fucking house. Get the fuck out." I rush to the bedroom door, but he jumps out of bed and moves to stand in front of it to block my exit.

I step back.

"Bill bought this house. I'm sure he used Mom's money for it." He places his hands on the doorframe. "So technically…it's our house."

I swallow nervously. No. No. "I didn't know…"

"That I'm your brother?" He tilts his head to the side. "Come on, sis. It just makes this better, don't you think?" He laughs at my silence. "I knew Bill would tell you. Dear ole dad. Can't help but be a savior." He looks me up and down, and I wish the shirt was longer. "It was pathetic how much he loved her." Evan steps forward, and I take a step back. "He couldn't save Mom, but he was going to do everything he could for you."

"Leave. Right fucking now," I demand through gritted teeth. "I won't tell you again."

He gives me a smile, showing off his teeth like a monster in the night that's going to rip my throat out. "You've always been a feisty bitch. You definitely didn't get that from Mother."

"Stop talking about her," I growl. I hate that I didn't get to know her. Probably for the best. She'd be so disappointed in me. Who I am. I'm going to make sure I become a woman she'd be proud of. Someone who stands up for women who are forced into silence. Bill gave me a chance, and I'm not going to waste it. "Get out." I point to the door. "Get the fuck out." I shove his chest, screaming at the top of my lungs, making my throat burn.

He grabs my neck and picks me up, slamming me onto the bed. He straddles my hips and pins me down, choking me while I kick and buck under him. "He might have saved you from Dollhouse, but don't forget who fucking trained you," he spits at me, and I close my

eyes, trying to turn my face from his, but there's nowhere for me to go.

Pain explodes in my head, and my eyes pop open when I'm yanked from the bed and shoved into the nearest wall. I fall to the floor, unable to keep myself upright. My shaking hands go to my face, and I cry into them when I see blood.

"Same ole pathetic little dolly," he taunts, kicking my side, and I begin to crawl away from him as fast as I can. "You can pretend to play house, to not need me, but you'll come back around, Eve. It's the only life you've ever had. You need to be used and abused. It's how you feel love." He kicks me again, the blow so hard it flips me onto my back, and I cry out, covering my face. "See you soon, sis."

That was my first night in this house. Evan wanted to make sure I understood that no matter what, I wouldn't escape him. It didn't matter where I went, he'd find me.

I left shortly after for Las Vegas. If he followed me there, he didn't make it known. He knew I'd be back. That this is where I'd call home.

He doesn't stop by often. Maybe once every six months. For the most part, he stays away. I think deep down he's afraid of Bill. He's got way more pull than Evan will ever have. And Bill mentioned some kind of deal. I still need to find out what that is.

Evan might slum it with evil, but Bill is on the Lords' good side. Evan can't compete with that. Plus, now that Isabella is a prisoner at Carnage, he has no one on his side. Isabella let him run the show, but now it's over.

I thought that night on the *Isabella* was going to change my life, but nothing could have prepared me for how much.

"Angel, I've been in love with you since the moment I saw you that night on the yacht. And if you think I'm going to just let you walk away from me, well…I'll prove to you that's not an option."

I lie awake staring at the ceiling. "The Red" by Chevelle plays louder than normal, and I tell myself that it's the reason I'm unable to sleep, but I know it's Kashton.

Now that I know he's staying across the street, I find myself looking out my living room windows to see if he's there.

Why do I care so much?

"Quit fucking watching me, Kash. Get a life."

"You are my life."

Shoving the covers off, I get up and pack a bag quickly, then I'm out the door. I walk over to his house and ring the doorbell. Bouncing on my heels, I wait for him to answer. "Kashton?" I shout, banging my fist on the glass doors.

I feel stupid standing out here in the middle of the night. He's probably not home and this is just me looking like an idiot.

After another minute, I turn and walk back to my house and throw my bag into my car. There can only be one other place he's at. I turn my cell to Do Not Disturb to make sure Adam doesn't call me in for a job, and within thirty minutes, I pull up to Carnage, ignoring the way my pulse races.

It'll be okay, Eve.

I press the Call button, and a male voice comes from the other end. "Hello?"

"Hi. Uh, it's Everett Sinclair. I'm here for Kashton." I sound like an idiot. But what else am I supposed to say? *Hey, I'm here to get fucked so I can get some rest?* If I'm lucky, he'll choke me out.

The wrought-iron gates open, and I pull into the circle drive. Grabbing my bag, I walk up the steps, and the door opens before I can even get to it.

"Hello, Miss Sinclair," Jessie greets me.

"Hello."

"I apologize, Miss Sinclair, but Kashton isn't here."

I frown and have a thought to leave, but what will that do? His butler will tell him I was here. Not like I can hide it. Plus, I need some sleep. Being here is better than being alone at my place. "May I wait for him to return?" I ask.

"Of course." He smiles. "May I show you to his room?"

"Yes, please."

"Follow me." He leads me to an elevator, and my breathing becomes erratic and my legs shake as it ascends. "Everything okay,

miss?”

I nod, pulling on the collar of my shirt. “Fine. Thank you.”

“Here we are,” he says when we reach Kashton’s door. He puts in a code, unlocking it, and gestures for me to enter before closing it behind me.

“Thank you,” I mumble to myself, glancing around his room. Double doors lead out to a balcony. His walls are matte black with a gloss black design. His TV is on, and a four-poster bed is covered in dark-purple linens. The man doesn’t even know how to do laundry. I can only imagine what the housekeepers see when they come into the guys’ rooms in the mornings.

I set my bag down and crawl into his bed still dressed. I wrap my arms around his pillow and inhale his scent. I don’t feel a ghost here. No one watching. I hate how safe I feel here when it was once a nightmare.

Kashton did that—changed my life. I wish I could do the same for him.

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THIRTY-FIVE



KASHTON

It has to be after midnight by the time I bring my bike to a stop in the circle drive and run up the stairs. I went to Eve's house, and she wasn't there. I tracked her phone, and it told me she was here.

Why the fuck would she be at Carnage? Have my brothers taken her in and thrown her in a cell? If so, why didn't they fucking call me?

I've called them and neither one answered me. Eve's cell is turned on Do Not Disturb, so every call goes unanswered, but I'm still able to track her.

As I rush through the door, Jessie spots me. "Sir—"

"Is Eve here?" I interrupt him in a panic.

"Yes. I parked her car in the garage."

"Where the fuck is she?" I snap. If my brothers kidnapped her, why would they bring her car?

He frowns. "Miss Sinclair is in your room…"

I run to the elevator and enter my room in a hurry to see the bed unmade, the TV on, and her bag on the round table by the French doors that lead out to the balcony. The bathroom door is slightly open, and I can see the light on. I enter to find her in my bathtub, her head back on the porcelain, eyes closed, hair up in a messy bun and the tub filled with bubbles while "Sorry" by Halsey plays softly from her cell. I pick up her phone, turn it off, and place it on the counter before turning back to her in the tub.

"Eve?" I ask and her eyes pop open. "Everything okay?" This is either a good sign or something bad has happened to her. My mind in-

stantly goes to Evan, and I scan her face, neck, and shoulders to look for bruises but don't see any. I've got cameras on her house so I can see when she's coming and going, and I haven't seen him there.

She slowly sits up, the water sloshing around, and her eyes meet mine. "I hope it's okay that I came over."

"Of course." I let out a deep breath to see that she's not injured. She's always welcome here. Anywhere I am, for that matter.

She runs her hand through the bubbles, dropping her gaze. "Thank you."

"May I join you?" I ask.

She nods, and I quickly get undressed and sink into the hot water, hissing in a breath as I sit facing her. I look over her makeup-free face. Her eyes are sad, her face worried.

I wanted to go for a ride. To try and free my mind, but it was on her the entire time. What she's seen. What she's been through. I wish I could help her, but she's not going to let me in easily.

"Talk to me," I urge. She needs to know I'm here for her. That she can tell me anything. My hands run up and down her legs under the water as I let her gather her thoughts and decide what she wants me to know.

"I've been thinking about what you said the other night after the meeting at Blackout… Evan didn't fuck me."

"That you know of or that you remember?"

She frowns, tilting her head to the side at my question. After how I've seen her react to things and what I've been told, I feel like there are times of her life that are missing. That she either chose to block out or just can't remember. I've seen her dissociate and I've witnessed how she feels afterward.

"I…" She licks her lips. "I know for a fact that we've never had sex."

"How?" I push.

She pulls away and rests her back against the tub, looking up at the ceiling. My eyes drop to her delicate neck, and she swallows before she says, "He just wouldn't."

I run a wet hand through my hair. I've seen it before. Even those outside of the Lords' world will rape members of their families. Sex is

sex to them. Blood relation doesn't matter. In most cases, it's about power. To keep the bloodline going. "You can't be sure, Eve…"

She sits up and takes my hands in hers. Big green eyes search mine, and I've never seen her look more unsure when she says, "It didn't happen."

The way her voice softens tells me she's convincing herself more than me. Maybe the thought of a half brother raping her is too much for her to accept. Maybe I'm the one who has put that thought in her head and now she can't get past it.

"I believe you," I tell her, hoping she doesn't hear the lie. She has no clue what happened to her. And honestly, I hope it stays that way.

She leans forward, and her soft lips gently touch mine. It's a test to see how I feel about her. If I'm still in love with her.

I slide my hand around the back of her neck, holding her in place, and her lips part for me to deepen the kiss. I take advantage of it, wanting to taste her. It's only been two days, but I've missed her like crazy.

Pulling away, I run my knuckles over her racing pulse, and her lashes slowly open. "Marry me."

She bursts into laughter, and the sound makes me smile. There's the woman I've fallen in love with. I will hand her a gun and a stapler. She can patch me up after she shoots me.

"I'm serious." I take her bubble-covered hands in mine.

"Kash—"

"We can elope and be married by tomorrow morning." One call, and the private jet will be fueled and ready to go within the hour.

"The Lords would never allow it."

She didn't say no. "They can't stop us."

"But they can punish you," she whispers.

I let go of her hands and place mine on her face. "Don't worry about me, angel. I spent six months in training; I can take whatever punishment they throw my way." It wouldn't matter, as long as I got to be her husband.

"They'll take what you love the most," she says.

Her. "I'll build you a castle. One with a moat."

She laughs again, softer this time.

"I'm serious. I've always wanted to own alligators. We'll get seven and name them after the days of the week. And we'll feed them nothing but human remains from Carnage prisoners. I can protect you, Eve. I promise."

Lowering her gaze to the bubbles, she sighs. "You're not untouchable, Kashton." She looks up at me through her lashes. "Your family isn't untouchable. This isn't a game that we can win."

"I won't let us lose," I promise her. Placing my hands on her face, I bring her to me and gently kiss her lips again, needing more.

EVERETT

I want to remember this moment. How good it feels to know for this second that I'm safe. That what woke me up back at my house was just a nightmare. It might have happened in the past, but that's over. This is now. This is my future. Even if it's for a short time.

"I'm sorry," I whisper.

He frowns, wondering why I'm sorry; but honestly, it's a long list. "You don't have to apologize to me, Eve. Ever. Okay?"

But I do. When he finds out who I really am, he will run as far away from me as he can. He'll realize how broken I truly am and that I'm not worth it.

His knuckles run down my chest, over my stomach, and softly touch my hip. I flinch when they linger on my butterfly tattoo. I know he wants to ask about it. He saw the marks on me that night on the *Isabella*.

I just can't seem to say the words. To tell him what I've been through. I'm ashamed of who I allowed them to turn me into. The me Kashton knows now isn't who I was. And if I tell him anything about my past, he'll see me differently. He won't want me anymore. I can't take that chance. I'm not ready to let him go.

We finish up in the bathtub and dry off before crawling into his bed.

"Why is the TV on?" I ask softly.

"I can't sleep without it," he answers with a yawn.

"I can't sleep without music playing," I tell him.

He shifts to roll over and grab his phone. "I can turn on some music—"

"No," I interrupt him, placing my hand on his chest to stop him. "I just meant I can't sleep without some sort of noise either." When a person's forced to live in silence, they begin to crave chaos. Their mind needs something to distract them, otherwise they'll go crazy.

He rolls back and gently kisses my forehead. "I'm right here, Eve, and I'll be here when you wake up."

I snuggle into him, and he turns onto his side. I place my leg over his hip, and he slides his hand under the covers to grip my bruised thigh, holding it in place.

I crave his touch between my legs, so I move my hips back and forth.

He opens his eyes, and I search them as my hand runs over the back of his head, feeling his soft hair.

I want to be his wife, but I'll never tell him that. Because it's not fair to him. He deserves a woman he can be proud of. Who can give him a family. I'm not that woman.

"Horny, angel?" he asks as his tatted hand runs up my thigh and dips between my legs.

I moan when he gently plays with my pussy. Teasing me. "Yes." He hasn't touched me since he played with me a couple of days before the reception. I had a little meltdown afterward, but I've wanted him ever since.

"Want me to fuck you until you fall asleep?"

"Please," I beg.

The corner of his lips turn up slightly. He repositions his hand and starts to finger me. My breathing picks up when he slides two into me. It's crazy how often my body begs for him.

A part of me questions if it's natural or because of my past. Would I be this way with another man? No. I trust Kashton. He's not like the others. I've never felt safer in my life, and that alone should terrify me.

Kash removes his fingers and I pout. He chuckles, getting out of bed, and I wait impatiently while he goes back into the bathroom to his closet. When he returns, he commands, "Stand up."

I can't get to my feet fast enough. I have no shame in wanting to be his toy tonight.

"Bend over the bed. Hands behind your back."

Kneeling next to his bed, I place my stomach and chest on the mattress with my arms crossed behind my back.

I bite my inner cheek to keep from moaning when I hear the metal clanking before he places my wrists in the unforgiving handcuffs. My body loves the sting. It has been trained to crave pain. It's why I've never let anyone touch me. Until now.

How far will I let him go? The answer is as far as he wants because I know he'll make it feel good.

"Spread your legs." His hand slaps my ass, and I yelp at the sting.

Doing as he says, I spread my knees as much as I can in the awkward position.

He kneels behind me, his knees holding mine open, and I feel something cold run over my ass and pussy.

"Kashton." I breathe his name while smashing the side of my face into his bed.

"I'm going to make you work for it, Eve," he tells me, and I know what he means.

My skin tingles with excitement.

I feel pressure against my ass, and I try to push my hips into the side of the bed.

"Easy." His free hand caresses my back. "Relax for me, angel. Don't fight it."

I whimper and close my eyes as he forces the butt plug inside me. My breath hitches, and I can't help but clench up when a cry is ripped from my lips.

"You're making it harder on yourself, Eve."

I gasp, my lips parting, and my legs tremble, loving the feel of him forcing it inside me.

"Deep breath," he commands, and I fill my lungs. "Let it out slowly."

As I release the shaky breath, my ass gives way to the base of the plug, and I bite into the comforter to keep from crying when it stretches me wide.

"Good girl." He rubs my back. "That's a good girl, angel."

I'm trembling, and sweat has broken out over my body.

He begins to rub my pussy, and I push against him, fighting the cuffs. "You're doing great, Eve. Now I'm going to fill that tight cunt as well."

"Please," I beg, knowing he's not going to fuck me. He could make me stay like this all night.

He pushes two fingers into me and doesn't go slow, fucking me rough and hard. My body rocks back and forth against the side of the bed, my breathing ragged and pulse racing. I don't care how desperate I look.

When he removes them, my body relaxes, slumping with exhaustion already. But it's short-lived, because now he's pushing something large into me. My breath gets caught and I tense, but I can't stop him. He pushes the dildo into my soaked pussy with ease, making me take it.

This is what I wanted. This is why I ran to him tonight.

I feel Kashton stand and then his hand is in my hair. He grips it tightly and pulls me off the side of the bed, yanking my head back, and I cry out. "That's my good girl." He leans over and kisses my cheek from behind.

Then he lets go and sits down on the side of the bed in front of me while I remain kneeling at his feet. "Tell me, angel. How's it feel to have both your ass and cunt filled?"

I'm panting, rocking back and forth on my knees.

"Hmm?" He arches a brow at my silence.

"I need you." I push my chest out, hoping he'll play with my breasts. My nipples are hard and begging to be touched.

He gives me a smile before reaching over to grab something off the nightstand. Then he's buckling a collar around my neck. It's thick and makes it hard to move. The leather rubs my skin, and I know it'll be irritated, leaving marks once he takes it off. Who knows how long he'll make me wear it.

"You're almost there." He stands and grabs my upper arms, pulling me to stand as well. Walking behind me, he undoes the cuffs, and I frown, but then he's placing his belt around my waist and forearms, pinning them down to my sides.

Kashton moves to face me once again and kneels. He picks up one leg at a time and places my feet into some kind of one-legged suit. "I had this made just for you, angel." He pulls the soft material up my legs, forcing me to keep them together. "It's a bondage sleep-sack." Standing, he continues to pull it up and over my thighs. Then my hips and waist. It gets tighter as it covers my arms and wraps around my chest. It feels like a strict corset covering my entire body, coming all the way up to the collar.

I stand in front of him, unable to move, and it makes wetness pour between my thighs, coating the toy that's buried deep inside me.

"How does that feel, Eve? Tight enough?" He runs his tatted knuckles down the side of my cheek.

I'm desperate for him to fuck me. To let me come. "Yes," I answer breathlessly, leaning into him.

He walks away, leaving me facing the bed. I try to look over my shoulder, but I can't without falling over, so I stay where I'm at.

I feel his body push up against the back of my legs when he says, "Open wide."

My lips part on their own before I can even process what's happening. Something large and round is shoved into my mouth, forcing it open wider before he pulls the leather tight around my head and buckles it in place.

Then he's picking me up, cradling me to his chest, and placing me on the bed. I mumble nonsense through the open gag as I look up at him.

"Beautiful." He stares down at me, his fingers lining my lips before slipping them into my mouth. "I've got your mouth strapped in an open-mouth gag," he informs me, pushing his fingers to the back of my throat. I try my best not to gag. "Good girl," he praises me, and I blink rapidly. "See? Those forty-eight hours on your knees did you well, angel."

I mumble at him, but even I don't know what I'm trying to say.

"You'll make a good little pet after all." He removes them and I rock from side to side.

Grabbing me, he pulls me to where my head hangs off the side of the bed, and I know what's coming. Kashton likes to fuck my mouth,

and I like when he does it.

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THIRTY-SIX



EVERETT

I exit Kashton's room the following morning at the same time Saint walks out of his at the end of the hallway. Kash steps out behind me just as the door across from his opens and a brunette joins us.

Her wide blue eyes meet mine and she gasps. "Eve." They go to Kashton and then back to me. "How have you been?"

I walk the short distance and hug her. "Hey," I say awkwardly. "Pretty good. How about you?" I haven't seen her since the wedding reception, but I like that she remembers who I am.

"Kash, can I speak to you in the office?" Saint asks, walking past us toward the elevator.

"Yeah. I'll be right there."

"Go ahead." I turn and give him a reassuring smile. I'm a big girl. We don't need to make it awkward. He doesn't need to walk me out. I know where to go.

"Oh, uh, okay." He glances at Charlotte, and then his eyes meet mine again.

I nod at him as he gets on the elevator with Saint.

Instead of waiting on the elevator, we decide to take the stairs so we can catch up. I get a glimpse of her wedding ring, but I already knew she married Haidyn. Like I said, I know a lot about her. Even before we met at Bill and Janice's wedding reception.

We exit on the second floor, walking out onto the top of the grand staircase. The sound of someone sniffling gets our attention, and we both look down over the balcony at the foyer below. I watch Charlotte stiffen out of the corner of my eye when she spots Ashtyn

walking up to Haidyn. He looks like he's going to ignore her until she calls his name.

"Haidyn?"

"What, Ashtyn?" He sighs heavily. Either he's had a long morning, or he doesn't want to be bothered by her.

Ashtyn goes to give him a hug but stops when he crosses his arms over his chest. Instead, she lowers her voice, softly speaking to him, and she nods a few times before rubbing tears from her face.

This bitch!

I can't stand her. I feel like there are several reasons as to why I don't like her, but the main one is because I know what the Spade brothers went through for her. If she had protected them instead of running, their lives would have been different. They wouldn't have been tortured for six months. And shooting Saint? What was the point in that? She was willing to kill him to save herself. If you ask me, that's not a woman who is in love.

Charlotte wraps her hands around the railing as Haidyn's phone rings. He pulls it out of his pocket and answers. "Hello?" His deep voice carries up to the high ceilings, and he gives her his back. Ashtyn understands their one-sided conversation is over. I smile at how disappointed she looks that he chose anyone else over her.

"Do you trust your husband?" I ask, turning to face Charlotte.

"Absolutely," she answers without hesitation. Then her brows pull together, like she's confused about why I asked her such an absurd question or possibly how I know they're married. But even if I didn't already know that information, the diamond on her finger gives it away.

"Do you trust Ashtyn?" I dig.

She nibbles on her bottom lip for a second before she responds. "She's been in their lives for a long time, but I know my husband. And"—she gives me a confident smile—"he would never do anything to hurt me."

I don't want to put thoughts in her head, but I also know how these whores work. "Let me share a little insight with you, Charlotte." I step into her, and her smile drops. "Even though your hus-

band isn't currently sticking his dick inside her, that doesn't mean she wouldn't slide it in herself if he were to give her the chance."

She reaches down and places her hand on her flat stomach, and I sigh. "You're pregnant." I should have known. That's what the Lords do—knock up their Ladies as soon as they can. Of course Haidyn is no different. Guess I don't know everything.

Charlotte smiles at me. "I am. Ashtyn was there for me when I needed someone. Plus, she's been through a lot."

"We all have," I add. "That's not an excuse to be a cunt."

She places her hand on my shoulder. "I know they have a past, but I'm his wife. His future."

I admire her level of trust. I wish I could have that with someone. Kashton might say he loves me and wants to marry me, but our future isn't going to be the same as Haidyn and Charlotte's. I'll let him think he can heal me, but I know he can't. You can't undo as much damage as I have. Love isn't the answer to everything in the real world.

We both stand silently, watching Ashtyn make her way up the grand staircase. She doesn't see us until she reaches the platform. Ashtyn gives us both a big, fake fuck-you smile. Well, that's how I see it. It may be more of a *I hope you just didn't see me trying to hug your husband like he's my own*.

"Hey, ladies," she says. "Eve, right? I saw you at the reception."

She tries to act like we didn't sit at the same table that evening. I skip the small talk. "I'm here to see Saint. You know where he is?" I ask.

She glances from me to Charlotte then back to me, tilting her head to the side as if she's not sure whether to believe me. She's probably wondering why the fuck I'm here. Did I stay the night? Why would I want to talk to Saint when it's clear I'm fucking Kashton?

After a long second, she finally answers. "If he's not in the office, he's down in the basement." Swallowing nervously, she adds, "Need me to get him for you?"

I wave her off. "I'll find him." Give her a dose of her own medicine. Maybe I plan on sucking his dick under his desk, or maybe I plan on letting him fuck me in the elevator. Or maybe I want him to bend me

over his desk so he can fuck my face while Kashton pounds my pussy from behind. Who knows? The choice is mine.

After a long second, she finally speaks. "Okay. Let me know if you need anything."

I ignore her, but Charlotte smiles before Ashtyn disappears down the hallway and out of sight.

"It was good to see you, Eve. Hopefully I'll see you again soon." With that, Charlotte goes the opposite way.

I take the grand staircase down to the first floor. Haidyn is placing his cell in his pocket. "Might want to rein that in," I suggest in passing.

"Excuse me?"

I come to a stop and face him. He looks like he wants to ask me what the fuck I'm doing here, but he already knows—his brother.

My stare drops to his wedding band before I meet his eyes. "The woman you let hang on you who isn't your wife."

His eyes narrow on mine, knowing Ashtyn wasn't *hanging* on him like I just accused him of. But the situation will at the very least put doubt in Charlotte's mind. A woman can only tell herself there's nothing there so many times before she stops believing it. And she knows about their past. That'll make her doubt him faster than anything.

I don't want to see them fail.

And I can't stand for a woman who pushes boundaries when she's aware he's with someone who isn't her.

"Never know who might be watching." I remove my sunglasses from my hair and put them over my eyes. "Like your actual wife." Then I turn and exit the Carnage doors as my cell vibrates in my pocket. I pull it out to read the text.

We need to talk. My office downtown.

The message from my dad instantly ruins my mood. Can I just have one good day? I feel like that's not too much to ask.

KASHTON

Lunch. I'll be at your house to pick you up at noon.

I send the text to Eve. It wasn't a question, so I don't need a response. Setting the phone down on my desk, I lean back in my chair

and smile.

Haidyn enters the office with a sour look on his face, and Saint also seems tense. The past twenty-four hours with my girl have made me feel much better.

"So, Eve?" Saint says. "Sure that's a good idea? I mean…more than once?"

Obviously, they know that I've been seeing her, but they don't know the extent of it. They have no clue I'm going to marry her. "The best decision I've ever made."

Haidyn grunts and Saint just chuckles.

"She's the one." I smile and Saint looks skeptical.

"The one?" he asks slowly.

I nod. "I'm obsessed. She's like crack."

"How would you know?" Saint asks. "You've never done crack." I open my mouth, but he continues. "She's a founder—"

"So is your wife," I counter.

"Yeah, but…" He trails off and looks at Haidyn, who softly shakes his head.

You better not fucking say it. "But what?" I bait Saint.

"Nothing." He decides to not say what he was originally thinking—she's useless. I already beat the shit out of a few guys for calling her that, and I won't treat my brother any differently.

The door to the office opens and Ashtyn enters. She gives a smile as she walks over to Saint. Her eyes scan the room, looking for someone else in here, and her smile grows when she realizes it's just the three of us Spades. "What is everyone up to today?"

"Working," Saint answers. Haidyn puts his attention on his computer, so she looks at me at his dismissal.

It's pretty fucking obvious he's distancing himself from her. I've had my head buried in the fucking sand for far too long, so now I watch everything. Too much went on, and if I had just opened my eyes and paid attention, I would have seen what was happening.

All that *I was blind but now I see* bullshit.

I get it, though. Haidyn has a wife, and Saint isn't going to tell Ashtyn to step back. Saint isn't like that. He knows we're not going to fuck her. She's back here at Carnage and belongs to him. That's

all he cares about. And now, with the babies on the way and her brother *dead*, he's going to let her do and have whatever she wants. She's his wife. I can't say I'd do it differently, because I'm not in his shoes.

Ashtyn has been a big part of our lives for as long as Saint has. Now things have changed for Haidyn, but not for Ashtyn. She still wants to be his *baby girl*. And I don't know Charlotte all that well, but I can't imagine she'd put up with that. Haidyn is her husband and she's not going to share him.

My phone vibrates, and I look down to see it's a response from Eve.

Can't. I'm busy today.

I chuckle and type back.

It wasn't a question, angel.

"Same." I finally answer Ashtyn.

"Can we all go for a ride later?"

Haidyn finally speaks to her while his eyes remain on his computer. "Charlotte and I have plans."

Saint looks at her. "Sweetheart, you're pregnant. I'm not putting you on the back of my bike."

"I trust you." She frowns.

He shakes his head. "Too many things can happen that I can't control."

Even when we had our chosens, Ashtyn was still ours. Saint let us have a piece whenever we wanted. I wouldn't say he regrets that, but we quit after they got married. He made her an honest woman, and I wanted nothing to do with her sexually after.

She turns and plops down on the couch, nibbling on her bottom lip. She looks bored and confused. She went from life on the run to being kept here at Carnage like a prisoner.

"Why don't you go see what Charlotte is up to?" Saint offers. "Maybe have a girls' day."

"She just left," Ashtyn answers, and I watch Haidyn to see if he reacts. He doesn't. I'm surprised he let her leave without him with everything that has been going on around here and the women who have turned up dead. "She went to spend the day with Blakely. They

invited me, but I thought I'd let them have some alone time." Ashtyn shrugs. "They have a lot to talk about."

Yes. They just recently found out that they are related. Who knew the two fucked-up women in our world are twins? Guess we should have seen that one coming.

"I called Elli, but she has plans with Sin today. She said she'll be here tomorrow, though."

Sitting up straighter, I ask, "Are Devin and Gavin delivering the babies?" Sin hasn't mentioned it.

She shakes her head. "No. They've got another week."

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THIRTY-SEVEN



EVERETT

fine

I respond to Kashton, but there's a smile on my face. I like that no matter how much I push him away, he doesn't let me get far.

I enter Bill's office, wondering why the hell he's got me coming in for the day. I'm sure it's something he could have called me about.

He sits behind his desk, reading over paperwork, and removes his glasses when he looks up to see me enter. "Hello, Eve." He smiles.

"What do you need to say that couldn't be said with a phone call?" I demand, and the smile drops off his face. This is going to piss me off.

He sighs heavily and gestures for me to have a seat, but I cross my arms over my chest.

"Kashton came to me the night after the reception," he begins.

"What did he want?" I ask, getting a bad feeling.

I'm not surprised, really. I told him a lot about myself, and I'm sure he wanted to verify it. Make sure I wasn't blowing smoke up their asses. Bill's probably mad I ratted out Evan as his son. He doesn't claim him. Some people just can't be helped, and Evan is one of them. Bill knows that no matter what he does or says, Evan will never change. I think a part of Bill really loves Sin's mother, and he would never bring Evan into his life to jeopardize their marriage or her life.

"He asked me to pull some strings."

I step forward. "Strings for what?"

"He wants to make you his Lady."

No. This can't be right. "I can't… They won't…" We just had this conversation in his bathtub. Why didn't he mention it to me then? That would have been the perfect time to say "Hey, by the way, I asked your father to pull some strings with the Lords so I can marry you."

"Eve." He comes around his desk and takes my hand.

"It can't happen," I whisper. Fucking around is one thing, but to be his wife? I can't give him anything. "No…"

"You deserve this."

I rip my hands from his and my chest tightens. "You told him no, right?"

He lowers his eyes to the floor, and my heart races.

"You told him no, right?" I demand when he doesn't answer the first time.

"Everett—"

"No," I shout, stepping back. "You can't be serious." This is more than what we've been doing.

"You deserve this," he whispers.

"Kashton doesn't," I grind out. "They will hurt him. Fuck, Bill, you're a goddamn Lord, for fuck's sake. You know what they will do to him. To his family." His brothers and their wives are all he has left. When they can't get to him through me, they'll go after the ones close to him.

I see it all the time when I sit in the cathedral and watch the confessionals. He's a Spade brother, so they will make an example out of him. "This can't be happening," I mumble.

"Hey." He reaches down for me, but I pull away, not wanting to be touched right now. I'm so mad at both of them. Kashton for not telling me he went to Bill, and Bill for doing whatever the fuck he did to give Kashton what he wants.

What about what I want? *You want to belong to someone.* You don't get more owned than being a Lady.

"You will get the life you dream of." Bill speaks through my rambling thoughts.

I give a rough laugh. "You've got jokes."

He places his hands on my shoulders, and I stiffen at the contact. "Trust me."

"That's rich." A Lord asking someone to trust him?

He sighs. "Your mom always wanted a little girl." Tears sting my eyes at the mention of my mother. This world took her from me before I ever got to meet her. "And she would be so proud of you."

"No. She wouldn't," I whisper as a lump lodges in my throat. "I'm no one to be proud of."

He gives me a kind smile. "You've survived so much, Eve. I just wish I could have stepped in sooner. Protected you like a father should have protected his daughter."

I pull back and his arms drop to his sides. Turning, I go to leave, knowing this won't go anywhere. He's made up his mind to help Kashton. The door to his office opens and in steps the Lord I want nothing to do with right now.

"Eve." His green eyes meet my watery ones.

"Adam," I say and shoulder past him, wanting to get the fuck out of here. I'm pissed and emotional. Never a good mix. "Your sister is a bitch," I can't help but add when I shove the door open and storm out.

I'm almost at the elevator when my arm is grabbed and I'm spun around. "Don't touch me," I snap.

Adam raises his hands and steps back, giving me some space. I'm on edge. What Kashton has done…the mention of my mother…the Lords don't believe in fairy tales, so why is Bill trying to sell me one?

Adam shoves his hands into the front pockets of his dress slacks. "How's she doing?"

"Ask your brothers."

He sighs heavily. "I can't do that." Shaking his head, Adam adds, "I'm not sure they'd tell me the truth anyway."

"She's married to Saint but seems hung up on Haidyn. She's also pregnant, so Charlotte won't stand up to her. But if I had to bet on a hand-to-hand fight, my money would be on Charlotte."

"She's been through a lot."

I roll my eyes. "She shot her husband. Her husband, who she knew cheated at the vow ceremony to make her his in order to protect

her, putting his own life in danger. Then she ran. When all she had to do was go to him, and he would have done anything for her."

"It's more complicated than that."

"No. It's not. She created a hostile situation and then cried victim."

"You're only saying that because it's her life. Not yours."

I give him my back, done with his conversation, and punch the button, waiting for it to open.

"Kash is doing the same for you."

I stiffen but refuse to look back at him. Of course Adam knows what Kashton has done. He's probably encouraging it because he knows who I really am. I wonder how his brother would feel if he knew what Adam knows about me.

"Kashton's trying to save you from this life you hate so much. The life the Lords decided they want you to have. He's willing to give his life for yours. Just because you don't pull the trigger doesn't mean your actions won't kill him."

I spin around. "What do you mean give his life for mine?"

"The Lords know if you fail, you can't be sentenced to be a breeder, so Kashton has agreed to take your punishment."

My stomach drops. It just keeps getting worse. How can he do this? Risk his life for mine?

"Give yourself more credit, Eve. He may be willing to protect you, but we all know you'll pass." With that, he turns and enters Bill's office just when the elevator dings behind me.

Numbly, I turn around and enter the elevator. I slump against the wall and hang my head.

FUCK.

KASHTON

It's a quarter to noon when I pull up to Eve's house. I find the front door unlocked and enter like I own the place. "Everything in My Mind" by Nevertel blares inside.

I check my watch to make sure I'm not too early. Stepping into her kitchen, I find her sitting on the floor, her back resting against the cabinet doors and a bottle of whiskey next to her. She's dressed in an oversized T-shirt and nothing else.

"Angel?" I crouch down in front of her and place my hands on either side of her face, forcing her eyes to meet mine. "Are you okay?" I glance at the bottle that has her red lipstick wrapped around the tip. It's half empty. I'm not sure how full it was before she started drinking, but it's the middle of the day.

I've known she's had a drinking problem since I started following her, but with a past like hers, she's bound to need some sort of outlet. A crutch that she leans on.

I want to be that for her.

"Why?" she whispers, her bloodshot eyes searching mine.

"Why what?" I frown.

Her eyes narrow the slightest bit, and I almost smile at her anger slipping through. "Bill told me, Kash. Why did you go to him?"

I lower myself to the floor in front of her and place my legs on either side, closing her between them, bending them at the knees. "I told you, Eve, I love you."

"No." She shakes her head. "No one can love someone like me."

"Why is that so hard to believe?" I ask, reaching out and tucking a lock of her silky smooth hair behind her ear.

Looking away from me, she stares up at the ceiling. I hate how brainwashed she is. My mother was the same. My father made her think she was nothing. Therefore, she expected nothing. "You're not broken, Eve."

She licks her lips. "If I fail…"

"You won't."

Her eyes find mine once again. "What if I freeze up?"

"You won't—"

"I can't be what you need," she growls, interrupting me.

I cup her face. "All you need to be is you. I'll take care of the rest."

She huffs, pushing me back, and gets to her feet. I follow. "I don't know why you and Bill keep feeding me these bullshit lines. I'm not going to fall for them."

I'm not sure what she means by that.

Eve squares her shoulders, and her eyes narrow on me, and I know what's coming before she even opens her mouth. She's going to

challenge me, and I'm going to have to hurt my girl to prove my point. "I won't marry you, Kashton."

"The deal is done, Eve."

She shakes her head. "No—"

"I already got confirmation from your daddy." She flinches at the way I refer to Bill being her father.

"You had no right," she grinds out.

"To love you?" I laugh.

"To take my life."

"I'm giving you one." Does she really think that killing and working for the Lords is all she's good for?

She storms off toward her room and slams the bathroom door shut. I enter the bedroom and lean against her dresser, waiting patiently. I knew she'd be upset. Push back. I'm prepared to do what must be done to keep my angry angel. Even if that means pissing her off.

The door swings open and she stands there with a syringe in her hand. "What's your plan, Eve? Knock me out?"

She doesn't answer.

"Then what? Run?"

Again, no answer, but the way her eyes darken tells me all I need to know. "How about this?" I push off the dresser. "You stick me, you're free." Her pretty green eyes look skeptical. Why would I let her go after I've fought so hard to keep her? "But if I stick you, you're mine."

She snorts.

"I'm serious, Everett."

She stiffens when I use her full name.

"No more back and forth. No more running." I walk up to her, and her eyes widen when they find mine. "When I win, and you wake up from your nap"—her eyes narrow at that—"you're mine. For good this time."

She sucks in a shaky breath, and I watch her loosen the grip on the syringe that she holds in the air. No way in hell am I letting her knock me out. She'll run. Have Bill hide her. And I just can't allow that. I'm not going to waste another six years of my life without her.

I reach out and run my knuckles over her racing pulse, and she lowers the syringe to her side. She has this inner battle. Eve doesn't want to give into what she wants. She prefers to be forced. I'll take her option away.

Leaning into her ear, I whisper, "You're going to make the perfect whore."

She slams her hand in my chest, shoving me back. "Fuck you, Kash." Lifting her other arm, she moves to poke me in the neck, but I said what I did on purpose. I want to piss her off. I stop the movement with my hand tightening around her wrist, and she drops the syringe with a scream.

I kick her legs out from underneath her, taking her to the floor, and straddle her hips, shoving her arms down to her sides to pin them as well. She bucks and screams while I reach over her, and she arches her back, seeing that I'm grabbing the syringe. I remove the lid with my teeth.

She gasps. "Kash—"

"A deal is a deal, Eve." I grip her cheeks to turn her face away from me and stick her in the neck.

Her body goes limp under mine. Her eyes soften and her breathing evens out. "Good girl." I push her wild hair from her pretty face. I didn't give her the full syringe like she planned on doing to me. My plan isn't to knock her out, just make her groggy.

"Come on, angel." I stand and pick her limp body up in my arms and walk her to the garage. I put her in the passenger seat of her car and then open the garage door with the clicker that hangs on the visor.

I make my way across the street to my house and back the car up my driveway. I can't just carry a passed-out Eve over to my house. Someone will call the cops in this neighborhood.

Once I've parked her car in my garage, I close the door and get her out, walking her to the basement. "Now let's get you ready to serve your Lord," I tell her.

Her vision starts to focus and she groans, looking around. "What—"

I check my watch. It's been an hour since I carried her out of her house. "Hello, angel." I stand beside her, taking in her naked body, admiring all the bruises I've given her up to this point and thinking about the ones I'm going to give her today.

She blinks, her eyes skimming the room, but all she can see is the ceiling, due to how I have her strapped down.

"Kash." She arches her neck and sucks in a deep breath. "You drugged me."

"I won the bet," I remind her. If this was me just waking up from sedation, I'd be on her bedroom floor, and she'd be long gone on a private jet. Probably on her way to another country.

"I can't…" She struggles and whimpers when she pulls on the restraints.

"Can't move?" I finish her thought. Her mind is still a little foggy. "It's because I've got you tied to a table in my basement."

Closing her eyes, she licks her lips.

"It's okay, Eve," I assure her, running my fingertips along her heaving chest before I wrap them around her delicate neck. I lean down when she opens her heavy eyelids, and I place my lips against hers. "I'm going to play with you."

She lifts her head the best she can, pressing her lips to mine, and I smile when she opens up for me. My girl wants to be used. I kiss her back, pinning her neck to the table, our tongues dancing, and she moans into my mouth.

I pull away and she sucks in a ragged breath. "I'm going to finish getting you ready."

Stepping away, I grab what I need, pour lube all over it, and then return to the side of the table. My fingers go to her pussy, and she moans while I play with it. Gently teasing her, running my fingers up and down her lips.

"Kash, please…" She trails off when I begin to push the dildo inside her, filling her cunt. Her body starts to tremble, and a soft cry fills the room.

"Perfect," I tell her. "I filled your ass while you were out. I know how much you love to struggle when I force a butt plug in, but I had

to do it before I could tie you down." I run my fingers down her trembling legs.

She doesn't respond, just fights the ropes.

I've got her lying on her back, arms tied underneath her, wrists secured in rope that is tied to the foot of the table. Her legs are spread wide, ankles secured to each corner, leaving her cunt open for me. It's not the most comfortable position, but it's not supposed to be.

A belt is strapped across her upper chest, another over her waist. "I made something for you," I tell her, grabbing what I have laid out on the counter. Walking over to her face, I hold up the surprise.

Her wide eyes go from it to me and then return to the item. "You're going to vow your life to me, Eve. And I shall do the same."

She licks her lips. "I vow," comes her soft voice.

I smile, pinching her nipple with my free hand, making it harden before I place the clothespin on it. I can't stand it straight up because I'm afraid it'll fall off, so I lay it on its side, clipping it around her nipple.

She hisses in a breath and arches her neck the best she can.

"You vow," I say, doing the same with the other, making her cry out. My hand falls between her open legs, and I grab a hold of her outer pussy lips and hold them together with my fingers when I encourage her. "Go on."

"We vow," we say in unison before I place the clothespin on her cunt.

Her cry fills the basement, and I rub my hand on her thigh, loving the way her body shakes uncontrollably. I'm just getting started. "You're doing great, angel."

I turn on the vibrators in her ass and cunt remotely from my cell.

Going to the head of the table, I undo the latch underneath it and slowly lower the edge while I hold her head, letting her go when it hangs off the side.

She lies with her head off the edge of the wooden table, trying to control her breathing. Her sexy body is covered in a thin line of sweat. It glistens under the bright light.

"Just lie there and come all over yourself, angel. That's all I want you to do for me, okay?"

She can't speak as I move to her head, and her heavy eyes glance up at me. I take a new piece of rope and make a slipknot around her hair as if it's a ponytail holder and tighten it. Then I make a loop, pulling the hair through it, successfully making a Lark's head hair tie.

Taking the remaining rope, I tie it underneath the table, securing her head in place. "Beautiful," I tell her, running my hand over her exposed body. Her arms are secured underneath her, legs spread wide and head hanging off the edge. "I'm going to prove to you, angel, that you were made for me."

Unzipping my bag, I toss what I want onto the table between her trembling legs. I grab the gag first and walk to where her head dangles off the end. "Open wide for me, Eve." I slide the metal into her left cheek, and she whimpers when I do the same with the right cheek. "Just a little more." I tell her as I push the metal, clicking it a few more times.

Her muffled cry fills the room, and spit covers her face when she tries to arch her back, making the table shake.

"You're okay, Eve." I run my knuckles down her exposed neck. "This isn't about sucking my cock. It's about fucking your throat." I feel her pulse race, and I smile down on her. "I can't wait for you to show me how good you've gotten at it."

Her heavy green eyes fall closed and her body tenses, the clothespins on her nipples moving slightly. "That's it, Eve. Come all over that toy for me."

Picking up the lube, I pour it over my hard cock and slide it into her open mouth. "My pretty angel." I grip her delicate neck. "I'm going to make you my filthy whore." Pushing to the back of her throat, I feel my cock bulge, and her body jerks the table violently. "Fuck," I groan, pulling out and sliding back in.

Slowly, I watch my pierced dick disappear down her throat.

"That's it." I pull out and hear her gasp. Then I do it again.

I set a slow and steady pace, allowing her to breathe while the vibrator in her cunt gets her off.

This isn't a race. I want her to remember this moment. A reminder that she belongs to me forever. There is no way out.

I look up to take in her body. It's trembling, her muscles tense as she pulls on the ropes that secure her in place. "Are you counting, angel?" I ask.

I pull out of her mouth and remove the clothespin from her right nipple at the same time.

A mumbling scream comes from her pretty lips. "It's more painful when you remove them," I inform her. Burying my cock back in her mouth, I clip the clothespin back on her nipple and feel her throat work on a whimper.

"Fuck, angel." I groan, feeling my balls tighten.

Pulling out, I come all over her drool-covered face and exposed neck. I quickly remove the gag and then the clothespins on her nipples, hearing her cry out. Then I do the same with her pussy and remove the vibrator.

"Good girl," I praise her, holding up the cum-covered egg. "That's my girl." I untie her and pick up her limp body and carry her upstairs.

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THIRTY-EIGHT



EVERETT

He played me, and I fucking let him.

Kashton knew my next move just by reading my face. I was going to knock his ass out and run for it. Get the hell away from here. To save him. Instead, he challenged me, and I lost. Fair and square.

You'll make the perfect dolly.

You'll make the perfect whore. His words were like a knife to my chest. It made me angry. I had to fight. To show him that he didn't own me. He won. I lost.

He may marry me, but I'll be nothing more than a toy to him. I'll never be known as a Lady in our world, and I'll never get to be a mother in mine.

I sit on the end of my bed, gulping down a water while Kashton rushes around my house. He brought me home after he was done fucking my face and gave me a bath. I sat there in the tub in silence while he washed my hair and his cum off my trembling body.

Everything hurts, including my still burning nipples and pussy lips. I already want him to fuck me again, and it's giving me mixed feelings. I'm not sure if that's progress or regression.

I didn't feel the need to vomit afterward, so maybe progress is the correct answer.

I look over the clothespins in my hand. Who knew something so small could be so powerful? Each one has one of the vows written in his handwriting.



They appear to look like any other wooden clothespin, but the ends have been dipped in something rough to cause pain when used.

"What is on these?" I call loud enough so Kashton can hear me.

He answers from my bathroom, knowing what I'm referring to. "I painted Mod Podge on the tips and then dipped them in coarse-grain sand. Once they were dry, I sprayed a clear lacquer over it to help seal them."

He made these for me? I love how much thought he puts into making sure I feel…something. That he keeps me present when I want to curl into myself. Kashton wants me to know that he's the one playing with me. That I'm getting off for him.

"Ready?" He exits my bathroom, pulling my Prada embroidered fabric trolley and matching duffel bag.

"Yeah," I answer softly, getting to my feet.

While he was bathing me, he talked me into going back to Carnage with him. Well, I can't say that—he told me we were going to Carnage, and I didn't have the mental strength to argue with him.

If that was his plan, it worked. All Lords are calculated in how they play the game.

Taking my hand, he escorts me out to my garage and opens my passenger door. "You're not following me?" I wonder.

"No. Leaving my bike in my garage. I'll come get it another time."

I fall into the car while he places my bags in the trunk before getting behind the wheel.

I look out my window. It's still daylight. The clock tells me it's a little after four p.m. How long were we in his basement? How many times did I come all over myself?

I can't answer either question.

He reaches over, and my fingers automatically curl into his, holding his hand. It's terrifying how good it feels to be wanted by someone you know will desert you when they find out who you truly are.

"How do you feel?" he asks, interrupting my internal rambling. He always knows when my mind slips away.

"Fine," I answer.

"Eve." He brings my hand to his lips and kisses my knuckles. "Talk to me."

Laying my head against the headrest, I give him a reassuring smile. "Really. Just tired." The sedative still lingers in my system.

"When we get home, I'll have Jessie bring us some lunch and have Devin give you an IV. Afterward, we'll take a nap. How's that sound?"

Is he going to tie me up and make me wait to be played with while we nap? Fuck, I hope so. "Sounds good."

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THIRTY-NINE



EVERETT

"The guys and I have to go to Vegas. Will you come with me?" he asks, standing in the doorway of his bathroom with a toothbrush in his hand and a towel wrapped around his hips.

I roll onto my side, propping my head up. It's been a week since he found me sitting on my kitchen floor, and we've been hiding out here at Carnage since. He's tried to keep my mind off the Lords with sex. It's working. I haven't had much alcohol. They say those with addictions trade one for the other. He's become mine.

Before I answer, I allow my eyes to travel over his chiseled abs and hard chest. The ink that covers his skin is mesmerizing. One of the sexiest things I've ever seen.

"Ashtyn and Charlotte are coming. I figured you could help keep them company while the guys and I take care of business."

If he only knew how much I can't stand Ashtyn, he wouldn't have used her to try and convince me to go.

"You want me to babysit two grown adults?" My eyes finally find his. "Because I promise you, I'm not the most responsible one out of the bunch." Charlotte holds that title.

"I wouldn't call it babysitting." He turns, giving me his back, and it's just as beautiful as the front. Entering the bathroom, he finishes brushing his teeth.

"Then what would you call it?"

Coming back to the bedroom, he shoves me onto my back and straddles me. His towel is now long gone. He pushes hair off my face as his eyes run over my jaw and down my neck to my bare

chest. A shiver runs up my spine when he licks his lips like he's ready to feast on me. "Charlotte and Ashtyn…" He trails off.

I place my hands on either side of his freshly shaven face and force his eyes back to mine. "You can fuck me after you tell me why you think I'd want to go to Vegas with you only to stay in a hotel while you run all over the city." I'll do it, of course. Charlotte is just too sweet and needs me.

"Haidyn and Ashtyn have a past."

It's cute that he thinks I don't know about their history. "Haidyn has fucked her," I correct him. "And you think Charlotte is jealous?"

"I wouldn't call it jealousy…maybe tension."

"You've fucked Ashtyn. Should I be jealous?" I reach up and wrap my arms around his neck.

"Fuck no." He chuckles. "It meant nothing."

A man's go-to words when he explains his last fuck to his current one. My fingers brush through his dark hair, my nails scraping his scalp. His lips part on a deep moan when I speak. "Well, it doesn't mean anything when we fuck either. Going to tell that to your next fuck?"

"Take that back," he orders, frowning.

"Make me."

"We both know you're going to be the only woman I fuck for the rest of my life, angel." His large tatted hands wrap around my throat, and he squeezes. I arch my neck for him and he lowers his lips to mine. "When you take it back, you can breathe."

I swallow against his hands, my pulse racing as I try to suck in a breath but am denied. My hands instinctively come up to wrap around his tatted muscular forearms and he smiles down at me. "Beautiful." His lips gently touch my parted ones. "You want me to choke you out, Eve?"

My eyes grow heavy. My body shuddering and clit throbbing.

"It only takes seven seconds to render you unconscious. I'd rather you not pass out, angel." His eyes search mine. "Does my cock mean anything to you?"

I give the slightest nod, my chest burning at the lack of oxygen.

"I can't hear you."

My lips move in hopes of speaking, but nothing comes out. The room begins to fade in and out, and my arms drop to my sides, no longer able to hold them up.

"Come on, Eve. You know what I want." He loosens his hands, and I gasp in a shaky breath and blink rapidly.

"It…it means something."

He rewards me with a winning smile. "Of course it does, angel. Your pussy was made for my cock." Reaching between our bodies, he grabs a hold of his hard dick and slides it into my soaked cunt.

I'm dazed; the room is still spinning. He starts to fuck me hard, causing unintelligible noises to flow from my numb lips like vomit. The headboard hits the wall, and his grunts fill my ears when he lowers his body on top of mine. I already have trouble breathing, and he grabs a hold of the back of my knees and shoves them apart, fucking me deeper.

"This means something to you, Eve," he growls. "Say it."

"It means something." My eyes fall closed as that feeling starts to build and I clench my pussy down on him, trying to suck him in. Needing more. Harder…faster…I'm not sure what it is. I just know what he's doing isn't enough.

And he knows it.

He slows to an agonizing pace, and I groan. "Harder, Kash. I need more."

He chuckles. "See how I control the situation? How I decide what you get and when you get it?" He pulls out and I slump into the mattress.

"Kash-ton," I choke out.

"Slow and steady will leave you wanting more," he taunts me.

"You better fuck me."

"Or what, Eve?" He gently kisses my neck, slowly pushing his cock inside me, and my breath catches in my lungs.

I don't respond. Instead, I wait for him to pull away, and I slap him across the face. It wasn't as hard as I wanted to because I'm weak right now, still trying to catch my breath.

His laughter fills the room, and I go to slap him again, but he pulls out, grabs my hips, and flips me over.

He yanks my arms behind my back and holds my wrists in one hand while he fists my hair and his knees shove mine open wide. Wetness leaks from my pussy at his aggressiveness. “Want me to treat you like a whore, angel?”

I try to bury my face in the bed, but he just shoves my cheek further into the mattress, not letting me hide.

“Want to fight me while I take it from you?”

Tears sting my eyes, and I yank on my arms, but he doesn’t budge. He easily overpowers me. I have no leverage.

“Beg me, Eve.”

“Ka-sh—” I choke out.

“What’s that?” he mocks. “You don’t sound like a woman who wants to be used.”

I rock my hips back and forth. My silent request for him to fuck me. He lets go of my hair to slap my ass, and I whimper. My breath is taken away with his weight on my back when he leans over and opens his nightstand. He repositions my arms before securing them with a zip tie.

“That’s better.” He runs a hand between my parted legs and plays with my pussy. “Now you’re at my mercy, Eve. What am I going to do to you? Want me to fuck your ass?” His fingers run up over my cunt to my ass, smearing my wetness. “Want me to make it hurt?”

I’m gasping, trying to catch my breath.

“Want me to just leave you here for the day?”

“No,” I rush out, struggling underneath his muscular body. “Please…no. I need you.” I’d beg for whatever he wants to give me right now. “Make it hurt.”

His cock slides back into my pussy, and I whimper at his large size stretching me. I’m already so sore, but I love it. He leans over my back, and his hand covers my mouth when he places his lips by my ear. “Be a good girl for me and take it.”

I nod the best I can as I breathe heavily through my nose. Then, like the motherfucker he is, he pinches my nostrils, taking away my air.

I buck underneath him. “That’s what I want to feel, angel.” He pulls out and then slams into me. “Fight me.”

I try to turn my head from side to side, needing to breathe, but his hand doesn't slip. My chest burns and fresh tears sting my eyes.

"Come on, Eve. You can do better than that." He kisses the side of my face while his cock fucks my pussy.

"You act like you want it." He laughs darkly next to my ear at my shitty attempt, and I blink away the tears.

I mumble helplessly into his hand while I give everything I have. Twisting and turning, bucking and kicking out my feet, but his legs hold mine wide open. My hips are screaming, and my back is arched at a painful angle while he smashes my tied arms between us with his weight.

"That's better." It doesn't faze him, though. "Feel how wet you are for this? For my cock to fuck you like you don't want it?"

I'm dripping for him.

My fight is useless, but that's the point. To wear myself out so it's easier for him to take it. But Kash knows I like the fight. The pain. The pleasure.

My chest aches and my throat is burning. My body starts to soften, but he doesn't slow. His cock fucks me ruthlessly while my pussy grips him tightly. "That's my good whore," he whispers as I come on his pierced dick before my eyes fall closed.

KASHTON

The following day, I'm boarding our private jet hand in hand with Eve. She doesn't seem all that thrilled to be going to Vegas with me, but I knew she couldn't resist when I mentioned the girls. For some reason, she has a soft spot for Charlotte.

Haidyn and Charlotte are already on board. She lies across the back couch with her feet in Haidyn's lap while he rubs them.

"Everything okay?" I ask, sitting across from them.

"Yeah." Charlotte nods with a groan. "My body just hates me."

"Have you had anything to eat today?" Eve asks her, snuggling into my side.

"I've tried." She pulls her feet from Haidyn's lap and sits up. "Can't keep anything down."

"I called Devin—"

"There's nothing he can do, Haidyn," Charlotte interrupts him. "It just has to pass."

Saint and Ashtyn board next, and she remains quiet as they take the seats up front. Then the last passenger walks on.

I tap Eve's thigh to let her know I'm getting up before I head to the front of the jet, and Haidyn follows.

"Hey, man." Haidyn gives Hooke a handshake hug. And I do the same before Saint.

"Sweetheart?" Saint turns to Ashtyn.

"Hmm?" She looks up at him from her cell. She was in the middle of typing away, and I'm sure it was Jasmine. Since she's in Las Vegas, I bet Ashtyn's already told her that she's coming.

"Will you sit in the back with the girls? I need to go over business with the guys."

"Sure." She gets up and makes her way to the back couch and plops down next to Eve. Charlotte has already stretched out, taking up her whole couch. Eve pulls her shades out of her purse and places them on before picking up the Hermès blanket draped across the back of the couch and pulling it up over her. A clear sign she plans on ignoring Ashtyn for the duration of the flight.

"Are they expecting us?" Hooke begins.

Haidyn nods. "Yes. We'll go to Kingdom first, get the girls settled into the room. Then the Kings are going to take us to the Airport."

"Eve?" I push her sunglasses to the top of her head as her heavy eyelids flutter open. "We're here."

Stretching, I pull the blanket off her and toss it to the side, then take her hand to help her up. We exit the jet and get into one of several waiting cars while the others get into their own.

"I don't know why I'm so tired." She yawns, dropping her head onto my shoulder.

I chuckle. "I do."

She slaps my chest playfully. We ride the short distance down the Strip and pull up to the back of Kingdom.

When we enter the hotel and casino, the Kings are already waiting to escort us to the Royal Floor fifty stories up.

Ashtyn knows them, so they say their hellos while Haidyn introduces them to Charlotte. Then it's my turn. Eve is shaking Titan's hand when I introduce her to the next. "Eve, this is Cross."

She meets his stare, and he looks her up and down, opening his mouth. "It's nice to meet you." She reaches out to shake his hand before he can get out what he was going to say, and I wonder what the fuck that was about.

Eve and I haven't had the talk about how she was here for four years chasing Ashtyn for Adam, but now I think it's time to have it. Do the Kings know her? Was she working for them here at Kingdom or at Glass?

The thought of her being a Queen makes me want to take a belt to her ass and a knife to every unlucky guy who paid to sleep with her. But that can't be my girl. No. Eve didn't sleep around, so a Queen is out of the question. But she slept with Adam. It's not like I'm the only guy she's ever fucked.

"This will be your room for however long you need to stay." Titan turns to look at the girls as we enter the Royal Suite. "It has four suites, its own butler, and twenty-four seven private staff. A sauna, movie room, and gym. Just press one on the phone, and someone will get you whatever you need."

"Thanks," they all say in unison.

Our bags are brought up, and we all make our way to our rooms. "I have to go," I tell Eve when she opens the sliding glass door and steps out onto a balcony.

"Okay." She doesn't bother turning around to look at me.

I wrap my arms around her from behind and kiss her hair, inhaling the strawberry scent. "I'll make it up to you."

She spins in my arms and wraps hers around my neck. "We'll see if you keep your promises."

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FORTY



EVERETT

The guys left about an hour ago. I don't know where they went or when Kashton will be back. Who knows how long we'll be in Sin City, so I went ahead and unpacked our things because I don't like living out of a suitcase.

I walk out of our bedroom and see the girls must be in their rooms. I'm already bored to death. I'm not much of a gambler, so I'm not sure what to do. Plus, I'm not sure how Saint and Haidyn would feel if I took their wives out on the town. I've seen what Ashtyn does when she runs wild in Las Vegas.

I knock on Charlotte's door, and she opens it with a smile on her face.

"They said something about our own private theater. I thought we could watch a movie," I offer. Kashton sent me a text of ideas to do with the girls without having to leave the Royal Suite. He was trying to be helpful, but I took it as a subtle hint to stay put.

"Sounds good. Give me ten minutes."

I close the door and walk over to the one I think Ashtyn and Saint are occupying and knock on it. She takes a little longer to open, and I give her a smile. *Be nice.* I ignored her on the plane, but I can't do that the entire time we're here. "Charlotte and I are going to watch a movie. Want to join us?"

"Yes." A bright smile spreads across her face, and I feel bad for hating her so much. I've spent so much time all alone that I never stopped to think about someone like her—someone who once had friends and then lost them.

I give them both a few minutes to get ready while I call down to whoever is in charge of this room. I ask if we can watch a movie and am told they will get the room set up with everything we need.

Less than fifteen minutes later, we walk into a room that could easily seat fifty people with an IMAX screen and all the goodies we could think of, from popcorn to candy and ICEEs.

"What would you like to watch?" the man asks.

"I love *Pretty Woman*," Charlotte answers.

"Hmm." Ashtyn frowns at that option. "What about *Titanic*?"

"Oh, I like that movie too." Charlotte nods, sitting in a black leather chair. She presses the button to recline her seat, wrapping up in a blanket. She places her cell in her lap and stares at it for a second. When she looks up and notices I'm watching her, she gives me a big smile.

"Everything okay?" I ask. She looks worried. Maybe she's still getting sick and needs something.

"Yep." When she looks away, her smile falls.

I glance at Ashtyn, and she's staring at me expectantly. Oh, yeah. *Titanic.* I shrug. "Sure." I'm up for whatever. I just needed something to do. I don't want to be that woman who waits around for a man. I almost roll my eyes at that thought. I followed him to Vegas, didn't I? That's already a failure in my book.

The butler starts getting everything ready, and Ashtyn grabs a cherry sucker out of a glass bowl. "Want one?" She holds another out to me.

"Thanks." I take it as she tries to hand one off to Charlotte.

"No, thank you." She yawns, and I have a feeling she'll be the first one out.

We all get comfortable, and the movie starts. As I predicted, Charlotte is out, with her cell in her hand before Jack and Rose's iconic back-of-the-boat scene.

Ashtyn sucks on her sucker like it's a dick, and the slurping noises are grating on my nerves. She pulls it from her lips. "This…this is my favorite scene." She looks at me, smiling.

And I don't like it. It's one of those *I know something you don't know* smiles.

She shoves the sucker into her mouth once again and goes back to trying to get it off. I watch her, wanting to slap it out of her pouty lips.

KASHTON

The guys and I enter the conference room of the old, abandoned airport that they refer to as the Airport. It is known as the most elite illegal gambling ring in Nevada. The Mason brothers own it and are already sitting at a table, awaiting our arrival.

"Hooke," Tanner Mason, the oldest brother, says. "Since when do you need an entourage to talk business?"

"What business?" Bones digs.

"That's not why I'm here." Hooke speaks to Tanner, ignoring Bones.

"Then what is the emergency, boys?" Tanner looks to each of us.

Haidyn pulls out his cell and scrolls through it for a second before holding it out. "You sent me this video. We need to find the woman."

Tanner frowns. "Why? Don't you have Hudson? Just ask him." He, too, is in the video with the woman, walking around the Airport.

"Can't." Haidyn shakes his head.

"Did you kill him already?" Trey, the youngest of the brothers laughs.

"Nope, but I ripped his eyes out. He can't see shit. And when I asked, he refused to cooperate." Haidyn grunts.

"You ripped his eyes out and he survived?" Trey sounds impressed.

"Very fortunate, I know." Haidyn smiles proudly.

"Why is she important?" Turner, the middle brother, takes a look at the video.

"She was a Queen," Titan answers. "A few years back."

"She's also my assistant," Hooke adds. "Has been for two years now. As far as I knew, she didn't know the Lords existed. Then she gets spotted with one in Vegas…" He shakes his head. "We're missing something."

"Technically, Hudson isn't a Lord," Saint reminds him.

"Close enough." Hooke huffs. "Whether he had been initiated or not, he was still working for them."

"Maybe she was working that weekend?" Turner offers.

"No," Titan says. "All bookings for Queens go through me. She knows that."

"Maybe he offered her a bonus to keep it hush-hush. Old client who wanted to meet up? I'm sure it happens." Trey shrugs and adds, "You can clearly tell she's *working*."

Titan runs a hand through his hair, not wanting to argue because it could be possible.

Hooke speaks. "That's an option, but she told me she was coming here for a photo shoot."

Tanner sits back, crossing his arms over his chest. "What kind of photo shoot?"

"It was for a magazine. The photographer was Harvey something." He waves his hand in the air.

The Mason brothers exchange a look, and Hooke steps forward and barks, "Fucking speak."

Tanner stands and Haidyn grabs Hooke's upper arm to pull him back from the table. "We'll check the cameras. Do a facial recognition, but it could take a few days."

"We'll wait," Saint tells them.

"What exactly are we looking for?"

Hooke sighs because that's an open question. "If she was with one Lord, I'm assuming she knows others." He shrugs. "I'd look through footage before and after the date that she was here with Hudson."

Tanner nods. "We'll keep you updated."

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FORTY-ONE



EVERETT

"Charlotte?" I tap her shoulder.

"Hmm?" She opens her heavy eyelids and looks up at me.

"The movie is over."

She pushes out her bottom lip. "I slept through the entire thing?"

I chuckle. "Yeah. You obviously needed it." The pregnancy is draining her in more ways than one.

We get back to the living room of the suite, and I notice Ashtyn has a little more pep in her step than usual.

I'm exhausted and Charlotte can barely keep her eyes open. "Good night, girls," Charlotte says through a yawn before disappearing into her room.

I enter our room and plop down on the bed. I pull up Kashton's contact on my cell and press Call. He answers immediately.

"Hey, angel." I ignore the way my heart flutters at the nickname. "We're about to head back to Kingdom—"

"Does *Titanic* mean anything to you?" I interrupt him.

He's silent, and I wonder if he's stepping away from the guys. "*Titanic*?" he finally asks, but this time he's lowered his voice, only proving my suspicions.

"Yeah. The movie. Does it mean anything to you?" For three hours, I sat there trying to figure out what the fuck she meant by her *favorite part*. She wanted Charlotte and me to know that for a reason. Even though Charlotte had already passed out.

"No."

"Think the first thing that comes to mind when I say it. *Titanic*. Movie. Jack and Rose. Cherry sucker," I rattle off, rolling onto my

back and staring up at the ceiling.

He's silent long enough that my pulse begins to race. I sit up and clench the cell in my head. "What does it mean to you, Kash?"

"The movie means nothing to me," he whispers. "It's nothing."

It's the same thing he said when I asked if I should be jealous that he's slept with Ashtyn. He's lying to me. "What does it mean to Ashtyn?" I reword the question.

"Everett." He sighs, and I know I'm not wrong.

I've never had a boyfriend—or even been in a relationship, for that matter—but I imagine if I ever did, I'd be the girl who would need to know everything he did with the girl before me. And although Ashtyn wasn't his girlfriend, she was in his life. Probably more than a typical girlfriend would be. Her twin brother was their best friend. They were all inseparable, and I need to know what significance this fucking movie holds for her. And why was she shoving it in my face? I'm no threat to her. I don't want her husband, and neither does Charlotte.

His refusal to answer tells me all I need to know. "Good night, Kash."

"Eve—"

I hang up on him and get off the bed. Storming out of our suite, I go to her door and knock on it. I'll go to the source.

"Hey. Need something?" Ashtyn asks.

Stepping inside the room, I slam the door shut behind me. "Charlotte is a better person than I am."

She's got a fake smile plastered on her face and flutters her lashes at me. "What do you mean?"

I step into her, and it starts to waver. "You may be pregnant, but your face isn't, and I will knock your teeth out of your fucking mouth."

The smile disappears, and her face goes white. "What…?" She gasps, her hand on her chest. "Why do you hate me so much? Is it because I've slept with Kashton?"

This bitch! She wanted me to know that information. As if I didn't already know she was their whore. Made it sound innocent but wanted to make sure I was aware that she was part of his past.

I want to laugh in her face, but she wouldn't understand why I find that funny. I'm not the least bit jealous of Ashtyn. I believe Kashton when he said it was nothing. What pisses me off is how she blatantly disrespects Charlotte. "Honey, Kash took what Saint offered him. I let him take whatever he wants. We're not the same."

Her eyes narrow on me, and I can't fight back the smile. There it is. The jealousy that I know is there. The very thing Charlotte says doesn't exist. She feels sorry for Ashtyn. I fucking don't.

Ashtyn wants to belong to all of them. She wants to be theirs, but it's just not happening. They're each moving on, and it's killing her. She's not the center of their world anymore. Pity.

She doesn't need sympathy. The bitch needs to be humbled.

"I'm not sure what point you're trying to make, but I assure you, Charlotte couldn't care less." Ashtyn squares her shoulders at my words. "You have a husband. So if you need a dick to suck, beg him for it." I give her my back and slam her door shut, done with this conversation.

I'm not sure what it will accomplish. Maybe it was the fact that I wanted her to know I see what she's doing. How she's throwing herself at men who aren't hers. Or how she wants Charlotte to doubt Haidyn. Either way, I feel better.

"Everything okay?" A sleepy-looking Charlotte opens her door before I enter mine, hearing the commotion.

"Yeah." I give her a reassuring smile.

Her eyes go to Saint and Ashtyn's door, then back to mine just as Muffin darts out of her room between her feet. She brought her cat with her. The thing is spoiled rotten, and I love it.

"Hey, pretty kitty." I pick her up and scratch her neck, making her purr. "What kind of cat is she?" I ask, already knowing. I just want to distract her from the conversation I had with Ashtyn. I know Charlotte has doubts in her mind, but she tries to convince herself there's nothing there. And I believe there isn't…for Haidyn.

"She's a Persian."

"She's beautiful." I set the cat down, and she runs back into the room.

Just then a doorbell rings throughout the suite. Charlotte frowns at me, and I shrug. The door to Ashtyn's bedroom opens, and she tosses her hair over her shoulder, making her way to the front double doors. Opening one, a woman with red hair enters, holding two bottles of tequila.

I know exactly who she is and why she's here. Thankfully, she has no clue who I am.

"Who wants to drink ourselves into a coma?" she asks with a bright smile.

Ashtyn laughs, closing the door behind her. Then she looks from me to Charlotte. "Well, *we're* all pregnant, so you'll be drinking alone."

I feel a pain in my chest at Ashtyn's words, but I plaster a smile on my face. "I'm not. I'll have a few with you." If Ashtyn is trying to force me to hide in my room, it's not going to happen.

"Perfect." The redhead sets the bottles on the bar top and grabs two glasses.

I feel Ashtyn's eyes on me, but I ignore her. I know this is another way of her throwing something in my face. It just proves that I can't trust her and my gut instinct to hate her is correct.

"I'm going to call it a night." Charlotte yawns. Honestly, I don't know how she's still standing.

"Good night," Ashtyn sings to her, and I want to deliver the threat of knocking her teeth out. She's got an audience, so she's going to be even more insufferable than usual.

I'll have a few drinks. Then I'm going to shower and pass out.

The redhead sits at the bar, pouring me a drink. Her cell sits by her glass when it starts to ring. She quickly ignores the call and turns it over. Giving me a big smile, she taps her glass to mine. "Cheers."

"Cheers," I agree and take a big drink.

KASHTON

I enter the suite and come to a stop when I see Ashtyn, Jasmine, and Everett sitting at the bar. Haidyn, Hooke, and Saint enter behind me, and Haidyn doesn't even offer a *good night* when he realizes his wife must be in bed. He heads straight to their bedroom, closing the door behind him.

Well, this can't end well. Is this why Eve is so mad at me? Why she called me asking about *Titanic*? Jasmine doesn't have anything to do with that, though.

"Kashton." Ash throws her arms out. "Look who came to visit." She gestures to Jasmine, as if I could miss the redhead I used to pay to fuck.

Eve tosses a shot back and slams the glass down, then gets up from her seat at the bar, heading to our bedroom.

"They're—"

"I better get going." Jasmine stands, interrupting Ashtyn before she can say anything stupid.

If Eve wants to know about everyone I've fucked in my past, I'll tell her. Jasmine knows we never had anything other than sex. Hell, I paid her for it. Every. Single. Time. Even after she stopped being a Queen. It was a transaction and that was it. She may be a part of our world, but we never had a future. Not one that I wanted anyway.

"What?" Ashtyn pouts. "We just got started."

Jasmine stumbles to throw away one of the empty bottles of tequila.

"You should crash here," Ashtyn tells her.

Jasmine shakes her head. "Absolutely not. I arrived in an Uber; I'll leave in one."

"I'll take you home."

We all turn around to see Hooke checking his Rolex as if to see how far past his bedtime it is. He is still on East Coast time. He looks tired, but his tone says he feels obligated to be a gentleman.

Jasmine snorts. "No thanks. I'll take my chances walking the Strip. Alone." Her cell rings and she sighs before answering. "Hello? Yeah, I'm about to head home. I'll stop by on the way." Hanging up, she walks toward the door.

Hooke moves to block her exit. "Booty call?" he asks, arching a brow.

"Who I fuck is none of your business, but no. It was Kink. There's an issue—"

"I'll take you," he interrupts her. Opening the door, he ushers her out while ignoring her protests.

I don't even bother to tell anyone good night and storm off to our room. I see Eve's phone on the bed. She turned it off after she hung up on me. I know because I called her several times, and each one went straight to voicemail.

The shower is running, and I rip open the glass door to see her standing under the spray. "What the fuck was that phone call about?" I demand.

She ignores me, and I reach in, grabbing her arm and yanking her around to face me. "Eve?"

"It sucks being ignored, doesn't it?"

I wonder how much she had to drink since our phone call because Jasmine threw an entire empty bottle of tequila away. And I know it was just her and Jasmine drinking because Ashtyn is pregnant, and she isn't that stupid.

"What the hell happened?" I command. "I was only gone for five hours."

She starts soaping up her naked body, and I watch the way her hands caress her breasts, down her waist and around her hips. The suds cascade over her thighs, and my cock hardens at the thought of shoving her to her knees and fucking her mouth until I come all over her face.

"Eve?" I grind out. Between whatever shit Ashtyn is trying to pull and Eve ignoring me, my irritated mood has gone sour quickly.

She finishes rinsing, turns off the water, steps out, and yanks the towel off the hook on the wall. "Well, we decided to watch a movie, and Ashtyn chose *Titanic* while sucking on a cherry sucker like it was someone's dick. That was my first clue, then she made sure to tell me how much she 'looooved' a certain part. I can only imagine why." She looks me up and down with disgust. "Surely it had to do with all of your dicks. Which means you lied to me."

Jesus Christ. I run a hand down my face. "I didn't lie. The movie meant nothing to me." She asked me a question, and I answered. Plain and simple.

"What do you call it?" she demands.

"The first time we…" I trail off.

"Fucked her," Eve growls.

"Yes." I grind my teeth but continue. "I dropped by Saint's dad's house, and the three of them were in the media room, and something was playing on the screen." I wasn't paying much attention to that. "We…took our turns." Eve's eyes narrow on me. "What do you want me to say?" I ask, throwing my arms out to my sides. "The truth or lie?"

"The truth," she snaps.

"Then don't get mad at me for it," I shout. Eve huffs, and I lower my voice. "She wants to piss you off." The fact that Jasmine was here proves that.

"No. She wants to fuck Haidyn."

I snort at that. "That'll never happen." Not again anyway.

She turns around, leaning her ass against the counter, and crosses her arms over her wet chest. "Tell me that if given the chance, she wouldn't fuck him."

I shake my head. "Haidyn would never—"

"But she would."

"Why do you care so much?" I wonder. "That's between Haidyn, his wife, Saint, and his wife." Haidyn would never step out on Charlotte. No matter what Saint would allow Ashtyn to do with another man. I'm not even sure if Saint would let Ashtyn do it anymore. He was all for letting us use her when he brought her back from Vegas, but we didn't want her. I've always cared for Ashtyn, but I'm not the same man I was back in college. And I still haven't forgiven her for shooting Saint.

"I don't trust her." She huffs. "She blatantly throws herself at him, and I don't know if Saint sees it or chooses to ignore it, but if Charlotte isn't going to stick up for herself, I will."

"What does that mean?" I ask.

She shrugs, turning around to give me her back, and starts brushing her wet hair.

I slap her ass so hard she jumps with a yelp. "Explain," I demand, ripping the brush from her hand and tossing it across the bathroom.

Spinning back around, her wet hair slaps my chest. "It means I threatened to knock her teeth out of her mouth."

My eyes widen. "Fuck, Eve…"

"She wanted to make a statement." She shrugs again. "So I made one of my own."

I place my hands on either side of her face. "You're crazy, you know that?"

She lifts her chin. "Let her go cry to her husband like a little bitch, and when he comes to me, I'll fill him in on what she's been doing."

"Saint isn't going to *come to you*," I tell her. I highly doubt Ashtyn will say anything to Saint because if she is playing a game that Charlotte is choosing to ignore, she now knows that Everett isn't. "I won't let him."

She snorts. "I don't need you to pretend to take my side over your brother's wife."

I frown at her choice of words. "I'll always take up for you. You come first. Over anyone else." I'm beginning to understand why my brothers went so far to do what they did for their wives. Why nothing else—not even me—mattered to them. If it came down to it, I'd pick Eve. Without a thought.

Rolling her eyes, she says, "And then she invited Jasmine. I know you've fucked her."

"It meant nothing." She's trying to act like it doesn't matter, but the fact that she even brought it up tells me otherwise. I like my girl jealous, but not at the cost of her trust. She can trust me. I'd never hurt her. Not like that. She's it for me.

"I don't care if it was last week, Kash, or since we arrived here today."

"I haven't been with anyone since you—"

"If you want to fuck them, fuck them." She shrugs, pretending like she doesn't care. "It's the fact that Ashtyn is trying to fuck with me and Charlotte that matters." Eve goes to turn back around once more, but I keep a hold of her, refusing to let her dismiss me.

"Listen to me, angel." My girl needs to unwind. She's stressed and drunk. "I'm serious." I drop my hands to push her wet hair off her shoulders. "Let it go. Ashtyn is just being Ashtyn. She'll get bored

and move on." I think she's lashing out because of Adam *dying*. Maybe the babies…hell, maybe she's just being a bitch. "Charlotte is a big girl, and Haidyn would never do anything to hurt his wife. And I'm not going anywhere. You're my girl. My angel." I give her a reassuring smile. "I promise…she's just fucking with you."

She huffs, and I can smell the tequila on her breath. "It's working."

Biting back a smile at her confession, I step into her, not caring that my clothes are soaking up the water that still drips down her naked body. "It's not worth it. She isn't worth it."

"Easier said than done," she mumbles.

"What about you and Cross?" I go ahead and ask. If she's going to be pissed at me, I might as well get the answers I want.

"Excuse me?" She steps back. "What about him?"

"Has he fucked you?"

Her eyes narrow. "You can't be serious."

"I saw the way he looked at you and the way you spoke before he could say too much."

She looks away, jaw sharpening. "No." Her eyes find mine once more. "Cross has never *fucked* me."

"Then what was that?" I push.

Running a hand over her hair, she sighs. "He gave me my tattoo."

My eyes drop to her hip. "Your butterfly?"

"Yes," she hisses. "It's the only tattoo I have. As you can see." She lifts her arms out wide and turns in a circle before slapping them down to her thighs.

My cell goes off and her eyes hold mine. "You going to get that?"

It's a challenge. She thinks I'm hiding something from her. Eve can go through my phone at any time.

I remove my cell to see it's a text and frown.

"Who is it?" she asks, wringing out her hair with her towel while looking at me in the mirror.

"It's an unknown number."

She turns around. "The Lords? Is it my assignment for initiation?" Eve nibbles nervously on her lip, her mood changing quickly.

I open it up. "It's Adam. He wants to see me in person when we get back." I pocket my cell, and she looks away from me. Pulling her

body flush with mine, I go to kiss her, but she pushes me away.

"Let me brush my teeth," she protests. "The taste of tequila is making me want to vomit."

I drop the conversation about her and Cross because I believe her. Turning to leave the bathroom, I prop my shoulder up against the doorframe and watch her in the mirror. "Let's go out."

She rinses her mouth out and turns to face me. "Go out?"

Nodding, I push off and walk over to her. "I want to take my girl out."

A soft smile pulls at the corner of her plump lips. "I'll have to get ready."

"Then get ready." I run my hand through her wet hair. "Do your makeup and fix your hair. Put on a party dress." They say this town never sleeps.

Leaning in, I press my lips to hers, and she lifts her right leg, wrapping it around my hip.

"Will you fuck me before?" she whispers against my lips.

I smile. "Of course. But you're not allowed to come."

She groans and her nails dig into my sides through my shirt, pinching my skin. "You love to make me wait."

"I love to see you desperate," I correct her, taking a step back and order, "Remove my belt."

Nibbling on her bottom lip, she quickly undoes the buckle and pulls the leather from the loops. Then she holds it out to me.

I take it and command, "Turn around."

Doing as she's told, she places her hands behind her back, and I tie them off with my belt. I step into her and grab a fistful of her hair, yanking her head back, making her cry out. "Do not come, Eve. Do you understand?"

She tries to nod but whimpers, shuffling on her feet. "I…I understand."

"We'll see." I quickly undo my jeans and shove them out of the way to pull my dick out. I need to be inside of her.

I run my free hand over her pussy, and she moans, pushing back against me, and I smile to myself. Taking my hard cock in my hand, I slide into her cunt, listening to her breath hitch as I stretch her to

accommodate my size. “Fuck,” I groan. “Goddamn, Eve.” My eyes drop to watch my cock disappear as I bend her over the counter once more.

The sound of our bodies slapping fills the room over her moans and whimpers. I’m so fucking hard for her. My girl. “Watch yourself, Eve,” I command, yanking her head off the mirror. “Look how pretty you are when I fuck you.”

Her heavy eyes find mine in the mirror, and I fuck her harder. An animalistic need comes over me, and I slam her hips into the side of the counter, knowing I’m bruising her. They’ll look beautiful later when I tie her to the bed and make her beg for me.

Her pussy clenches, and I slam into her, making her cry out. “Do not fucking come, Eve,” I remind her.

“I’m…” Her heavy eyes fall shut. “I’m trying…not to.”

I let go of her hair, grip her hips, and drop my eyes to watch my cock slide in and out of her tight cunt. I’m so close. This is a quickie. For me. To give her something to look forward to later.

My balls tighten and I smile to myself as I slam forward and come inside of her. Pulling out, I take a stumbling step back, and she slumps against the counter, hands still tied behind her back.

I reach forward, grip her arms, and yank her to stand. Turning her to face me, I grab her neck with one hand, feeling her pulse race, while the other gently pushes her wet hair from her face. “Look at me,” I order.

Her lashes flutter open while she tries to catch her breath. I lean forward and gently kiss her plump lips. “My cum will leak from your cunt tonight while we’re out on the town. You will not touch yourself. Do you understand?”

“Yes sir,” she whispers.

“Get ready.” I kiss her parted lips once more before I pull away and let go of her neck, going to pick out her outfit.

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FORTY-TWO



KASHTON

I stand with my back to the wall inside the elevator at Carnage. My hands are in Eve's hair while her arms are wrapped around my neck. She moans into my mouth while her hips grind into mine.

"I have to go." She groans in disappointment but makes no move to pull away.

"Let's go back upstairs," I urge. We've been back from Vegas for two days and have spent every second in my room. We went out in Vegas that first night and then spent most of our time there in bed as well.

I can't get enough of her.

The sound of the door opening has me deepening the kiss. Just a way to keep her where I want her a little while longer. We didn't even sleep last night, and my cock is still hard.

Someone clears their throat, and Eve pulls away. I side-eye Ashtyn, dropping my hands from Eve's hair before putting my attention back on Everett. "I'll walk you to your car."

She gives me a naughty smile. "No need. My place tonight?"

"Absolutely." My eyes drop to the black pleated miniskirt she wears. I want to lift it up so I can see her cum-covered thong from all the times I came inside her over the past forty-eight hours.

Stepping forward, she kisses me one last time, and I slap her ass playfully, making her yelp. Then she turns, giggling, and exits the elevator just as the door slides closed.

I place my hands in my pockets and lean back against the wall. Closing my eyes, I exhale, not looking forward to this long day. I'd much rather be in bed with Eve. All she had to do was say yes, and I

would have thrown her over my shoulder and carried her back up to my room.

"So…you and Eve." Ashtyn speaks for the first time since she stepped into the elevator and interrupted us. "Is it serious?"

I say nothing while I also ignore the vibrating phone in my pocket. It's probably Adam. I'm avoiding him. I asked if the text I received in Las Vegas had anything to do with the cops coming to collect Eve, and he said no. They are still gathering whatever it is they think they'll find that'll give them cause to arrest my girl. That was all I needed to know.

"I mean, I guess that's a stupid question." She goes on at my silence. "You've only known her what? A month at the most? But then again, Haidyn married Charlotte rather quickly."

"Six years," I answer to stop her rambling. "I've known Eve for six years." Not a lie.

"Oh." Her eyes widen before they drop to the floor.

Then I add, "You were gone for a long time, Ash. A lot changed."

"Yeah." The elevator stops at the basement, and as the door opens, she whispers to herself, "I guess."

I step in front of her, blocking her only way out. "What you did with Jasmine in Vegas? Don't ever pull that shit again. My relationship with Eve is that serious. Do you understand?" I'm not going to mention the *Titanic* bullshit because then I'd be ratting out Eve for telling me. That's what she wants. To think that Eve is threatened by her. I won't give her that satisfaction.

Ashtyn swallows nervously before giving a soft nod. "I understand."

Turning, I give her my back and exit the elevator into the basement. I see Saint and Haidyn with Benny. He's naked and crying. They are always fucking crying. How is the bastard not dead yet?

"Hey, sweetheart." Saint smiles at Ashtyn when she comes up behind me.

"Hey," she says softly.

"What's wrong?" he asks, now frowning. "Everything okay?"

"I'm just tired. I'm going to go back upstairs. Gonna take a nap."

"Okay. I'll walk you up there."

"You don't have to…"

"Nonsense." He looks at us. "I'll be right back."

We wave him off, and they disappear into the elevator.

I walk over and take a cigarette from Haidyn's pack on the counter.

"What was that about?" Haidyn asks me.

"What?" I act dumb.

"She looked right at you when he asked if everything was okay. You're not fucking her, are you?"

"What the fuck?" I bark and then lower my voice. "Are you serious?"

"Wouldn't be the first time." He shrugs. "I don't know what you guys were doing while I was hiding out with Charlotte."

"Fuck no," I growl and add, "Ashtyn and Eve are in some kind of war." If that's what you want to call it.

He frowns. "Why? Eve jealous you've fucked Ashtyn?"

That makes me want to laugh. She knows no other woman could compare to her for me. "Eve thinks you're going to cheat on Charlotte with Ashtyn." I expect him to laugh, but he doesn't.

"I'm not going near Ashtyn, but honestly, Charlotte has mentioned it a few times." He grabs the pack of cigarettes and removes one. "She was sent a video of us fucking Ashtyn at the House of Lords."

"I'm confused. Someone sent a video of us fucking Ashtyn to Charlotte?" I want to ask which time, but it doesn't matter. We had sex with her on multiple occasions. One isn't any more important than the other.

One time being when we went for a ride and ended up taking a break and fucking her on a picnic table. It makes me think that's why Ashtyn wanted us all to go for a bike ride the other day. Is she trying to bring back old times? Thinking history will repeat itself? It'll never happen.

He nods. "Yep. Charlotte got pissed about it. For good reason." He clenches his jaw. "If I saw a video of someone fucking my wife, I'd kill the bastard. Wouldn't matter if it was before she met me or not." I hand him my Zippo, and he lights the cigarette. "Then Charlotte heard Ashtyn and me having a conversation…"

He trails off and it has me curious. I'm a nosy bitch. "What kind of conversation?"

He blows out the smoke. “She told me she loved me.”

My eyes widen. “In front of Charlotte?”

“Yeah.” He takes another pull of the cigarette. “It’s my fault. I had told Ashtyn that I loved her the night we were both taken. Right before the car wreck. It wasn’t supposed to mean anything. I just wanted her to know that I was there for her. But when she said it back, it just felt…odd, ya know?” I nod and he continues. “The timing of her confession. Charlotte and I were already married, and I knew that Charlotte didn’t like that Ashtyn and I have a past, so I’ve tried to put as much space between us as possible. Which is hard while we’re living under the same roof. Every time I turn around, Ashtyn seems to be there.”

“That’s why you’ve distanced yourself from Ashtyn.” I knew there was a reason and Charlotte was why. I just didn’t know what had happened between them.

“You’ve noticed, huh?” He chuckles.

“Of course I have.”

He takes another drag from his cigarette. “It’s for the best. She has Saint. She doesn’t need me. My wife does.”

If Saint were to die, then Haidyn would take over for him—he’s Ashtyn’s guardian—but that doesn’t mean physically. And we’re going to pretend that day will never come. I can’t imagine losing another brother.

“I haven’t said anything to Charlotte yet, but I’m thinking about moving out.”

“From Carnage?” I ask, confused.

He nods. “We need our own place, and the babies will be here before we know it. My wife deserves to have a life outside of this hellhole, and I want to give her one.”

I understand what he means. That’s why I’m choosing to stay at Eve’s tonight. So we can have some privacy, just me and her in a place that isn’t here. “Where are you going to go?”

“I found some property. Enough for all of us. I was actually going to talk to you and Saint about it—”

The sound of the elevator dinging interrupts him, and then a second later, we hear Saint. “Okay.” He claps his hands, returning to the

basement. “Where were we?”

My phone starts vibrating in my pocket, and I pull it out to see **My Life** light up the screen. “One sec,” I tell them and answer. “Hello, angel. Miss me already?”

“I’m bored.”

I smile at her choice of words. “Bored?” I give the guys my back. “What do you want me to do about that?”

“Play with me.” Her breathing picks up at her answer.

“Head to my house,” I command. “I’ll call you back in a minute.”

“What? Kash—”

I hang up and turn to face the guys while I walk backward toward the elevator. “I have to go. I’ll be back tomorrow.” I wave to them as they call out my name. My girl wants me to play with her. I’m not going to ignore her. She comes first. Before anything. Plus, the prisoners we have aren’t going anywhere.

I can only imagine how much courage it took for her to make that call. She waited until she was in the car. Otherwise, she would have asked me in the elevator. She’s coming out of her shell for me. Wanting to be used more.

She’s getting comfortable with me, and I love that. Eve still gets down on herself afterward, but that’s okay. We’ll work on it together. I’ll continue to remind her that it’s okay to enjoy being my toy.

EVERETT

I back into his driveway across from my house when my cell rings. I remain sitting in my car while I answer. “Why am I at your house?” I look at mine through my windshield.

“You want me to play with you, Eve. That means you do as I say.”

My thighs tighten and I nod. “I understand.”

“There’s a spare key under the welcome mat. Let yourself in.”

I have a moment of panic that he’s going to lock me in the collar and chain me in the basement, but a part of me also wants that. I want him to grab me by the hair, drag me down the stairs, and make me his pet. Force me to like it. I knew the possibilities before I made the call. That it could be days before I see sunlight again.

I’m desperate for whatever he wants to do to me. The trip to Las Vegas opened my eyes. I am jealous of girls from his past. Well, ev-

eryone except for Ashtyn. But all the others before me—yeah. I want him to myself. I want to know what it feels like for something to be all mine.

"Now, Eve," he orders, making me jump.

Turning off the car, I wait for my Bluetooth to disconnect and then grab my phone. When I get out of my car, I see a neighbor waving at me with a hose in his hand while he waters his garden. "Hello, Eve, how are you?"

I nod and mumble to Kashton. "Who the fuck is this guy?"

"Just ignore him," he says into my ear, also hearing the neighbor through my phone. As if I'd speak to him. I hardly talk to people that I like.

I pick up the mat, grab the key, and unlock the front door. "I'm inside."

"Lock the door and go to my room. It's past the kitchen and at the end of the hallway, through the double doors."

My heels clap on the marble floor as I make my way through the house. He's purchased some furniture, but the walls are still bare and there aren't any rugs.

I enter his bedroom and flip on the light. He has a black bedroom set that consists of two dressers and two nightstands. The large size of the room makes the furnishings look small. No linens or curtains on the windows. It's bare other than the furniture. "Okay."

"Go over to the nightstand closest to the bathroom, open the top drawer."

Doing as I'm told, my heart races at what I see. It's full of several different types of items that can be used to restrain…me? Some I've never seen before.

It makes me nervous.

"Eve?" Kashton's voice makes me jump.

"Yeah?" I blink, trying to swallow the nervousness of what he plans on doing to me. This is what I wanted. To be his toy. For him to play with.

I want to please him. To prove to him that I'm worth it. In our world, we're only as good as what we can be while lying on our backs.

Make me your whore comes to mind.

"There's a purple toy. See it?"

"Yeah." I reach in and pick it up. It's small, with what looks like a tail on the end. I've never used toys on myself before. They were always used for training at Dollhouse. I have to remind myself that this isn't Dollhouse, and Kashton isn't punishing me.

"Grab it, along with the handcuffs," he orders.

"Okay." I pick up the cold metal. They're the real deal, and I don't see a key to them in the drawer.

"There are two black belts that have rubber spikes on them. Grab them both as well."

I pick them up and swallow nervously. *Spikes?* "Got them."

"Now walk to the laundry room."

I frown at the command. "Why?"

He huffs, clearly irritated that I questioned what he told me to do, but he indulges my concern. "Because the neighbor was outside and the front double doors are glass. He can see inside, and he knows you're there. Now…go to the laundry room."

I shut the drawer and make my way back to the laundry room right off the garage. It's large, with two sets of washers and dryers, a folding island, and floor-to-ceiling cabinets for storage. "I'm in the laundry room," I tell him, glancing around. I can tell the man has never done a load of laundry here. Not a single item on the counters, and I bet the cabinets are empty as well.

"Get undressed. Everything except for your heels."

I place him on speakerphone before setting my cell on the floor next to where I stand. I remove my shirt and bra, then slide out of my skirt and underwear, standing in nothing but my Louboutins. My legs shake, but my pussy is soaked. Of course, that could be his cum leaking out of me from this morning.

"Okay," I say and run my sweaty hands down my bare thighs. I'm shuffling in my Dolly 160mm leather pumps. All of a sudden, they feel uncomfortable. I want to remove them, but only because he told me to keep them on.

"Take the belts and wrap each one around your upper thighs. The spikes go on the inside. Make sure to cinch them tight."

"Oh-okay." I hate that my voice shakes. I was so confident earlier when I called him. Now I'm a trembling mess.

"Good girl," he praises me, and my thighs tighten. "Let me know when they're on."

I pick up the first one and wrap it around my upper thigh. It's not leather, but a mesh type of fabric with what looks like soft rubber spikes along the inside. I pull it tight and buckle the first one. It doesn't feel all that bad. A little pinch here and there, but nothing unbearable. Then I repeat the second one. "They're on." I lick my lips as both belts start to sting at every little movement I make.

"Kneel in front of the door that leads to the garage," he commands, and my heart races.

I slowly get to my knees and whimper when the cold marble hurts. The new position also pulls the belts tighter, the spikes biting into my flesh.

"Place the vibrator inside of your cunt, angel. I know you're wet enough to slide it in."

I bow my head and suck in a shaky breath. "Yes, sir." Picking up the purple toy, I rub it back and forth over my pussy, enjoying the pain from the spikes. He knows I've been trained to get off on it. I hate how much I like that he thought of me when buying these.

Doubt fills my mind, and I think that they were for another girl he's fucked. Someone he planned on living a life with. Are all these for me? Who else would they be for? Does he have other women over here while I'm at home across the street?

Maybe he's had them for years and I'm not the first to use them?

"Talk to me, Eve," comes his voice, as if he knows what I'm thinking, more soothing than before. "Tell me how wet you are. How much you want me to play with you."

My cheeks blush with embarrassment, but my thighs clench and the spikes feel so good. "I'm wet." Licking my lips, I add. "I want… you to play with me." I slide the tip inside my pussy and whimper. "I want you, Kash. Please come and play with me."

"You'll start with a toy."

My breath hitches as I push it farther into my soaked pussy, feeling it stretch its way inside me. "Oh." I lean forward, slapping my free

hand on the floor while I lift my ass up so I can spread my legs farther. I imagine him behind me, pinning my arms to my back, holding my face to the floor while I rock back and forth. "Fuck," I mumble as it slides all the way in. I try to catch my breath when I place my other hand on the floor as well and bow my head. "It's in," I breathe so softly I'm afraid that he didn't hear me.

It feels intrusive and bigger than I know it is. I want to pull it out, but I don't. This is how he wants me. I can feel my pussy clenching down on it as my thighs flex on the spikes that feel like they're slowly digging into my skin.

"Good girl," he praises me, and I lick my lips, shuffling on my hands and knees. The cold floor makes me shiver. "Now take the handcuffs and cuff your wrists behind your back."

Moving back to a sitting position, I moan when the toy shifts inside me.

I pick up the cold metal and wrap it around one wrist, tightening the cuff. He hears the click and says, "You're doing great, angel. Now the other one."

Placing my hands behind my back, I'm able to lock myself in the other one, and I adjust my knees once more. I'm panting, and I know he can hear it. "I'm ready for you," I tell him, trying to calm my racing pulse. "Please…" How long before he gets here? "I need you…"

I cry out when the vibrator stuffed in my pussy turns on. Leaning forward, my head drops, my breath momentarily taken away. My thighs clench, and it forces the spikes to dig further into my sensitive skin.

"Sit up straight, angel," he orders, like he can see me.

I rise up and push my shoulders back, trying to ease the pressure between my shoulder blades as my thighs tighten while my hips rock back and forth. "Oh God…" I trail off, biting my inner cheek. "Kashton—"

"You're doing great, Eve. Sit right there like a good girl and wait for me. Do you understand?"

"Wait…for you?" I gasp, my stomach muscles tightening. "How long?" I'm bouncing up and down on my knees. Fuck, I'm going to

come on his floor. “Please—”

“If you’ve moved when I get there, you will be punished.” With that, he ends the call, and I suck in a deep breath, trying to control the urge to come. Does he want me to come? Or is this a test to not get off?

The toy changes rhythm, and it begins to pulse. I bite my bottom lip, pulling on the handcuffs, trying to use my hands to remove it. Needing to stop it. But it’s too strong and the cuffs aren’t meant to be escaped without a key. I cry out his name when my eyes close and I throw my head back, coming all over myself.

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FORTY-THREE



KASHTON

I pull up to my house and pass her BMW in the driveway, pushing the garage door opener and pulling inside. I exit my car.

"Hey, Kashton."

I turn when I see the neighbor standing at the end of my driveway, looking over Eve's car. "What's up, man?" I indulge him to give my girl more time with her toy.

Walking to the end of the driveway, I shake his hand.

"Not much." He runs his hand through his hair. "I, uh, noticed you finally moved in."

He means he saw the furniture company that delivered a few things while I was in Vegas. I had Sin stop by and let them in. It wasn't like they could steal anything, and I had the basement locked. "Getting there."

"Cool. Cool." He nods his head. "I haven't seen your wife…"

Just like I expected. He's going to be a nosy little bitch. "Out of town with the kids," I tell him.

Hell, I could tell him they went to the moon. He's not going to know the difference because she'll never be here again. Eve will be the only woman to walk in and out of this house, and that's only until she's my wife and we sell both of our houses in this neighborhood.

I like the idea of buying land like Haidyn mentioned. Building something for my wife—a fresh start for us—that gives us space yet keeps us all close. We aren't required to live at Carnage. We've just chosen to. Everything we've ever needed was there. Why go somewhere else?

Moving to places like this raises red flags. It was easier to stay where our work is. But now? Our lives are changing. I want my own place and own space with Eve. If I want to fuck my wife on the kitchen counter at two in the morning after I make her pancakes, then that's exactly what I'm going to do. We can't do that at Carnage. Hell, I don't even want to leave my room with her there because of how many people are always around. And the prisoners in the basement? I don't want her to even have to think about that.

"It was good seeing you, but I have to go," I tell him, turning and entering the garage. I grab my backpack from my car and then close the garage door, noticing he's still standing at the end of my driveway.

I don't like it. Does he watch Eve when she's home? When she pulls into her driveway? Does he know when and where she goes? He doesn't have much of a life. He's twenty-five with no job. Most would ask how someone so young with no career could afford a house in this neighborhood. It belongs to his mommy and daddy. He's got a younger brother that his parents didn't plan on having at such a late age in their lives and would rather travel the world. So while they're out and about seeing the world, he's here raising him.

The man needs a hobby. Instead, he stays home all day playing video games and getting high. Plus, he talks too much. I learned all about his life one afternoon while he was watering his garden.

Once the garage closes, I open the door and enter the laundry room. Eve kneels before me, her head down, hair falling around her face while her body shakes.

"Hello, angel." All she can do is give me a soft moan. "This is what I want to come home to. You on your knees…ready and willing to be my whore."

I took my time getting here. She's been kneeling for a good thirty minutes. Long enough to give her a taste of what's to come.

I crouch in front of her, gathering her hair in my hand, and gently pull her head back. Her heavy green eyes glance up at me, but she's not seeing anything. She's in a daze. "Perfect," I say, running my free hand down her cheek and over her neck, feeling her pulse race.

She's trembling and breathing heavily through her parted pretty red lips. Her nipples are hard, and I give them a little pinch to see how she reacts. Her breath hitches in response.

My angel is all worked up: chest heaving, body covered in sweat. It's a sight to see.

I drop my hand between her shaking legs. "You've come on my floor." I smile at her, feeling the puddle underneath her.

"I'm…sorry," she whispers, her body jerking involuntarily. The sound of the vibrator fills the room.

"Don't apologize, Eve." It's what I wanted her to do. "How many times have you come?" I ask while my fingers play with her swollen clit.

"I…I'm not sure."

I arch a brow. "You didn't keep count?"

"I tried…please?" she whispers, bouncing up and down on her trembling legs.

"How do these feel?" I push my palms down on her thighs, pressing on the spiked garter belts.

She throws her head back, letting out a cry that makes me smile.

"You like them, don't you, Eve?"

Nodding quickly, she sucks in a ragged breath.

"Words," I order, doing it again. My fingers squeeze the bands. She liked when I placed her studded belt inside out around her legs when I fucked her in the basement of her house. "I had these made for you," I tell her.

They're nothing extreme or anything that would make her bleed. They're just small fabric belts lined with rubber spikes on the inside. Just enough to give a little bite.

"Yes…yes…they hurt so good."

"Good girl," I praise her, and she whimpers. I drop my hand, and her head hangs forward. I stand and undo my jeans, pulling out my hard dick and stroking it slowly while I pull out my cell with the other. I open the app and change up the vibrator to the highest setting, making her cry out again.

"Kash…pl-please?"

I lock my phone and place it next to hers on the floor. Then I grab her hair with one hand and my pierced cock with the other. "Open wide, angel."

Her trembling lips part and she glances up at me through her black-painted lashes. It's going to be covering her face soon.

I slide my cock into her willing mouth, and she sucks on it like she's begging to be used. I throw my head back and groan at how needy she is. "That's it, Eve."

She gags, and I pull back before I thrust forward. "Take it…all of it. I know you can do it. Let it slide down your throat. Open up for me."

I watch her take my cock as tears fill her eyes, and I tighten my hold in her hair when she tries to pull away.

Her body trembles below me as I pick up my pace and fuck her mouth, loving the way she rocks her hips back and forth like she's trying to fuck the vibrator in her tight cunt. I pull out, and she gasps in a breath, but she keeps her mouth open. "Good girl." I slap her pretty face and then shove it back in.

I'm so close to coming. She makes me weak in the knees when she looks up at me with those tear-filled eyes.

The sounds of her gagging and my groaning fill the room. Her eyes roll back into her head, and I know she just came again. I pull out and slap her once more, but this time to get her attention. "Eyes on me, angel."

She blinks rapidly, shuffling on her knees. I slide back into her mouth and fuck it once more. This time I don't stop until I'm holding it down her throat and coming.

When I step back, she gasps as cum and drool run from her parted lips.

I crouch in front of her. "Good girl, angel. You did so good for me." I kiss her and she kisses me back, moaning into my mouth.

She needs more. Good. Because I'm not done with her.

"Please?" she begs roughly when I pull my lips from hers. "Please fuck me. I need you to fuck me."

"Soon, Eve," I promise her.

She bows her head, and I reach over, grabbing her lace thong off the floor. "Look at me," I command. She lifts her head, and I can't

help but smile when I see the heated look in her eyes. She's mad at me. "I need to clean you off." I rub her thong over her cheeks, chin, and lips. The material isn't all that great for cleaning up my cum along with her tears and drool, but that's the point.

I'm just playing with her, rubbing it around her face. "That's better," I say and drop my hand between her shaking legs. A desperate moan leaves her parted lips, and she tries to ride my hand.

"You've made quite a mess. Got cum all over yourself and the floor." I run the wet material along the cum-covered floor and then roll it like a burrito before folding in the sides. I want to make sure it's a tight ball. Then I grab her chin, forcing her head back, and she opens her mouth, thinking I'm going to fuck it again. Instead, I shove her thong into it.

Her eyes widen and she tries to fight me. "Breathe through your nose, Eve," I command and she blinks rapidly while I shove her underwear into the corners of her lips, filling her cheeks out. "Taste yourself, angel. They're soaked with your cum."

She whimpers, closing her eyes tightly. Once I'm happy with it, I open my backpack and remove the microfoam tape and tear several pieces off before I secure it over her freshly clean chin, lips, and cheeks, placing it right underneath her nose.

"Gorgeous," I trace my fingers over the tape. "I knew it would look beautiful on you," I tell her. "You can still see the outline of your pretty lips."

She begins to mumble nonsense, leaning forward, her silent request to be played with.

The doorbell rings and her eyes go wide. I stand to my full height, shoving my still very hard cock into my jeans and zipping them up. She starts screaming into the gag, most likely begging me to release her.

"I'll be right back," I tell her, reaching into my backpack and grabbing my gun. I shove it into the waistband of my jeans and close the door from the laundry room off the hallway, choosing not to put my shirt on.

The fucking neighbor stands on my front porch with both hands behind his back. This is why I didn't want her kneeling in the grand

foyer waiting for me. You can see right into the house. Can't wait for us to get out of this neighborhood.

I walk up to the front double doors and open both. I've got nothing to hide. "Can I help you?" I ask.

"Yeah." He rocks back on his heels while glancing inside the house. *He's looking for Eve.*

"What do you need, Christopher?" I sigh, checking my watch. She's been kneeling for almost an hour. As much as my girl loves pain, I want to move her to the bedroom.

His eyes finally focus on me, and he blinks, realizing I don't have a shirt on. "I, uh…" He brings his hands around from his back and holds out an envelope. "I got some of your mail."

"Thanks." I snatch it from his hands. "Next time, leave it in my mailbox."

"Isn't that illegal?"

"Only if I turn you in," I interrupt him and slam the door in his face. I hear him curse when he catches sight of the gun stuffed in the back of my jeans when I walk away, tossing the mail to the floor.

I enter the laundry room to find Eve exactly where I left her. "Come on, angel."

Walking up behind her, I grab her upper arms and pull her to her shaking legs. I know she's unable to stand, so I pick her up and cradle her to my chest, carrying her out of the laundry room. With a quick glance at the front doors, I see the kid is gone.

I walk into my bedroom and place her on the bed, face down since her arms are cuffed behind her back. She rolls from side to side to relieve the pressure of the spikes digging into her thighs now that she's lying on them.

I leave her to grab a couple of things.

EVERETT

The new position isn't much better than kneeling on the floor.

I arch my back while my wrists fight the cuffs. I can't help but struggle, knowing I'm not going anywhere. My soggy, cum-covered thong fills my mouth, making it impossible to beg him. The tape is tight enough that I can't move my lips or breathe through it.

My nose is running, and I rub it against his mattress, smearing my snot and tears on it.

The vibrator still hums between my legs on high, and I have no clue how many times I've come all over it. My mind is foggy, and my vision goes in and out. Every muscle aches.

Tilting my head to the side, I have a view into his bathroom. I can't see him, though. He must be in his closet. I wait for him to return like the good girl I am.

I rise up on my knees, spreading my legs and arching my back when I feel that sensation again. My eyes fall shut and I hold my breath while I come on the toy.

His hand hits my ass, and my eyes pop open.

"Fuck, you're soaked, Eve," he praises as his fingers play with my throbbing clit. "I love how much you like this. I knew you would. You're such a pain slut and a dirty whore. Aren't you?"

Tears sting my eyes at how close he is. I'm thankful I'm gagged and that he doesn't want me to agree with him.

"Knees up underneath you. I want your ass in the air." He slaps my inner thighs.

I wiggle the best I can to get into position.

"That's it," he says before I feel wetness pour over me.

I stiffen, knowing exactly what it is.

"You're okay, Eve. Just lie there and let me play with you." He rubs his fingers between my ass cheeks, and I try to calm my breathing through my runny nose.

He pours more onto me, and it slides down my shaking legs. Then I feel his fingers pushing and prodding into my ass. I try to pull away, but there's nowhere for me to go.

"Relax," he commands with a hand softly rubbing my lower back. "You're going to feel so good, angel."

I close my eyes tightly when I feel the tip of the butt plug push against my ass. I try to relax into the bed the best I can, but my body is wound so tight.

I want it, though. For him to own every inch of me. To use me. To sit back and watch me come all over myself while he tells me how good I am for him.

I crave his acceptance.

"That's it, Eve. It's almost there. You're doing so good."

I whimper when I feel it stretch my ass before it slides inside me.

"Lie flat."

I slide down on my legs and stretch them out, trying to release the ache in my shoulders while he goes into the bathroom and washes his hands.

He comes back seconds later and begins to wrap something around my ankles, then right above my knees, tying my legs tightly together, making sure to secure the vibrator in my cunt and the butt plug in my ass.

Then he brings the heels of my shoes to my ass and wraps more tape around my shins and thighs and the spiked bands, pressing them deeper into my skin.

I can't move my legs, and I begin to mumble into the gag, knowing he's not going to fuck me anytime soon.

I manage to roll onto my side, and he chuckles, opening the top drawer of the nightstand. "Don't worry, angel. I'm going to tie you up nice and tight. Just how you like it."

I start to fight the tape and cuffs, knowing there's no escape. I was trained to fight the inevitable. No matter how much you know you're not going anywhere. The helplessness is what turns me on.

He grabs what he wants, shuts the drawer, and then pulls me back onto my stomach. He takes the tape and wraps it around my upper arms, forcing my chest up off the bed, and then wraps it right below my elbows. I feel the handcuffs release, and I moan into the tape at the indentations they left. But he quickly replaces them with more tape around my wrists.

I can't fucking move anything, and I feel another orgasm starting. I'm so sensitive; it's painful in the best way.

He wraps his hand around my throat and slowly pulls my head back, forcing me to look up at him through my heavy eyes. "Such a pretty angel." I swallow against his hand. Kashton gently pushes my hair off my face, and my vision starts to blur as that orgasm creeps closer. I can't stop it. There's no way to control it. Even when drugs aren't involved.

I hold my breath, and my body flexes against the tape and spikes around my thighs as that dark wave washes over me and takes away my sight. I come so hard that when I can see again, I have to blink away the tears that have filled my eyes.

He's still holding me in place, staring down at me. "That's it. Look at you being a good girl for me. Coming again. I want more, Eve. A lot more. I want you unable to walk or talk afterward."

I try to stretch my tied arms and whimper.

"It's okay, angel. I'll take care of you."

I'm just a mindless toy for him to control. And this is what he wants me to do. Come all over myself and his bed. There are worse things he could do to me.

"You're the prettiest toy I've ever seen." His hand squeezes my neck, restricting my already heavy breathing, and my body jerks involuntarily. "Enjoy this, Eve." He leans down and gently kisses my forehead. "You're going to be like this for the day." Then he releases my throat and steps away from the side of the bed.

My head drops to the bed, and I suck in a shaky breath through my runny nose, trying to collect my thoughts. To stay in the moment. It's so easy to fall into myself, but he wants me present.

This is a test, and I will pass it. For him. Toys are tossed away when they're no longer fun.

I scream into the tape when the plug in my ass starts to vibrate too.

Fuck. He was right. This is going to be a long day.

He sets his cell down on the nightstand next to the bed, and "Dance With The Devil" by Breaking Benjamin starts to drown out my gagged cries.

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FORTY-FOUR



KASHTON

I kept Eve at my house for two days. I was so proud of her. As hard for her as I know it was, she stayed with me. I made her focus on her body. Every orgasm, every spank, and every bite of my belt. She knew it was me, and when she wasn't gagged, it was my name she called out and begged to fuck her.

We returned to Carnage yesterday afternoon. With the neighbor being weird, I didn't want to keep her there long. I got a group text from Bill last night while I was lying in bed with Eve, telling me to meet him at Dollhouse this morning. I told her that the guys and I had somewhere we had to go. She didn't even question it.

My brothers and I decided to ride in the Cadillac SUV instead of taking our bikes, and none of us has said a word. We're all wondering what the fuck we're doing here.

We enter the building at the back of the property—Dollhouse—and stand around waiting for Bill to arrive. The place gives me the creeps. It's large and eerily quiet. Definitely old money and needs to be renovated. Better yet, someone should just bulldoze every structure on the land and then burn what's left. Sick things have happened on this property to innocent people.

A lot of twisted things take place at Carnage, but those bastards deserve it. We don't imprison children, and we don't rape women. Now, we do make sure that any woman brought in is sterilized, because it's no place for children.

Dollhouse is a whole new level of hell.

"What do you think this is about?" Saint questions, checking his watch.

"Whatever it is, it can't be good," Haidyn guesses, looking around.

The door opens and we all turn to see Bill enter with Adam behind him.

"This really isn't good," Haidyn mumbles.

I haven't told my brothers that I've been in touch with Adam lately or that I have his number. For all I know, Haidyn is still in contact with him as well. They all seem to have their secrets, so I'll keep mine.

We say our hellos and hug our brother. "What's going on?" I demand, getting to the point.

Something tells me this has to do with Everett, and the fact that Bill wants to share it with Saint and Haidyn is putting me on edge. Has she done something? Do they want us to take her into Carnage as a prisoner? I won't let them do it. If something needs to be done regarding my girl, I'll handle it on my terms and in a space only I control. No one touches her, and no one else gets to decide her fate.

"Follow me." Bill turns, and we silently follow him through the cold building and down a flight of stairs, coming to a stop at a set of double metal doors. Several hasps and staples run down the center of the doors, making sure to keep whatever is on the other side in, but they're currently missing the padlocks to keep them locked in place.

Bill pushes them open, and the smell of rotting fish and cold air hits our faces. We're used to this shit, but even now, it makes me want to gag.

They open to a large hallway that consists of concrete floors and walls. From experience, I know they're the easiest to keep clean. The drains strategically placed on the floor and butted up next to the wall three feet from one another prove my point.

We follow after him and Adam, passing door after door, and I notice that each room has a red bulb above the door. "What are those for?" I ask, gesturing to one when they turn to look at me.

"Training in progress," Bill answers, and my stomach drops. *It is about Eve.* "They are lit when the room is in use."

We turn a corner, and I catch sight of cameras facing each direction, showing those who are coming and going. Makes it hard for anyone to escape when they're watching your every move.

Coming to a stop, he pushes one of the doors open, and we enter single file. Someone flips on a light switch. A cluster of LED lights shine down from the ceiling in the center of the concrete room. It looks like an operation setup at first glance, but they highlight a metal chair. The wall behind the chair has a countertop from wall to wall with cabinets underneath it. The first things I've seen that aren't concrete. Instead they are stainless steel. Each one has a lock on it.

"What is it?" Saint questions, stepping forward, but we all know what it is.

It's a bondage chair bolted in place to the floor. Definitely handmade for Dollhouse. The top half reminds me of a cross—an upright post, along with the crosspiece in the center, both narrow in size. No more than four inches wide in width. The bottom has two metal legs. The center where a seat would be doesn't exist. It looks uncomfortable as fuck.

"They call it the giver," Adam answers.

"Cameras in each corner," Haidyn observes, looking around. "What do they record and who has access to the feed?"

"They stream the training to potential buyers," Adam says. "It makes them feel like part of the process."

Saint snorts, shaking his head, and my blood rushes in my ears. Adam said there were tapes of Eve. Is this what he meant? I hated the idea, but this? This is beyond what I could have imagined.

"Stream? As in the internet? Anyone can see what goes on in here?" Haidyn demands.

"It's a restricted site on the dark web that's monitored closely by a team. They had to make sure each streamer was vetted. Can't accidentally allow the police access," Adam assures him.

Bill turns to face me, and my pulse races. *This is it.* "Eve was here," I say and specify, "In this room."

"How do you know that?" Saint asks skeptically.

"She's a doll?" Haidyn asks, sounding confused.

I get it. Why would she be alive to talk about it? We don't know much about dolls except that they're either tortured, sold, or killed.

I haven't told them much about my girl. Mainly because I couldn't confirm it. She lied to them when she told us about Evan. They never took the time to question how she knew so much. Or what she knew that she wasn't sharing with them. The only one I told about her being a doll was Sin, and he's kept that conversation to himself.

"She was," Bill answers, keeping his eyes on mine and ignoring Saint. "We have a video. Well, specifically footage of her arrival day."

My stomach sinks at *arrival day,* and I take a step back as I observe *the giver*. It has belts of various sizes hanging all over it to restrain the victims in place. "How…" I clear my throat. "How long was she here for?"

"A year." Bill is the one to answer.

I rub the back of my neck. A year. She spent a whole year of her life in this hell. It's amazing she was ever able to leave. That she survived such an awful place.

"I want to see it." That's why they brought us here, right? To show me what she's been through? If this is Bill's way of trying to scare me away, it's not going to work. As her *father*, he doesn't think I'm good enough for her. And I'll be the first to tell him there isn't a Lord in this world who's good enough for Eve, but I can make her happy. I can give her the life she should have had. I will wash her past from her memory. They brainwashed her here; I'll do the same. A year? I'll give her the rest of my life, and I will devote it to making her feel loved and worthy.

"Kash—"

"You're free to leave," I interrupt whatever Saint was about to say.

If he doesn't want to know, then he doesn't have to stay. As badly as I don't want to see it, I have to. She'll never tell me. That much I know. No matter what I do to try and get it out of her.

Bill looks at Saint, and he sighs but doesn't make any move toward the door. He then glances at Haidyn, who widens his stance and crosses his arms over his chest. "Adam, play the video," Bill orders.

We all turn to look at the wall in the direction the chair faces. It acts as one big screen for a projector that hangs on the opposite side of the room above where the counter is. It describes what Eve was telling us about that night in Tyson's office at Blackout after the reception. How they force the dolls to watch porn.

It starts out showing a different room from the one we're in now. It's much larger than this one and has chains hanging from the ceiling. The walls look wet with condensation and there's dried blood on the floor.

The door opens and a guy in his early twenties enters with a naked woman in his arms. It's Eve. My girl. Even though she looks different, I'd recognize her anywhere. Her hair is an ashy blond and matted; her head hangs off his shoulder. She's bruised and dirty, appearing lifeless. Her complexion is much paler, and she's practically skin and bones.

He drops her to the floor like deadweight, and she groans, rolling onto her side, and curls into a ball. I let out a breath, knowing she's at least alive.

The kid removes a black hood from his back pocket and tosses it to the floor next to her.

Isabella enters. "Name?" she demands, but the smile on her face tells me she already knows who the naked woman on the floor is.

The kid reads off his phone. "Everett Sinclair. Founder. One suicide attempt. One pregnancy but no children—miscarriage and has been sterilized."

"Mm-hmm," Isabella nods. Clearly already aware of Eve's past.

My eyes drop to Everett, and she shakes, lying on the floor, grabbing at the thick metal collar around her neck.

"What do you want to do with her?" the kid asks, sounding annoyed.

Isabella glares at him.

He shrugs. "She's pretty much useless to us. Not sure why you even considered accepting her."

She rolls her eyes and counters, "Men are useless."

"Eve?" A man enters the room, and I straighten my back and my pulse begins to race. I know him. It's the same guy I saw at Bill's re-

ception—Evan.

He uses his boot to kick her side, forcing her to roll onto her back. She tries to fight him, but she's too weak. He crouches next to Eve, running his fingers over her chest and down her stomach before they slide between her legs.

She closes them, and he stands, laughing. "She'll make the perfect whore," Evan assures Isabella.

Her eyes narrow on him for a long second before she checks her watch. "She's all yours. I'm leaving. I've got dinner plans with my husband in twenty." She pats his back. "I'll check in on her in a week to see how she's doing."

"Here." The kid hands Evan a key.

Evan bends down and unlocks the thick metal collar around Eve's neck before handing them both back to him. Then he picks up her limp body and carries her out of the room and down a brightly lit hallway.

"Pl-ease." She finally speaks, her voice cracking.

My chest tightens at how weak she sounds. Where has she been up until this point? Where was she before this? I'd expected her to show up fighting mad. Angry and hating the world like the Everett I love. But this is different. She's entering Dollhouse already broken—mentally and physically.

His laughter fills the hall. "I always knew you'd end up here, Eve."

The footage then cuts to this room, and the door opens when he enters with her. Evan sets Eve in the makeshift bondage chair in the center of the room, and she shivers.

"There's usually a series of events that must take place before this, but I think she'll understand. We'll go ahead and get started. I can clean you up later. You're just going to get dirty anyway."

Kneeling in front of her, he places her legs against the metal backing, bent at the knees. He fastens each ankle with a black leather restraint, locking both buckles in place. Then a second around her upper thighs. The leather pulls tight enough that you can see her ashen skin pinching.

She hasn't even tried to fight him, but the action gets her attention.

"What—" comes her hoarse voice, and her eyes open, glancing around aimlessly.

She seems drunk. Possibly on drugs. She's got bruises on various spots of her malnourished body. Short, shallow cuts cover her skin as well. They're fresh. You can tell by the dried blood on her pale skin. Was this from her suicide attempt? They said she had tried. What the fuck did she do to try to end her life?

Another belt is placed across her lower waist, digging into her protruding hips. I notice she doesn't have the three vertical lines I saw on the *Isabella* or her butterfly tattoo yet.

He picks up her left arm and pushes it against the arm post that makes up half of the cross. He secures belts around her wrist and upper arm, palm out. Then does the same with the other.

Evan walks behind the device she's strapped to and picks up a mask. Placing it over her head, he shoves it forward in order to secure it. It resembles a gas mask. It's black, covers a large portion of her face, and comes to a point high up on her nose and down over her cheeks and mouth. She mumbles into it and blinks rapidly.

Crouching behind her, he turns on a tank that I'm assuming is oxygen. He then moves to stand in front of her and grips her chin, forcing her head back. "Breathe, Everett. Deep breaths. In through your nose and out through your mouth."

Her wide eyes fill with tears and her body tenses.

"Breathe. Come on…deep breath in through your nose." Her chest finally rises as it fills with air. "That's good. Out through your mouth. Good girl," he praises her. His hand drops from her chin and runs down her sternum. "Again."

She does it again and her eyes begin to get heavy.

"That's it." His hand drops lower and moves between her parted legs. He starts to rub her pussy. "You're doing so good. I'm going to make you the best whore for them. You're going to make such a pretty dolly."

She blinks rapidly, and he pushes on her inner thighs, causing the legs of the chair to open wider. The clicking sound indicates it locks them in place with each inch until he's happy to have them wide open.

Mumbling moans come from her mask-covered face while she fights the new position.

There's a knock at the door, and he frowns but walks over to it. "Good evening, sir. I didn't know we'd have a visitor."

I stiffen when I see a man we all know enter. "Yes. Well, I wasn't going to bother coming, but I needed to make sure she was delivered. See it for myself."

My heart starts to hammer in my chest at the sound of his voice, my mind running with possibilities of what the fuck is going on.

"What in the fuck is he doing there?" Haidyn barks, stepping closer to the wall, but neither Bill nor Adam answers.

I watch Eve go in and out of consciousness for the next few minutes while Evan sets things up on a rolling cart. The other Lord just stands there, staring at her.

Evan walks behind her once more and begins to wrap rope around her neck, which is already bruised and irritated from wearing the collar she arrived in. Her mumbled words fill the mask while panic shows in her large eyes, like she thinks he's going to choke her.

"Now, now. Just an added precaution," he assures her.

As if she could move a muscle. Does he think she's going to attack him? The poor thing can barely crawl right now, let alone harm anyone.

Evan wraps the rope three times, tying it off behind the chair each time. She tries to stretch her neck to see how much room he left her, but there's none. I can see that it's pulling on her skin. He takes the excess rope and begins to cross it over her chest, making an X between her breasts before tying the remainder off at the back of the narrow chair. Looks like a half-assed chest harness.

"Walk me through this…procedure," the Lord observing orders.

Evan starts an IV in the crook of her right arm and speaks to the Lord. "She'll spend around five hours a day for the next few weeks in this chair. She'll be restricted to a liquid-only diet, and this will help keep her on constant fluids while allowing us to administer any drugs that she may need."

Drugs? What kind of drugs could she possibly need? Maybe penicillin, but something tells me that's not the type he's referring to.

Evan tapes off the IV and then grips her chin, forcing her to look toward the Lord who seems bored. “As you can see, there are three hoses connected to her air-purifying respirator. One is the obvious—air. The second is nitrous oxide, and the third is a stimulant for arousal. We are able to regulate how much she gets from each. Sometimes they need more for training purposes and compliance.”

My chest squeezes at his words. That’s the point in this. To make her want sex. To want to be used. And now that I know how she likes to be fucked, I hate that it worked. Even all these years later.

“Nitrous oxide?” The Lord tilts his head in thought. “It doesn’t cause long-term effects?” He actually sounds concerned about her health, but I know it’s because he can’t sell a dead girl.

“There have been some who didn’t take well to it. It’s trial and error to see how much can be given and for how long.” Evan shrugs carelessly. “Everyone’s tolerance is different. But in the long run, we’ve seen more progress with it than without.”

“What is your success rate?” the Lord asks, seeming more interested now.

Evan smiles at him, letting go of her chin, liking the fact that the Lord is curious. “I’m not sure that you will ever find statistics on that. Some whores were just too stubborn and refused to submit. Our clients were less than pleased.”

“Something tells me you no longer have that problem.” The Lord chuckles.

Evan fucking blushes. “No. Not anymore. This system is hard for anyone to ignore. Even the strongest give in eventually. The dolls can’t fight the drugs.”

“With the system you have, who could resist?”

They both laugh.

I glance at Eve, and she can barely keep her heavy eyelids open. She’s so fucking high, and it makes me wonder what’s in the IV as well. He said fluids, but what kinds of fluids? I know it’s nothing good for her. They will only give her the bare minimum to keep her alive. Everything they put in her body is for their benefit.

“And Dollhouse only produces the best of the best.” Evan goes back to work. Pulling on a pair of gloves, he grabs a dildo off the cart and

places a condom over it before covering it with lube. Kneeling down in front of her, he rubs her cunt, and she moans into the mask. "That's it, Eve. It feels good, huh?"

Her eyes fall closed.

Evan screws the base of the dildo to a platform in the center of the floor that's directly underneath the opening of the chair. Grabbing a remote, he pushes a button. It slowly rises, and he helps guide it into her pussy.

She arches her tied neck, and her body tenses before she breathes deeply. "Let it do all the work." He rubs her inner thigh, and her body begins to shake, pulling on the restraints. "All you have to do is sit here and enjoy it."

Getting up, he reaches for the cart again, grabs another one, and lubes it up while the other Lord watches with appreciation in his eyes.

It's a fucking machine.

Evan comes back to her, bends down next to the seat, and reaches underneath it. He then inserts the dildo into her ass, and she cries out into the mask. Her fists clench and every muscle in her body tenses while she holds her breath. "A good and obedient doll loves all her holes filled," he tells her.

Tears run down her bottom lashes, and she fights her restraints, but he's got her tied too tight. She can't move a muscle.

"She doesn't seem very compliant," the Lord observes, sounding disappointed.

"It's in," Evan informs him and stands. Walking behind the chair, he messes with the tank, and her eyes roll into the back of her head, and she relaxes into the chair. "Like I said, some need more than others. It's not an exact science, but the mind and body can be manipulated."

"She's as stubborn as they come," the Lord grunts.

Her body is slick with sweat, and she's trembling. She looks like a sacrifice, and in a way, I guess she is. Everett was handed over to be a sex slave for the rest of her life. She's a founder. Who knows how long she'll live like this. She was what, nineteen, twenty? She could live until she's ninety. Take her out of the world and any harmful sit-

uation, and she will live a very long life with the enhancements she was born with. Plus, who knows what they're putting in her system that will contribute to that.

Evan gets my attention as he rips off the gloves, throws them away, and then puts stickers on her chest and her wrists, right up to the restraints. "This is going to track her heart rate and rhythm. It will tell us how many times she orgasms." Reaching into his pocket, he pulls out a Sharpie and pops the lid. "And this tells the audience who she is." He then writes 111 across her stomach.

All of a sudden the 111 on her hip when we were on the *Isabella* makes sense. Something tells me that motel room she uses isn't a coincidence either.

Tossing it to the side, Evan grabs the remote and pushes a button, and the fucking machine turns on. The dildo in her pussy makes long, slow strokes while she sits there, forced to take it.

The muffled sound of her panting and moaning fills the room before the older Lord turns to Evan. "I trust she's in good hands?"

"Absolutely. She's not going anywhere. I'm going to make her my very own personal doll and devote all my time to her." He reaches out and lovingly rubs the top of her head while her tear-filled eyes look up at him, silently begging him to help her. "She'll sell for a record-breaking amount when I'm done with her."

The door opens, and the kid from the beginning of the video pops his head in. "May I speak to you for a second?"

"Please excuse me," Evan tells the Lord and exits the room, shutting the door behind him.

The Lord looks her over, tilting his head to the side before he slowly walks around her with his arms crossed over his chest. Coming to a stop next to the chair, he says, "You're going to love your new home, Eve." Her eyes find his, and she thrashes in the chair while her chest heaves. "I bet you wish he would have killed you." He runs his fingers along a fresh cut on her side. The dried blood still remains. "You've been lucky for far too long. Now your luck has run out."

The door opens and Evan returns. "How about a tour of the facility?" he offers the Lord. "If you have some time to spare, of course. I don't want to keep you if you have somewhere to be."

He glances down at Eve for a second. "What about her?" It's like he thinks she's going to disappear if he takes his eyes off her.

Evan removes his cell from his pocket, and the sound of a woman gagging fills the concrete room, along with men grunting. "She's not going anywhere. Plus, I can track and control everything from my phone."

The Lord seems satisfied with that. "I've got time." They both exit the room, laughing to one another while they leave her strapped to the fucking chair, all alone.

The video comes to a stop and the three of us spin around to face Bill and Adam. I see Gavin has entered the room while we were watching the tape. Where the fuck did he come from?

"What the fuck is going on?" Haidyn snaps at Bill. "Why in the fuck was my father in this room with Eve?"

Adam squares his shoulders and answers. "Because…Everett is your sister."

"Half sister," Bill corrects him.

Silence blankets the room at their confession. Saint and I both look at our brother.

Bill sighs and adds, "She was the woman you chose to save when you were forced to pick."

"Pick for what?" Saint beats me to it.

I can't seem to speak at the moment; my mind is trying to process everything I just saw.

Haidyn stares at them unblinkingly. His face has paled, and he looks stunned. Finally, he blinks, taking a step back. Then he runs a hand down his face, sighing. "Sophomore year at Barrington. My initiation. My father made me choose between two women. I had to kill one. I chose the other."

"I bet you wish he would have killed you."

I turn, fully facing him. "Wait." I take a deep breath, trying to calm my racing heart. "So this whole time, you've known who she is?" I demand. He knew she was his fucking sister and never told me? *He knew her before I met her on the* Isabella*?*

"No," Haidyn growls. "They were chained up in the basement of Carnage. Both were naked but had collars and hoods on. I never

saw their faces. They were gagged so I never heard their voices." He closes his eyes and hisses. "Goddammit." When they open, he narrows them on Bill. "The kid in the beginning of the video had a hood, and she was wearing a metal collar. This was the same night, wasn't it? After I chose to spare her life, our father sent her here? Garrett kicked her and said he didn't want to see her again." He doesn't allow Bill to answer before he continues. "He was mad that I didn't kill them both. Told me that women are no use to me unless I'm fucking them. That they are only for pleasure and reproduction."

"This was the same night," Bill agrees.

"So she was at Carnage?" Saint asks, confused. "How did we never know that Garrett had another child?"

"We rarely stayed there." Adam is the one who answers.

He's right. We hated being there. We were at Barrington during the day and hung out at the House of Lords most nights. We weren't at Carnage unless our fathers told us we had to be. And even then, it wasn't like we wandered around. We did what needed to be done and then got the hell out of there.

I turn back to Bill, and he holds out a manila envelope. I rip it from his hands and tear it open, letting it fall to my feet when I remove the contents. There's a picture of Everett lying in a hospital bed. Her arms and legs are secured in medical restraints. She's got a patch over one eye. I wouldn't even recognize her. She looks less like herself than she did in the video we just watched. She's so frail. Sunken cheeks and ashen skin. She's covered in bruises of various colors and sizes. Cuts mark her skin. Her nose appears to be broken and her lips split.

It makes me physically ill to see her like this. To know that this was once her life.

Haidyn's shoulder bumps mine, and as I read over the information, Gavin clears his throat. "When Bill brought Eve to me, she was severely dehydrated and malnourished. She had a broken wrist, the injury obviously old, and hadn't received proper care. She had a positive drug and rape test, along with a few bruised ribs and a collapsed lung. Plus, she needed plastic surgery on her nose due to disfigurement."

My hands fist, wrinkling the paper.

"She was used," Saint says.

"She was beaten," Gavin corrects him.

"You mentioned drugs." Haidyn looks at Gavin. "We watched Evan give her drugs. For a year, he pumped her full of who knows what… Is she an addict?"

I've never seen her do any drugs, but alcohol? Now I understand why she drinks so much.

"No. She's not addicted to drugs," Bill assures him. "She went through detox afterward." He sighs heavily, and it makes me wonder how hard that was on her.

"Suicidal?" Haidyn growls. "They mentioned in the video when she arrived that she was suicidal. How the fuck did she try to kill herself?"

Bill drops his eyes to the floor before he glances back up at him. "First time she was in a car wreck. Garrett had someone transporting her. Eve managed to run it off the road."

"First time?" Haidyn snaps when he doesn't give more information.

"Second attempt, she was here in Dollhouse and tried hanging herself," Bill states.

"Jesus," Haidyn hisses.

My hands shake as I hold the papers. "When was this?" I gesture to them before I throw them over to Haidyn. I clear my throat, trying to wrap my head around all this information about my girl. My girl wasn't just raped, she was beaten. She survived so much but tried to end her life twice.

"This picture was taken six years ago. This is at the end of her year at Dollhouse," Bill answers.

"Evan said she would sell for a record-breaking price…are you saying she wasn't sold?" Saint questions.

"I bought her," Bill states.

I take a step forward to punch him in the face when Haidyn's hand slaps my chest. "I'll handle it."

Adam steps in front of Bill to protect him. "He bought her to save her."

"Bullshit," I snap.

"It's true," Adam assures us.

"How much?" Haidyn asks skeptically.

Bill steps out from behind Adam and fixes his suit jacket. "Three million."

My blood fucking boils. "Let me get this straight. You paid three million to fuck her? You bought her to be her *daddy*?"

"No." He shakes his head with disgust. "I've never slept with her."

I snort, not believing that. "You took advantage of her," I grind out. "You knew she was at Dollhouse and what she had been trained for. Why else would you spend that much money on her?"

"I loved her mother," he snaps and then lowers his voice. "My wife failed her assignment and was forced to become a breeder. Garrett paid a lot of money to get what he wanted from my wife. I knew Everett existed, but I couldn't get my hands on her. After Garrett took Everett to Carnage, I couldn't get close to her. I offered him money. I tried everything to convince him to give her to me. He wanted sons, not a daughter, but he refused. Said he found a use for her. At the time, I didn't know what he meant. After he sent her to Dollhouse, it took me a year to get her out of it. But I promise I spent all that time trying."

"All this time," Haidyn whispers. "You told me about the breeders that night at the cathedral when you informed me of what Charlotte's future was if she failed, but you didn't mention Eve or your wife to me."

"I didn't…" Bill trails off, glancing away.

"Didn't what?" Haidyn demands.

"I didn't want you to know about her," he answers softly, as if ashamed.

"That wasn't your decision to make," Haidyn shouts.

"Look at what she's been through," Bill tries to reason with him. "What your father put her through. Do you really think she wants to know you?" He steps up to Haidyn, and I brace myself to take Bill down if they start swinging. I need to knock the fuck out of someone right now. I can barely handle the rage I feel after what I just found out Eve has been through. "She's known about you all her life. Everett was raised at Carnage. She's also aware you've been living

there since your father was killed, and she has chosen to not want you in her life."

Haidyn shakes his head, not wanting to accept that she didn't want to know him. "And you?" He glares at Adam. "You knew she was my sister and didn't tell me?"

Adam swallows and glances away from us.

I understand why no one told me. They didn't know I'd fallen in love with the gorgeous blonde the night of our initiation on the yacht. But to keep something like this from Haidyn is pretty fucking shitty. Even for Adam.

"How long have you fucking known?" Haidyn demands.

"Four years," Adam admits softly.

Haidyn steps forward, but I grab his upper arm. He spins around to face me. "How are you not as pissed as I am? They kept her from us." He points at Gavin. "Even him."

"I am. But not at them. I'm pissed about what she's been through. That she's known she had a brother and has chosen not to come to you." She must feel so alone. I know what it feels like to have no one, even when you know they are there. I never want her to feel that way again.

The conversation that Eve and Adam had while I hid in her closet comes to mind*. "No. Bill knows I want nothing to do with them."* She didn't want to be around me because it would lead to her being around Haidyn. And Carnage? It must have taken a lot for her to finally step inside that place to be there with me. To feel safe there after Garrett hid her there.

"Are you blaming me?" Haidyn snaps at me.

"No," I say through gritted teeth and look at Bill. "You said that Garrett had found use for her. What the fuck does that mean?"

He peers at Haidyn and then Saint. My pulse picks up for a different reason when he clears his throat. "She was to be their personal breeder."

I fucking knew it. *Motherfucker.* "You're saying Garrett…her own father…raped her?" He said *their*, which can only lead me to believe all of our fathers.

"Surely Garrett wouldn't—"

"He was a disgusting son of a bitch," Haidyn interrupts Saint but keeps his attention on Bill, waiting for him to answer my question. "I put nothing past him."

Bill rubs the back of his neck. "He did. They all did."

I run a shaking hand down my face, letting out a shaky breath.

"Unbelievable," Saint hisses to himself.

"In the video. The kid said that she had been pregnant but was sterilized. Why would my father allow that to happen if the Spade brothers wanted to use her as a breeder?" Haidyn asks, confused.

"It's why she tried to commit suicide," Adam answers. "She caused the wreck on purpose after she found out she was pregnant. That's why the medical records state a miscarriage. Garrett found her shortly after…"

"Eve survived, but the fetus did not. There was extensive internal damage that resulted in a hysterectomy," Gavin explains. "She was in a coma for two weeks."

"Christ," Saint whispers.

"You treated her?" I snap at Gavin.

"Not then. Only after Bill retrieved her from Dollhouse," he rushes out. "And…" Gavin trails off.

"And what?" Haidyn growls.

"She was lucky to survive both times," Gavin finishes, and I watch Haidyn flinch at his words.

Not sure *lucky* is the best word to use. My girl is stronger than I gave her credit for.

"You said they wanted her as a breeder. What in the fuck were they going to do with these extra children?" I question. "I understand that Garrett hid her, but kids? What the hell were they going to do with them?"

"We can't answer that." Gavin shrugs. "Because the only ones who can tell us are dead."

I take a step back, dropping my chin to my chest, trying to comprehend all that I've learned. I knew she was keeping a lot from me, but this? I could never have guessed her past. I knew Dollhouse was part of it, but it's so much worse than that.

Our fathers raped her in hopes of knocking her up. Now I see why she wanted nothing to do with me. *"I'm not the same person I was back then."* I thought she was joking. Challenging me. Now I realize just how right she was.

"How is LeAnne involved in all of this?" Haidyn asks.

"I'm not sure what you mean," Gavin says, sharing a questionable look with Bill.

"Charlotte told us that she saw Everett at the cathedral when Charlotte's father took her there. LeAnne was running an offering, and Eve was in attendance without a cloak and mask," I explain.

"That can't—"

"The Spade brothers were friends with LeAnne's husband." Bill interrupts whatever Adam was going to say. "It's possible." I don't miss the heated glare that Adam throws at Bill. I go to ask what the fuck that was about, but Haidyn speaks before I get a chance.

"Have you fucked her?" His mind must be bouncing all over with all this information.

I tense, knowing that's a yes. I hate that he's fucking touched her, and I know Haidyn will too. Just for different reasons.

"It's complicated," Adam answers softly.

"Fucking complicated?" Haidyn shouts, stepping forward. He swings, knocking him in the face. "You knew what she's been through and fucked her anyway?" He hits him again.

Bill grabs Adam's arm and yanks him away from Haidyn while Saint gets a hold of Haidyn. I wasn't going to stop him. He can beat his face in for all I care. But can I be mad? The rational part tells me no. The other says *hell yes*. He knew who she was and didn't help her connect with Haidyn.

Am I any better? No. I now know just how dark her past is, and it's not going to stop me from loving her or fucking her. I'm going to make her my wife. It doesn't matter what happened to her; I will make sure it won't be in her future.

"Haidyn—" Adam wipes the blood from his busted lip.

"Fuck you, Adam. Both of you," he snarls. The sound of a door banging open makes me jump. I look over to see Haidyn exiting the

room. Saint stands next to me, head down and hand resting on the back of his neck.

I feel Adam's eyes on me, but I can't look at him. Or Bill. He might have saved her from being sold, but the damage was done. You can't erase a year of something like that. Especially when drugs were used to get results.

It makes me understand why I found her on her kitchen floor with a half-empty bottle while she told me she didn't want to be my wife. She thinks she's a whore who can't be loved. That she doesn't deserve to be happy. She was never told that she deserved the world.

EVERETT

I'm sitting on Haidyn's bed, petting Muffin and talking to Charlotte. She's having a good day today. She went out and did some shopping with Blakely and wanted to show me what she got for the babies.

Three babies. I hate that I'm going to be an aunt and can't even tell her that. I want to hug her and cry. Tell her how excited I am. That I'm going to spoil them and will drop everything if they ever need me. But I can't say those words, and they'll never get to know I'm here for them. It's for the best.

"EVE?"

Charlotte and I both look up when we hear Haidyn shouting my name. I frown, getting up off their bed and walking to the bedroom door. Sounded like he was coming from the hall.

I open their door and see him exiting Kashton's room.

"Everything okay?" Charlotte asks him.

He stops and glares at me. He looks pissed. Breathing heavily, like he just left the gym, I notice his hands are clenched.

The sound of the elevator dinging has me taking a quick glance to see Kashton and Saint exiting. They come to a stop and watch.

I give Kashton a smile, thankful to see him. For a split second, I thought that something had happened to him. That's what scares me the most. Falling for him. You never have to experience loss if you never allow yourself to love.

"Did you know?" Haidyn demands my attention.

I feel like this is a trick question and am not sure how to answer. I swallow nervously. My gaze shoots to his wife before returning to him. I've got to tread carefully because I don't know what he's been told. I'm guessing Kashton has filled them in on Evan. That I'm keeping secrets about how I know so much about Dollhouse.

"Haidyn—"

"Did you know that you're my sister?" he snaps at me, interrupting Charlotte.

"What?" She gasps now, looking between the two of us, and I get a glimpse of Ashtyn opening her bedroom door to see what the commotion is about.

Great. Just what I need. An audience. How the fuck did he find out? I haven't told a soul. Especially Kashton. I'd never make him keep secrets from his brothers. I have so many that I will take to my grave. Hell, I will die to keep most of them, but I say, "Yes."

"Were you ever going to tell me?" he demands.

I look up at my half brother through my lashes. Our father hated him almost as much as he hated me. I knew Haidyn was too good of a person to let him know who I was. It would have only gotten him in trouble with our father. I know he's dead now, but telling him would open another door that I need to keep shut. For both of our sakes. "No."

His face falls and the man that is six seven looks like a little wounded child. The anger fades, replaced with sadness and regret. "Why not?" he asks, his brows draw together. "I could have protected you."

That's why I never said anything. "Protect me?" I shake my head. "We were all on our own, Haidyn." Everyone was. The guys had each other, but they still went through hell. They were separated and tortured all because Ashtyn ran and fucked everything up. Our father kept me away from Haidyn because he knew we'd get close and Haidyn would choose me. That was one less thing he wanted to fight Haidyn on. "And he's been dead for years." After the Spade fathers were killed, there was no reason to confront any of them. I was free to move on with my life. I didn't want to come back to this. Kashton changed all that.

"I'm sorry." He runs a hand over his head before it drops to his side. "I'm sorry that Dad sent you to Dollhouse. I should have asked about you…the girl I picked to save."

My head snaps up and I glare at him. *Dollhouse?* "How do you know that?" I demand. Stepping closer to him, I shout, "How do you fucking know about that?"

"Eve." It's Kashton who says my name, and I look over at him. He walks slowly toward me, but I see the sadness in his eyes as well. And Saint. He can't even look at me. His hands are shoved into his pockets, his eyes on the floor.

What the fuck? "Where the fuck have you been?" I ask instead. I zero in on something in Kashton's hand. It's an envelope of some kind, and it makes panic rise. What could be in there?

"We've been at Dollhouse," Haidyn answers. "We watched your tape."

My stomach drops at his words, and I take a step back, feeling like someone has just punched me in the gut. *No*. That was too long ago. The videos have been destroyed. Evan promised me that they were no longer there. That they're all ruined after a doll is sold.

"I don't believe you," I whisper, even though I do. How else would they know what goes on there? That everything is taped?

"Eve." Haidyn steps closer to me. "Bill showed it to us."

I shake my head. My dad? The man who said he'd protect me, give me a better life, betrayed me? Why? Have I done something wrong? Is he mad at me? One of my biggest fears is that I'll let him down. It took a lot of time and effort to get me out of that hell. I promised him I would make it worth it.

"Angel—"

I push around Kashton, shove open the door to the stairwell, and run down them, ignoring Kash calling out behind me. I rush out of the front double doors and down the steps to my car. I don't even look in my rearview mirror to see if he's following me as I race home.

I enter my house. How fucking dare they do that? Angry tears roll down my face, and I wipe them away aggressively. I don't cry—not anymore—but I'm pissed. Embarrassed. This is why I didn't want to get close with Kashton. I knew better but allowed it to happen anyway.

Entering my bedroom, something gets my attention. An envelope sits on the end of my bed. It looks identical to the one Kash was holding. With shaking hands, I open it up and pull out the contents. The first thing is a picture of me lying in the hospital bed when Bill saved me. I look like shit. Unrecognizable.

It was after I ran into Kashton on the *Isabella*. Evan punished me for that night. Bill found me six weeks later. I didn't think I was going to survive much longer. If I didn't commit suicide, Evan was going to kill me.

I toss it to the floor and look over the report of what had been done to me. Everything my body survived at Dollhouse. Is this what they read? They know everything. Things that I can't even remember. The drugs cloud your mind. I guess that's one thing to be thankful for. Months are missing from my life.

"Hey, sis," a voice says softly from behind me.

My chest tightens. It's like a fucking nightmare.

I turn around to see Evan standing in the doorway of my bedroom. "Did you do this?" I hold up the envelope. "Did you fucking do this?" I scream.

"I told you Kashton would be a problem. He'd get too close. I had to show them, sis. They needed to see who you really are."

"Show?" *The video?* "You…you told me you deleted them." I'm shaking uncontrollably.

My other half brother, my boyfriend, and his friend all watched this man in my room train me to be a whore. A year is a long time. What video did they watch? How many were there? Everything inside of Dollhouse is recorded so potential clients can view the product. There could be thousands of videos of me there.

It's a way for them to make more money off the dolls. The ones watching have to pay in order to view the footage. That way Doll-

house can vet them to make sure they're not getting caught by law enforcement.

He says nothing, and my throat tightens at his silent answer. "You're a fucking bastard."

Evan frowns. "He can't love you, Eve. Not like you need."

Do I believe that Kashton loves me? No. A woman like me can't be loved. But I know that he wants to care for me more than anyone else ever has.

Fuck Evan for thinking no one else could love me. Kashton makes me feel…different. He's helped me accept myself for who I am and what I like in bed.

Evan begins to laugh, and it makes me nervous. Does he know what Kashton has done? That he went to the Lords to request me as his Lady? "You're a doll, Eve. My dolly."

"I'm not yours," I shout.

A smile spreads across his face. "You were when you were coming for me."

Bile rises and I gag at the thought. "No," I say in denial. We share a mother—he's my half brother—and we never had sex. It was never physical. He might have trained me, but it wasn't like that. They use toys at Dollhouse. He makes it sound like he means something entirely different. "We didn't…I wouldn't have…"

"Oh, you did." He nods his head. "You came all over my fingers, my face, and my cock."

"You're lying," I say through gritted teeth. This is what they do. Lords manipulate you. They wait until you're at your lowest and then kick you.

He removes his cell from his pocket and shoves it in my face. A video starts to play. It's of my cell at Dollhouse. I'm on my knees, my upper body strapped in a straitjacket. Other than that, I'm naked from the hips down. Evan stands in front of me. One of his hands in my hair while the other is wrapped around the base of his dick. My blood runs cold as the sound of his cock fucking my face fills the room.

"That's it, dolly." He smiles down at me. My eyes are glossed over as I stare up at him. He pulls out and I gasp in a breath. He slaps

me hard but holds me in place by my hair before he shoves his spit-covered cock back into my mouth.

My eyes are unfocused and my mind is elsewhere, but it's me.

He ends the video. *Kashton was right.* My stomach turns, and I place my hand over my mouth, gagging into it.

Evan laughs. "That sound brings back memories. I knew if I showed them a video, you'd come running home. You're so predictable."

I swallow the bile so I don't embarrass myself more than I already have.

Turning to give him my back, I yank open the top drawer of my nightstand to grab my gun—I'm going to end this once and for all—but it's not there.

"Looking for this?"

Slamming the drawer shut, I face Evan to see him pointing it at my chest. I give a manic laugh that makes him frown. "Do it," I say holding my arms out wide, and he snorts. "Really. You'll be doing me a favor." He smiles. "Do it, you fucking coward." I'm shaking, and my adrenaline is pumping. I'm embarrassed and ashamed. How could I have been so stupid?

He steps into me, the end of my gun pressing into my chest. "I'm the coward?" He cocks his head. "You're the one who has attempted to kill herself twice and couldn't succeed. You're the coward, Eve."

"I might have let myself down, but at least I don't have to drug and rape women."

Pain explodes in my face, and I'm knocked off my feet. I blink rapidly, lying on the floor while he stands over me, yelling. I can't make out what he's saying. It's like I'm in a tunnel, his words echoing.

Touching the side of my face, I feel wetness and then see blood on my shaking fingers.

"Get up, you fucking bitch," he barks, grabbing my hair and yanking me to my shaking legs.

When he lets go of me, I take the opportunity and run to the kitchen. My hand curls around the knife handle just as he comes up

behind me, slamming my body into the counter. My knees hit the cabinets so hard the wood splinters.

"Come on, sis. Don't be shy now." He reaches around and squeezes my wrist, forcing me to drop the knife, and I scream in frustration. "You owe me for Haidyn, after all. Or have you already forgotten?"

He places the blade between my legs from behind, and I stiffen when I feel it run up the inside of my leggings. "You think I raped you?" He chuckles. "Stupid bitch. You let me do whatever I wanted with you. You think he fucks you because he loves you? No. He loves fucking you because of how I trained you. I made you the whore you are." The knife comes to a stop, pressing against my pussy. I gasp for breath, trying to spread my legs farther to keep him from cutting me. "Now…be a good dolly and beg me to fuck you."

With his hand in my hair, he bends me over, shoving my upper body onto the countertop. I bite my tongue, determined to not make a noise.

"I can't wait to remind you of how much you enjoyed it." He lets go of my hair, pulling down my leggings to expose my ass.

I seize my chance to grab a second knife from the block. "Fuck you." I push up and slam my head back, connecting with his face.

He groans, stumbling away, but recovers quicker than I can move. Fisting my hair, he yanks me back, dragging me to the bedroom. I kick and scream the best I can. Twisting in his grip, I take the knife and swing, successfully stabbing him in the side.

"Motherfucker," he hisses. "Fucking bitch."

I'm thrown onto the bed, and he gets on top of me. I continue to kick and scream so loudly my lungs burn. I'm in survival mode and not thinking clearly.

He flips me over so I can't fight him, yanking my leggings all the way down my kicking legs, knocking my shoes off in the process. My nails dig into the bedding, trying to get out from underneath him, but all it does is pull the blankets down. I can't get a good grip.

This isn't like the times I fought men at the motel. I wasn't prepared for him to be here, and he was counting on that.

Taking a handful of hair, he buries my face into the bunched sheets, trying to suffocate me. My heart races as I try to breathe. My lungs

burn and my strength weakens by the second. When my body relaxes, he yanks my head up, and I gasp.

"You begged me, sis. I will say this… You were hard to train at first, but in the end, I broke you. Guess I can't take all the credit, though, huh? The Spades had you before I did. You arrived already begging to be fucked. You didn't give a shit who the cock belonged to."

He lets go of me, and my head falls down onto the bed. I try to get my bearings. My breathing is erratic, and my vision is blurry. My leg burns, and I feel something wet and warm underneath me on the bed. Did I pee myself? I did it once at Dollhouse, thinking it would keep them from wanting to go near me. They didn't fucking care.

I hear him unzip his pants, then he's tossing me onto my back. He rips my T-shirt off my heaving chest before wrapping his hand around my neck, squeezing it so tightly my eyes feel like they're going to pop out of their sockets. "It'll be like old times, Eve. You on your knees and me fucking your face."

A single tear falls from the corner of my eye, and he leans down, licking his way up my cheek, and I cower away from him. "Don't worry, sis. I'll make sure he sees all the tapes…new and old."

I reach up, grip the handle of the knife in his side, and yank it out. He sits up, screaming, and I go to stab him again, but something hits me in the side of the face, making me see stars for the second time.

"Goddammit," he growls, getting off me.

I roll over, cradling my face, and fall off the side of the bed with a thud. It momentarily knocks what little air I had left out of me.

Blinking, my eyes begin to focus, and I look up to see him just as he stands over me. He grips my right ankle, and I twist in his grasp, slamming my free foot into the side where I stabbed him.

He drops me, and I scramble to the bathroom door since it's the closest. The bloody knife is right by it. I could throw it at him, but that will just give him an advantage—a weapon to kill me with—and I don't know where my gun went. I'm assuming he still has it.

So I quickly crawl on my hands and knees over to the bathroom door, grab the knife, and slam the door shut behind me. Getting up on my knees, I lock it and then fall backward.

I cradle the knife to my chest, trying to catch my breath. He can get in. That piece-of-shit lock isn't going to save me, but it can give me an extra few seconds to catch my breath. When he gets in, I'm going to have to decide: try to fight him off or kill myself before he gets an advantage over me. He came prepared and probably has drugs on him that he'll shoot me up with.

I won't be that woman again. I'll die before I allow *him* to touch me. Tightening my hands around the handle, I hold the knife to my neck. If he gets in, I won't have more than a couple of seconds.

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FORTY-FIVE



KASHTON

Haidyn pulls up to her driveway, and I jump out, running into her house. "Eve?" I call out, getting no response. I rush through her living room, past the kitchen, and see a trail of blood that leads to her bedroom. "Everett?" I shout, panicking more than I already was when she ran out of Carnage.

I enter her room, and there's blood everywhere. Signs of a struggle on the bed as her comforter, sheets, and pillows are disheveled. I follow the trail of blood to her bathroom door. There are handprints smeared all over the white wood.

"Oh, fuck," Saint whispers, entering the bedroom, followed by Haidyn.

"Eve?" I try to open the door, but it's locked.

I don't even bother giving a warning. I grab hold of the doorframe, rear back, and kick the door open. The wood splinters and the door crashes against the interior wall.

She's sitting on the floor, naked and covered in blood. She holds a bloody butcher knife in her hand, the tip pressing into her neck. I slowly kneel down in front of her. "Eve, I'm here," I tell her softly to not frighten her.

Her wide eyes look up at mine. "I'm…sorry," she whispers.

"It's okay." I reach out. "Give me the knife, Eve." Her knuckles are white from gripping the handle.

As if she forgot she was holding it, she drops it to the floor like it's on fire. Her lips tremble when she whispers, "He's here."

"Check the house," I bark at Saint.

"Who am I looking for, Eve?" Saint asks.

She rocks back and forth, and I reach out, cupping her tear-streaked face. "Look at me, Eve. Eyes on me," I order and her red-rimmed eyes find mine. She can't not follow an order. Now I know why. "Who is here, Eve? Tell me. Who are we looking for?" I'm sure I can guess, but I need her to tell me.

"Ev-Evan."

Saint takes off and Haidyn rips a towel off the counter, tossing it to me.

"I'm sorry…" She reaches for the knife again, but Haidyn picks it up and throws it onto the sink and out of her reach.

"Did she cut herself?" he asks me.

She's been suicidal before. There's so much blood that I can't tell if she's harmed herself or if he did it. There was a lot on her bed and the floor. An obvious path was left where she crawled across the bathroom to where she sits with her back to the wall. It all can't be from him, otherwise he'd be dead on the bedroom floor. The knife is covered in it as well, letting me know it was used.

I grab her arm, stretching it out, and begin to frantically rub the clean hand towel Haidyn handed me across her skin. It just smears the blood. "Did you cut yourself?" I ask her again because she didn't answer Haidyn.

"I…I'm sorry," she whispers.

Fuck. "Eve." I grip her face, forcing her eyes to meet mine. They look glazed over and empty. "Did you take something?" Maybe she took something before he showed up. There's a cut on the side of her face, but it wouldn't bleed this much.

She doesn't answer.

"Check her drawers for pill bottles," I bark at Haidyn, and he starts opening and slamming them shut. She doesn't do drugs, but maybe… "He could have given her something. Eve?"

"Place is clear. Blood smeared on the back door tells me he ran." Saint comes rushing in, interrupting me. "Maybe he heard us pull up."

She begins to tremble. "I'm sorry."

There's so much blood. I can't find the source. If someone was bleeding this much, there would be a body. "Eve," I snap, getting im-

patient. My concern grows by the second; I'm terrified she's going to bleed out right here in front of me. "Talk to me. What happened, angel? Please," I beg, desperate for an answer. "What did you do?" She's looking pale.

"I came," she whispers, her eyes pinned on my shirt, unable to meet mine. "He told me…that I came."

"Maybe she's in shock," Saint offers.

I grip her face with my blood-covered hand, forcing her head back against the wall once more. "Listen to me. You didn't have a choice, Eve." The video that Bill and Adam showed us proves that no one could stand a chance at Dollhouse. "He was here in your house. I need to know…did Evan hurt you or did you hurt yourself?" I can't help her if I don't know how.

"I tried to…" She's gasping, trying to breathe. "I told him to shoot me… If he got in the bathroom, I was going to kill myself," she whispers. "I won't let him touch me. Not again."

My chest tightens at her confession.

"I don't see anything," Haidyn says, slamming the last drawer shut before walking into the shower. "Put her in here. Wash off the blood and see where it's coming from."

I pick her up, step into the shower, and sit down with her on the cold tile. Haidyn takes the sprayer and begins to wet her down from her hair to her face and her chest while she coughs and chokes on the running water. The blood gathers around the drain while I frantically search her, secretly hoping that it's all his.

She's shaking and her breathing becomes labored as I look for anything to tell me what the fuck is going on.

"I didn't cut myself. I promise." She sniffs.

"What did you do, Eve?" I ask, holding out her arms for Haidyn to wash off. "Huh? Where is the blood coming from?"

She doesn't answer.

The water runs over her legs. She's got bruises on her thighs from where she wore the spikes for me the other night. I knew she got off from pain. Now I'm sick that I allowed myself to do this to her. Embarrassed that Haidyn is going to ask me where they came from and I'm going to have to explain what I did to his sister.

Blood instantly pours from her inner thigh as soon as it washes away. "Fuck. She cut her leg." Haidyn hands Saint the sprayer so he can remove his belt. He drops to his knees next to me and I hold her shaking leg out while he wraps his belt around her upper thigh to stop the bleeding.

She crosses her arms around herself and starts rocking back and forth.

"I begged… I came…"

I grab her wet face, forcing her attention back on mine while Saint calls Devin to give him a heads-up that we're coming. "Listen to me. You didn't have a choice, Eve," I remind her. The poor thing isn't listening. Is she in shock?

She begins to gag.

"Eve." I sit up and grab her wet hair off her shoulders and chest. She's about to get sick.

EVERETT

Nineteen years old

I sit cross-legged in the center of the concrete room. Waiting. Always waiting and alone.

I'm so lonely.

The sound of the door creaks open and a figure enters. "Hey, dolly."

He's come to visit me. I almost smile.

Kneeling down in front of me, he pushes my hair back from my face. "They said you wanted to see me." He runs his thumb over my cracked lips, and I part them, but he pulls them away and I whimper. I wanted to taste them so badly. I'm starving.

His laughter fills my room.

"She's making good progress," a woman's voice says. She comes and goes, only visiting to see how I'm doing.

"Told you." He stands.

"Keep it up," she states and walks out.

When he begins to follow her, I say, "Pl-ease?" My voice is rough from lack of conversation. I don't know how long I've been in here alone. In the dark. I'm going crazy. I keep seeing a figure standing right outside my room. I talk to her, but she just stares back at me. Her eyes judging and her lips frowning in disappointment. It's my

imaginary friend. She's followed me here, but she no longer speaks to me. Just hovers and stares.

He gets my attention. "What do you want, Eve? Hmm? Want me to fuck you?"

"Yes…please." This is what he wants, but it's what I want too. I have this itch between my legs. I need him to help me. He's the only one who can. No one else touches me but him.

He kneels once more and grips my chin. "Come on, Eve. Beg me to fuck your cunt. Tell me you want to come."

"I want to come. Please let me come. I've been a good dolly." I try to reach out to him, but I can't. I'm strapped in a straitjacket. It's tight and my arms have gone numb. Or they no longer exist, I'm not sure. Haven't been able to use them in days. I got in trouble and was strapped in this for punishment.

"I'll tell you what. You suck my cock really good, and I'll let you come. How's that sound?"

I lean forward, parting my lips for him, needing him.

He lowers his zipper and pulls out his dick. His hand slaps me across the face, and I cry out from the sting on my cheek. Gripping my hair, he yanks my head back and shoves his cock into my mouth, gagging me.

I lean over, my hands on the tile. My abs tighten as my body strains while I vomit on the shower floor.

"You're okay, Eve." Kashton's hand softly rubs my back, and I close my watery eyes.

"Such a good dolly."

I do it again at the memory of his voice. For so long I was able to block him out. Maybe it was the drugs they forcibly shot me up with, or maybe I was just good at denial.

"Get her something to wear," I hear Kashton order over my dry heaving.

"I'm sorry." I sniff as drool runs from my parted lips. I spit it onto the shower floor and add, "I…didn't know."

He won't love me. Not anymore. I'm trash. Disgusting. I didn't know Evan was my half brother at the time, but that doesn't matter. I was exactly what he trained me to be—his whore.

The thought has me vomiting once again.

"I don't think we should move her," Haidyn speaks.

"We need to get her the fuck away from here," Kashton growls. "She needs medical assistance, and she's safer at Carnage. We'll grab something that we can take with us in case she gets sick in the car. Wet a washcloth to bring as well."

"We need to do something with the cut. That tourniquet isn't going to be enough. It's too deep," Saint observes.

"Eve?" Kashton's hands are on my wet face, his eyes on mine. "Do you have your bag here with you?"

My bag? "No." It's at the motel.

"What bag?" Haidyn demands.

Kashton ignores him, sighing. "Go to the kitchen," he orders Saint. "Grab a knife and a lighter. She keeps them next to the sink."

"Kash, man…what the fuck?"

"It's our only option at the moment," Kashton snaps at Haidyn.

I don't understand why or what they're arguing about.

Kashton pulls me out of the shower and places me on the bathroom floor, flat on my back. He straddles my chest and grabs my wrists, pushing them above my head, pinning them to the cold floor. I'm soaking wet, naked, and freezing. My teeth chatter. "Kash—"

His blue eyes are soft, his lips frowning. "I'm sorry, Eve. This is going to hurt, but it'll be over quick."

Fingers grip my thighs, and they're spread wide open. "Please…" I beg, trying to squirm free, but they're too strong.

"It's okay, angel. You're going to be okay," Kashton tells me, but I think he's lying. "Eyes on mine, okay? Look at me."

Something cold runs over my thigh, and I scream at the burn. It stings. My body starts to tremble under Kashton.

"Hold her," Haidyn barks.

"I am," Saint growls.

"Hurry up," Kashton shouts, his hands tightening around my wrists, making me whimper.

"Please…stop…" A scream is ripped from my mouth, and my back bows off the floor when I feel like they lit my leg on fire.

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FORTY-SIX



KASHTON

I sit next to her hospital bed back at Carnage. She passed out after Haidyn cauterized the cut on her leg. Then I wrapped her in a blanket and rushed to get her here. She needed medical attention, but we couldn't move her until we could control the bleeding. It was just too much.

"Do you not have surveillance on her house?" Haidyn asks, breaking the silence.

I snort. "Of course I do."

"Why didn't you play it, then?" He sighs.

I wanted her to tell me what was wrong. I wanted her to tell me what happened. Plus, I'd have to skim through the feed to find my answer. But I refuse to answer him.

Haidyn stands by the window while I make circles on her hand. A knock on the door comes, and Haidyn opens it.

Bill rushes in. "How is she?"

I called him on our way back to Carnage and told him to get his ass here, then hung up.

Sin and Ryat enter behind him before I can respond. "No body. No evidence. The blood trail stopped at a dirt road behind the housing addition. I'm assuming he had a car parked there or called for someone to come get him, but there was a lot of blood. So whatever she did to him, he needed medical assistance quickly or he was going to bleed out. Here are her car keys." Sin places them on the counter next to her bed. "Ryat followed me back, and I parked it in the garage."

"Thanks," I tell them.

"Who the fuck did this?" Bill demands, walking over to the hospital bed. He takes in her bruised neck and cheek. His face tightens seeing the glue and Steri-Strips that cover the cut on it as well.

"Evan," Haidyn responds.

"What? No." Bill shakes his head. "Everett doesn't have anything to do with him—"

"She does," I interrupt, glaring at him. My girl is very good at keeping things about her life a secret. She thinks no one cares, but I do. Bill was with Isabella for years and is now married to Janice. He's too busy for her. But I'm not. "I don't know specifics, but he was there. In her house."

Bill turns his back and runs his hand over his hair.

"She put up one hell of a fight," Sin declares. "Wherever he is right now, he's in pain, if not dead."

"Where would he go to seek treatment?" I look at Bill. I'm going to find Evan and drag him to Carnage by his fucking neck. I'm going to love hearing the piece of shit scream for me.

"I don't know."

"Bullshit," Haidyn snaps. "Where the fuck would he go?"

"I'm not lying to you," he shouts. "I've been her only advocate…" He glances at me and clears his throat. She has me now. I've taken over that role, and I'm not going to fail her. Lowering his voice, he adds. "I haven't spoken to Evan in years, except for when he showed his face at my reception. And up until now, I didn't think Eve did either."

"You have surveillance on her house, right?" Haidyn looks at me and I nod. I already told him so. "Let's watch it. Maybe it'll give us something."

Saint grabs the remote and turns on the TV while I pull my phone out. I go to the app, pull up the feed, connect my cell to the TV, and push Play.

Just as I suspected, he was already there waiting for her. He appeared from the woods behind her house and entered through the back door. "I thought you said *you* found the video," I snap at Bill when Evan tells her that I needed to see who she really was.

Bill shakes his head. “We never said that. It was sent to us by an unknown number.”

Evan has them. He wanted to scare me away from my angel. Joke’s on him, because that’s not possible.

When we rush in, the video shows me kicking down the door to the bathroom, finding her on the floor, giving her a shower. As I pin her to the bathroom floor, I end the video. They don’t need to see any more.

It’s obvious Evan knows I have cameras outside of her house, but does he know I have them on the inside too? I think it’s safe to say no. Otherwise, I don’t think he would have shown up at all. Or maybe he did.

That could have been his whole plan. To show me how broken she is. How scared of him she is. He was who trained her, brainwashed her. He knows how her mind works and what will scare her the most.

“What the fuck did Evan mean by she owes him for me?” Haidyn growls.

Bill sighs, looking over at a sleeping Eve. “When you turned yourself over to Isabella. Your brothers called Adam to help find you. He knew who Charlotte really was. And he suspected that you were with Isabella but couldn’t be certain. Adam contacted Eve, and she…”

“She what?” he demands.

“Eve reached out to Evan, trying to find out if you were at Dollhouse. It took him a week, but he confirmed that’s where you were.”

“So Eve was your someone.” Sin nods in understanding.

Haidyn looks away, running his hand down his face. Eve contacted the one person she wanted to avoid to save him. The half brother who raped and abused her. So we could rescue the half brother who didn’t even know she existed.

“How could you let her do that?” Haidyn whispers.

Bill chuckles. “When she makes up her mind about something, there’s no stopping Eve.”

Silence falls over the room, and I bring her hand to my lips, kissing her soft skin. Devin got the area cleaned up as much as he could. He couldn’t give her stitches in her leg since we cauterized it at her

house. She's covered in bruises. The worst are on her neck, where he was choking her.

Haidyn sighs. He feels guilty. Responsible for her life. He wishes he'd known she had existed so he could have helped her, but would it have mattered? There were so many Lords working against her for so long. I'm not sure it would have made any difference.

"How do we help her?" he asks, cutting the silence.

That's a good question. "I'm not sure."

"Therapist? Psychiatrist?"

"Not one the Lords control," I answer. "And I fear one who isn't part of our world wouldn't understand what she's been through." I refuse to let her end up in a padded room, drugged out of her mind.

"There has to be something," he says through gritted teeth. We all feel helpless right now.

"I'll take care of her," I assure him.

He turns to face me, and I think he's going to argue. Tell me that I'm not good enough for her. I'm not. If I were a good man, I'd let Bill hide her away. In a place I wouldn't even know about. I'd let her go with Adam and be dead to the world. But I can't. The thought of her with anyone else makes me physically ill.

"I can't let her go," I tell Haidyn and look at Bill. "I love her." Her father needs to understand how serious I am about my request to make her my Lady. This isn't a game. I'm all in. Whatever it will cost me, I'll pay; and I'm not talking about money.

"She's suicidal, Kash." Haidyn huffs. "She had a knife to her neck. We both thought…" He can't finish that sentence. "We just watched her tell him to shoot her."

"Yeah, well, I remember a time when we thought you were suicidal." I once found him with both wrists cut, bleeding out on the floor. Saint and I made a deal with the Lords to keep him from being a prisoner here. The Lords don't like it when you try to take control of your own life.

"But I wasn't. I was set up," Haidyn snaps. "That's the difference. She has tried it. Twice. And tonight—"

"She didn't cut herself. We just watched proof of that." Evan cut her inner thigh when she head butted him. I'm not sure if he meant to

hurt her or if her quick movement caused him to do so.

"She admitted that she'd hurt herself before she would allow him to touch her. And that's enough to be concerned," Haidyn growls.

"Because she felt she had no choice." I let go of her hand and stand. "You saw the tape that Bill showed us. What he did to her. She thought she had two options—let him rape her or kill herself."

"That feeling doesn't just go away," he snaps. "She needs protection. Twenty-four-hour care."

I snort. "You sound like you want her on drugs."

"If that keeps her alive." He shrugs.

"Boys," Bill says, but we ignore him.

"I've known her for six years. You just realized she exists. You're not going to take over her life." I don't care if she hasn't been a part of my life that entire time. She is now, and that's what matters.

"I—"

"Boys," Bill barks, and we both turn to him. Sin, Ryat, and Saint all stand behind him. I thought they'd left. "Maybe take this somewhere else," he offers.

"I'm not leaving her." I plop back down next to Eve and take her hand once more.

Haidyn storms out of her room and Saint sighs, following him. Ryat quietly exits, but Bill and Sin linger. I know what Elli went through. That she overdosed and almost died on him when the Lords forced him to hurt her. I know how much he still blames himself. Ellington is a different person now, though, and they're happily married. Eve and I can be the same way. It'll just take her time.

"Can you get Devin for me, please?" I ask Sin. "I want her moved to my room." She deserves privacy, and I'm going to give it to her. I'll lock everyone out so she can get the rest she needs.

"Of course." He turns and exits.

I look at Bill. "When I went to you and demanded that you pull strings so I can marry her, you made a big deal out of her being a founder." He swallows, knowing where I'm going with this. "Adam went to speak, and you interrupted him to tell me she's *different*. He was going to tell me that she's the child of a Spade, wasn't he?"

I knew it had to be more than just a founder. When I compared her to Elli, Bill insisted that she was different. I should have fucking known. There were signs that I chose not to see.

"Yes." He nods.

"Why didn't you tell me?" I growl.

"I…" He takes in a deep breath. "I wanted her to tell you. I thought she would open up to you."

She hasn't. Not at all. And I fear that now she'll close me out more than before.

"I'm going to take care of her." It's a promise that I will die to keep. Adam said that Bill had the means to help her disappear and I want him to understand that if she goes, I go. It doesn't matter where we're at or what we're doing; she will have me for the rest of my life.

Bill nods, patting my shoulder. "I know, son." Glancing down at her, he adds, "Keep me updated on how she's doing. I'm going to make some calls and see what I can find out about Evan." With that, he leaves me with her.

I sit silently until I hear the door open and look over my shoulder to see Devin while Sin softly closes the door. "I want her in my room."

He nods. "Sure. Of course. It'll be a few more hours before the sedative wears off. When she wakes up, just call me. I'll bring her some pain meds and change her bandages if needed."

He leaves and I pick her up.

"What do you need from me?" Sin asks, staring at an unconscious Eve in my arms.

"Get the door. Please."

EVERETT

I open my heavy eyes to see Kashton next to me. His hand gently touches my face. I blink, feeling lightheaded.

"Hey, angel." He speaks softly, and my eyes begin to focus. "We're in my room back at Carnage. You're okay, Eve. You're safe," he assures me.

I sit up and so does he. Pushing the covers off, I look down at my leg.

"We had to cauterize your thigh before we could move you. You were losing too much blood. Devin cleaned the area. Are you hurting? I can call him to bring you some pain meds."

"No." My voice cracks on the single word, and I clear my throat. "I'm fine." I lie down, giving him my back, pulling the covers up to my neck. I'm so tired.

I feel him adjusting himself in the bed to give me some room and I decide to turn to face him. He reaches out, running his knuckles over my cheek.

"You were right," I admit softly. "But I swear…I didn't know Evan was my brother at the time." Tears sting my eyes. "Not until afterward…when Bill saved me." I feel the need to explain in his silence. "I…I don't remember much from Dollhouse. I'm sorry…" My body starts to tremble under the covers.

"Don't be sorry, Eve." He sighs. "I'm so sorry, angel, for what he did to you…what you've been through…but I promise it changes nothing. I still love you. I still want to be with you. Do you understand that?"

I close my eyes, and he kisses my forehead. "Tell me you understand, Eve," he commands softly.

"I understand," I whisper, glancing up at him. "I promise I didn't cut myself. He did it…I tried to fight him in the kitchen. He managed to get the first knife. I was able to stab him with another—"

"I know," he interrupts my rambling. "I know you didn't do it. No one is accusing you of anything. You're safe here with me." Kashton slides to lie down next to me but keeps his distance, as if he's afraid to get too close. I start to panic that he's going to pull away from me. "Try and get some rest, Eve. I'll be right here when you wake up."

I scoot closer, cuddling into his warm body, noticing he wears nothing but his boxer briefs. His muscular arm wraps around me, holding me to him, and I close my heavy eyes, allowing myself to relax into him.

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FORTY-SEVEN



KASHTON

My phone vibrating on my chest has me opening my eyes to see it's dark in the room now other than the TV. I must have fallen asleep with Eve once I got her settled in. It vibrates once more, and I pick it up to see it's a video from an unknown number who's started a group chat with Haidyn, Saint, Bill, and me.

Fucking Evan. Well, this tells me all I need to know—the motherfucker isn't dead.

I take a look at Eve to see she's passed out beside me when a soft knock comes on my bedroom door.

Getting out of bed, I grab a pair of jeans off the floor. I took my bloody clothes off once I got her up to my room. I open the door, running a hand through my hair to see Haidyn and Saint already in the hallway. "We're going to watch it in the basement."

"Give me a second." I close the door and go back over to the bed and kiss her cheek. When she doesn't show any signs of waking, I'm sure she'll remain asleep. I don't want her to wake up and be scared that I'm not here.

Exiting the room, we silently ride the elevator down to the basement and push through the plastic strip curtains. Saint connects his phone to the TV that hangs on the wall in the corner.

"We should bring Isabella out," I say, and they both turn to look at me. "I'd bet my life this is about Eve and Dollhouse." Who else would it be about? Evan is fucking with me. He wants me to see his dolly. Every chance he gets, he wants to remind me of how much she wanted him. "She was in the last one." I've avoided going to her,

afraid she'd tell my brothers too much information about Eve. Now I know this bitch knows everything.

Haidyn nods. "I'll get her," he agrees, then takes off down the hallway to get the fucking bitch.

While Saint is connecting the feed, Haidyn drags Isabella into the room and shoves her to the floor. "Kneel," he barks, positioning her on her knees.

"It's ready," Saint announces, pointing the remote up to the TV, and the video starts to play.

The room looks different from the other video we watched.

This one has padded walls. It reminds me of a psych ward. There's a chair in the middle of the room that resembles a dentist's chair.

Evan enters and holds the door open. Blood drips from an open wound on his right cheek. I hope my girl is who gave it to him. "Put her in the chair," he orders.

The same younger kid from the previous video drags Eve in and tosses her into the chair.

I run a hand down my face when I see they've got her in a straitjacket. Other than that, she's naked.

Her head falls back, and her eyes wander aimlessly around the room. A fresh red mark evident on her face tells me she attacked him and was then restrained and slapped around.

"You seem to like pain, Eve." Evan laughs. "Let's test and see how much." He picks up his cell and presses a few buttons. Then she begins to move, her hips rocking back and forth in the chair and her eyes falling closed on a whimper.

She's got a vibrator in. Makes me wonder if it's in her pussy or ass. Possibly both.

He keeps his back to the camera, getting items ready, laying them out on a tray. "Put this on her and strap her down. Nice and tight. I don't want her moving while I work." Evan throws what looks like a black leather collar over his shoulder to the young Lord, who then pushes her to sit up so he can place it around her neck. It's a posture collar with a mouth cover. It comes high enough to also cover up her cheeks and lips.

He fastens the six belts behind her before pushing her to lie down. It forces her to arch her neck in the new position. The kid then proceeds to strap her ankles, thighs, and chest down to the chair before he takes a step back and watches her.

By the way her eyes are unfocused and her lack of fight, I'd say she's either going in and out of consciousness or she's getting off on the vibrator.

When Evan turns around, I frown, trying to figure out what the fuck he's up to. He rolls the tray next to her chair and grabs the last strap from under the chair and buckles it over her forehead, holding her head down to the chair with her neck arched back from the strict collar. "How's your cunt feel?" he asks, slapping her thigh, and her body jerks when she moans.

He smiles. "Yeah. I knew you'd come around. Too bad you couldn't have done this sooner, dolly. But just in case you decide to misbehave again, I want to give you a reminder of who is in charge here." He then picks up a pair of gloves and slides them over his hands. Moving to her nose, he starts pinching it and moving his fingers around while she lies there strapped to the chair.

"That's the sweet spot," he says to himself before picking up a square white packet and ripping it open. It's an antiseptic wipe. He proceeds to clean her nose before he tosses it to the side and grabs a tool from the tray I recognize as Pennington forceps. Evan places it on her septum where his fingers just were, the clamps pinching it tightly.

She blinks rapidly, her eyes instantly filling with unshed tears at the discomfort they cause.

"Don't worry. All slaves get a bull ring. It's to show you're just an animal. A pet to be trained. Once you're sold, your owner can choose to remove it." He then picks up the needle. I expect her to scream into the gag and fight, but she places her tear-filled eyes on the ceiling, her breathing picking up and her nostrils flaring.

My heart swells for my girl even as my stomach knots. She's trying to be tough. To prove that she can take whatever he does to her. Either that, or she's given up. I don't even want to think about that. They said she had already tried suicide once before she arrived at

Dollhouse. She hasn't tried inside of Dollhouse yet if he said she was still fighting him.

He pushes the needle through her septum, and her eyes scrunch shut while he pushes the silver ring in simultaneously. Evan starts to screw the silver ring in place as he says, "Now, typically, a septum is pierced with a sixteen or an eighteen gauge. This is a 14-gauge. And in a few weeks, I will stretch it to a 12-gauge. It will be painful but doable, of course. You will be unable to remove it, for it is permanent and will be up to your owner's discretion."

She still had it on the night of the *Isabella*. I thought it was dainty and cute. Now I feel sick to my stomach seeing why she had it.

Tears run out the corners of her eyes, and she breathes heavily through her freshly pierced nose. "Take her back to her room," he orders, removing his gloves and walking to stand back at the counter behind her.

The kid undoes the restraints and lifts her to stand from the chair, but her legs give out and she falls to her knees.

"Sir?" he asks, stepping back from a shaking Eve.

Evan walks back to her. He grips her hair, shoving her face to the floor. Crouching beside her, she shoves her ass and pussy up in the air, and he runs his hand between her legs and brings it to his face, rubbing his wet fingers together. "Came all over your toy like a good whore." He pulls her to standing by her hair, and she screams into the gag before Evan shoves her into the guy. "Return her as is."

"The collar, sir?" the kid asks cautiously.

"Just as she is," Evan shouts at him.

"Yes, sir." He nods and pulls her out of the room as the door shuts behind them.

Evan adjusts his noticeably hard dick in his jeans. "Teach the bitch to fucking bite me."

The video goes black just as my cell vibrates in my hand. I ignore it, knowing it's Bill.

"What do you have to say about this?" Haidyn barks at Isabella.

She looks away from him, but he grips her face, forcing him to meet her stare. "You let that piece of shit torture my sister?"

She smiles, though it's not friendly. "So you've met your father's whore?"

"How about this… Everything we watch him do to her, we do to you," he offers, and her face pales.

My phone vibrates, and I see it's a text from Easton.

When you have a second, give me a call.

"Kash—"

I ignore Saint and shove open the door to the stairs, going up the first flight, coming to the landing, I press my back to the wall and slide down to sit on my ass. I try and catch my breath. I'm fucking shaking I'm so mad. What I saw…I hate it for Eve. Hate that I can't change it. That no matter what I say, I can't save her from herself.

I go to Sin's number and press Call, placing my cell to my ear.

"Hey," he answers softly.

I clear my throat. "Hey. Everything okay?" I ask, thinking something is wrong with the babies. I've been hiding out with Eve and haven't had a chance to be there for him or Elli since Devin and Gavin delivered them.

He sighs. "Yeah. I'm calling to check on you and Eve. How is she doing?"

I slam the back of my head into the wall and look up the flight of stairs. "I don't know," I answer honestly. She's kept so much bottled up for so long. At some point she's going to explode. And what is Evan doing? Why now? She's gone years without remembering much from Dollhouse, and now he wants her to? Does he think he still has some kind of hold over her and that she's going to go crawling back to him? If that's the case, he fucked up. Now that she remembers, she despises him more than ever.

"Remember when I had you take Elli to that appointment?" he asks, interrupting my thoughts.

"Yeah."

"Well, you took her to a therapist…" He trails off.

"Just spit it out, Sin." I sigh, running a hand down my face.

"We don't want to overstep, but we want to offer help in any way we can. Elli has an appointment tomorrow, and if Eve would like to take it, Elli will call and speak to the doctor. Explain the details…with-

out giving any information about Eve, of course." He pauses. "But I understand if that's too much—"

"No," I interrupt him. "It's not too much."

He adds. "She has no connections to the Lords in any way."

"That's very nice of you guys. Thank you. Please give her my information, and we'll be there."

I hang up and get to my feet, running up the stairs to my room. Fuck Isabella. The bitch isn't going anywhere. I want Eve. My angel. She needs me now more than ever. I find her still in bed asleep.

It has to help, right? If Elli sees a therapist, then the idea can't be as bad as I thought. They're not going to drag her away from me and place her in a padded room. It's just one conversation. For her to talk to someone who won't judge her. Who knows what to say, what to do, and how to help.

A professional.

EVERETT

I sit in the passenger seat of the Cadillac Escalade V. The guys keep several in the garage at Carnage. Kashton flies down the highway. I woke up this morning and he helped me shower. Then Devin came by and looked at my bandages.

But we haven't spoken. There's tension between us, and even though he's right next to me, I've never felt so alone. So disgusted with myself.

Not only does Kashton know my past, but so do his brothers. It's humiliating.

He exits the highway and pulls into a parking lot. Getting out, he opens my door and takes my hand. We walk up a short flight of steps and enter a glass door. "Have a seat," he orders, going over to a desk while I sit down. Looking around, I try to decide where the fuck we are.

Kashton speaks softly to a woman behind the desk, and she glances at me a few times before putting her attention back on him. It makes the hairs on the back of my neck rise. What the fuck is he doing?

"Miss Sinclair?" a woman calls from an open door to my right.

Kashton looks at her and then to me. He strolls over, grabs my hand, and pulls me to stand. "It's okay," he assures me, brushing my hair off my shoulders. "I'll be right here waiting on you."

"I don't…"

"Hello, Everett." The woman smiles brightly at me, and I'm confused as fuck.

Kashton ushers me through the door, and the lady closes it behind me.

I tense. There's a couch, two chairs, and a love seat, along with a desk, and it smells of vanilla. I must be going crazy.

"Please have a seat." She gestures to the couch.

I remain standing, trying to come up with a logical explanation for where I am and why. Kashton wouldn't do this to me.

Her soft-brown eyes trace the Steri-Strips on my face from where Evan hit me with my gun so hard it cut my cheek. Then they drop to my bruised neck, and I swallow nervously. "It's okay, Everett. I'm here for you."

My chest begins to burn at her words. I've heard them before, and it was a lie.

I spin around, yank open the door, and rush out of the room. "Asshole," I snap at Kashton, rushing past where he still stands at the desk, then out the front door.

"Eve? Eve, wait. What happened?" he calls out, chasing me down the steps.

I come to a stop, turn, and punch him in the face, ignoring the way my hand instantly throbs.

His baseball hat falls off his head in the process. "Fuck," he groans into his hands, cupping his nose.

"Oh my God." The lady from the front desk gasps from the top of the steps. "I'll call the police."

"No. No. No," he rushes out, waving at her. "It's fine. We're fine." He turns back to look at me, looking confused and wounded. Bending over, he picks up his hat and slides it on backward.

"But she—"

"I said we're fucking fine," he snaps at the woman over his shoulder.

I'm fucking shaking. "How could you?" I scream, slamming my fists into his chest.

"What?" He sighs. "What did I do?"

"A therapist? Really?" What in the fuck was he told? What would make him think this is okay?

"I'm trying to help," he grinds out.

"Well, stop," I shout.

He tosses his head back and laughs—a manic, body-shaking laugh—before running his hand down his bloody face. "I don't know what to do, Eve." His eyes frantically search mine. "Tell me what to do, and I'll do it."

"I'm fine." I take a step back from him. There's nothing he can do, and the fact that he wants to help proves that he now sees me as broken. What happened to the man who wanted to collar and chain me up in his basement? He's no longer here. Now this man wants me to seek professional help? He wants me to allow a stranger to cut me open and bleed. For what? Redemption? To be whole for him?

"Quit fucking lying to me," he snaps. "And for God's sake, quit lying to yourself."

I go to slap him, but he catches my hand and yanks me toward the Escalade. At least it's not back into the building.

I pull free, turn, and start to run in the opposite direction, but he's quicker. Wrapping an arm around me from behind, I yelp when he picks me up and places me in the SUV before slamming the door. He storms around the hood, rips open his door, and falls into the driver's side.

"Want to beat the shit out of me?" he screams. "Do it in the fucking car. Not in public." He throws the car into drive and squeals his tires.

"Fine," I growl and reach across the center console to hit him with both my fists. I rip his hat off his head and grip the bill, hitting him with it before I toss it to the back and continuing with my fists.

He tries his best to block me, but I get a few more hits in before I give up. I'm trembling at what he did. It feels like such a betrayal. He thinks I'm broken. I am, but I thought he was different.

This is what my father—Garrett—required. He made me seek therapy. Made me sit in a straitjacket and talk about my feelings. It was a way to control me. To fuck with my mind. To convince me I was insane and that all fathers treated their daughters the way he did me.

Even Bill didn't force me into therapy after he found me. He let me work out my issues my own way. Maybe that's the problem. I never did work them out.

"Are you done?" he snaps.

"No." I hit him one more time in the arm and then plop back in my seat.

My heavy breathing fills the car, and he runs a hand through his hair before letting out a huff of annoyance.

I'm trembling, and angry tears sting my eyes. I drop my head to see my jeans have blood on them. At first I think it's from the hand I used to hit him with, but then I realize it's from my cut. "Fuck," I whisper, pressing my shaking hand on it. The pain causes me to hiss in a breath.

"What?"

I blink away the tears and look out the passenger window. "Fuck you, Kash—"

He yanks my hand away and growls. "Goddammit."

"If you wouldn't have picked me up…"

He gives a rough laugh. "Me? If you wouldn't have made a scene."

"I was trying to leave," I scream.

"I'm trying to help you," he shouts.

Deafening silence fills the car, and he reaches down, undoing his belt. When he rips it free and hands it to me, he says, "Put it around your thigh. Nice and tight. It'll hold until we get back."

"I'm fine." I cross my arms over my chest, refusing his help and hoping that I bleed all over his seat. That's the least I can do after what he just tried.

He veers off the road and slams on the brakes, causing my seat belt to tighten on me. Leaning over, he lifts my leg, making me grind my teeth while he slides his belt underneath it and ties it off. I think it's tighter than it needs to be.

I bite my bottom lip to keep from crying out. He grips my chin, placing his face in front of mine. "You might not care if you bleed out, but I do."

Those angry tears return, and I swallow the knot lodged in my throat. He loosens his hold on my face and runs the back of his tatted knuckles along my bruised cheek. "I love you, Eve. I'm trying to show you how much. Tell me what I need to do. Tell me what I can do to help you, and I'll do it."

My eyes search his, but I don't answer because I'm not sure what can be done. I can tell he sees me differently now, and I hate it. This is why I don't get close to anyone. I prefer to live in my bubble, where I'm just a nobody. "Just take me home," I whisper.

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FORTY-EIGHT



KASHTON

We pull up to Carnage, and she growls. "I told you to take me home."

Coming to a stop, I reach around my seat to the floorboard, grabbing my hat and slipping it on. "This is your home." I get out of the car and go over to open hers.

"Kashton, no." She tries to stay in her seat, but I pick her up and carry her up the steps and inside.

Entering the hospital wing, I bark, "Where the fuck is Devin?"

"I'm right here. What's wrong?" he asks, coming down the hall.

"She ripped her leg open."

He ushers us into a room, and I set her on the gurney.

"I said I'm fine," she argues, trying to get up, but I push her down by her shoulders.

"Restrain her," I order Devin.

Ninety-nine percent of the people he sees here are prisoners of Carnage. Every bed, table, or gurney we have is outfitted with restraints for the prisoners who need medical attention. They can't be trusted.

"What?" Eve gasps, her wide eyes on me. "Kashton…no." She starts to fight, but Devin is quick at getting her wrists in the medical restraints and then her ankles. Once done, I let go of her, and she narrows her eyes on mine. "I fucking hate you." She throws her head back onto the gurney, and a sob breaks through. "I…hate you."

Devin cuts open her jeans with a pair of scissors, and I sit down on the couch next to the bed, dropping my head in my hands, listening to her cry.

"She's ripped it open. I'm going to have to numb the area, clean the wound, and stitch it."

"Then fucking do it," I snap at Devin.

He leaves the room, and I stand, running a hand down my face. I walk over to the side of the bed and push her wild hair from her tear-streaked cheeks.

"Please?" Her bloodshot eyes meet mine, and they look like the same ones I saw on the tapes. When she begged Evan not to hurt her.

Am I doing the same thing? Am I hurting her by keeping her here? No. I'm helping her. I'm protecting her from them. If she goes back to her house, Evan could show up again and hurt her. Or worse, she could kill herself before he gets the chance. She admitted to us that she'd had the thought. Haidyn wasn't wrong that she needs help. I'm going to be the one to do it.

I have to protect her from the world and herself.

"Please, Kash." She arches her back and slams down onto the gurney.

"Let it out, angel," I tell her. Maybe she will exert herself and fall asleep.

Her body tenses as she pulls on the restraints, a cry ripping from her lips.

"It's okay to be mad," I tell her.

The door opens, and I expect it to be Devin, but it's Haidyn. "What the fuck happened?" he barks, rushing in with Saint.

Fuck this day. "She's fine." I want to slap myself. It's the same thing she told me, and I called her a liar.

He looks at the restraints and her blood-covered jeans, how she's got her head turned toward me, away from the door while she sobs into the pillow.

He steps forward, and I walk around the end of the bed. "You need to leave."

"Kash—"

"Get the fuck out, Haidyn," I bark. I'm not in the mood to deal with him right now. One thing at a time, and my girl always comes first.

Saint rushes to close the space between us, his hands on our chests. “Not in here,” he urges.

Haidyn turns and leaves, with Saint following to calm him down.

I walk back over to Everett and sit down, taking her hand in mine. I hold it, but she doesn’t hold it back. It lies limp.

She tries to pull it away, but the restraints don’t allow it. “I’m sorry, Eve,” I tell her, running my free hand over her soft hair. “I’m so sorry.”

She’s going to hate me. Fine. Let her hate me. This is who I am. A Lord who controls his Lady. She may not be my wife yet, but she will be, and I’m going to do a lot of things that she isn’t going to agree with.

The door opens, and I look up to see Devin with all his supplies. “May I speak to you for a moment?”

I let go of her hand and move to the other side of the room, where he whispers, “I can numb the area, but there’s always a possibility she’ll tear them open again if they don’t have the time to heal.” I glance over my shoulder, and she’s struggling in the restraints, trying her best to get free while she cries so hard her body trembles.

I place my attention back on him. “Sedate her.” I know what he’s asking, and she needs the rest. He needs her calm in order to help her, and I’d rather him not have to do this to her again.

He nods. “Yes, sir.”

Returning to her side, I cup her cheek, rubbing the remaining tears away, and kiss her forehead while Devin prepares the syringe. He rubs the alcohol on her upper arm before he gives her the sedative.

“You’re going to be okay, Eve. I’m not doing this to hurt you,” I explain.

Her body relaxes into the gurney, eyes on mine when they grow heavy, but as they close, she whispers, “You’re just like them.”

I lie next to Eve in our bed. She’s been out for about an hour now.

I keep fucking up. Nothing I ever do is right or good enough. I’m trying, but that doesn’t matter.

My tatted knuckles softly brush her hair from her bruised cheek. I'm going to rip Evan apart. Tear him to fucking pieces with my bare hands.

I'll make sure she gets the revenge she deserves.

My cell rings and I roll over to pick it up off my nightstand. **Bill** lights up the screen. "Hello?" I ask, getting out of bed, not wanting to wake her. Devin said she'd be out for a few hours, but I want her to get as much rest as she can.

"I received a video," he says in greeting.

I frown and pull the phone from my face to look at my messages. "I don't see anything new to the group chat."

"It came to me. Personally."

"Okay." I draw out the word. "What's on it?"

"I'm going to forward it to you. Call me after you watch it."

Click.

I lean my head back and close my eyes, taking a deep breath. My phone beeps in my hand, and I open it. Stepping out onto my balcony, I take a quick look at her in bed. She hasn't moved. Falling down into a chair, I press Play on the video.

"Where is she?" Bill demands, standing in a hallway with Isabella.

"William—"

"Don't lie to me. Trent told me she's here." He gives her his back and shouts. "Everett?"

"She's not going to hear you," Isabella states. She stands in a pair of high heels and an elegant black dress. It looks like Bill caught her before a dinner date with her husband—his best friend.

Bill spins around to face her, and she holds her hand up. "But I will allow you to see her."

Bill snorts at her choice of words, but Isabella holds all the power.

The cameras change to a new hallway, and they enter a room. Evan sits behind a desk, typing away on his cell. He stiffens when he looks up to see his father with Isabella. "What are you doing here?" Evan demands, getting to his feet.

"He's here to see Everett."

Evan gives a rough laugh. "There are no visiting hours."

"Don't test me, Evan," Bill growls. "I want to see her. Now."

His son straightens his shoulders and opens his mouth, but Isabella says, “Take us to her.”

“She’s in isolation at the moment.”

“Why the fuck is she in isolation?” Bill demands.

“She’s being punished?” Isabella arches a brow at Evan, and he nods. “Well”—she waves a hand in the air—“five minutes can’t hurt. Take us to her.”

Evan clenches his jaw and stomps past them out of the office, and they follow after him.

The cameras change once more to another hallway, and they come up to a door. Evan grabs a set of keys from his pocket and goes to open it when Bill asks, “What’s this red light?” He points to it on the wall.

“Live feed,” Evan answers through gritted teeth.

“Turn it off,” Isabella orders him.

Evan pulls his cell from his pocket and does as he’s told. Opening the door, it creaks as light filters into a small concrete room from the hallway.

“Eve.” Bill rushes to the girl lying on the floor.

I cover my mouth with my hand when I get a look at her. She’s on her side, arms tied behind her back with rope that wraps around her waist and upper chest. Her thighs and ankles are also tied.

The room can’t be any bigger than four feet by four feet; she couldn’t even stretch out to lie flat if she wanted to, and there isn’t a single light in the room.

“Everett?” Bill shakes her, but she shows no sign of consciousness. “What’s wrong with her?” he demands, but neither answers him. He feels her neck for a pulse and curses. Then he yanks his suit jacket off and lays it over her. “She’s freezing.” Then he starts to untie her ankles.

Evan steps forward, but Isabella reaches out, placing a hand on his chest, and shakes her head at him. He tenses, stepping back.

“What did you give her?” Bill snaps. “It’s obvious she’s been drugged. And when was the last time you gave her something to eat?”

"It takes forty-five days to die of starvation. She's only been here two weeks," Evan quips.

Bill looks up at him with narrowed eyes. "You allow this?" He glances at Isabella. "He's killing her."

Isabella checks her watch and sighs. "Take her to the infirmary."

"What?" Evan growls. "But she's—"

"I'll give you one million for her, but she leaves with me. Now," Bill interrupts him.

"Absolutely not," Evan snaps.

"You don't get to decide," Bill tells him and looks at Isabella. "You're going to sell her anyway. I'll buy her now. Two million."

She arches a brow in thought.

"She's not being sold." Evan crosses his arms over his chest.

"What?" Bill snaps looking back and forth between them. "What is he talking about?"

"We've found better use for her," Evan answers.

Bill's face whitens when he asks, "What the fuck is it?"

"She's going to be a recruiter." He gives an evil smile.

"No." Bill shakes his head. "She'll never do it."

Evan throws his head back. "Eve will do whatever I tell her to do. I'm the one she answers to. I'm the one who gives her orders."

Bill runs a hand down his face, stressing. "Three million."

Isabella opens her mouth, but Evan beats her to it. "No amount of money will allow you to leave with her. She is going to bring in ten times that. Every woman she helps us take will be trained and sold. She is worth way more here than a quick buck." He looks his father up and down with disgust.

"Isabella," Bill growls.

"Take her, Evan," she orders. "Get her some fluids and food. You can continue her punishment in a couple of days. She's worth nothing to us dead."

Evan huffs, bends down, and picks up her limp body before he carries her out of frame.

Bill begins to pace the narrow hallway before turning to Isabella. "You can't do this."

"I can do whatever I want."

"Goddammit," Bill shouts. "Aimee would kill you for this."

She purses her lips, glancing away before she says, "Aimee knew the risks when she decided she wanted to be initiated."

"She would not have done this to your daughter. To Annabelle. For fuck's sake, Isabella, she was your best friend."

Isabella softly laughs. "Yes, she would have." Stepping into him, she lowers her voice. "I'm a woman in a man's world. I have to take what I want."

"Eve is innocent." Bill fists his hands.

"Maybe." She shrugs. "But you know the rules. She must serve the Lords. One way or another." Isabella gives him her back to walk away.

But his words stop her. "If Evan kills Eve, I will burn this place down. With you in it." She turns back to face him. "I will not give up on her."

Isabella smiles at him before turning once more and leaving him standing in the hallway alone.

The video ends, and I lean forward with my elbows on my knees and place my phone to my ear.

"Hello?" Bill answers.

"What the fuck was that?" I bark. "You told us you didn't know where Dollhouse was, but you've been there?"

"No. I told you I was waiting for confirmation that Haidyn was there. I couldn't show up with Charlotte until Isabella told me it was okay to bring her. I had been there several times."

"Why don't I believe anything you say?" I growl.

He sighs. "I understand this is difficult…"

"Difficult?" I shout, standing. "If you knew where Dollhouse was, you could have taken them down years ago." Adam's boss—the detective on Bill's private jet—told us that they had been looking for their location. Bill knew all along and could have helped them. The boss probably has no idea that Bill was holding out on him.

"No one was going to take her down," he snaps. "There were too many Lords helping Isabella keep that place running. What did you want me to do? Call the cops?" He snorts. "I needed help. I needed…more."

"You needed us," I growl. "You used me, Saint, and the others. You let Haidyn sit in there and be tortured in order to get what you wanted."

"It was to save your brother," he shouts. "I had to save not only Haidyn, but Charlotte. Hell, I had already failed Eve." Bill lowers his voice. "I may be a Lord, but sometimes that isn't enough."

EVERETT

Nineteen years old

I blink, trying to clear my vision, but it does no good. Wherever I am, it's dark and cold.

I'm also starving.

My knees are shoved to my chest, and my back is up against what I can only guess is a wall. I'm in a cell.

I spend most of my time here.

I've been sentenced to a life in prison. One that treats the innocent like criminals.

I can hear voices—screaming—in the distance. Cries of pain and shouts of desperation.

It never ends. All hours of the day and night.

There are no clocks on the walls. Time means nothing. It's used as torture, not a convenience.

I hurt everywhere. There's an ache in my chest and a throbbing in my head.

It's the drugs. They have lasting effects. When they first hit, you're flying, but when they wear off, you're fucking as low as you can get. I imagine it would be hard at any time, but when your body is being starved of everything it needs to survive, I think the hit is harder.

I can't feel my arms. Last I remember, they were tied behind my back.

This is what fighting gets you. When you don't lie down and take the abuse, they force it on you.

I hear the sound of a lock clicking, and like a dog about to be fed, my mouth starts to water.

"Hello, dolly." He enters.

I lower my head, trying to hide my eyes from the harsh light.

"How do you feel?" he asks. It's the same stupid question all the time.

"Numb," I lie. If I give him any other answer, he drugs me.

His hand touches my hair, and I yank my head away.

He grips a handful of it and drags me away from the wall. I scream out and start kicking, but my legs are tied together. He throws me onto my back and straddles my chest.

I can't breathe from his heavy weight.

His hand grips my cheeks, and he forces my head back. "Still being an ungrateful bitch, I see."

I try to scream, but nothing comes out.

"We've got a long life to spend with one another," he goes on, "and I want us to both enjoy it." When he gets up off me, I roll onto my side and suck in a ragged breath, my throat and chest burning. I bring my tied legs to my chest and spit onto the concrete floor. "We'll try the hard way."

I feel the sting of something across the back of my legs, and I cry out. He does it again, and I try to crawl away, but he's got me tied to prevent it.

Lords always win because they cheat.

So I scoot like a worm, but the room is too small. There's nowhere for me to go. I see his belt and hear the whoosh *before it comes down across my face.*

Sobbing, I curl into a ball the best I can. This is my punishment. I tried to kill myself and failed.

He kneels next to me and pushes the hair from my face, making me scowl. "Why do you make me hurt you, dolly? Hmm? Don't you want to be my good girl?"

Snot covers my face, and I lick the salty tears off my cracked lips. "Y-es."

"Show me, Eve." He stands and undoes his jeans, followed by his zipper. "Show me how good you want to be for me, and I'll treat you like a good girl."

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FORTY-NINE



KASHTON

I ’m in the shower, my head on the wall while the warm water runs down my back. My jaw is clenched, and my fists are up by my head.

A recruiter?

Evan got greedy. He wanted to keep her for himself. To be what to Eve? Her pimp?

Everything Everett went through, and he was going to punish her. He wanted her to help capture innocent women to be trafficked. He knew what he was doing. He knew how much it would hurt her.

She’d rather die than put someone else through what she’d gone through.

My phone beeps, and I push away to see it lit up on the bathroom counter. A part of me wants to smash it with a hammer. I’m tired of all the incoming texts and videos. It beeps again, and I reluctantly turn the water off and get out, grabbing a towel off the hook.

I wrap it around myself when I hear Eve scream from the bedroom.

Shoving the bathroom door open, I enter just in time to see her sitting up in bed. She’s wide-eyed and gasping for breath. “Eve?” I rush over to her. “What’s wrong? Are you hurting?”

Her green eyes are frantic, and I gently push her hair from her face. “I’m—” She swallows.

“What? You’re what?” I pull the covers off her to glance at her thigh. It’s still wrapped, and there isn’t any blood, reassuring me that her fresh stitches are holding.

“I’m going…” She places her hand over her mouth, and I yank her from the bed and rush her to the bathroom, knowing exactly what

she's trying to tell me. Falling to her knees, she leans forward and gets sick. "I'm…sorry…" she says before she dry heaves.

"You're okay." I hold her hair, crouching behind her to rub her bare back with my free hand. "It's okay. Let it out, Eve."

She gets sick once more and then sits back.

I flush the toilet and grab my phone off the counter. I message Devin, asking if the drugs will upset her stomach. He responds immediately.

> They shouldn't. Is she feeling ill? I can give her something if that's the case.

I begin to respond when I see her getting to her shaky legs. Putting my cell down, I walk over to her, but she takes a step back, wrapping her arms around herself. Her watery eyes are on the floor, and it makes me sick to think about what woke her up. I spent six months with Isabella here at Carnage while she trained us. Eve spent more than half her life in hell. First Carnage and then Dollhouse.

What did she dream about? Was it Evan? Did he hurt her? She blocked out so much for so long that now there's no telling how much she'll start to remember.

Running a hand through my hair, I notice she has vomit in hers. I wasn't fast enough to pull it back for her. "Would you like a bath?" I ask, not wanting to point it out to her.

She nods, and I shut the bathroom door and turn on the water to the tub. Once I get it to temperature, I send a quick text to Jessie and then reach my hand out to her. When she just stares at it, I speak. "It's okay, angel. Let me help you." The last thing I want is for her to fall and hurt herself.

Eve allows me to assist her into the tub, and she pulls her knees to her chest, laying her forehead on them.

"You can't get your stitches wet just yet, so I have to let it drain."

She doesn't show me any sign that she's acknowledged what I said.

I grab a cup, fill it from the faucet, and let it run down over her hair and back.

She sits facing forward, softly rocking back and forth while I shampoo and condition her hair. Once I'm done, I lower myself to my knees and place my forearms on the side of the tub to look at her. "Feel better?" I ask.

Licking her lips, she whispers, "I'm sorry."

"It's okay."

Her green eyes stare straight ahead at the wall. I place the back of my hand on her forehead, down over her cheek and to her neck. I can't tell if she has a fever or not. She feels warm, but that could be from the hot water.

"Jessie is bringing you some soup."

She drops her eyes to her legs. "I'm sorry," she repeats and adds, "For saying you're like them. You're nothing like them."

"Who is *them*, Eve?" I question, wanting to keep her talking to me even though I have an idea of what she meant. Every man in her life has drugged her. Now that includes me. This was different from when I challenged her at her house. When she was going to drug me to run.

"Our fathers," she answers softly.

I open my mouth, but she goes on. "She told me you were a good boy, but I didn't believe her. No one who survives hell comes out holy." Her eyes glance at my nun tattoo when she adds, "We're all damned."

She's talking in riddles, which makes me wonder if Devin gave her too much. "Who told you that?"

Her eyes meet mine and my frown deepens. She looks tired…off in another world, but her answer makes my blood run cold. "Your mother."

"My mother?" I repeat.

She doesn't answer. Instead, her eyes go back to the running faucet.

"What about my mom, Eve?" I dig, needing her to explain. My mother has been dead for quite some time. When would she have seen or spoken to her?

She sniffs. "I had an imaginary friend. Isolation will do that to you… make you see things that aren't there. She was so pretty." A smile

tugs at the corner of her lips. "Golden blond hair that flowed down her back. Big eyes. They were so bright." Her voice drops. "The prettiest thing about her was that she never had any bruises. Her skin was so vibrant and…perfect. I wanted to be her." Sighing, she licks her lips. "She and I would play in the basement."

I stiffen, knowing my mother was caged down there.

"When we would go down there, there was always a woman. She looked cold and hungry. I wanted to help her…set her free, but she never would let me. Told me it was too dangerous. That she was where she was meant to be. One time, I was down there with my imaginary friend, and my father caught me. Threw me in the cell across from hers. It wasn't long after that I heard someone new join us in the basement. It was you." She pauses and I swallow. "You gave her a brownie…" Eve drops her head to look at the water. "Your father found you, dragged you to the elevator. That's when she spoke to me. She said, 'He's a good boy. Not like them.' I didn't believe her because I didn't think people were born bad. I thought 'Just give him time…they'll change him.'"

I run a hand down my face and take a deep breath, wanting her to continue but giving her time.

"Your father came back, opened her cell. He started to beat her. He didn't know my father had thrown me into the cell across from her. He unlocked my cell and removed his belt." Her shoulders start to tremble. "He tied my wrists together with it and shoved me face-first into the cell door, using the rest of his belt to secure my hands above my head to the bars. I had to stand on my tiptoes. Your mother yelled and begged him to not rape me. He didn't, but he… did other things. Once satisfied, he shoved open the door and slammed it shut, leaving me hanging there. Your mom sat on the floor of her cell, hands wrapped around the bars, sobbing. He walked over and spit on her before he left us alone." A tear runs down her cheek.

I wipe it away and realize my hand is shaking.

"I managed to untie the belt from the bars, and once I was able to sit down, I used my teeth to undo my wrists. Your mother cried. She just kept saying, 'He's a good boy. He's not like them.' Then she…"

Taking a second, Eve sucks in a shaky breath. I know what she doesn't want to say. My mother killed herself. "Then there was just… silence. It must have been morning when you came back down. Your father told you she was gone. You started screaming for her."

My heart thunders in my chest as I begin to comprehend what she's telling me. Everett was the girl huddled in the corner of the cell across from my mother. She was right there in front of me. I could have saved her, but my focus was on finding my mother who was already dead. I should have saved Eve.

"I remember thinking *I'll do that one day. I'll get the chance to end it. The only difference is no one will scream for me. No one will miss me*."

Her watery eyes meet mine. "I'm sorry, Kashton. It's my fault…" Her eyes redden. "It was me that night…she ended her life because of me." Sniffling, she goes on. "I took her from you—"

"No." I reach out and cradle her face in my hands. "It's not your fault, Eve. None of it was."

She nods her head and I shake mine. "No. My mother…" I sigh. "She wouldn't want you to blame yourself. She made that decision."

"Because of me." Eve begins to cry. "It's my fault…everything is my fault."

"Stop. Stop, Eve," I say firmly to get her attention. Her watery eyes meet mine and she blinks rapidly to clear her vision. "Quit blaming yourself, angel. My mother…" I'm not sure what to say to her. She felt she had no other choice. To her it wasn't a life worth living. But I can't say that to Everett, because she's tried to end her life twice.

Eve blinks, fresh tears falling from her bottom lashes. "She would be proud of you, Kashton."

My stomach knots at her words. Eve is wrong. My mother would be ashamed of who I've become. As hard as I tried not to become my father, I did. The woman sitting in front of me is proof.

It doesn't matter how many videos are sent to me; I'm not letting her go. She may not physically be in the basement chained to the wall with a collar around her neck, but I'm going to make sure she is chained to me for life. I'm going to make her my Lady.

"Come on," I order, standing and helping her do the same. "I'll dry your hair. Your soup is going to get cold."

EVERETT

I've been locked in Kashton's bedroom for a week. The only fresh air I get is when I sit out on his balcony like I am right now.

It's not a warm day, but it's also not cold. I'm wearing one of his hoodies while drinking a bottle of water. I'm craving a fucking drink. Jessie keeps me fed, and Kash—well, he hasn't left my side.

He's hovering, and it's obvious he doesn't trust me. He made that very clear when he had Devin knock me out to stitch up my leg for the second time.

We haven't fucked. He hasn't even touched me, really. He gives me baths but doesn't join me. We sleep in the same bed, but he doesn't make any advances.

I've either scared him, or he no longer finds me attractive. I've become the useless trash that no one wants. Not someone like him anyway. Just the ones who pay to fuck you when they're in the mood.

I wish he'd just kick me out of Carnage. Send me away. That would be easier to accept than this.

He's also fighting with Haidyn. I've heard their hushed conversations in the hallway while they think I'm asleep. Haidyn wants me on medication. He thinks I'm suicidal. I was at one point, but I don't want to die today.

I refuse to take medication. It's why I don't do drugs. They would probably make things easier. Help blur the memories. But that's what the Lords did to me at Dollhouse, which is why I refuse to take anything. For so long, I've tried to convince myself I'm not the same woman, but maybe I am.

Kashton thinks I'm broken. Haidyn thinks I'm a danger to myself. I think I'm fine. We can't all three be wrong. Someone has to be right. The question is, which one of us is it?

"I have to leave, Eve," Kashton announces, stepping out onto his balcony.

I look up at him. "Where are you going?" Finally. I'll get a second to breathe. Think for myself. He places my food orders with Jessie, and

he decides when he bathes me. Kash also brushes my hair. The only thing I do myself is brush my teeth and wipe my own ass. I've allowed him to take over my life.

He sits across from me, and I look away from him to focus on the woods. His stare is too intense. He's always looking for something, and I don't want to give him a reason to think he's found whatever it is. If Haidyn can ever convince Kashton to join his side, I'm fucked. As much as I hate that he knows the real me, I've grown accustomed to being with him. To knowing what it's like to not be alone and forgotten. Even if it is tied to a bed.

"We'll only be gone a couple of hours," he assures me but ignores my question. It also tells me he's going with his brothers. "If you need anything, Devin is here, and Jessie will be by to check on you."

"Okay." I nod.

He stands, leans over, and kisses my forehead before he steps back into his room.

I sit silently until I hear his bedroom door shut and lock. Getting up, I go to my nightstand. My phone is charging. I let it die days ago. Who the fuck do I need to talk to?

Ashtyn added me to the girls' group chat. I know it was to just piss me off. Blakely and Elli kept posting pictures of the babies, and everyone is planning Laikyn's baby shower.

I just couldn't handle it. But since Kashton is gone, I might as well see what I've missed.

Turning it on, my cell beeps, and I see an incoming text. It's a name and a number.

Adam came through with a job. He doesn't see me as weak. Or damaged. He knows what I need and is willing to give it to me. Adam doesn't hover around me when I'm working.

I bite my bottom lip as I read over it. It's for tonight. A couple of hours from now.

Deciding that's what I need—to get out, to feel like the old me—I quickly throw my hair in a high pony, brush my teeth, slap on bare minimum makeup, and get dressed. What's Kashton going to do? Punish me? He won't even fuck me.

The most he'll do is tie me to the bed while I throw a fit. Possibly sedate me.

I'm not one of those women who is going to quit her job for a man. I have things I have to do, and I've been slacking by letting him coddle me like I'm a sick child needing care.

I'm ready in twenty minutes and walk right out the front door. I'm not a prisoner here. He said *we,* so that means Haidyn and Saint are with him, and I'm not even sure the girls are here. They get to come and go as they please, so why can't I? I didn't see Jessie or Devin, so it was easy to leave.

I send a quick text to make sure my date will be there, and my cell rings through the speakers in my car as I pull out of the gates of Carnage.

Kashton lights up the screen on my dash.

I debate answering it, but I feel good at the moment. More like myself than I have since they returned from Dollhouse. "Hello, baby." I've never used a pet name before, but it just feels right in a good, condescending way.

"Eve," he growls in warning.

"Yes?" I ask innocently, quickly checking the rearview mirror to make sure he's not on my ass.

"Where the fuck are you going?" he snaps.

Of course the bastard has a tracker on me. It's either on my cell or my car. He might have had Devin insert one into my body when he sedated me. "I'm just running out for a minute. I'll be back soon."

"Return home. Now."

Home? Has Carnage become my home? I hate to admit that it has. I'm not sure how to feel about that, but I'm not going to let it sour my good mood. "I will be back later."

"Fucking now, Eve," he shouts.

I don't know why, but I like this side of him. I'm not the kind of girl to obey. He'll have to make me, but I still like it. "Can't do that." I smile.

Fuck, freedom feels good. The air blowing in from my cracked windows, the ability to drive wherever. We've both been on eggshells for the past week. He stares at me like I'm broken. He watched one of

my training videos, and it's no longer the same. He doesn't know what to do or how to act. Why doesn't he just kick me out and tell me goodbye?

I was fucking spiraling while I was trapped in his room, and now I feel better.

"I'm not running, Kash," I assure him. "I'll be back—"

"Turn around," he barks. "Now."

My teeth grind and my mood starts to fade. I shift in my seat. "No."

"I've gone too easy on you." He huffs.

My laughter fills the car, that careless attitude returning quickly. "Too easy on me? That's a joke, right?" I bait him. All I've done the past week is rot away in his room while he coddled me.

"Everett, if you don't turn around right fucking now, I will hunt you down, strip you naked, and chain you up in the basement."

"Don't threaten me with a good time," I quip.

He takes in a calming breath, and I tighten my thighs, images rising of his gorgeous face while he has me gagged and unable to beg him to come. *I need him to fuck me.*

"I promise you, Eve, you'll have anything but a 'good time.'"

I feel like he's recently had another conversation with Haidyn about me, and I don't like it. Maybe I won't return tonight after all. I'm about to tell him to go fuck himself when I get a text. I glance at it quickly.

See you soon, gorgeous.

I smile at myself and tell Kashton, "Do what you have to do, Kash."

"Eve—"

I hang up on him.

I'm walking into the biker bar, glancing around to make sure Kashton didn't somehow beat me here. It's packed for this time of night. The petite brunette is working behind the bar, and she smiles when she sees me.

"I'll take a vodka tonic," I tell her.

"Okay." Walking away, I watch her get it ready, and she comes back to set it in front of me.

I place a twenty down and see a guy enter. I give him my flirtatious *I want you to fuck me* smile. I'm not in the mood for small talk or role play. I have to get the job done before Kashton shows up. Maybe if I can beat him back, he won't lock me in a cell. I don't know, though. That sounds fun. I haven't been touched in a week. Right now, I'd take anything he wants to give me. Maybe that's why he doesn't want to fuck me. Because he knows the reason as to why I like to be fucked. Why I get so desperate for him.

I flinch at that thought and quickly push it out of my mind.

I don't even take a sip of my drink before I'm leading the guy over to my motel room.

I allow him to open the door for me, and I step inside. He shuts the door and then removes his jacket before placing it on the bed.

Reaching into my purse, I pull out my gun and fire, shooting him right in the head. "Disgusting bastard," I spit out.

The sound of Kashton's car pulling into the parking spot in front of the motel room has a smile growing across my face. "Let's see what you got, big boy."

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FIFTY



KASHTON

I bring my car to a screeching halt in front of room 111. Picking up my cell, I read over the incoming text and fist my hands.

"Motherfucker," I shout, hitting the steering wheel.

Honestly, I'm not sure why I'm surprised. I knew this was coming. This is what I wanted. The Lords just gave me her assignment for her initiation to be my Lady. All she has to do is pass and she's mine.

The thing about Eve is that they know who she is. They know where she's weak and what drives her mad. And they always use that against you. She will be no different. They want to test her to see how much she can take. And right now, I'm concerned about just how little it'll take before she breaks.

Getting out of my car, I walk into the motel room, and she turns to face me, gun raised right at my head.

I smirk, leaning up against the closed door.

"You look pretty happy about the possibility of getting shot." She arches a dark brow.

She's barely spoken to me in the past week. I haven't said much to her either, though. I've been trying to navigate what to do. Between what I now know about her past and Haidyn, I've been confused and running in circles.

I'm afraid if I try to talk to her about it, it'll bring up bad memories. I don't want her to hurt more than she already is. Especially after how she reacted about the therapist. But right now, she looks more like the woman I fell in love with than she has in the past week.

She's dressed in black skinny jeans that hug her long legs with a tight-fitting T-shirt and matching leather jacket that's unzipped. Her

bleached-blond hair is pulled off her face in a high ponytail—not a single hair out of place—and her makeup is light. She looks like she's ready for me to take her out for a movie. Not for a job.

"Do what you have to do, angel," I tell her what she told me on the phone. I was furious that she ran the moment I left her alone. I had every intention of hauling her home, stripping her naked, and putting her in a cell. And after the text I got, that might still happen, it just won't be at Carnage.

I cross my arms over my chest, noticing the dead guy on the floor. One bullet right between the eyes. My girl never misses. If she were to ever shoot me, at least I know it'd be a fatal shot. Unless her point was just to wound me.

She snorts and moves to place the gun on the dresser, then she's rushing me. My angel wants a fight. That's what I promised her.

I'm knocked back into the door when she leaps onto me. She's like trying to give a feral cat a bath. Her open hands hit at my face, and her legs wrap around me. I walk over and fall onto the bed, smashing her underneath me to have the advantage. Not like I need it. I'm letting her take her frustration out on me. The dead guy on the floor wasn't enough for my girl. He was too easy of a target.

Sitting up, I manage to grab her flailing arms and flip her onto her stomach. She lets out a scream of frustration and bucks when I bring them behind her back and pin them in place with one hand while the other removes my belt. Then I'm wrapping it around her forearms over and over before I turn her back over. I didn't need to tie it off. It'll hold good enough for now.

"Kash," she growls

I straddle her hips and smile down at her while she tries to get her breathing under control. I haven't even broken a sweat. "Is this what you wanted, Eve?" I ask calmly.

It just pisses her off more. She grinds her teeth and arches her back.

"Remember that night in the cemetery?" Her eyes narrow on mine and I lower myself on top of her, my lips trailing along her racing pulse. "When I asked you if you wanted me to save you from a

rapist? Then you could reward me by letting me have my way with you while you begged me like a good whore?”

She bucks wildly at my words. “Fuck you—”

I wrap my hand around her throat and sit up, watching her pretty narrowed eyes shoot daggers at me. “There’s nothing to be ashamed of, Eve.” I sit on top of her while she fights to breathe. “I’ll give you whatever you need.”

Her painted lashes flutter and her body starts to soften underneath me.

Letting go, she gasps and coughs. I get up off her and stand next to the edge of the bed, pulling her to a sitting position. “Deep breaths, angel,” I command, listening to her sputter.

Reaching around her, I undo the belt and toss it to the floor, and then I rip her jacket off her arms.

I lay her back down and squat to remove her boots. I untie the laces, rip them from the eyelets, and then do the same with the other before I pull them off. Then I stand, undoing her jeans, and pull them down her shaking legs. “I’m disappointed. I thought you wanted a fight.”

Her only response is a cough.

I take her left ankle and bend her knee to her chest, bring her left arm down, and use one of her shoestrings to tie her wrists to her ankle, then repeat the process to the other. It’s not the best, but it’s all I’ve got to work with at the moment.

“Your underwear is soaked.” I run my fingers over the wet spot on her white thong. “Did he touch you? Did it turn you on when he attacked you?” I ask, referring to the dead guy who is still in the room with us.

She’s still trying to get her breathing under control and chooses to ignore me.

I lean over her trembling body and grip her cheeks. “Eve? Did you let him touch what’s mine?”

Clenching her jaw shut, she refuses to respond. Glancing around the room, I yank a pillow from the headboard and grab the end of the pillowcase and shake the pillow out.

“Kash?” She gasps.

"Too late, angel. You had your chance to speak." I hold the polyester fabric out in front of me, twisting it a few times to tightly roll it up and then slide it underneath her head so I can wrap it once around her neck.

"I—"

I pull the ends tight, cutting off her words.

Eve rises up a bit, her head a few inches off the bed. I push forward and tenderly kiss her parted lips. "This is me proving my point, angel." I make sure to talk slowly so she can follow what I'm saying. Right now, her bottle green eyes are large and swimming with tears that haven't fallen yet. Her body fights the restraints while she desperately tries to breathe. "You do not allow any other man to kiss, touch, or fuck you. No one gets to play with what's mine, do you understand that?"

Her pouty lips open and close, but nothing comes out.

"Your job does not matter. No other man matters. I'm all that matters to you. You are my whore, and you will be my Lady," I remind her. She doesn't know it yet, but it's going to happen sooner rather than later.

Kissing her lips once more, I pull away and let go of the pillowcase but leave it wrapped around her neck.

Her head falls to the bed, and she sucks in a deep breath. I unzip my jeans, pull my hard cock out through my boxer briefs, and then crawl onto the bed. Pushing her underwear to the side, I slide my cock into her. She's ready for me.

The argument we had on the phone.

The fight with the dead man on the floor.

What little foreplay we've had.

It has her all worked up. I don't have time to tie her up and let her sit in the corner with her ass and pussy filled while she comes all over herself. This is as close to a 'playtime' as I can do right now. I've been on the clock since I received that text.

Leaning forward, I place my arms behind her knees, shoving her feet and arms into the air.

She whimpers at the position, trying to arch her back, but my weight is on top of her. "Beg me to fuck you," I order. "Be my dirty

angel and beg me for it like a good whore."

"Please." She licks her lips before sucking in a deep breath. "Please, Kash…fuck me. I need you to fuck me."

I pull my hips back and slam forward, making her body tremble. I do it again, and her eyes fall shut. "I need…"

"Look at me when I'm fucking you."

They spring open, and I give her a soft smile. Goddamn, she's so fucking beautiful. "What do you need, Eve? Tell me." I slowly pull my cock out and watch her squirm with need under me when I don't put it back into her needy cunt immediately.

"I need you to hurt me," she whispers.

My girl does love the pain. "Don't you dare close your eyes. I want them on me, angel. Understand?"

"Eyes on yours," she agrees.

I slide my achingly hard cock slowly into her cunt, loving the sound of her breath catching. Grabbing each end of the pillowcase still wrapped around her neck, I tighten my fingers on the material and hold it into the bed, cutting off her air once more while I fuck her tight cunt until I'm watching her beautiful tear-filled eyes roll into the back of her head.

EVERETT

I lie on the hard and cheap mattress, staring up at the ceiling while Kashton is propped up on his elbow next to me. His free hand lightly runs along my neck. The room has finally stopped spinning, and I have my breathing under control while his cum leaks from my pussy. I should be embarrassed. I got off. Came all over his pierced cock like the trained whore I am. But that's what I wanted. He chased me down and reminded me of who I am—his.

"How do you feel?" He breaks the silence.

I glance up into his worried blue eyes that are grazing my body.

"I'm not going to get sick," I assure him. His eyes meet mine and he frowns as if he doesn't believe me. "I'm not as fragile as you think." I almost roll my eyes that I have to clear my throat after him choking me out. I've got a pounding headache, but other than that, my body feels amazing.

"I never said you were."

"Would you have fucked me had I not attacked you?" He needed to assert his dominance. Put me in my place. That's why I did what I did, and I need to know that he didn't see me as weak. I lower my voice to say what's been on my mind. "You haven't touched me in a week, Kash."

Cupping my face, his soft blue eyes search mine. "I didn't want to scare you," he admits, and I hate that I even put that thought in his head. "I know you don't believe me, but I'm really trying to do the right thing, but I don't know what that is." I open my mouth to speak, but he goes on. "No one has ever cared about your feelings or overall mental health. Is it so bad that I do?"

I don't know how to respond to that because I would rather him tie me up and fuck me than talk about my problems or my past. I'm fucked up.

"I want to take care of you."

"And you're going to accomplish that by chaining me up in the basement?" I ask sarcastically, referring to our argument during our phone call.

"Yeah," he replies simply, causing me to swallow nervously and then flinch at how tender my throat is.

It's his mother. Kashton failed her. He saw her locked up day after day, and a part of him knew that as long as she was in there, she was safe from the world his father forced him to live in. Kashton thinks the only way to protect me is to throw me in a cell and keep hold of the only key. I'll be untouchable to anyone but him. It sounds as pleasing as it is terrifying.

I've always been caged. It became home. Is that why I ran back to Carnage for him so fast? It was all I knew for so long. I crave the pain, his touch, and the need to please him. My past has shaped me into who I am just as much as his has.

I sit up, and his hand falls from my neck as he does the same. I get out of bed and turn my back to the mirror to face him while he stands on the opposite side. "Will you hand me my jeans?" He removed them on that side of the bed.

"Get undressed," he orders, his now heated stare dropping to my shirt. "You don't need your clothes."

"I have to drive home." As much as I want to be his toy tonight, we have to get out of here. I have to call in this job to have the dead man's body removed.

"Leave your car. You'll ride with me," he states. Problem solved.

"I'm not leaving my car here." Fuck, he's being more unreasonable than usual. "It'll get stolen." At the very least, it'll get broken into.

"I'll buy you a new one. Whatever you want."

Goddammit. "I like my car. I want my car." I sound like a spoiled brat, but he's being a dick.

His cell goes off, and he pulls it out of his pocket and reads over a message. Then he puts it away, bends down, and grabs my jeans. "Go ahead." He tosses them onto the bed in the center. "But just so you know, I'm going to be ripping those off you again soon."

I grab my jeans and go to the restroom really quick. After washing my hands, I slide them on, and I hear my phone go off.

Opening up the message from an unknown number, my stomach drops at what's written across it.

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FIFTY-ONE



KASHTON

She just got her assignment. I can tell by the way her entire body stiffens while she clutches her cell.

One text has changed her night.

I exit the motel room, needing to grab my bag from the car. I came prepared to drag her back to Carnage. Now I'll use it for a different reason. When I walk back into the room, she's sitting on the bench lacing up her boots. I can see her hands shaking trying to thread it.

"I got a text," she informs me.

I drop my bag onto the bed, and she looks over her shoulder before her eyes snap back to mine. Walking over to her, I squat and start lacing them for her. "Me too." I actually received two. But who's counting? I look up at her as I tie the laces and start on the next one.

She sighs, running her free hand through her messy ponytail nervously. "What now?"

"I do what I have to do," I answer, and she swallows, knowing what I mean by that. I'm not letting her go, and if the Lords think otherwise, then they can go fuck themselves. When I finish lacing the other, I stand and take her hands, forcing her to her feet. "I'm sorry."

Biting her bottom lip, she averts her eyes to my T-shirt. "None of this is your fault."

She thinks I mean her past, but I'm referring to her future. "I'm going to make you hate me."

Her eyes meet mine, and she gives me a sad smile. "I could never hate you, Kashton. I was just…frustrated."

She's referring to what I've done to her the past week. The therapist, having her restrained and sedated. She has to know that I can do much worse to her than that. "I'm going to break you, Eve," I admit. "You understand that, right? What the Lords want me to do to you?"

Slowly, she nods.

Bill and Sin told me this would happen, and I told them she could take it. After everything I know now, I'm not so sure she can, but there's no stopping it.

Her pretty green eyes scan the room, unable to meet mine. "I trust you, Kashton," she whispers.

"I love you." Leaning forward, I gently kiss her forehead. Pulling away, I walk over to her purse and remove her car keys. Putting them in my pocket, I pick up her cell that was next to her on the bench. "I'll give you a sixty-second head start."

She tilts her head to the side in confusion.

"Run."

She rushes out the door, and I remove my pack of cigarettes and Zippo and sit on the end of the bed.

I use her phone to dial up a number, lighting a cigarette while I wait for him to answer.

"Hello?" comes a familiar voice.

"It's Kash," I state since he won't recognize this number. "Got a minute?"

"One sec," he whispers, and I take a drag, letting the nicotine fill my lungs. Usually, it calms me. Right now, it's not doing shit. "What's going on, man?"

"You at Carnage?"

"Yeah. Saint and Haidyn are pissed at you. You removed your tracker."

Yep. Ripped that bitch out the moment I left my brothers after Eve hung up on me. We were at Dollhouse looking for Evan. Bill thought he might be there. Saint wasn't talking and Haidyn was voicing his opinion on how Eve can't be left alone. I didn't remove my tracker because I'm hiding. It's because I don't want to lead Haidyn to Eve. He's got this big-brother-needs-to-protect-her complex now. As

much as I am grateful for that, she doesn't need him. She needs me. Especially now that I got her assignment. Haidyn would never allow me to do what I'm about to do to her.

"What do you need?" Sin asks at my silence.

"I received Eve's assignment for her initiation. I'm going to send you a list of things and an address."

"When do you need it by?"

"An hour," I say, swiping to her messaging app to type out the things in a text before pressing Send, shooting it his way. "Sent." Then I delete it so she can't go back to read it later.

After a second, he hisses. "Goddammit." He just read my message. Then he clears his throat. "I'll meet you there."

"This stays between us." I feel the need to say it out loud. Maybe for my own sanity because what I'm about to do is insane. I don't want to hurt her, but in order to keep her, I'll do whatever the Lords want.

"Of course."

He hangs up and I take one last drag before I stand and check my watch.

Times up, angel.

EVERETT

I'm running, knowing he's behind me. He took my keys, so my car was out of the question. He wants me on foot, adrenaline pumping and exhausted. Less work for him to do if I'm too worn out to struggle.

It's dark out, and I'm having a hard time seeing where I'm going. It's slowing me down. The moment I ran out of the motel, I darted for the woods behind it. The fucker will have to carry me kicking and screaming back to his car. I ditched my leather jacket, but at least I didn't wear heels tonight. It wasn't about looking sexy for the job. It was about comfort. I wasn't going to play with my food. I was supposed to be in and out. No hiccups. Boy, was I wrong.

My leg isn't completely healed, but it was doing better. It's on fire now, and I keep feeling it to make sure I haven't ripped my stitches open and am bleeding.

The text was one word—Dollhouse.

Last I heard, it's no longer in operation. Not since Isabella was locked up in Carnage.

Why there?

What do they want him to do?

"I'm going to break you, Eve."

He was so confident, and I have no doubt he'll do whatever he has to do. He's already proven that to me. But can I do the same?

I don't want to let him down.

"You can do it," I tell myself. He believes in me. I just have to believe in myself. This proves that he still wants me, right? I have to try for him. For us.

I come to a stop; my legs are Jell-O, and my heart is racing. I can't breathe. Falling onto my ass, I push my back into the tree and cover my mouth with my hand. Who knows how close he is.

I'm not sure why we're even playing this game. Why did he allow me to run? Is this another one of his fucked-up versions of hide-and-seek? We haven't played it other than that one time.

He said he got a text too. Maybe his was different than mine? More instructions?

Or maybe he just wants me turned on. Kashton knows the chase excites me. Fuck, I'm wet right now—and my underwear isn't just soaked from his cum leaking out of my pussy.

But I'm not going to make it easy on him. If he wants me, he'll have to work for it.

I get to my shaking legs, bend over with my hands on my knees, and try to calm my breathing before I take off again. I can keep this up all night.

The sound of twigs breaking has me standing up and flipping my loosened ponytail out of my face. It comes again on my right, and I turn to look to see if he's there, but nothing. I turn and step forward to run in the opposite direction when I hit something hard. I yelp in surprise and look up into a set of familiar eyes. Even in the dark night, they glow a light blue.

"Caught you, angel," Kashton says.

I expect him to be smirking or laughing like the usual game we play, but he's not this time. Instead, his pretty eyes are void of any

playfulness.

I swallow nervously. My fear is rising by the second. I'm terrified. Not of Kashton, but the possibility that he won't love me after this. What if he tosses me to the side, and I'm all alone and broken? What if this does me in, steals what little sanity I'm hanging on to, and throws me over the edge? How many times can I go crazy before he no longer cares? How far can I go before I can't return to me? It took years to feel alive again. I may never be able to get back to this.

"I changed my mind," I rush out. How long will they keep me there? Another year? I won't survive again.

"It's too late for that, Eve."

"No." I shake my head, taking a step back. "We don't need the Lords to control what we do."

He says nothing.

"We can be together, Kash. It's what we've been doing." Fuck the Lords and their bullshit rules. "We don't need their permission," I snap.

"It'll all be over soon," he promises. It's the first time I don't believe him.

"I'm scared," I admit, wrapping my arms around myself. I don't like to be vulnerable, but I can't lie to him like he is to me.

"That's the point." He reaches into the pocket of his hoodie. "They want me to put you through hell. And I'm going to make sure I deliver."

A shiver runs down my spine at his confession. "I won't go back there." Tears sting my eyes.

Last time I was forced. No one would go willingly. They'd have to be insane.

"Sometimes you have to hurt the one you love. It's for your own good, angel. You'll see."

I spin around to run, but his hand slaps over my mouth from behind and yanks me back to the front of his body. I try to scream, but it's useless. I feel a poke in my neck and my eyes get heavy, my hands falling to my sides.

Please…no.

When my knees give out, he picks me up, and my eyes fall closed as he carries me back toward the motel.

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FIFTY-TWO



KASHTON

I pull up to Dollhouse and see Sin's car is already waiting on me. Getting out, I walk over to it.

"Got it." He opens his passenger door for me.

"Thanks." I reach in and grab the bag of items he collected for me.

He tosses his backpack over his shoulder. "I'm going to stay in case you need me."

"No. Go home to Elli and the babies."

"Bill is out of town this week. My mom is staying at our house to help."

I start to tell him I don't need him when he counters, "I'll stay out of the way. Just know I'm here if you need me." He closes his passenger door.

I guess it can't hurt to have an extra person here in case something goes wrong.

"When do you have to get started?"

I push back the sleeve of my hoodie to check my watch. "I've got twenty minutes."

"Is she okay?" Sin glances over at my car, but he can't see into it because my windows are blacked out.

I sigh. "For now. I gave her a sedative, but she'll be up soon."

"I'll carry your bag so you can get her." He takes it out of my hand and follows me over to my car.

Opening up the passenger car door, I pick her up and follow Sin up the steps and into Dollhouse. The house has a haunting feeling to it. I always thought Carnage was cold, but it has nothing on this place.

"Right on time." A Lord enters the grand foyer, checking his watch. "I was worried you wouldn't show."

I look over at Sin, and his jaw sharpens before he looks away from the Lord, cursing under his breath.

"Why the fuck are you here?" I snap as Eve moans in my arms. She's going to wake up any second.

The Lord removes his suit jacket and folds it over the chair to the right. "Same as you. Got a text with instructions."

"Why the fuck would they send you?" Sin growls. Obviously as surprised as I am to see him here.

Bill drops his eyes to Eve in my arms. "To make sure Kashton gets the job done."

EVERETT

Thunk… Thunk…

I feel drunk. Like I'm walking through a fog on a gravel road in heels. Everything is unstable and I can't see shit.

Thunk… Thunk…

There's this noise in the back of my throbbing head. Repeating over and over.

I open my heavy eyes, and I see one dimly lit light after the other above me pass by.

My arms are above my head and my back feels like nails are dragging down my skin. It burns.

Thunk… Thunk…

What is that sound?

I blink, trying to clear my vision, and another light passes. It feels like I'm lying on one of those moving sidewalks in slow motion.

Thunk… Thunk…

As my vision begins to clear like fog fading away, I start to get my senses back. I realize the cold nails under my back is really a concrete floor and the reason it feels like it's scratching me is because I'm moving.

Lifting my head, I see the back of Kashton. His white T-shirt strains against his flexing muscles. He's got a hat on backward and a piece of rope over his left shoulder. It's tied around my ankles, and he's using it to drag me down a hallway.

I try to sit, but I don't have the use of my arms yet.

Thunk… Thunk…

Suddenly, the sound makes sense. It's his boots on the concrete floor. Slow and steady. He's in no rush.

"Ka-sh?" My voice cracks, and I'm not sure he heard me.

My head falls to the floor, unable to hold it up any longer, and my scalp stings from him dragging me, the motion pulling my hair. That explains the headache. I look around aimlessly, and something catches my attention. Red bulbs above doors as we pass.

We're at Dollhouse. My heart leaps in my chest at the thought of being back here.

All of a sudden, the memories rush back. Us at the motel, him telling me to run, him catching me. He drugged me and brought me here.

"I'm going to break you, Eve."

Panic grips my chest and my fight or flight kicks in. I use what strength I have and roll over onto my stomach, and my hands try to grab a hold of anything to stop him.

No. No. I can't do this. I can't be here.

"Good morning, Eve," comes his voice echoing off the walls.

Morning? It was dark in the woods. How long have I been out?

"Kashton. Please don't…" My throat tightens, thinking of what he could do to me. "I don't want to be here. Take me home. Please…" I beg him as he continues to drag me down the hallway.

Funny, I wanted to leave Carnage, and now it's the only place I want to be. I try to kick my tied feet and twist my body to slow him down, but it doesn't even seem to bother him. My hands reach out to grab a hold of a doorframe, but it's too far away.

"Sorry, angel. We can't leave until you've proven to be a good whore."

My breath gets caught in my lungs at his words, and I slap my hands on the concrete to try and stop him once more. My fingers burn and my nails break as they drag along the cold floor.

He gives the rope one hard pull, yanking me forward, and we come to a stop. I try to crawl away, but his weight is on top of me.

"Kashton. Stop," I scream, tears filling my eyes. "Please…don't do this."

He grabs my arms and yanks them behind my back, tying my wrists together with rope. Then he flips me onto my back.

I arch my neck and scream, hoping someone will hear me. Anyone. But I've been here before, and there's no one to save me.

He slaps his hand over my mouth, silencing me, and forces my head down. His free hand gently pushes my wild hair off my face. "It's okay, Eve. You've been a doll before. I'm going to make sure you enjoy it just as much as you did last time."

Tears blur my vision. He's so cold. Heartless. This isn't the Kashton I've fallen in love with. How can he switch it up like that? How could I have been so stupid to think he could ever love me?

Removing his hand from my face, he pulls another piece of rope out of his hoodie and starts to wrap it around my neck.

"What are you doing?" I ask, panicking. "Stop." I try to pull away, but it's no use. I scream in frustration, and angry tears pour from my eyes.

Pulling, he yanks me to standing by the rope wrapped around my neck, momentarily cutting off my air. He ushers me forward on my shaking legs and I stumble into his body since my arms are tied behind my back. Bringing me to a stop in the center of the room, he tosses the excess rope from around my neck up above our heads and over a pipe that runs from one wall to the other. Then he walks behind me, tying it off at the back of my neck.

"Kashton." My body trembles and I try to swallow. It's choking me.

"Remove her heels," he orders.

He stripped me naked but dressed me in heels? Why? I try to spin around to see who the fuck he's talking to, but the rope doesn't allow it.

The rope around my ankles is cut and then someone grabs my leg, bends it at the knee, and removes my heel before it's dropped.

My panic rises when I'm forced to stand on my tiptoes. The same is done to the other. I cry out when the rope tightens, forcing me to tilt my head to the side as it rubs against my neck and the side of my cheek, pulling on my sensitive skin.

He places both hands on my face, forcing me to meet his stare. "You love it when I play with you."

"N-oo," I choke out the single word. "Please…I'm begging you." I've watched so many Lords beg for their lives during a confessional or offering, yet I never understood it until now. When you have nothing left other than your voice, you use it.

His once pretty blue eyes are dead. Now replaced with nothing more than soulless black holes. I've seen this before. Here at Dollhouse. There's an evil that lives here and takes over your soul. No one can escape it. "It's okay, Eve. Enjoy it. Think of it as my wedding gift to you."

I shake my head, and the rope tears at my skin. It's itchy, and the fact that I can't use my hands because they're tied behind my back makes it harder to stand.

He steps away, letting go of me, and removes a Sharpie from his hoodie. He writes on my chest and thighs before walking behind me to write on my ass.

Then he gives me his back while walking over to a chair that is a few feet from me. There's a box on top of it. He pulls out a rag that seems to be soaked in something because he wrings it out over the concrete and the contents splash up onto my trembling legs.

Returning to me, he shoves the cloth between my lips, and a sour taste fills my mouth.

"Swallow it," he demands, and there's nothing else I can do.

I blink rapidly, swallowing, and it makes me choke. I try to open my mouth wider to breathe around the rag. He gives me a second and then shoves the loose ends back in.

"Good girl," he praises me before ripping clear tape off a roll. He wraps it around my head, securing the soaked rag in my mouth.

He then writes something on it too. He tosses the Sharpie across the room, grips my tear-streaked face, and forces my head back.

"Your thighs say *free use*, your chest says *Kashton's whore,* and your ass says *rape me*. The tape on your mouth says *Kashton's dolly*."

I sob into the rag, trying to get my balance. My legs are already burning and cramping from having to stretch.

"The Lords want me to prove you're useless, Eve." His cold eyes glare into mine. "So I'm letting Lords fuck you. Their cum will leak from your cunt. Run down your pretty legs." His free hand drops between my thighs, and he runs his fingers over my pussy. I try to close them, but I'm forced to stand on my tiptoes.

He gives me a smile that makes my heart skip a beat with fear. "You're wet, angel. See? It won't be that hard for you after all."

I shake my head, trying to deny it. I'm not wet. This isn't a game we're playing. Doesn't he understand that no one leaves here? Not as the same person they arrived as anyway.

"One more thing." He shoves my head back, letting go and stepping away. He picks up the box that sits on the chair and brings it over to me.

"Each Lord gets a souvenir." He holds up a razor blade in front of my face and my wide eyes go to his. "They're going to cut you. A tally for each cock that fucks you."

I scream into the gag and fight the ropes as fresh tears blur my vision. I'm desperate to get free, silently hoping he'll take pity on me and let me go.

"Line them up," he commands. Grabbing a chair, he spins it around backward and crosses his arms over the top of it, settling into the best seat in the house to watch me get raped.

I'm his offering. He wants something, and this is how the Lords are going to give it to him. All he has to do is let them have me.

But why would he want me after this? Why does he want me broken and used? I thought he loved me. He's supposed to protect me.

A set of rough hands touches my thighs, and I thrash in my restraints. The rope cuts off my air momentarily as my nose runs and my heart thunders so hard in my chest, I fear I'll have a heart attack.

The blood rushes in my ears, and I begin to sob when I realize my ankles are kicked apart, forcing me to arch my neck back in order to get just a little air to breathe.

Death is the only option at this point. I can only hope that he kills me afterward.

"Everett?" A hand touches my face, and I flinch at the tender contact. "Look at me, Eve."

I open my swollen eyes to see Kashton standing in front of me.

"Welcome back, angel," he says, giving me a smile. It's as cold as I feel. Pulling his hand back, I see it's bloody. "You did so good for me. I knew you would."

I try to speak, but I can't. The gag still fills my mouth; the tape remains wrapped around my throbbing head.

I'm still standing in the center of the room on my tiptoes with the rope around my neck and my arms tied behind my back.

I wish I were dead.

"Do you want to see?" That fucking evil smile is still on his face. "Let me show you." Walking away, he comes back with a full-length mirror and holds it up in front of me.

Vomit rises at what I see. I'm bleeding all over. Cum mixed with blood runs down my shaking legs. The words written on me in Sharpie are front and center. Gashes so deep that parts of my skin hang. The only good thing is I can't feel it. Maybe I've lost too much blood.

My bare feet slide in the puddle underneath me.

I look away, choosing the ceiling instead, but a hand grips my hair, forcing my head back to look, so I close my eyes as my shoulders shake.

Disgust washes over me, and I hate myself. No one can love this. I told myself we'd get to be together forever if I did this. It was a lie. He tricked me. It's for his own personal gain. But one day, his time will come. And when I get my chance, I'll fucking make him choke on the skin I cut from his body.

A hand slaps my wet cheek, and my eyes spring open. "Look at yourself, angel," he growls.

"Fuck you," I scream into the gag, and he laughs at me.

"The Lords allowed you to watch them cut their own for years, Eve, and you thought they wouldn't do the same to you?"

I see the irony. I just don't care. I didn't choose this life, and now more than ever I feel like a failure for not succeeding at ending it all those years ago. Two chances and I failed both times.

"Eve," he barks, slapping my face, and I narrow my watery eyes on his. "Do you really think you're special? That they'd spare you?" Kashton shakes his head. "You're a useless woman, Eve. There's nothing special about that."

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FIFTY-THREE



EVERETT

I feel drowsy. High on drugs. The kind they fed me at Dollhouse.

Everything hurts and my skin itches. To the point it burns. It's the cuts. The feeling has returned. I liked it better when I was numb.

I groan, hoping the drugs take me under once again. I can't handle any more of this. Maybe someone will cut me deep enough that I'll bleed to death. That's the thing about the Lords; they know enough about the body to hurt you but keep you alive.

"Eve?"

I hear Kashton's voice. The soft and sweet one that I loved so much. It's a trap. My mind is playing tricks on me.

"Eve, wake up."

No. I want to stay here. In this drug-induced high where he loves me. Where he didn't turn my body over in hopes of getting something he wants.

"Come on, Eve. Open your eyes. Look at me." He sounds desperate. Scared, almost. It's just another lie. A way to humiliate me.

"Please…no." My voice cracks. At least the damn rag is gone. Now I can breathe a little easier.

"You're okay. I'm right here with you."

I hate you, I want to say, but the words don't come out because it's not him I really hate. It's me. He just showed me who he really is—like every other man in my life. I was the dumb one to believe he would be any different.

A hand touches my face, and my eyes open. It takes a second for them to focus, but when they do, I see his face inches from mine—

and he's smiling.

Panic bubbles up, and I scream. He pulls back, and I scramble away, falling onto the floor, and push my back against a wall. A sob of relief escapes now that I can fight back. I've got some kind of chance. The rope is gone, my arms are free, and I can speak. I'm weak, but I'll fight until there's nothing left. I just need a weapon. My hands frantically touch my neck to see that it's also free.

"Everett. It's me, Kash—"

"Stay away from me." I reach out and grab the nearest thing, which is a blanket, and cover my naked body up. It'll give me some time to look for something to use.

He holds both hands up and sighs. "I'm sorry, angel. I'm so sorry—"

"Fuck you!" I shout, pulling my knees to my chest. "I hate you." My lips start to tremble. "Stay away from me. Stay away from me, you sick bastard."

KASHTON

My chest aches seeing her like this. I've officially broken her. I got the girl, but at what cost? Her sanity? No. I don't accept that. She's stronger than that.

My love for her hasn't changed. If anything, I love her even more now. It'll just take some time to get her back. "It's over, Eve. It's over, and you did so good."

She whimpers, pulling her arms tighter around herself.

"I'm so proud of you." It's probably the first time she's ever heard those words in a nonsexual way.

Shaking her head, she cries softly, holding on to herself.

I look over her disheveled hair and tear-streaked face. She didn't look this defeated after Evan attacked her in her home. I've done this to her. She trusted me and I hurt her. With Evan, she knew what she was getting, knew she couldn't trust him. I'm supposed to be her protector, her Lord, and I had to treat her like every other bastard in her life. I have to prove to her that I'm not who she now sees me as. "Would you like a water?"

Eve nods and I back out of the room and down the hallway to grab one out of the fridge.

Walking back into the room, my jaw clenches when she trembles at the sight of me. I only have myself to blame. I sit down on the floor, keeping a safe distance away. I don't want to scare her more than she already is. "I'll roll it to you. Okay?"

She nods once more.

Rolling the bottle across the floor, it stops when it hits the wall she's got herself plastered to. Her watery eyes stare down at it for a second. "It's okay, Eve," I assure her.

"Did…did you drug it?" she asks and her teeth chatter.

I frown at her question. "No. It's brand new. The seal hasn't even been broken."

With shaking hands, she unscrews the lid and spills the water as she turns it up and drinks.

I sigh in relief. Baby steps. She gasps in a breath, pulling it away.

"Talk to me, Eve." I need to keep her mind here with me.

"Where are we?" she whispers, scanning the disheveled bed and door behind me. She's not familiar with this room.

"Blackout. We're in Tyson's apartment."

She frowns, not remembering leaving Dollhouse. She was unconscious when I carried her out of there.

"How…how long have we been here?"

"Two days. You needed time to recover."

She flinches at my words, and I fucking hate how she won't let me near her. I just want to pull her into my arms and hold her. Tell her how much I love her. She did it. She beat them. Just like I knew she would. I'm so fucking proud of her.

"Talk to me, Eve. How do you feel?" Silence isn't good for her. She'll fall back into her own mind, and that is a hell I need to keep her out of. I've never hated the Lords more than I do now. They knew she was doing better, had moved on, and they wanted to send her back. Trap her inside her own mind. It's the one thing we can't escape. I know. I've been there.

"I want you to leave," she whispers, unable to make eye contact.

Never. "I can't do that."

She sniffs and closes her eyes tightly. Still whispering, she says, "I thought you loved me."

My chest tightens, and I scoot closer to her. "I do, angel. I love you so much." I'm going to spend the rest of my life proving it to her.

She shakes her head, refusing to believe me. "You don't hurt someone you love."

Sometimes you have to hurt the one you love comes to mind. "I'll never hurt you again," I promise her.

"But you did…" Tears fall from her pretty eyes. "That's not love."

"It's not what you think."

Her glare snaps to mine and there's the glimpse of that fire that I fell in love with. A piece of the anger this gorgeous blonde showed me that night in the cemetery. I already knew then that I was going to marry her. Maybe she's not as far away as I thought.

"Not what I think?" she repeats softly. "You drugged me."

I didn't have a choice when I chased her in the woods outside of the motel. It was the only way I could get her to Dollhouse. "I didn't want to hurt you."

Her face tightens. "But you did." I can see her body trembling under the blanket. "You let them rape me." I run my hands through my hair at her words, wanting to hold her. "You let them cut me."

I look away, swallowing the knot in my throat at what she remembers. When my eyes meet hers once again, they're swimming in fresh tears. "Angel…"

"Don't call me that," she screams. Lowering her voice, she drops her gaze to the floor. "You stood there and watched while I begged them to kill me." She's trembling, pushed up against the wall, trying to make herself small. Needing to get as far away from me as possible.

I won't let her do this to herself. She didn't come this far to give up. My girl wants to fight.

I stand, and her eyes go wide with panic. "Nooo. Don't you dare. Stay away from me." She throws the water bottle at me, and I duck, hearing it hit the floor behind me.

Walking over to her, she begins to scream. I pull the blanket off her, and she tries to crawl away, but I grab her arm and yank her to her feet. She kicks and screams while I drag her to the bathroom. I shove the door closed with my boot so she can't get away.

I position myself behind her and grab a handful of her matted hair, forcing her to face the mirror. "Look at yourself," I command.

"No," she sobs, eyes tightly shut. "Just stop…please. Stop." Her body thrashes against mine as she shoves herself away from the counter.

"Open your eyes," I shout, needing a reaction from her. One that helps her see what I see.

Her eyes open, and she stops screaming when she looks at her reflection in front of us.

I let out a long breath and soften my voice. "Look at yourself, Eve. All of you."

"What?" She breathes. "I don't understand." Frantically groping at her naked body, she works to comprehend what she thinks she knows and what she sees. "You said we've only been here for two days."

"We have." I undo her tangled hair from my fist.

She turns to face me and looks over her shoulder at her back. "Where were we before we came here?"

"Dollhouse."

Her watery eyes glance up at me. "But you…" She looks down at her arms and hands. "You let them… I was bleeding."

"It was a hallucination, Eve."

She bows her head, and all you can hear is both of us trying to catch our breath. After a moment, she says, "No." Her eyes meet mine and fresh tears fill them. "No. It was real."

"It wasn't," I assure her.

"I don't understand." She wraps her arms around herself.

"I had to make you think it was real," I say honestly, and she sniffs. "I had to threaten you, chase you from the motel, sedate you in the woods. I had to plant doubt in your mind, Eve. I had to make you think I was going to hurt you, knowing that I was taking you to Dollhouse."

"What happened when we got there?"

Sin and I silently follow Bill through Dollhouse. He comes to a door and holds it open for us to enter.

Stepping inside, I take in the cold, sterile room. Reminds me of a hospital, but it's nothing like that. There's an elevated metal table in the center. Restraints hang over both sides from one end to the other.

It makes me wonder if she's been here before, in this very room, back when she was a doll. If so, what did they do to her?

"Place her on the table," Bill orders.

I lay her down, and she shifts onto her side, curling into a ball. I have to readjust her because it's not wide enough. She's going to roll right off the side. "Kashton?" she whispers, her voice rough with sleep.

"Strip her down first. Everything but her underwear and bra." Bill speaks as he keeps his back to me and Sin.

Sin steps back, and I remove her boots, skinny jeans, and T-shirt. Then I start with her shoulders while Sin does her ankles. We meet in the middle, and I tighten the last one around her waist.

Bill turns around and nods to the door. "You may leave."

"No." I shake my head. Is he crazy? "I'm staying."

"You're leaving." He looks at Easton as if he expects him to pull me out of here. Bill sighs when he sees Sin isn't on his side here. "The sooner we get started, the sooner you can take her home."

"What are you going to do to her?" I don't think Bill will kill her, but I also don't trust anyone with her other than myself right now.

"I've been instructed to administer a drug…" He trails off.

"You're going to make her hallucinate," Sin finishes, knowing exactly where he was going. "The mind is a powerful thing."

Bill nods. "Yes. And I can't do it with you in the room."

"Why the fuck not?" I snap.

She begins to pull on the restraints, her body gently rocking back and forth, straining against the worn-out leather.

"You're going to make it worse. Get the fuck out and let me do what they want before she wakes up."

I watch her lashes start to flutter, and with reluctance, I back out of the room. The moment we step out, Bill locks it.

My hand goes to the knob, panic rising. "Unlock the door." I bang on it, but he ignores me. "Bill. Open the fucking door."

I hear her cry out on the other side of the door.

"Come on." Sin grabs my arm and pulls me away. "There has to be a place where you can watch it."

I rush into the room next door and flip on the light to see it's an observation room. We have one at Carnage, and it makes me nauseous to think what they did to her in that room while others watched when she was here.

Bill fills a syringe and then walks over to her, administering the drug into her arm.

"I know it's not much, but at least when it's over, you can tell her it was only a hallucination." Sin speaks softly as he watches Eve. "I had to look my wife in the eye when they forced me to break her heart."

I don't have anything to say about that because I couldn't imagine having to make her think that she means nothing to me. But something tells me this won't be any easier on her. If we're lucky, it won't be me she sees in her hallucination. Eve knows I love her, right? I haven't given her any reason to see me as the bad guy. To make her think I'd cause her real harm. Except for in the woods. The Lords wanted her to hate me for forcing her hand in being here.

"Saint told me that you and Haidyn are fighting," Sin says while we wait for her to react to the drug.

I run a hand down my face. I was here at Dollhouse with my brothers when I was notified that Eve had left Carnage. Thankfully, they rushed back home while I went to the motel to get her. "Yeah."

"Over Eve?"

I nod.

He turns to face me. "She's yours, Kash. Sometimes you have to remind someone to stay away from what isn't theirs. I'd kill a brother over my wife. She will always come first."

Sin thinks Haidyn wants to take her away from me. In a way, he does. He wants her on prescription drugs. I've seen her self-medicate with alcohol. She doesn't need it. I'm what she needs. I can help her.

Sin thinks Haidyn wants her in a different way. He and the others don't know that Eve is his sister and that Haidyn is afraid of losing

her. That she will try to commit suicide again and succeed.

A silence falls over the room and Eve starts to move, but she's still pretty out of it.

"How was therapy?" he asks. I know what he's doing. Sin's trying to keep my thoughts off the woman that I'm about to hurt. "Did it help?"

I snort. "Nope. She freaked. Ran out of the building and then punched me." I smile. That's the Everett I fell in love with. She'll get back to that eventually. I'll make sure of it.

"What do you mean freaked?"

"She yelled at me. Was mad that I took her."

"Hold up." He frowns, turning to face me and I do the same. "Are you telling me she didn't want to go?"

"Well, I didn't really tell her she was going…"

"The fuck?" Sin snaps. "Are you kidding me?"

"You told me to take her," I argue.

"No. I said if Eve wanted to go."

I glance back at the observation window, and she's pulling on the restraints but still isn't fully awake yet.

"Christ, Kash." Sin gets my attention again.

"Elli goes," I argue defensively.

"That's not how things work. Elli was the one who came to me and said she wanted to go to therapy. She decides if I stay in the waiting room. She decides if I sit in on the session. And she decides if I just observe or if I get to participate. Elli controls the situation."

"I just wanted to help," I say on a sigh, crossing my arms over my chest. Eve is the type of woman who doesn't think she needs anyone else. So I tried to give her a little shove.

We fall silent once again. After what feels like hours, her body begins to shake. She arches her back and the words that come out of her mouth tear at my chest.

"Ka-sh?"

I'm right here, Eve. Right here*. I step closer to the window and place my hands on the glass.*

"Kashton. Please don't…" she begs.

My stomach drops at the sound of fear in her voice. I thought I was helping her.

"I don't want to be here. Just take me home. Please…?"

But I'm the one who's hurting her.

I take a step back and let myself lean against the bathroom wall. I'm exhausted. I haven't slept in days, too worried about my girl.

"Sin met us there. He brought a couple of things I thought I would need. I was instructed to put you in a room; you were given a drug that the Lords ordered you to have." It was hell listening to her scream, not knowing what she was experiencing but knowing that it was me she was picturing hurting her. She seemed awake, but she wasn't. Her eyes were open, and her body shook, and she begged me…fuck, she begged me so many times to stop hurting her. It was unlike anything I'd ever seen before.

I've watched men and women beg for their lives at Carnage, but I've never given a fuck about them. Their pleas fell on deaf ears. To know the one you love thinks you're hurting them is a different kind of hell.

Everett steps into me, and I keep my hands to myself. "So you didn't let them rape me?" Her watery eyes search mine, but they look hopeful. That just maybe I'm not the monster she saw me as.

"No." I hate that she could even think I'd let that happen. She sees me as a monster, otherwise she wouldn't have hallucinated it. Even if it is far back in her mind, it's still there. "I'd never let anyone touch you, let alone hurt you."

Her eyes drop to my shirt, and her soft cries fill the room before she pushes her body into mine.

I wrap my arms around her, and she breaks into a sob. "It felt…so real."

"I know." I kiss her hair, letting out a long breath. "I'm so sorry, Eve."

I've been there. I of all people know how real a hallucination can feel. I saw all my brothers and Ashtyn dead. I heard Ashtyn scream for me to save her and carried her body in my arms after I watched the Lord slit her throat while he was raping her. I felt my brothers' blood on my hands as they hung from the ceiling.

"You're okay." Eve tightens her hold on me. "I'll never hurt you." I'll kill myself before I ever let her think I'd do her any harm.

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FIFTY-FOUR



EVERETT

"W ake up, Eve."

My face is slapped, and I jolt awake. "Hmm?" I mumble into the gag.

Kashton bends down and picks up a bloody razor blade and holds it in front of my heavy eyes. "Hold still. It would be a shame to cut this pretty face." He chuckles. "It was the only rule I had for the Lords."

I stiffen when he grabs the top piece of the tape and slowly starts to run the razor blade down it, cutting it away. He rips the last piece off and removes the gag.

My head hangs forward, and I spit and cough, trying to get the nasty sour taste out of my mouth.

"So pretty." He places his hands on either side of my face and forces my head back so I have to look up at him.

"Fuck you." I spit in his face. He takes his right hand and slaps me hard while his left hand holds it in place. I taste blood, and I spit that on him too. "Fucking kill me, you bastard," I shout, fisting my hands behind my back.

He shakes his head, making a tsking *sound. "I watched the tape of you here, Eve. How much you enjoyed it. The cum that dripped from your overused cunt. I know it's been a while, but I think I can get you back to that doll who begged to be played with."*

His thumb runs over my lips, and he leans down, pressing his mouth to mine. I sink my teeth into his lip, biting until I taste his blood this time. We'll both bleed.

Kashton pulls back with a growl and slaps me across the face once more.

I want to cry, but the force has the rope pulling tight on my neck, and it takes my breath away.

"I'm doing this for us." He huffs. "Ungrateful bitch."

I give a manic laugh, sucking in a breath that burns my lungs, staring up at the ceiling. My vision is cloudy, and my head is pounding. How long have I been here? What do I have to do to pass? Just survive? I'm not sure that's possible.

"I'll prove to you that you enjoyed it." I lower my head to watch him grab a syringe out of his pocket.

My heart shatters because I know what it is. I don't stand a chance. All Lords play dirty, and he's no different.

He stabs me in the arm and plunges the drugs into me. Then he steps back and tosses the syringe to the side. "Now let's hear you count each time you come on their cocks."

I sit straight up, gasping for air. I blink rapidly, and when my vision comes into focus, I see we're still in the apartment above Blackout.

Kashton is sound asleep next to me.

Taking in a shaky breath, I run my hands through my tangled hair to push it off my face.

It was a hallucination, Eve, Kash had told me.

Even in my dreams, I can't escape something that didn't happen. It wasn't real. But I've never felt anything more real in my life. I remember girls having hallucinations at Dollhouse. They looked like they had been possessed by demons, the way their bodies twisted and turned. The screams that came out of their mouths. It was horrific and so painful to watch.

Getting out of bed, I make my way to the bathroom and flip the soft light on. I go to the his-and-hers sinks and turn on one of the faucets, splashing cold water on my face. I do it again and then start digging through cabinets for something to help relieve this pounding headache. Everything fucking aches. Finding some Advil, I pop two in my mouth, cup the water, and take a sip. I'm so thirsty.

Turning it off, some of Kashton's things catch my eye. He's got his wallet, a money clip filled with hundreds, and his pocketknife on the counter.

I take a quick look into the bedroom, and he's still asleep—head on the pillow, facing away from me, arms underneath it, and the covers up to his shoulders. Licking my lips, I pick up the knife and hold the cold metal in my hand. Why didn't I kill myself in my hallucination?

I could have. There was a rope wrapped around my neck. I could have lifted my legs at any time and hung myself. It was a sign, right? Why didn't I think of it? Would that have brought me out of my hallucination, or would it have given Kashton a reason to punish me? Probably would have just been another reason to torture me. I won't ever know because none of it existed.

I don't think anyone is capable of pulling themselves out of a hallucination. I'm pretty sure you have to ride it out. Especially if you're given drugs to induce it.

"Angel?"

I gasp and drop the pocketknife, startled by the sound of Kashton's voice. He stands in the bathroom, dressed in nothing but his black boxer briefs. He hasn't touched me sexually. I passed out in his arms a few hours ago after he picked me up off the bathroom floor.

Why would he want to touch me? I screamed for him to get away from me. I told him I hated him. He probably hates me now. "I'm sorry."

"It's okay." He steps in, and I take a matching step back. Bending down, he picks up the knife and puts it in a drawer. "What are you doing awake?" he asks through a yawn.

I bite my lip and bow my head, too ashamed to tell him what he did to me while at Dollhouse. I should never have believed he'd be that way. That he would hurt me. He's been the best thing to happen in my life. The Lords want to ruin it. It's working.

"Eve, I want you to talk to me. Tell me what I can do to make it better."

I run a hand through my hair, avoiding eye contact. "I'm fine." It's the same lie I always seem to be telling him. If he knew how fucked-up my head was, he'd run the other direction.

"No, you're not." He steps into me, and I lean into him.

"It was just a bad dream." Another lie.

Without another question, he picks me up and carries me back to bed. My mind tells me it's because he wants me far away from the knife he put in the drawer. My suspicion is confirmed when he pulls the bathroom door closed behind us.

He thinks I'm suicidal.

I cuddle up to his body and he sighs, relaxing into the mattress. We lie in silence for a few seconds when I speak. "Why are we here?"

"It was the closest to Dollhouse," he answers softly. "I didn't want you at Carnage, and my house is on the other side of town."

Why doesn't he want me to return to Carnage? Is Haidyn mad at me? Probably. "Did I pass?" I try to lighten the mood. I'm embarrassed that I freaked out when I woke up. That I accused him of hurting me in such a way. That I looked as weak as I was for so many years.

Kashton gives a soft chuckle. "You're perfect." He kisses my forehead.

"Can we go to my house tomorrow?" I ask through a yawn. Hopefully, I can get some sleep. My body is so tired, but my mind is running.

"No," he answers, and I hold in a sigh. "Evan is still on the run, and that's the first place he's going to go looking for you. But we can go to mine."

I'll take that offer.

"Get some rest, angel."

A part of me wants sex right now. Wants him to throw me onto my stomach, pin my arms behind my back and force my legs open so he can fuck me until I pass out. It would probably help me sleep better. I've avoided it for so long, but now that I know what it can feel like to really be wanted, I crave it more now than I did then, when I was on drugs.

Maybe it's the reassurance I need. That he still finds me sexually attractive. As fucked up as it sounds, no matter what I went through at Dollhouse, the training never stopped. It was constant. Neither my body nor my mind ever had a break.

I run my hand over his chest, letting my nails softly graze his skin. His muscles flex as I trail a path over his chiseled stomach.

He wraps his hand around my wrist before I can slide it into his boxer briefs. "Eve," he warns.

"I want you to fuck me," I admit, wanting him to know my intentions. I'm not going to be the weak woman I was a week ago; the one who was kneeling in the shower, vomiting. It took me years to find myself after Bill saved me from Dollhouse. I won't allow them to take that much of my life this time.

He sighs. "You need to rest."

"For how long?" Might as well give me a timeline.

"As long as you need."

"And who decides that?"

"Me."

I huff. "What if I say I'm ready now?"

"You can say whatever you want, doesn't mean I'm going to believe you."

I get a pain in my chest at his choice of words. I know he meant it sexually, but I feel like he means I can say I'm not suicidal but that doesn't mean he believes me.

Knowing I'm not going to win, I drop it. The fact is, he doesn't want me.

Pulling away, I roll over, letting out a huff of annoyance. He pulls my back into his front, snuggling into me, and I immediately soften against him. His body is so warm, and I hate how much I've grown accustomed to him.

He kisses my hair. "I don't want to scare you, Eve."

I understand where he's coming from. This is my fault. My mental breakdowns have led him to believe that I'm unstable. I don't have an argument to change his mind. And I can't deny that he's right.

KASHTON

"Open the fucking door," I bark at Bill while my hand jiggles the doorknob to the room.

I hear the lock click, and I shove it open, barging inside. "Eve?" I rush over to her. "Eve, look at me," I urge her, running my hands over her face.

She finally stopped screaming a few minutes ago and her body just went slack. Bill said it was over, and I couldn't get to her fast

enough. "Why isn't she awake?" I snap at him.

"She needs time, Kash," Bill answers, unbuckling her restraints. "Take her home. Let her rest. The drugs take a lot out of you. Make her drink. A lot. The more fluids she has, the better."

I pick her up off the table, and she lies limp in my arms. She feels feverishly warm and sweaty, but her breathing has finally evened out. I thought she was going to give herself a heart attack by how worked up she was.

Sin picks up my bag and her clothes, following me out of the room to our cars parked outside. He opens the passenger door for me, and I place her in the seat. Her head rolls to one side, and I reach up, removing my hoodie and shoving it next to her head to lie on and then recline her seat. Closing the door, I remove my cell from my pocket and call up a friend.

"Hey, man. What's—"

"I need to crash at your apartment," I rush out, interrupting him. "And you can't tell anyone I'm there."

"Of course," Tyson answers.

"On my way." I immediately go to my contacts and call up the next.

"Kash?" he answers on the first ring.

"I need you to meet me at Blackout. Eve needs an IV." When Bill says she needed fluids, I knew what to do. Gavin can give it to her. She'll be opening those beautiful eyes and looking at me in no time.

"I'll be there in twenty."

I open my eyes to the sound of the club below us. It's dark in the room other than the glow from the TV. Lifting my head, I blink a few times until my vision clears and see that Eve is still in my arms, and she's sound asleep, softly snoring.

Pulling my arm out from underneath her, I roll onto my back. Fuck, I'm sweating. Her body puts off so much heat when she sleeps. I get out of bed, dressed in nothing but my boxer briefs, and make my way to the bathroom to take a piss.

After I'm done, I wash my hands and walk back through the bedroom, out the door, and to the hallway. I need a cigarette. Making my way to the kitchen, I grab my bag and unzip the front pocket

and then step out on the balcony to light one up with my cell in hand.

I've had it turned off since I got the text about Dollhouse. Sin keeps me updated on Carnage and tells me that my brothers are going mad wondering where I am. Especially since Haidyn knows I'm with Eve.

He thinks I'm hiding her from him. I am, but that's beside the point. Once she's my Lady, he can't do shit to her. I'll have control. Physically, mentally, medically. Until the day I die. Then it's up to whoever I choose to leave as her guardian. I would have chosen Haidyn before. Now I'm not so sure.

I bring the cigarette to my lips, thinking about what she said to me before she fell asleep. She wanted me to fuck her. The sad part is I wanted to, but I'm afraid it's too soon and I'll scare her. I never want to see her shaking while she cowers on the floor because she thinks I'm going to hurt her. Not like that.

"Kash?"

I turn to see her standing in the living room, eyes heavy and the bedsheet wrapped around herself. I put out my cigarette and step inside. "I'm sorry I woke you."

"You didn't." She yawns and opens the sheet to let me in, and my eyes fall over her naked body. She has some bruising where the restraints held her down while she fought, but it's not bad. Nothing that won't be gone in a few more days. Gavin checked her thigh and changed her dressing when he stopped by to give her the IV. He said it was healing nicely. "The music downstairs is loud."

"Come on. I'll tuck you back in."

She pulls away, taking a step back, and I pause, watching the way her gaze drops to the floor.

This is why I didn't fuck her. She's not ready. I want her to be feisty and throwing punches at my face, not cowering at the sight of me.

Swallowing, she glances up at me through her lashes, and I search her face to try and read her thoughts, but there's nothing there. Just pretty green nothing—blankness.

"Talk to me, angel."

"Do you really want to marry me?"

Without a doubt. “I want to spend the rest of my life with you.”

“What if I told you that you don’t know everything about me?”

“I’d tell you I’m here to listen whenever you’re ready to share.” I don’t think she knows everything about herself. The fact that she couldn’t remember that Evan raped her told me what I need to know. She’s suppressed so much of her past, there’s no telling what happened to her.

“I…” She looks away and takes in a shaky breath. “I can’t give you kids.”

I frown, confused, because she knows that I’m aware of this. She told me and a room full of Lords at Blackout.

“I was raped and got pregnant,” she whispers, and my stomach knots at her confession.

Fuck. Eve doesn’t know that I’m aware of what the Spade brothers did to her. What my father did to her.

“You know my biological father is Garrett Reeves, but what you don’t know is that he raped me.” Wrapping the sheet tighter around herself, she continues. “He and all of the Spade brothers’ fathers raped me.”

I swallow the lump in my throat for the horror she’s been through and the fact that she’s finally opening up to me.

“They tried to get me pregnant for years,” she sniffs, and I want to wrap my arms around her, but I cross them over my chest and stay where I’m at. “When I finally did…my father told me that if it was a girl…he’d set it on fire,” Eve chokes out. “But then he changed his mind and said that he hoped I had a girl so she could be useful—give him what I couldn’t. He was going to rape her…” Placing her hand over her mouth, she begins to sob. “But a boy would give him another chance. He’d force him to fuck me…maybe he’d have better luck…”

I can’t hold back. I rush to her and wrap her trembling body in my arms. “I’m so sorry, Eve.” But it won’t matter. They’re just words. They can’t change her past or her feelings.

She pulls away, and I allow it, brushing some wild strands of blond hair from her tear-streaked face. “My father had a man come and pick me up…take me somewhere…”

"To where?" I wonder. I already know the piece of shit is dead.

She shakes her head and sniffs. "I didn't know who he was or where he was taking me, but I saw an opportunity." Her red-rimmed eyes find mine. "I had to do it." She swallows. "I couldn't…wouldn't let the Lords ruin another innocent life. I had to protect my baby."

"I know, Eve," I assure her. I'd never judge her for her past.

"I saw a chance at finally ending it all." She closes her eyes tightly before opening them. "So I forced us to crash." She blinks and fresh tears fall from her swollen eyes. "I would go with my baby. If there was an afterlife, we'd go together. I couldn't imagine—" She licks her lips nervously. "But I lived." Her eyes meet mine and they plead for me to understand why she chose to do what she did. "Why?" Her voice cracks.

"Eve—"

"We were supposed to die together." Her lips tremble. "I was supposed to protect my child." She sobs. "And I knew I couldn't do that—"

Wrapping my arms around her once again, I place my chin on the top of her head.

"I…lived." The regret that she survived is evident in her voice.

"Listen to me, Eve." I pull back and cup her tear-streaked face in both of my tatted hands. "Quit blaming yourself. It wasn't your fault. None of it." My girl was trapped. A kid imprisoned in a hell who was used only to breed.

Pushing me away, she steps back. "Don't you see the problem?" she growls.

I frown, confused by her change of tone. "Eve…"

"I can't give you children," she shouts.

My frown deepens, and she snorts, rolling her watery eyes.

"I didn't know how to feel after I found out I survived. We were both supposed to die. We were supposed to be together in another universe where no one could hurt us. Where parents love and protect their children. I wanted that. A different life. A dad and mom who loved me."

"I love you," I tell her. "You're going to be my wife. I'm going to vow to take care of you, to love you and to protect you. I promise

you that no one will ever touch you again." She looks away from me. "Kids don't matter to me. You matter to me." She frowns as if that's a concept she can't accept. "You asked me if I had a life, and I said I was looking at it. *You* are what I'm looking at, angel. You're who I see when I close my eyes at night, and you will be the last person I see before I leave this world. I'm going to spend every day I have left devoting my life to you because you are the one I want."

"You still don't get it," she whispers, shaking her head.

"Explain it to me. Tell me what you want me to do, and I'll do it." It's not the first time I've told her that. All I need is for her to tell me how I can make it better.

"I had to learn to be okay with what I did. Because I survived, I had to live with my choices. My mistakes. But you came along and changed that."

She's right. I didn't understand what she was trying to tell me, but now I do. She wants to give me a family. She's tried to commit suicide twice that I know of, and now she wants to live. I've forced myself into her life and have her hating herself for the choices she made. "What do you want, Eve?" I ask her. Wanting to hear the words. Pushing her a little more.

"I want to give you a family," she whispers, as if ashamed to admit that. "I want babies. I want baseball practice at five and cheerleading at six. I want a messy home and happy kids. I want you to call in sick on a random Monday because you want to take our family to an overpacked water park." She gives a small smile, picturing that thought before lowering her voice. "I want a second chance. I want to break the cycle."

"Then that's what we'll do."

Her face falls and she sighs. "That's impossible, Kash."

"We'll adopt," I tell her. "As many kids as you want. Hell, we can have our own baseball team if you'd like."

She laughs like I'm joking, and it's the most beautiful sound I've ever heard. She's already getting back to herself.

"I'm serious, Eve. Anything you want. I'll give it to you." I will make it happen.

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FIFTY-FIVE



EVERETT

I lie awake in bed above Blackout, unable to sleep. I think those two days that I was out have fucked with my sleep schedule. Or it could be because I haven't had a single sip of alcohol.

I tried to push him away. I thought if I trauma dumped all my problems on him, he'd run away. Yet here we are, in bed, and he's still snuggling up to my back.

But no sex.

I can't pretend to understand how he must feel. My father and half brother both raped me. Along with his father. That takes time to process. And when he wakes up, he might change his mind and realize I'm not worth it.

Kashton shifts and lets out a moan that makes my thighs clench. Fuck, I'm so horny.

His cock is right at my ass, and I wish he'd take advantage of me. But it just proves that Kashton is a good guy. He's nothing like our fathers.

I know about his mother committing suicide and how Isabella punished him when she was training them. I know he has abandonment issues and probably feels alone right now because his brothers have moved on. I'll be everything he needs.

I'm going to be his Lady, take his last name, and make sure he knows he always has me. No matter what, because that's what a Lady does. I owe him that. He deserves happiness.

If he wants me to wait on him at home, kneeling on the floor when he walks through the front door, then that's what I'll do.

A Lady serves her Lord. No matter what.

I just wish I could give him children. I've never felt like less of a woman than I do now. I understand it's my fault. I chose to do what I did, and I must pay the consequences. I just wish I had met him sooner. That things were different.

"Eve," he says roughly in my ear, "why are you still awake?"

I don't say anything and instead close my eyes.

"I can feel your heart racing, angel," he states, and I sigh. His hand travels from my waist up over my chest and to my neck. He wraps his fingers around my throat, and I moan, pushing my ass into his cock. "I'm not going to fuck you."

"Why not?" I whimper, reaching back behind me, between our bodies to find his pierced dick. "You're hard." At least I know his body still wants me.

"And I bet you're wet."

I roll my eyes, push him away, and turn over to face him. His eyes are open, but he looks tired. I feel bad for him. I just want to make him feel good, and the only way I know how is with my body.

Is this what a healthy relationship looks like? When a man doesn't want to have sex with you because he wants to let your body rest? I doubt that's really the reason why. I want him to use me. "Play with me," I tell him.

His eyes search mine before they drop to my neck and he runs his tatted knuckles down over my breast. Leaning in, I lick my lips before his touch mine.

I push against him, and he rolls onto his back, his hands gripping my ass, taking me with him, and I straddle his hips, grinding against his hard cock.

Moaning into his mouth, I lift up and reach between us to pull his dick out. Fuck, I need him. "Please?" I beg, pulling away to suck in a ragged breath.

"Get up." He taps my thigh, and I giggle, falling off him onto my back.

Kashton gets out of bed and exits the room. He returns seconds later with his bag. He sets it on the end of the bed and unzips it before pulling out a few things.

I lie down and swallow, telling myself I'm not going to panic. That it's going to be okay. That this is my future husband. That I'm not at Dollhouse. Only he touches me now.

"On your stomach," he orders. "Hands behind your back."

I roll over and throw the pillow onto the floor so my head can lie flat and do as he says. The bed dips when he crawls onto it, straddling my ass. He crosses my wrists and then wraps something rough around them. If I had to guess, I'd say rope.

Then he gets up and pushes me onto my back. He rips off a single piece of tape, and I close my mouth, swallowing before he gently places it over my lips. His tatted fingers softly press against my mouth, and I moan, arching my hips for him.

"Hard to beg when you can't talk," he states, and I whimper, trying to adjust my tied hands behind my back. Then he rolls me onto my stomach once more.

He picks my legs up off the bed and wraps more rope around them, and I try to pull my legs up under me so I can put my pussy and ass in the air, but I can't.

Mumbled words are all that come from my taped lips when I try to ask what he did. He falls down beside me, and I lift my head to look over at him as he snuggles under the covers.

His eyes roam my face, and his knuckles brush the hair off my cheeks. I wiggle, trying to move, and he smiles.

"I've got your legs tied to the footboard, angel. Your arms behind your back and your mouth taped. You're going to lie here with me until morning."

My eyes widen and I start to thrash beside him. What? No.

"Hey, calm down, Eve. You'll hurt yourself." He sits up, grabs the covers, and pulls them up over my body before he pulls me into him. Kashton kisses my forehead. "I told you I'm not going to fuck you tonight, Eve, and I meant that. Be a good girl and get some rest for me, and I'll fuck you tomorrow."

KASHTON

She struggles for no more than five minutes before her body relaxes into mine and her eyes close. The poor thing is exhausted. She just needed to feel safe. To know that I had her.

I've learned that my girl likes being bound. Even if I'm not fucking her. She told me to play with her. This is part of foreplay with her. She likes the unknown. The excitement. What am I going to do next?

I shouldn't be surprised that she wants me to fuck her this quickly. She needs reassurance that I want her physically. That after what she told me, I'm not disgusted by her.

Her cell lights up on the nightstand, and I pick it up to see it's **Fuckface** calling. I take a second to decide if I want to answer it. I'm sure Adam wants to give her a job, and I'm going to tell him hell fucking no.

She's quitting. No more putting her life in danger. The woman seems to be enough danger to herself. Getting her away from Adam will hopefully help some, and that's also because the Lords will one day find out that he's not dead and will go after him. It's only a matter of time.

Deciding to answer, I put her phone to my ear. "Hello?" I speak softly to not wake her.

"Your cell is off," he barks.

So this call is for me. "Yeah," I say, getting out of bed and making sure she's covered. "Need something?"

He sighs. "We got another video."

I tense, watching her sleep. Walking out of the bedroom, I grab my bag, needing a cigarette, and move to stand in the hallway. "Who got another video?"

"Bill and me, so I'm assuming that you guys received it as well."

I enter the living room and drop it on the coffee table and run a hand through my hair.

"I'm guessing it's Evan sending them to us. He's the only one who could be accessing the tapes right now. Or knows where they're at."

Has Adam not spoken to Bill? "He has them," I say.

"How do you know for sure?" he asks slowly.

"He attacked Eve last week in her house after we met up with you at Dollhouse. I've got cameras at her place, and we watched it. He told her—"

"Wait a second," he interrupts me. "What do you mean he attacked her? Last week? Why the fuck hasn't anyone told me?"

Wonder why Bill is also keeping secrets from him? "I'm the only one who has your number," I snap. "And I've been busy."

"Doing what? Fucking Eve?"

My teeth grind. I hate that he's fucked her, but I won't let him talk about her like that. "No. She did her assignment for her initiation."

He sighs heavily. "How did she do?"

I pause. Why hasn't Bill told him this? Aren't they best buds now? "She passed" is all he's getting from me.

I return to the bedroom to check on her, and she hasn't moved. "I have my cell with me, but I'm keeping it off." She gets my attention when she moans, rocking her hips back and forth. I lower my voice, stepping back into the hallway. "Send it to her phone. I'll delete it afterward."

"Okay."

I rub the back of my neck. "Adam?"

"Yeah?"

"What kind of video is this?" I need to know what I'm going to see.

He's quiet for a moment before he speaks softly. "She's being punished."

I duck my head, rubbing my temples at how or why she would be punished. But the truth is they don't need a reason. It gets them views. Brings in money. There are a lot of sick bastards out there who live to see others suffer.

The phone vibrates in my hand at the incoming message. "I got it. I'll talk to you soon." I hang up without another word.

Checking on her again, I turn up the volume just a little on the TV in the bedroom before making my way to the living room. Sitting down on the couch, I open the message and play the video.

It's another concrete room, and you can hear screams coming from the other side of the door. My chest tightens at the sound. It's Eve. I'd recognize it anywhere.

The door is ripped open, and Eve is pushed inside. She's wearing a black latex suit. The only parts of her body that you can see are her bare feet and hands, and from her neck up.

Two men enter behind her, guarding the door. Both are dressed in all black, complete with guns strapped to their thighs and handcuffs on their belts.

Eve is on the floor. No longer screaming but now groaning in pain from the fall.

"What now?" Evan barks, entering the room and slamming the door behind him. He locks all four inside the room.

"Suicide attempt, sir. Tried to hang herself," the one on the right states.

Fuck, Eve.

"Goddammit," he hisses. "Where the fuck did she get something to hang herself?"

"She was cold…"

"So you gave her a blanket?" Evan snaps.

"A sheet, sir." One huffs, offended that they'd allow her such luxury. "There were only a few scraps of one. We found it…"

"Found it what?" Evan demands, placing his hands on his hips, glaring at them.

"Amusing," the other one finishes, clearing his throat.

Evan's eyes narrow on them. "After I'm done with her, you two will meet me in my office." It's not a suggestion.

"Yes, sir," they both mumble.

He walks over to her, arms crossed over his chest. "What do you have to say for yourself?"

She slowly gets to her knees. He patiently waits for her to get to her shaky legs. Eve lifts her chin, looking him in the eye, and I see her reddened neck where she had the sheet wrapped around it, confirming what they said. "Fuck y—"

He backhands her across the face, knocking her off her already unsteady feet. It wasn't a hard hit, but she's weak. "Secure her hands behind her back and prep her legs," Evan commands.

She scrambles to get to her hands and knees. As one of the guys kneels to grab her leg, she manages to get a kick in, knocking him back on his ass.

The other one jumps on top of her, slamming her flat onto the concrete floor, face down, and he grabs her hands. Bringing them be-

hind her back, he secures them with a brown leather belt and buckles it in place. "Hurry up," he growls to the other one as he holds her down by her matted hair, smashing her face into the concrete floor.

"I'm trying," he snaps, pulling something off his belt. He manages to pin one leg down and wraps the cuff around it, buckling it in place. Then he repeats the process with her other ankle.

"Leave," Evan orders, and the two unlock the door before rushing out while he goes to stand by her. "Eve, Eve, Eve. What am I going to do with you?" he asks, kicking her side, forcing her onto her back.

She glares up at him with her septum piercing in place. There's no time stamp on the video, so I don't know how long she's had it, but it looks to be the same ring that he pierced it with. "Kill me," she offers.

He laughs and looks right at the camera. "Why would I do that? Our clients are loving the show you're giving them. Big, tough girl who thinks she can win. It's quite comical, really. How you continue to use so much energy fighting when it would be easier to just obey."

She says nothing. Instead, she sits up to relieve the pressure on her back from smashing her arms.

"That's why I have a gift for you."

"No." She tries to get her legs underneath her so she can get up, but he pushes her back down before she has the chance.

He removes something from his back pocket while straddling her waist. Eve arches her back, and a blood-curdling scream comes from her cracked lips as he shoves a syringe into her neck, plunging the substance into her. Once he removes it, he stands over her, watching.

"Ple-ease." She begins to cry out of frustration or desperation, I'm not sure. Probably a little bit of both. "Stop." Her shoulders shake, and she rolls onto her stomach. "Just let me die," she sobs, and my chest tightens at how desperate she is for death.

"You're making good progress, Eve. When it comes to coming all over yourself. It's your mind we've got to work on. You don't need it. All they want is your body."

She closes her eyes tightly, smashing the side of her face into the floor while her hips lift up in the air and her cries soften.

"Yeah. Just let the drugs do their job. Don't fight it. You'll just make it harder on yourself."

He grips her hair and forces her up on her knees, facing the camera. Her eyelids are heavy, breathing labored, and her hips rock back and forth as she sits on her knees. "Tell the audience why you feel so good, dolly."

Dark lashes blink slowly, and she licks her cracked, dry lips.

"Come on, Eve." He shakes her head, his hand still fisting her hair. "Tell them your cunt and ass are both filled with vibrating dildos. The best part is they aren't even turned on yet."

She moans.

"You've got one more week of orgasm training. And then I'll lock you in a chastity belt. No penetration and no coming." He smiles and adds to the audience watching, "That's when they really start to beg, and desperation shows just how obedient they can be."

Letting go of her hair, her head hangs forward, and he removes his cell from his pocket. The sound of the vibrators fills the room seconds later. Her body tenses and she throws her head back, crying out, coming almost immediately.

"You're so pretty, Eve. But your face isn't what's going to bring in the money. Your love for pain is what's going to have the men wanting you to themselves."

I'm confused as to what game Evan is playing here. He's speaking to the audience as if they still have plans to sell her. But the video that Bill sent me was Evan explaining that Eve was going to be a recruiter.

Pausing the video, I start to pace. "Why?" I ask myself. I know the feeds bring them money, and I bet they're collecting a lot with Eve. So why not lie? The viewers will never know that she's not sold. They will just think that they didn't buy her.

The last video showed Evan turning off the live feed when she was in the small room, so the audience has no clue what they have planned for her future. Evan is using that to his advantage.

Sitting back down, I push Play.

Her voice rings out as her body begins to shudder while she comes once more. He gently pulls her hair off her face and shoulders, gripping her cheeks. Snot and tears run down her bruised face. When you're dehydrated and starving, you tend to bruise quicker than normal.

I wouldn't believe it if I hadn't seen it with my own eyes before, but hers go blank. Just like that night on the yacht when I first touched her. She's mentally checked out. Or she's just high on the drugs and the orgasms. There's no telling what they've done to her off camera that is contributing to her current state of mind.

"Eve?" he questions, glancing at her and then smiles proudly. "That's what I want to see." He reaches out and runs his knuckles over her latex-covered breast. "See? I knew you could do it, dolly. But this is a punishment. And the only way to learn from a punishment is to remember it."

He turns and walks to a drawer. Opening it up, he removes a chain and gag. Standing in front of her, he orders, "Open wide."

She does as she's told. No fuss. No pleas. He gently places the gag between her dry and cracked lips, slipping it into her obedient mouth. Then he wraps the thick straps around her head and buckles it tight, the leather pinching her already sunken-in cheeks.

A black rubber tube with a bulb hangs off the front, telling me it's an inflatable gag. He picks up the bulb and squeezes it in his hand. She doesn't even act like she notices. Her once pretty green eyes remain vacant, but her body still trembles. It makes me wonder how many times she's come since she was shoved into the room. Evan pumps it again, and she blinks, her body jerking involuntarily.

I'm afraid he's going to cut off her air. Inflatable gags are no joke, and she's not coherent enough to communicate if she's able to breathe through her nose. Some can be filled so large that they block your airway, or she could gag, resulting in vomiting, which she could drown in.

Doing it once more, Evan's finally satisfied when her cheeks are swollen and helps her to her feet, positioning her in the center of the room, turning her to face him. "Look at me, Eve."

She stares at his T-shirt, eyes so empty she might as well be dead.

"Eve," he growls.

Still nothing.

He angrily removes his belt from his belt loops and slaps her across her upper thighs. As the leather hits her latex-covered legs, her eyes widen, and she falls to her knees. All you can hear is the faint sound of a mumble through her gag. Inflatable gags make it damn near impossible to speak.

"There you are." He yanks her up, and her wide eyes look around as if she doesn't know where she is. She tries to talk, but drool is already running down her chin. No recognition of what just happened.

"You've got a butterfly gag in your mouth," he informs her, and she tilts her head back as her throat works, trying to swallow. "It's inflatable and very restrictive. You'll have to breathe through your nose because the gag won't allow it."

Blinking rapidly, tears fall from her bottom lashes.

"You were a good girl just now, but you still have to be punished for that stunt you tried to pull." He runs his knuckles over the bruises forming on her neck before removing a chain from his pocket and connecting it to her ring in her nose.

She shakes her head quickly, her body now trembling.

"No sudden movements, dolly. I've seen these ripped out before." He gently pulls on the chain and her body bumps into his. He holds the chain tight to prove a point, his face inches from hers, and stares down at her. "It's not pretty, and then I have to pierce you somewhere else."

She stiffens, closing her eyes tightly.

He lets the chain go so it hangs down her chest and stomach. Then he reaches up to grab a chain that's connected to a pulley system on the ceiling. He clasps it to the end of the one hanging from her nose ring and slowly lets it rise. The pulley tightens the slack, making her rise up onto her tiptoes, forcing her to arch her head back at an extreme angle. You can see the skin of her septum pulling from the position.

"I'm doing you a favor, Eve. I was planning on replacing that bull ring with a bigger gauge tomorrow anyway. A few hours like this,

and it'll stretch out nicely, so replacing it won't hurt." He gives her a smile. "As much."

He then kneels, pulling chains that are connected to the floor and forcing her feet apart. Connecting the chains to the belts wrapped around her ankles, he forces her to keep her legs wide open.

She fights the belt around her wrists, and he pulls his cell out and turns up the vibrators once more. You can see her muscles flex through the latex. It's so tight, making it a second skin.

He reaches up between her parted legs and unzips a short zipper that runs from the front to back. Inserting his hand inside, he pushes on the toy in her pussy, making her shudder.

"Your viewers want to watch your cunt drip, dolly. Let them see how much you enjoy this." He rises to his feet, running his wet finger up her sunken stomach and heaving chest, leaving a trail of wetness along her latex-covered body. "Pain and pleasure go hand and hand for many. We at Dollhouse hold ourselves to a high standard, and we produce the best of the best. You're going to be the best for me, aren't you, dolly?"

She can't nod without pulling on the chain connected to her nose, so she just stares up at him with wide, tear-filled eyes.

He gives her a big smile before it quickly disappears, then he walks behind her. She tries to follow his movements, but all she can do is look up at the ceiling.

Stepping up to her back, he wraps his hands around her vulnerable throat, holding her body to his. She struggles, trying to breathe as her nose starts to bleed from the chain pulling on the piercing.

He lowers his head to her ear and speaks loud enough for the audience to hear. "Try to kill yourself again, and I will put you through hell, bitch. You think this hurts? You haven't experienced the kind of pain I can make you feel. You will beg for death, and when I decide you've had enough, I'll end your pathetic, useless life and chop you into pieces. I will then sell you off piece by piece, pound by pound for pennies, like a cow slaughtered for beef. Do you understand me?"

She blinks rapidly as tears run down her face because that's all she can do.

He kisses her matted hair before releasing her neck and stepping away.

Drool runs down her chin, and her nostrils flare once she's able to breathe while a mix of snot and blood drips from her nose.

"I'll leave you to think about your future." With that, he exits the room with her hanging there, and the camera shuts off.

"Fuck." I stand and throw her phone across the room. My pulse is racing, my hands are clenched, and my heart hurts for Eve.

All I can think is that was five minutes of her life out of a year. He left her there for three hours? Three fucking hours unable to breathe properly and in pain.

My father allowed this to happen to her. Garrett might have been the one to drop her off, but he knew what Dollhouse was about. That she'd spend day and night in agony. Being trained so men can what, get off on hurting her?

Picking up the phone, I delete the video and then toss it on the coffee table. I rush back into the bedroom to find her asleep, just how I left her. I can't do it. See her in such a vulnerable position. What if I fall asleep and she has a nightmare? Dreams she's back there, and I don't wake up to free her? Or worse, she dreams I'm the one hurting her and then wakes to being tied up and sees me lying next to her.

I won't do that to her.

Ripping the comforter off the bed, my hands shake as I untie the rope from around her ankles, then quickly undo her wrists. I push her onto her back and rip the tape from her lips.

She moans, arching her back, and I jump into the bed, yanking the comforter over us and pulling her into me. "Kash?" she mumbles.

"It's me, Eve. It's me," I assure, clinging to her. I need to feel her heartbeat against my body. To know she's here. Alive. In my arms. Where she belongs. I kiss her forehead, and she sighs, her body slack in my arms.

"You've got one more week of orgasm training." Now her getting sick after I would get her off makes more sense. She was forced to come over and over. Eve hated that her body would betray her. That she couldn't fight the drugs. And then to turn around and make her

go without. Orgasm denial can be just as brutal mentally and physically. It's a very thin line. Her emotions were already running wild and then add the drugs—the poor thing never stood a chance.

"I promise, angel, he'll pay for what he did to you."

I can't torture a dead guy, but I will make sure Evan takes all of our fathers' punishments. He wanted to make an example out of Eve; well, I'll make one out of him.

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FIFTY-SIX



EVERETT

I wake up and stretch out in bed, quickly realizing that how I fell asleep and how I woke up are not the same. My arms and legs are free, and I don't have tape over my mouth.

I'm immediately disappointed.

Why did he free me? Did he fuck me, and I don't remember? No. Kashton would never do that. He always demands my presence when he's playing with me.

Rolling over, I see him next to me, lying on his back. One arm is tucked underneath his pillow, the other on his chest. I reach out and run a hand down his chiseled abs and to his cock. My mouth starts to water.

I'm so hungry for him. Like an animal that was once chained out back, left to starve. He let me off the leash. Wanted to give me a chance to look for food.

It's not fair. I was able to go for so long with no sex, and then I met him, and I crave it. It's like an alcoholic falling off the wagon. But I knew this would happen. It's why I tried to deny it.

I push the covers off and get out of bed, needing to use the restroom. After washing my hands, I make my way to the kitchen for a drink. I'm thirsty. Whatever they gave me at Dollhouse still has me feeling a little fuzzy.

People always seem to think about the psychological toll the Lords take on your mind, but what about your body? Everything hurts, and I have marks from restraints, so I know they had me tied down to something. The Advil I took has long worn off.

Entering the kitchen, I flip on the light and think about getting a water but see a bottle of whiskey on the counter, so I grab a glass out of the cabinet and pour enough for a shot. I'll buy Tyson a new one to replace it.

I throw it back, hissing in a breath when I spot Kashton's bag on the coffee table next to my phone.

He said that Sin met him at Dollhouse to bring him a few things, and I bet they're in there. I pour another drink and walk over to the couch, sitting down. I pick up my cell and go through it to see if I've missed anything in the past few days.

I had an incoming call from Adam for a minute and thirty seconds about two hours ago, which tells me that Kashton answered. But I don't see anything else that looks new. Not like I have a long list of people who contact me on a daily basis.

Setting it down, I open up the bag and look into it. My heart leaps with excitement when I see rope, handcuffs, and zip ties. The tape he used on my mouth must still be in the bedroom.

Tossing back the last of the drink, I pick up the handcuffs and head back to bed.

I kneel between his muscular legs with mine tucked underneath my ass and pull his dick out through the hole in his boxer briefs. He doesn't even move. I place my left wrist in a cuff and then put my hands behind my back and cuff the other. Just like he had me do when I waited for him to play with me at his house.

My pulse quickens with anticipation of what he'll think of doing when he wakes up and sees what I've done to myself. Will he leave me here tied next to him or play with me?

I blow my hair out of my face, realizing I should have put it up before I lost the use of my hands. Bending over, I lick up his soft cock, running my tongue over his Jacob's ladder.

He doesn't give me any sign that he feels it, so I do it again, this time pulling the tip into my mouth. I suck on the saint's cross, and he moans, his hips shifting a little.

Letting go, I spit on his dick to get it wet, making it easier to suck into my mouth. My back aches and my arms already hurt, but I'm so wet for him.

He wants to marry me. This man wants to own me. What kind of woman would turn him down? Especially one like me? Broken. We don't get chances like this. To find someone who loves us, knowing what kind of past we have. Knowing all I've ever been is someone's whore.

I'm his, but it's different. I can't explain it, but he doesn't make me feel ashamed of what I need. What I want. He doesn't judge me, and I know he's not going to get rid of me and sell me off to the highest bidder. This man wants to chain me in his basement. Kashton wants to keep me forever.

"Eve." He groans my name, and the roughness in his tone makes my pussy clench. His voice is so sexy when he starts to wake up and is groggy.

I pull on the cuffs and whimper at how tight I made them. It feels so good. I spit on his dick once more and then lick up to the head and pull it into my mouth much easier this time, able to push my mouth down on it.

His hips thrust and I smile when his hands slide into my hair. *That's right, Kashton. Play with me. Make me your dirty angel.*

He pushes my head down, and I open wider to allow more of him. Gagging has my shoulders shaking, and he pulls my mouth from his hard cock with his hand fisted in my hair.

I look up at him through my lashes, and he's got his head off the pillow looking down at me. His blank stare gives nothing away, and panic rises that I've cuffed myself and can't get out on my own.

Will he judge me? Does he think I'm mental? He already tried to take me to therapy. I'll try for him. If that's what he wants. I just need him to want me back. He's a Lord. They take what they want. I'm what he wants, right?

The doubt fills my mind just as fast as my lust does when it comes to him.

"Need your face fucked, angel?" he asks, running his free hand down my cheek.

My breathing accelerates, and I lean into it. "Please."

He pulls me to a kneeling position by my hair, and I hiss in a breath, although my clit is throbbing. He also sits up. Letting go of

my hair, he gently pushes it back from my face before running his hands down my arms to find them cuffed behind my back.

I swallow nervously as his eyes search my face. He doesn't look surprised that I've cuffed myself. Just indifferent. I hate how easily he can turn off his emotions.

I've never managed to not show what I feel. I act out, break shit, and cry for no reason other than it feels good to do something I can control. For so long, I had no control over my life or body. I like it when Kashton takes over and doesn't make me think. I know that he's not going to hurt me. No more than I can take anyway.

"Kash, please," I beg, pushing my chest out to him.

He grabs my hips and lifts me up off my knees to throw me onto my back. I scream out when I crush my arms underneath me. "Kash—"

"You wanted this, Eve." He spreads my legs wide open, taking his hard dick into his hand, and pushes into my pussy without any foreplay.

His hands slide underneath my neck, and his tatted fingers tangle in my hair, arching my head back, and he begins to fuck me. His strokes are slow and deep while his lips drop to my neck. He gently kisses my sensitive skin while I gasp, trying to catch my breath.

My legs are spread wide and my thighs ache. His body is crushing mine while my pussy clenches around his pierced dick.

"That's it, Eve. Fuck, you're already so wet for me." He sucks on my neck, and my body begins to tremble. "Come for me, angel. I want it all over my dick. Show me how much you like me to fuck you."

My heart is racing, my pulse quickening, and my sight goes spotty. I can't tell if he's choking me or if I can't breathe because of his weight on top of me.

Either way, I accept it.

KASHTON

I pull out, and she slumps into the mattress, gasping for breath. Her legs shake, and I look at my cum-covered cock. "Good girl, Eve," I tell her as her pretty green eyes look around aimlessly.

When I woke up and realized she had found my handcuffs, I couldn't turn her down. She needed something from me. That video

I watched just proves how much she was groomed.

Everett is proving to herself that she can be used, and she is challenging me to see if I turn her down. Never. I'll prove to my girl that she's enough.

Getting off the bed, I grab her shoulders and pull her over to the edge, hanging her head off the side. She looks up at me, and I smile down at her, my tatted knuckles gently pushing her hair off her face to get it out of the way. "You wanted me to fuck your face, right?"

She licks her parted lips, still trying to catch her breath. I grab my dick and smear her cum along her cheek. "Lick it clean, angel."

She sticks her tongue out, and I rub the tip along it, letting her taste herself.

"That's it," I groan, wanting to come. I had to hold off from doing it inside her cunt. She woke me up wanting me to fuck her face, and my girl gets what she wants.

I just wish we were at my house where I have more toys. I'd fill that ass with a plug and put a collar around her neck while I have her kneeling at my feet, begging for it.

Opening her mouth, I push my cock into it, loving the way her hips buck on the bed. "All the way, angel. I want to see you swallow it."

Her legs fall open, and I can see her slick thighs. My hands grip her legs, spreading them wide open. My cock vibrates from her whimper, and I slap her pussy, making her jump. "Keep sucking," I order, pulling my cock free of her mouth, giving her a second to suck in a deep breath before slowly pushing it back down her throat.

She shudders and the sound of her gagging fills the room. This is my go-to angle when I'm fucking her mouth. It allows me to go deep, and it gives her little ability to fight. Her head is between my thighs, her arms restrained underneath her. She has no leverage to get away from how I want her to take my cock.

And I know my angel loves it.

I pull out and she sucks in a ragged breath. I take my cock and rub it across her face, smearing her cum and drool. "Gorgeous."

"Kash—"

"Pull your knees to your chest," I order, interrupting her.

She does as she's told and bends her knees, putting her legs together.

I wrap my right arm around her shaking legs behind her knees and pull them toward me. It lifts her ass and lower back up off the bed, tilting her more off the edge. She gasps, and I feel her stiffen, trying to catch herself.

"I got you," I assure her. "Just lie back and relax. You'll take what I give you. Understand?"

"Yes sir," she answers before opening her mouth like the good girl she is for me.

Sliding my hard cock back between her pouty lips, I slowly feel the back of her throat stretch for me, causing her to gag once more. She's getting better at taking my dick, but I like the sound and the way her body bucks when she gags on it.

My arm holds her legs in place while my free one reaches around and plays with her soaked cunt. She moans around my cock before I pull my hips back. I slide it back in before she can get in a breath and love that she sticks her tongue out for me, letting me get even deeper.

"Goddamn," I whisper, pushing two fingers into her pussy. She tries to rock her body for more, but I've got her locked in place.

Pulling out, she gasps and spits on her face before I shove it back in. "Leave it open," I demand. "I'm going to come on that pretty face of yours."

My hips move back and forth with a quick pace. The sound of my heavy breathing fills the room along with her gagging. I remove my fingers from her cunt, and her body slumps in protest. "This is about me, angel," I remind her. "You wanted me to fuck you."

I move my hands to grip her ankles, holding her legs in place—bent at an angle and against her chest while I watch my cock fuck her face. The bulging outline of my dick sliding down her throat has my balls tightening. "Such a pretty sight." I want her to know how pretty she looks. "My dirty angel letting me use her."

Shoving my cock down her throat one last time, I hold it longer than usual, and she pushes her hips up in the air, her body fighting to breathe.

I don’t give her a warning when I pull out, grip my dick, and come all over her face.

We’re lying in bed with the TV on, but the volume is low. After I came on her face, I cleaned her off, and we crawled back into bed, both satisfied for now.

She’s insatiable. I give it an hour before she wants me to fuck her again. To remind her who owns her.

I’m on my side and she’s on her back, eyes closed, but I know she’s not asleep. My hand rests on her chest, feeling the slow rhythm of her heart beating. I run it down over her stomach and to her hips. My eyes stay on her face as I touch her butterfly tattoo. Her eyes spring open and instantly find mine. She said that Cross gave it to her while she was in Las Vegas. She hasn’t told me, but it’s easy to assume it was to cover up the 111 carved into her hip that I saw on the *Isabella* that night.

“Why a butterfly?” I ask with her eyes still on mine.

“It’s stupid,” she whispers.

“Doubtful,” I argue. “Tell me. Why a butterfly?”

She looks away to stare at the ceiling. “They represent change. A new beginning. I wanted a different life for so long. Bill gave me that opportunity. I promised myself I would never try and take my life again.”

“There’s nothing stupid about that,” I tell her.

Eve laughs softly and I frown. “After I got it, I went back to my place and cried. I thought it would give me hope. Make me someone I wasn’t. It didn’t. All it did was cover up the truth.”

“And what was that?” I wonder, tracing the dark wings.

“That I was a worthless whore.”

My fingers pause, and my teeth grind at her answer. “That’s not true,” I growl, meeting her stare.

“No matter what I try to cover up, the truth was always going to be there. You can’t erase your past. No matter how bad you want to.”

“The truth…” I pause and watch her eyes grow large with worry about what I’m going to say. “The truth is that you’re a survivor, Eve.

There is nothing stupid or worthless about that."

Looking away, she swallows. Taking a deep breath, her eyes find mine again when she speaks. "Have you ever felt free?"

I tilt my head at the change of the conversation. "Free?"

She licks her lips. "The first time I ever felt free was the night on the *Isabella*. For two weeks before the party, Evan wouldn't allow anyone to touch me. It was a dream, really. No beatings, no toys, no sex." A smile tugs at her lips. "He wanted time for my bruises to heal. I had to be the perfect doll." She looks away. "Anyway, that morning we flew to New York. A woman came in to do my hair and makeup. I was given a dress to wear. I felt like a princess. I was speechless. The yacht took my breath away. The ocean was endless. It was breathtaking. The sun on my face. It was the first time I was allowed to drink alcohol." My hand slides up to cup her face, and she turns slightly to look at me. "I saw you standing there and thought, *Wouldn't it be nice to talk to a stranger? To have a conversation with someone who didn't want to fuck me?*"

I swallow because that's exactly what I had thought when I was with Saint and saw her on the deck.

"I wanted to jump off the yacht and swim in the ocean, but I didn't know how to swim then." She laughs at herself. "I imagined that I was there with my husband—a Lord who wanted to show me off to his colleagues, knowing I'd be going home with him. No one would touch me. No one would hit me, and no one would rape me." She swallows. "And when I saw you again, I had to speak to you. Then, like a trained whore, I threw myself at you…"

"Stop, Eve," I interrupt her. "Stop being so hard on yourself." She didn't know any better.

She takes a deep breath and lets it out slowly. "I…I just wanted someone to notice me."

"I did," I tell her, and she looks away from me. "Did he hurt you?" Her eyes find mine once more. "After you left the room? Did Evan hurt you because of me?" I already know the answer to this because Bill told us she was beaten when he found her. And if I've got the timeline right, he didn't save her until after the party on the *Isabella*.

"I ran into him, and he was mad." She licks her lips. "I told him that the Lord was dead. I was on my knees, hugging the toilet. I felt sick after I let you touch me. Evan was yelling…I don't remember much after that. He drugged me."

I sigh, running a hand down my face. "I could have saved you. I would have helped you had you just said something to me."

She gives me a sad smile. "You wouldn't have stood a chance against Evan."

"You don't know that."

"I know he had unlimited resources and a lot of powerful Lords on his side. Dollhouse was unstoppable, Kash. As much as you wanted to help, you had limits. Plus, my father knew I was there. You going up against your father's brother wouldn't have done any of us any good."

I might not have been a Lord, but I would have done anything for her. And I know my brothers would have helped me. "Then what happened?" I ask, needing to know.

"Like I said, it was a blur. I woke up in a room. No longer on the yacht. It looked like wooden paneling—a cabin maybe…there was yelling coming from another room. Lots of it. I hurt everywhere. Worse than I ever had. I was in and out of it for a while. Then when I woke up, I was in the hospital room with Bill and Gavin."

The picture that Bill showed us of her secured to the hospital bed with a patch over her eye. She looked like she had been beaten. Evan had hurt her because of me. I fucked up his plan that night and someone had to pay. She was his victim. His easy target.

She leans over onto her side and places her hand on my chest. She pushes me back, and I roll over, bringing her with me so she straddles my hips.

"I'm here now, Eve." I push her wild hair from her face, tucking it behind her ear. "And I promise no one will ever touch you but me. Do you understand that?"

She gives me a smile and leans over, bringing her lips close to mine. "I do."

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FIFTY-SEVEN



KASHTON

After our conversation, her stomach started growling. I managed to get her to crawl out of bed and made her breakfast. Thankfully Tyson keeps the kitchen stocked because someone is always staying here. She chose waffles and a side of toast.

"How long are we hiding out here?" she asks from inside the shower.

I go to respond when the doorbell rings. I look up in the mirror, and she opens the glass door, arching a brow. "Expecting someone?" she asks.

"Nope," I say, grabbing a towel and wrapping it around my hips. "Stay here." Closing the bathroom door behind me, I check her cell on the end of the bed. I see it's not even eight in the morning yet, so I'm confused about who could be here. I know Tyson keeps this place locked up tight when it's closed. Stepping into the living room, I grab my gun from the front zipper pocket of my bag. It's always loaded and ready to fire.

I make my way to the door to the apartment and open it to find Tyson standing in the hallway. "Ringing your own doorbell?"

His eyes drop to my gun at my side and then run over the towel and my bare chest. "I wasn't just going to walk right in. I didn't know what you'd be doing."

I step to the side, and he enters the apartment. "I just wanted to give you a heads-up that Haidyn and Saint are on their way here."

Fuck. "You told them—"

"No," he cuts me off. "Bill has called a meeting. I was instructed to tell you to join us."

Bill knows I'm hiding out with Eve; he's aware she needed rest, so for him to call a meeting, it must be important.

I place my gun on the kitchen counter. "How long do I have?"

"Maybe twenty minutes. But they don't know you're here. So if you go downstairs before they arrive, then they'll just think that you beat them to Blackout."

I nod. "Thanks for the heads-up."

"Of course." He goes to walk out.

"What is this meeting about?" I need to prepare Eve as much as I can. She's had enough surprises over the past couple of days.

"You know what I know." With that, he exits the apartment.

I return to the bathroom to find her out of the shower and brushing her teeth. Her pretty eyes meet mine in the mirror before she rinses her mouth out. "Who was it?"

"Haidyn and Saint are on their way here. We're having a meeting downstairs."

She turns off the water and bows her head. I understand why she doesn't want to see them. Eve now has to face them after finding out what Evan did to her. Now more than ever I'm glad that I didn't tell her that my brothers and I know that our fathers raped her.

"Hey." I walk up behind her, grab her arm, and turn her to face me. "It's going to be okay. I promise." Leaning forward, I kiss her forehead. "Afterward, we're leaving." Getting the fuck out of this town.

"Where are we going?" she asks.

"Wherever you want." My girl deserves a vacation.

Eve and I finished getting ready and made our way down to the club. Tyson excused himself to his office to make a phone call. Then Ryat arrived, followed by Sin.

Haidyn and Saint got here not long after that, and there's been tension since. A lot of it. We haven't spoken. I think everyone is confused by what's going on, and of course they're mad at me for ignoring them for the past several days.

"Why the fuck are we here so early?" Sin glances at his watch as if he'd rather be in bed.

"Long night?" Saint chuckles.

"Just wait. Your sleepless nights are coming," Sin says, smiling with satisfaction.

Tyson enters the room and claps his hands. Ryat was sleeping with his head in his hands, but jerks awake at the commotion. "I'm going to make this quick, but we're waiting on two more," Ty states.

Everyone looks around silently, counting to ourselves. I'm surprised Tyson's minions weren't invited. I know we're waiting for Bill. He was the one who supposedly called this meeting. Surely, he's not bringing Adam with him. Maybe Tyson's detective is also joining us. That has me on edge, because I know he's after Eve. Bill wouldn't set her up. Would he? Not after what she just went through at Dollhouse.

I see movement out of the corner of my eye, and to my surprise, Bill enters the club with Adam by his side.

"The fuck?" Ryat asks, rubbing his eyes before looking from Adam to Easton.

Sin just shrugs. He's so over it.

Tyson looks at me and then at Haidyn and Saint. None of us are surprised to see our brother. "You're supposed to be—"

"Dead," Adam finishes Tyson's sentence.

"We don't have a lot of time," Bill growls, walking over to Eve. She stands from my lap and hugs him before I pull her back down and wrap my arms protectively around her waist.

"Why the fuck are we here?" I demand, wanting to get this over with. I promised Eve we would leave after this, and I'm ready to get the fuck out of here.

"There were three bodies found at Barrington recently," Adam states.

Saint nods. "Yeah. It's been all over the news. All three were missing for over a month."

"What's not on the news is that there's a fourth woman," Adam adds.

"Her parents don't want her mentioned?" I wonder.

"The police don't want her information released. She's still alive," Bill answers.

"Well, that's good, but it sounds fishy to me." Haidyn rubs his chin. "If it's the same MO, they've been raping, torturing, and then killing these victims for years. Why leave one alive now?"

"Maybe a copycat," Sin offers, leaning back in his chair. "They've seen the news but only know very little of what actually happened to the previous victims."

Adam crosses his arms over his chest and looks at Eve. "It's more complicated than that."

"How?" I demand getting a sickening feeling in my stomach.

"I've gotten word from my boss that she was awake when the women were found. When questioned, she gave a description of the person who was 'holding' her."

"Well, who was it?" Haidyn demands, getting irritated.

"She described Everett to a T."

"What?" She jumps off my lap. "No." Eve turns to face me. "I did not kidnap, torture, or kill any of those women."

That gut-wrenching feeling intensifies. I look at Adam. "You came with a plan. What is it?" He wouldn't risk being seen in broad daylight if there wasn't a good reason for it. No. He and Bill have gone through every scenario, and they need us to see it through.

He looks at Eve and then at me, nodding. I run a hand down my face, and Haidyn curses under his breath.

"What?" she snaps. "Use your fucking words, because I don't understand your silent gestures."

"We kill her," Sin answers.

Eve gives a rough laugh, throwing her head back. When her eyes meet mine, she stops. "Kash. No. You can't be fucking serious? Tell them no. Absolutely not."

"Eve." I get to my feet.

"No." She takes a step back. "You can't kill her—"

"No one in this room is going to agree with you," Sin announces, standing. He's tired and ready to end this shit. "I would do unspeakable things to guarantee my wife and children's safety. And every Lord in this room would do the same."

"Kash," she whispers, looking at me. "Please don't allow this."

"I'm sorry, Eve," I tell her. "He's right." Any threat to my future wife must be eliminated.

"I can't believe this." She runs her hands through her hair aggressively.

Adam steps forward. "This isn't one dead body found, Eve. They've already got your prints on the one that you found, and with a detailed description by another, they've got you for two, and they will blame you for the others." He shrugs. "They'll say you were working with an accomplice. Most likely Isabella, since she's 'missing,' and you'll go down for who knows how many counts."

"They could try and push the death penalty," Bill suggests.

"I didn't do this." She looks at me, her pretty green eyes pleading with me, and it breaks my heart because they look the exact same as the video I watched last night. When she begged Evan to just kill her. "You know that, right? That I didn't do this?"

"It doesn't matter what we think you did or didn't do." Eve narrows her eyes on Haidyn at his lack of belief in her. "It's what they can prove, and they have the evidence stacked against you."

"They can't prove it, because I didn't do it," she grinds out.

"What's the status on the woman?" Ryat asks.

"Apparently, she was severely beaten and raped, like all the others, but instead of being killed and dumped, they left her to die. The cops were able to get a little information from her before she went into surgery, but she hasn't woken up yet. Brain swelling. She's been back into surgery twice since. They've got her in a drug-induced coma right now to try and relieve the swelling."

"She may not survive," Saint states the obvious.

"There's always a chance," Adam adds. "And if she does wake up, they'll show her pictures of Eve. And I have a feeling that even if she doesn't recognize Everett, they'll pressure her to say it's her. They've been wanting to close these cases, and this gives them the advantage to do so."

"And we can't allow that," Bill says.

"You agree with them too?" Eve snaps at Bill.

"I would have done anything to save your mother," he says softly.

"You're killing someone's daughter." Everett turns to me. "Kashton, what if I had been killed? Hmm? I was that girl. Beaten and raped, and I survived. She can have a life after this. She deserves a chance."

My girl can beg me all she wants, but it's not going to do her any good. "Not at the expense of yours." It's not even up for discussion.

"I can talk to her—"

"Absolutely not," I snap. Has she lost her fucking mind? She's obviously not thinking clearly from the drugs that Bill had to give her at Dollhouse for her assignment. I need to call Gavin for another IV. Maybe that will help.

"It wasn't me," she shouts desperately. "If you kill her, then it changes everything. It puts all of you on their radar. You become exactly what they're trying to accuse me of."

"I'll take that chance," Haidyn states, and she bares her teeth at him.

"I know I'm exhausted and all, but what if we're looking at this the wrong way," Ryat suggests. "What if she was planted?"

Adam opens his mouth but closes it just as quickly.

"Like a mole?" Haidyn questions.

Ryat nods. "Yeah. You were right when you said it's odd that they'd leave one alive. Doesn't sit right. A body gets dumped and found by Eve and then they want to pin it on her? Now you've got a woman who describes her perfectly?" He looks Eve up and down. "Bullshit. The girl was either brainwashed or part of the plan."

"You can't take that chance," Eve growls. "She could be innocent."

"We've seen this before." Adam ignores her. "A woman planted and the ones she was spying on had no clue until things went south."

"Just furthers the point. She's got to go," Bill adds.

"How do you suggest we do it?" Haidyn asks.

"Gavin," Sin and I answer in unison. Then I explain. "She's in the hospital. Gavin has access. Just make it to where she never wakes up." It doesn't have to be gruesome or lengthy. Just quick and easy. Eliminate the problem.

"I can't believe I'm hearing this." Eve's hands shake as she rubs them down her leggings.

"What if we kidnap her instead?" Sin shrugs.

"Absolutely not—"

"Just hear me out," Sin interrupts Eve, looking at Adam to explain. "If she's a mole. She'll have information we could use."

"If Evan is involved like we think, she could lead us to him." Saint nods.

"It's the only plausible explanation," Adam agrees. "We know they administer drugs at Dollhouse; it wouldn't be too far-fetched to think they take blood samples. Evan could have very easily planted Eve's DNA on the dead body for the cops to find."

"But this woman is in a coma right now," Ryat reminds him. "What the fuck do we do with her until she wakes up? *If* she wakes up?" he corrects himself.

"Sounds no different from Laura," I add. "We keep her alive until she's coherent. We have Gavin remove her from the hospital and Devin monitor her at Carnage. When she wakes, we see what she knows. That determines whether we kill her or throw her in a cell."

Either way, we won't let her go free. The woman knows too much about Eve to identify her. So like Sin said, she's got to go.

"You need to get the fuck out of town. I don't care where you go, but go. Don't pack a bag, don't go to Carnage. I've got the jet fueled and ready for you at a private airfield. I'll send you the information." Adam checks his watch. "We'll let you know once she's been delivered to Carnage."

Ryat is the first one to say goodbye, and Sin follows. Adam lingers over in the corner, talking to Bill, and Tyson has to stay until we're all gone to lock up.

I grab Eve's hand, pull her toward the elevator, and push the button, then I turn to her. Green narrowed eyes burn into mine. She's mad, but I really don't give a shit. This is her life, and I take that very seriously. The door opens and I usher her into it, pushing the button for the top floor, and step out. "I'll be right up."

She huffs, leaning back against the wall, crossing her arms over her chest as the door slides shut.

I make my way back to the bar area, and Saint nods when he spots me over Haidyn's shoulder. Haidyn turns to face me. "Where the fuck

have you been these past few days?" he demands.

"Funny. You didn't tell me where you were when you were hiding out." I don't point out that he was gone for weeks.

"I wasn't with your sister," he snaps. "Is this some kind of revenge? Trying to pay me back for leaving Carnage?"

I snort. "You're the last thing on my mind, Haidyn."

He huffs and then the anger leaves his face. I stiffen, knowing what he's going to say next. "We received a video."

"I've seen it," I inform him, not needing him to explain what was on it. Watching it once was enough.

"Kash—"

"I would stay and help with the girl, but I'm leaving with Eve," I interrupt him. "Adam will let me know when it's done, and we'll return." With that, I turn, giving them my back, and make my way upstairs.

The one good thing about Haidyn being Eve's brother is that he'll do anything to protect her. I might be mad at him, but I trust him a hundred percent to do what needs to be done.

EVERETT

I'm pacing the living room of the apartment above Blackout when the door opens. I glance up to see Kashton enter. "I won't let you—"

"Save your life?" he snaps, cutting me off.

I place my hands on my hips and arch a brow at his attitude. But even I know that Sin was right. None of those Lords downstairs will see this situation how I see it. I know I'm innocent. Killing another innocent woman who has been through so much trauma won't protect me. Her death will still be on my hands. Even if she is a mole. I doubt she volunteered. She was most likely forced into it. Blackmailed and groomed. I know firsthand how hard it is to try and find yourself when your mind has been altered for years.

Kashton sighs, running his hand down his face. "I'm tired, Eve." Slowly, he walks over to me and cups my cheek. His blue eyes are hard when he adds, "Don't fight me on this. You won't win, angel."

My teeth clench. All I've ever known is fight. I huff, "Kash."

"I want to have a life with you." His words make my breath come quicker. "As close to a real life as we can have in our world. But if

you force my hand, I will do whatever needs to be done."

I swallow nervously and whisper, "What does that mean?"

Running his tatted knuckles down my racing pulse, he answers, "It means that if I have to collar and lock you in a basement to keep you safe, I will. Either I kill those in my way, or I keep you hidden from the world. You can fight me if you choose to do so, but know my actions will depend on you." Leaning in, he gently kisses my forehead. "That decision is yours." Then he pulls away, walking off to the bedroom.

I numbly follow after him, not sure what to do or think after his threat.

I love Kashton. We've made it to a point where we can never go back to life without one another. But one question remains. Do we have a future?

I have no schooling. No career. I have money, but he has his own.

After Bill saved me, he gave me my mother's inheritance. All I have to offer Kashton is my body, and even that doesn't work. I can't give him an heir. The next generation. The Lords won't allow that. He may think we've won, but it's not over.

They will make sure to rip us apart when we least expect it. Just when everything starts to settle down and they see us happy. That's when they'll step in and take over. Remind him of who he is—a Spade brother who must carry on the tradition and give them children to groom for when he's no longer alive to do their bidding.

Stepping into the bedroom, I see him placing our toiletries in a bag, and I sit on the end of the bed. "I want to be your Lady," I tell him. If I'm going to die, I'm going to die as his wife. It might sound sad, but it'll be the biggest accomplishment I'll ever achieve.

Fuck Garrett. Someone in this world does want me.

Kashton drops the bag at his feet and exits the bathroom to walk over to me. He gently brushes the hair off my shoulder and frowns, glancing down at me. "You will be."

"When?" I ask, licking my lips.

He opens his mouth, but there's a knock on the door.

Heading back down the hallway, I follow him to see Bill walk through the door when Kashton opens it.

"Right now," Kashton says to me, and I frown.

"Right now what?"

My father lays some papers out on the kitchen counter and hands Kashton a pen. He signs it and then turns to me, holding out the pen.

"I don't understand." I look between them.

"Marriage license," Bill states. "You passed your assignment. With everything going on with the police, you need to be legally married as soon as possible. I'm not saying it'll help, but it can't hurt."

I look at the papers and then Kashton. He signed it like it was nothing. Not a doubt in his mind. I wasn't lying to him. I do want to be his Lady, but why does he want me? I don't understand…

"Don't overthink it, angel." Walking over to me, he places the pen in my hand and cups my face, like he can read my mind. "Trust me." He leans in and kisses my forehead. When he pulls away, I walk over and sign my name.

"Thank you." Kashton shakes my father's hand and slaps his back.

"Take care of my girl," Bill says, and tears sting my eyes. My life would have been different had Bill been my biological father. He turns to me and pulls me in for a hug and whispers, "Told you, princess. You'll get everything you want." He kisses my cheek and then pulls away. "I'll have these filed today."

Kashton lets him out, and then he turns to face me.

That's it. I'm officially Mrs. Pierce. The thought hits me like a fist to the chest, knocking the wind out of me.

"Breathe, Eve," Kashton orders, his hands on my face once more. "Nice and slow. Just breathe, angel."

I nod, sucking in a shaky breath.

"That's it. Another one."

I do it again, and a smile graces his gorgeous face, showing his dimples. He looks so happy, and I feel like I'm having a heart attack. I wrap my hands around his tatted arms. "I do trust you," I tell him.

His eyes search mine, and then he leans in and presses his lips to mine. I moan into his mouth, my body leaning into him. He grips my ass and picks me up. I wrap my legs around his waist, and he carries me back to the bedroom.

We fall onto the bed, and I pull away, laughing. The range of emotions I'm feeling is making me lightheaded.

"There's my girl." He dots kisses along my neck.

"Kash." I arch my back and grab his belt, unbuckling it, but he pulls away.

"We have to get out of town, Eve."

"But I want my husband." I bat my lashes at him.

He gives me a soft smile. "Don't worry, angel. You'll spend all night tied up, begging me to let you come. But right now, we've got to go." With that, he stands up, grabs my hand, and yanks me to my feet, slapping my ass.

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FIFTY-EIGHT



KASHTON

She's in the restroom when I step out on the balcony in the living room and dial up a number. He answers on the second ring.

"Hey, man, what's up?"

"I need a favor." I cut to the chase.

We don't have a lot of time. Adam sent me the information for his jet, but I have to decide where it takes us. I finally turned my cell back on now that I've seen Haidyn and Saint. They won't be blowing me up right now. They'll be busy helping Adam, and they know I'm going to be hiding.

"Anything," he states.

"I need a place to stay. Eve and I need to get out of Pennsylvania. Now. Still have your summer home?" The Lord has property all over the place.

"Yep. You're more than welcome to stay there," he offers without thought. "I'm actually in Las Vegas right now."

I frown. "You're still in Vegas?"

"Yes. Well…no. I was home but returned yesterday." He doesn't offer up any reason as to why, and I don't pry.

"Thanks for letting us stay. It should only be a day or two."

"Stay as long as you like. I'll let the staff know you're coming and to help you with whatever you need."

We hang up just as my wife enters the living room. I exit the balcony, shut the sliding glass door, and walk over to her. "Ready?"

She nods, looking around aimlessly.

"Eve?" I say sternly and her green eyes find mine. "Ready to leave, angel?" I soften my voice.

"Yes, I'm ready," she answers.

I send a quick text and then take her hand, pulling her out the door.

The flight alone isn't quite two hours. We could have driven, but instead we chose to fly. I didn't want to use Adam's plane since he can still track us with it, and I'd like to go under the radar as much as possible. I don't put it past Haidyn to threaten to kill Adam if he doesn't reveal where we're at.

I pull up to the tarmac and come to a stop. I get out and open Eve's door. Taking her hand, we walk up and onto the waiting jet.

"Good afternoon, Mr. and Mrs. Pierce." The flight attendant greets me and then nods at Eve.

I guide Eve over to the couch and sit down next to her.

"May I get you two something before takeoff?"

"No thank you," Eve answers softly.

"I'm good. Thank you." Turning to my wife, I see she's got her chin up, head held high. "Angel." I cup her cheek and turn her to face me.

Placing her hand on my chest, she leans into me and parts her lips. I kiss her, sliding my hand into her hair, and she shifts on the seat to turn her body more toward me.

Fuck, I'm so horny. I want to strip her naked and bury my face between her thighs right now. I need to taste her. Hear her scream my name in pleasure and not in pain.

"Starting the honeymoon early?"

She pulls away at the sound of a visitor, and I look up to see Sin. "Hey, man." I stand and pull him in for a handshake hug. Slapping his back, I say, "What are you doing here?"

"You're getting married. Someone has to be your best man."

I chuckle. "Thanks for letting us borrow your jet."

He shrugs. "Anytime."

"You didn't have to come," I add, wondering why he isn't at home with Elli and the kids. He looks more awake now than he was an hour ago at Blackout.

He smiles and pulls his cell out of his pocket. "Elli is spending the day with my mom. I'm going to fly back tonight." His cell rings and his smile widens. Patting my shoulder, he walks toward the back bedroom, answering his video call. "There are my girls…where's my boy?"

"He's still sleeping," Elli answers before he shuts the bedroom door.

EVERETT

We landed in New York two hours ago. A car was sent to pick us up, and we were taken to a house in the Hamptons. A nice older man gave us a tour of the grounds and showed us our bedroom. I tried to act interested, and any other time, I would have been, but Kashton could tell I was distracted.

I'm married.

I'm nervous. I hate how much I doubt myself. How weak I've made myself look over the past month. That isn't who I want to be.

Kashton's Lady? Absolutely.

The woman who jumps when her husband touches her? No.

That's not who he fell in love with. I've gone from broken to psycho to pathetic over the course of my lifetime. How do I get back to the woman I want to be?

I'm standing in the bathroom, finishing up my makeup while my phone sits on the counter. "Never Leave" by Seether fills the room to help take my mind off everything. I need noise. Silence makes me uncomfortable. I need something louder than my own thoughts.

He rushes into my room, like always, and I sit on the bed. "Get up," Cyrus orders.

I stay where I'm at, my arms crossed over my naked chest. I've been free to roam my room for the past few days, but I knew it was too good to be true. No ropes, no chains, no visitors. It's been heavenly.

"Fucking bitch." He comes to the bed, grabs my ankle, and yanks me off.

I try to get a hold of the comforter, but I'm too slow, and before I know it, I've landed face down on the floor. "Get off me," I shout, trying to roll over. It's easier to fight face to face.

He grips my hair, yanks my head back, and then slams it into the floor. The first time, I see stars; the second time, I taste blood; and the third, I'm gasping to breathe as the pain sets in.

Grabbing my arms, he brings them behind my back and ties them in place. He wants an easy fuck. He's never into the fight.

"You're a whore, Eve. Born for one thing and one thing only." He huffs and unzips his jeans. "If you can't give us what we want…well, then you're worthless. And you know what we do with worthless whores?" His chuckle fills my room as his knees shove mine open, forcing my ass up in the air. "We sell them off."

Blinking, I see a set of blue eyes in the bathroom mirror, and I turn to face Kashton.

He's not his father. Kashton is as good of a Lord as I'll find. He has feelings and he cares about the ones he loves.

My chest hurts. I feel like I'm robbing him of a future. I'm in love with this man, but it's going to cost him everything to love me. I won't do that to him.

He slides his tatted hands into the pockets of his dress slacks.

The man is gorgeous. He's got his dark hair slicked back and is dressed in an all-black tux. He looks mouthwateringly good. His blue eyes roam my body, looking over the white silk robe I'm wearing. I've done my hair and makeup, but I haven't gotten dressed yet.

My heart races at what he expects from me. The life that he deserves to have. "I saw you that night," I tell him.

His gaze meets mine, and he tilts his head in thought. It's the smirk on his face that makes my palms sweaty. "On the *Isabella*?" He chuckles. "I remember, angel."

I swallow the knot in my throat and square my shoulders. "No. At Hooke's show."

He frowns. "I don't…" Trailing off, the recognition dawns on his face, his features hardening. "You were here recently? In New York?"

My only response is to stare at him. *This is for your own good, Kash.* I'm not worth it.

"Why… If you saw me, why didn't you say something to me?" he asks, rubbing the back of his neck, confused.

"You were busy."

"Busy?" He snorts. "I'd never be too busy for you."

"You were practically fucking Jasmine by the bathroom." I hated watching him with her, but it was better than the alternative. I knew they had dragged Ashtyn from Vegas. Adam put me on a plane and sent me here to follow them for him. I knew if Kashton saw me, it'd be over, and the guys would drag me back with them to Carnage. I couldn't let that happen.

His frown deepens. "You were at Hooke's show? I don't…understand. What were you doing there?" His jaw sharpens, and he looks away from me. He snorts and answers his own question. "You were following Ashtyn." Running a hand through his hair, he growls. "Fucking Adam." When he gives me his back, I swallow nervously. Having to give him up will be the hardest thing I'll ever do. "Why didn't you say something to me?" he growls.

"Jasmine—"

"I would have dropped anyone or anything for you," he shouts, spinning around to face me. "I told you she meant nothing."

I snort. "We're not going to pretend like you were pining away for me. Let me guess…you're a man with needs, and she fulfilled them."

"No." He shakes his head, glaring at me. "We're not doing that." Kashton points a finger at me.

"Doing what?" I feign innocence. "Pretending that we were each other's first?"

"Pretending that you're not trying to sabotage us," he snaps.

My throat closes up, and I look away from him.

"It's not going to work, Eve. I won't let it—"

"Maybe I've changed my mind. What if Bill hasn't filed the license yet?" I glance back at him, shrugging carelessly. "I no longer want—"

"Stop, Eve," he barks, interrupting me. "We're fucking married. This is just a formality." Stepping into me, he runs his warm hands up and down my shaking arms, his eyes intently staring into mine. "You haven't changed your mind. You're doubting yourself."

Tears sting my eyes. How does he know me so well? It's not fair.

"You're doubting your worth."

I step back and look away, but he grips my face in both of his hands. "You are more than enough. You're my angel." His eyes soften, and I blink rapidly. "My beautiful, angry angel." Letting go, he steps away to leave the bathroom.

"You don't regret me?"

His eyes meet mine. "No."

Those butterflies I always get when he speaks take flight in my stomach. "It's never too late to change your mind," I add.

I'm really trying not to lose my shit, but I'm afraid I don't have high hopes.

He steps back into the bathroom, removes his hands from his pockets, and cups my face. They're warm and feel like home. I feel safe when I'm with him, and I refuse to let the Lords ruin that because I know they'll try again.

"Angel, I would have married you that day I saw you on the yacht if you had not run from me," he admits, his eyes searching mine.

Kashton leans in and kisses my forehead before he steps away, giving me his back.

I step forward with a knot in my throat, but he deserves to know what he's getting into. "I can't give you a family, Kash." He turns back to face me. "Do you understand that? The Lords will want you to have children." I've told him this several times, but he just keeps brushing it off. He needs to understand that all I'm bringing to the table is anger issues and crazy mood swings. He's a Spade brother. I've seen them try to rip everyone I know apart to get what they want. We won't be any different. We're not special.

"Everett"—he takes my left hand, running his thumb over my ring finger—"we've talked about this. You're going to be my family. You're all I need."

"You don't want kids?" I spilled my past to him the other night but never asked what he wanted. Honestly, we should have had this conversation long before now. Lords are required to reproduce. I can't give him that.

"I want you." He brings my hand to his lips and kisses my knuckles. Letting it go, he places both hands on my face. I love when he touches me. Kashton is a hands-on person, and that's something I love about him. He can never get enough, and I swallow it up as much as I drink alcohol. "As long as I have you, I have everything."

"But they will force you to have children."

"No—"

"Will you fuck other women?" I arch a brow.

He chuckles like my question was a joke. "Are you asking if I'm going to cheat on you? Of course not."

I lick my lips. "What if they force you to?" He frowns, and I go on to explain. "What if they put a gun to my head and say in order for me to live, you have to fuck—"

"Eve," he interrupts my hypothetical situation. "We're going to have a lot of issues in our marriage. Me fucking another woman isn't going to be one of them."

I yank my hands from his, crossing my arms over my chest. "What the hell does that mean?"

The smirk on his face tells me he thinks this is funny, which just pisses me off more. "It means you're hardheaded, argumentative, and sometimes flat-out crazy, but the qualities that make me want to strangle you are also what make me love you." He cups my face once more, that annoying smile still on his lips. "The Lords gave you an assignment, you completed your initiation. It's over. Now it's just you and me. Forever."

I refuse to accept that I get to spend the rest of my life with this amazing man. Nothing good ever happens to me. "But you're a Spade—"

"So are you."

I flinch at his words. I never have and never will claim that I came from a Spade brother—one of them. "For you, that means something. Not to me. I'm useless—"

He wraps his hand around my throat, cutting off my words. His blue eyes darken, glaring down at me while he pushes my back against the wall. "Don't ever say that," Kashton orders. "You're not useless, Eve. Do you understand me?"

I can't answer him because it'll be a lie, and we both know it. I can't change how I feel. I've felt it all my life. "I…" I lick my lips. He holds my neck, patiently waiting for me to agree. "I have no purpose. Nothing to give you." The words hurt worse than anything else I've ever been through. The pain I feel can't be fixed by a doctor, alcohol, or medication. It's an open wound that will never heal.

Lords are meant to serve, and I'm betraying them by killing their own. One day, I will be the confessional that they strip down and tie to their altar.

"You want a purpose?" he demands, and I swallow nervously against his hand still gripping my throat. "Huh? Is that what this is about, angel?"

I don't answer because he won't understand.

"I'll give you purpose."

My breath hitches as he pushes his body farther into mine, pinning me against the wall. I can feel him shaking with anger. I've never seen him this worked up before.

"I'm your purpose. You'll serve me…your Lord." He loosens his hold on my neck, but he doesn't release it. His eyes soften as he goes on. "I'm going to vow my life to you, and you will vow yours to me. I'm going to take care of you. Do you understand that?"

"I understand," I whisper.

Letting go of my neck, his eyes search my face when he continues. "I'll make sure to remind you every day for the rest of our lives." With that, he turns and exits the room.

I slump against the wall and bow my head. *He's my purpose.* I can do that. I will be the best wife and devote my life to him.

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FIFTY-NINE



KASHTON

My phone vibrates and I pull it out of my pocket, glancing at it.

SINNY: All ready.

ME: Thanks. Be there soon.

I stand on the balcony of the bedroom, looking over the calm ocean with a glass of scotch while she gets dressed, our conversation from an hour ago heavy on my mind.

"I saw you that night."

She was here. Right in front of me and I missed her. Too busy hanging on another woman when the one of my dreams was in reach. How many times was she within arm's length and I didn't see her?

There were times I thought I imagined her that night on the *Isabella*. That maybe I was fucked up from the adrenaline, alcohol, and the gum for my motion sickness. I told myself she didn't exist. That she was like a fever dream. A whirlwind of chaotic behavior that barreled into my life and then just…poof. Disappeared.

But I knew she was real. I can say it a million times, but she'll know how much she means to me. I was telling her the truth when I said I'd give up anyone and anything for her. I'll prove it to her.

"I'm useless…"

Our fathers made her feel that way. Evan didn't help, but I feel like the damage was already done by the time she was delivered to Dollhouse. It was just a punishment. Her father sent her there because he didn't know what else to do with her after she almost killed her-

self. She was no longer useful because she couldn't have their children, and he didn't want to deal with the trauma he created.

My cell vibrates in my pocket again, and I pull it out to see it's a group text, this time from Bill to my brothers.

Package delivered.

Sighing, I place the phone back in my pocket. Gavin managed to get the girl to Carnage. At least something is going right.

The sound of the door to the bathroom opening and closing has me smiling. I take another sip of my drink and wait for her to tell me she's ready.

"Kash?" comes her soft voice. She's going to be timid after our fight. I know her mind is reeling over what I said.

"I'm your purpose." Eve wants and tries to be independent, and I support that, but at the end of the day, she needs someone to control her. I will be that man.

"Out on the balcony," I tell her before tipping back the glass to finish off the scotch. Then I set it on the railing and turn around.

Eve stands at the open sliding glass door with her hands behind her back, wearing her wedding dress. I take in the silky black material. It accentuates her narrow waist and flares at her hips, then falls to the floor with a short train. It has a slit up her right thigh, showing off the flawless skin that I've had my hands on. The sleeves fall off her shoulders, and it dips low in the front. But not in a revealing way. Just enough to make me want more.

Her hair is up and off her face, showcasing a set of diamond studs in her ears.

This woman is going to be my Lady, and I'm going to treat her as such. An angel in everyone's eyes and my dirty little whore in our room.

She needs the balance.

Licking her lips, her gaze drops to my shoes, and I walk to her. Without saying a word, I cup her face, forcing her to meet my stare, and lower my lips to hers.

Her hands go to my hips, and she pulls me into her when I open my mouth and deepen the kiss.

I've always hated the idea of weddings. I feel like they're not needed. But she deserves more. She napped on the short plane ride here, and I spent the entire time planning something I hope she loves. Between Hooke and Sin, they've come through for me. I couldn't have done all this on my own with such short notice.

Pulling away, her lashes flutter open, and she looks at me with apprehension in her eyes. "You look beautiful, angel."

She blushes and I love it.

"We better get going." Taking her hand, I usher her back through the room and down the stairs to the front of the house.

Hooke bought this house a couple of years ago, and I don't think he's stayed one night here.

Stepping out onto the front porch, she comes to a stop when she sees a limo sitting in the circle drive. "Kash?"

"Come on." I tug on her hand, and she rolls her eyes, giggling.

She crawls into the limo, and I get in behind her. Sitting down, I close the door and reach into the pocket of my jacket and remove the soft fabric. "I need you to wear this."

Her eyes drop to the material, and she swallows as her eyes meet mine. Nodding, she licks her red-painted lips. "Okay."

I smile at her. No apprehension. No questions. She's letting me have full control of her and the situation. I'm not going to let her down.

"Face the door," I tell her.

She turns the best she can, giving me her back, and I place the silk material around her head and tie it gently so it doesn't mess up her hair.

"You may sit back."

She sits ramrod straight, hands in her lap and her lips parted while her heavy breathing fills the limo. "Kash?"

"I'm right here, angel." I take her hand in mine and signal the driver to get going.

EVERETT

The car comes to a stop, and Kashton helps me out of it since I can't see. I strain my ears to try and get a clue as to where we are, but my pulse is racing, and my heart is pounding. I can't hear any-

thing over the blood rushing in my ears. I don't know why I'm so nervous.

"I'm going to carry you," he informs me.

I laugh. "Aren't you supposed to do that over the threshold?"

"I'm going to do it then too." He sweeps me up off my heels and I yelp, wrapping my arms around his neck.

I inhale his scent, and my pussy clenches. My fingers slide into his hair, scratching my nails against his scalp.

"Eve," he warns.

"Hmm?" I hum before my lips touch his neck.

"If you keep doing that, we'll have to push back the wedding a few hours."

"I'm okay with that."

"I'm not." His chest rumbles.

I huff and relax in his arms. He's planned something for me, and I don't want to ruin it for him.

We slow and he sets me down on my heels, steadying me before he removes the blindfold. "You may look now, angel."

Doing as I'm told, I gasp at what I see. Nothing but blue ocean as far as I can see in front of us. "What?" I turn to look behind me, and I see the private marina where the car dropped us off. We're standing on the stern of a yacht. It looks like a dark cloud with its matte black and silver trimmings.

I wrap my hands around the railing and look down at the water. Closing my eyes, I listen to the waves and take in a deep smell of the ocean. It's the calmest I've ever felt.

Opening my eyes, I glance at Kashton to see he's watching me. "What?" I ask, unable to wipe the smile off my face. I must look like an idiot right now.

He takes my hands. "You said the first time you ever felt free was that night on the *Isabella*." Giving me a soft smile, he adds, "I wanted to give you a new memory on the ocean. This day is the first of the rest of our lives. The life you deserve."

It's hard to swallow past the knot in my throat. I've never had a man care about how I feel, much less listen to what I have to say. "It's gorgeous." I cup his face and lean into him. "Thank you." I

press my lips to his, and he gently kisses me before pulling away. I groan, wanting more, and he chuckles.

"Come on."

I let him escort me off the deck and down a set of stairs and through a door. It's the owner's suite, with a dark cherry wood platform sitting in the center. A bed rests on top of it, wrapped in black silk sheets.

The far wall is covered in thick matching drapes from floor to ceiling. Silver ropelike cords hang down. I walk toward them and pull them open to get an ocean view. "It's beautiful." It's like a dream. One that I've had before, though I know this one will end much differently. I always wondered what my life would have been like if Kashton could have helped me that night on the *Isabella*. Now I'll get to know.

Kashton comes up behind me and wraps his arms around me, gently kissing my cheek. "Yes, you are." He makes me blush.

Turning in his arms, he pulls away, and I look around once more, taking in the room. Glancing to my right, I see a sitting area. It has two couches facing a coffee table and two lounge chairs as well. More windows showcasing the blue water. It's scary how calm it looks but how deadly I know it can be. That's what Kashton reminds me of. He can be so gentle with me at times, but I know what my Spade is capable of.

There's a knock on the door before it opens and Sin slips inside. He gives Kashton a nod, who turns to me. "I have to do a few things. Stay here with Sin."

"Leaving me with a babysitter?" I arch a brow.

Kashton chuckles and kisses my cheek before whispering, "I'm not letting you run away this time." I can't help the smile that tugs at my lips when he turns to Sin and orders, "Keep her in here."

"Yes, sir." Sin nods as Kash sneaks out.

I stand awkwardly with my arms crossed over my chest. I've never been around Sin by myself before. Is it weird to see him as my adopted stepbrother? Not really sure what I'd call him since Bill isn't my biological dad. And he didn't adopt me.

"How is Ellington?" I decide to ask. Might as well make small talk while I'm here with him.

"Perfect," he answers, smiling.

"And the babies?"

"Also perfect."

A silence follows. This is the time that a father would show pictures of his children. Something tells me he doesn't want to because he knows I can't have kids. Or maybe that's just my insecurities talking. "Do you have any photos?"

"Of course." He doesn't hesitate to pull out his phone and open up his camera roll. He's beaming. "This is our son, Brexton." It's a picture of a baby dressed in a blue onesie. He's got a green pacifier in his mouth while Elli is holding him, looking up at the phone. Her hair is in a messy bun with a huge smile on her face.

"He's handsome," I tell him and add, "Elli looks great."

He swipes left and shows me the next photo of Elli sitting up in their bed, back against the headboard, holding a baby girl dressed in a pink onesie. It has little teddy bears all over it. "This is our daughter, Annaleigh." He smiles down at it.

"She's beautiful."

"Just like her momma," he agrees.

The next one has the babies lying side by side in gliders in the living room. They both have mittens on their little hands.

"Congratulations," I say. "I'm glad everyone is doing great."

"Thanks." He places his cell in his pocket and looks at me. "How about a drink?" he offers, walking over to a bar back in the corner.

"Absolutely." I run my sweaty hands down my dress. I feel a little nauseous. Unsteady.

As I make my way to him, he pours me a glass of champagne. I consider just grabbing the bottle but decide against that.

He then pours his own, and we clink our flutes together. "Here's to the rest of your life." He throws his back, and I stare at mine.

The rest of my life. But it's not just my life. It's Kashton's too. He's stuck with me.

"Eve?" Sin gets my attention.

"Hmm?" I meet his stare.

"I have something for you." He walks over to the bed, and I see a box lying on the black silk. He returns, holding it out to me. "Bill wanted me to give it to you."

I frown but take it with shaking hands. Opening it up, I swallow nervously, looking over the beautiful necklace. It's white gold, diamonds, and blue sapphires. "Bill wanted me to have this?" I ask, looking up at him.

Sin nods. "Bill told me it was your mother's, and he wanted you to have it for your wedding. He said it covers your something old, something borrowed, and something blue."

A knot lodges in my throat and I can't breathe.

"And he said you needed these for your something new to go with the necklace." Pulling a box from his dress slacks, he holds it out and opens it for me. Bvlgari Divas' Dream diamond and sapphire drop earrings.

My skin gets hot.

"Eve? Are you okay?" Sin asks, sounding worried.

I nod, trying to speak. "Y-yes." I refuse to blink and let the tears fall.

He sets the box with the stunning earrings down. "May I?" He reaches out his hand, and I let him remove the necklace that I still hold. Then I turn, giving him my back, and my eyes stare out the windows looking at the ocean.

I don't deserve this. Any of it.

"Done," Sin announces, and I turn back to face him. His eyes drop to it and he gives me a big smile. "It's beautiful."

The door opens, and I see my husband enter. "Ready?" He smiles when he spots the necklace, which tells me he knew all about it. I'm sure he knows about the earrings as well. It's a lot all at once, but that doesn't mean that I'm not thankful.

"Oh." Sin reaches into the pocket of his suit jacket and removes his phone once more. "Photo op. Hold this for a second." He hands me his phone, and I take it while he gets my husband a drink. Handing Kash the flute, he then takes his phone back and holds it up for a selfie.

"Seriously?" I ask with a laugh, unable to hide the smile on my face. I've never been this lucky. This loved. I shouldn't be surprised by the gifts Bill gave me. He's been this way since he saved me. But the thought that Kashton put into all of this is overwhelming. In the best way.

"What?" He shrugs. "If there's no proof, it didn't happen."

The three of us get into the picture, holding our champagne flutes, and he takes another. Then he reaches into his pocket and pulls out something. "I almost forgot. Here you go." He hands Kash a piece of gum. Then winks at me. "That almost ruined the night." Then he exits the room, downing his drink.

"What was that about?" I ask my husband as he pops it into his mouth while I set my full glass down.

He turns to face me and places his hands on my cheeks. "I love you."

My eyes search his and a calmness sweeps over me. Something I've never felt before. It…feels good. "I love you, Kash," I tell him.

"I know technically we're already married, but…" He pulls back and drops down onto one knee. I can't help the smile that spreads across my face. "Everett Sinclair, the love of my life, will you vow to spend the rest of your life with me?" He removes a black box that has a black ribbon wrapped around it with GRAFF written in gold letters. He unties the ribbon and opens the box to reveal an emerald cut diamond on a diamond band.

My wide eyes go to his, and that knot of emotion returns. I blink, trying to hold back the happy tears. I nod, biting my lip and choke out, "Y-yes."

He slips it onto my trembling finger and stands. He cups my face, and I choke back a sob. "Till death do us part," he promises.

"Till death do us part," I vow.

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SIXTY



KASHTON

Her tear-filled eyes drop to inspect the 8.12 carat emerald cut diamond. It has a cut shield diamond on either side with a diamond-set platinum band. I knew the moment I saw it that she needed it. "How does it fit?" I ask, running my thumb over it.

"Perfectly." She assures me. "It's perfect." Placing her hands on my face, she kisses me, and I wrap my arms around her, pulling her into me.

I wanted this to be special for her. A chance to show her just how much she means to me. Words only go so far. They only mean so much. I'm going to prove to her how much I love her. That I can take care of her.

"Seriously?" Sin calls out, and she pulls away laughing as I look at the open door. "It's time."

"We're coming," she laughs softly.

I look over her necklace and then check her ears and see she hasn't put in the earrings Bill got her. "Be right there," I assure him and he closes the door when I grab the small box and hold it out to her.

She removes the diamond studs and replaces them with the earrings that Bill gave her. I close the box with the diamonds now in them and set it aside. "You look stunning, Eve."

Her cheeks turn pink at the compliment. "Come on." I take her hand, and we exit the owner's suite and step out onto the deck. I've got it lined with rose petals to a black altar at the bow of the yacht.

"You shouldn't have done this for me," she whispers.

I turn to look at her, and her watery eyes scan the bow. "I'd do anything for you," I tell her, and when she looks at me, I gently kiss her lips. This is just the start of our forever.

"Truly Madly Deeply" by Savage Garden begins to play, and Sin clears his throat, standing under the altar.

Eve glances at me. I shrug. "Where's Howard?" I ask, looking around.

He smiles, answering, "I told the officiant he wasn't needed. I'm going to marry you." Sin pulls his shoulders back. "Don't worry. I'm legit. I got ordained online today."

I open my heavy eyes, hearing my phone beep. Looking at my wife, I see she's tucked into my side, right arm across my chest and sound asleep.

Reaching over, I pick up my cell and see I have a new video message. I gently pull out from underneath Eve and put on my dress slacks before opening the sliding glass door and stepping out onto the balcony. The ocean looks like black glass. It's so dark out here, and the sound of the waves is calming. After our ceremony, I opted for the patch that Sin also got for me in case the gum didn't work. I prefer the patch much more.

I fall into a chair and run a hand down my face before I open up the video. It's in the group chat with Saint and Haidyn.

When I press Play, a room comes into view. It's the same one she was in for her initiation, but only Evan is currently present. He's got his back to the camera, tossing some things onto a tray, but I'm unable to see what they are.

The door opens and Eve is shoved into it. "Fucking bitch," she hisses at the man who pushed her inside before turning to face Evan.

The door opens once again, and my pulse races when I see who has entered. Her back is to him, so she doesn't notice. Too focused on Evan.

"Get on the table," Evan orders her.

"I will not," she argues, snorting.

Evan turns to face her. His eyes flicker to the Lord watching their exchange. "If you don't—"

"You will have to make me," she interrupts him.

I love my girl, but she's so stubborn. It's going to get her killed one day.

"Eve…" Evan smirks. He's enjoying this. "We've talked about this."

"And I told you to go to hell." She spins around to rush out of the room but doesn't get far. The Lord swings, punching her in the face.

My heart races when she drops to the concrete floor like dead-weight. She didn't even see his fist coming.

She's on her side, her legs and arms twisted, matted hair covering parts of her already bruised face. Now it's bleeding.

"Put her on the table," Evan orders the kid who brought her into the room while he walks over to the Lord. "Mr. Reeves. What a surprise."

Garrett shakes his hand while he watches the kid arrange an unconscious Eve on the table. "Still as stubborn as ever, I see," he says, referring to his daughter.

Evan squares his shoulders as if offended, and I get a sickening feeling. "It takes time, sir, but I assure you, she will submit."

"I'll be the judge of that." Garrett crosses his arms over his chest.

Evan turns and walks over to the counter while the kid prepares Eve. Arms out to her sides and strapped down to the table, palms up. A thick belt around her chest, stomach, and upper thighs, along with her ankles.

All I can think is *at least her legs are closed*. They're not going to rape her. But if not that, then what? Why did Evan want her in this room to begin with, and why is her father here? He tossed her away like trash. Why does he care about her progress?

Everett groans in pain as she starts to come around, arching her neck.

I run a hand through my hair. *Goddammit, Eve.* At least she's alive. I just keep reminding myself that they don't want her dead.

Evan starts opening and slamming cabinets, and my stomach knots. He's changing his plan. Now he's going to prove a point to Garrett at Eve's expense.

"Here." Evan wads up what looks like black fabric that has a belt connected to it. "Put this on her," he orders the kid.

The Lord-in-training starts to softly push Eve's hair off her bruised and bloody face.

"Give me that," Garrett snaps, yanking what I now see is a hood from the kid's hands. He shoves it over Eve's head and face, not caring about being gentle as he stretches it. The fabric is tight, showing off the hollowness in her eye sockets, the curve of her nose, her sunken-in cheekbones, and her chin before he pulls it down to cover her neck. It has a thick belt that Garrett pulls tight and buckles in the front.

Eve moves once more. "Wh-at?" The only part of her face that can be seen is her mouth. She licks her busted lips, smearing the blood across them.

"This as well." Evan tosses something else to Garrett.

He snatches it midair and then grips Eve's cheeks painfully, making a cry ring out in the quiet room. He shoves the black rubber into her mouth. It resembles a mouthpiece with a hole in the center for her to breathe out of. He pushes her head up, fastens it, and then drops it to the metal table.

She can no longer see or speak. It's probably also hard for her to hear. She's helpless. At their mercy.

Her hands fist, and she starts to fight the restraints. She's coming around now, and I shift in my seat. "Hold on, angel," I whisper to my phone. Whatever it is, it can't last forever. She's in bed right behind me. This isn't the end for her.

Bill finds her and pulls her out of this hell. He saves her.

Evan pushes a tray over to her side and starts an IV in the crook of her arm, then hangs a banana bag on a hook.

"What the fuck is that for?" Garrett demands.

"Epinephrine," Evan answers, and Garrett arches a brow in question. "Adrenaline. There are higher risks when administering it this way, but…"

"Give me a syringe and I'll stab her in the heart with it," Garrett interrupts him.

Evan looks nervous for a second. "A shot of adrenaline straight to the heart will only last maybe twenty minutes before she passes out. I'm diluting it some and giving her less this way, but it will last longer."

"Fuck," I growl, shifting in the seat again.

"Hmm." Garrett nods his approval.

Evan grabs a piece of sandpaper and walks over to Eve. He starts to rub it over her right hip. She comes alive, thrashing on the table as much as she can. Mumbled cries and screams fill the room, and spit flies from the hole in the mouthpiece.

Evan scrubs and scrubs until he's rubbed the area raw. When it starts bleeding, he's satisfied and tosses it to the floor, then picks up a knife.

I put my free hand over my mouth when he starts to cut three lines vertically over her hip. Blood pours down her side and onto the table.

She shakes uncontrollably, and her muscles flex.

"What is this for?" Garrett asks, looking over the marks on her skin.

"This is her number. It's a reminder of where she once was and where she can always be sent back to," Evan answers. He then unscrews a lid to a white bottle that he grabbed from underneath the cabinet and pours it over her bloody skin.

She arches her back and neck, screaming through the mouthpiece.

"What was that?" Garrett demands.

"Sulfuric acid," Evan answers, and I tense.

"Won't that burn her?" Garrett questions. "She'll be hard to sell if she's got burn marks all over her skin. You've already rubbed it raw," he growls.

Evan walks over to the sink and fills a cup with water. "It's just a warning," he states and then walks back over to a struggling Eve to flush the wound. "It'll heal."

Her frail body violently shakes, making the table rattle.

Once satisfied the wound is clean, he rubs salt into it before placing a large bandage over it.

I let out a shaky breath. A part of me hates to see her in pain. The other tells me that it was smart to help with infection. Either way, it

should never have happened to begin with.

Evan removes the IV and picks up a roll of duct tape, tossing it to the kid. "I want her arms behind her back. Tight as you can."

"Yes sir." The kid nods.

He goes to work unbuckling her restraints. She immediately starts to kick and fight.

Garrett helps with the last two belts, rips her off the table, and shoves her to the floor. It wasn't hard. The poor thing has no senses and is weak.

He pushes her onto her stomach, grabs her arms, and pins them behind her back. He holds them up at an angle, and I bite my inner cheek, hoping he doesn't break her fucking arms. I remember Bill and Devin telling us that she had a broken wrist that Devin had to re-break because it hadn't healed properly. But no one ever gave us an estimate of when it was initially broken.

Thankfully, the kid works fast, starting at the top of her arms, and wraps the tape all the way down to both wrists. He rips the tape and stands. So does Garrett.

They all three watch her kick and squirm while she lies naked on the floor. I know her wound hurts, and she rolls onto her back, trying to relieve the pressure on her freshly carved hip.

She's covered in sweat and gasping for breath through the small hole in the mouthpiece.

"Sir?" the kid asks Evan. "What would you like me to do with her?"

"Put her back in her cell."

"Like this?" he questions, looking over her restrained body.

"I gave you an order," Evan yells at the kid.

"Yes, sir." He picks Eve up and carries her out of the room.

Garrett turns to face Evan. "I want to see progress."

Evan grinds his jaw. "It will come," he promises. "It takes time—"

"I don't think you understand who the fuck she is," Garrett snaps. "She would rather die than do what you want. She wants to kill herself, and when she realizes she won't be successful, she'll push you to do it."

Evan shakes his head. "It will work. She will be the best recruiter we've ever had."

The video stops and I frown.

Recruiter. There it is again. It makes me think of the meeting that Bill and Adam called at Blackout. Why I'm on the run with her. They want to set my girl up as helping to lure others into sex slavery and blame her for those women's deaths.

I don't believe it.

She would never do that. Can a person be brainwashed? Absolutely. She's proof of that. How she feels about being useless…unable to have a child…they brainwashed her to believe that. Too many years of damage to undo. But to force someone to endure the same abuse she survived? No. That is not who Eve is. Not who she wants to be.

Garrett was right. Eve would rather die or hurt herself than hurt someone innocent.

Getting out of the chair, I turn and come to a stop when I see my wife standing behind it, her watery eyes on my phone in my hand.

FUCK.

EVERETT

I'm tossed onto a cold surface and try to scramble away, but there is nowhere for me to go. I can't see or hear. So I lie flat and kick out my legs.

When I don't feel anything, I drop them to the floor and try to calm my breathing.

What happened? Where am I?

I was fighting with Evan and then…nothing.

Everything hurts. My face is pounding and it's itchy. I can feel rough material all over my skin. Something is wrapped around my neck. A collar, maybe?

My hip is burning. Did they brand me?

I have no use of my arms or hands. They're secured tightly behind my back. I'm hot. Can a person overheat? My face is sweating, and I can barely breathe. Whatever is in my mouth is big, and it has some kind of tube that keeps hitting the back of my throat that makes me gag.

I can't die like this. In my own vomit. I will go down fighting. Not helpless.

"Eve?"

I blink, and my blurry vision rises to meet my husband.

He looks away and sighs heavily. "I'm sorry—"

"When did you get that?" I ask with a shaky voice.

"While you were sleeping."

"Why"—I clear my throat—"would you watch it?"

His jaw sharpens before he answers. "I want to know."

"To know what?"

Running a hand over his head, he says, "What you went through."

"What I went through?" I repeat with a sour taste in my mouth.

I sit with my back against a cold wall. There's nothing else for me to do. I jump when I feel hands on my face. I'm shoved forward and start to fight, but then the mouthpiece is gone, and I relax.

Finally. I want to cry but don't think I have any tears left.

Then the thing around my neck is removed and the hot material over my face is pulled off.

"Hello, dolly." Evan kneels in front of me.

I say nothing.

"How do you feel?" He runs his thumb over my lips, and I lean into him. "That's my good dolly." He drops his hand to my hip, and I whimper. "Would you like something for the pain?"

"N-o," I manage to get out. I hate the drugs.

"Are you sure?"

I nod and beg. "Please?"

"Please what, Eve?"

"My arms. I want my arms."

He pulls out a pocketknife and holds the blade to my neck. I arch away, pushing my head into the wall. "Have you learned your lesson?"

"Yes," I rush out. "Yes. I promise. Please…"

"Lie on your stomach," he orders, stepping back.

I push myself off the wall and lie down on my stomach, my head to the side, and he starts to cut the tape.

A sob escapes when he sits down next to me and pulls me into his lap. I don't have the use of my arms. They just flop to my sides, and I bury my head in his chest.

"Now, now, dolly. I don't like to hurt you. You know I love you, right?"

I'm sobbing, unable to answer him.

"Shh." He runs his hand over my sweat-covered hair. "You make me hurt you, Eve. I'm here to help you. You just need to let me."

I nod my head, soaking his shirt with my tears, snot, and drool. "O-kay," I hiccup.

I look up at my husband, and he's just staring at me. Why are things coming back to me? Why am I letting them in? I liked it when I didn't remember. When that part of my life never existed. It was a nightmare that I woke up from.

Kashton steps forward, and I take one back. His jaw sharpens, and he glances away.

"What I went through," I repeat again.

"Angel—"

"Want to know what happened after that video ended?" I look to his phone in his hand. "Evan left me in my cell like that for twenty-four hours." My gaze returns to his, but he can't look at me. "By the time he removed my hood, I was a sobbing mess. I begged him to help me. Told him that I'd be his best girl." I swallow the lump in my throat. "He told me he loved me. That he was doing it to help me."

Kashton drops his head and rubs the back of his neck.

"Is that what you want, Kash? To know how pathetic I was?"

"You were never pathetic," he growls. "You were trying to survive."

"Survive?" I snort. "I wanted to die, Kash."

He glares at me, and I step into him.

"My first week at Dollhouse, a guard came into my cell at night, and I knew what he wanted." I lick my lips. "What every man I had ever met wanted from me—my body." I wrap my arms around myself. "When I didn't willingly give him what he wanted, he took it."

He runs a hand down his face.

"The next night he came back." I sniff. "I refused to let it happen again, so I did the only thing I thought would stop him." My voice cracks.

Kashton reaches out and brushes his tatted knuckles along my tear-streaked cheek. "What did you do, Eve?"

"I pissed and shit myself," I answer, ashamed, and he tilts his head to the side. "It's all I could think to do to make myself be unattractive to him. To make him disgusted by me." My body shakes with anger. "But he didn't care." Fresh tears fall from my eyes, and Kashton wipes them away too. I wish he could do the same with my memory. "He rubbed my face in it like a dog. Then he beat me, but not before he got off." I give a rough laugh. "Because God forbid a man not get to have what he wants. He ended up making me despise myself."

"Eve—"

I step back from him, and his hand drops to his side. "What else do you want to know, Kash? Want to know about the time they pierced my nose like I was cattle?"

He looks away, and his Adam's apple bobs when he swallows.

My chest tightens. "You know about that too? How?"

He doesn't answer.

I slam my hands into his chest. "How many videos have you watched?"

"Five," he answers, looking back at me.

Five videos? I know about the day I was dropped off at Dollhouse and this one, now my nose piercing. What did the other one show? One was humiliating enough. I give him my back, spinning around.

"Eve, wait." He grabs my upper arm and turns me to face him.

I swing. My hand slapping him across the face. "Don't touch me," I scream and then shove him back, but he doesn't budge.

"Stop, Eve," he orders, but I hit him again.

"Fucking bastard!" I shout at the top of my lungs. This man is supposed to be my husband. The man I spend the rest of my life with, and now I can never look him in the eyes again.

He's different from Evan, Adam, or Bill. They know I'm broken. Kashton is supposed to see me differently. Evan is ruining that.

"Let go of me," I demand, trying to yank my arms free of his iron grip.

"Fucking stop, Eve," he growls. Then my legs are kicked out from underneath me, and I'm on my back. Kashton's on top of me, his hands gripping my wrists and shoving them above my head.

"Get off me," I say through gritted teeth.

The door opens to the owner's suite, and I stop fighting. Our heavy breathing fills the room.

"I heard screaming. Need some assistance, sir?" the man asks my husband.

It instantly makes my blood boil. What about me? Why not ask if I need help? I'm naked on my back, and he's on top of me, pinning me down. What if I wasn't willingly here with Kashton?

"Leave," Kash orders.

The guy quickly looks from me to my husband. "Hooke keeps sedatives—"

"Leave or I'll throw you fucking overboard," Kashton shouts, interrupting him.

The man slams the door shut, and Kashton places his attention back on me. "Are you done?" he barks at me, sucking in a deep breath.

His cheek is red from my hand, and his jaw is clenched. Hard blue eyes search mine, waiting for a response. I huff, softening my body and tightly closing my eyes. He releases my wrists, and I place my hands over my face.

"Don't do that." His voice is no longer harsh, but there's still an authoritative tone. "Don't hide from me, angel."

I refuse to look at him. I can't. Too ashamed of who I am. What I allowed to happen to me.

"Eve?" he growls.

I turn my head with my hands still covering my face, and suddenly his weight disappears. I roll onto my side.

His hands are rough and forceful, shoving me to my stomach. My eyes spring open when he grabs my arms and pulls them behind my back. "Kashton." I whimper when he places my wrists tightly in handcuffs.

Then his hand falls between my legs. I bite my lip to hold my breath when his fingers gently play with my pussy. I know what he's doing.

"Spread your legs," he commands, slapping my ass when I don't comply fast enough.

Pushing my knees apart, I lift my pussy in the air for him.

He begins to finger me, and I bite my lip, refusing to let him know I'm enjoying it.

"I'm your husband, Eve. Your Lord. You vowed to be mine. That means I own you. Every part of you. Do you understand that?"

I sniff and tears fall from my eyes onto the carpet.

He removes his fingers and slaps my pussy, making it sting, and a moan escapes my lips. "Answer me," he orders, doing it again.

"Y-es." I gasp.

"Yes what?" Another slap.

I cry out and my body trembles. "You're my Lord. I belong to you."

"Good girl." His fingers return to my soaked pussy, and this time I rock back and forth, hoping he fucks me. I'd rather him choke me out than finish the conversation we were having. Being someone's useless whore is all I'm good for. This is what I know.

He removes his fingers, and I slump, trying to catch my breath, but stiffen when I feel something cold pressing up against my lips. "Relax, angel," he growls, and I know what's coming.

I moan when he begins to push the toy into me. "That's it." His free hand rubs on my clit in a slow and taunting way. I begin to pant, wanting more.

My pussy fills with the toy, and I break out in goose bumps.

He grabs my hips and rolls me onto my back, crushing my cuffed arms underneath me.

Kashton straddles me, and I see he has a Sharpie in his hands. Biting off the lid, he spits it out and starts to write on my chest.

My wide eyes go to his. "Kash?" I begin to panic. "Please…don't." It's my hallucination all over again.

"You've left me no choice, Eve," he says flatly.

I try to sit up, but his left hand grips my throat and he shoves me down, pinning me to the floor while his right hand continues to write on me. "Please…" I choke out.

"You're going to learn the hard way" is his only response to my desperation.

He drops the Sharpie, grips my upper arms, and pulls me to my feet. Moving his hand to my hair, he drags me over to a mirror, and I

trip over my own feet to stop him.

It doesn't work. Instead, I shut my eyes as he forces me to my knees in front of it. "Look at yourself," he commands.

I bow my head, letting my hair shield my face and the tears that run down it. I'm trembling at the thought of what he wrote on my body. It'll last for days. Weeks, even. It'll be a constant reminder of how worthless I am.

Seconds later, his hands are in my hair once more, yanking my head up, and I squeeze my eyes shut. He wraps something around my neck and fastens it in place, pulling pieces of my hair. Then it starts to tighten.

My eyes spring open and meet his in the mirror to see him standing behind me. I can't breathe. The collar around my neck is so tight that it's taking away my air.

I try to tell him, but nothing comes out of my mouth. Instead, I'm gasping for breath.

He moves to stand in front of me. Crouching down, he runs his tatted knuckles through my tears. "It's an inflatable posture collar." He informs me. "The more I inflate it, the more it cuts off your air." He holds up a black pump in his hand, and his tatted fingers wrap around the bulb, squeezing it once more.

My wide eyes remain on his and my face throbs from the lack of oxygen while my pussy clenches on the toy it's filled with.

He opens the valve, and the collar deflates. I gasp in a burning breath before choking. He waits patiently for me to get myself under control.

"You're beautiful, Eve." He tells me, and I blink away the tears that fill my eyes. "You don't need to be ashamed of who you are."

I try to adjust myself, but I'm on the floor with my knees tucked underneath me, my arms cuffed behind my back, and a posture collar on that has the potential to choke me. He has total control of me, and I'm dripping wet for him.

His eyes search mine. "I love you and I'm going to keep reminding you of that until you believe it."

"I…do," I whisper hoarsely.

He tilts his head to the side. "I don't think you do. They brainwashed you, Eve."

I try to shake my head in denial, but the strict collar prevents it.

"I could see a hundred videos of you, and it wouldn't matter. The only things that matter now are…you're my Lady…my whore…my toy." His fingers drop to my breast and I lean into him. "I'm the only man who will touch you, play with you, and fuck you."

"I know," I assure him through the knot in my throat.

I'm so confused. Who I was and who he thinks I can be. I'll still be a useless whore. His useless Lady. He knows I want to run and hide from him, but he won't let me. Not this time.

"We've been here before, angel," he says, reading my mind. "You and me in a room on a yacht. I let you get away, but I told you that would never happen again. You can't escape me. Not even in your mind." He stands and I look up at him through my watery lashes. "This will be your first lesson."

He holds up the black bulb that has a small tube running to my collar. Kashton squeezes it twice, and it restricts my air but doesn't cut it off completely.

Then the toy he placed inside my pussy starts to vibrate. If I could moan, I would, but I can't do anything.

"Look at yourself, Eve," he demands.

My heavy eyes fall to the mirror in front of me and I see my reflection.

I vow.

You vow.

We vow.

It's written down my body in large black letters. "We took vows, angel. Vows that cannot and will not be broken."

I take a long breath, filling my lungs, then slowly release it. The vibration between my legs gets more intense, and my hips buck forward on their own. My body breaks out in a sweat, and I wish I could beg him to let me come.

He sits down behind me on the bed, his knees on either side of my shaking body. His tatted fingers gently touch the side of my face, pulling my hair to lay down my back. "Gorgeous." They fall to my

breasts, and they play with my hardened nipples. “You’re going to prove to me that you believe me.” His eyes are as cold as ice as they hold mine.

He’s going to retrain me. My husband knows that my memories are coming back. I shared too much. So he’s going to wipe them clean, and if I could speak, I’d thank him. I’d much rather be his whore than remember who I once was.

“Now”—he lets go and picks up a remote—“let’s get started.”

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SIXTY-ONE



KASHTON

When we landed in New York earlier today, I sent Sin out on a little shopping spree while Eve and I were at Hooke's house. I gave him a list—some things that I thought my wife would like.

By the way she's rocking her hips right now, I'd say I did pretty good.

She's remembering. I think it scares her more than anything. Everett has always been standoffish, and she's always run from me. She has a hard time believing that I want her; what if she never does?

I've seen enough videos now to notice the pattern. Her training. I'm going to have to do my own training but do it differently. They made her fear her future. I'm going to make her crave one. Evan had her for a year, I'm going to have her for the rest of her life. It will take time and persistence. This is a marathon, not a sprint, and I'm going to devote everything I have to it.

I pick up the bulb and squeeze it once more, watching her eyes get heavy in the mirror. "That's it, angel. How's your cunt?" I reach around and slide my hands between her shaking thighs. She tries to spread them for me, but the position doesn't give her much to work with.

Running two fingers over her pussy, I bring them to her face and smear her wetness through her tears. "That's my girl."

I turn up the vibrator, and her lips part on a silent gasp. Her shoulders pull back, pushing out her chest, and her lashes flutter. Her pouty lips are turning blue from lack of oxygen and her eyes are swimming in tears.

She slumps when I shut off the vibrator. And when I deflate the collar, she gasps and chokes out a sob. "Pl-ease?" She begs as a thin line of drool runs down her chin from not being able to breathe or swallow from the inflated collar.

"What do you want, Eve?" I command.

She closes her eyes before they meet mine in the mirror and whimpers. "Make me…" She swallows. "Make me forget."

It breaks my heart, but I can't go soft now. I was telling her the truth when I thought she was running and I told her I had been soft on her. My goal was never to hurt her. It was to love her. I've won. She's mine. But the more videos I watch, the more I understand just how hard on her I have to be for her to see that I love her. That she should love herself.

"Forget what?" My first rule of her training will be to make her say it.

Fresh tears fill her pretty green eyes before she answers. "Anyone before you."

I'll wipe every single one of them from her memory. She told me and the Lords at Blackout that Evan used submissive and cerebral conditioning. She was forced to watch porn while she came over and over. I'm going to make her watch herself while she gets off.

I turn on the vibrator, and she moans; heavy lashes fall closed. I pump the bulb, inflating the collar three times, and they open. "Watch yourself, angel. This is your second lesson." I pump it one more time, knowing it's not going to choke her out but will definitely hinder her breathing. "Open wide," I order.

She does as she's told, and I reach around, using my free hand to pull her lips back while my other places the bulb into her mouth. I then run my fingers in and around her lips and check to make sure she's not biting them or her tongue. "Be my good girl and hold it in your mouth for me."

She blinks rapidly while her body jerks involuntarily.

I check the clock on the nightstand. "You'll kneel like this for thirty minutes and remember how many times you come." Her shoulders tremble at my order. "Make sure to keep your mouth open. If you close it, you'll be biting down on the bulb, and it'll inflate the collar."

Her green eyes widen, realizing what I did. “I don’t want you to suffocate yourself.”

I run my fingers through her hair, feeling how soft it is. Her body stiffens and her lashes flutter. Once she rides it out, her shoulders slump and her heavy eyes find mine in the mirror.

“Good girl,” I praise her for coming.

She whimpers around the bulb shoved into her mouth. Her hips pick up immediately, riding the vibration between her legs that continues.

I give her a reassuring smile in the mirror. “It’s okay to enjoy it, angel.”

Her drool-covered chest is heaving. Her collar is inflated enough to apply pressure, allowing her to breathe just enough to not pass out on me. That would defeat the purpose of her training.

“Let’s add a little something.” I get up, and she mumbles nonsense as I retrieve an item from the bag and return to my seat on the side of the bed directly behind her. I want to be able to see her in the mirror.

Leaning around, I grip her breast and attach the Japanese Clover nipple clamp. She cries out, biting down on the bulb in her mouth, and her eyes go wide with panic. “Careful,” I warn her. She blinks rapidly to clear the tears from her vision. I apply the other one, loving the way she whimpers and letting the chain fall to lie across her chest.

I slip my fingers into the collar to test the tightness. “You’re going to make yourself pass out.”

She’s gasping for breath around the bulb that has reinflated itself in her mouth. Drool covers her lips, chin, and trembling thighs.

“Once your time is up, I’ll remove that bulb and let you beg me to fuck your pretty face.” I reach around, grab the chain linked to the nipple clamps, and pull on them, smiling at the scream that comes from her stuffed lips. “And then you’ll thank me.”

After I was done fucking my wife, I crawled into bed with her, and she fell asleep in my arms, but I couldn’t join her. I slid out of bed

and made another drink. I sit in the chair in the corner of the owner's suite with a glass of scotch, staring down at my wedding ring. I can't speak for my wife, but I can say everything I went through was worth getting to this point in my life. And I vow to make sure that I give her a life that's worth it too.

I'm preparing myself for the shit show we'll return to. Saint didn't mention my tracker when I saw him at Blackout. Haidyn will be mad when he finds out I married his sister.

He'll think I planned this. But didn't I? This is what I wanted. I can't hide from him that she had an assignment and is returning as my Lady. I don't want to keep the fact that I'm her husband a secret. I'm proud of her and to have her as mine.

Sin left right after the wedding. He took Hooke's helicopter to catch his own jet back to Pennsylvania and asked when we planned on going home. I told him a couple of days. He promised to send it back when we're ready. I'd rather stay out here on this yacht where no one can touch us. But that's not life. The honeymoon will have to come to an end at some point.

My phone rings again, and I get up to answer it on the nightstand. I glance to make sure she's still asleep.

"Hello?" I answer softly.

"Hey, man," Ryat says. "I know you two are away, so I'll make this quick. I spoke to Gregory Mallory."

I frown. "The judge?"

"Yeah. He owes me. Anyway, after we left Blackout, I started thinking…in order for them to arrest Everett, they'd have to have an arrest warrant. One that a judge has to sign off on."

"Has he?" If that's the case, we'll just stay here where they can't touch her.

"No. He said they haven't even submitted the affidavit yet. If something changes, he'll let me know."

"Thanks…"

"He also said if the warrant comes across his desk, he'll deny it."

"Thanks, man. I appreciate it."

We hang up, and I set my phone on the nightstand and return to the chair. I plop down and take another drink.

"No."

The sound of my wife has me glancing up at where she's lying in the bed, but I must be hearing things, because she's sound asleep. Her naked body twisted in the dark sheets.

"Kashton…please don't…stop."

She's reliving her hallucination in her sleep. I drop my glass and rush over.

"Everett." I sit down next to her.

"Stop it." She arches her back.

"Eve." I nudge her shoulder to wake her up, and she goes feral. Kicking and screaming. I sit on top of her, and she manages to slap me.

"Eve," I bark, grabbing her flailing arms by the wrists and holding them down on either side of her head.

Her lashes open and wide green eyes look up into mine.

"You're okay, angel. It was just a nightmare," I assure her.

Her body softens under mine, but her eyes frantically scan the room, trying to confirm what I told her.

I let go of her wrists and get up off her.

She slowly rises to sit, still trying to catch her breath. Unwrapping herself from the covers, she gets up and walks into the bathroom while I silently remain sitting on the edge of the bed and wait for her to return.

After a few minutes, she comes out and walks over to the minibar, where she pours a drink and takes a sip. Hooke's staff had the yacht prepared for a celebration. "This is what they wanted," she says softly.

"What who wanted?" I don't know what she sees when she sleeps at night. And she hasn't shared anything else about what she saw during her hallucination. But if I had to guess, I'd say the training I put her through a few hours ago is what caused her nightmare.

My eyes scan the vows that I wrote with a Sharpie on her chest and stomach, and I smile to myself.

"The Lords. They want me to go crazy. They didn't want you to marry me, so they made sure I would lose my mind so that you would have to lock me up in the basement at Carnage."

I get up, stepping into her. “That’s not going to happen.”

It does make me wonder how far off she is. Haidyn thinks she’s suicidal, but Saint hasn’t voiced his opinion on that yet. Evan keeps sending us videos of her training at Dollhouse. Maybe they’ve planted doubts in my brothers’ minds so that when I refuse to enslave her, it’ll cause a fight. Separate us more than we have been lately. What connection does Evan have with the Lords? Why would they be on his side?

“Think about it…my assignment was pointless,” she states, and I frown. “I didn’t have to kill anyone or prove myself. They just wanted to get inside my head.”

I hadn’t thought of it that way, but she’s not wrong. Assignments are usually to prove your loyalty. What’s the point of making her see me hurt her? What’s it got to do with loyalty to the Lords? Maybe they wanted her to be terrified of me? Walk away from me? I won’t ever let that happen.

“You’re the only person to ever pretend to love me,” comes her soft voice.

“I’m not pretending.” How could she think that? I knew she’d need more training than just kneeling in front of a mirror one time. She told me that she knew I loved her, and now she’s saying something different. It’s that doubt that creeps in when she remembers what she went through. “I do love you.”

She ignores my confession. “They want me to fear you. Taint your image in my mind. That’s why they had you take me to Dollhouse. Why my hallucination made me your offering.”

That…doesn’t make any sense. “An offering?” I repeat and she nods. “How so?”

She bites her bottom lip. “You tied me up…and let men line up to rape me. Said that the Lords wanted you to prove that I was useless.”

I’ve never told her she was useless because she can’t give me an heir. That was her mind playing tricks on her. Just like the Lords wanted.

“You gave them razor blades, and after you watched them rape me, they got to cut me.” She lowers her voice. “Anywhere but my face.”

My hands fist. “I would never—”

“It doesn’t matter what you would or wouldn’t do,” she shouts, interrupting me. “All they needed was to plant the thought.” Huffing, she takes another drink. “I’ve literally puked at the idea of me and Evan, and that’s the part you played in my hallucination. Why, Kash?” she barks at me. “Why did I see you instead of him?”

“They wanted me to scare you,” I say through gritted teeth.

“Exactly.” She throws her arms out wide. “And they know I can’t give you kids.”

She’ll never get over the fact that she can’t get pregnant. “I don’t need children.” I thought we discussed this last night.

“Funny.” She snorts. “When we were hiding out at Blackout, you were ready to adopt as many kids as I wanted.”

I can’t win with this conversation, so I say nothing to that.

“But don’t you see?”

“It doesn’t matter.”

“Of course it fucking matters,” she shouts.

I open my mouth, but before I can speak, my cell rings. She turns and picks it up off the nightstand. “It’s Saint.” She hands it out to me with a sigh.

Why the fuck is he calling me this late? I hit Answer. “What?” I growl. They know I’m away with her.

“The woman didn’t make it,” he says in greeting.

I give my wife my back and run a hand down my face, then hang up without even responding. What is there to say? I toss my phone into the chair in the corner.

“What did he have to say?” Eve asks.

I turn back to face her and see her standing there with her hands on her hips, waiting for my response. “The woman passed.”

Without a word, she turns, enters the en suite bathroom, and slams the door shut.

It’s time for another lesson. Another reminder that it doesn’t matter what she saw in her hallucination. This is her life now.

I grab some things from the bag and enter the bathroom. She’s standing at the sink, washing her face. Her narrowed eyes meet

mine before they drop to the cuffs and collar in my hands. "I'm not in the mood." She turns off the water and grabs a towel.

I smile to myself. The honeymoon isn't over yet. "I'll take that challenge."

EVERETT

Kashton brings the car to a stop in the circle drive at Carnage. I stay in the passenger seat until he opens my door. It's not that I can't do it myself, it's because I'm reluctant to return. Worried about how things will go.

It's been over a week since I ran out of here and he chased me to the run-down motel. Kashton told me he's been avoiding his brothers, and I hate that I'm the reason. They are all he has. I don't want to come between them.

I could feel the tension between them when we had our meeting at Blackout. And I never asked Kashton what was said after I went up to the apartment. He didn't offer up any information, so I figured he didn't want to share.

He grabs my hand, and we enter the building and ride up to their office in silence. He holds the door for me, and we step into the room.

Saint and Haidyn are arguing but stop mid-sentence when we walk in. All eyes swing to us. Even Ashtyn and Charlotte are present.

Haidyn turns to fully face us and takes a step in our direction.

I step back, but Kashton's hand in mine stops my retreat. So does Haidyn. He looks away and runs a hand down his face. I'm not ready to have the uncomfortable conversation with him. That's why Kashton is going to do it alone. We discussed it on the way back from New York.

"Will you girls give me and my brothers a minute?" Kashton asks, breaking the uncomfortable silence.

Ashtyn looks like she wants to stay, but Saint takes her hand, pulling her from his chair, silently telling her to get the fuck out. Charlotte kisses my brother on the cheek, and Kashton turns to face me. "I'll be right there," he assures me, and I nod.

The girls and I get into the elevator, and since I was first stepping on, I press the button for the birdcage. Ashtyn begins to laugh. "Se-

riously?" Her eyes drop to my ring. "How did you get Kash to propose to you so soon?"

"Well, for starters, I didn't fuck his best friends," I remark.

She huffs, and Charlotte's eyes go wide while she bites her lip to try and hide her smile. The moment the door slides open, Ashtyn stomps off and rushes to her room, slamming the door shut behind her.

I know I'm baiting her. If I'd be nice, it would be easier, but I've never been fake. I'm not going to pretend I don't know what she did to Saint and his brothers. Or that she left them high and dry for four years.

I've fallen in love with Kashton, against my better judgment. Still, I couldn't imagine shooting him and leaving him for dead and then just forgetting he ever existed. I would give my life for him. That is what a Lady does. When you marry a Lord, you no longer get to think about yourself. You're part of a team. And I know that Kashton would do anything for me, therefore I will give him nothing less of me.

Stopping at Kashton's door, Charlotte gets my attention. "Haidyn would never hurt you."

I turn to face her. Giving her a soft smile, I speak. "I know." Everyone in the office saw me take a step back from Haidyn. It wasn't because I'm afraid of him, though. I'm just used to being on my own. Kashton is all-consuming, and I know Haidyn wants to make up for lost time. The two of them will be suffocating.

"He's confused." She sighs heavily. "Worried…he wants to be a big brother and protect you, but he thinks you hate him." Her eyes drop to the floor, lowering her voice. "Because of what your guys' father did to you—selling you to Dollhouse."

I know he knows more than that, and I wonder if he's told his wife. I glance away and run a hand through my hair nervously. "It wasn't his fault." You don't get to pick your parents. And in our world, they're pretty much all pieces of shit. It's rare to find someone who actually cares about you. And if you do, you're one of the lucky ones.

"Haidyn protects who he loves, and he hates that he wasn't able to do that for you." She adds, "I know you have Kashton, but I just want you to know that Haidyn would do anything for you if you'd let him into your life." With that, she turns and enters their room.

I open Kashton's door and fall onto the bed, staring up at his ceiling. I wish we were still in New York, drinking champagne and eating chocolate-covered strawberries on a yacht while floating out on the ocean. But nothing about my life has ever been a honeymoon. Life must go on at some point. And we've returned to it.

The door opens, and I shoot up to see my husband enter. "How did it go?" I ask right away.

He removes his cell and the keys to his car from his pockets, tossing them onto the nightstand. "Haidyn is pissed, and Saint didn't say a word."

"What is Haidyn mad about exactly?" I nibble on my lip.

"That I married you."

Right. Because I'm not good enough for his best friend. I drop my head, and Kash lifts it by placing his finger under my chin and forcing me to tilt my head back. "He's pissed that he wasn't there," he corrects himself.

Pulling away, I nod to myself.

"I'm going to take a shower. Join me?"

"Yeah," I answer, and he's already heading to the bathroom. "But I think I should talk to Haidyn first." I don't want him to think I'm afraid of him.

"He went to the basement." He reaches up and removes his T-shirt. "He'll be down there for a while." Kashton starts the shower.

Turning, I exit the bedroom and ride the elevator down to the basement. I'm not a coward, and I don't want my brother to think I'm one.

I exit when the door opens and step out, passing through the plastic curtain strips, and don't see him in the pits area.

Continuing on through the hallway, I see a woman ahead of me. She looks frail. Her head is down, and her dirty hair covers her bare shoulders.

The sound of "Hallelujah" by No Resolve echoes throughout the hall, and I know Haidyn is in the process of torturing someone. He's been in a sour mood because of me. Even Charlotte won't be able to pull him out of it. I'll have to do it.

I know a part of Charlotte likes that about him. No Lady willingly gives herself to a Lord without knowing what he's capable of. You have to crave that kind of darkness to allow it into your life.

The woman's bare feet drag across the concrete floor, and she holds a piece of rope in her right hand that pulls a baby doll behind her. Looking up, her eyes meet mine, and my heart races when she speaks. "They took my baby." Her voice is raspy as she steps into me, and I turn my shoulders to avoid her touching me.

"They took my baby," she repeats, shoving my chest and pushing my back against the cold concrete wall.

I go to shove her in return, but she's yanked away before I get the chance. "Laura." Haidyn places himself between us. The smell of blood hits my nose when I see it's all over his clothes. "What are you doing out of your cell?"

"THEY TOOK MY BABY!" she screams.

"Here it is." He bends down and picks up the doll and holds it out to her. The rope she grips is wrapped around the doll's neck several times. It's naked, an eye missing and covered in dirt. One of the arms is twisted backward.

Her wild eyes go from his to mine, and I wonder if she knows who I am. She looks back at Haidyn, throwing the baby to the floor.

He sighs. "Come on. Let's put you back where you belong."

She begins to scream at the top of her lungs. The screeching sound makes my ears hurt. He bends down, wraps his arm around her thighs, and picks her up, throwing her over his shoulder, then carries her down the hallway while she drags the baby behind them.

I follow after him, passing cell after cell until we come to an opening. It has a set of stairs on either side that goes up to the second floor of cells. The basement is huge. Covers the entire length of the building. I've been everywhere down here. I could navigate it with my eyes closed.

Haidyn throws her in the cell, making sure to toss the doll in there as well, and slams it shut, locking it.

Turning around, he looks surprised to see me. "Are you lost, Eve?" His voice is cold, and I swallow nervously. "Kash isn't down here."

"I was looking for you," I tell him, and my tongue feels heavy all of a sudden.

His eyes soften, and he looks hopeful, asking, "What do you need?"

"I was wondering if you wanted to have lunch with me tomorrow?" I ask nervously.

"Of course." He frowns as if there isn't another option.

I take a step back, nodding awkwardly. "Okay. I'll see you then." Before I can make a fool of myself, I rush through the hallway and to the elevator.

Stepping into Kashton's room, I lean against the door and close my eyes, trying to catch my breath as my shaking hands come up to my face.

"What took you so long?"

I jump at the sound of my husband's voice. Dropping my hands, I see him standing in the bedroom with a towel wrapped around his hips, water still dripping down his tatted chest. "I'm having lunch with my brother tomorrow," I say, trying to wrap my head around it.

There's so much happening so fast. I went from having no one but myself to rely on to having a husband and a brother who has a wife of his own and babies on the way. I've got a family.

Kashton strolls over to me and gently kisses my forehead. "That's great, angel."

The following afternoon, I'm standing in our bedroom when there's a knock on the door. I take a shaky breath and run my hands down my shirt. I'm so nervous. I've been around Haidyn several times, but never just the two of us. And never as brother and sister. Opening the door, I find Haidyn standing in the hallway.

He places his hands in his jeans pockets and rocks back on the heels of his boots. He's nervous too. That helps me a little. Neither one of us knows what to say or what to talk about. Our childhood is

out of the question, and I've married his best friend. What else is there to know?

"Ready?" He clears his throat.

"Yep." I nod and close the door behind me. Kashton left early this morning. He said he had somewhere to be and that he'd meet me back here after my lunch with Haidyn. I've been too nervous to worry about where he went.

We get into the elevator just as the door at the other end of the hall opens, and I get a glimpse of Ashtyn stepping out of her and Saint's room, giving me a *go-to-hell* look before the elevator door closes.

I follow him to the garage, and he opens the door for me to get into his black Lamborghini. As we pull out of the gates of Carnage, he says, "What type of music do you like to listen to?"

Is he like me? Does he have to have noise too? I know for most, it's just habit to get in the car and turn the radio on. "Anything. Doesn't matter."

He fiddles with the controls for a moment, and then "Hate Me" by Blue October starts to play through the speakers. He keeps it low enough that we could have a conversation if we had something to talk about, but instead, we choose silence.

Carnage sits out in the middle of nowhere by itself, so it takes a good thirty minutes to get anywhere when you're not speeding. The particular restaurant we go to takes us forty-five minutes.

He opens the door for me to enter, and I thank him before he tells the hostess his name. We're taken to our table and sit across from one another. It makes me wonder if he chose this place or if Charlotte did. Either way, I like the fact that they took the time to get reservations at a nice, quiet restaurant.

We each order a water, and I rub my sweaty hands on my jean-clad thighs. I don't know why I wanted to do this. I should have begged Charlotte to join us. At least then we'd have a buffer. It's not that I didn't want her to join us. I think she would have insisted we go alone. She wants Haidyn and me to have this time together.

Picking up the menu, I cover my face and try to calm my racing heart.

"I guess congratulations are in order," he finally says.

Setting down the menu, I see he's staring at my wedding ring. "Yeah. Thank you."

"You wanted to elope?" He frowns as if that's hard for him to believe.

"I didn't think anyone would want to be there," I say truthfully. He stares at me intently, and it makes me shift in my seat. "Not like I'd expected you to give me away or anything." I give a nervous laugh.

"I would have," he answers, and my stomach knots. He pulls his cell from his pocket, and after unlocking it, he shows it to me.

It's a group text. I arch a brow at the name. "My bitches?" I ask with a smirk.

"Sin named the group." He rolls his eyes.

I laugh softly and look over the picture that Sin sent to him and Saint. It's of Sin, me, and Kashton. The one he took with our champagne flutes on Hooke's yacht. I sit back and sigh. "We didn't know he was coming. We used his jet, and he just showed up right before takeoff."

I don't want Haidyn to think that I purposely left him out. It wasn't like that at all.

He locks his cell and puts it away. "Why…" He pauses. "Why didn't you come to me?" His eyes drop to the table before glancing back at mine. "Why didn't you want to know me?"

I hate that I am the way I am. That I prefer to be by myself. I've become my father. I've made others feel less than because of my actions. "It wasn't you. I've always been a no one, and I think it was hard for me to admit that you were my brother."

He frowns.

I weave my fingers together on the table as I speak. "I was at the cathedral the night Bill was telling you about the breeders and what Charlotte's future looked like." I sigh. "Bill was already with Isabella when he saved me, and I stayed clear of her. For good reason. So when I found out you were with Charlotte, I had to remain staying away from you."

"I haven't been with Charlotte for very long." He calls my bluff, sitting back in the seat and crossing his tatted arms over his chest.

"You've been my sister your entire life."

Looking away, I answer, "I couldn't go back to Carnage." Dropping my eyes, I add, "I fought too hard for too long to get away from there."

"You went back for Kashton," he reminds me.

Fuck. I want to crawl under the table and hide. "Rejection was also a factor."

"Rejection?"

I knew he was nothing like our father, but that didn't mean he'd accept who I am. "What if I tried to speak to you and you wanted nothing to do with me? Or what if you didn't believe me? I'd feel like a fool. I've done just fine on my own, and I didn't need anyone else."

"Look"—he runs a hand over his hair—"I want to get to know you, but I'm not going to force a brother-sister relationship. Just know that I'm here if you need me."

I nod and pick up the menu once again, but I can't concentrate on anything that's written on it. We're out for lunch. Just the two of us. There's a reason… "Why did you pick her?" I ask, slamming the menu down harder than I mean to.

His eyes meet mine while he slowly lowers his to the table. "Pick who for what?"

"The other woman. That night at Carnage. Why did you choose her to be the one…" I lower my voice to whisper. "To die? Why not me?"

He sighs, looking away from me. "I picked her because of Garrett." His eyes come back to mine. "He never even gave the other woman a single look. He was focused on nothing but you. And I knew…he wanted me to pick you. So I picked the other one."

I'm silent for a long second, letting his words sink in. And then I burst out laughing. He quickly looks around the quiet restaurant before giving me his attention once more. "You're telling me, I'm alive today out of spite?"

He chuckles and picks up his water. "Yeah."

I laugh harder, and he joins me.

He takes a sip and places his drink on the table. "In all seriousness, I'm sorry about everything."

I shake my head. "None of it's your fault."

"I guess we're even, huh?"

I frown, not understanding what he means.

"Bill told us that you were the one who told him I was in Dollhouse. That you reached out to Evan, and he confirmed I was there…you saved me."

I drop my gaze to the table, catching sight of him twirling his wedding ring.

"I owe you everything, Eve." He speaks softly, and I look up at him through my lashes. "Because of you, I get to be with my wife and be a father."

I sit in my bed and read over the text that Adam just sent me. My heart racing, I bite my bottom lip and call the last person I want to talk to. It's not even an option. It rings once before his voice fills my ear. "Well, hello, dolly."

My teeth grind. "I need a favor."

He chuckles, and it makes me sick to my stomach. "It'll cost you. How much depends on what it is."

"Haidyn," I start. "I think Isabella has him."

He snorts but doesn't say anything.

"I think he's at Dollhouse, but I need verification." I bite my nail. I can't go back there. No matter how much I want to save Haidyn. This is my only option. Plus, Isabella will know something is up if I walk into that hell. She wouldn't let me near him.

Evan sighs. "I'll see what I can do, but I can't promise anything. And Eve…you owe me either way. Understand?"

"Yes, sir," I whisper, feeling a knot in my stomach.

"Someone had to stop her. I knew your brothers could do it," I tell him honestly. The Spade brothers would have done anything for each other, and I knew they would burn that place down to get him back.

Haidyn nods and sighs. "I know it doesn't mean much now, but had I known I had a sister, I promise your life would have been different."

I swallow the knot in my throat at his words. I believe him. Charlotte wasn't wrong. Haidyn will go to hell for the people he loves. I

never realized until now how much I needed to hear that. That someone would have stepped up and protected me. "It means something. And thank you," I tell him.

He gestures for our server to come take our orders. I haven't even looked to see what they have. "And I don't doubt that you can take care of yourself, but if Kashton hurts you, just know, I'll break his fucking legs."

I laugh and the server comes over. Once he walks away, I tell my brother, "I'll keep that in mind."

Sitting here with Haidyn makes me think of Ashtyn. I think this could be a part of why I dislike her. She grew up with four guys who would have done anything for her. Hell, they did, and she gave it up. I watched her fuck it all away in Vegas while they were being punished here for her actions because she thought her husband was dead.

I've been cheering Haidyn and Charlotte on since Bill had Haidyn meet him at the cathedral.

I exit the cathedral just as I watch the bike pull out onto the two-lane road. I make my way down to the Rolls-Royce Wraith, and the driver opens the back passenger door for me. I slide in, and he shuts the door but makes no move to get behind the wheel. He remains standing outside the car.

Pulling my cell out, I speak. "A little harsh, don't you think?" I say to Bill, who sits next to me. He just had Haidyn meet him at the cathedral in the middle of the night to show him Charlotte's fate as a breeder if she fails her assignment. I was hiding in the back, eavesdropping.

"That's what Haidyn needed. He can't help but be a savior."

My phone beeps in my lap and I read the text from ***Fuckface****.*

You free tonight?

I type back.

Yes.

It beeps again.

The bar. 11 P.M. Info to come…

"He's going to get you killed," Bill states, openly gawking at my cell.

"We're all going to die." I lock the screen.

"Eve," he growls. "The Lords are going to find him. He can't run forever."

"How is that my problem?"

"They're going to take out everyone around him. I won't let you be collateral damage."

"Tell me about Charlotte," I urge. "How did you meet her?" I know their story, but I want him to tell me.

He rubs the back of his neck nervously while a smile plays on his lips. "She was my therapist."

My brows arch. "Therapy? No offense but you don't seem like the type to sit through therapy sessions." We were raised to not have feelings. All Lords are machines. You kill, you fuck, you groom your children to do the same. If someone is forcing you to seek therapy, it's to manipulate you.

Chuckling, he nods to himself. "It's a long story."

"I've got time," I say, holding my arms out wide.

He doesn't hesitate to tell me about how he met Charlotte and tricked her into marrying him with Adam's help. His smile is infectious as he talks about her like she's the only woman in the world. And I know that in his eyes, Ashtyn could never compare to his wife.

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SIXTY-TWO



KASHTON

We're all gathered at Blackout for a meeting. While Eve was out to lunch with Haidyn, Hooke called Saint and wanted to get us all together. So I shot Haidyn a text to just meet us here since they were already in town.

I'm lounging in a chair, sitting at a round table with Ryat and Sin. Colton is sitting on top of the bar next to Finn. Alex and Jenks are in a booth over to my right.

The club is currently closed since it's the middle of the day, so we didn't have to hide in his office.

The door opens, and I look up to see Haidyn holding it for Eve to enter. I stand and walk toward her. "Hello, angel." I open my arms, and she steps into me. "Everything okay?" I ask softly into her hair.

"Yes," she assures me.

I let out a sigh of relief. I want her to have a relationship with Haidyn. One that a brother and sister are supposed to have. She needs that. To know that people care about her. I'm all she'll ever need, but one day I will no longer be here.

"What's going on?" Haidyn asks, pulling his pack of cigarettes out of his pocket and lighting one up. "What did I miss?"

"Not much. Hooke should be here any moment," Ryat answers.

"Did he find Hailey?" Haidyn wonders.

I shrug. "Wouldn't tell us. Just said that he needed to meet with us. He landed twenty minutes ago." I sit in my chair and pull my wife onto my lap.

I don't miss the way Colton's eyes go from Eve to Haidyn, wondering why she arrived with him but is sitting on my lap. No one here

other than Haidyn, Saint, and Sin knows she's my wife. Sin doesn't even know she's Haidyn's sister.

Tyson walks out from the back with Hooke next to him. Hooke pulls out a barstool, and Tyson chooses to remain standing.

"The Mason brothers were able to get me a number. I've managed to track it down, and he's here." This is what he must have been doing in Vegas while we were at his place in New York.

"What's the plan?" Sin asks.

"Well, I don't really have one. We need to lure him in, that way we can trap him and find out where she is."

"I'll do it," Eve states.

"No." Haidyn shakes his head.

She huffs and pushes off my lap. "Give me her phone number," she orders Hooke.

He looks at me, and I nod. I'm interested to see where her mind is going. If I think it's not safe, I'll squash it.

She pulls out her cell, and he rattles off Hailey's number. Eve types away for a second and then places her phone on the table in front of me.

"Eve," Haidyn growls.

"It'll be fine," she assures him. "Like Hooke said, we have to lure him in. Blackout is the best place. All of you will be here."

"What did you send her?" Ryat asks.

"I pretended to be an old friend. Told her that she was right and I dumped my piece-of-shit boyfriend and got a new number. I asked if she could meet up, told her I'd love to tell her all about it at Blackout tonight. Drinks on me."

"Won't work," Hooke tells my wife. "Her phone is off. It's been out of use since she went missing."

Eve's cell beeps. I look at it sitting on the table and read her incoming text out loud. "Can't wait to hear all the tea."

Saint frowns. "How did he answer that if Hailey's phone is off?"

"They've forwarded all of her incoming messages and calls," I answer.

Ryat nods, confirming. "I've done it before." He smiles proudly. "It's actually pretty easy to do. You install an app on your phone and

theirs, and it sends you everything their number receives…texts, emails, calls…and you make it appear that you're responding from the number they reached out to if need be. You also have access to their search history or any app that they use. It's literally like you're looking at their phone on your own."

"I don't care. I don't like it." Haidyn voices his opinion.

"It'll be fine." Eve rolls her eyes. "Seriously, all of you will be here. I'll be at the bar when he shows. I'll make it obvious I'm waiting for someone. He'll sit down, strike up a conversation, and dig to see if I'm here alone and who I'm waiting for. After a little while, when she doesn't show, he'll want to leave. I'll have him follow me outside, you guys grab him and stick him in the car and take him to Carnage. Simple."

"It's never that simple," Haidyn argues.

"Why not keep him at Blackout?" Alex questions. "Tyson has a basement, and you don't have to take him far. We have the bartender slip him something and we just drag him down the steps."

Hooke shakes his head. "I don't want him here. The best place for him is Carnage. I want to see how he reacts when he finds out Isabella is there." He looks at me, and I stand, handing Eve back her cell. "See if they have a connection like I suspect."

"Your safety comes first. If I think he's getting shady, it's over," I tell my wife.

"With all of us watching, what could happen?" Alex asks, arms out wide, and Haidyn snorts.

EVERETT

Checking the time on my phone, I see it's almost midnight. I've been sitting here since ten o'clock. I never mentioned a time in my text, but the party doesn't start until after eleven. Everyone knows that.

The guys are all over Blackout tonight. Ryat and Sin have been sitting in a round booth right off the dance floor for as long as I've been perched at the bar.

Kashton is standing up on the breezeway with Saint. I haven't seen Haidyn, but I know he's here too because we rode together. Thankfully, he gave up his argument about how bad of an idea this is.

I can handle myself. I know I wasn't always like this, but I like to think I've come a long way since I was that scared little girl. I kill grown-ass men. Sure, there have been some close calls, but it's always worked out. This one won't be any different.

I'm going to play whatever part I have to in order to help them find this missing woman. I hate to tell Hooke, but it's been weeks. If she's part of the human trafficking ring, she's been sold and is long gone. If she's lucky, she's dead. But even if that's the case, she should be laid to rest. Everyone is entitled to peace, and her family deserves to pay their respects.

"Is this seat taken?"

I look over to see a man standing beside me. He looks young. Mid-twenties, dressed in light-wash jeans and a plain white T-shirt. His blond hair is combed over, and it makes him look like a jock.

He's my guy.

I bite my bottom lip, looking around nervously. "Yeah. My friend is running late as usual." Reaching out, I go to pull the barstool from his hand, but he doesn't let go of it.

"How about I sit until she gets here?" he offers. "Promise, I'll get up the moment she arrives."

Sure, you will. I nod and he gives me a charming smile. I pick up my drink and take a sip from the thin straw.

"Do you come here a lot?" he asks.

I shake my head. "I used to, but I moved away a couple of years ago with my boyfriend." I roll my eyes. Kashton wasn't happy that I had to take my wedding ring off. I told him to keep it in his pocket so I could have it back as soon as we get this piece of shit outside.

"Sounds like there's a story there." He laughs, signaling for a bartender.

"He cheated. I left. That's all there is." I finish off my drink as the bartender walks over and takes his order. I allow him to get me another one. "How about you?" I look to see if he's wearing a ring. I'm surprised he isn't. They use men like him to pick up women—charming and good looking. They lure you into a back alley where they throw you into the trunk of a car, and then the world never sees you again. Your life is gone. Over. And you wish that you'd just die. You'd

be surprised how much your body and mind can endure when you wish either one would just give up.

"She also cheated on me," he answers.

The bartender places our drinks down on the bar, and we both pick them up, turning to face one another, and tap the glasses together. "Fuck them," I say, and he smiles, tossing his back, and I take a sip of mine.

"Yeah. Fuck them." He winks, and I want to roll my eyes but instead, I bat my lashes.

Pretty sure that was him telling me he'd rather fuck me, but whatever. That's not happening, but I can play along.

He stands and motions to the bartender to return. When he does, he orders two shots before he turns to walk away.

I arch a brow. "Leaving me already?"

Smirking, he shakes his head. "Save my seat?"

"Sure."

He walks away and disappears into the crowd. I keep my eyes on my phone that sits by my drink and have to hide my smile when I see I have a new text from the same number that Hooke had given me earlier.

Can't make it.

Of course she can't. The thought sends a chill up my spine. The poor woman is gone, and Hooke will probably never find her. I hope the Lords beat the living shit out of this guy.

He returns to his seat. "Well, fuck," I sigh, slamming my cell down.

"What's wrong?" he asks, placing his hand on my thigh. I stiffen, and he removes it just as quickly.

I push my hair off my shoulder, hoping that my husband didn't see that because he will most definitely blow my cover. "My girlfriend canceled." I frown. "I was really wanting to see her."

"Well, no reason for the night to go to waste." He shrugs.

"What do you have in mind?" I look him over as if I'm interested. Not like I need to give him that impression. Men don't care if you want them or not. They don't ask for permission.

"Let's have another drink and then take this to a party."

There's always a party. It's funny how predictable they all are. "Sounds good." I down what's left of mine while he orders another.

I pick up my cell and send a text to the group chat that Kashton added me to this afternoon.

Get ready.

Then I turn my cell off. I don't need a response, and I don't want this man to read my texts.

I take a quick look over my left shoulder and up to the breezeway, noticing Kashton isn't there. My eyes quickly scan the club. It's useless, though. The neon lights flash to the bass of the music, so it's hard to focus on much.

Something wet drops on my thigh and I look down, running my fingers through it, smearing it over my skin. Frowning, I look at my hand and rub my fingers over the oily substance. I take the bar napkin and wipe it off along with my thigh. Then feel up under the bar to see if something is dripping, but it's dry.

Weird.

"Here you go."

I wad up the napkin and toss it onto the bar, then take the shot from him. We clank them together once more and down them.

Without another word, we get up, and I follow him through the club and out the back door where I immediately step to the right for Alex and Colton to jump him. The poor bastard never saw it coming. He tries fighting back, but they get him tossed into the back of the Cadillac SUV and drive off, squealing the tires within seconds.

Kashton grabs my hand and pulls me toward my car, opening the door for me. I crawl into the back while he takes the driver's seat and Hooke gets in the passenger side. We had to bring mine for the back seat, and I'm still cramped back here.

My body starts to heat up, and I rub my hands on my bare thighs. Sighing heavily, I lean my head back and close my eyes. My skin is tingling.

"You okay, Eve?"

Looking up, I see Kashton's pretty blue eyes staring at me in the rearview mirror. "Of course," I answer him.

He gives me a smile that makes my thong wet. Fuck, I want to sit on his face so bad. I can't wait to get back to Carnage.

Hooke turns to look at me and frowns. "Are you going to get sick? You had quite a bit to drink."

I want to argue that I can hold my liquor, but instead I say, "I'm fine." Just horny as fuck.

They fall back into a conversation while I gently rock my hips back and forth on the seat, imagining it being my husband's face while my hands are cuffed behind my back.

Kashton reaches around his seat and tucks his tatted hand under my heated knee, and I have to bite my lip to quiet a moan at his touch. I wish Hooke would have gone with the others so I could beg my husband to fuck me.

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SIXTY-THREE



KASHTON

I enter the basement with Eve's hand in mine. Everyone beat us back to Carnage. We took our time, knowing it would take them a little while to set the motherfucker up.

He kneels in the center of the room, still dressed and face bloody. Alex and Colton only hit him a couple of times. We're going to do the rest.

Sin digs into his back pocket and removes his wallet. "Maxwell," he states, reading off his license.

"Where is she?" Hooke demands, shoving the picture of his assistant in the man's face.

The guy throws his head back, laughing, and Hooke kicks him in the side, pushing him over. After a second, he sits up and his eyes go to my wife.

She stands by the wall, arms crossed over her chest and head down. I think she had a little too much to drink. Even with her high tolerance. We didn't expect him to take so long to arrive.

"How's the whore doing?" Maxwell asks, and I look back at him.

"Excuse me?" I ask. He'd better not be talking about my wife.

He smiles at Eve, his eyes lazily looking her up and down while he runs his tongue over his bloody lip. "Look at her. The bitch is begging to be fucked. It's too hard to resist."

"Eve?" I call her name, and she glances at me.

"I'm fine," she states, squaring her shoulders.

I storm over to her and grab her upper arms.

Her green eyes meet mine, and I search them, realizing that they're dilated. I reach up and touch her neck to feel her pulse, and

she leans into me. It's racing and her skin is clammy.

Licking her lips, she softly says, "I'm fine."

She's lying.

"Kash?" Haidyn demands, waiting for me to say something.

"He drugged her," I grind out.

She shakes her head. "No—"

The man's laughter interrupts her denial, and I turn around to see Haidyn punch Maxwell in the face, knocking him over. He yanks him up by his shirt and shoves him into the wall at his back.

His laughter just grows. "Why are you mad? I'm sure your friend will let you take your turn with his whore."

"She's my sister," Haidyn barks.

"What?" Ryat's wide eyes whip to her.

"Sister?" Tyson questions.

Everyone looks from Haidyn to me, but I don't pay them any attention. My focus is on my wife. She's practically panting. How did I not notice? I watched them carefully and never saw him put anything in her drink. Tyson even briefed the bartender beforehand so something like this wouldn't happen.

"Like father like son." Maxwell's laughter grows.

I spin around at that, and Haidyn shoves him toward me. I fist my hand and swing, knocking him in the face, and he falls to the floor, rolling to his side, groaning.

"How the fuck do you know my father?" Haidyn shouts, but the guy doesn't answer.

Sin grabs a chair and rolls it over to me. I help Eve to sit in it; I don't want her to fall off her heels and hurt herself.

"I'm fine…really." She's trying to convince me, but it's not working.

"What did you give her?" Hooke demands.

"Something that will make her a lot more fun." Maxwell gives a bloody grin.

"Take her to Devin," Saint suggests. "Have him push some fluids to get it out of her system."

"You can try, but that isn't going to work." The guy shakes his head.

Haidyn and Ryat start digging through the pockets of his jeans and find an unmarked white dropper bottle.

"And why is that?" I snap as Ryat hands it over to me. I unscrew the lid, holding it above the opening, and pinch it, watching drops fall back into the bottle. It's thick and has a cloudy tint to it. Definitely not eye drops.

"What the fuck is that?" Ryat wonders.

"It's a topical. You drop a little piece onto their skin and then they rub it in. Their body soaks it up," the guy explains.

I step toward him, and Maxwell smiles at me. "Go ahead, strip her naked, tie her up, and let each one of them have their turn, because you won't be able to satisfy her craving."

I look over at her sitting in the chair. Her legs are crossed while her knees bounce. Her skin is dewy, eyes heavy.

He goes on at my silence. "If you're not going to share her, you might as well tie her to your bed and put a vibrator up her cunt."

"I'm fine. I wiped most of it off with the bar napkin." She runs her hand over her thigh.

Wait a second…

"You knew he drugged you and didn't say anything?" Haidyn demands, thinking the same as I am, but she doesn't answer.

The man frowns as if not pleased with the fact that she rubbed it off. He looks her up and down. "Doesn't matter how much she *wiped off*, she'll still feel it. She'll have extreme mood swings. Depression lows and drug-induced highs. Isn't she suicidal?" His eyes meet mine. "I'd keep a close eye on her, if I were you."

I've heard enough. Walking over to her, I grab her hand and pull her to her feet. I'm starting to drag her out of the basement when he speaks again.

"She's the one, isn't she?"

I get a cold chill up my spine and come to a stop, turning to face him.

"The one what?" Saint asks, but I know what he's talking about.

"The woman who lures men to their deaths."

Saint and Alex both laugh like that's impossible. But Haidyn looks at me skeptically. He's thinking about it. He saw her work at the cathe-

dral when we picked up that prisoner for Carnage. "What's he talking about, Kash?" he asks.

Holding in a sigh, I lie. "No clue."

Maxwell laughs. "Lying to your brothers?" He makes a *tsking* sound. "They say pussy is the first thing to ruin a family."

"What the fuck is he talking about, Kashton?" Haidyn snaps. "Is she killing Lords?"

She steps toward him and yells, "I'm right fucking here. Quit talking about me like I'm not." But I pull her back.

The guy arches a brow as if to say *told you so*. Her anger has come out of nowhere, the drug amplifying her emotions.

"We'll discuss this later. She needs to see Devin." And with that, I yank her through the plastic strip curtains and into the elevator.

EVERETT

I'm so fucking horny. I tried to pretend like I'm not, but my pussy is soaked, my skin is tingling, and my knees want to give out so I can kneel in front of Kashton while he fucks my mouth.

The elevator door closes, and he pulls me into him. His hands cup either side of my face while his worried eyes search my heavy ones.

Rising up on my tiptoes, I press my lips to his.

"Eve." He pushes me back, frowning.

"Fuck me." I drop my hands to his belt and undo his buckle, but he catches my wrists, stopping me.

"As much as I want to fuck my wife, I need Devin to look at you first."

"It's just sex," I try and reason with him. We've done it a hundred times since he's come back into my life.

"He drugged you," he says through gritted teeth.

"I wiped most of it off." That wasn't a lie.

I bounce on my toes with need. I've never felt anything like this before. Even when I was at Dollhouse. Not that I can remember anyway. I'm desperate. Imagine if I had absorbed all of it or if he had given me the entire bottle.

The elevator comes to a stop, and he pulls me down the hallway and through the double doors to the hospital wing. He takes me to

an office where Devin sits behind his desk. He looks up, frowning, and stands. "Kash, everything okay?"

"No," he growls. "Eve's been drugged. Some kind of…cream…topical shit. I was wondering what you can do for her." His hand holds mine in a viselike grip. He's angry with me, and I want to make it right.

Devin walks over to me and takes my wrist, feeling my pulse, and then steps away. "Take her to exam room one. Get her in a gown, and I'll be right there."

"Kash, I promise, I'm okay," I whine while on the way to the room. "I just want to go to bed." *So you can fuck my brains out.*

"After he gives you the all clear." He kisses my forehead before running his hands up my legs as he slides them under my dress. I raise my hands above my head to let him slip it off me. Then he's picking me up and setting me on the table before he removes my heels.

I bite back a moan so he doesn't see how desperate I am, but it feels so good. His tatted hands on my heated skin. Like a lit match to gasoline. I'm on fire for my husband.

He places my arms in the gown's openings and pulls it closed, tying it off.

The door opens as Devin enters, and Kashton removes his hands and turns to talk to him. I groan in frustration. I tune them out as Kash hands him the eye dropper and rehashes what was said down in the basement.

"Fluids will help detox the liver," Devin insists. "I'll draw some blood and start an IV. Once it's done, I'll take another blood sample and compare."

I lie back on the table and close my eyes. So much for getting fucked. This could take all night.

The urge to kick and scream like a child is strong, but I tell myself that will just prove their point. I need to keep my emotions in check.

"Is there anything that we can use to wash it off with?" Kashton asks. "That has to help a little bit, right?"

"Yes, but I'm afraid it won't be much of a change. Her body has already absorbed most of it by now. You've touched her, right?"

"Yes," he growls. "What the fuck does that have to do with anything?"

"I'm just pointing out that she's absorbed it. That's why you can touch her and not get the same response."

Kashton runs a hand over his head, stressed. "How long does something like this last?"

Devin steps closer to him and lowers his voice. "Depending on what it is and the dosage she got…" He shrugs. "She could see side effects for up to several weeks."

"I'm horny, not deaf. I can hear you," I tell them, and Devin clears his throat.

Kashton walks over to me and takes my hand while Devin starts my IV in the other. He draws a tube of blood and then hooks me up to a drip. "Here. I'll leave you two be. Just use this to wash off the infected area. I'm going to go have tests run on the blood sample, then I'll be back."

As Devin exits the room, my husband lets go of my hand and walks to the other side of the bed. "Where was it? The exact area," Kash asks through gritted teeth.

I slide the gown up more than I need to and run my hand over my skin to show him where. He begins to wash it.

I look over his defined jaw and dark hair. As much as he is intimidating, he's also so handsome. The rough material of the washcloth on my skin has me breaking out in goose bumps. It's like the best back scratch. I reach out, grip his shirt, and pull him toward me. But before my lips can touch his, he pulls away.

"Eve," he warns.

"Please." I lift my hips off the exam table. "I'm begging you, Kash."

"Hey." He places the washcloth over my thigh and leans into me to push my hair out of my face. "I want to make sure you're safe, Eve."

I've never known a man to care so much. I'm lucky to have him but also irritated. "I am. I'm just horny."

"I don't know what he gave you. You were drinking…you could have a reaction or…"

"You know how many times I've been drugged?" I give a laugh, and he frowns. "I'll be fine." I try again to yank him toward me, but he pulls away, and I huff.

"I will tie you to this table if I have to." He meant it as a warning, but I think it sounds like a good time.

"Yes, please do," I beg.

He sighs heavily and stands when the door opens. I narrow my eyes on Haidyn as he enters. "What did Devin say?" he asks.

"He took a blood sample and started an IV. He said topical or not, flushing the liver will help. I also just washed off the infected area." Kashton shrugs. "Not sure it'll help, but it can't hurt."

Haidyn nods. "May I speak to you a second? Privately."

Kashton turns to me, and his hard eyes meet mine. "Stay right here. On this table. Do you understand?"

Where the fuck am I going to go? Out the window? That won't get me fucked. Just break my legs. I nod.

"I mean it, Eve. I want you in this very spot." He points to the table I lie on, and it reminds me of when I let him treat me like a pet. I'd love for him to collar and fuck me right now. Tie me up, put me in bed, and fuck my face until I'm drooling all over myself.

"I understand."

He kisses my forehead and then turns, exiting the room with Haidyn.

I slam the back of my head on the table, throwing my arm that doesn't have an IV in it over my eyes. The light in here is too bright.

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SIXTY-FOUR



KASHTON

I step right outside the room, refusing to go far. I'm not surprised to see Saint and Hooke also out here in the waiting area.

"Did you find out anything?"

"No," Hooke growls.

"Did you kill him already?" I wonder.

"I'm going to give him a few days of hell and then see what I can get out of him. We're going to introduce him to Isabella tomorrow and see if they know one another."

I nod. "Well, if he's here, then he's not with Hailey." Who knows where the woman is. She could have been sold already. She could be in another country, or she could be right under our noses. "Did he have her cell phone on him?"

"No," Hooke answers.

"He had a lot to say about Eve." Haidyn crosses his arms over his chest.

"Oh yeah, like what?" I bite, knowing he isn't going to let up.

"She's been killing Lords."

"Which is crazy." Saint shakes his head. "I mean, I'm not saying a woman couldn't kill a man, but he made it sound like there have been many, many men."

I say nothing.

"Kashton," Haidyn growls. "What the fuck was he talking about, and what do you know about this?"

I look away and run a hand down my face. I can't keep this from them anymore. "Eve works for Adam."

Silence falls over them as they glance at one another.

"Adam is dead," Hooke finally says.

Haidyn lets out a long breath and Saint frowns. "How do you know this? Did she tell you that?" Saint questions.

"Yes and no."

"Well, which one is it?" Haidyn barks.

"I spoke with Adam. He told me—"

"When the fuck did you see Adam?" Saint growls, knowing that Adam didn't tell me this when we were all together at Dollhouse.

"Was this before he died?" Hooke questions, tilting his head to the side.

"Wait a minute." Haidyn widens his stance. "Are you telling me she's been working for Adam all this time?"

"Yeah." I step closer to him, and he straightens. "The entire time you were talking to Adam behind our backs, he was knowingly working with your sister in Vegas." His face tightens at the fact that our brother was keeping a secret from him. Sin was right: you can't trust anyone. "Now, if you don't mind, I'm going to spend time with my wife who was drugged. Alone."

I give them my back, yank open her door, and enter the room. She's lying on the table, and her eyes meet mine. "Hey." I rush over to her when I see she's crying. "What's wrong, Eve? Are you hurting?"

"No." She sniffs.

I brush my tatted knuckles down her wet cheek. He said she'd have crazy mood swings. The woman already runs hot and cold in a blink of an eye. The drug can't be helping. "Talk to me."

"I'm horny," she whispers. "I need you to fuck me."

I sigh and look at the bag of fluid. "You're more than halfway done, angel. When we get back to our room, I'll fuck you. Okay?" It's not that I'm not hard, because I am. But I want to make sure she's okay first. I'm her husband. This is my job. To take care of her. To put her first.

Maxwell said she'd be insatiable. What will getting her off right now do? It could make her want it even more. And then when will it stop? As much as she wants it, her safety comes first. As soon as

she's done and Devin gives her the all clear, I'll have her coming all night.

Eve nods and turns her head away from me, rolling onto her side. I notice she's trembling and stand up to grab a blanket out of a cabinet and cover her up with it.

"Thank you," she mumbles.

"You're welcome, angel."

EVERETT

I lie on the table while Kashton sits next to me holding my hand. Devin returns, takes another blood sample, and removes my IV since I've finished the bag.

Kashton stands. "I'm going to talk to Devin really quick, and then we'll go to our room."

"Can we stay at your house tonight?" I want to be alone. Have an entire place to ourselves. Not just one room that his brothers have access to, and since Evan is still out there, I know Kashton won't take me to mine.

"I'll speak to Devin," is all he says and walks out of the room.

I stand and remove the gown, then pull my dress back on. I'm placing my heels on when he enters the room.

"Sit on the table," he orders.

I want to argue but do as I'm told.

He crouches down and removes my heels. Then he stands, kicks off his noir Hermès Bouncing sneakers, and crouches back down, sliding my feet into them. They're way too big, but he already knows that. "I don't want you to fall off your heels."

He takes my hand, and I follow him out of the room. I don't feel any better. If anything, I feel more uncomfortable than I did before. My skin is flushed, my pulse racing, and my clit is throbbing. My underwear is soaked.

I'm having hot flashes, but I'm freezing cold.

My legs are shaking, and my skin itches.

Kashton pulls me through Carnage, and I smile to myself when we walk out the front doors. He's taking me to his house.

Thank God.

My car is still parked out front, and I fall into the passenger seat while he walks around. He gets in, starts up the car, and pulls out of the gates. His cell rings and **Haidyn** lights up my dash since he's connected his cell to my car.

Sighing, he hits Answer. "Hello?"

"Where the fuck are you going?" my brother demands.

"We'll be back in the morning," Kashton tells him.

Not if I have any say.

"Kash—"

He hangs up and "Fall Back" by Lithe fills the speakers of the car. I shift my legs, rubbing them together. Reaching over, Kashton grabs my hand, intertwining our fingers before bringing it to his lips. He gives my knuckles a soft kiss and then places them back on my lap, holding it.

I kick off his shoes and undo my seat belt, and he glances at me quickly. "Eve," he warns. "Put your seat belt back on."

"Make me." I pull my hand free from his, leaning across the center console, and start to kiss his neck while my hand rubs between his thighs. My nails dig into his jeans, and he hisses in a breath. He smells so good. All masculine and rugged.

"Eve, you have to stop." Kashton clears his throat.

"Why?" I rub my hand over his cock, and of course he's hard. Fuck, I crave him in my mouth.

Pulling away, he shifts in his seat, trying to give himself some room in his jeans. I push his hand out of the way and unzip them. "Let me."

"Fuck," he groans, knowing exactly what I'm about to do.

We both know he can't stop me right now because he's driving. That's why I chose to take advantage of the situation.

I reach inside his zipper and through his boxer briefs to pull his dick out. My mouth fucking waters at the sight of him. I lean down and take the tip of his pierced dick into my mouth.

"Angel," he moans, shifting his hips when his hand goes to my hair. His tatted fingers sliding through the strands as he grips it, pulling it off my face the best he can. I don't fucking care.

I bob my head, taking more, and I whimper around his large size filling my mouth.

He lets go of my hair and slides his hand down my spine, and then I feel him yanking the hem of my dress up before his hand slaps my bare ass.

I shift, trying to adjust myself to a more comfortable position, but it's impossible. This isn't about me. It's about him.

His hand slides between my legs, and I lower my head, pushing the tip of his dick to the back of my throat, letting the drool run down his pierced shaft. He likes it messy, and I don't want to disappoint him.

"Fuck, Eve. You're so wet." His fingers pull my soaked thong out of the way, and he runs them over my pussy, teasing me like he loves to do.

I lift my head off his dick and gasp. "Please?"

The car swerves, and I have to let go of his dick to grab a hold of his thighs to keep from falling into the steering wheel. He comes to an abrupt stop.

I go to rise up to see what the fuck he's doing, but his hand leaves my ass to grip my hair, and he shoves my face down as he speaks. "You're going to finish what you started, angel."

Yes, sir. My pussy clenches at his words.

"Open wide and drool all over my cock, Eve. Until I'm coming all over that pretty face." His hands tangle in my hair, and he grips it tightly, making me whimper as he shoves my face down onto his hard dick.

I open my mouth willingly to let him have his way with it. He's slow at first, letting it slide down my throat while I do exactly what he told me to and cover his cock in my saliva while it runs out of my mouth.

"That's it," he groans, shifting in his seat, leaning back into it now that he's pulled over. "Fuck, angel. Your mouth feels so good." Shoving my head down, I have to remove my hand from his shaft as my breath is taken away when the head of his pierced cock fills the back of my throat.

I don't even care. Fuck my face. If I die, I die.

My hair is yanked and my mouth freed from his cock. I sit up and gasp in a breath. "Undo my belt," he orders.

As I do as I'm told, he lifts his hips off the seat so I can pull it from the loops. He rips it from my hands, pushes them behind me, and ties them behind my back.

Then his hands grip my face, and he pulls me to him and his lips crash into mine. He kisses me desperately and feverishly.

I shift on the seat, yanking on my tied hands. Pulling away, he gathers my hair in his hands once more and shoves my face down between his legs. "Open wide, angel."

Parting my lips, I shuffle on my knees. I'm in the most uncomfortable position that I could possibly be in. My stomach muscles clench and my thighs are sore as I try to hold myself up, but none of it matters.

"Goddammit, Eve," he growls, and I moan around his cock. "That's it…good girl."

I suck as hard as I can while drool runs from my open mouth. His heavy breathing fills the car and his hips buck while he fucks my face.

I'd smile at the way he shifts and praises me if I could. I feel a sense of pride being his whore. Letting him use me.

This is what being a Lady is all about. Serving your Lord.

"Fuck…Eve, I'm going to come—"

I open wide while he shoves his cock to the back of my throat, cutting off my air. My body jerks involuntarily and tears fall from my eyes as his warm cum fills my mouth.

With the position I'm in, it's hard to swallow, and it causes me to gag. He yanks my head from his cock and cum leaks from my mouth.

He's breathing heavily, and I'm gasping to catch mine. Pushing me into my seat, he fastens my seat belt.

"Kash." I lift my hips, pushing against it. My hands are still tied with his belt behind my back.

"Oh, no," he chuckles. "You're staying in your seat until we get home."

I throw my head into the headrest and lick my wet lips, knowing that when we get to his house, he’s going to fuck me.

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SIXTY-FIVE



KASHTON

I park in the garage, and once the door shuts, I get out and open her door. "Lean forward," I order and undo my belt from around her wrists.

She reaches out and I take her hand, yanking her from the car. I pick her up, and she wraps her legs around my waist while her arms go around my neck.

I push the door shut with my knee and enter the house. Her nails dig into my hair, and she yanks my head to the side while her lips find my neck.

"Eve," I growl, and a shiver runs through me when her teeth nibble on my skin.

"Yes?" she breathes before sucking where she just bit me.

"Payback is a bitch," I warn her, opening the door to the basement.

Her laughter tells me she's up for the challenge.

Coming to a stop at the bottom of the stairs, I tap her ass, and she releases my waist. I set her down on her feet and leave her there to go over to the cabinets that run along the side wall. I grab a few things and then turn to see her staring at the metal table I've added since last time she was down here. It's three feet tall, four feet long, and two feet wide. The perfect size for me to tie her to and do whatever I want to her. I want my girl to have options.

She stands there staring at it. Her hands reach out and pick up one of the black leather belts that hangs off the side. They are all lined with tiny rubber spikes for her pleasure.

Slowly, I walk up behind her. I gather her hair in one hand and place it over her left shoulder while I lean down and gently kiss the

right side of her neck. “Don’t be nervous, Eve. It’s only you and me.”

Who knows how many men and women have seen the videos of her at Dollhouse. Who knows how many out there even exist. I don’t care what I have to do or how much I have to pay, but I will own all of them. And when I do, I’m going to fucking burn them.

She turns in my arms and looks up at me. “I trust you.”

I gently kiss her lips and pull away. “Turn around.”

Once her back is to me, I reach down, grabbing the hem of her dress, and slowly push the material up and over her head before I toss it to the side. She begins to drop her arms, but I grab them and bring them behind her head, elbows out.

“Face me,” I command.

Doing as she’s told, her heavy green eyes look up at me through her lashes. “Beautiful.” I run my knuckles over her hard nipples.

“Please?” she begs, pressing her body into mine.

“Don’t move.” I stroll over to the counter and grab a couple of things that I need before returning to her.

I set one on the table, slide my hands into the gloves, and unscrew the lid to the small tube. I squeeze a tiny amount onto my finger and then softly swirl it around her nipple, making sure to cover it nicely. Then I proceed to do the other.

Her heavy panting fills the large basement, and she bites her bottom lip. Then I toss it to the floor. “You may drop your arms.”

“It…tingles.”

“It will take eight minutes to fully kick in.” I inform her of the Capzasin I smeared all over her nipples.

“God.” She hisses in a breath, her hips rocking back and forth.

I remove my gloves, then toss them into the trash and grab what I want. “Lie on the table, Eve.” I help pick her up, and she lies down, arching her back.

Pushing her arm down to her side, I buckle her wrist in the thick leather belt. Then I do the same to the other.

“Kash—” she breathes. “Fuck, it burns.” Her watery eyes meet mine.

“That’s the point,” I tell her, pushing her hair from her shoulder.

I pick up the posture collar, slide it under her neck and fasten it in place. Her eyes plead with me to fuck her, but not yet. I'm going to play with my angel. The point is to give her enough that she passes out afterward. Otherwise, who knows how long this drug will affect her.

She stares up at the ceiling, and I walk to the edge of the table where her legs hang off the end. I slide her feet into the high heels I made sure to bring with us from Carnage.

Then I take her left ankle and bend her knee, pushing her leg back to open her up for me. Her muscles strain as she tries to resist, but I'm able to grab the leather belt off the side of the table and wrap it around her thigh and shin, securing it in place.

She arches her back and cries out when I do the same to the other.

"That's it." I run my fingers over her exposed cunt. I've got her wide open and strapped down in place. She can't move.

"Kash…please?" she cries, trying to wiggle.

"Almost," I promise, and she groans in frustration.

Going to grab the last few things that I need, I return and squeeze the lube all over her. So much so that it covers her pussy, ass, and thighs before it drips onto the table.

She was already wet but needed more for what I have planned.

I coat the butt plug and then run the tip over her ass.

She jumps and starts pulling on the restraints. Her breathing getting louder. "Just relax for me, angel. I promise it's going to feel good."

I start with my finger first, gently pushing it in and out while she lies tied to the table, moaning and whimpering from pain and pleasure.

"That's it. You're doing great," I assure her before I insert a second and work them in and out faster. Then a third.

"Fuck, Eve. You're taking them so well." She's gasping. "You're such a good whore."

She cries out when I replace them with the plug. I go slow and steady with it, loving the view of her ass giving way to it. I could make it hurt, but I want her to enjoy it. I want her to know that I can give her pleasure.

Her body tenses and her legs strain against the leather belts as her ass opens up for the base.

"You did it, Eve," I tell her and look to see tears running from the corners of her eyes while she stares at the ceiling. The posture collar prevents her from looking at me. "You're a good girl."

She blinks and licks her lips. I walk to the side of the table and lean over her so she can see me. "So good." I kiss her trembling lips. "Fucking perfect, angel," I breathe across her lips when I pull away.

Removing a remote from my pocket, I hold it out in front of her face and press the button.

Her lips part and she cries out while I run my free hand over her hair. "That's the sound I want to hear."

EVERETT

"K-a-sh," I manage to say between pants. My heart is racing, my nipples on fire and my ass…I cry out again when it feels like it shocks me.

"E-stim." Kashton speaks over the blood rushing in my ears. "Electro stimulation. Do you feel it?" he asks, but I can't answer. I'm too busy trying to remember to breathe. "Does it hurt?"

Another shock takes my breath away, and my entire body tenses.

"Eve?" He grips my cheeks. "Answer me. Does it hurt?"

"Nooo," I manage to get out.

He doesn't let go of my face. "Breathe for me, angel. This isn't meant to be painful. Just enjoyable."

I take a deep breath, and he smiles. "Good girl. Another."

I part my lips to take in a deep breath, and it shocks me again, forcing a moan out of my mouth instead.

"That's my girl." His hand releases my face, and he walks out of my sight.

I can't move my arms, my legs, or my neck. The little spikes dig into my sensitive skin. All I can do is lie here and stare up at the ceiling, and it's fucking amazing. My teeth chatter, and I'm already sweating. My nipples are on fire, and my ass is stretched. I whimper when his fingers are on me. They play with my pussy before he starts to fuck me with them.

I’m panting and the room is spinning when another shock hits me. Then he’s stretching my pussy. It hurts but in the best way. I can hear him talking, but I can’t make out his words. He’s too far away. The room is too hot. The belt is too tight.

I’m spinning and feeling lightheaded. Fuck, this is amazing. This is what sex is supposed to feel like.

His pierced cock fills my soaked pussy and my eyes roll back into my head. Kashton leans over my body, his face above mine all while the shock continues to come and go.

I’m pretty sure I’m drooling all over myself and trying to remember how to breathe.

“Eyes on me, angel.” His voice breaks through my foggy brain.

I blink, my lashes heavy. I feel high. Maybe drunk.

Is it the drugs?

Are they hitting me more now? I can’t move. I don’t want to. I want to be Kashton’s good girl. His lips are moving, but I can’t seem to do the same. He doesn’t seem concerned, though. More amused than anything.

I’m just his whore. A doll to fuck however he pleases, and I will thank him when he’s done with me.

There’s no pain, no tingling, and no shocks. Just a feeling of being on cloud nine. My heavy eyes are on his, and I know that I will give this man anything he wants of me whenever he wants it.

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SIXTY-SIX



KASHTON

Eve lies in my bed while Gavin gives her an IV. I called him after I was done playing with her in the basement. She needs more fluids, and since we left Carnage, Devin can't tend to her.

My cell rings and I look to see its Haidyn. I consider pressing Ignore. He knows I'm with his sister and the current state that she's in. But since she's preoccupied with Gavin, I answer. "Yeah?"

"I'll make this quick," he says in greeting. "I was speaking to Charlotte, and she mentioned something."

"What is it?" I ask when he doesn't elaborate.

"She thinks this topical was used at her mother's spa."

I walk into the living room and start to pace. "The spa?"

"Yeah. Charlotte was getting hydration IVs and massages there regularly. After she brought it to my attention, I took her down to the basement and was able to identify him. Maxwell worked there. Was an employee of Isabella's."

I nod to myself. "Makes sense. Think the bitch knows where Hailey is?"

"Doubtful. Hailey went missing after you guys rescued me and we brought in Isabella."

"Yeah, but the video the Mason brothers gave you shows that Hailey was in Las Vegas before you gave yourself over to Isabella."

"True." He sighs.

I plop down on the couch and lean forward, running my hand through my hair. By this point, Hooke isn't going to find her, and we all know it. It's the fact of locating her body and laying her to rest.

"Kashton?"

"One sec," I say into the phone and stand when I see Gavin in front of me. I nod to tell him it's okay to speak.

"She's doing well. Let me know how she feels in the morning. If you think she needs another one, I'll swing by and give it to her."

I walk him to the door, give him some cash, and thank him for stopping by. As I shut and lock the front door, Haidyn speaks in my ear. "How is Eve?"

"Getting better. I had Gavin come by and give her another IV. She just finished."

He sighs. "I'll let you go, but I want to know one thing."

"What is it?" I ask cautiously, heading back toward the primary suite. I know whatever it is, I don't want to answer it.

"How deep is she in with Adam?"

I come to a stop at the bedroom and look over her in the bed. She's sitting up with her back against the headboard, her green eyes looking at her phone. As if she feels me staring, she peers up at me through her lashes. "Trenches," I answer without letting her know what I'm talking about.

"Motherfucker," he growls. "I'm going to kill him—"

"I can handle it," I interrupt Haidyn. "I've been handling it." She hasn't had a job since the night of her assignment. I'm not sure if that's because Adam knows I'm against it or because he knows Eve needs to hide due to someone trying to frame her for the bodies found.

"Kash—"

"Trust me," I urge.

"I do." He sighs. "It's just that…she deserves a brother. One who protects her."

"And she has one," I acknowledge. Eve pushes off the covers, getting out of bed. My eyes drop to her long, lean legs and slowly take in her shaved pussy and large breasts. Little bruises dot her body in various places from the spikes inside the restraints from the table in the basement. The vows are still very noticeable on her skin. A reminder that she belongs to me. "But she also has a husband. If I need help, I'll ask you for it." I hang up and toss my phone onto the dresser.

She steps into me, leaning her head back, her eyes searching mine. They're still dilated from the drugs that bastard gave her. "Who was that?"

"How do you feel?" I ask, ignoring her question and pushing hair back from her face.

"Horny." She bites her bottom lip while undoing my belt.

"What are we going to do about that?" I reach up and start playing with her nipple, loving the way her breath hitches when I give it a light pinch.

Unzipping my jeans, she yanks them down my thighs, along with my boxer briefs. "Whatever you want."

The room fills with her giggles when I pick her up and toss her onto the bed.

Janice called Eve this morning and asked us to join them for dinner. We couldn't turn them down. We enter the house and make our way to the formal dining room. We're ushered to our seats as Elli and Sin sit down across from us.

"How is everyone doing?" Sin's mother asks, looking around.

We all nod and say good.

"I wish Haidyn and Charlotte could have made it." Janice frowns. "I know pregnancy can be hard on the body. To be so small and pregnant with three? Poor thing. I felt sorry for her and took her some soup."

Bill glances up from his plate, clearing his throat. "You went to Carnage?"

She nods. "This morning when I went out. Charlotte assured me that Haidyn was taking care of her, but I couldn't do nothing." She smiles. "And that cat of hers…Muffin is so adorable."

Bill looks like he wants to talk to her about going there but is choosing to bring that up later when they're alone. As far as I know, Janice has no clue that her ex-husband is a prisoner of ours. She thinks he's dead. Something tells me Bill doesn't want her to know the truth.

Sin is shoveling his food into his mouth, and his mother frowns. "Easton, are you in a hurry to leave?"

"No. But I've learned that having kids means you either eat quickly or you're eating cold food."

Elli laughs, rubbing his back. "Take your time, Sin. It's okay."

"He's not wrong." His mother chuckles, looking at Eve, and I hold my breath, hoping she doesn't ask her about children. I don't want her to feel uncomfortable about there not being any children in our future. "Eve?" she says.

"Yes, ma'am?" She looks up from her plate.

"Please call me Janice. I was updating my calendar yesterday and Bill told me that your birthday was a month ago."

I frown, wondering why she didn't mention it.

Eve doesn't respond to that.

"I know we missed it, but I want to throw you a party. It'll be a small get together. Here at the house." Janice smiles excitedly.

"I don't celebrate birthdays," Eve states, looking up at her through her painted lashes.

"Oh." Janice's face falls.

Bill takes his wife's hand and brings her knuckles to his lips and kisses them. "I think a birthday party is a great idea."

"No, Bill, she doesn't want one," she whispers to him, but we can all hear. "I shouldn't have overstepped—"

"Don't you think so, Eve?" he cuts off his wife, looking at mine.

"Yeah." She nods at Sin's mother. "That's very kind of you. Thank you." Her eyes drop back down to her plate, and a silence blankets the large room.

The sound of one of the babies filters through the baby monitor that Sin has on the table. "Told you. They have perfect timing." He grabs his wife's plate.

Elli stands and so does Sin. "What are you doing?" Her eyes drop to her lunch in his hand.

"I'm going to feed you while you feed them," he answers.

She rolls her eyes but smiles as she gives him her back and he follows after her.

EVERETT

I'm wandering around the house aimlessly. I needed a second to myself. To clear my head.

It's still weird to be around so many people at once. I've never known what it feels like to have a family or have someone who wants to throw me a birthday party. I hate how excited I got when she said that. But then I quickly felt guilty for wanting something I don't deserve.

I have no friends to invite. And as much as they want to be, they're not my family.

Making my way slowly up the staircase, I step onto the second floor and enter the room that Bill told me was mine.

I have a room here. I shouldn't be surprised, but again, I'm not sure how to feel about it.

Opening the door, I step inside. It's got an instant calming feel to it. Soft yellow curtains frame French doors that open to a balcony. Pristine white carpet with a light blue rug. A king-size bed sits in the middle of the room with pastel-colored throw pillows atop it. The old me would want to vomit. The new me wants to crawl into the bed and close my eyes. Imagine what it would be like to have a childhood in this house. To know what it feels like to be loved.

"I wanted to make it as welcoming as possible."

I turn around to see Janice has entered the room. I give her a smile. "I love it."

"Anything can be changed."

"No. Really. It's perfect." I don't want to disappoint her or cause her to think her efforts aren't appreciated. I look up to see Kashton step into the room. He crosses his arms over his chest and leans against the doorway, staring right at me. I turn my attention back on her. "Thank you. For everything."

She gives me a smile and then pulls me in for a hug. I awkwardly wrap my arms around her before she steps back. "This is your home too, Eve. You are welcome here anytime." With that, she gives me her back, and Kashton steps to the side as she walks out and closes the door softly behind her.

He strolls over to me, and I shuffle from heel to heel. I hate feeling like this. Out of control. Not knowing what to say or do. But I seem

to always feel like this when we're alone.

Once he reaches me, he cups my face, forcing me to look up at him. "Why didn't you tell me your birthday just passed?"

I lick my lips nervously, not sure how to answer. I already said all that needed to be told downstairs.

"Eve?"

I drop my hands to his jeans and undo his belt and then his button before lowering his zipper.

"You're deflecting."

I look up at him and bat my eyelashes. "Don't you want to christen my bedroom?" I grab the hem of my dress and pull it up and over my head and then shove my underwear down my legs and kick it away. Standing in front of him with nothing but my heels on. He loves it when I leave them on.

He groans, his eyes running up and down my body. His hands drop to my hips, and he pulls me flush to him. "You're not playing fair," he whispers, digging his fingers into me.

"You're not playing with me at all," I counter, giving him a sly smile. This is what I want to be. His mindless sex toy. "Now…bend me over this bed and fuck me. Then we can go back downstairs and hang out with your cum leaking from my pussy."

"Whatever my wife wants."

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SIXTY-SEVEN



EVERETT

I finish applying my lipstick in the bathroom before I pull my dress on. Exiting the room, I make my way downstairs. My feet slow when I catch sight of the grand foyer. Kashton stands by the front doors with Sin.

Coming to a stop, my chest begins to ache watching my husband hold a baby. Kashton softly sways from foot to foot with the little guy passed out in his arms after his feeding.

Kashton smiles down at the baby before looking up at Easton. Their lips are moving, but I can't hear what they're saying over the blood rushing in my ears.

All I can think of is that I took the option of being a father away from him. He'll never know that feeling—that kind of love—as long as he's with me.

I've made a lot of mistakes, but I've never hated myself more than I do now.

I hate my father for the life he had planned for me. Fuck him for the choices he made me make.

Ellington gets my attention by walking up to them. "Thank you," she tells Kashton, holding out her arms for her baby.

"Anytime," Kashton assures her.

And that pain intensifies. All his friends are having children. How long will he wait before he decides he wants one? How long will the Lords wait before they force him to have one with whoever they choose? A Spade brother can't just decide to not have children. It doesn't work that way.

Look at Charlotte. She was given fertility drugs without her knowledge to get pregnant. That's why she's having triplets. And Ashtyn. She's having twins. Possibly by her husband and her rapist. The Lords don't care what they have to do to get their way. They will kill or walk over anyone to get what they want.

"It was good to see you, Eve."

I blink when Elli speaks to me. "You too." I look away when I catch Kashton staring at me. Did he see me watching him? Does he know what I was thinking? Of course he does. I wear my emotions all over my face, and he's always watching. He pays attention to my every move.

"We should do lunch soon," Elli offers with a smile.

Nodding, I agree, "Just let me know when." It's weird to go from nothing to a family and friends. It's overwhelming and yet confusing. I also don't want to put others in danger because I've come around to the idea of not being alone all the time.

That's just being selfish.

Kashton gets the door for them, and they say their goodbyes. I finish making my way down the stairs when he turns to face me.

"Eve—"

"I'm ready to go," I interrupt him, knowing what he's thinking and not in the mood to discuss it. I want a bottle to drown myself in.

KASHTON

We enter Carnage and see Jessie there to greet us. "Good evening, Mr. and Mrs. Pierce. Is there anything I can do for you?"

"I would like a bottle of whiskey," Eve answers.

Jessie looks at me for permission, and I give a soft nod, not wanting her to see. She's irritated with herself right now, and I'm enabling her.

"Of course. I can bring it to your room—"

"No need. I'll come with you," she interrupts him.

I place my hands in my pockets and watch my wife walk away with Jessie to grab some liquor. Maybe I'm allowing it for my own selfish reasons. I want her to open up to me, and the only way she's going to do that is with alcohol.

Eve drinks often, so she's got a pretty good tolerance, but a bottle? She's got to have a point where she'll answer questions that I have. Show her vulnerable side. I'm going to test her just to see how many drinks that will take.

I make my way down to the basement to find Haidyn. "Where is everyone?" I ask.

"Saint went to bed and Hooke went out."

"To Blackout?"

He shrugs. "Not sure. He didn't offer and I didn't ask."

"Anything new on Hailey?"

Haidyn takes a hit from his cigarette. "Nope."

"What about the woman? What did Devin do with the body?"

He just stares at me before he takes another hit. I step closer to him, narrowing my eyes. "What did you do, Haidyn?"

"Don't worry about it." He gives me his back.

I reach out and grab his arm, and he spins back around to face me. "Tell me," I grind out. "Saint called and told me she died. He made it sound like she succumbed to her injuries. Is that what happened?"

"Yeah. That's what happened."

We've been at Carnage for an hour when I walk through the bedroom to find her in the bathroom, submerged in the tub, bubbles chin high, and a bottle of whiskey three-quarters gone.

I sit on the edge, and she glances up at me before looking down at the bubbles. She avoided the conversation I wanted to have with her at Bill and Janice's. In all honesty, that wasn't the place to have it. But now she's naked and has nowhere to go. "I'm sorry," I tell her.

Her pretty green eyes find mine and she frowns. "For what?"

"For tonight. I…I wasn't thinking." Elli had to use the restroom and asked me to hold Brexton. I didn't think about it until I saw Eve on the stairs. Sin's hands were full with their daughter, and Janice wasn't around.

My wife reaches over, grabs the bottle, and starts to gulp what's left of it down.

I yank it from her hand, and her eyes narrow on mine. She sits up, her chest now out of the water and bubbles. "I'm not heartless, Kashton. I'm not going to keep you from your friends' children." Then her eyes go to the bottle.

I move it out of her reach before speaking. "I never said you were." I frown at her harsh tone. "I just—"

"I don't want to talk about it," she interrupts me, just like earlier.

"I think we should."

"No." She stands and the water sloshes around.

Getting out, she grabs a towel, but I wrap my fingers around her upper arm, pulling her to a stop. Water and bubbles run down her body to pool at her feet. "We'll figure something out."

She yanks her arm from my hold and stumbles back before righting herself. She's had more to drink than I thought. "What the fuck does that mean? Figure what out?"

"Adoption." I step into her, not wanting her to fall and hurt herself. This floor is slippery when wet. "We'll have kids, Eve." I saw the look on her face, and I know how much regret she has. Bringing a kid into the Lords is doable. Plus, they won't be blood related, so the Lords won't force them to be initiated. "We'll give them the childhood that we wish we had."

"No." Eve shakes her head. "We're not adopting. You want kids, have them with someone else."

I know what she's doing. She wants to start a fight. Wants to push me away. It's her way of coping with the choices she was forced to make.

"You're my wife," I grind out. "I'm not going to be fucking anyone else, let alone have a child with another woman."

She snorts as if that's unbelievable. "Give it time." Turning, she gives me her bubble-covered back and starts to exit the bathroom, but I grab her messy bun and yank her back before spinning her around and pinning her to the door with my hand around her neck. "Kash—"

"Drop the attitude, angel," I growl.

She huffs, and I can smell the liquor on her breath.

Loosening my hand, I run my fingers down her chest, smearing the bubbles across her smooth skin. "I know you're upset." I soften my voice, and her eyes harden. "But I'm not going to cheat on you. I love you."

Eve slams her hands into my chest. I take a few steps back to give her some space. "I don't know why," she grinds out.

"Why what? Why I love you?" I frown.

"No one loves a whore."

"You're not a whore." This is what years of grooming does to someone. I have no problem constantly reminding her that she has worth. I will devote my life to it.

"I begged you to fuck me that night on the *Isabella*, Kash. You said it that night yourself…I was about to be raped but threw myself at you instead." She drops her eyes to her bare feet. "That's what a whore does."

"You were confused," I argue.

She shakes her head. "I knew what I wanted." Her eyes glance up at me. "But that was then, and this is now."

"Exactly—"

"This is forever," she whispers, staring at her ring. "I don't want you to resent me in five, ten, fifteen years." Her watery eyes plead with mine. "I won't be able to live with you not loving me."

"I'm always going to love you, Eve. Until the day I die."

She licks her lips and glances away. "I don't deserve your love." Her watery eyes glance aimlessly around the bathroom. "I don't deserve any of it."

"You deserve the world, Eve, and I'm going to give it to you. Anything you want, it's yours." I don't care what it costs me—money or my life. I'll gladly pay it.

"Our fathers…"

"Are dead," I interrupt her. "They can't hurt you anymore." Taking her face in my hands, I force her eyes on mine. "You know that, right? That I'd never hurt you, Eve. Not like they did." I'm human. So I can only imagine that I'll hurt her along the way somehow, but what our fathers did to her? Never. I want my wife to have a normal

life. To have freedom as long as she's safe. I take a step toward her, and she matches it, pushing her back into the door.

"I let them ruin our future." She sniffs. "I let them take everything from us."

She couldn't have fought them and won. "You were just a child, Eve."

"They didn't treat me like one," she admits, and my chest aches for my wife. Her bottom lip starts to tremble before she nibbles on it. "First time they raped me I was fourteen. I didn't even have my first period until I was fifteen. You would think they'd know how that works…" She trails off, and I allow her a second to collect her thoughts. "Saint's father stayed away from me for the most part. He rarely paid me any attention." Her voice is soft, and I have to strain my ears to hear her. "Adam's did the same. I think they both knew I wasn't going to get pregnant. But my father wouldn't give up…" She drifts off. I'm not sure if it's the conversation or the alcohol. Maybe a mix of both.

She blinks her eyes, her heavy lashes fanning her cheeks. I step closer to her, afraid she's about to pass out and fall to the floor, but she looks up at me.

"My father raped me in hopes to get me pregnant." She nods to herself. "But yours…" Her eyes drop to the bottle of whiskey.

What could be worse? I need to know what my father did to my wife when she was a child. What she went through. It's like watching the videos. A sick part of me needs to know.

She wraps the towel around herself. A sign that she's going to share something because she wants to cover her body. Shield it from me. "He would come into my room. Tie my hands behind my back and yank me off the bed." Her watery eyes meet mine. "He'd say, 'Worthless whores get fucked on the floor.' Then he'd shove my face into the carpet and say, 'Your cunt may be useless, but at least your ass serves a purpose.'" The first tear runs down her face, and I step into her.

Cupping her cheeks, I lick my lips. "I'm so sorry, Eve." My words are pointless and hollow. They won't change her past.

I hate myself for needing to know. What did it change? Nothing. What did it help? Not a Goddamn thing.

"I wish I would have known…I would have protected you." Does she blame me? Is that why she thinks I'll hurt her? That I'm playing some long game here where I make her my Lady and then fuck around on her and have children with someone else? I'd never do such a thing.

"You're not your father, Kash," she whispers, reading my mind. "You're the only man I've ever willingly slept with. The only man who's ever treated me like a person. You care about how I feel and make me feel safe."

I frown at her words. "What about Adam?" Did he take advantage of her? Maybe it was like when I met her on the *Isabella*. He saved her and she felt obligated to repay him?

She tilts her head to the side. "I know you think we're friends, but we're not. I work for him. That's it. We're not close and never will be."

"But you slept with him," I go on, and her brows pull together. "Are you saying it wasn't consensual? That he raped you?" She's vulnerable and very easily manipulated. He could have convinced her she wanted it. I know my brother, and the thought of him tying her up and fucking her makes me want to slit his fucking throat. But if he coerced her into it, I'll throw him in a cell at Carnage and make him pay for the rest of his life.

"No." She shakes her head. "I've never slept with him."

Why is she lying to me? "Eve, it's okay. I mean, I hate that you've slept with him, but I understand he's been there for you."

She steps back and hits the door with a thud. "What makes you think I slept with Adam?"

I reach out to help steady her. She's gripping the towel tightly, and if she falls, she may not use her hands to catch herself. "He told me. Said it was years ago when you guys were in Las Vegas together."

She stares at me unblinkingly. I know she's shut down. I'm not going to get anything else from her, and I'm not going to push.

I don't want to add to her self-hatred. I hate to see my wife blaming herself for things that she's done. She probably felt lonely, and

he was there for her. Another reason I don't like their friendship. I'm just a jealous bitch. "Come on, angel. Let's go to bed." She's drunk and needs some rest.

She remains quiet while she allows me to put her in bed. I turn on the TV, and when I kiss her forehead, her eyes are already closed.

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SIXTY-EIGHT



EVERETT

I pull up to the house and slam on my brakes. Getting out of my car, I enter the front doors like I own the place. "Apologize," by Timbaland and OneRepublic plays through the speakers of the TV that's mounted on the wall.

"You son of a bitch," I yell over it, and a set of green eyes glances up at me from the kitchen.

"What can I do for you, Eve?" Adam asks dryly.

My eyes drop to the blood smeared on his shirt. "Quit telling lies, for starters," I snap.

"It was a long night." He turns to the fridge. "I haven't been to bed yet, so forgive me if I'm not in the mood to play your games."

I huff. The nerve of this guy. Something gets my attention, and I turn to see Missy entering the kitchen from the hallway. She's got a black eye, a cut on her cheek, and has a few stitches with a busted lip.

Her eyes drop to the floor, and she wraps her arms around herself. I notice she's wearing an oversized T-shirt and nothing else. It's got to be Adam's. "You know, at some point it stops being rough sex and becomes abuse."

She glances at Adam before she sits down at the bar. I'd bet my life she's still a virgin.

Adam grabs a bag of frozen peas out of the freezer before turning to face us. "Hold that to your face," he orders, holding them out across the island to her.

Taking them, she looks at me. "There was a fight at the bar last night. A guy used me as a shield."

"A human shield?" I'm not surprised. That place is shady at best.

She flinches, placing the bag on her face and answering, "Yeah."

"What do you want, Eve?" Adam sighs.

"We need to talk."

He nods. "My office. Keep that on your face," he commands Missy, and she gets up, walks to the couch, and lies down.

I follow him to his office, and I slam the door behind me.

"Please enlighten me on what I've lied about," he says sitting at his desk.

"You told Kashton that we've fucked."

He tilts his head to the side. "He asked me a question, and I answered. Why is that such a bad thing?"

Why were they even talking about my sex life in the first place? "Because it's a lie." He knows I don't sleep around. That's why he said he was proud of me when I slept with Kashton after I told him.

"No, it's not."

Is he high? "Yes, it is. I've never slept with you, Adam."

I worked so hard to not have sex after Bill saved me. I realized I needed to get away. Start a life for myself. The next year, I was introduced to Adam. He was on the run, going to Vegas, and I begged him to take me with him. I saw an opportunity to get the fuck away from here.

Adam runs a hand down his face. "I know it's hard to come to terms—"

"Come to terms with what?" I bark, not liking the accusation.

"Everett, you were trained."

I give a manic laugh. "Are you saying that I begged you to fuck me?"

His eyes soften but he says nothing.

"No." I lick my lips. "We didn't…" I trail off. "I would remember that."

He opens a drawer and pulls out an envelope. Removing the contents, he holds something out to me.

I take it with shaking hands, and my heart leaps in my chest at what I see. I'm lying in the center of the bed, tied, spread eagle, with a blindfold over my eyes. Adam stands at the foot of the bed,

also naked, with his dick in his hand and his cum covering my pussy and thighs.

"No," I whisper as my legs give out, and I fall onto the edge of the couch. "This isn't me…" Tears sting my eyes. "We didn't." But we did, and it is me.

I had gained maybe twenty pounds here from when Bill pulled me out of Dollhouse, but I'm still too thin. They didn't make sure to keep you fed while in training, but the drugs also helped curb your appetite. Plus, starvation keeps you weak.

"I'm sorry, Eve," he says softly. "I didn't know that you didn't remember. We just never talked about it. You were really drunk and showed up at my room. I was drunk, wallowing in my own pity that night that I had to leave home, my mom dead, my sister running to Vegas… I should have told you no. I took advantage of you."

"It was pity sex." I sniff, understanding what he means. "I begged you to fuck me. I took advantage of you."

"No. That's not what happened at all," he rushes out.

I glance up at him.

"You're beautiful, Eve. And that night you were upset. You were trained to serve." I flinch at his words, but that's only because they're true. "It wasn't your fault. I should have said no and put you to bed to sleep, but I was weak. I took total advantage of the situation, and I'm sorry for that."

"I… Why can't I remember?" I ask more to myself. After Evan told me we had sex, I was able to remember bits and pieces. Maybe not every time, but there was something there. "Why don't I remember with you?"

He shrugs. "I can't answer that."

"Where did you get this?" I hold up the photo.

"Isabella gave it to Haidyn after their training senior year. She was blackmailing him. Told him she had proof I was in Vegas and that if he didn't give her what she wanted, she'd make sure I was found and charged for the death of the missing girl that I didn't kill."

This just keeps getting better and better. "So Haidyn has seen this picture of me naked, tied to a bed, with your cum between my legs."

He sighs. "He didn't know it was you."

I stand and he takes a step toward me. “Please don’t.” I hold out my hand and he steps back, giving me space.

“I’ll call Kash—”

“No,” I rush out. “I just want to be alone.” I’m on the verge of tears. I’m a fucking train wreck. A whore. I told Ashtyn I hadn’t fucked Kashton’s friends. Turns out that’s a lie. I did. Threw myself at him from what it sounds like.

“Eve—”

“I’m sorry,” I interrupt him.

“You have nothing to be sorry for.”

I rub my sweaty hands on my jeans before taking a step back. “I have to go. I’m sorry I interrupted your day.”

KASHTON

I’m standing in the basement with Saint and Haidyn. Both of them are in shit moods today. I, on the other hand, woke up in a great mood. It’s going to be even better in a couple hours when I’m in bed with my wife.

My cell rings, and I see its Adam. “I’ll be right back,” I tell the guys and rush toward the stairs. They still don’t have his contact information that I know of, and if he’s calling me, it has to be about Eve. Last I heard the cops were at a standstill since the woman disappeared. They don’t have enough evidence yet on my girl to bring her in, but they’re searching for it.

“Hello?” I answer before running up the stairs. “Everything okay?” I look down over the railing from the second floor to make sure they’re not following me. I push open the door and step out into the hallway.

“Eve came to visit me today.”

“What did she want?” I ask when he doesn’t elaborate.

“I didn’t know that she didn’t remember we had sex.”

I come to a stop and frown. “She came to see you to talk about sex?”

“I guess you two had a conversation about it, and she was mad at me for lying.”

“You lied—”

“No. We had sex.”

I grind my teeth at the fact that he keeps bringing this up. I know what she's been through and who has used her. I honestly don't see her any differently, but I definitely don't want him to rehash him fucking her. "Get to the fucking point, Adam," I snap.

"But she doesn't remember. To her, it never happened."

As much as I'm happy that my wife can't remember fucking my brother, I frown. "Well, I feel like that's logical after what she's been through. She chose to block it out, right? I've seen her dissociate before."

"Yeah, I guess." He sighs. "I just wanted to let you know. She was upset. On the verge of tears that she had no recollection of it. She stormed into my house but left with her head hanging. I told her I'd call you, but she told me not to. That she wanted to be alone. But one thing I know about Eve is that her being alone usually isn't a good thing."

I hate how well he knows my wife. "How long ago was she there?" I haven't checked her tracker at all today.

"Earlier this morning. Before noon."

So she went straight to him after she left here this morning? "And you're just now calling me. It's almost ten," I bark, checking my watch. She was supposed to be spending the day with Janice, going over things for the birthday party Janice wants to throw her.

"I've been a little busy," he snaps defensively.

I start to make my way to the garage. "Thanks for letting me know," I say tightly. "The drugs aren't helping."

"What drugs?" he questions. "Eve doesn't do them."

My skin heats up that he knows her so well. "She was drugged the other night at Blackout. Some kind of topical shit to make her horny."

He's quiet for a second before he speaks. "Gen."

"Who the fuck is she?" I demand, entering the garage.

"It's a drug. Not a she."

I roll my eyes, grabbing my helmet. "Well, whatever it is, she's having major mood swings." Before he can say anything else, I add. "I'll text you later."

I check Eve's location on my phone. "Goddammit," I hiss, seeing where she's at.

Jumping on my bike, I squeal out of the gates of Carnage. I don't even bother to tell the guys I'm leaving as "Fire Up the Night" by New Medicine blares in my ears.

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SIXTY-NINE



EVERETT

I sit at the bar, working on a drink. I'm not sure how many I've had at this point. I've been here since they opened.

The club is packed on this Friday night. I'm not in a people mood, but I'm in a get-fucked-up mood, and the loud music is drowning out my thoughts. So that helps. Plus, my house is the first place Kashton will go to look for me when he realizes I'm not returning to Carnage.

I spent the day with Janice, pretending to care about food and decorations for a birthday party I don't want to have, when all I wanted to do was bang my head up against a wall.

Needing to use the restroom, I get up from the bar. I'm hovering over the toilet—you couldn't pay me enough to sit on them—when I hear the door open and close and several sets of heels clap on the floor.

"Fuck. That man is so fine," one of them says dreamily.

"Tyson Crawford is definitely my type," another laughs.

"Yeah, well…did you see the guy who walked in right before us? He's my type. Motorcycle and all. He can take me for a ride anytime."

"No. Who was it?" another asks.

"Kashton Pierce."

I hold in a sigh. No doubt Adam called him, and he's here to drag me home.

"Bitch, I'd take both of them, and don't pretend you'd turn down Tyson," one giggles and I roll my eyes.

"Who's the Kashton guy?" a third voice questions.

I snort at that. *Only the most amazing man alive.*

"He's a Lord."

"They both are," one corrects her.

"What's a Lord? That like some kind of fraternity or something?"

"Yeah," the first one answers, and I smirk. If that's what you want to call them.

"They're the reason I didn't get to go to Barrington," one whines.

"But your sister Millie went, didn't she?"

"Yep. She and her best friend went to the House of Lords for a party, and her friend got knocked up by one. The guy got in deep shit for having sex—which is crazy because I've been told it's one big orgy—anyway, his father paid her two hundred and fifty thousand to have an abortion."

I exit the stall and walk over to wash my hands. They glance at me but continue their conversation.

"Fuck that. I would have had the baby. She could have gotten way more than that in child support." One frowns, looking at herself in the mirror. "Aren't they rich?"

"I don't think all of them are, but the majority, yes."

"Anyway," the third girl says, "they're both married."

"Kashton isn't," the brunette argues.

"Yes, he is." She runs her hands through her hair. "I looked, and he's wearing a wedding ring."

The original one snorts. "Like they fucking care. My sister told me what went on at those parties. They all pass their girlfriends and wives around. Plus, they have more side chicks than days of the week. I'm going to shoot my shot." She pops open her lipstick and smears it over her trout pout.

It makes me think of the Spade brothers and Ashtyn. How Saint passed her around to his friends. Not like she had a choice. Saint is partly at fault for the way Ashtyn is. He made her the center of all their lives knowing he would one day take that away from her.

"Like Kashton will turn you down." The redhead laughs. "Are you still on the pill?"

"Yeah, but I was on antibiotics last week." She winks, and I want to slam her face into the counter. Up until now I didn't mind her infatu-

ation with my husband. I mean, I get it. He's hard to resist. "I've had baby fever the last few months."

"Your mother would kill you," one tells her with a frown.

"She'd be mad at first, but I think she'd come around."

"Good luck," I can't help but join their conversation, smiling at her in the mirror.

All three of them look at me. The one in the center, the one planning on fucking my husband, smirks at me.

"Our girl doesn't need luck," the redhead quips. "Just look at her."

I take the invitation and examine her. Short dark bob with a glittery silver dress and Gucci heels. She's pretty, but I don't care who she thinks she is; my husband won't want anything to do with her. "I don't think you're his type."

Her brown eyes narrow on me, and I smile, drying off my hands before exiting the bathroom and making my way back to the bar. I stand at the far end right off the hallway so I can scan the club while "Sweat" by Open Till L8 blasts throughout.

I spot Kashton across from me at the opposite end immediately. You can't miss him under the flashing neon lights. He's standing, giving me a side view as he speaks to Colton and Alex.

"Another?" the bartender hollers over the music, noticing my return.

I nod at him while staring at my husband, waiting for him to glance my way.

"Here you go." The bartender drops my drink in front of me, and I catch sight of the woman come into view while she rounds the bar.

I stand up straighter when she walks right up to Kashton. It's hard to miss the disco ball she's wearing.

Alex notices her, but Colt and Kash both ignore the bitch. She bumps into my husband, and he glances her way and then steps back from the bar, giving her space.

Good boy. I'll rip his balls off if he entertains her advances.

She frowns, looking across the bar at her friends, who are nodding and smiling, encouraging her to try harder.

This bitch.

She taps his arm, and he looks down at her. Rising on her tiptoes, she cups her mouth, trying to talk to him.

His eyes find mine across the bar the moment heat rolls over my body like a raging fire when she leans into him.

Picking up my drink, I begin to move, shoving my way through the club and to the opposite side. As I approach them, Kashton reaches out to grab my arm, but I pull away, walk up to her, and throw my drink on her.

She gasps, her arms flying out to her sides when she steps back. "What the—"

"He's married. Fucking bitch." I punch her in the face.

She immediately falls to the floor, passed out. One hit to the face, and she's out.

That felt good, to let out a little aggression, but don't try and fuck someone you know belongs to someone else. I'm his wife. Not some fuck he sees every other Monday.

Her friends rush over and try to help her up, but Alex intervenes.

"Everett." An arm wraps around me from behind and my heels are lifted out from underneath me. I'm hauled back through the crowd and set down on my Jimmy Choos in the hallway that leads to the bathroom.

I spin around to yell at Kash, but he wraps his hand around my throat, shoving my back into the wall. "Goddammit, Eve," he growls in my face.

"I'm sorry for interrupting. Did you want to fuck her?" I snap, breathing heavily.

His hard eyes search mine, and I glance at his lips, licking mine. Fuck, I'm so horny. I want him to fuck me in front of the bitch. Show her what she's missing while showing he's taken.

My hands fist his shirt, and I pull him closer to me, wanting his body on top of mine.

I lean into him, and he goes to kiss me, but Colton comes up next to us. "Tyson wants to see you two in his office."

"Fuck," Kashton hisses, letting go of my neck. He grabs my hand, yanking me from the hallway and to the elevator.

My anger grows at Tyson interrupting. I need some hate fuck right now. Put me in my place while he proves to me that I'm the only one he wants. Is that too much for a woman to ask?

KASHTON

I pull her into Ty's office and shut the door behind me.

"Sit," I order, guiding her into a chair, and she huffs but stays put.

Alex smiles at her, and she gives him a death glare. He doesn't want to fuck with her right now. She's worked up and needs an outlet. If she decides to use his face, I'm not going to stop her.

Tyson stands behind his desk, sleeves rolled up and hands shoved into the pockets of his dress slacks. He looks like a dad trying to decide how to discipline his kids. "And here I thought Sin was going to be my biggest problem." He sighs. "Then you two show up." Moving his hands to his hips, he glares at Eve. "What the fuck was that?"

"Tyson—"

"She's wanted for murder, kidnapping, and sex trafficking." He interrupts me. "The list goes on."

"We both know she didn't do it." I argue. I might be pissed at my wife for the scene she just caused, but I'm going to defend her.

"They don't know that." Ty looks over at Colton and demands, "Where the fuck are Finn and Jenks?"

"With the girls," Colt answers. "Making sure no police reports will be filed."

The door opens, and I look to see the detective who wants to frame my wife for murder enter the room, followed by some younger guy dressed in his police uniform.

Fuck this night.

"What are the odds?" Detective Haynes comes to a stop, spotting Eve. "Officer Anders, take this woman into custody."

"With pleasure," the kid says, pulling the handcuffs free from his duty belt.

Alex and Colton both stand, but I'm quicker. I remove my pocketknife and flip it open. Stepping into the detective, I slam it to the hilt into his upper thigh, making him hiss. "Goddammit."

The other pulls out his gun and trains it on me. Everyone else in the room does the same, but theirs are pointed at the young cop.

"If he touches my wife, I'm going to slice your neck open. Do you understand me?"

He swallows, his wide eyes going to the punk kid who I can see out of the corner of my eye remains by the door with his gun pointed at me. The detective growls, "She's a murderer."

I don't deny it, twisting the knife a little. "I'm going to murder you if he touches her."

Baring his teeth, he tries to catch his breath. "Stand…down," he tells the kid.

"But—"

"Stand down," he shouts, and the cop puts his gun away. Everyone else keeps theirs trained at him just in case.

"Leave." It's Tyson who gives the order, and I yank my knife from the detective's leg, making him grunt. It wasn't deep enough to kill the man, but he'll need stitches.

"Tyson—"

"We're in the middle of an important meeting. Get the fuck out. Next time, you call and give me a heads-up before you walk into my club." He glares at the kid. "And don't ever come here dressed in uniform again."

The detective squares his shoulders, and I smile down at him as I take my pocketknife's bloody blade and run it over his white shirt, cleaning it off.

He turns and exits with a limp, the rent-a-cop slamming the door shut behind him. I close the knife and turn to face my wife. She sits in her seat, arms crossed over her chest with a look of hatred on her face like I did something wrong.

"You're married?" Alex chuckles, his eyes falling to both of our rings. She wasn't wearing hers when she set up that guy for Hooke. "Congrats, man," he adds, putting his gun away.

"Thanks," I say dryly. "It's a blast. You should try it."

She arches a brow at my sarcasm. I can practically see the steam rolling off her, she's so heated.

"I can see that." His laughter grows louder.

"You two—"

"Don't worry, Ty. We won't be coming back for a while. I'm putting my wife under house arrest."

Eve snorts like I can't keep her in one place. The collar and chain in my basement prove otherwise.

"I guarantee he's waiting for you guys in the parking lot. Already called in reinforcements. And probably has a roadblock set up to stop you and arrest her," Tyson says. "You can take my car. Lake can come get me, and I'll pick it up tomorrow."

"Give me your keys." I reach out my hand to my wife, and she digs in her clutch before tossing them at me even though my hand is right in front of her. She's silently begging me to take my belt to her ass when we get out of here.

I bend down, pick up her keys off the floor, and hand them to Colton. "Drive her car." Then I turn to Alex and give him mine. "Ride my bike. Keep them busy."

"Meaning?" Alex questions for clarification.

"Slow them down. Speed them up. Anything to keep them off our asses so they don't follow. I don't care if you have to crash it or get arrested. I'll pay your medical bills or bail you out."

"Got it." He nods and Colton just smiles.

I grab my wife's hand, yank her from the seat, and leave the office, letting the door shut behind us.

We were able to slip into Tyson's car and get out of there without any issues. Thirty minutes later, I'm pulling up to the motel. She gets out, slams the door, and enters room 111.

I exit much slower and check my phone to see if the guys had any problems, but I don't have any texts or missed calls. It makes me even more nervous. Why didn't he chase us?

This is exactly why I didn't take us to her house or mine. I figured he might be waiting there for us.

I walk into the motel room to find her sitting on the bench. I stand in front of her, my ass resting on the dresser the TV sits on with my arms crossed over my chest. "Want to tell me what tonight was about?"

Her pretty green eyes glare up at me. “I find it hypocritical that you’re mad at me for hitting a bitch who wanted to fuck you, yet you stabbed a man who was going to touch me.”

I want to laugh at her logic but instead I explain the obvious. “One, I’m not going to fuck anyone but you. Two, he was going to arrest you. And three, I was referring to you going to Blackout tonight in the first place.”

She looks away. “I wanted a drink.”

“Bullshit,” I argue and she huffs. When she remains silent, I add, “Adam called me—”

She gives a rough laugh, getting to her heels. “I fucking knew it.”

“Eve—”

“I don’t want to talk about it.” She walks toward the door.

“Where the fuck are you going?” I bark, pushing off the dresser.

“The bar—”

I grab a hold of her upper arm and yank her back, cutting her off. “No, you’re not.”

“Let go of me,” she growls, trying to push me away.

I shove her onto the bed, and she tries to kick me, but I manage to push her leg out of the way, grab her arm, and flip her onto her stomach. I grasp both of her arms and pin them behind her back. “What the fuck is wrong?” I demand.

Adam told me, but I want her to open up to me. She has about other parts of her life, why not this? Did he mean something to her? He said that she didn’t remember, but maybe she lied to him. Maybe she thought it meant something to him and when he explained it didn’t, it hurt her.

She softens under my hold, but I don’t fall for it. Instead, I hold her in place. If I let go, she’ll try to hit or kick me. Worse, I haven’t checked to see if she’s carrying. She might have a gun strapped to her chest for all I know. I don’t want to get shot tonight.

I lean over her body. “Eve—”

She rises up and slams the back of her head into my face. I let go of her and stumble back as my vision is momentarily taken away from me. It doesn’t matter how lightly you get hit in the nose; it always makes your eyes water.

"Fuck," I groan, cupping it to see if it's bleeding.

The sound of the door slamming shut tells me she's gone to the bar, because I've got Tyson's car keys in my pocket. I guess she could hitchhike, but I'd put my money on her over any unlucky bastard who offers to give her a ride.

She's still feeling emotions from the drugs that fucking bastard dropped on her thigh. I'll have to fuck it out of her later. Tied up tightly with her cunt and ass stuffed should change her attitude quick.

I don't follow her. Instead, I go to the bathroom and turn on the sink, grabbing a towel and getting it wet before holding it to my face. Glancing up, I remove it to look in the mirror, and I'm surprised that it's not bleeding. She didn't hit me as hard as she could have.

Good one, angel.

I smile, turning the water off and tossing the towel into the sink. My girl wants to play. I'll make sure to play with her.

Exiting the room, I go to Tyson's trunk and pop it open. "Bingo." I smile to myself, reaching in and grabbing the bag. You can always count on a Lord to have the essentials on him at all times.

Closing the trunk, I make my way back into the motel room. I pull out my cell and go to my music. Seconds later, "Even If It Kills Me" by Papa Roach fills the small room.

I throw the bag onto the bed and unzip it. I'll be ready to play with my girl when she gets back.

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SEVENTY



EVERETT

“Can I have a bucket of ice?” I ask, sitting down at the bar as “Comedown” by Bush plays on the old speakers.

The bartender looks at me oddly, and I want to roll my eyes. Where the fuck is Missy when you need her? Probably still passed out at Adam’s house after getting punched in the face last night.

“Sure.” She finally nods, and I go to get cash out of my clutch but realize I left it in the motel room.

“Fuck,” I hiss. I could go get it but decide not to. He’s going to choke me out the moment I step back into that motel room.

Joke’s on him. I’m looking forward to it. The longer he simmers, the more pissed he’ll be.

I need…something, and I’m not sure what it is. I just feel lost and confused. I need him to make me feel alive. To feel like someone else.

“Everything okay, honey?” the guy next to me asks, sipping on his scotch.

“Yeah.” I sigh. “No. I forgot my wallet.” I hold up my right hand. “Need to soak my hand in some ice.” It’s starting to swell. My knuckles are bruising.

He frowns, glancing at it. “That looks pretty bad.” I cup it in my other hand, and he gestures to the bartender. “Whatever she needs is on me tonight.”

“Oh, I couldn’t—”

“You can and will.” He winks.

“Thank you,” I mumble.

The bartender brings me a bucket of ice, and I shove my fist into it, hissing in a breath at the frozen water.

"What happened?" He scoots his barstool closer to me.

This is why a woman should never allow a man to buy her anything. He immediately wants something in return for it. Even if it's just your time. He thinks you owe him something.

You don't.

"Got in a fight with my husband." I hold up my other hand and show him my wedding ring.

"Oh." His eyes widen at the size. "That's…pretty."

I shrug. "I guess so. Not like it means anything."

"How did getting into a fight hurt your hand?" he digs more. It's not that he's really interested. He just wants to keep me talking. If I'm chatting with him, I'm not talking to anyone else.

"Went to hit him and missed. Hit the wall instead."

His eyes roam my face, neck, and chest that my dress exposes before dropping to my thighs. "Well, it could have been much worse."

"Meaning?" I know what he's implying, but I want to hear him say it. It gives me reason to stab him.

"A woman who hits a man can't expect him to not hit her back," he answers. "We have to protect ourselves too."

A man like him will say anything to justify any type of abuse. "I guess so." I drop my eyes to my legs and pull my hand from the ice bucket, cradling it to my stomach.

I'm not saying I'm any better than a man right now. Did I go a little overboard with Kashton tonight? Yes. I just wanted to be alone. I needed a moment, and no one was giving it to me.

But he came for me. That's what I've always wanted. For someone to care enough to show up, and Kashton always does.

"Thanks for the ice. I should get going." I stand from the barstool.

"You're upset. You shouldn't be alone tonight."

Unbelievable. But I'm not surprised. This bar is known for rapists and human trafficking. Statistics cite it's usually someone known to the victim. A family member or someone close to the family. They gain your trust and then turn on you when they think they've got you right where they want you. The ones who don't bother to get to

know you are few and far between. All they see is an easy target and a fast payout.

Dollhouse is an exception to all the rules. Typically, when you're kidnapped and sold, traffickers want you out of the country. But Dollhouse pays a premium dollar to those who bring in people to be trained. They don't ask your name or where you come from because they wipe whatever life you had clear away. You become a number and show up on an app for others to bid on.

Then you're sold to the highest bidder, given a bath, and put on a plane. After that, there's no hope left. By then, you're no longer who you once were anyway. You're just a doll to be stripped down and used.

"I have a motel room next door." I give him a shy smile. "That is…if you want to join me."

"I'd love to." He stands, and happiness bubbles up inside my chest. Maybe this is what I needed.

He follows me across the parking lot and notices the blacked-out Bentley parked outside the room with the personal BLAKOUT license plate. "Your car?"

"Yeah," I lie.

"Huge rock and nice car…he must take good care of you."

I roll my eyes since he's behind me. Most men believe that you can't support yourself. Coming up to the door, I turn the knob and spin around to face him before I open it all the way. "Not always."

He reaches up and pushes my hair behind my ear. The simple touch makes my skin crawl. "Well, that's what I'm here for."

This man thinks he can get me off. If women had half the confidence in themselves that men have in their useless dicks, we would rule the world. Be unstoppable, I swear.

I turn and shove the door open, stepping inside. The room looks like it did when I left it, except my husband is nowhere in sight. There's a black bag on the floor by the dresser that wasn't here before, but that's it.

"The Kill (Bury Me)" by Thirty Seconds To Mars plays from his cell phone sitting on the dresser beside the TV, so I know he didn't go far. He'd never leave his phone behind. Maybe he's in the bathroom.

I turn to the man. "Would you—"

He wraps his hand around my throat, picks me up off the floor, and slams my back onto the bed, cutting off my air.

"I bet you like it rough." He gives me a sinister smile.

You have no idea, buddy.

I buck my hips, and it forces him up off his knees a little bit but not enough to get out from underneath him.

He laughs. "Feisty bitch."

I reach up to stab his eyes out, but his arm is longer than mine so I can't reach his face. Instead, I grab at his suit jacket and button-down. Anything I can reach.

His free hand yanks my dress off my shoulder to expose my bra, and he frowns that I'm not naked underneath.

Fucking bastard. Where is Kashton?

I arch my neck, trying to relieve the pressure on my throat, but it does no good. My fisted hands punch at his chest, and he laughs, letting go of me.

Gasping, my throat burns when I manage to breathe. He gets off me and stands at the end of the bed. He undoes his belt and then unzips his slacks. I take the opportunity to roll onto my stomach and reach for the lamp on the nightstand as he grabs my ankle and pulls me down to the end of the bed. I flip back over and slam it into the side of his face, breaking the lamp.

"Fuck," he stumbles back.

I shove my heel into his chest, knocking him into the dresser and TV, causing it to crash to the floor. He trips over it, stumbling around, disoriented.

Reaching out, I take advantage of his situation and yank his belt from his slacks since he had it undone and jump on his back, wrapping it around his neck from behind and pulling it as tight as I can.

He thrashes around, slamming my back into the mirrored wall before he shoves me into a corner, making me grind my teeth at the sharp edge biting into my skin.

His hands frantically try to reach behind him to grab at me, but all he gets is a few loose strands of my hair every now and then, yanking pieces from my scalp.

"How does it feel to choke, you bastard?" I grind out, refusing to let go no matter how much my right hand hurts.

His legs give out and he falls to his knees, and still I hang on for dear life. If I let go, I'm dead. I won't get an advantage over him again, and I don't have a gun or knife on me. This is it.

He falls face-first onto the floor just as the door opens. Kashton steps inside and comes to a stop.

"About fucking time. Where the fuck have you been?" I bark.

KASHTON

"What—" I look out at the bar across the parking lot and then back at her. "What the fuck are you doing?" I step inside, shutting the door behind me. The bed is disheveled, the TV broken and on the floor.

"What's it look like I'm doing?" She gets up on shaky legs and falls back into the dresser, running the back of her hand across her drool-covered chin while she tries to catch her breath.

Her dress is shoved up to her waist, and she pushes it down to her thighs before fixing the shoulder strap.

"Are you fucking serious right now?" I demand, staring at the dead guy. At least I hope he's dead. I kick him to see if he makes any noise, and he doesn't.

"He came on to me." She shrugs. "Then he attacked me."

I set my Crunch bar on the dresser, along with the bucket of ice I got for her hand.

Eve begins to laugh. "I almost died because you were getting chocolate?" She arches a brow. "Are you about to start your period, Kash?"

I want to strangle her, but it looks like the mystery man beat me to it because her neck is red and irritated. I move to stand in front of her, pinning her ass against the dresser, and she stiffens. "You're fucking crazy," I tell her, cupping her face.

She licks her lips. "Yeah, but you knew that when you met me."

"I did." I run my knuckles over her throat, and she leans her head back so I can get a better look at the redness on her sensitive skin while she tries to calm her breathing.

"And you still love me," she adds.

"I do," I agree, and she lowers her head, meeting my stare. "How's your hand?"

Her green eyes hold mine, and there's a challenge in them. "How's your nose?"

"Not broken," I answer.

"Mine either." She places her hands on my hips, pulling me into her.

"I know what you're doing," I tell her.

A smile curves the edges of her plump lips. "What am I doing?"

Fuck, I'm obsessed with this woman. She is everything I've ever wanted in my life. I want to consume her. Devour her.

"You're not getting out of your punishment."

She lifts her right leg, wrapping it around my hip, and I lower my hand to slide up her dress and grip her thigh. "I've been looking forward to that all night."

Her lips near mine and I move my head to her neck. My fingers dig into her soft flesh while my lips tenderly kiss her racing pulse. The room fills with her panting, and her hands grip my shirt. "Kash, please."

"What do you need, angel?" I ask her, already knowing what it is and that I'm not going to give it to her.

"Fuck me." She tries yanking me toward the bed.

Reaching down, I grab the hem of her dress and pull it up and over her head, tossing it away. She doesn't even wait for me to remove her underwear. She throws them across the room and steps back into me.

"Lie on the bed," I order.

She takes a step back, licking her lips nervously.

"Now. Eve," I command when she just stands there. What little confidence she had five minutes ago is now gone. "On your stomach with your head at the foot of the bed."

Turning, she crawls onto the mattress and gets into position. I push the bench out of the way and step up to the footboard. I secure her wrists to each corner, careful with the hand she hit the woman with back at Blackout.

I stuff a pillow underneath her hips, propping her ass and cunt up in the air, and then tie each ankle to the corners of the headboard.

When she ran over to the bar, I removed the rope I found in Tyson's bag and had already secured them to each corner of the bed, knowing what I was going to do to her when she returned.

She struggles with the ropes, and I come to the foot of the bed. Crouching down, I sweep her hair from her face, gripping it in my fist and lifting her head off the end so I can look her in the eye when I speak. "What do you want me to do to you, angel?"

"Play with me," she begs. "Please." She pulls on the restraints.

"Do you think you deserve that after how you've acted tonight?" I ask.

She bites her bottom lip and closes her eyes.

"Answer me." I give her hair in my fist a tug, making her whimper.

"No." She sucks in a ragged breath.

"No," I agree, letting go so her head hangs off the edge. I undo my belt and pull it from its loops. Doubling it over, I order, "Count," then slap it down across her ass.

She cries out, her body tensing and pulling on the ropes that hold her down. "One." She sniffs.

Whack.

"T-wo," she stutters.

Whack.

She's gasping, her body trembling, and I smile at the red marks across her round ass. "Three," she counts through a sob.

Whack. I hit her upper thighs.

"F-four." She humps the pillow underneath her hips.

"You're going to be sore tomorrow, Eve. I want you to remember this. Every time you move, I want you to know that I'm in charge here. That you're my wife and that I control what you do and where you go. Do you understand?" She could have gotten arrested tonight. What if I hadn't shown up at Blackout when I did? Would she still have gotten into a fight? I think so. My girl went out looking for trouble.

Whack. I hit her thighs once more and she buries her face in the end of the bed.

"Five." She manages through a sob.

My eyes admire her sweat-covered body, loving the fresh bright red marks my belt left. I should do this every night. Just in case she tries to go out on the town without me. I want everyone to know she's mine. That I'm her husband. I protect her and I own her.

I undo both ankles and she pulls on her arms thinking I'm releasing them next. "Bring your legs up underneath you," I order and rip the pillow from under her hips. "I want your ass and cunt in the air for me to see."

She lets out a cry of pain as she gets into the new position. I smile, knowing it's stretching her freshly welted skin.

Undoing my zipper, I pull my hard cock out and get onto the bed, spreading her legs farther with my knees, slowly sliding into her. Loving her attempt to keep me out.

Leaning over her back, I command, "Open your mouth." I shove my belt behind her teeth, forcing her to bite on it. Then I bring it around her head and slide the leather through the buckle, pulling it tight. I grip the excess in my hand, holding her head in place.

My other one slides between her trembling legs and feels her pussy. "You're soaked, angel. Getting your ass spanked turned you on. If I didn't know better, I'd say you acted out on purpose."

She mumbles around the belt, and I smile to myself. Pulling my cock out, I look down and watch it disappear into her tight pussy.

I groan. "Fuck, Eve." My breath catches and I pull back before slamming forward. Her back arches more, and I pull on the belt, forcing her head back. "Don't come." I growl. "This is about me. Not you."

My girl acts out in order to be punished. She knows I'm not going to take it too far. This isn't about hurting her. It's about controlling her. My free hand slaps her ass right over one of the marks from my belt, and her cunt grips me in response. I do it again and she cries out around the belt in her mouth. "You're doing so good, angel," I tell her. "Taking my cock like a good whore." I pull out and push forward. "Feel your pussy sucking me in?" I do it again. "You need me, angel." I smack her ass again, and she begins to shake uncontrollably. "You better not come. If you do, I'll tie your legs down and take my belt to your ass again."

I'm panting and she's crying. I pick up the pace, slamming into her cunt while my one hand holds the belt and my free hand grips her ass. My eyes drop to watch my slick cock fuck her.

Pulling my jeans up, I fasten them and then run my belt through the loops. I glance up to see her standing at the sink, staring down at her phone, her ass and thighs red from what I just did to her while my cum drips from her pussy. She didn't get off. I'm going to make her beg me for that later.

My girl always does this. She's able to avoid telling me what I want to know. I asked her about Adam, and she slammed her head into my face to get away from the conversation. There's only one thing I need to know. "Do you love him?"

"What?"

I walk up behind her, turn her to face me, and her breathing accelerates. I grab her phone from her hand and place it on the counter, wanting all her attention.

I take her flushed face in my hand, forcing her eyes to mine. "Do you love him?" I repeat.

"Who?" she asks, swallowing nervously.

It doesn't matter if she does, she's mine. And like Sin once told me, he'd kill a brother for his wife. I'll do the same if mine tries to take her from me. "Adam."

That gets her attention. "No. Why would you ask that?" Her eyes search mine.

Letting go of her, I step back and push the bench back to the footboard of the bed and sit down on it. "He called me and said you were upset, and when I tried to talk to you, you completely shut me out. You took the time to go see him but won't talk to me about it. There has to be something there, Eve."

"There's nothing there. I…" She hangs her head and sighs. "I don't remember sleeping with him." Glancing up at me through her lashes, she sniffs. "After Evan…" She looks away. "Things started to come back to me. But even after Adam showed me the picture, I still don't remember."

"Picture?" I question. What the fuck does she mean by that?

Eve walks over to the dresser and opens up her clutch. Pulling out a picture, she holds it out to me.

"Adam gave you this?" I demand, looking over it. My jaw clenches. What the fuck? He didn't tell me that he had this.

"Yeah. He said Haidyn gave it to him."

"Haidyn has seen this?" I jump to my feet. "When?"

"Yes," she answers softly. "Something about Isabella and blackmail. But Haidyn didn't know that was me. Probably still doesn't."

I run a hand down my face and toss the picture onto the dresser, face down.

"I'm sorry." She sniffs, and I turn to face her. Her tear-filled eyes look up at mine where she now sits on the bench. "I'm so sorry, Kash."

I kneel in front of her, taking her hands in mine. "It's not your fault, Eve." I'm not happy she's slept with Adam, or that he has a fucking picture of it, but I don't blame her for what she did before I found her. What I hate most is that my brother has had the past four years of her life. If I had just tried to find Adam, he would have led me to her. Instead I wasted time.

"Don't you understand? If I can't remember sleeping with Adam, there are probably others that I don't remember." Her bottom lip starts to tremble. "I tried so hard to not have sex…After Dollhouse… my body…" Her shoulders shake. "I never wanted it until you. That night on the *Isabella*…you saved me from that Lord. You make me feel better…about myself and what I like. I didn't want to be a whore…I want you to be the only man I've ever slept with. I'm so sorry…"

"Angel." I sigh, get up to pull her into my lap, and sit down on the bench. "You're not—"

"You're the one I love," she interrupts me, tears slowly falling down her cheeks. "I promise. It's you, Kashton. It's always been you…"

"It's okay, Eve." I try to ease her conscience as I hold her tightly to my chest.

"And tonight. That woman was talking in the bathroom with her friends about sleeping with you and getting you to knock her up—"

"That's never going to happen."

"It just reminded me of what I can't give you."

How long is she going to beat herself up with this? The rest of her life? Probably. But I understand, it's her biggest fear. And our fears have a way of settling in the back of our minds. So whenever she thinks of it, I'll remind her that it's nothing to worry about.

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SEVENTY-ONE



EVERETT

I sit in the passenger seat of Tyson's Bentley eating my husband's Crunch bar while he drives us into town. My ass and thighs are screaming at how hard Kashton took his belt to them. I love it. I deserved that punishment for my outburst. For my past. Who I allowed myself to be. I needed him to put me in my place. To show me he's in charge.

"Can we stop by the cemetery?" I break the silence. He doesn't even have the radio on, and that's not like him. He's worried about Adam and me, and I hate that I've placed any doubt in his mind. I can barely stand Adam most days. The fact that I slept with him makes me want to vomit. He could never be who Kashton is to me.

"Of course," he answers, hand in mine resting on his lap.

I break off a piece of the Crunch bar and hold it in front of his face to eat.

Then I lean down and pick up the bottle of whiskey that I talked the bartender out of from the bar next to the motel before we left. She wasn't that willing to give it up at first, but I threw a wad of hundreds at her, and she changed her mind. I needed a drink and the liquor stores are already closed for the night.

He glances over at me and then places his eyes back on the road.

"What?" I ask, yanking my hand from his. I can't wait for this damn drug to be out of my system. Even I'm tired of the mood swings.

"Nothing." He shakes his head.

"You're lying. It's something. Spit it out."

He remains quiet but he peers at the bottle once more.

"Are you calling me an alcoholic?" I ask, crossing my arms over my chest.

"We both know you'd be dead from alcohol poisoning if you weren't a founder."

I huff. "If I wasn't a founder, I'd have died long before I started drinking," I say, looking out the window as he drives down the highway. The drugs that Dollhouse pumped into my system alone would have done me in. A person can only take so much before their body gives out.

The enhancements help our immune systems. It's a way for those at the top to live longer. You'll never see a powerful Lord with cancer or any type of untreatable disease.

But it also backfired on them. They say that's how the confessional and offerings started. The ones they wanted out would live for too long, so the Lords came up with a way of getting rid of a founder whose time wasn't up yet.

It's supposed to keep them accountable.

It's rigged. If they want you dead, you're dead. They put you in a position where you're forced to fuck up, and then they end your life.

"Eve—"

"Don't bother," I interrupt him, ending the conversation. He's not wrong. I've been trying to drink my life away for years. Why stop now?

KASHTON

She sits in front of the unmarked headstone, and I sit behind her, resting my back against the tree trunk. She leans into me, and I wrap my arms around her waist, my chin perched on her head.

"I'm not even sure why I come here. It just feels right, ya know?"

I don't say anything, because I don't have anyone to visit. My mother was cremated and then tossed away. My father is buried at Carnage, but I pretend he never existed. If you ask me, he's the one who deserves to be forgotten.

"Did Bill tell you about your mother?" I ask her. As sad as it is, she seems happiest when she's here in the cemetery.

"A little. I was my mom's second child. She had Evan really young and then was sentenced to be a breeder. After Bill saved me and told

me who he was to my mother, I started to dig. I wanted to know if she had more children. But Bill told me that after me, she had a miscarriage. Then another one, and after that, the Lords deemed her unfit to fulfill her duties. So they killed her."

"Do you believe him?" It makes sense. A life of a breeder ends when they are no longer useful to the Lords. So I've been told…

Everett sighs heavily. "I want to. I'd rather her be dead than out there somewhere being forced to breed with the Lords. The sad part is that I'm not even sure which grave is hers. If any of them is her."

My eyes scan the unmarked graves. There are hundreds. Some have missing pieces and have been stained over time from the weather.

"She was cremated. Her body was of no use, so they destroyed it. Same for my baby. After my stay in the hospital at Carnage, Garrett placed an urn in my room. Said it was my baby that he had cremated. I was eventually dropped off at Dollhouse after Haidyn chose the other woman, and by the time Bill saved me, I couldn't go back to Carnage, so I don't know what happened to my baby."

"So why this plot? What made you choose this grave?" I ask.

"Because it's where I'd want to be." She glances up at the tree I'm leaning against. The same one I stood at when I found her here when I was following her.

I kiss her hair.

"When I die, burn my body and dump me here."

"Absolutely not." I deny her absurd request.

"Kash—"

"You will be buried at Carnage next to me. Where you belong." No exceptions.

She turns in my arms, and I let go of her. A frown on her pretty face. "I want to be cremated."

"You're being buried."

She huffs, getting to her feet. The bottle of whiskey in her hand. "You're saying I don't get to choose?"

"You get to choose whether you want to be buried on my right or my left," I say, looking up at her where I remain sitting. It's that simple.

“Unbelievable,” she hisses, giving me her back. My eyes drop to her legs. She’s still wearing her dress and heels from the club because we didn’t have anything for her to change into. “Even in death, you decide everything.” Tipping the bottle back, she takes a sip. “What about your next wife?” She turns to face me once more.

“Next wife?” I can’t help but smile. “Angel, you’re going to be my one and only wife.”

She pops a hip out. “Say I die first and then you get married again. And then you die and she buries you—”

I burst out laughing, cutting her off, and her eyes narrow on me.

“What’s so funny?” she demands and her knuckles go white from tightening around the bottle.

“You. You come up with the craziest hypothetical situations that aren’t going to happen,” I answer through a smile.

“It’s a legitimate concern.” I frown, and her eyes drop to her wedding ring. “It happened to Bill.” Her eyes meet mine and I hold in a sigh. “He told me how much he loved my mother and wished he could have saved her…but now he’s on his third marriage to Janice, and he’ll be buried with her.”

“Is that why you want to be cremated?”

She shuffles from foot to foot. Taking a deep breath, her green eyes find mine. “My body is useless. It would be a waste of space. Burn what’s left of me and throw my ashes here.” Licking her lips, she adds softly, “This is where I belong.”

I look over the abandoned cemetery. I don’t think there’s anything I can say that will make her feel differently. My wife thinks very little of herself because of how she’s been used, but I’m making it my life’s mission to show her how important she is. That she is somebody.

My wife.

My world.

My everything.

I hope I go first so I don’t have to spend a life without her, but I’ll be dammed if she’s cremated and dumped here. I will make sure that her guardian knows she is to be buried at Carnage next to me.

"You belong next to me—your Lord. Your husband. And that's where you will be laid to rest." This is something I will not budge on. I don't care if I die twenty years before she does, there will be instructions to make sure my wife is next to me.

"So bossy." A smile tugs at her lips, and I don't hide mine.

My girl likes me taking control and telling her what she'll do.

She falls to straddle my legs, and it pushes her dress up in the process. My hands go to her thighs. "Want to know a secret?"

"Absolutely."

"My first kiss was in this cemetery."

My teeth grind. "Who was he?" I demand.

She smiles. "So jealous."

If she is able to remember the fucker, he's dead. "I mean it, Eve. Who the fuck was it?"

"Why? Going to kill him?"

"Yes." I'm going to bury his body right here with all the other sorry bastards.

Her smile just grows, showing off her perfectly straight teeth. "Why would you do that?"

"Because I don't want anyone out there walking around knowing what my wife's lips feel like."

She throws her head back, laughing. As much as I love that sound, I don't find this funny. Reaching up, I wrap my hand around her delicate neck, cutting off her laughter. Bringing her face to mine, I glare at her.

"That's a shame because I'm quite fond of him." My hand tightens at her confession, and she leans forward, pressing her lips to mine, and speaks softly. "It was you."

"Don't lie to me, Eve."

"I'm not. It was you. In this very spot."

I snort. "You only let me kiss you to distract me so you could drug me." It didn't take me long to figure out her plan when I woke up on the ground covered in dirt.

She laughs softly. "True, but…that doesn't change the fact that you were my first kiss."

I frown, and she props the bottle of whiskey up against a rock on the ground before wrapping her arms around my neck. Her fingers gently play with my hair while her gaze drops to my shirt.

I can tell when her mind wanders off. "What is it, Eve?"

"I… My body was used a lot, but no one ever kissed me." Her eyes meet mine. "Until you," she whispers.

I let go of her neck and push her hair off her shoulder.

"I told myself to stay away. Not to let you get too close, because I knew…"

"Knew what?" I urge.

"That if I let you kiss me I'd be done for."

"Done for?" I smirk, trying to lighten the mood. "You make it sound like falling in love with me was a horrible mistake."

She slaps my chest playfully and rolls her eyes.

Grabbing her face, I bring her lips to mine. My fingers slide into her already tangled hair, and she moans into my mouth while her hips grind into mine.

She pulls away, panting, her heavy eyes on mine. "You know you're the best thing to ever happen to me."

I'm going to give this woman the life she dreams of. Whatever she wants.

She leans in to kiss me, and this time her hand falls to my belt.

I swallow her yelp when I slap her ass. Removing my belt, I pull away from her lips and push her arms behind her back. I tie them without looking, and when I'm satisfied, I wrap an arm around her waist and get up, placing her on the ground.

"Kash," she breathes, arching her back.

I kneel over her, pushing her dress up to her neck to expose her body to me, and then undo my jeans, pulling my hard cock out.

I don't bother removing her underwear. Instead, I just pull it to the side and slide into my wife. No foreplay.

The thought of being the first and only man to kiss her gives me an animalistic need. Of course there could be others she just doesn't remember. But I'll take it. It means something to her, so it means something to me.

I wish now more than ever I would have paid more attention on the *Isabella*. Fingering her that night made me like every other man that had used her. I should have asked questions. Forced answers.

She cries out, and I silence her with my lips. My hands slide under her head, gripping her hair and holding her in place as I slam into her soaked cunt.

"I love you." Pulling away, I dot kisses along her jaw and neck.

"I…love you," she gasps.

Sitting up, I wrap my hands around her delicate neck and watch her eyes grow heavy. "Such a pretty angel."

I slow my rhythm, pulling my hips back. Her pussy tightens, trying to suck me back in. I smile down at my wife while she struggles to breathe.

Her plump lips are parted and her back arches. "Eyes on me, Eve," I order when they grow heavy. "Don't you dare pass out on me."

She blinks, her lashes fanning her cheeks, and I smile when her body begins to shudder. "That's it." I drop my eyes to look down to see my cock covered in cum when I slide out before slamming forward. "Good girl." I loosen up on her neck, and she gasps in a shaky breath while her body trembles on the ground.

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SEVENTY-TWO



EVERETT

"I 'm going to meet up with Janice and Elli. They invited me over this evening." I smile at Kashton while I stand in his bathroom.

It's been a week since I went all crazy on the girl at Blackout and he fucked me in the cemetery. We had my birthday party last night and it was actually really fun. I had a great time hanging out with friends and eating cake. I think I told Janice twenty times how amazing it was. I'd never eaten anything that tasted so good in my life. She really did outdo herself.

He steps inside and leans against the countertop. "Want me to come? I can drive you."

"No." I turn to give him a smile. "I don't think it'll take long. I'll only be gone for a few hours. Tops. Plus the drive will take up most of that."

"Okay." He nods, and I let out a sigh of relief that he's not tagging along.

I can't do a job if he's with me. "I want to stay at your house tonight." Moving to stand before him, I wrap my arms around his neck.

"I want to talk to you about that." He places his hands on my hips.

I frown. "About your house? Are you selling it? We can stay at mine if you'd prefer." There's no reason for us to have two houses.

Shaking his head, he gives me a soft smile. "How about we get a place that's ours?"

I tilt my head. "Somewhere new?"

"Yeah. Something that we build. Together."

I lean up and kiss his lips. “I love it.” My place has too many memories of Evan just popping in whenever he wants. Carnage is the last place I ever want to be, but for Kashton, I’d do it. His house is too close to mine. Somewhere new sounds amazing. New beginnings and making new memories. Just me and him. I swallow the lump that forms in my throat at that thought. It’ll just be the two of us for the rest of our lives. What will I do if something happens to him? How will I live without him now that I’ve had a life with him?

One of the hardest things to comprehend for someone who was once suicidal is when they decide to live, how scary the thought of death really is.

He slaps my ass, and I push my hips into his.

“Later,” he promises.

I step back, and he reaches into his pocket. “Here. Take my car.” He hands me his keys.

“You sure?”

“Of course.” He kisses me on the forehead. “Yours needs fuel. I’ll stop and fill it up tomorrow for you.”

There’s a knock on his bedroom door, and he steps away to answer it.

I peek my head out of the bathroom to see its Haidyn. I smile at him, and he returns it. It’s weird, going from no one in my life to a group of people who make me feel welcome.

“Saint wants us down in the basement,” he tells Kashton.

I pick up my cell as they carry on with their conversation, and I see I have to go. I’m going to be late.

Pulling up to the motel, I park in front of room 111. When I started working at the bar and motel—taking out bastards—I chose this room. It’s sentimental to me. It’s labeled with the same numbers that Evan carved into my hip, so I ripped the three ones off the door and carved them into the wood instead. It made me feel good at first. Now it serves as a reminder of my past. I want a different future with Kashton. I’m going to have to walk away from this life, and for him, I will. But it can’t hurt to take out one more bastard.

I get out and drop my bag off inside before I walk over to the bar.

My heels clap on the uneven ground before I enter the bar. It's only eight o'clock, so it's not very busy. The place never is to begin with. It's next to a highway outside of town. You have to know about it to end up here.

No one driving by says, *Hey, let's stop there and have a drink*.

I sit down and Missy spots me. She frowns, confused as to why I'm here, and it makes the hairs on the back of my neck rise.

"What can I get you, miss?" She's got her dark hair up in a high pony and her makeup on the lighter side with nude gloss.

She looks good. Better than last time I saw her with a bruised face.

"Whiskey. Please."

"Coming right up." She taps the bar and pours me a glass.

"Thank you," I say, dropping some cash onto the bar top and picking up my drink, exiting the bar and returning to the room.

I'm doing this one differently. I instructed him to meet me here. Fuck the bar tonight. I don't have time for small talk. I'm going to kill the bastard, run to my house, and get back to my husband. I have plans to spend all night on my knees for him. Limbs tied and mouth open. Just like the good girl I am for him.

A knock comes on the door, and I smile. How gentlemanly of him.

Getting up, I open it to see a young man standing before me. His eyes drop to my high heels and run up over my skinny jeans and tube top.

I wasn't in the mood for a dress. They always seem to tear it off or pull it down. The tube top probably wasn't the best choice, but it's not like I can wear an overly large T-shirt and sweatpants.

"Hi." I pop my hip out and give him a fake smile.

"Hey." He rubs his jaw and surveys my left hand.

I took my ring off and left it in Kashton's car. Stepping to the side, I gesture for him to enter.

He enters the room, and I shut the door, locking it. I don't want someone slipping in without me knowing. If he's got friends coming, they're going to have to kick it in.

My cell lights up on the dresser by the TV, **Fuckface** flashing across the screen. I press Ignore. Interesting. He knows I'm working.

"So…" The man turns to face me. "How does all this work?"

"You pay me, and I fuck you." I twirl my hair around my finger. I wore it down, knowing it wasn't the best idea.

"Yeah. Yeah." He nods, reaching into his back pocket and removing his wallet. He grabs a twenty and tosses it onto the dresser. The guy seems nervous. Definitely younger than my usual fifty-year-old and older married bastards.

I arch a brow. "What do you have in mind?"

He licks his lips. "I…uh, I'm an ass man."

Cheap bastard.

Twenty bucks to fuck my ass? It's usually the ones who pay the least that expect the most from you. But then again, women are out there doing it for free.

"I didn't prep for that," I say honestly. "Does that bother you?"

He pulls his lip back with disgust, and I want to laugh. Kashton doesn't give a fuck.

His cell beeps, and I look at his front pocket. "Do you need to get that?"

He waves it off. "They can wait."

Red flags are going off, but I'm here for a reason. I got the text for a job, and I have never missed one. **Fuckface** lights my cell up once more, and I huff. "Remove your pants," I order.

His face reddens. "I, uh—"

I kick him in the dick as hard as I can, and he drops to his knees, doubling over. He screams like a little bitch, and I kick him in the face.

Falling onto his back, I open the top drawer to the dresser and stand over him with my gun pointed at his head. "Who the fuck are you?" I demand.

I knew this would happen. That my luck would run out. That they'd put two and two together and find out what I'm doing. My first sign should have been Missy confused to see me. They always know when I'm doing a job. She must have called Adam, and that's why he was calling me.

"Speak, motherfucker." I stomp my red-bottomed heel between his legs, pressing down on his balls.

"Fuucckkkk." He arches his back and spit flies from his mouth. "I…I wasn't going to hurt you," he cries.

"Then what the fuck are you doing here?" I demand, adding a twisting motion to the pressure.

He fists his hands and gasps in a breath. "Delivering you…"

"Delivering me to where?"

"Cathedral."

Fuck. I remove my heel, crouch down, and yank his cell from his pocket. I go to his texts, and my stomach drops at what I read.

I fall down onto the bench at the end of the bed. Pointing the gun at his head, I pull the trigger.

KASHTON

I stand down in the basement with my brothers and Hooke. The sorry bastard we took from Blackout—Maxwell—lies naked and curled up in a ball on the floor. A couple of days with no food or water has given him time to reflect on his life choices.

"Where the fuck is she?" Hooke asks, running a hand down his face.

I've never been one of the guys who tortures others. I leave that to Saint and Haidyn. I have a problem when it comes to getting information out of people. I end up just killing them. Like this fucker. If I was Hooke, I'd shoot him right between the eyes, but that defeats the purpose of getting the information he needs.

"She's…gone," he chokes out.

"Is she dead?" Haidyn demands.

"I don't know." The guy sits up, cradling his broken arm to his chest. "I did my job—"

"Which is?" Hooke interrupts him.

"Clients send me information on potential dolls, and I investigate."

"Investigate?" Saint snorts.

"You stalk them," I clarify. "Learn their routine. See who they are and who they know. You decide if they're worth taking."

I learned so much about Eve when I was following her. It told me everything I needed to know—she was alone and vulnerable. That thought makes me smile. My angel is a lot of things, but she's not helpless.

"So you chose Hailey to be a doll?" Hooke begins to pace. "Who wanted her?"

"You don't understand," the guy wails. "She was never taken. She was in on it."

Hooke rushes over to him and kicks the guy in the face. It knocks him to the ground, and Hooke shouts, "Quit fucking lying. She would never help you."

He cries and rolls over to his side. "She…was a recruiter."

"I don't believe you." Hooke spits at him. "She has a younger sister."

Haidyn looks at me, and I rub the back of my neck when he starts walking my way. I know exactly what he's going to say. "Evan was going to make Eve a recruiter."

I nod.

"It's not like this is the first time we've heard of this," Saint adds. "Ashtyn's mother and Luke were helping recruit for Isabella while framing Adam. We just didn't find this out until recently."

"Your point?" Hooke barks.

"His point is maybe they were brainwashed," I answer, thinking of my wife. Hooke opens his mouth, but I raise my hand to stop him. "You said it yourself. Hailey has a younger sister. What if they were using her to get to Hailey?"

Hooke frowns.

"Have you spoken to her sister?" Saint asks Hooke.

He shakes his head. "No. All I know is that she lives in Las Vegas. Hailey visited her often."

"That makes sense as to why Hailey went there and was with Hudson. Call the Mason brothers and have them do a search on the cameras for the sister." I shrug. "It can't hurt."

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SEVENTY-THREE



EVERETT

I sit in Kashton's car while "Power Over Me" by Dermot Kennedy plays softly through the speakers and I hold my cell in my hand.

I'm trying to get the courage to make the phone call I don't want to make. I knew it would be this way. That I'd choose him. It wasn't even a question.

He has more to live for than me. I won't be the reason he wastes his life. I have no future. He has everything. Even if he doesn't see it that way.

I look down at my wedding ring and a sense of pride washes over me. To be called his. Even if it was for such a short time.

The vows we took don't mean any less just because we didn't spend years together.

Glancing at the clock on the dash, I see I've got twenty minutes. It's now or never.

Licking my lips, I go to his contact and press Call. The song stops and the sound of his cell ringing fills the speakers.

"Hey, angel. Where you at?" His voice hits my ears, and tears instantly sting my eyes. "You were supposed to be back an hour ago. Everything go okay?"

I swallow the lump in my throat, trying to buy myself some more time. "I—" I can't get the words out. I close my eyes, slamming the back of my head against the headrest, mad at myself for being so weak.

"Eve?" His voice has changed from welcoming to worried. "Everett, where are you?" Kashton demands this time.

Sniffling, I'm able to whisper, "I'm sorry."

"Eve," he growls. "Where the fuck are you? I'm not going to ask you again."

I manage a smile through the tears that silently fall. Always so bossy. "Please know this is my choice."

He tries to video call me when I see my face on the screen. I hit Decline. Hearing me fall apart is one thing. Watching it is another. I don't want him seeing me like this to be the last memory he has of me.

"Angel," he sighs. "Please. Tell me where you are. I'm coming. Just tell me where I'm going." I hear him snapping his fingers and whispering, "Eve."

I can only imagine he's pointing at his cell telling Haidyn and Saint that I'm on the phone. And then Kashton speaks to them. "Barrington."

Looking up out of the window, I see the university. I'm sitting in the north parking lot. I knew he'd be able to track me. If I didn't want him to find me, then I wouldn't have called him. It's either on my cell or in his car. Either way, I'm here for a reason.

"We're coming," he tells me.

It'll be too late. "I love you."

"Don't," he growls. "Don't pull this shit now, Eve. We'll be there—"

"It's okay," I interrupt him. I've accepted my fate. It was always going to be this way.

"I can save you," he rushes out, and my chest tightens at the thought of leaving him alone. "Whatever it is. Whatever has happened…I can save you."

I smile through the tears. "You already have. Don't you see that, Kash? You have shown me what it feels like to be loved." He has saved me from myself. For so long I felt I didn't deserve this life. That I would die alone. At least now I get to die for a good cause.

"No—"

"This is all I can give you." The truth hurts as much as a lie would. Because I wish I could give him more. The family and life he deserves. "This is my purpose." To save him. "You're my purpose," I remind him.

"Listen to me, Eve." His voice is cold. He's mad at me. I get it. But it won't change my mind. "We are on our way. Just stay right where you're at, and we'll discuss this. Whatever it is, the guys and I will take care of it. Okay? You'll be okay. I'll keep you safe."

I smile at the thought of how much he wants to protect me. He'll make a great father someday. I regret it won't be me who gives him kids. "Sometimes you have to hurt the one you love," I say, quoting what his mother once said to him. "I love you."

"EVE—"

I hang up and toss my phone out the window before I drive off. I already spent too much time telling him goodbye. They'll be here soon looking for me.

KASHTON

"Goddammit," I shout, throwing my cell into the dashboard of the Escalade.

"Yeah, she's at Barrington…"

I tune Saint out in the back seat on speakerphone with Tyson. I'm trying to rack my brain and figure out what the fuck is going on. What the fuck has happened since she left Carnage earlier? What have I missed? Who is after her? I thought I had taken care of this when Haidyn killed the girl. Who has she spoken to that has put Eve's life in danger?

I got comfortable playing house with her. Thinking that some vows would change our life and make it a better world for us to be in together.

Adam assured me that the cops had backed off. For now. They needed more evidence. It can't be them.

The Lords always want what you have. Nothing is sacred. Not to them, and therefore not to us.

"Kash?"

I bend down and grab my phone where it lies between my boots on the floorboard, and I call her again.

It rings five times before going to voicemail. "Hey—"

I hang up and call her again. "Pick up, angel. Pick up." I will her to answer her damn phone, but again, nothing.

"Kash?"

I drop the phone to my lap and run my hands through my hair. I'm shaking. I'm not sure if it's from anger or fear, but I can't stop it.

"Kashton!" A hand hits my shoulder, and I look over to see Haidyn speaking to me. His lips are moving, but I can't hear anything.

I've gone numb. All I can think about is getting to her so I can wring her neck for telling me goodbye. Why would she do it over the phone like that? Eve isn't a coward. No. My wife is strong and says what's on her mind. No matter if you want to hear it or not.

"Kashton, man, are you listening to me?"

I blink and notice we've come to a stop. "Where is she?" I demand, looking out the window to see we're in a parking lot at Barrington. It's a Saturday night. There's not a soul here other than us. All the college kids are out and about getting fucked up.

"That's what I'm trying to tell you. She's not here."

No. No. No. This can't be happening. It's like a bad dream. I look at my cell. It shows she's here. "The tracker is on her phone." I never put one on her. Rookie mistake. I should have held her down and put one in her neck. "Her cell is here."

I shove the passenger door open and get out of the SUV. I call up her number and listen as it starts to ring to my right. I run toward a small patch of grass. Dropping to my knees, I pick up her cell to see **Kashton** lighting up the screen.

"Fuck," I say through gritted teeth. Closing my eyes, I tighten my hold on her cell.

"Where the fuck is she?" Haidyn demands and then snaps at Saint, "Call Tyson. Tell them not to come here. We need to spread out. Cover more ground."

She played me. She came here, called me to say goodbye, allowed me to track her, and then ditched her cell. She knew I'd come running right to her.

"Where the fuck do I tell him to go?" Saint asks, holding his arms out wide and looking over the dimly lit parking lot.

That's the million-dollar question. *Where the fuck are you, angel?*

I call up Adam. He's the only one I can think of right now that might know something.

"Hey—"

"Has the detective picked up Eve?" I interrupt him. Maybe things have changed and she's running from them.

"What? No. Not that I know of. Why?"

"She just called me and told me goodbye. She was upset and sounded…"

"Sounded what?"

"Suicidal," I answer, hanging my head. *Sometimes you have to hurt the one you love* was what my mother told me before she killed herself. Haidyn was right. I should have done more to help Eve. I thought I could fix whatever was wrong through, what? Sex. Talking about our feelings? Bullshit. It didn't help one fucking bit. I ignored the signs, and now she's going to be gone. "We tracked her phone to Barrington but she's not here."

I can tell he's driving because I can hear the background noise from his Bluetooth. "I'll make a call and let you know what I find out."

Hanging up, I look around Barrington. I pray that my wife is planning on getting arrested. That's something I can fix.

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SEVENTY-FOUR



EVERETT

I had to go to my house after I killed the man at the motel. I needed a few things before I drove to Barrington and made the call to Kashton. Now it's time.

I pull off the two-lane road and bring the car to a stop. Opening up my purse in the passenger seat, I remove my Kimber Micro-9 Aurora. I double check to see one round in the chamber and seven in the magazine. Then I make sure the safety is off.

I pick up Kashton's white zip-up hoodie and slide it on. I zip it all the way up in order to conceal what I have underneath.

Getting out of his car, I lift the back of my hoodie and push the barrel of the gun into the waistband of my jeans. I want to have the element of surprise, so that's where it has to be.

If I was a praying person, this is where I'd ask God to save me. But I'm not here for me. I'm here for my husband. I knew when I read the text on that Lords phone that I'd die today. For him.

My black boots that I changed into at my house thump on the steps as I make my way up to the double doors. Taking a deep breath, I grab the old handles and shove them open.

They creak, and I stomp my way through the entrance and smash through the second set of doors.

Four men dressed in black jeans and matching hoodies stand in front of the Lords' altar. All of them wear masks and their hoods are up. I wish I could say I'm not scared, but the rope that hangs from each end of the altar makes my stomach knot.

They're going to tie me to it and torture me. The thought of them recording it and sending it to Kashton makes me want to vomit. He

doesn't need to see that. His imagination will be bad enough.

"You wanted me. Here I am." I hold my arms out wide. My voice echoes throughout the large space.

The one on the far right steps forward. "We wanted your husband."

How do they know we're married? Not many do. "Always the bridesmaid. Never the bride," I chide, rolling my eyes.

The one next to him steps forward. "Oh, I think we can make do with Mrs. Pierce."

The way he says it freezes me where I stand. They'll definitely record whatever sick shit they're going to do to me and send it to Kash. They'll keep me alive long enough to send him a message as to where I'm at, and he'll come running. Then they'll get him too. It will all be for nothing.

That's why I can't leave here. Not the way I walked in.

"Where's Rhett?" one of them demands.

They could only be referring to one man. "The guy you sent to the motel to kidnap me? He's dead."

They grunt, and the one on the far right readjusts his stance.

"We going to get to it or just stand here and talk?" My fingers itch to reach for my gun. Four against one isn't the best odds, but I'll take as many as I can with me.

I have a vest on. I came as prepared as I could. If there's the slightest chance I can survive this…

"I didn't expect you to be so enthusiastic." The one on the far left tilts his head to the side in thought.

"I did," another laughs. "She's a whore. And whores love to be used."

"Only my husband can call me that." I lift my chin with a smile.

They all laugh. "Well, we'll make sure to call you that when he watches us fuck you."

I fist my hands. Kashton will rip their heads off if I don't do it for him.

"Come here." The one on the far right turns and taps the Lords' altar with his hand. The sound bounces off the high ceilings. "Get undressed and lie down like a good whore would do."

"You didn't think I'd be that easy. Did you?" I arch a brow.

Yes. They did. They expected me to be carried in by the guy that I killed in the motel room. He was sent to pick me up and deliver me by whatever means were necessary.

The sound of a gun cocking behind me has my pulse racing. Fuck. There's another. He was probably outside, and I didn't even bother checking. I was already running out of time. I spent too much time on the phone with Kash.

"Strip," the distorted voice commands behind me.

I spin around and come face-to-face with a new Lord dressed in a cloak and mask, but they seem smaller, shorter. "No."

A laugh carries from the mask-covered lips before "Take off your clothes!" is shouted at me, the gun pointed at my face shaking in their hand.

I stay where I'm at. If they want me naked, they'll have to cut my clothes off me.

"Are you deaf?" The gun is shoved into my forehead, forcing me to arch my neck, and I swallow at the feel of the cold metal.

"I've been close to death before. It doesn't scare me," I say, trying to control my breathing. I'm terrified. Not for me but for Kashton. The longer I take, the more likely it is he'll find me. What if he has a tracker on his car? Surely not. Or Haidyn and Saint would have found us while we were hiding out at Blackout.

The gun is lowered and a mocking laugh is hurled my way. "We're not going to kill you. Not right now, anyway." Then the gun is fired.

I lose my hearing first. There's nothing but a loud ringing. Then the pain takes over. It's like a hot flash but a million times worse. Blinking rapidly, I realize I'm on the floor in the middle of the aisle of the cathedral.

With shaking hands, I run my fingers over my right leg, and it's wet. Lifting my hand, I see it's covered in blood. A burning sensation takes over my chest, and I suck in a deep breath.

"Get her up," the one who shot me orders. "Get her undressed and secured to the altar."

I grip my thigh, trying to stop the bleeding, but it's not going to do any good. I feel around, trying to see if it went through, but I can't tell.

That burning intensifies as I'm grabbed from behind and yanked to my feet. Then I'm thrown over a shoulder and a scream is ripped from my lips as I'm hauled to the Lords' altar. I should fight, but I've got to use this time to my advantage.

My adrenaline is pumping, but my blood pressure will drop with how much blood I'm losing. Right now, my body is in fight-or-flight mode.

"She's wearing a vest." The guy grunts at the feeling of the bulk of it digging into his neck and shoulder.

"So fucking remove it," someone orders.

I'm tossed onto the altar and groan as they go to either side of the end and each grab an ankle. I roll over onto my side, reach behind me, and grab my gun. I get a shot off into one of them before they even notice.

The ringing returns, and I've lost all hearing once again. I don't realize I've been shot a second time until I'm lying on the floor on the back side of the altar. Blood runs from my left arm, and I grit my teeth. At least I can hold the gun with my right hand.

Fuck. I've got to kill them before I die. I have to take them with me. I won't leave them behind to hurt Kashton.

I get up and slam my back against the side of the altar, trying to calm my breathing and listen for any sign of movement, but my ears are ringing. Blood pools under me from the bullet wound in my thigh. I need to wrap my belt around it, but my left arm is useless, and I refuse to let go of my gun.

"Come on, Eve," one of them taunts me. "You're not one to hide."

The vest restricts my movements more than I'd like, but if I take a bullet to the chest, I'm dead within seconds. I can't chance it.

A figure steps into my sight, and I don't even think before I fire. One of the guys falls to the floor, a mask still covering his face, but the blood begins to pool underneath his lifeless body.

"Fucking get her," someone barks. "There are more of us."

I've got six bullets left. It's now or never. I go to stand up, but something wraps around my throat from behind. I look up to see someone leaning over the altar, and the belt around my neck tightens to the point where it cuts off my air.

I have to stand in order to relieve the pressure, but I still can't breathe as they drag me across the altar. I'm shoved into it, pinned against the front. The belt feels like it's cutting my skin in half.

Reaching over my head, I fire, and then the belt is released. I fall to my knees, coughing and sputtering as drool drips from my lips.

Three down. Two to go.

A scream erupts from behind me, and I spin around to fire, but I'm knocked back with what can only be another bullet to my vest. The force of the bullet takes away what little breath I have. I lift my gun and fire off two more rounds aimlessly. I'm losing and running out of time.

I fall to my side and begin to crawl to the back of the altar, needing a second to regroup. I'm unable to catch my breath, and I don't know if it's from being choked or another bullet.

Unable to move a muscle, I lie on the cathedral floor, looking up at the high ceilings, and a calmness washes over me. Finally. After everything I've done wrong in my life. I was able to do something good for someone.

I hope Kashton understands why I did it. What he means to me. That I would have given the world for him to have what he deserves.

My vision begins to blur, and I choke on blood that fills my lungs. I'm dying, and it wasn't for nothing.

I had a purpose, and I was able to save a life instead of taking one.

A blurry figure steps around the altar, and I lift my gun, my hand shaking as I pull the trigger, firing off another round.

My eyes fall closed as they laugh. I missed and don't have the energy to try again. "Goodbye, Eve," their distorted voice says before another round of shots fill the cathedral.

KASHTON

"Who the fuck texted you the address?" Saint demands.

"It's unknown," I answer, my knees bouncing. While we were at Barrington, I got a text that Eve is at the cathedral. We called Tyson and filled him in, but he's farther out than we are. Adam called me and said she hadn't been arrested. I'd rather my wife be in jail than at the cathedral.

"Your car is here," Haidyn announces when he barrels into the parking lot.

I don't even wait for him to bring the Cadillac to a stop before I'm jumping out and running up the steps and inside. Once I enter, I come to a stop, looking over the blood-covered floor. It's smeared down the aisle and covers several of the pews.

It's everywhere. Puddles of it. And in some places, it's splattered. I count three dead bodies while I search for my wife.

"Eve?" I call out, and her name echoes in the silence. It makes my heart race to think that any of this blood might be hers. "Eve?"

"What do you need us to do?" Ryat and Sin enter with Haidyn and Saint. Hooke follows behind them. He was at Carnage when I got the call and tagged along to do whatever he can to help.

"Check the office," I order, and they take the side door by the staircase.

I rush down the aisle, checking both sides to see if she's hiding between the pews, but don't find anything. Coming up to the altar, I see the blood on it and walk to the opposite side.

There's a handprint. "Think I found something," I call out, and Haidyn and Saint come running toward me.

Kneeling, I see the altar has a door that slides shut, and it's cracked open. I yank it back and a hand falls out onto the floor. It's covered in blood, but you can't miss the emerald-cut diamond on the ring finger.

"Eve." I grab her arm and yank her out of the confined space. Her body falls to the floor, and there's so much blood, I can't tell where it's all coming from.

Haidyn presses his fingers to her neck. "She doesn't have a pulse."

I unzip the hoodie to see she's wearing the bulletproof vest that was hanging in her closet. "Have to get it off. Hang on, Eve." I yank on the Velcro straps, and Haidyn helps hold her head as I push it up and over her before tossing it aside along with the hoodie. "Start compressions," I order him.

He positions his hands on her chest and presses down. The sound of her ribs breaking makes me flinch.

"Fuck," he curses, yanking his hands back.

"What are you doing?" I bark. "Keep going."

"I'm breaking her ribs." His large eyes meet mine in horror.

"Fucking break them," I snap. Bones will heal.

He places his hands back on her chest and presses down. *Crack.* "Sorry." *Crack.* "I'm so sorry…"

I tilt her neck back, opening her airway, pinch her nose, and breathe into her blood-covered mouth.

"She's not…" Ryat trails off as he and Sin come back.

"Fuck." Sin places his hands on his head and sighs, looking down at her.

"Go to the basement," I rush out, trying to think of what's here that we can use. "The triage…find me adrenaline." It has to be here. I've seen them use it before.

"Kash—"

"Fucking go," I shout at them, interrupting Saint. "Now."

Ryat and Sin both take off, and I go back to breathing into her mouth.

"Come on, angel," I say, feeling her neck again for a pulse while Haidyn counts with each chest compression, apologizing for hurting her. "Come on."

"See if you can find the source of the bleeding," Haidyn barks at Saint.

He drops down at her feet and rips open her bloody jeans. "She's got a bullet wound in her thigh." Saint undoes his belt and ties it tightly above it. "Another in her arm. Doesn't look like either one has an exit wound."

"Take my belt." I sit up straighter but refuse to remove my finger from her neck.

He does so and ties it off as well.

"Another in her upper chest, underarm area." He goes on searching. "Looks like it went right between the opening of her vest. It… I…"

"You what?" Haidyn growls. "Spit it out."

"I need to pack it with something."

"Then find something," Haidyn snaps at him.

"Here"—Hooke yanks his shirt off—"use this."

"Got it," Sin calls out as they return, and he hands me the syringe. I bite off the cap as Haidyn sits back, and I shove it into her chest, plunging the adrenaline right into her heart.

"Come on, Eve. Come back to me," I say, looking down at her. But nothing happens. I rub my knuckles roughly into her sternum. If her ribs breaking didn't do anything, my hands won't. "Give me another one." I look up at Sin.

His face falls, and Ryat places a hand over his mouth. "That…that was all there was."

The sound of the double doors opening echoes in the cathedral, but I ignore them, knowing it's just Tyson and his guys.

"Start compressions again," I order Haidyn.

He immediately goes back to CPR, and I breathe into her mouth, willing her to live. To not leave me.

I don't understand. The adrenaline should have worked. She's a founder, for fuck's sake; she has the enhancement. It should have helped.

"Kash." A hand lands on my shoulder, and I shove it off. "Kash, man…"

"No," I shout at Saint, knowing exactly what he's going to say. "She's not dead." I look at him, and he knows. I've failed her. "Find something to pack her chest."

His soft eyes take in her bloody body before they find mine once more. "She's gone, Kash," he says softly.

"No." I shove Haidyn off her and pull her limp body into my lap. I hold her, squeezing my lifeless wife to me. "Please…" My throat closes, and I bury my head in her bloody neck. "Don't leave me. I need you. Please, angel," I beg her to come back to me, knowing it's not going to do any good.

She's gone.

"Goddammit," Haidyn shouts, walking away from the altar.

I rub my shaking hand down the side of her bloody face. "Come on, angel. Wake up. Open your eyes. I need you. Please don't do this. I need you."

"Find who the fuck did this." Saint jumps up, barking orders. "Scan the building, the cemetery out back for any more bodies. I want all

these dead Lords taken to Carnage and whoever else you find. Collect their phones and search their cars. Now. Move it."

The sound of something breaking echoes through the vaulted ceiling, and I know it's Haidyn destroying shit.

"I counted three bodies," Ryat hollers at someone. "No other cars than Kashton's and all of ours in the parking lot."

"Pl-ease," I whisper, running my bloody hand through her now strawberry-blond hair. So much blood. Everywhere. It's dripping off the tip of her fingertips while we sit in a puddle of it. "Open your eyes, Eve. Look at me. I need you, angel."

"I've got Tyson's men searching the perimeter." Sin announces.

"No. No. No," I mumble to myself, refusing to accept it. "You can't do this…to me." How could she leave me like this? She wouldn't.

I lay her back down, being gentle with her head, and start compressions on my own.

"Kashton." A hand touches my shoulder.

"Don't touch me," I shout, pulling away to push my palms into her chest.

"Kashton. Stop." I'm yanked back and I go to swing at whoever the fuck pulled me from my wife, but I can't get my heavy arms to work as I'm pushed into the back of the Lords' altar. Tyson's face is suddenly in front of mine, his hands on my shoulders. "I'm sorry, Kash… she's gone." I can't breathe. "We need to get her out of here. We've got to leave. Get her to Carnage."

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SEVENTY-FIVE



KASHTON

Haidyn pulls up to Carnage, and I get out of the back seat with her in my arms. I rush up the steps and shove the doors open with my boot.

"Devin?" I shout, but he's already waiting for us. "You have to help her," I tell him.

His wide eyes go from mine and then drop to her before looking at my brothers standing behind her. "Saint said…she had passed."

"Help her," I shout.

"Follow me."

I walk numbly, following him.

We exit the elevator, and the coldness hits me like a slap to the face. We're in the same hallway where I once found my brother lying in his own blood after his wife shot him. I avoid coming down here for that very reason.

Devin leads me into a room with nothing more than a metal slab in the center and a chair in the corner.

I place her on it. Gasping for breath, I turn to see Devin just standing there. "What are you doing?" I snap at him. "Do something. This is your job."

"Kash—"

"No," I shout, interrupting Saint. "Devin can help her." I put my attention on the doctor in the room. "She's had one syringe of adrenaline. She just needs more." She's going to need a blood transfusion as well. I don't know her type, but she can have whatever she needs from whoever she needs it from. I'll slit throats if I have to.

"Kashton, it's been too long," Devin says softly.

"No." I refuse to believe that. "The brain can live up to seven minutes after…" I can't say the word. She's not…gone.

A hand touches my shoulder, and I look to see its Haidyn. His bloodshot eyes drop to Eve lying on the table beside me. "I'm sorry, brother." He clears his throat. "She's gone."

"No." I turn and pick her up. "Why isn't anyone doing anything?" I pull her into my arms and fall down into the chair in the corner. "Charlotte was given…something." The same drug that Haidyn used when he pretended to die on us. "Adrenaline brought her back. It will work. She just needs more."

My chest is tight as I rock her back and forth. Looking up, I realize he led me to the morgue. That lump in my throat gets bigger, seeing I had laid her on the metal slab that's now smeared with blood. My chest tightens. It's getting harder to breathe. I haven't been in here since my mom's body was in this room.

"Kashton?"

I blink at the sound of my name to see Devin standing in front of me. His eyes go to a blood-covered Eve and then back to mine. "Let me take her."

"I…can't…" I clear the lump in my throat and finish my sentence. "Let her go."

I cradle her tighter to my body. My arms have gone numb. I can't feel anything. Just the massive hole in my chest.

"Take as much time as you need," Devin says and then turns, exiting the room.

I glance over her face. She looks so peaceful. How she appears when I watch her sleeping next to me. It's the blood that reminds me of the truth. It's my mind playing tricks on me. Refusing to believe she's truly gone. That I've lost her.

"I'm sorry, angel," I tell her, struggling to breathe.

Her body trembles in my arms because I'm the one shaking.

The door opens but I ignore it. Instead, I hold her tighter. Devin can't have her. Not yet. I'm not ready. I was holding onto hope that he could do something that would bring her back, but deep down I knew it was hopeless.

My angel is officially an angel. I may not believe in heaven, but I hope that wherever she is, she's getting the rest she needs.

She deserved to be loved longer. To know what it felt like to be important. To know that she was my world.

"Kash?" Haidyn speaks softly. "They're here."

"Who?" I ask, not even looking up from her, unable to recognize my own voice. I feel like I'm having an out-of-body experience.

"Ryat and Sin," he answers. "They found him."

My stinging eyes meet his. "Who?"

Haidyn frowns and runs a bloody hand through his hair. "The guy from the cathedral?" He words it as if it's a question.

He and Saint were talking in the SUV on the way here, but I'd tuned them out. Instead, I silently cried in the back seat while I held my dead wife.

"They've got *him* in the basement." His eyes drop to Eve before he looks away, unable to look at what's left of his sister. Or maybe me. I've failed both of them. Because of me, he no longer has a chance to know her. "They're waiting for you."

"I…I can't—"

"I'll take care of her." I hadn't realized Devin had returned. He gives me a soft smile. "I promise. I'll stay here with her until you return."

My vision blurs as tears fill my eyes, and I swallow the knot in my throat. "I can't…let her go."

Devin steps toward me and holds his arms out. "May I?" he asks.

Fresh tears fall down my face.

"Let me take her, Kash," he insists. "I promise she'll be here when you're done."

I nod, unable to say anything but knowing she deserves revenge. That whoever hurt her should be here, stripped naked, lying on a cold slab all alone. Not her.

Devin places his arms under her lifeless body and lifts her from my grasp, and I watch him carry her to the table in the center of the room. She's practically unrecognizable. I didn't think someone so small could bleed so much. I'm not even sure how many times she was shot. I think Saint has counted three bullet wounds, but I can see bruises on her neck where my face smeared the blood while I

held her to me in the car. Where I kissed her and told her over and over that I loved her. That I was sorry for not being the man she married. The husband she deserved.

All I can do is hope that it was fast. That she didn't suffer. But I know the truth. I've seen it enough. The blood smear where she dragged herself to hide behind the altar. She suffered. She felt pain. I deserve to feel the same pain. Know the same fate.

I get up on my shaking legs and walk over to her. I push the bloody strands of hair off her gorgeous face and lean down to kiss her forehead. She's so cold. I look around and see a gray blanket. Grabbing it, I drape it over her and speak softly. "I'll be back, angel." I need her to know I'm not leaving her. That this isn't goodbye.

I turn to leave when Devin's voice stops me.

"May I wash her?" I just stare at him, and his eyes soften. "I'd like to clean her up if you don't mind."

All I can do is nod. I'm incapable of speaking at the moment.

Then I exit the room with Haidyn. "Kash—"

"Please, do-n't." My voice cracks.

He grabs my shoulders and spins me around. I think he's going to hit me. Knock me on my ass for her death, but instead, he pulls me in for a hug.

My shoulders slump and fresh tears fill my eyes as I try to hold in a sob. We were raised to not show emotion. Especially over a woman. "I'm sorry," I whisper through the lump in my throat.

"Don't," he growls, pulling back and gripping my upper arms. His hard eyes are filled with tears that he doesn't want to cry. "Don't do this to yourself."

"It's my fault she's gone." I shake uncontrollably, glancing at the door her body is behind. "I…love her. I tried. I would have done anything—" I can't finish the sentence because my throat closes.

He pulls me back into him, hugging me once more. "I know, Kash," he whispers hoarsely. "She knows. She loves you too."

My knees give out, but he holds me up.

I'm not sure how long we stand in the hallway, but we manage to get ourselves together. It's hard to be intimidating when you're a sobbing mess.

"We'll get them," he promises, and I nod.

I don't have any doubt in my mind. I will tear this town apart to get the answers I want. But it won't bring her back.

He slaps my back, and we turn, heading to the basement. We stay silent, and thoughts of my last conversation with my wife fill my mind.

"You're my purpose."

"I love you."

It's crippling to think I won't crawl into bed next to her tonight or wake up with her in the morning. What life I had is over. She'll be the one I place in the ground, but I'll never live after this. I might as well bury myself with her. And I will. We will rot together. But I'll make sure to take everyone that was involved with me first.

We enter the basement to see Sin and Ryat standing next to Saint while Hooke hangs out over in the far corner. Tyson is also here, and there's a guy in the center, lying on the floor by the pits. He's bleeding from what looks like his arm by the way his opposite hand grips it.

He looks up at me. His wide eyes search mine before they glance at my blood-stained clothes.

"Well, well, well," I say, the dots instantly connecting, and I want to strangle him to death. It was right there in front of my face all this time. "My neighbor Christopher."

Saint looks at Haidyn and whispers, "Neighbor?"

Haidyn shrugs at Saint, just as confused. They still don't know about the house I bought to be close to Eve.

"It's starting to make sense now." I nod to myself. "How Evan knew to enter and leave her house from the back door. I didn't have cameras back there. I bet you had the car ready and waiting for Evan after she stabbed him."

He looks away, and I walk over to the counter and pick up the pack of Haidyn's cigarettes. "String him up," I order, my voice now as cold as this room. Then I grab the lighter next to the pack.

The crying session that Haidyn and I just had in the morgue was exactly what I needed—almost therapeutic. It reminded me of the cry that Elli had after her therapy session.

Giving them my back, I listen to him struggle as the guys get him ready for me. Numbly, I dig through the cabinets to find what I'm looking for. Honestly, I'm winging it.

Picking out a few things, I turn back, taking a drag from the cigarette. He hangs from his tied wrists above his head.

"My wife is dead." I say the words I've refused to acknowledge thus far, and it knocks the wind out of me. My legs threaten to give out, but I remain upright. I can't look weak right now. I'll save it for later when I'm all alone in our bed. "And someone has to pay for that."

"I didn't do it," he screams. "I didn't have a say. I was ordered—"

I place the tip of the knife to his neck, and he swallows. "You will suffer for my loss."

The whole fucking world will pay for what the Lords cost me, but I'll start with this piece of shit. I step back, giving a humorless laugh. I can feel my mind slipping. Whenever they ask why a man has gone crazy, the answer always starts with *She*…

"And you know what?" I ask, not expecting him to answer. "After I found out she was a founder, I started taking the enhancements."

Audible sighs of "shit" and "fuck" fill the cold basement.

No one knew that I was taking them. Not even my wife. "So I'm going to have a lot of time on my hands now."

He breathes heavily. "I didn't hurt her."

I look at Sin and Ryat. "We found him behind the cathedral in the cemetery," Ryat informs me at my silent question.

"Then who did?" I demand, looking back at the kid.

"I…I don't know…" he sobs. "But I can prove it."

Proof? Fuck, I want to vomit, knowing exactly what he's going to say. "How are you going to do that?"

"My cell," he rushes out, looking at Ryat. "He has my phone. The guys made me record it. It'll show I didn't touch her."

Ryat pulls the kid's phone from his back pocket, and I just stare at it. Do I want to see what happened to her? This isn't like her videos from Dollhouse. They aren't from years ago, the pain I know she

survived. It's going to be from an hour ago, and now her body lies in the morgue.

I look at Haidyn, and he takes my silent request, snatching the phone from Ryat's hand and connecting it to the TV screen on the wall, navigating to the video. The cathedral doors fill the screen.

Eve walks in moments later. She's wearing my white zip-up hoodie, dressed in jeans and platform boots with her hair up in a tight pony-tail and her makeup done. She's my angry angel. Ready to take on the world.

Four Lords stand at the Lords' altar, and I watch the fifth enter behind her, pointing a gun at the back of her head. She refuses to do what they want, and a part of me wishes she would have just gotten on the altar. Maybe it would have stalled them. Given me enough time to arrive and save her. She knew we were looking for her. That I would have found her.

Eve's shot in the leg, and the sound makes me flinch. She falls to the floor. A Lord walks down the aisle and grabs her. A blood-curdling scream comes from her before she's slammed onto the altar. She pulls a gun from the back of her jeans and gets off a shot, falling over to the other side of the altar and out of sight.

One walks around and then falls to the floor, telling me she was still alive and able to shoot. Two down. She's a good shot, but they were ready for her.

It was an ambush that she willingly walked into.

But at the beginning of the video, they said they wanted me. Why? Why didn't she let me turn myself in?

One of the masked men wraps a belt around her neck and pulls her over the altar. She shoots him but then is hit herself. She crawls the best she can back behind the altar and out of frame. The fifth one that had entered behind her walks around the altar and points a gun at her. "Goodbye, Eve," their altered voice fills the basement before the camera shuts off.

"See?" the kid shouts. "I ran out the side door. I never touched her."

I want to fall to the floor and curl into a ball. The only thing that's keeping me on my feet is my adrenaline. It's going to fade, and I'm

going to crawl onto the metal slab and hold my wife. After I make this man suffer. "You helped set her up. And that's enough."

He thrashes in his restraints and screams at the top of his lungs. He can do whatever he wants. He's dead to me. "Check my messages," Christopher rushes out. "I sent you the text."

I look at Haidyn, and he starts scrolling through the phone. He pulls up an app, and sure enough, you can see he was the one who sent me the text with where she was, and he was able to hide his number. "Why?" I snap.

"She was just the bait. She wasn't supposed to die. Evan wanted her."

Evan. The name makes my blood boil. Fucking rage.

"He knew she'd give herself over to him for you."

"Where the fuck is he?" I demand.

"I don't know…but I can find him."

"Was he at the cathedral?" Haidyn growls.

"No. We were supposed to stall. Just hold her until you arrived. Then give her the option…you or her."

"So that's why you texted Kashton." Saint nods to himself. "You needed them both there but wanted her there first. Rough her up, and then when Kashton arrived, she'd give herself over and he'd kill Kash." He looks at me. "Get you out of the picture."

Haidyn frowns. "But that doesn't explain how Eve got there. What made her go to the cathedral?"

"Evan…" He sucks in a deep breath. "He wanted to play with her."

My teeth grind. He knows that I *play* with my girl. He was jealous. Wanted to have what was mine and knew exactly what he could do to get it. If he laid one hand on her, she'd fall back into the mindset she had at Dollhouse. Or maybe he planned on drugging her. Either way, he was going to leave there with her. But I didn't show in time, and they killed her.

"I can find Evan…I'll give him to you. I swear."

I snort. I've got the kid's cell, and it will take me right to him. "Haidyn." I gesture with my hand, and he passes me the cell. I turn to Tyson's men. "Find him." Colton nods. "Next time I see you, it better be because you're delivering Evan. Do you understand?"

"Yes, sir," Alex answers, and they rush out of the basement.

I place my attention back on Haidyn. "Give me your phone." I hold out my hand to him again.

He does so without question.

I go through it and find what I'm looking for. "Hallelujah" by No Resolve fills the basement, and I turn it all the way up, taking a puff of the cigarette before putting it out on Christopher's back.

This is for you, Eve. I will make sure the world pays for the cost of your life. To me, it was priceless.

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SEVENTY-SIX



KASHTON

I fill a syringe with adrenaline while a burning cigarette hangs from my mouth. Tossing the vial onto the counter, I walk over and shove it into his chest. His jaw clenches and he throws his head back.

"Once that one starts to wear off. I'll give you another. And another. As long as it takes. Or until your heart gives out." Either way. He won't ever see daylight again. He'll die down here.

Christopher cries and bows his head. "How long…what takes?"

"Ever heard of flaying?" I hold up the knife in my hand.

His wide eyes go from mine to others in the room as if someone will help him. They won't. "Now, I will say, I've never done this before so we're going to learn together."

"You sick bastard," he screams, fighting the restraints. The adrenaline is coursing through his veins, enhancing his fight or flight.

"From what I do know, there should be some prep work, but I just don't have the patience for that right now." I run the tip of the blade lightly along his leg, and he tenses to not be cut. "I've heard it's easier to skin someone alive after they've sat outside and boiled in the sun. But we'll try it this way first. And typically they start with the face. The point was to get it all off in one go. But I'm not too worried about how many pieces it takes."

"HELP ME!" he screams over the song that I put on repeat. "Please…someone…" He begins to sob.

"Did you help my wife?" I shake my head. "No. You just stood there and watched. My brothers will do the same."

I walk behind him, and he tries to look over his shoulder, but his arms are tied above his head. I cut along the back of his neck and blood starts to pour down his naked body. "I need some water," I order to anyone.

Sin walks over to the sink and fills a bucket. He then grabs a cup and brings both over to me. He scoops up some water and pours it over the kid's back so I can see. "Keep it coming."

It's tedious work—skinning someone alive. The hardest part is to not kill them. You don't want to cut too deep and have them bleeding out. Anytime you put a knife to skin, there's going to be blood, but there's an art to it. And I'm not sure I have that gift.

Standing back, I look at the kid hanging from his tied wrists. He's still conscious. The adrenaline is doing its job.

He's sobbing uncontrollably and would have blacked out long ago if not for the drugs. Pieces of his flesh are on the floor. I hate to admit I have done a hack job. I was trying to be professional at first, but then just started cutting in no particular pattern.

Tossing the knife into the sink, I run my bloody hands down my shirt. "Hose him down and put him in a cell."

I've done enough for tonight. If he dies, he dies. "Where are the bodies? I want to see them."

"They're out back," Saint answers.

I head to the stairs and storm up a flight to the first floor and then out the back door. I hear everyone following me. Coming to a stop, I see three men piled on top of one another, and I kick the one on top. His body rolls off the other two.

Sighing, I run my bloody hands through my hair. "Fuck," I shout.

"You know them?" Ryat asks.

Saint is the one who answers. "We went to Barrington with them."

"These are the guys you beat up at Blackout," Tyson observes.

"What?" Haidyn looks at me. "That night Ty called us?" he demands. "How did Eve know them?"

I begin to pace. That's just the thing. "She didn't."

My angel was very private with her life. She didn't go to Barrington. She spent a lot of time in Vegas after she recovered from Dollhouse.

When I followed her, she was never with anyone. She didn't even meet a girlfriend for coffee, let alone go out and party with others.

"Are you sure?" It's Saint who digs.

"I'm positive," I snap. "The night Haidyn and I went to the cathedral to pick up a Lord, she was there. From that night on, I was following her night and day. I'm telling you, she didn't know them." She barely had any contacts in her phone other than me, Bill, and Adam.

"But you got into a fight with them because of her…"

"She never even looked their way at Blackout," I interrupt Haidyn. "I walked over to Eve, had a conversation and then I returned to the table, and they…pissed me off. I beat the shit out of them. That was that."

"Then they knew of her," Ryat suggests.

"But how?" Haidyn snaps.

"Where are their phones?" I hold my hand out.

"They didn't have any on them," Sin answers.

"Give me their wallets," I bark.

"Didn't have those either."

"Well, isn't that convenient?" I say through clenched teeth. "Goddammit."

I make my way back to the morgue. My feet are heavy and my stomach is in my throat. The adrenaline is officially wearing off, and it's like a plane falling from the sky that's going to crash and explode. Coming up to the door, I take a second before I have the strength to shove it open.

My boots come to a stop once I step inside the cold, sterile room. I don't know what I expected to see—her sitting up and laughing? Her saying, "Surprise. I got you"?—but none of that happens.

Instead, she lies under a fresh white sheet, and she's been cleaned. You can see every bruise on her exposed neck where she was choked with the belt that I saw on the video.

I've never felt this way. So helpless. Useless. I had one job when I made her my Lady, and I failed.

"I'll leave you be. Please let me know if I can do anything for you," Devin says as he starts to leave the room.

"May I hold her?" I ask, trying to swallow the knot in my throat. I keep my back to him. When he doesn't answer, I add, "I can shower." I'm still covered in blood and pieces of skin. Devin spent the time cleaning her. I don't want to get my angel dirty.

I hear the door softly close, and then I see him out of the corner of my eye standing next to me. He sighs heavily before he says, "It's been hours. Rigor mortis has started to set in, Kashton. I'm afraid—"

"I understand," I interrupt him.

I've been around dead bodies all my life. I'm not thinking clearly about Eve's. I just wanted to sit in the chair and hold my wife, but that is no longer an option. Even in death, she continues slipping away from me.

I spent too much time skinning that bastard alive.

"Let me know if you need me." He turns and exits the room, and I numbly walk over to the sink. I wash my hands and arms, along with my face and neck, trying to clean as much as possible without having to leave her to shower. I remove my T-shirt, boots, and jeans, stripping down to nothing but my boxer briefs.

Drying off, I walk back over to her and lift the sheet. I take her left hand in mine and run my fingers over her wedding ring. Her skin is so cold. It feels almost fake.

Flashbacks of our wedding night play in my mind like a movie.

"Thanks, man," I tell Sin, giving him a handshake hug before he climbs into the helicopter.

"No problem. It was my honor." He nods, and I step off the helipad, watching him take off while the wind from the rotor almost blows me off the edge of Hooke's yacht.

I spot my wife standing with her back to me, looking over the dark ocean. Making my way to her, I place my hand on the small of her back, and she turns to face me with a smile on her face and wraps her arms around my neck.

"What do you want to do, Mrs. Pierce?" I watch her body to see how she reacts to having my last name. I expect a look of disgust. Maybe regret. But instead, she pushes into me and smiles.

I promise to make you happy, angel.

"Let's go skinny-dipping."

"Want me to teach you how to swim?" Hooke's yacht has a pool and a hot tub. I'll spend all night in the water with her if that's what she wants to do.

Smiling, she laughs softly. "I've learned how to swim since I was last on a yacht, Kash."

Of course she has. "Are you just trying to get me naked?" I arch a brow.

My wife giggles. "Maybe…" Trailing off, she bites her bottom lip. "Or you could teach me how to dive."

"Well, you're in luck. I am the best diver you've ever met."

"I'll be the judge of that."

"Kashton." Haidyn's voice fills the room as he enters, cutting off my memory.

I look up at the ceiling, trying to keep the tears that cloud my vision from falling. "Leave me alone, Haidyn." Taking a shaky breath, I add, "I…I need a second. Please." I know she's his sister, and he deserves to tell her goodbye too, but I need her right now. I just want to be by her side. Alone. I know how this works. Devin will come to me once I leave this room. He'll want to take the next steps—embalming and burying her. I don't want to think about that. Once she's in the ground, I'll be visiting a grave, not my wife. The last bit of her existence will be gone. Forever.

When the door shuts, I lean over and kiss her cheeks with trembling lips. "I love you, angel." My other hand comes up and runs through her freshly washed bleached-blond strands, and I make one final promise to my wife. "I'll see you soon."

Lords don't believe in heaven and hell. And I know that even if they did exist, I'd be sent to hell. Where I'd burn. Rightfully so. I earned that.

But another life? I will hold out hope that that's a possibility. And if so, I'll find her sooner than I did in this one. No matter what. We were meant to love one another. In this life or another. Death will not keep me from her.

I crawl onto the cold metal slab and lie with her, pretending she's just sleeping. She'll wake up any second and tell me that she loves me. That she's sorry. And if I'm really lucky, she'll knock me out with her right hook.

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SEVENTY-SEVEN



KASHTON

Three days my wife has been dead.

Three motherfucking days of hell.

A Lord is raised among death—the blood and torture—but I've never stayed around to see what happens afterward.

The planning. The arrangements. Thankfully, Janice and Charlotte helped me. The other wives did too, but they've stayed the closest. I think they can see I'm losing my mind. That I've lost my soulmate.

Soulmate?

Never in my life have I believed in that shit. Until Eve. Now she's gone, and I'm supposed to move on with my life as if she never existed.

It's a weird concept.

She wanted to be cremated. I had her placed in a casket.

She wanted her ashes to be spread in the cemetery behind the cathedral. I buried her in the cemetery at Carnage.

My wife hated flowers. I had the biggest arrangements I could get my hands on delivered for her funeral. I've never seen so many colors in one place in my life. She wasn't the type of woman who liked pinks and purples, but Janice suggested colors. Said it was a way to celebrate life.

Eve hated her life. She was told for the longest time that she was useless. And in the end, we all die. Just like the flowers.

I stand in front of a fresh pile of dirt. My wife is buried underneath it while "Where I Left You" by HOLLOWFRAME plays. She hates silence, so I made her a playlist with over a hundred songs that's set to repeat.

We laid her to rest over an hour ago, but I can't seem to walk away. I don't want to leave her out here alone.

I'm unable to say goodbye. It's crazy how hard loving someone can be. I've always been afraid of being abandoned. I thought I'd lose my brothers and be left to this world all alone. But Eve? The loss of her is unlike anything I've ever felt.

I'm physically here, my heart is beating, but I feel dead.

I'm going to leave instructions with Bill that she be dug up and my body laid with her. Some would find that unethical. I don't give a fuck what others think of me. No one has to understand the type of love we have.

Even in death, I will hold my wife in my arms, because that's where she felt safe and it's where she belongs. We were supposed to be together forever, and I'm going to make sure that's what we do.

I see movement out of the corner of my tear-filled eyes and sigh. "Go home, Easton," I order hoarsely. I'm physically tired. Haven't slept in days and mentally drained. I've been drugged and beaten before, and I feel weaker now than I ever have in my life.

"I'm where I need to be," he says softly.

I refuse to let my loss take away from others. It's shown me just how precious our time really is. That's such a cliché, but it's true. "Elli and the kids need you."

"My wife is aware that a brother needs me more."

Brother? It reminds me to tell Haidyn and Saint to make him a Spade brother. He'll be my replacement.

After I watched her being lowered into the ground, I just wanted to be alone. I stood and thanked everyone for coming, but it was time for them to go. Then I saw all the guys huddled by the gates of Carnage, no doubt talking about who needed to babysit me. I guess Sin drew the short straw.

I know they've all started a group chat—even with Ty's minions—without me in it.

Is he sleeping?

When did he eat last?

Has he left the morgue?

I spotted the texts when Haidyn was visiting Eve and offered to stay with her while I went and showered and got some rest. I declined his offer, but I did pry myself away from her long enough to sit in the corner while he told her goodbye.

It was like she was dying all over again. Watching him apologize for not being there for her. For what their father did to her. I hated to see my brother hurting, knowing it was my fault. Had she not been my wife, she wouldn't have willingly walked into an ambush for me.

I've cost us everything.

His sister. My wife. Our future.

I fall to the ground and cross my legs as the song changes to "Lifetime" by Three Days Grace. Now I realize why Eve spent so many nights sitting at the grave of what she deemed to be her mother and baby. It's just too hard to let go of what you could have had.

We were supposed to be together forever, and I'm going to make sure that's what we do. The thought gives me an idea, and I glance up at Sin. "Can you help me with something?" Might as well give him something to report back to the others about.

"Anything." He nods, shoving his hands in the pockets of his dress slacks.

I get to my feet and look at the pile of fresh dirt where my wife lies. She doesn't have a headstone yet. "They take time," Janice told me. "I know a guy," Bill assured me. Charlotte helped me order it, and it should be ready in a couple of weeks.

I won't let her be like those graves in the cemetery behind the cathedral who were killed, buried, and left with unmarked graves. Everyone will know who the fuck my wife was and that she was loved.

"I'll be back, angel," I tell her before I turn to Sin. "Let's go."

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SEVENTY-EIGHT



KASHTON

I sit at the biker bar in the middle of nowhere. It's where she always led me to when I followed her. I needed something to drink.

"Iris" by The Goo Goo Dolls plays through distorted speakers.

"Another," I mumble to the brunette bartender.

"Yes, sir," she says softly, grabbing the bottle.

"Just give it to me."

Her eyes meet mine apprehensively. "I'm sorry?"

"The bottle." I place my elbow on the bar and gesture with my fingers for her to give it to me.

"I don't think—"

I reach over and rip it from her hands before tossing a few hundred-dollar bills on the bar for her to take. "Leave me," I order.

She spins and runs to the other end of the bar, happy to get away from me. I know I look like shit, but I fit in here. It's not a safe space for anyone.

I tip the bottle back as I feel someone coming up next to me. "Hey, sugar."

I ignore her. I'm not here for pussy or anyone's company. Just had to get away from Carnage and my brothers, their wives. Eve's funeral was three days ago, and their concern for my life was suffocating. I was beginning to feel like I was already buried with her. Unable to breathe. And Janice kept bringing me food and asking why I wasn't eating what she had dropped off from the previous day. I understand everyone is just trying to help, but I want to be left alone.

A hand touches the sleeve of my jacket, and I tense. "Get away from me before I snap your fucking neck."

She gasps, yanking her hand back, and then storms off. I take another swig from the bottle and then set it down, gesturing to the bartender once again.

"Yes, sir?" she asks softly over the song that seems to be on repeat. I'm getting a headache.

"Another bottle."

"Uh…" She raises her eyes to look over at someone and then places her attention back on me. "Yes, sir."

I knock the one back in my hands, hoping I drown in it, but no such luck. Maybe the next one will do it.

"Here you go, sir." She places a full bottle of bourbon in front of me. It's got to be the cheapest you can get, but whatever. I don't even taste it.

I go to pick it up, but it's snatched from the bar top before I can get it. "Did you threaten to snap my ole lady's neck?" a guy hisses from beside me.

The bartender takes off once more, and I hold in a sigh. "I'm not in the mood to pay for pussy."

"Are you calling her a whore?" he yells.

I laugh, imagining what my wife would be doing right now if she were here. Eve would already be up on her feet, hand gripping the bottle and swinging. No questions asked. Well, if I'm being honest, she would have broken that bitch's nose who touched me, and I'd be beating this guy's ass, defending my Lady's actions.

"Here." I dig into the pocket of my leather jacket and toss him a dollar. "This is probably what she's worth."

My head is slammed into the bar in the next second.

"Motherfucker." He grips the back of my jacket, yanking me from the chair and shoving me to the nasty bar floor with a punch to my face.

Fuck, it feels good.

"Get him up," the guy barks.

I'm grabbed and brought to my feet. When my knees give out, two men stand on either side of me, helping hold me up by my arms.

I give a bloody smile to the man who stands in front of me, because this is what I've wanted since I held my wife's body in my

arms.
To die.

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SEVENTY-NINE



KASHTON

"Come on." Eve grabs my hand and leads me through the crowd of people.

"Where are we going?" I ask, but her only response is a giggle as she drags me through the foyer and up the stairs.

"Where are you two going? We haven't cut the cake yet."

I look down over the railing to see Elli standing in the foyer with her hands on her hips, watching us walk up the stairs. Sin comes to stand next to her.

"We'll be back," Eve assures her.

"Maybe." I wink, and Sin grabs Elli's hand, pulling her back to Eve's birthday party when she tries to protest.

My wife pulls me into her bedroom and shuts the door before flipping on the light. "I don't want a quickie," I tell her. "You know I like to take my time." My hands go to the hem of her dress, and I start to yank it up.

She slaps them away and smiles at me. "We're not up here to fuck."

I arch a brow. "Then why are we in here?" I look around the room that she has never slept one night of her life in. It gives me a pain in my chest. I wish Eve would have had this life. The mother that she deserved.

Placing her hands on my face, she forces me to look at her. I reach up and push some loose strands from her face. Her eyes are glassy from the alcohol, but she looks stunning.

"I wanted…" She pauses, swallowing, and I frown. "I wanted to tell you thank you."

My pulse races at her words, because I know exactly where she's going with this. "Eve—"

"I've never celebrated a birthday before, and I want to thank you for giving me something so special."

Janice was nice enough to let me help plan this party for my wife. "You better get used to it, angel. We'll be celebrating it every year."

"Gosh, every year?" She rolls her eyes like she's terrified of the idea, but the smile on her gorgeous face tells me the truth.

"For the rest of our lives," I assure her. And thanks to the enhancements, it'll be a very, very long time.

She places her lips on mine, and my hands cup her face while she kisses me. When she pulls away, her eyes drop to my jeans. "I'll take that quickie now."

I grab her thighs, and she jumps up, wrapping her legs around me, giggling, as I walk her to the bed, knowing damn well I'm not going to be done anytime soon. The party will just have to wait for the birthday girl to return.

The memories come and go like the weather. There's no controlling them. At first, I thought it was the silence.

It was driving me mad. There isn't a TV in this godforsaken place. Eve broke it when she fought the man the night I took my belt to her ass, and they haven't replaced it.

Just a small radio. And after fiddling with the knob for who knows how long, I could only find a country station. I hate that shit. So fucking depressing. But it's better than nothing.

I'm currently sitting on the end of the bed, elbows on my thighs and bent over, gripping my hair with my hands. I'm so tired. Who knew heartbreak would be so exhausting? It's an inner battle that I just want to give up on.

A part of me has died, but for some reason I'm still breathing.

The pain. It's crippling. I remember losing my mother, and it didn't feel like this. Maybe it was because I knew my mother was better off. Whereas with Eve, I wanted to give her a better life. I wanted to be someone she'd be proud to call her husband.

"Whiskey Lullaby" by Brad Paisley and Alison Krauss begins playing, and I jump up and rip that bitch from the fucking wall, snapping the

cord and tossing it across the room as well.

Silence it is.

A knock comes at my door, and I don't even bother to answer it. No one knows where I am, and if it was one of my brothers, they wouldn't be fucking knocking.

"Sir?" The soft knock comes again.

I groan; it's the bartender. Yanking the door open, she gasps, taking a step back. Her wide eyes look over my busted face, and then she leans to her left to get a view into my room. She scrunches her button nose at the smell that rolls out of the open door like a cloud of smoke.

"What?" I bark and she jumps again.

"I, uh…" She unzips her overly large coat to remove two bottles of whiskey. "I thought you could use these." Her cheeks blush as she glances up to meet my stare. I'm pretty sure my right eye has swollen shut. The bastards didn't kill me. Just beat the shit out of me and left me in the parking lot. I can't catch a break.

Patting down my jeans, I find my wallet in my back pocket and hold it out to her. "Thanks."

She averts her eyes to her dirty shoes and bites her bottom lip. "Oh, I don't need…"

I rip the bottles from her hand, throw the wallet at her and step back, slamming the door shut in her face.

"Wait! What about your wallet?" she hollers from the other side of the door.

"Keep it." I won't need it.

I go over to the only dresser in the room and set the two bottles down. Then I sit on the end of the bed, taking a swig of the one I started on this morning. It's almost gone.

The whiskey runs down my chin and onto my chest. Pulling it away, I toss the now empty bottle across the room, and it shatters into a million pieces against the wall before falling to the floor like the others before it.

A week I've been hiding in this run-down hole-in-the-wall motel out in the middle of nowhere.

No cell. No tracker. No connection to the outside world.

After I laid her in the ground, I had to get away. The "I'm sorry for your loss" wouldn't change anything. She's gone. Nothing I can do will bring her back.

I failed her. The one person that I was supposed to give my life for ended up giving hers for me. Before I left Carnage, Ty's men informed me they still hadn't found Evan. I've given up. The bastard won. He took my girl from me.

I went a little mad and killed some prisoners and then bolted. I found myself at that bar, and then after I got my ass kicked, I crawled to the motel next door and locked myself in room 111. Where I've been rotting away.

It felt right. This is where I belong. I spent so many nights following her here. Watching her kill men. If only she would have taken me with her.

I long to see her, hold her, and hear her voice one last time. The thought has me glancing at her phone on the nightstand. Adam, Bill, the wives…everyone has her number because she had become part of their lives. I've kept it off because I don't want anyone to call looking for me, knowing I have it. But it can help me with one thing…

Getting up, I walk over to the side of the bed, plop down, and pick up the motel room phone, dialing her number.

Her voicemail picks up and I hold my breath.

"Hey, Kash," comes her soft voice and a lump forms in my throat. I tried calling her several times when we were rushing to Barrington, but the moment her voicemail picked up, I ended the call.

"I wanted to leave you one last message. Just in case you thought to check."

I slap my free hand over my mouth to quiet the sob so I can hear her speak.

"I'm sitting here at Barrington, looking over the empty school. I'm trying to get my thoughts together. I have to call you to say goodbye, and it breaks my heart. To leave you. But just in case it comes down to life and death, I choose to die for a cause. For you. I love you, Kashton. And if there's a God, I thank him for sending me you. My biggest regret is running away that night on the *Isabella*. Not be-

cause of me, but because that's six years you went without knowing you were loved. I took that from you and I'm sorry. I wish…" Her voice cracks, and I swallow nervously. "This is the only way I can repay you for loving me when everyone in my life always made me feel worthless. You gave me a purpose, and I'm honored to be your angel in this chaotic world." She sniffs, and I close my eyes, hating that she's hurting. "I have been at war with myself all my life. Until you…Kashton Landon Pierce, my Lord. You helped me find peace. And this is something that I could never repay you for. Your mother would be proud of the man you've become, Kash. And I'm lucky to have been loved by you." She pauses, and I close my eyes when I hear her whisper, "I love you, Kash."

I find myself back on the bench at the end of the bed, rocking back and forth. I listened to her voicemail more times than I can count. My sadness has turned to anger.

She knew what she was going to do when she called and said goodbye. I would have gone with her. Fought next to her. We could have died side by side. I'd never make her go alone.

Reaching out, I pick up her wedding ring. I curl my fingers around it and close my eyes. I made her a promise, and I intend to keep it. I won't fail her again.

My plan when I woke up from the beating I got was that I'd just jump on my bike and drive it until I lost control, but that would put others on the road with me at risk as well. I don't want to hurt anyone. Not anymore. Plus, the bikers at the bar beat the fuck out of my bike with crowbars after they were done with me. So I now have no transportation. Not like I need to go anywhere anyway.

I set the ring down, pick up my revolver, and remove all the bullets except one. Then I spin the cylinder and shut it. It's the same one my father gave me for my initiation. Who knew one day I'd need it. *"Keep it. Maybe one day you'll put it to good use."*

I'm not even nervous or scared. I've made up my mind. I left a note for my brothers. They'll understand. They would do the same if they lost their wives. They have each other. They don't need me.

Picking the ring up again, I hold it in my left hand. Then I bring the barrel of the gun to my right temple.

I close my eyes, take a deep breath, and almost smile. It's crazy how calming death can be when you're ready to let go of life.

"I'm coming, angel."

Taking in one last breath, I pull the trigger.

EVERETT

Eleven years old

I sit huddled in the corner of the cell, my knees to my chest and my forehead resting on them.

"You fucking bitch," the man growls, and I try to make myself smaller, pushing my naked body into the wall.

"You can't stop him," the woman tells the Lord as the door creaks when he opens her cell door.

He just found their son down here and dragged him off. I was hoping Cyrus wouldn't return but he has.

"If you'd quit entertaining him, he'd stop coming to see you," he yells before I hear him slapping her.

I flinch, my body trembling.

"He'll never be like you," she screams. "He'll never be a monster."

I lift my head and look through the bars to see her on her bloody knees and him looming over her in her cell across from mine.

"I'll tell you what, you worthless whore. Next time he comes to visit you, I'll kill you right in front of him. Maybe that's what the boy needs. Yeah, he needs to be disciplined. He needs to be taught a lesson. And I'll start with you." He exits her cell, slamming the bars shut and locking her inside.

He goes to walk away but spots me in the opposite cell. I scramble to press my back into the wall when he opens it.

"Leave her alone," she screams.

He laughs, grabbing my hair and yanking me from the wall. "Did Daddy put you in time-out?" He yanks his belt from his pants and drags me over to the door. He wraps it around my wrists and pulls me to my feet. He ties his belt around the bar above my head.

"You fucking bastard," she screams over my sobs. "Leave her alone. She's a child."

"She's going to be our whore." He tangles my hair and shoves my cheek into the bars. "Aren't you, bitch?" He slaps my ass, and I try to crawl through the bars to get away from him, but there's nowhere for me to go.

His laughter fills the cell before he yanks open the door and closes it, leaving me tied to it.

He walks over to the woman and spits on her and then leaves us alone.

Tears and snot run down my face as I stand on my tiptoes, trying to free my wrists. When I do, I scramble to the back wall and pull my knees to my chest.

She falls onto her hands and lets out a blood-curdling scream that makes my ears ring. Her fists pound the floor, and each time, the pieces of broken light bulb cut her. After a few minutes, she falls back against the wall, and her tear-filled eyes meet mine. "He's a good boy," she tells me. "He's going to be a good man."

I hate to tell her but no one in this hell walks away holy.

"He'll be nothing like his father. I'll make sure of it." Reaching out, she picks up a piece of glass.

I get to my hands and knees and crawl across the cell. "No. Don't—"

"That bastard is a man of his word, and I will not be the reason my son turns into his father. I'd rather break his heart." Her watery eyes fall to the glass in her hand. "Sometimes you have to hurt the one you love." She repeats what she'd told him when he was down here earlier.

Blue eyes are on mine as she reaches up and runs the tip of the glass along her neck, sacrificing herself.

I blink. Harsh light has me lifting my hand to try and cover my eyes.

Groaning, I close them and let out a deep breath. "Fuck." My chest hurts. Why does it feel like something is sitting on top of me? My hand goes to remove the bulletproof vest, thinking it's still on, but there's nothing there.

"He-hello?" I ask roughly. My throat is sore, and my body is sluggish.

Looking to my right, I see a bag hanging that has a tube connected to my arm. It's an IV.

Where am I?

I manage to sit up, and the room sways. My hands go to my temples, and I press on them, trying to calm my breathing. My heart is racing, and that pressure on my chest is getting heavier.

"Kashton?" I clear my throat. Fuck, why is it so sore? Am I at Carnage? Somewhere in the building I've never seen before?

Crawling out of bed, I get to my shaking feet and wobble like a newborn giraffe, trying to remind my legs how to work. I've never been so weak in my life. I slowly pull the IV from my arm and see a gown draped over the end of the bed. I pick it up and gently slide my arms into it because I'm naked. Then I take a quick glance at my body.

I've got bandages and bruises all over that I can see, and I can't put much pressure on my right leg, but I have to find Kashton. Did they kidnap me? The last thing I remember was lying on the floor in the cathedral, bleeding out, with a gun pointed at my face.

Tying off the gown in the front, I make it to the door.

Opening it up, I look left and right to see a dimly lit hallway. Nothing but concrete walls, but there's a door at the end on the right. I have a moment of panic that it's Dollhouse. That they dragged me here and Kashton is being tortured in another room.

Everything was for nothing. I refuse to let them get away with this. What has Kashton done? I'm the one who was killing Lords. I'm the one who reported the video to Bill, alerting him to the fact that Haidyn was trapped in Dollhouse by Isabella. That led to the halt of Dollhouse. No one else would want to run that hell.

My heart races as I let the door close behind me and lean up against the wall to help keep me upright. I could use my gun, but I didn't see it anywhere. They must have stripped me naked and saved my life just to make me watch them take my husband's.

After a second, I pull up the gown, trying to get a better look at why I'm so slow and out of breath. I see stitches in my thigh and more in my arm.

Have I been drugged? Was that what was in the IV? With a quick glance around the hallway, I don't see any red bulbs.

How long have I been out? Did I save Kashton? Is he in the clear? What if everything I did was for nothing and they hurt him? I left my cell at Barrington, so I don't have any way to contact him, and there wasn't one in the room I woke up in.

I hear a phone ringing at the end of the hall on the other side of the only door. Pushing off the wall, I grit my teeth from the sharp pain that runs up my side and push on, dragging my right leg behind me.

I put my hand on the knob. Turning it softly, I push it open just enough to peer inside it.

"Hello?" I see a familiar face answer the cell that sits on a desk. What the fuck am I doing with him?

"I need you to come home." I know that voice too. It's Saint on the other end of the call.

"I can't do that," Adam says, falling into his chair. The top three buttons are undone on his button-down. He's sans tie, sleeves rolled up, and he's got a rag in his hands while cleaning off the blood that covers them.

"I don't ask you for much. If anything," Saint snaps, and then he lowers his tone. "But I need you. We all need you."

"I'm sorry, Saint—"

"Haidyn has spent days in the basement. Days, Adam," he growls. "If I have to hear that damn 'Hallelujah' song one more time, I'm going to cut my fucking ears off." Saint sighs. "And I honestly don't know what the fuck he's doing down there because Kash killed most of our prisoners. We don't have many left."

Kashton. Thank God. He's alive. Happy tears sting my eyes. He's at Carnage. Safe. I can't wait to see him. But if I'm not there, where am I? And why?

"Have Charlotte help keep him busy—"

"Charlotte is pregnant with triplets," Saint growls. "She can barely get out of bed at the moment. The poor thing can't even keep down saltines. She is not capable of keeping her husband *busy* right now."

Adam runs his now somewhat clean hands through his hair aggressively, then looks over to the right and shrugs.

I push the door open just a tad bit more to see who he's looking at, and it's Bill sitting in a chair.

What the fuck is going on? I want to storm in, but something is telling me to stay quiet. Plus, my moves are sluggish already. Storming in is going to be a problem.

"It'll be okay," Adam assures him.

Saint snorts. "Kash is gone, Adam. Nothing here is okay."

"What do you mean gone?" Adam sounds concerned, but his face doesn't show it, causing me to frown.

"That's why I'm calling you. After we buried Eve, he went fucking postal, Adam."

Buried Eve? What the fuck is he talking about? I'm right here.

"Then he just left," Saint goes on at Adam's silence. "He packed a backpack and jumped on his bike. Haidyn tried to follow him, but he couldn't keep up."

"Find him," Adam suggests, leaning back in his chair, getting comfortable.

"What the fuck do you think we're doing?" Saint snaps. "He never replaced his tracker. Hell, for all we know he took a corner too fast and is lying dead in a ditch somewhere." He lowers his voice. "Sin and Ryat have been looking for him for over a week."

Week? How long have I been here? Where the fuck is here? Why am I not with my husband? I look down at my left hand and notice I'm shaking and that my wedding ring is gone. I was wearing it when I entered the cathedral. If I was going to die, I was going to die as Mrs. Pierce.

A silence lingers between them, and I take a deep breath before I shove the door open. Two sets of eyes snap to mine. Adam immediately jumps to his feet.

"Sa-int." My voice is rough as I rush to the desk.

"Eve?" he barks.

"It's me," I say through the knot in my throat and pick up the cell before they can stop me. "I'm…alive. I'm here," I rush out, trying to get as much information to him as possible. Maybe he knows where

Adam is, and that will lead them to me. I turn and run toward the door.

"What the fuck are you doing, Adam?" Saint shouts and then softens his voice. "Eve where are you?"

All hope I had vanishes, and my stomach drops. Of course Adam is hiding out. "I don't know." An arm wraps around me from behind before I reach the door, and I scream, trying to fight them. "Please… Saint. Find Kashton. Tell him—" I cry out when a hand tightly grips my wrist, causing me to drop the phone.

"Adam?" Saint shouts.

Adam bends down to pick up the cell.

"What the fuck—"

He ends the call, cutting off Saint. "Fuck," he curses, tossing the phone across the room.

"Get her back to her room," Bill demands, handing me over to Adam.

"No." I fight him, but it does no good.

He lifts me off my already shaking legs and carries me back to the room I escaped from. He shouts for someone before tossing me onto the bed, and a guy I don't know enters.

"Yes, sir?"

"Restraints. Now," he orders.

"Adam," I try to reason with him. "I have to see Kash. He thinks I'm dead."

"You need to rest," he tells me. His voice is gentle, but his hands aren't as he holds me down in the bed while the gown rips open. I don't even care.

The guy pulls restraints out from underneath the bed, and I scream and fight, but they easily get my wrists secured by my sides and then my ankles.

"Catheter and feeding tube. Now. They should have never been removed," Adam snaps and then adds, "She will not leave this bed until I say. Understand?"

"Yes. Yes, sir," the guy agrees, nodding quickly.

I'm gasping for breath when Adam pushes my wild hair from my face. His eyes are full of concern as they look over me. "This is what

you wanted, Eve."

I shake my head, and snot runs from my nose.

He nods. "It's going to be okay. I promise."

"My husband…needs me," I sob, trying to breathe. He's out there all alone.

I feel a sting in my arm and look to see a new IV has been started. Then I shiver when something cold fills my body, making me instantly relax into the bed. "Kash—" My tongue feels swollen, and I can't get his name out.

"It's okay, Eve," Adam repeats, then looks at the guy. "You do not leave this room."

My eyes get heavy, and I have a problem keeping them open. Saint said Kashton has been gone a week? How long before I see him? Another week? Two? A month? I need to be with him right now.

"Get some rest. We'll talk soon."

It's the last thing I hear before the darkness swallows me.

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EIGHTY



EVERETT

"How long have I been here, Adam?" I demand, sitting in his office. I was finally allowed to leave my room today after my catheter and feeding tube were removed. I'm weak from being confined to bed and living off Jell-O cups. I want my husband, some pancakes, and a bottle of whiskey. In that order.

Adam and I were never close, but now I hate his guts. Is he hurting my husband on purpose? Did they have a falling out and this is him getting even?

His green eyes pin me from where he sits behind the desk. "A little over three weeks."

My teeth grind. "I need to leave."

"Eve—"

"This isn't up for debate," I snap. "You've kept me strapped to that bed for long enough. I need to find Kashton."

He sits back in his seat, and I turn to see Bill enter the room when the door opens. "We know where he is," Bill states.

"How long have you known?" I demand, but neither answers me. "Do his brothers know?" Maybe Sin and Ryat found him and returned him to Carnage to be with Saint and Haidyn. Maybe Saint filled him in that I'm alive. That he heard my voice, and I'll be home soon.

Adam shakes his head.

I fist my hands to keep from punching his fucking face. "Take me to him," I command. "Right fucking now."

"You're not ready," Adam argues.

"Ready for what? To see my husband?" That's ridiculous. "This is not your decision to make."

His eyes slowly look over my body, and I roll mine. I've been seeing a doctor. I've been cleared. I still get winded easily, and I can only walk for short periods of time, but for the most part, I'm me. I feel better. But I don't care if I was in a fucking coma; he should not have kept Kash from me.

I get up and slowly walk over to Bill and do what I never thought I'd do in my life. "Daddy, please," I beg the man that took me in. He saved me to give me a better life, and this is my better life. To be with Kashton. "He needs me." My husband's been lied to, and he's hurting. "I need him."

"I don't think—"

"It's fine," Bill interrupts Adam, and I want to throw myself into his arms and cry happy tears.

Adam clenches his jaw and narrows his eyes on him. Obviously, that's not what they've discussed.

I couldn't care less. At least one of them is on my side. "Where is he?" I'll fucking walk there if I have to.

"Adam will take you," Bill assures me, but his eyes are on Adam.

"Take me to him. Now," I order and turn my back on them. I don't have my cell phone or my wedding ring. All I have is a set of clothes that Adam and Bill gave me—a T-shirt and sweatpants. They're not even mine. Who knows where they came from.

"You'll wear this until Adam removes it," Bill states, pulling a blindfold from the inside of his suit jacket.

My wide eyes go to his, my heart racing. "Why?"

"You either wear it or you stay here." He leaves no room to argue, shaking the black fabric.

I yank it from his hands and slide it over my eyes. If this is what gets me to my husband… Taking in a shaky breath, my sight is taken away, and I hold out my right hand and say, "I'm ready."

The blindfold is yanked from my eyes, and I look around. Nothing but trees and a two-lane road. The clock on the dash shows its almost midnight.

Adam doesn't speak to me, and I have nothing to say to him. He's betrayed his brother.

I still don't know where we were or why I was with Adam and Bill. They never told me, and believe me, I asked. They pretended like I didn't. And honestly, I'm not sure if it even matters. I was drugged for most of my stay. This morning was the first time I was allowed out of bed to use the restroom on my own and got to shower. I still feel lightheaded, hungover-like, and starving.

He pulls off the road and comes to a stop at a motel next to a biker bar. My teeth grind that this is where he is. "You've known the whole fucking time," I growl.

"He's in room 111."

"Is this a joke?"

"No." Adam sighs, relaxing into the driver's seat. "I'll wait here." His green eyes meet mine. "Don't fuck him."

"Excuse me?" I snap.

"You heard me." His eyes drop to my chest. "You're not healed." Then he looks away. "He'll be rough. You'll get injured, and then you're back in the hospital, setting your recovery back."

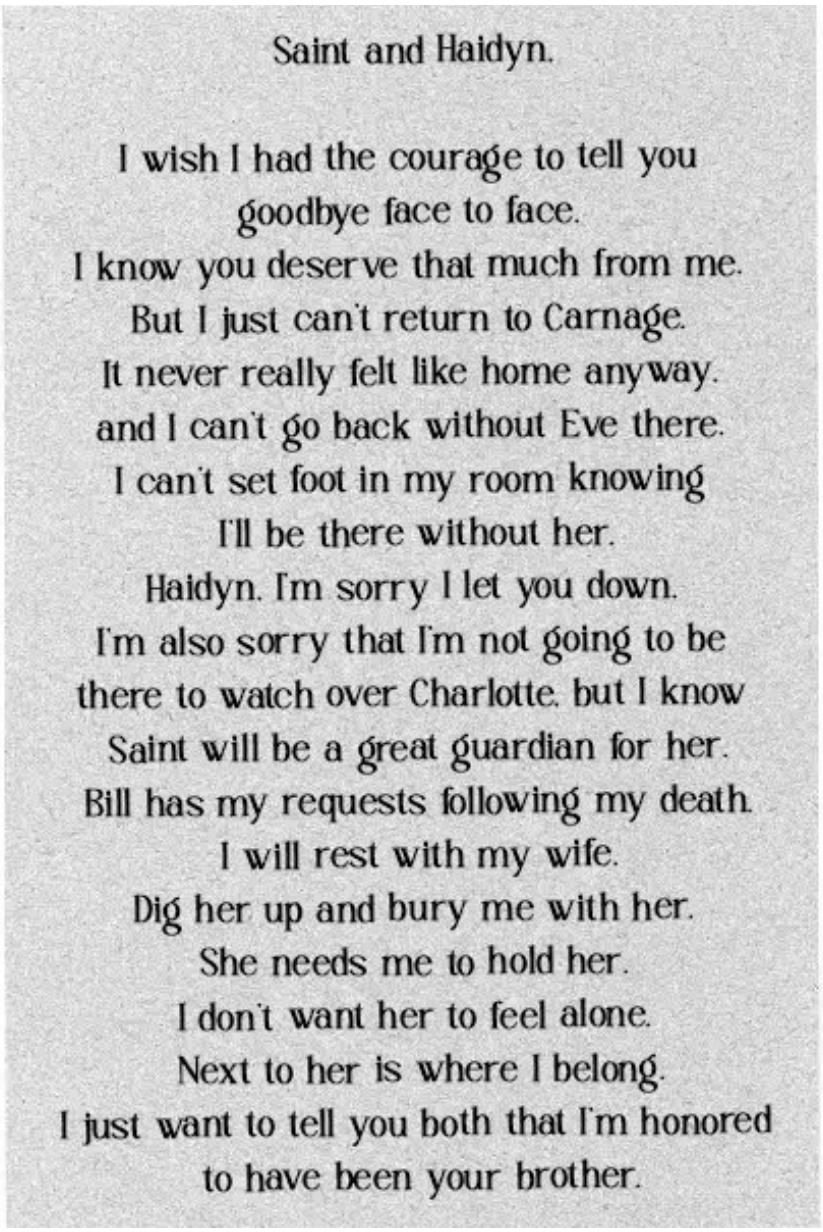
I don't respond to that. I get out, slam the car door, and rush into the motel room.

Without knocking, I turn the handle, and it opens. The door squeaks as I step inside. It's darkly lit with a single lamp that buzzes in the far corner. I broke the other one. There's still no TV, and it makes my chest ache. He always has to sleep with the TV on. The research I've done shows that those who feel abandoned need to feel as if they're not alone. The noise from a TV gives them the illusion that someone is in the room with them.

The place smells of booze and cigarettes. Worse than I remember.

Stepping forward, glass crunches under my shoes. The mirror wall is shattered, and I see my wedding ring along with a folded piece of paper on the table.

I pick it up and unfold it. Silently, I read over it.



Saint and Haidyn.

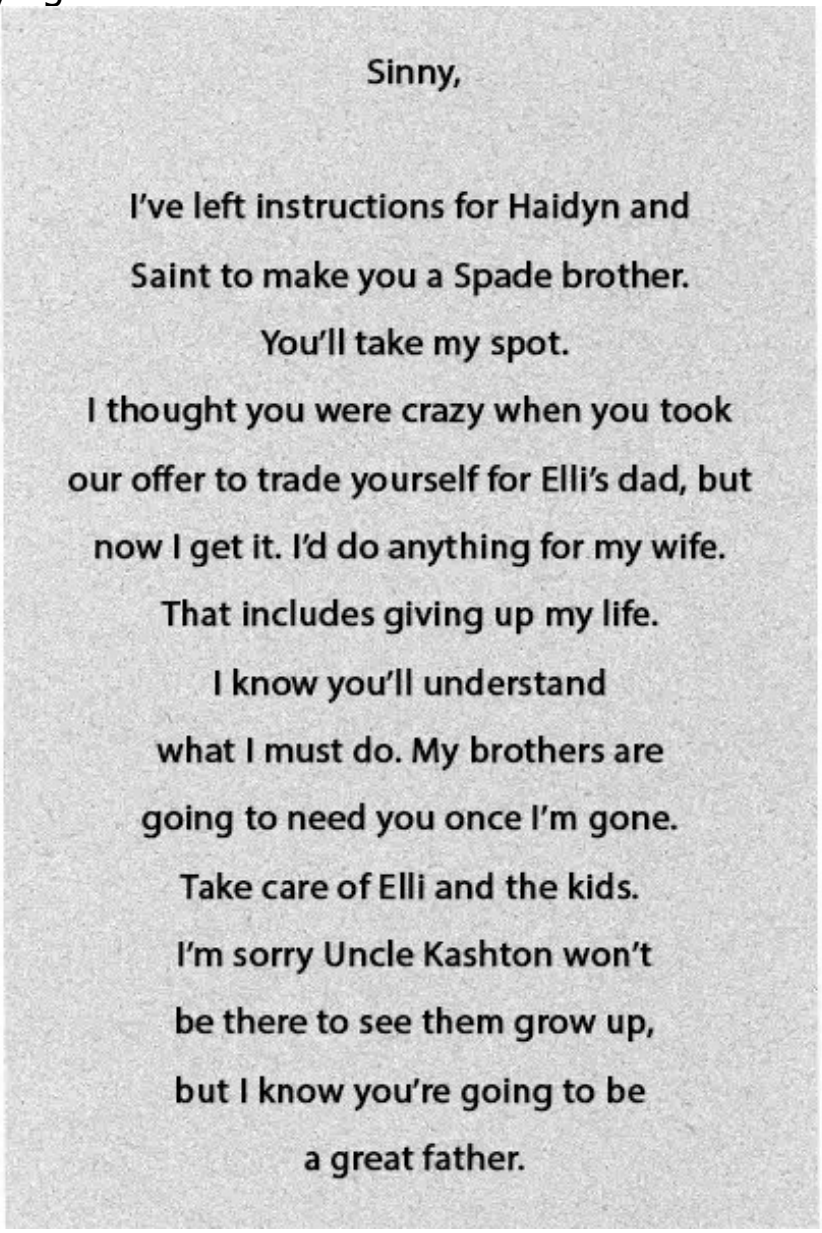
I wish I had the courage to tell you
goodbye face to face.
I know you deserve that much from me.
But I just can't return to Carnage.
It never really felt like home anyway.
and I can't go back without Eve there.
I can't set foot in my room knowing
I'll be there without her.
Haidyn. I'm sorry I let you down.
I'm also sorry that I'm not going to be
there to watch over Charlotte. but I know
Saint will be a great guardian for her.
Bill has my requests following my death.
I will rest with my wife.
Dig her up and bury me with her.
She needs me to hold her.
I don't want her to feel alone.
Next to her is where I belong.
I just want to tell you both that I'm honored
to have been your brother.

Turning, I see him lying in the middle of the bed naked. He's so tall that his feet hang off the end. He's on his stomach, arms fanned out, the pillows and blankets on the floor.

Tears silently run down my face after reading his letter to Saint and Haidyn. What happened that he thought I'd died? What or who did he bury that he thought was me? Was it a body burned past recognition? A fake body? Wouldn't Devin have run blood work?

If I thought Kashton were dead, I would do everything imaginable to question it. I wouldn't accept it.

Setting the letter down, I see another one folded just the same. I grab it, hurrying to unfold it.



Sinny,

I've left instructions for Haidyn and
Saint to make you a Spade brother.
You'll take my spot.
I thought you were crazy when you took
our offer to trade yourself for Elli's dad, but
now I get it. I'd do anything for my wife.
That includes giving up my life.
I know you'll understand
what I must do. My brothers are
going to need you once I'm gone.
Take care of Elli and the kids.
I'm sorry Uncle Kashton won't
be there to see them grow up,
but I know you're going to be
a great father.

My watery eyes drop to the gun on the floor. Bending down, my shaking hands pick it up and pop open the cylinder. One bullet remains in the revolver, and it was lined up with the barrel. Now his letter to his brothers makes sense, along with the scattered ammunition. Was he going to kill himself? Did he try? The thought terrifies me.

Adam's words echo in my mind. *"Just because you don't pull the trigger, doesn't mean your actions won't kill him."*

Setting the gun down, I quickly rip my clothes off and crawl on the bed next to him. Fuck Adam and what he said. My husband needs me. Physically, emotionally, and mentally. I made a vow to be his and that means giving him whatever he needs.

"Kash?" I say, running the tips of my nails along his tatted arm. "Kashton, I'm here." I shake his shoulder, getting his attention. "Wake up, Kash."

Oh God, he's not already dead, is he?

He groans, shifting his weight to his side. Placing his arm over me, he pulls me into him, and I sniff, trying to hold the fresh tears back. "Eve." He sighs my name.

My chest squeezes at the sound of his rough voice. I sob that he's alive. "Yeah, baby. I'm here." I lick my trembling lips. "I'm here with you."

"I miss you so much, angel," he whispers, and my stomach drops.

"Wake up… Kash." I clear my throat, trying to sound authoritative, but I've got a massive knot restricting my words.

My watery eyes roam his face, and my heart hurts at what I see. He looks like shit. Busted nose and lip. Swollen eyes, bruises, and cuts. He hasn't shaved in who knows how long. "What happened to you?" My hands shake, afraid to touch him but wanting to help at the same time.

Is he in pain?

His heavy lashes flutter open, and I get a quick glimpse of his pretty blue eyes before they fall closed. They look bloodshot and tired. His hand moves up my spine as I cuddle into him, and I slide my nails down his tatted back.

"I love you," I tell him as I bury my face in his neck and kiss his warm skin. He feels alarmingly hot. Does he have a fever? Are his cuts infected? Why hasn't he had Gavin come by and look at him?

"Eve?" He pulls back, and this time his eyes are open and on mine.

"Yeah, Kash." I sniff. "It's me. I'm here," I assure him. "I—"

His lips find mine, and I allow him to push me onto my back. I wrap my legs around his waist, and my hands go to his unkempt hair.

He kisses me so hard it takes my breath away, his beard tickling my face. Lifting his hips, his hand falls between our bodies, and I beg

him to fuck me, pushing Adam's words out of my mind.

I need him and he needs me. I made it on time. He's here and alive.

Pulling my lips from his, I beg him, "Please fuck me, Kash. I need you."

"I need you too, angel." He slides his pierced cock into my pussy with no foreplay.

I'm not even close to being wet, but I would never deny him. He buries his face in my neck while he works his hips back and forth, my pussy becoming wet with each thrust.

"Fuck, angel." He groans. "Fuck, I miss you so much."

Tears fall from the corners of my eyes. "I'm here, Kash." My throat burns with trying to hold in a sob at how he feels. That he thought I'd leave him. But I can see why he thinks that. I told him goodbye. I thought I was going to die, so I made him think that as well. Just like he put doubt in my head when he chased me out of this room and I thought I'd woken up in Dollhouse.

"I love you, Eve. I love you so much." His weight is on top of me, his face in my neck with my arms and legs wrapped around him, holding him to me.

"I…love you," I tell him, trying to catch my breath. There's a pain in my upper chest that I ignore.

"I never made love to you…I'm so sorry. Please know I love you, angel."

He fucks me as tears run down the side of my face. I wish I could stop them, but I can't.

I was terrified of what I'd find and then horrified by what I did. I cling to him, telling him how much I love him while he holds me like there is no tomorrow. As if this is our last time together. But it can't be. I won't let it. I'll show up every time for him. No matter what it costs.

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EIGHTY-ONE



KASHTON

I open my heavy eyes and sit up, my hands going to my busted face. The bright light coming from the bathroom makes me groan. Did I leave it on?

Fuck. I need a drink and a cigarette.

"Fuck, angel." I groan. "Fuck, I miss you so much."

"I'm here, Kash."

The hallucination was so realistic. Haidyn and the guys saw their loved ones being tortured and killed. I see my dead wife alive.

I don't know how many days it's been since I tried to kill myself and my gun let me down. It was a sign that I don't deserve such a quick death. I should suffer like my wife did. So I'll spend the rest of my days rotting here all alone.

My hands drop to my sides, and I feel something wet next to me. "What the…?" I trail off when I see a spot of blood covering the dingy sheets. I run my hand over it and then rub it between my fingers. It's fresh.

I pat myself down, looking over my torso. I've got blood on my chest, arm and ribs. I run my fingers through it to see if I cut myself, but there's nothing there. Maybe it's from the guys who beat me up in the bar, but that was a while ago. Or maybe I did shoot myself, and I'm just slowly bleeding out over time.

Getting out of bed, I stumble to the bathroom to clean myself up and come to a stop. My heart begins to pound in my chest at what I see.

My wife stands in the shower. One hand is pressed on her upper chest while her forehead rests against the wall. A steady stream of

blood trails down her body before washing away in the drain.

As if she feels eyes on her, she looks up at me. A soft smile graces her lips. "I'm fine. I promise."

"Eve?" I blink, trying to decide if I'm fucking high or dead.

"I'm fine," she repeats and takes her hand away from her chest, stumbling back.

I rush into the shower and place my arms under her, picking Eve up. Pulling her out from under the sprayer, I carry her to the bed and lay her on it. I pick up a shirt from the floor, wad it up, and press it to her upper chest where I see the blood pouring from.

She tilts her head back, and a blood-curdling scream leaves her trembling lips.

My hands shake and my brain tries to focus on what the fuck I'm doing. *She's not here.* This is a hallucination. She's going to die over and over again. But a different way each time.

This is my hell. A damnation.

"It's okay, angel." Even in my hallucination, I lie to her. "You'll be okay." All I can do is try and keep her calm.

Her watery eyes go to the door of the motel room. "Adam." She swallows, trembling on the bed. "Get…Adam."

Her color is starting to whiten as the shirt in my hands soaks up the blood. "He's not here, angel," I tell her. I'm going fucking crazy. This is it. If I don't kill myself soon, the guys will find me and lock me in a padded room at Carnage.

I don't know what significance my hallucination would have to Adam. Maybe it's the fact that he also left me. It's her reminding me that I'm alone. But I chose that this time. I had Haidyn and Saint, and I still left them by choice.

"He's…here." She's gasping to breathe. "Out…side."

Knowing it won't do any good, I still find myself walking over to the door. I open it up to see a truck parked right in front of my motel room. The driver's side door swings open and Adam jumps out. "What's wrong?" he demands, eyes looking over my naked and blood-covered body.

I stare at him, blinking. Confused.

"Move." He shoves me out of the way and rushes into my room. "Goddammit," he hisses, going over to her.

"I'm okay," she tells him, but her face is turning ghostly pale.

"Put some fucking clothes on," he snaps at me. "We have to get her to Carnage. Thankfully it's not too far."

"I—"

"We have to fucking move," he shouts, picking her up and carrying her out to the truck. "Let's go."

I quickly throw on a pair of jeans and a T-shirt without bothering with my boxers and shove my boots on untied and without socks. Then I'm running outside and jumping into the back seat where he's laid her down. I pull her into my arms. She's limp, just like she was while I sat on the cathedral floor and rocked her back and forth, begging her to come back to me.

I close my eyes and whisper, "It's just a hallucination."

"It's fucking real, Kash," Adam barks, speeding down the road while "Hold On" by Chord Overstreet plays through the speakers.

I shake my head. "My wife is dead," I say, holding her in my arms. Her eyes are closed, but she's breathing. I can see her chest moving with each breath, and I've got one finger on her thready pulse. She's still naked and covered in blood once again.

"Pull yourself out of whatever delusion you're in and put pressure on the wound so she doesn't bleed out," Adam shouts at me. Then he picks up his cell from the cupholder and dials up a number with his bloody fingers.

A phone rings through the speakers of his truck. "What?" a familiar voice barks.

"Saint—"

"What the fuck, Adam? What is going on? I've been calling Bill since you hung up on me last time."

"I'm on my way to Carnage. We're not far," Adam tells him.

Saint pauses for a second before he says. "We?"

"I've got Eve…and Kash."

Adam brings the truck to a screeching halt in the circle drive at Carnage. My door is ripped open, and Saint helps me out.

"She's been out for about twenty minutes," Adam rattles off to Devin as he greets us inside the double doors.

Haidyn stands to his right with Charlotte, who looks like she's seen a ghost. Hooke is also present and appears shocked, staring at not only my wife, but at Adam as well.

Devin glances from her bloody body to mine and then to Adam. His eyes wide and his mouth opens. He seems as confused as I feel.

"Devin," Adam barks at him.

He flinches and blinks rapidly. "Let's get her to surgery," Devin orders and I follow him.

"She had a gunshot wound to her axillary. One in the right thigh. A third to her left arm. Three weeks ago." Adam starts to explain her condition to Devin. "She required a blood transfusion. She was walking and talking just fine today. At first, I thought she maybe just tore the stitches open, but I think it's more than that."

"We'll take a look," Devin assures him.

I kick open a revolving door and place her on a gurney. Grabbing her hand, I run next to it as they quickly wheel her into an operating room. Gavin is already getting things set up and starts an IV immediately as others start running around.

"Ka-sh?"

I look down at her heavy eyes fluttering open. "She's awake," I holler at anyone who'll listen to me and bend down, placing a soft kiss on her forehead. "I'm right here, Eve. I'll be here when you wake up," I promise her.

She opens her mouth to say something, but Devin places an anesthesia mask over her nose and mouth. "Deep breaths, Eve," he commands, and she shakes her head.

Her tear-filled eyes meet mine, and I can see how scared she is. I understand because I'm fucking terrified. "They're going to help you, Eve. Let them help." I try to assure her even though I don't know what the fuck is going on.

Taking in a long breath, her heavy eyes remain on mine.

"That's it," Devin tells her. "Another."

She shakes her head and lifts her right arm to try and remove the mask, but I grab it in mine. “I’m not leaving, angel. I’m right here with you.”

Taking in another deep breath, her eyes fall closed, and I begin to count to myself. One…two…three…

When they don’t open and her hand relaxes in mine, I let go, placing it down by her side.

“Out, Kash,” Devin demands.

“But I told her—”

He shoves me out the revolving door, and I stand with my bloody hands on my head, facing the operating room. I’m still trying to process what I’m seeing. What has happened in the last few hours. I’m so confused and fucking pissed.

Gavin removes the mask, tilts her head back, and slides a glidescope down her throat to help thread the breathing tube. Devin places her left arm out so it’s perpendicular to her body and starts to suction the blood from her upper chest and shoulder area to find the source as it drips down the side of the table to puddle on the floor. It’s like the night she died all over again. I’m stuck in some kind of loop. It’s not a hallucination or a nightmare, just a living hell. This is my punishment for everything I’ve done bad in my life. Gavin gets my attention as he starts using gauze to help with the bleeding.

Turning, I see Haidyn and Saint gathered with Adam in the small waiting room. Charlotte sits in a chair, nibbling on a saltine cracker.

I walk over to Saint, and he holds out his arms as if I’m going to give him a hug. Instead, I reach down and yank the gun he has tucked into the waistband of his jeans. Cocking it, I point it at Adam.

He throws his hands up, and all the chatter stops. “Kash—”

“What in the fuck is going on?” I demand, interrupting him.

“Just put down the gun.” Adam looks from Haidyn to Saint, but neither one of them makes a move to stop me. I’ve seen what they’re capable of when it comes to their wives, and if they were in my shoes, they’d act no different. Hooke also stands off to the side, not daring to get in my way. This doesn’t involve him.

“Adam,” Ashtyn squeals, rushing through the double doors. “Oh my God…”

Saint wraps an arm around her, holding her back, because I've got a gun trained on her brother's chest.

"Fucking answer me," I shout. "I held my wife's body in my arms. I held her cold hand while she laid in the morgue. I buried her in the fucking ground." The gun shakes uncontrollably in my hand. I would normally hate how weak I look right now, but I need answers. "She was dead. So tell me, how in the fuck is she here now?"

Ashtyn cries. "Kash…please don't…" Saint covers her mouth with his hand to shut her up.

I ignore them, keeping my eyes on Adam. His hands remain raised in surrender. I'm not ashamed to admit that I'd kill an unarmed man. I've done worse to a human.

"She needed to die." He licks his lips. "The Lords would never allow you to be with her. She knew that."

"Why?" I demand.

Haven't I done enough for them? Don't I deserve to love who I want? Is this a punishment? They had to have put her in my path. They sent Haidyn and me to pick up that Lord from the cathedral, and I guarantee they knew I was looking for her and that she was his half sister. So why give me something only to take it away?

They will take away what you love most, she once told me.

The doors open, and I see Ryat and Sin rush in but come to an abrupt stop. I put my attention back on the brother who betrayed me. I'm not sure why I'm surprised. He's done nothing but fuck us over for the past four years. I just kept hold of the idea that he'd come home and everything would go back to normal. Like a scared little boy begging his big brother to come back. It was a stupid thought; we're better off without him.

"Listen," Adam growls, getting angry but also dodging my question, "you went to Bill and told him to make her your Lady. He told you what to expect."

"No." I shake my head.

"Yes. You said you could handle it. You said *she* could handle it." Adam nods over to Sin. "You were there with me. You know."

I whip around to glare at Sin. "You knew my wife wasn't dead?" I bark.

"Eve is alive?" he asks, wide-eyed, looking at Haidyn for confirmation. He nods in answer while standing in front of his pregnant wife, shielding her from me. As if I'd ever hurt her. But I get it. I'd protect Eve if the roles were reversed. I'm a suicidal madman running on very little sleep and still trying to decide if this is real or not. "I don't know what's going on." Sin looks back at me. "We got a text from Saint that you were on your way home and to get to Carnage ASAP. There was an emergency."

I place my attention back on Adam. "Three weeks," I say through gritted teeth. "Three fucking weeks you've let me think she was dead." It was the most agonizing thing I've ever been through. I'd rather take three years of training than live a day without her. Cuts and broken bones will heal over time, but what I felt when I lost my wife? I'll never recover from that. Even if she is alive.

"We've known she was alive for the past week," Saint says.

I turn to him and ignore the sobbing Ashtyn in his arms. She's trying to pry his hand off her mouth so she can beg me to not kill her brother. "What the fuck did you say?"

"I—"

"You knew she was alive?" I ask, even more confused than before. "Why the fuck didn't you tell me?"

"We tried," he says through gritted teeth. "You left. No cell phone. No tracker. Calls, texts, and voicemails went unanswered."

"How did you know?" How am I the only one between my brothers who didn't know my wife was alive?

"I had Sin call Bill and demand contact with Adam. A few days later, we were told to call Bill." Saint nods to Adam. "Adam answered, and I begged him to come home. To help us find you. You left, and Haidyn was on a warpath. I needed help, but Adam refused to come back."

"Wait. Wait. Wait." I feel like I'm losing my mind. "Did Bill know she was alive this entire time?" I growl at Adam, and the fact that he can't look at me answers my question. "His wife helped me plan Eve's funeral, for fuck's sake."

"Janice didn't know," Adam rushes out, shaking his head at Sin. As if his mother could be such a coldhearted bitch.

I turn my attention back to Saint and the previous conversation. "How did you know Eve was alive during that phone call? He just told you?" I take a quick look at Adam, and his arms are still raised since I have the gun pointed at him.

"Eve started shouting for me in the background," Saint adds. "She seemed confused and was crying. I asked her where she was, and she didn't know."

My teeth grind, and my pulse quickens at the thought of how scared she was. Did she not choose to leave me? I thought that maybe it was her idea to pretend to be dead, but now I'm not so sure.

"She started screaming…he hung up—ended the call—after I found out she was there with him. I immediately told Haidyn, but there was nothing we could do. We didn't have Adam's number for contact. We had called Bill directly to talk to Adam, and he was no longer answering."

Adam sighs. "I did what needed to be done."

I give him my attention once again.

He takes a deep breath, adding, "The Lords needed to see what you would do."

"You don't work for the Lords," I shout. "You've betrayed them. No longer acknowledge them." That's why he had to leave us again, right? Because he was going to take them down from the inside. At least that's what I got from our talk on the jet that night. Yet here he is, back in our lives.

"It's complicated."

"So you're putting Sin in danger?" I arch a brow. "Because they ordered him to kill you, and instead of doing what he was told, he saved your sorry ass. How many of us are you going to fuck over?"

He looks quickly at Sin and then back to me. "You don't understand—"

"Of course I don't!" I scream, my lungs burning. "Because you're not telling us anything."

"The Lords didn't want you to marry her because she can't give you children," he grinds out. "She can't reproduce, which renders her useless to you."

"My wife isn't useless," I shout. A woman is worth more than having fucking kids.

I pull the trigger.

Charlotte yelps, Ashtyn falls to her knees, and Adam stumbles back, grabbing his arm. Blood slips through his fingers.

"Oh my God," Ashtyn sobs while Saint scrambles to keep a hold of her, needing to use both hands.

He'll survive. It was just a warning shot. Skimmed his fucking arm. I should have blown it off.

Someone speaks from behind me. "That's not entirely true."

I turn to see its Gavin. "How is my wife?" I drop the gun to my side and fully face him.

"Still in surgery," he answers.

"Then why are you out here?" I bark.

He scans the room before meeting my hard stare. "She's in good hands. May I speak to you?"

I run a hand through my hair. He's just trying to defuse the situation. Doesn't want me to kill Adam in front of everyone.

I walk toward Gavin and slam the side of the gun into Sin as I pass him. He hisses in a breath when the heated barrel burns his chest before he grabs a hold of it.

Following Gavin into a room, he ushers me to sit down at a table. There's already a rolling cart waiting that has instruments on it. "What is that for?"

"This is for you," Gavin states, pulling on a pair of gloves.

"Oh, no. I don't—"

"You need stitches, and that eye needs to be looked at. I'd be surprised if you don't have some kind of infection."

"Fine," I growl. "Make it quick." I want to be with my wife when she wakes up.

EVERETT

I arch my neck and try to relieve the pressure in it. It feels so tight, but it doesn't help. Sighing, I open my heavy eyes, and I'm met with a familiar blue set that reminds me of the sky on a clear day. I never thought I'd see him again.

"Hey, angel." Kash smiles down at me, running his tatted knuckles over my cheek, and I lean into him. "Don't cry, Eve."

Am I crying? "What…happened?" My voice is rough and my throat sore.

I look around to see I'm in an unfamiliar room that resembles a hospital. I remember the motel, us having sex, and then afterward I felt dizzy. I got up to use the restroom and there was blood. I needed to shower. I tried to stop it with a towel but there was just too much. I knew I'd gone too far. Adam told me not to have sex, but I couldn't turn Kashton down. He needed me and I wanted him.

"Devin called it a wound dehiscence, but to explain it in a language I understood, he said that your fresh stitches ripped open from overexerting yourself." He frowns, tilting his head to the side. "Why did you let me hurt you?" He grabs my hand and brings it to his lips, gently kissing my knuckles.

"I was fine."

Kashton sighs, running a hand down his face. "Clearly you weren't." His brows furrow. "I would have never—"

"I wanted you." He needed me. I love my husband, but we both crave the physical aspect of our relationship as much as anything else. We're both addicts who needed a fix.

I go to sit up but flinch. My hand immediately goes to my chest, wanting to reduce the pain.

"Lie down," he commands gently and then pulls up the blanket and crawls under it and into bed with me. I curl into him and let him hold me. "Why would you let me hurt you, angel?"

I want to ask him how he could even ask me that when we both know that he was planning on killing himself in that motel room, but there's time to talk about that later. The thought that I could have been too late makes my body shake. What if I had found him dead? To even imagine that is terrifying.

"I'm right here," he assures me, softly rubbing my back as if he knows what I'm thinking.

I sob into his T-shirt, and he lets me get it all out. So many emotions I've never felt before that I'm not sure what to do with. I ran into the cathedral to save him, and it almost ended up killing him

anyway. What if he had succeeded? Would I have ever found him? How long would Adam have kept me from him?

I must have fallen asleep in my husband's arms. When I wake up, I'm in the room alone. I look around to see some clothes neatly folded on a chair by the window. A pair of oversized sweatpants and a T-shirt. They're Kashton's. I slowly get out of the hospital bed and begin to dress myself. It takes me longer than usual, but I want to be in his room. Alone. Just the two of us, hiding away from this world that seems to be against us. They don't know how stubborn and determined I am, but I'll continue to show them.

Exiting the room, I see Charlotte sitting in a chair with her head in her hand. Ashtyn sits across from her, staring at an invisible speck on her yoga pants. Her head snaps up when she hears me approach.

She jumps to her feet, which makes Charlotte lift her head. Her blue eyes look between Ashtyn and mine.

Charlotte gets to her feet much slower. "Ash—"

"Stay out of this, Charlotte," Ashtyn interrupts her.

I square my shoulders, ready to fight this bitch. I don't care if it puts me back in the hospital or not. Some things are worth it. "Problem?" I arch a brow.

Ashtyn snorts. She has to lean her head back to glare up at me because I'm taller than her. "You pretended to be dead and then showed up like nothing happened."

I don't argue that because I really have no clue what the fuck happened. How Kashton thought I was dead or where the fuck I was with Adam. I've got time that is missing, memories nonexistent. I can't argue something I know nothing about.

"Ashtyn," Charlotte starts again. "I'm sure there's a reasonable explanation."

"An explanation as to why she fucked over Kashton while she hid out with my brother?" Ashtyn's eyes drop to my bare feet, and she looks me up and down with disgust.

Ah, now her attitude makes sense. She thought her brother was dead, and then he returned with me. Maybe she thinks I've been shacked up fucking Adam. That's something she's done before with another man, so why wouldn't I?

I step into Ashtyn, and Charlotte looks worried. Her eyes dart around the room as if she's trying to decide whether to run and get help or not. "You shot your husband, leaving him for dead. I was willing to die for mine. So keep your judgmental bullshit to yourself. We are not the same, and you have no clue what you're fucking talking about."

She gasps, and Charlotte's wide-eyed gaze drops to the floor.

Ashtyn spins around to storm off but comes to a stop and turns to face me. Her dark hair slapping her in the face. "Know what, Eve? For once you're right." She gives me a chilling smile. "I ran to save my unborn child. You killed yours. We're *not* the same."

"Ashtyn," Saint barks at her.

I look over my shoulder to see her husband standing behind us. His eyes meet mine with sympathy, and I glance back at his wife.

The smile remains on her face, and she lowers her hands to her growing belly. "At least I can still have children."

"ASHTYN," Saint shouts, making Charlotte flinch.

Ashtyn huffs, then turns and walks through the double doors, not bothering to look back when Saint rushes after her.

A silence falls over the room, and I hate how right she was. I made a decision that cost Kashton a future where he could be a father. It's my biggest regret. I was supposed to have died with my child, but instead, I failed us both. A parent is supposed to protect their children. Not hurt them.

Would my mother have killed me if she had the chance? I hope that her answer would have been yes. No one should be forced to be a parent. Especially a child themselves.

"She didn't mean it." Charlotte breaks the silence. "She's just—"

"Where are they?" I interrupt her. I've never needed someone to fight my battles for me. I'm not about to start now.

There's a reason she was sitting out here with Ashtyn. And I don't know where Saint came from, but the rest of them aren't far away.

"In the room." She nods to the door next to where I was. "They had just gone in there to *talk* before you came out."

I waddle my sore ass over to it and don't even bother knocking before I shove it open. Everyone in the room turns to look at me.

Devin is wrapping Adam's upper arm, and if I cared, I'd ask what happened. I don't.

"Eve. You shouldn't be out of bed." Haidyn is the one who speaks, meeting my stare. Then he looks at Kashton as if he expects his brother to back him up.

"How do you feel, angel?" my husband asks, walking over to me. He places his hands gently on my face and tilts my head back so I can look up at him.

"Fine," I say, because *good* would be a lie, and I don't want to admit to any man in this room that I'm anything other than okay. There are pain meds in my system, because I'm kinda foggy, but I'm also hurting everywhere.

He leans down and kisses my forehead, and I whisper, "Will you take me to your room?"

Pulling back, his eyes search my face for a long second before he takes my hand and starts to walk me out of the room.

"Kash—"

"It can fucking wait," he interrupts my brother, not bothering to look back. Letting the door shut behind him, he speaks. "I'm going to pick you up. Let me know if I hurt you."

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EIGHTY-TWO



KASHTON

We enter my room, and I notice I'm still covered in blood from trying to stop her from bleeding in the car on the way to Carnage. "I need a shower," I tell her, gently setting her down on her feet.

"I'll take one with you."

I hate how soft her voice is. My wife likes to be heard. She speaks her mind, and she yells it for all to hear. She seems so unsure of what to do or how to act. Maybe she thinks I'm mad at her. Honestly, I'm not sure what to be. I still don't have any answers on what the fuck happened or how it went down. But I know they'll come. Right now, all that matters is I'm not hallucinating and it's not her that I buried in the Carnage cemetery.

We walk into the bathroom, and I turn to face her. "Let me help you." I don't give her any room to argue, and thankfully she doesn't try to fight me. I grip the hem of my T-shirt that she wears and pull it up over her head careful with her arms. Then I push the sweatpants down her legs and help her step out of them. She's naked underneath.

I scan over her right thigh. There's a fresh scar and bruise. Running my hands up her hips and over her ribs, I look at the new bandage that I know covers the fresh stitches that go from her shoulder to her underarm.

Then there's another scar and bruise on her upper arm. They match the body that I found on the floor of the cathedral, the one on the tape, where I watched her get shot. My hands go to her neck, and she arches it for me as I run my fingers over her throat to

check for bruises. There are none. It has been three weeks, though. A gunshot wound would leave longer visual effects than whatever they used to strangle her. That just makes me even more confused. How could there be a body that had the same matching injuries?

I know I didn't imagine all of that. The guys were there. Devin bathed her, brought someone in to embalm her before he helped me bury her. I watched her get shot three times in the fucking video.

I think I'm going insane.

"Kashton." She wraps her soft hands around my wrists when mine begin to shake on her neck. "Talk to me." Her worried eyes search mine.

There's so much I want to ask her, but I'm not sure if I want the answers. I went to a dark place when I thought she'd died. If I ask her questions, she'll ask me some as well. And I don't want to answer them. "Come on." I let go of her and step into the shower, turning on the sprayer, checking the temperature of the water. I help her inside and then I hurry to undress and enter behind her.

"I don't think I can get this wet." She gestures to the fresh bandage.

"I'll be careful," I assure her before quickly washing off the blood and then turn to grab her shampoo. I squirt it into my hand. I haven't thrown any of her stuff away. I just couldn't get rid of her presence. I wanted the reminder that she was all mine. Even if it was for such a short time. When I left this world, I wanted to make sure all our stuff was in the same place she had it.

"Sit on the bench." She slowly sits down and turns the best she can to give me her back. Lathering it in my hands, I begin to shampoo her hair.

EVERETT

We both remain silent in the shower. My mind is racing as quickly as my pulse, but I don't know what to say or how to act.

I'm afraid things have changed. What were they talking about when I walked in there? What does he know that I don't?

Getting out of the shower, I allow him to dry me off. He's treating me as if I'm incapable of taking care of myself. Maybe I am. Will he

chain me up in the basement after this? That way he always knows where I'm at and I can't put myself in danger?

I'd let him. If it meant I'd never see him like he was in the motel again.

We enter his bedroom, and he pulls back the covers, gesturing for me to crawl in. I drop the towel and slide into the cool sheets.

He climbs in beside me. I'm not sure what day it is, much less what time it is. The curtains to his balcony are open and it's dark out.

Lying side by side, the silence eats at me, and I know he wants to turn on the TV.

He drapes his arm across my chest, and I flinch. "I'm sorry," comes his voice.

"I'm fine," I assure him. I'm not some delicate flower, and being shot doesn't change that. I want him to know that I'm still the same woman he wanted to marry.

I sit up, ignoring the sting in my chest and shove the covers away as I straddle him.

"Angel," he warns, and his hands go to my hips. I have a moment of panic that he's going to shove me away. Deny me.

His fear is abandonment and mine is for him to stop loving me. I never knew it could be like this. I've become dependent on him and can't imagine a life without him.

"I didn't know you thought I was dead," I say softly. My nails gently run up and down his chest. I know how it sounded. My goodbye call to him. But that was in case I didn't walk out of there. I would have never wanted to put him through that unless I really was dead.

"But you were willing to die for me," he counters.

I bite my bottom lip nervously. "You would do the same for me."

"As your husband, that's my job."

"No. Your job as my husband is to love me unconditionally."

I feel him shift, and then the light on his nightstand turns on. He places his hands on my face and frowns. "You think I don't love you anymore?" I open my mouth, but he continues. "I…" He looks away for a second before he glances back at me. "I was a wreck without you, Eve." I swallow the knot that lodges in my throat, remembering the call I overheard with Saint and Adam. How Kash had killed their

prisoners and left. “I was so mad at you…” He closes his eyes. “For leaving me.” He looks up at me, and my chest tightens thinking of him in that motel all alone. “You may not have died, but you willingly walked into an ambush knowing damn well that you might not walk out.”

“Kashton—”

“And that fucking voicemail,” he adds with a growl.

So, he heard that. “Kash—”

“I begged you not to do it.” He interrupts me again. “To give me time to save you.”

“That’s what they wanted. They were going to kill you.”

“Why?” he questions, his brows drawing together in confusion. “What did they want from me that you thought you could give them?”

I frown at his question. He makes it sound like he already knows. “I…I don’t know,” I say honestly. “There was a text…and I knew it was either you or me.”

“It’s always me,” he grinds out. “In any situation like that. It’s me.”

“Is that why you were going to kill yourself?” I ask.

He glances away and his jaw sharpens.

I place my hands flat on his chest and dig my nails into his skin. “Tell me how that’s any different, Kashton.”

He snorts. “The sad part is you actually expected me to go on without you. As if I didn’t lose my wife.”

“I wasn’t dead.”

“I didn’t know that,” he snaps, and his body tenses underneath me. Running his hand down his unshaven face, he sighs and relaxes back into the mattress. I scan his stitches, thankful one of the doctors was able to help him. “I buried you, Eve.”

“I wanted to be cremated.” I smile down at him, trying to lighten the mood about a previous conversation we had, but it doesn’t work.

“I begged a God I don’t believe in to bring you back.” His sad eyes stare into mine. “I haven’t done that since I was a child.”

“Well, if He exists, He heard you,” I try to joke again.

He lets out a long breath. “Tomorrow morning, I’m digging up that body and we’re going to get to the bottom of this, because it was

you. And you were dead."

I take his hand and gently place it on my bare chest. "I'm right here." I know he can feel my heart pounding. "Alive. In this bed with you right now."

His hand trails up and then runs through my wet hair. "I feel like I'm going to wake up from this dream and you'll still be gone." He speaks softly, as if he's too ashamed to say it out loud.

Tears sting my eyes at his confession. I lean down and press my lips to his, giving him a soft kiss.

His hands find my hair, and he holds it back when I part my lips for him. He deepens the kiss, and I swallow the urge to cry. I can't imagine what he went through. Or how he felt. But I don't want him to feel that now. I'm not going anywhere.

I grind my hips on his and he gently pulls on my hair lifting my lips from his. "We can't," he breathes.

"I'll go slow," I tell him.

"Eve," he growls when I reach between us and begin to stroke his dick. I didn't expect him to be hard. He's too concerned about me after what happened at the motel. But he was on top and had no idea what was happening.

"I'll control it." I lick my lips.

"No. You won't." He grabs my wrists and removes my hand from his soft dick.

My stomach drops when he gently lifts me up and places me next to him. I lie down while he rolls onto his side to face me. His hand gently brushes my wet hair from my face. "I love you, Eve. More than anything in the world, but I'm not fucking you."

I gently nod at the rejection. "I…I would if you needed it."

He sighs heavily. "You almost died again because of me. This has nothing to do with needs. It has to do with your life, and I won't risk it. Never again."

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EIGHTY-THREE



KASHTON

Click.

I let out the breath in one hard whoosh and grind my teeth when the gun doesn't go off. "Come on," I grind out. My right hand now shaking, I squeeze again.

Click.

"Goddammit," I shout, jumping to my feet.

I catch sight of myself in the mirror on the wall across from me. I'm bruised and cut all over. My eyes are swollen.

I'm to the point that I think I'm delirious. I don't know how much I've slept since I found her at the cathedral. I've tried. Trust me. I thought I'd see her in my dreams, so I tried to put myself into an alcohol haze. But she didn't show. Not how I wanted her to, anyway. All I saw was her lifeless body covered in blood.

At least I no longer cry. I'm pretty sure that's due to the punches to the face I deserved. My fists are cut and bruised from punching the walls, and I've spent more time on my knees screaming for her, as if my begging could bring her back.

It can't.

I throw the gun at my reflection, and it shatters the mirror, just like the bottles scattered on the floor.

"Seven years of bad luck, Kash." *I hear her voice in my head, and I laugh at the thought.*

I'll be dead by noon. "Those seven years won't matter, angel," I say as if she's here with me.

The urge to pick up the gun to try again is strong. But maybe it's the universe's way of telling me I don't deserve death.

I've been taking the enhancements. It was to live a long life with her. What if this is my punishment instead? A long and healthy life all alone with a hole in my heart that nothing or no one can fill.

Everett's passed out, and I lie next to her in our bed, gently stroking her damp hair while she sleeps.

I'd never admit it to her, but I'm afraid to close my eyes. To miss a second of this—her in my arms. Last time I held her, we were covered in blood, and I begged her not to leave me.

That day I found her in the cathedral will haunt me for the rest of my life. Even in my dreams. I won't be able to escape it.

I tried to kill myself in that motel room. Twice. What if I had succeeded? Why did I play Russian Roulette? Why didn't I just fill the revolver and shoot myself? Not leave it to chance?

A knock comes on the bedroom door, and I frown, looking over my shoulder at it. I slowly remove my arm from underneath her and stand. Pulling on a pair of basketball shorts that are on the floor, I open the door to see Haidyn standing in the hallway.

He takes a quick look inside to see her covered up and fast asleep before his eyes meet mine. Holding out a box, he says, "Adam told Sin and Ryat where you had been hiding, and they went to collect your things."

"Adam told them?" I ask slowly.

His jaw sharpens. "Yeah, apparently he knew the whole time."

I figured that was the case, otherwise how would Eve have found me? Sure, we'd spent time at the bar and the motel, but she wouldn't have known that was where I'd go to mourn her and kill myself. Missy probably ratted me out. She was the bartender working that night the bikers beat me up.

"Good shot, by the way. I would have blown the bastard's knee out." Haidyn grunts.

I take the open box from him and look down to see my gun, Zippo, cigarettes, and bullets rolling around freely, along with her wedding ring and cell phone. "Thanks." All could have been replaced. When she was bleeding out, none of it mattered. I go to shut the door, but he stops it with his boot.

"What the fuck is this shit?" He reaches into his leather jacket and removes a folded piece of paper, and I know exactly what it is.

I go to grab it out of his hands, but he yanks it back.

"A suicide note?" He arches a dark brow. "You gave me a lecture about being suicidal, yet you wrote me and Saint a goddamn letter saying goodbye?" His eyes drop to the box still in my hand. "The single bullet that's in your revolver tells me exactly what you were going to do." He shakes the note as if to prove his point. "So don't bother lying to me."

I grind my teeth. "Yet here we both are."

He's right that I can't lie to him. The evidence is damning. I couldn't return here without her. We had been married for such a short time, but her smell lingered, her things cluttered the bathroom, and her clothes were in the closet. She had taken over my life just like I had known she would. It was either burn this place down or end what pathetic life I was forced to have without her.

"Yeah." His eyes go to her once more before he nods to himself. "We're both still here."

"Good night, Haidyn." I yank the letter from his hand and shut the door in his face.

Turning, I walk over to the trash can by the French doors that lead to the balcony and rip it multiple times before dropping the pieces into it, then turn around to get into bed only to come to a stop. Eve sits up in bed, her hair wild and eyes heavy as they stare at the evidence I just tried to destroy.

She runs a hand through her hair, pushing the bleached-blond strands from her face while yawning. "What are you doing up?" She eyes the darkly lit room as if there's an answer to her question.

"I'm coming to bed, but you need to take your meds since you're awake." Devin dropped them off right after she fell asleep. I didn't have the heart to wake her.

"I don't want them."

"You're taking them, or you go back to the hospital." I go over to my nightstand and grab the pills and a bottle of water. "Take both." I hand them to her, and she tosses the two pills into her mouth and

then takes the water. “Good girl,” I tell her, and she rolls her eyes, handing me back the bottle of water.

I crawl into bed beside her, and she rolls onto her side to face me. She tries to hide her unease, but I see her flinch at the new position.

“You should lie on your back.”

“I’m a side sleeper.” She yawns again. “Doesn’t matter anyway, the pills are going to knock me out.”

She’s not wrong, but that doesn’t mean how she sleeps won’t affect her when she wakes up. I’ll just move her once she’s out.

“Get some rest, angel.” I kiss her forehead and tuck a few wild pieces of hair behind her ear.

Her soft snoring fills the room, and I smile for the first time in three weeks. I could have lost this forever if my gun had gone off. I don’t believe in God, but something saved me that day, and I will forever be grateful for a second chance at the life I always wanted.

I open my eyes to see I’m alone in our bed. “Eve?” I yell, jumping up.

“In the bathroom,” she calls out.

I rush into it to find her washing her hands. “What are you doing?”

“I had to pee.” She gives me a bright smile, looking at me in the mirror. Her eyes look more awake, her color more vibrant.

Taking a deep breath, I feel like I can finally breathe. That maybe, just maybe this is over. That she’s on the upswing of recovery. As I walk over to her, she turns the water off and faces me, drying her hands. I take her face in mine and kiss her forehead just as someone knocks on my door.

I sigh. “We’ll never get a moment of peace as long as we live here.”

“They were worried about you.” I pull away to look down at her. “I overheard a phone call between Adam and Saint.” I let her tell me what I already know because she has no clue that I had this conversation last night in the waiting room. “Saint was trying to find you.” Her eyes search mine, and I give her another kiss before I pull away and go answer the door.

Once again, Haidyn stands in the hallway, this time with Muffin in his hand. She meows and jumps down. She hops onto the bed as Everett sits down, and her purring fills the room when Eve begins to scratch her fluffy head.

"Need something?" I ask Haidyn.

"Sin and Ryat are here."

"And? What the fuck does that have to do with me?"

"Kash," Eve sighs from behind me.

I plaster a smile on my face, and Haidyn frowns, confused. "Why are they here?" I ask tightly, trying to sound nicer.

"Saint wants us down in the basement."

"I'll get ready."

I turn around to tell Eve not to bother, but she's already shutting the bathroom door. My eyes drop to Muffin lying on the bed. She's on her back, legs spread and eyes closed. Walking over to pick her up, I hand the furry pussy back to Haidyn. "We'll meet you down there." Then I shut the door in his face.

EVERETT

We exit the elevator hand in hand, and a shiver runs through my body. It's always so cold down here.

"You okay?" Kashton asks me.

"I'm good." I should have taken another pain pill this morning, but I refuse to feel foggy anymore. Thankfully he didn't fight me on that, but I know he'll restrict me in other ways to make sure I don't do too much.

He pulls back the plastic curtains and allows me to go through first as he follows. Coming into the pits area, I see everyone in attendance. Even Ashtyn and Charlotte, which surprises me.

Ashtyn steps forward, glaring at Kashton. I go to step in front of my husband, but he pulls me back. She opens her mouth to speak when Saint's voice breaks through the awkward silence. "Go upstairs, Ash."

She spins around to face him. "I will not."

"It wasn't a suggestion." He narrows his eyes on her.

"Saint—"

"Now," he barks.

I have to bite my lip to keep from smiling. I've never seen him give her anything less than what she wants. I mean, I haven't been around them much, but from what I've seen from the sidelines, everyone seems to cater to her.

Huffing, she spins around and storms out of the basement, making sure to run her shoulder into mine. Like always, she's going to throw a fucking tantrum for not getting her way.

"Why are we down here?" Kashton asks, pulling me to stand in front of him. He wraps his arms around my upper arms and rests his chin on top of my head. "My wife needs to be in bed resting."

Fuck, I missed this so much. I knew I loved him, but I never knew it could be like this. How attached I could get to another human being.

Adam adjusts his stance, crossing his arms over his chest. "You want answers. I'm going to give them to you."

Kashton snorts. "Your version or the truth?"

Adam sighs but doesn't respond. Instead, he looks at me, and I stiffen in my husband's arms. My pulse begins to race wondering what he's about to say. "You did bury Eve. Just a different version of her."

"That doesn't make any sense." Kashton pulls away from me, and I feel cold all of a sudden. I wore one of Kashton's hoodies, knowing it's freezing down here. He moves to stand by my side instead.

Adam's eyes remain on mine when he speaks again. "She's a twin."

"No." I shake my head, and I feel everyone turn to look at me. "I'm not." My eyes go to Kashton, who is frowning. "That's not true." I look back at Adam. "You're lying."

"Yes. You are," Adam argues. "You had an identical twin, and I killed her. To save you."

I refuse to believe it. He's lying to save his own ass for what he did. "I would have known that."

Haidyn turns to face me. "Do you remember seeing Charlotte at the cathedral?"

I frown. "What? When Bill had you meet him there? No. She wasn't with you." Why would he ask me that?

He tilts his head in thought. "No. When you were younger. Charlotte saw you at the cathedral. It was an offering. You were there with LeAnne."

"No. I wasn't." I glance at Kashton, confused. What are they talking about? "I wasn't allowed to leave Carnage when I was younger." I was kept at Carnage until I was given to Dollhouse at nineteen. Then I spent a year in that hellhole.

"Let's say you're right…" Ryat speaks to Adam. "If Garrett had another daughter, why would she be with LeAnne?"

Kashton runs a hand through his hair. He looks unsure about whether to believe Adam or not.

"I'm right. It's how the cops had your DNA on the dead girl," Adam goes on. "Your identical twin played a part in killing that woman and dumping her in the cemetery that she knew you visited. And the woman who was found but had survived. She was tortured by you… the other you. They wanted her to go to the cops and describe Eve. It was just another base they were covering to make sure you went down for the murders."

"But Haidyn killed her," Saint adds. "It put a kink in their plan."

"What?" I gasp, looking at my brother. "You killed her?" When he doesn't say anything, I look at my husband, but he's also ignoring me.

"How long have you known about this?" Haidyn snaps at Adam.

He sighs. "Not long. I started to get suspicious one night after I met up with Kashton. He had just left Blackout and told me that he had seen and spoken to Eve while there. But he couldn't have. I had just gotten off a call with her, and she was on the opposite side of town about to do a job."

"What?" I turn to look at Kashton. "You spoke to her?"

"I…" He shrugs. "Uh…I don't know." Kashton stumbles over his words. "But I…the three guys from the cathedral were the same three guys I beat up that night at Blackout after I spoke to Eve…uh, your sister. So if she set up the meeting at the cathedral, then it makes sense that she had those guys helping her."

I run a hand through my hair nervously and take a step back from him.

"Think about it…Isabella is here. She ran Dollhouse. Their leader was taken away by Everett. If Evan hadn't confirmed to Eve that Haidyn was at Dollhouse, then we wouldn't have gone and pulled our brother out and brought Isabella here. They knew they had one secret weapon left." Adam's green eyes find mine, and I swallow nervously. "You. So they set you up. Tried to get rid of you so she could move in on Kashton, pretending to be his wife, gain access to the inside of Carnage, and then set Isabella free. But when the woman was killed, causing their original plan to fail, they had to change it up. Decided to kill you instead."

"No," Kashton barks. "Christopher said that Eve was set up because Evan wanted her…"

"It's possible," Adam agrees. "If you were with her twin—Vivian—then he had Eve, and you didn't know the difference."

"I would have known the fucking difference," my husband snaps.

"But—"

"Christ," Saint hisses.

"And then when Eve came to me, denying we'd slept together, I knew something else was going on, and I had to figure it out," Adam says.

"So we didn't have sex?" I ask, hopeful.

He shakes his head. "No. It was your sister. The picture didn't make sense. How Isabella got it in the first place to give to Haidyn for blackmail. I didn't have any cameras set up in my hotel room. Your sister had to set it up when I was making us a drink or undressing… I'm not sure. The point is, she put that phone there to record and sent it to Isabella, who then took a picture from it to use against Haidyn. Your sister was following you, and it led her to me. I'm not sure if that was their plan, but it ended up working in Isabella's favor."

"Wait." Haidyn holds up his hand. "What picture?"

Adam faces Haidyn. "When I was in Las Vegas following Ashtyn, Isabella showed you a picture—"

"The girl tied to your bed?" He tilts his head to the side.

"Yes."

Haidyn looks at me. "That…that was you?"

"No," Kashton snaps. "Well, her twin."

My brother rubs the back of his neck. "I didn't know."

"How…" I swallow. "How did she know so much about me, but I didn't know she existed?"

"Your father separated you at a very young age."

I turn to see someone new join our conversation. Bill emerges from the hallway, dragging a woman with him. He pushes her to her knees in the middle of the room, and I take a step back, not wanting to be anywhere near her. "Vivian knew so much about you because she was raised by LeAnne." He yanks on the woman's hair, pulling her head back, and she bares her teeth. "Tell them, Isabella. Tell them everything *you* know."

She begins to laugh, and I see Charlotte move to stand in the far corner of the room. Haidyn follows to stand in front of his pregnant wife.

Isabella has her hands cuffed behind her back, but that doesn't mean she won't try to use her body to take one of us down. The woman is as evil as they come.

"Pathetic." Bill shoves her to the concrete, face down, and kicks her onto her back. "LeAnne took you two in and raised you until you were two."

I wrap my arms around myself, so confused. My first memories are of this hell. I was around five. Anything before that doesn't exist.

Bill pushes his boot into her chest, and her shrill scream fills the room, making me flinch. She kicks and bucks, but he just presses more weight onto her naked body to hold her down. "Garrett didn't want one girl, let alone two. He wanted boys. When he got girls, he was going to sell you both. But LeAnne convinced him that one of them would be good to use." His eyes meet mine, and I swallow nervously. "She kept one, and he could have the other. A woman who'd come from a founder and a Spade brother…he could charge as much as he wanted."

I wonder what he means by that, because that's exactly what Ashtyn is, and I don't see anyone trying to sell her. But she's the last person I want to talk about, so I keep my mouth shut.

"Why not sell them both?" Haidyn asks.

"He did," Bill answers. "But he didn't sell Eve until she was older."

I bow my head, not wanting all of my husband's friends to know my past. I'm not sure how much he's shared with them about me, and I honestly would rather not know.

"Garrett sold her to Isabella."

I look up through my lashes at Charlotte, and she frowns, meeting my stare. "My mother *bought* you?" She steps forward, but Haidyn stops her with a hand on her shoulder.

"She was an investment," Bill states, and my breathing picks up. "Evan knew of Eve and wanted her at Dollhouse. When Haidyn didn't kill her, Garrett figured his best bet was to sell her."

Kashton reaches out to take my hand, but I pull it away and cross my arms over my chest.

"I never knew," Charlotte whispers, still looking at me, tears pooling in her blue eyes.

I want to tell her that it's okay, that I know it wasn't her fault, but it's pointless. My words won't change how she feels.

"What about the other woman? Where does she fit in?" Ryat asks.

"What other woman?" Bill counters.

"Let's just ask her. We put her in a cell." Sin walks off down the hallway, and we all wait silently for him to return.

He's got a woman by the back of her neck. She's naked, tripping over her own feet, and her hands are zip tied behind her back. Her head is down, and her dark hair covers her face.

She's softly crying. He brings her into the room, kicks the back of her legs, forcing her to her knees, and yanks her head back by her hair. Her cries echo throughout the basement.

"Christ." Adam rushes over to her. "Let go of her," he orders Sin.

He raises his hands and takes a step back, looking at Kashton, who runs a hand down his face, knowing who she is. "Fuck," my husband mutters.

"Someone give me a fucking knife," Adam barks.

Sin hands his over since he's still the closest. "Hey." Adam takes her tear-streaked face in his hands. "You're okay. It's okay."

I take off and ignore Kashton hollering at me. I rush up to the second floor, grab a bottle of water, and manage to find a blanket, then

run back into the basement. “Here.” I hand them to Adam.

“You know her?” Saint asks, looking over her.

“Yes. I fucking know her. She works for me.” He grabs Missy’s hands and pulls her to stand. She covers herself with her arms. “Thanks,” he growls at me, yanking the blanket from my hands to wrap it around her shoulders before pulling it closed.

I step back with my hand pressed into my chest. I shouldn’t have run up the stairs. Now there’s a burning sensation and I can’t catch my breath.

Kashton steps into me, but I sidestep him, not wanting to be touched right now. He can yell at me later.

“We just did what we were told to do,” Sin says, hands still raised.

“Which was?” Adam demands, walking Missy over to a chair and placing her in it. He unscrews the bottle of water and practically waterboards the poor girl, holding it to her trembling lips.

“You gave me and Ryat the address to the motel Kashton was staying at. She was there.”

Adam crouches down in front of her in the chair and places his hands on her dirty, tear-streaked face, holding her hair back in the process. “Why were you in the motel?”

She sniffs. “To get his phone.”

“Whose phone?” Adam demands.

“This one?” Ryat pulls one from his pocket. “She had it on her when we entered the room.”

Missy rubs the tears from her face, taking a deep breath. “I thought it was odd that Everett was at the bar that night. I wasn’t aware she had a job. When she left, I texted you that she was there. I watched her enter the motel room. A guy arrived not much later. I called you when she left the motel to make sure it was cleaned up, and you confirmed that she didn’t have a job, but that you would get the room cleaned. I didn’t hear from you until a few days later. You said the room had been cleaned, the body disposed of, but the guy didn’t have his phone on him…”

“I didn’t take it,” I tell her. I always leave the phones behind. You never know who might be tracking them. Adam has their bodies dis-

posed of and their cells destroyed after they get what they need off them.

"He didn't have a phone on him." Adam shakes his head at her. "We checked. How and where did you find it?"

"Kashton took over the room shortly after. I had to wait for him to leave to get back into it. I had just found it under the bed when two guys showed up," she whispers, staring at the floor, unable to make eye contact with anyone in the room.

I feel sorry for her. She doesn't know this life. Not like we do. Sure, she works for Adam, but she runs the bar. She's not that deep in the trafficking world. She serves people alcohol and listens to them bitch about their pathetic lives.

Adam stands, snatches the phone from Ryat's hand, and starts to go through it. His eyes meet mine, and I swallow.

"What is it?" Kashton demands.

Adam walks over and hands it to him.

Kashton reads over it and then runs a hand down his unshaven face. "This is why you went to the cathedral?" He looks at me with narrowed eyes.

"Yes." I lift my chin. I stand by what I did.

"It was a trap," he barks. "How did you not know that?"

"I knew what I was going to find," I snap defensively. "I'm not stupid."

He snorts and I step into him, but Adam grabs my upper arm, pulling me back.

"Don't touch my fucking wife," Kashton shouts, bowing up to him.

"Kash." I place my hands on his chest, pushing him back. "Take a breath. Okay?" My eyes search his and he turns, giving me his back, running his hand through his hair.

There's a lot to take in. So much is going on, but Adam isn't going to hurt me. Not here. There are too many Lords to protect me. And honestly, I'm not scared of Adam. In a one-on-one, I think I could take him. He has a dick, and I don't care what that means to a Lord; it's their weakness. One hit and he'll be on his knees.

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EIGHTY-FOUR



KASHTON

The phone shakes in my hand.

> VI: Don't kill her. Deliver her to the cathedral. Alive. We'll use her for bait. Kashton will come running to save her. I'll leave with him, and she'll be all yours.

"You read this text?" I turn to ask her, to make sure I'm understanding what the fuck she did.

"Yes." She nods. "The job felt…off. He made a move, and I killed him. I was going through his phone and saw that there was obviously more involved."

"So you just decided you'd go. Alone." My wife is crazy and in deep shit.

Sighing, she looks away from me. "I went to my house, grabbed a few things, and stopped by Barrington to call you. I knew I had to throw you off. I was already late returning to Carnage, and I needed time."

"To die," I bite out. "Makes sense."

"Kash." She sighs.

"How the fuck did you find Everett before we did?" I interrupt, demanding an answer from Adam. She and I can talk about her choices later when we're alone. "I called you and informed you she was missing and asked if she had been arrested. We hung up and then you called me back and said no."

Adam runs a hand through his already disheveled hair. "Saint had called Tyson, informing him that they were on their way to get Everett. They didn't know what was going on, but she had called you, and it didn't sound good."

I look at Tyson. “So you called Adam?” Why the fuck would he call him about my wife?

“No.” Tyson shakes his head. “But Sin was with me at the time—”

“You called Adam?” I snap.

“No,” Sin growls, “I called Bill. Told him to get to Barrington because Eve was there. We didn’t know the situation. Just that someone needed to get there and fast.”

“But she wasn’t. Her cell was.” Haidyn frowns.

I look back at Adam, and it is taking everything in me to not rip his head from his shoulders. “How the fuck did you know where my wife was?”

He looks at her and then drops his eyes to the floor. I wish I had a gun on me because I want to shoot him again right now. Haidyn’s suggestion about his knee sounds pretty good. I’ve had all I can take with him and my wife. “Adam?” I snap.

“I have a tracker on her,” he barks.

My entire body tenses. I look at my wife, and her eyes—wide in disbelief—are on Adam. “You…you what?”

“You have a tracker on his wife,” Sin repeats through gritted teeth.

“I—”

“What the fuck, Adam?” she shouts and runs toward him.

I grab her waist arm and yank her back. He won’t hit her, but the last thing I need her to do is hurt herself. She just had fucking surgery and is still recovering. My wife should be in bed right now. Not dealing with this shit.

“You were pretending to pimp yourself out,” he yells at her. “You were working for me and killing grown-ass men in a run-down motel.” His eyes meet mine before returning to hers. “I couldn’t take that chance. I couldn’t allow anything to happen to you.”

“You should have told me,” I grind out. “I would have—”

“Removed it,” he interrupts me.

“Absolutely,” I snap. “Having a tracker on my wife is fucked up, but you knew she was in danger. That she had done a job that wasn’t an actual job. I called you…I told you I was looking for her, and all the while, you knew where she was. That is unacceptable.” My heart is

racing; my skin is heated. I'm so hot right now I'm sweating. "Where the fuck is it?" I demand.

He sighs and the little pause makes me snap. I rush him, wrapping my arms around his waist and picking his feet up off the floor. The momentum has me ramming his back into the cabinets lined across the back wall, bringing us both to an abrupt stop with a grunt. "I asked you a fucking question," I grind out, pulling him from the wall and punching him in the face before he even has a chance to answer.

Adam fights back. Good. I don't want an easy win. I want to fucking smash his face in. I kick out my legs, taking him to the floor, and punch him again. He gets in a couple of hits, but then he goes into defensive mode and uses his arms and hands to shield his face after I get in another good hit.

I'm yanked off him and shoved to the side, and Hooke grabs a hold of me. Tyson comes to stand between us, arms out. I take a second to catch my breath and Hooke steps back knowing I'm not going to jump Adam again.

"Where the fuck is the tracker?" Tyson yells at Adam who still lies on the floor with blood covering his busted face.

"Left…hip." He rolls to his side and spits blood onto the concrete floor. "Her left hip."

I turn and grab my wife's hand, pulling her through the basement and to the elevator. She yanks her hand from mine and crosses her arms over her chest. "I didn't know," she whispers.

I can't talk right now. Not because I'm mad at her but because of how stupid I was. Everything makes sense now. How he knew it wasn't Eve that I had spoken to that night at Blackout. He tried to tell me that he had spoken to her and knew she was at the motel. But that wasn't it at all. It's because he tracked her. How he knew where she lived when she passed out in my arms at her house. Maybe he had been there before, but now I'm not so sure.

I'm so fucking stupid.

"Kash—"

I can't… "Not right now, Eve."

"Are you mad at me?" she snaps, grabbing my arm. "It's not my—"

"Fault?" I growl, interrupting her and pinning her to the side wall. "Maybe if you hadn't lied to me."

"Lied to you about what?" she demands, glaring up at me.

"What you were doing. Working for Adam." Did she ever really lie, though? She just continued to live her life; I was the one who took it over.

"I—"

"I told you not right now." It's not going to be a productive conversation, so it's pointless.

She huffs and the elevator door opens. I take her hand, and she lets me pull her toward the hospital wing. "Devin?" I call out. "Devin?" I bark.

"Yes?" He runs out of a door and comes to a quick stop. He looks Eve up and down. "What's wrong?"

"She has a tracker. I need it removed. Now."

He frowns. "Where is it?"

"Left hip," I answer.

Nodding, he says. "Of course. Room one."

I pull her into it and grab her shirt, but she pulls back. "Did you fuck her?"

"Who?" I snap.

"Me…my sister?"

My brother has had a tracker on her for years, and she's concerned about me screwing someone else? "Are you serious?" I snort.

"Don't do that." She shakes her head. "Make me sound crazy."

"The fact that you think I'd cheat on you is crazy," I shout.

"You thought she was me," she screams, slamming her hands into my chest. "You buried her thinking it was me. You almost committed suicide because you thought I died." Angry tears fill her pretty green eyes. "So…did you fuck her thinking it was me?"

I shake my head. "No."

"Adam did." She crosses her arms over her chest.

"I'm not fucking Adam," I growl, but I couldn't be happier that he has never fucked my girl.

The door opens behind me, and Devin enters, cutting off our argument.

I stand in our office behind Saint's desk with my hands shoved into the pockets of my jeans, staring out the wall of windows.

The sound of the door opening has me stiffening. I'm really not in the mood right now to deal with anyone. After Devin removed Eve's tracker, I had to be alone. This is where I found myself.

"Adam left," comes a woman's voice that makes my skin crawl. It furthers my point that I'm in a sour mood.

Looking down over the circle drive, I see Adam walking down the steps with the brunette from the motel. Missy was her name? I snort. I'm sure it's fake, along with everything else that has to do with him.

"When will he be back?" she goes on.

"If we're lucky, never."

"Kash," she sighs, "he's your brother."

"That means nothing to me," I say honestly. He's gone too far this time. I can't forgive him. If that makes me a horrible person, then so be it.

"It should," she argues.

I turn around and look at Ashtyn. She's been crying. I can see the streaks down her face, and it annoys me even more. "Tell that to Eve."

"Hmm?" She frowns. "Tell her what?"

"Go and tell her that she should forgive Garrett because he's her father."

Her frown deepens. She wanted to talk to me. I'll talk.

"He raped her."

Her face pales, and she drops her eyes to the floor.

"Your father raped her. Mine raped her. Saint's raped her. For years, her father let all of them rape her. A child. So, again…go tell my wife that she should forgive her father because he's her dad and see what her response is."

Wrapping her arms around herself, she remains silent.

"That's why she tried to commit suicide…the one that ended up costing her the baby. In case you were wondering." She looks up at

me through her lashes. "Because there was a possibility that she was pregnant by her father. The same man who told her if it was a girl, he would allow them all to rape her too. If it was a boy, he'd force him to rape his own mother."

She sniffs, and I want to roll my eyes but refrain. I don't think she feels bad for Everett. Or hell, maybe I'm just a piece of shit and she does, but I don't care. I know what she said to my wife. About killing her child and no longer being able to have kids. Funny enough, it was Saint who told me. He was worried about Eve's mental state after what his wife said to mine.

I'm usually not this heartless, but I've reached my limit.

Fuck anyone who tries to hurt my wife. Physically or mentally. That woman has been through enough, and I will let the world know that if they attack her in any way, I will make sure they never do it again. You want to make my wife feel bad; I'll make you hate yourself.

"I don't know if it's a trauma response," I go on at her silence, "or the fact that you're jealous your life isn't the same as it once was…or maybe you're just being a bitch." Her eyes narrow on mine, and I know I've hit a nerve. Good. Tells me my guess is spot-on. "But you need to shut the fuck up and keep whatever opinions or thoughts you have to yourself because no one wants to hear them."

She takes a deep breath. I think she's going to yell at me. Maybe cry and try the sympathy card, but instead, she turns and exits the office, slamming the door shut on her way out.

Walking over to my desk, I remove the tracker from my pocket that Devin took out of my wife's hip and drop it into the top drawer.

Then I make my way up to the birdcage. The elevator door opens, and I step out just in time to see Jessie exiting my bedroom with an empty wheelchair. "What's wrong?" I rush over to him. "Eve okay?" I left her with Devin after he removed her tracker.

"Yes. Yes." He nods. "After Devin applied a new tracker, he gave her some pain meds. Said she did a little too much today. He didn't want her walking back to the room." He smiles at me. "Mrs. Pierce is in bed." Then he heads toward the elevator.

I push open the door to the dimly lit room. She's got the TV on but the volume low. My wife is in bed, covers up to her chin, facing away

from me. I unlace my boots, kick them off, and quickly get undressed, leaving only my boxer briefs on, and then gently crawl into bed with her.

She sighs, rolling over to face me, and I push back the hair from her face. Mrs. Pierce. I love the sound of that and will never get used to it.

Her lashes flutter open but quickly fall closed.

"How do you feel?"

"Tired," she whispers.

Leaning in, I kiss her soft cheek. "Get some sleep, angel."

"Kash?"

"Hmm?"

She opens her heavy eyelids and looks up at me. "I'm sor—"

"Don't," I interrupt her.

It's not her fault. She had no clue what Adam was doing. I know my girl would have cut it out herself had she known it was there. I had it replaced with one of my own. After everything, I want to make sure I have eyes on my wife every second of the day.

Is it about control? A part of it, yes. But it's mainly for safety. I haven't seen a single Lady who hasn't gone through something because of who they married. We've all got enemies, and I've got to protect what's mine.

Looking over her face, I watch her sleep peacefully. She hasn't woken up from any nightmares since she found her way back to me. I'm not saying she won't ever have them again, but I'll be here to remind her that I love her if she does.

EVERETT

We all stand outside in the cemetery by the gates of Carnage. The guys brought equipment in to dig before they started digging with shovels. Then another piece of equipment was used to remove the vault lid. Charlotte and I watch. Ashtyn hasn't shown her face since Saint made her leave the basement. I'm not sure if that's because she's crying after Adam left or because she doesn't want to be around us.

I look over the headstone. It's as gorgeous as it is sad. It's black with angel wings and reads *Everett Sinclair Pierce*, along with my

birthdate and the day my husband thought I died. Across the bottom is engraved *My life I vow to you*.

A car pulls up, and I look over my shoulder to see both the driver's side and passenger doors open, and two men step out. The ones I gave my statement to.

"Okay, Kashton. You've got ten minutes before I call this place in," the detective states, coming to a stop and placing his hands on his hips. The younger one looks me up and down.

"Glad you could make it," Kashton greets them.

"Yeah, well…you really didn't give me a choice."

"I'm going to solve your case." Kashton smiles, and the younger cop snorts as if that's impossible.

"It's getting solved today, all right." The detective's eyes are on mine when he says it, letting me know he's not leaving here without me in cuffs. I hope Kashton stabs him again. The only man who is allowed to handcuff me is my husband.

"Okay. We're ready," Haidyn announces.

I've never been to a funeral or watched someone be buried, but there's a lot to it—when done properly. A cement vault sits below the casket that was sealed. It took them a minute to get into that. Then they had to break the seal of the casket.

Ryat and Sin jump down into it to help them out. Charlotte and I both step closer and look down into the grave that's supposed to be mine. It feels weird, being out here knowing that my husband buried this body thinking it was me.

The casket opens, and I can't see much because they're all down in the grave. The plan is to roll her onto her side, place a tarp under her, and then lift her out. I didn't interject, but I was very confused when they were discussing it.

Me or not, she's dead. Why dig her up? What do you do with a corpse?

We step back as they lift her and drop the tarp onto the ground next to the now open grave.

A cold chill runs up my spine when I look at her. It's me. Dead, but me. Bleached-blond hair and all.

I feel like I'm staring death in the face. This is what I'd look like if I had died in that cathedral. Years of thinking I was insane, and this was the reason—I had a twin sister. An identical twin. Someone else in this world looked just like me.

"Angel?"

I look up when a hand touches my arm, and I meet my husband's stare. He rubs my cheek with his tatted knuckles. I don't know what to say. I can't imagine what he felt, holding me. Having to tell me goodbye. She's dressed in one of my dresses and a pair of my red bottoms. I can't imagine the pain he went through having to pick out something to bury me in.

"Go inside, Eve," he orders softly, bending down and kissing my forehead. "I'll be there shortly." With that, he turns, and Sin hands him a shovel.

Kashton moves to stand over her chest, and he places the tip of the shovel right at her neck. With both hands gripping the handle and his left boot on the step, he slams it down. The steel slices right through her neck, ripping it clean off her shoulders.

Charlotte gags before slapping a hand over her mouth, and I turn to her. "Come on." I grab her other hand and pull her toward the house. I'm not sure what the fuck they're doing, but she's always nauseous. Seeing shit like that doesn't help.

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EIGHTY-FIVE



KASHTON

I bend down and pick up the head to the body I thought was my wife.

Fucking bitch.

"The fuck?" The young cop holds a hand over his mouth as his wide eyes stare at the headless woman.

"Turns out my wife has an identical twin," I inform them in case they haven't caught on yet. "And it was her DNA you found on the dead girls."

"What?" The detective glares at me. "How do you know that?" Before I answer, he continues. "This proves nothing. They could have been working together."

"It wasn't my wife. So stay the fuck away from her, or I'll bury you in this fucking grave," I bark, standing to my full height and stepping forward to pick him up and toss him into it to give him a visual. But Tyson grabs my arm pulling me back.

I knew it wouldn't be this easy and they would think Eve still played a part. That's why I had to call in backup. I hated having to do it, but this isn't about me. It's to protect my wife.

The detective huffs and runs a hand down his face.

"Dispose of the body," I order, ignoring him and the cop. They'll find out soon enough. Now that I know she's not Eve, I want nothing left of it.

"And this?" Ryat picks up the head with a handful of the bitch's hair.

"Sin." I hold out my hand.

He removes a clear plastic bag from his back pocket, shaking it out and holding it open for me.

I take the head from Ryat and place it in the bag upright, making sure all the bleached strands are shoved inside of it. It's crazy how identical she is to my wife. She was either watching Eve's every move, or she was getting all her information from Evan. Either way, she mirrored my wife as closely as she could. The features are there, since they are identical. I never took the time to look for scars on her body that I know Eve has, but she even had the butterfly tattoo on her hip like Everett. All I knew was that it was my wife I found lying dead on the cathedral floor. I was too busy grieving to question whether it was possible that it couldn't be her.

Sin spins the bag around before tying it off at the top.

The young cop is puking up his guts, and I roll my eyes. The bitch is dead. Not like she feels anything. And she doesn't stink because she was embalmed. A little musty, but nothing too bad. I wish I could have saved her, and I would have dragged out her torture for what she did to my wife and what she was going to let Evan do to her.

"I know someone who might want this back," I speak, and Ryat chuckles.

"I'd love to deliver it for you," he offers.

"House call?" Sin arches a brow at Ryat and hands him the bagged head. "Oh, take me with you. I want to help."

Ryat laughs, nodding. "You can tag along."

A car pulls into the gates of Carnage, and everyone turns to see who it is. It's my backup. The last person I want to see but sometimes you have to do things you don't want to.

"What the fuck is he doing here?" Haidyn demands.

"I invited him," I answer when Adam exits his car.

"Why the fuck would you do that?" Haidyn barks loud enough that Adam can hear.

"We need him," I grind out, and a sour taste instantly fills my mouth. "He'll only be here a few minutes." Then he's out of my life for good.

Adam joins us by the graves, placing his hands in the front pockets of his jeans.

"Well, boys, this is your proof." I direct my attention to the cop and detective.

"Proof of what?" the young cop asks, running the back of his hand across his chin to clean up the puke on his face.

"I was the one who killed Vivian." Adam nods to the headless body lying on the tarp. "I've got her phone." He holds it out to the detective. "It was on her at the cathedral. It has everything you need to prove Eve had nothing to do with the case."

The man stares at it before he glances at me. "Phones can be tampered with."

My teeth grind. *This motherfucker…*

"I—"

Holding up my hand, I silently cut off Adam. I step up to the detective, my chest bumping his. "Take the fucking phone, get in your car, and leave. Make whatever statement you need to make. Do whatever you need to fucking do to close this case without mentioning my wife's name. She wasn't involved and if you try to say she was, I'll chop your fucking head off like the bitch behind me. The only difference is I'll do it while you're alive." I'm done playing with these bastards and I'm no longer going to hide my wife. She's going to live her life however she fucking wants. Eve did what she thought was right by calling the cops when she found the dead body in the cemetery and I won't let them punish her for that.

His jaw sharpens and the young cop leans in, speaking softly into his ear. After a second, the detective reaches out and snatches the phone from Adam's hand.

The cop nods to me. "Consider the case closed and Everett's name cleared."

"Get the fuck off the property," I order, and they both turn and get into their car before exiting the gates.

"You think they'll return?" Sin asks.

"No," I answer. If they do, I'll show them I'm a man of my word.

Silence falls over the cemetery, and I give Adam my back. It's his fault Eve's in this position. He could have told the police about Vivian the moment he was suspicious she had a twin. It could have saved us a lot of time. And I'm sure as fuck not going to thank him for

showing up today when I needed him. It's the least he could fucking do.

"Get rid of this fucking body," I bark out, seeing the dead woman wearing my wife's dress.

My cell vibrates in my pocket. I huff at the familiar number and answer. "You better have a good reason for calling me."

Haidyn and I make our way up to the birdcage. I open my bedroom door but don't see Eve inside. "She must be with Charlotte," I tell Haidyn.

He opens his and enters. I walk in behind him to find my wife sitting on their bed petting a purring Muffin. You can see the hair flying with each stroke.

"Where's Charlotte?" Haidyn asks.

"In the bathroom," my wife answers.

He goes over and knocks on the door when he realizes it's locked. "Everything okay?"

Charlotte opens it, giving him a smile. "Just had to use the restroom," she assures him and pats his chest.

"Charlotte was showing me the backpack you got them for Muffin. That was so sweet." Eve smiles at me.

"Oh yeah?" I look at Haidyn, and he narrows his eyes on me. "I thought so." I never had my chance to get information from Charlotte about my girl, but it turns out I wouldn't have gotten anything anyway. She never saw my wife. She had seen her identical twin there with LeAnne, and it was only that one time. LeAnne had to keep her from Charlotte because she didn't want anyone to know that Eve or her twin existed. They were playing the long game and going to use her when needed.

"We take her for a walk at least once a day." Charlotte beams. "Muffin loves it." The cat meows in my wife's hands as if agreeing.

"I hope you're taking pictures," I remind her, and Charlotte nods.

"I'd love to have a pet," Eve says.

"Oh, really?" Haidyn arches a brow at me. "You should get a cat." My smile drops. "They're great." He walks over and picks Muffin up

from Eve's arms. "She sleeps on my pillow every night."

"Uh." I scratch the side of my face, all of a sudden itchy and breaking out in hives just thinking about a hairy pussy sticking it's littered-covered paws on my face while I sleep. "I don't think—"

"I think I would like a dog more," Eve says, and I give Haidyn a big fuck-you smile. The fucker would totally get my wife a cat and call it payback for their daily walks in the woods.

"Whatever you want, angel," I tell her.

"Maybe get one of each." She gets to her feet, and Haidyn winks at me. Bastard.

"Did you get everything you wanted?" Eve asks, looking at me.

For a second I had forgotten about the phone call I got after I chopped her twin sister's head off. I nod. The police are gone. They won't be bothering my wife anymore.

"What are you doing with the body?"

"The guys are disposing of it," I tell her. It's on the way to the morgue to be cremated.

"The head?" she asks.

"Returning it." Haidyn is the one who answers, and she frowns, not understanding.

"Ryat and Sin are going to drop it off on LeAnne's doorstep." Going to leave a little reminder that you can't fuck with us. She knew Everett was an identical twin and decided to send her after Eve when we saved Haidyn and dragged Isabella to Carnage. That can't… No. I won't let that go unnoticed.

"Well, that's—"

"Necessary," I interrupt my wife, and she sighs. This is something I won't budge on.

My phone rings and I pull it out of my pocket. "Hello?"

"They're here," Saint informs me.

I hang up, and my wife frowns, sensing my mood. "What's wrong?"

"Tyson's men just arrived."

"Okay," she says slowly and then looks from me to Haidyn. "Is that a bad thing?"

"They found Evan."

Eve gets to her feet. "Where is he?"

"He's here. They're going to put him in the basement." They called me while I was in the cemetery to let me know they were on their way with Evan.

Her green eyes drop to the floor, and I walk over to her. "You don't need to see him." I brush hair off her face, and she lifts her chin to meet my stare. "It's up to you, angel. You can have your revenge if you want, or I can do it for you."

"No." She frowns and steps back. "I can do it."

"Okay. It doesn't have to be right now." She still needs time to heal.

Picking up her cell off the bed, she types away on it, and I glance at Haidyn. He arches a brow, and I shrug, not sure what she's doing. "Ordered," she states, locking her screen. Her eyes meet mine. "Two days."

"Two days what?" I ask, confused.

"That's when my packages will be here."

"What packages?" Haidyn wonders.

She gives me a chilling smile before looking at her brother. "That's…a surprise."

With that, she walks past me and out of their room. I smile, following after her, knowing my girl is going to fuck Evan up, and I can't wait to see how she does it.

Entering my room, I close the door and watch her sit on the end of the bed. Her head is down, and she stares at the floor.

Sitting next to her, I take Eve's hand in mine. "If you're not ready—"

"I need to tell you something." She looks up at me, and her green eyes are swimming with unshed tears. "You're…" They drop to the floor before they return to mine and she whispers. "You're going to hate me."

I laugh to try and lighten the mood. "That's impossible, angel."

Licking her lips, she pulls her hand from mine. "You know how I told you I had an imaginary friend?"

"Yeah."

"It had to of been my sister, right?" She frowns. "She looked like me but not like me." Getting to her feet, she starts to pace. "She

was what I wanted to look like. She wasn't malnourished or covered in bruises. She was beautiful—"

"You are beautiful, Eve." I stand, grabbing her hand, bringing her to a stop.

She pulls it from mine once more and crosses them over her chest. "You don't understand."

"I'm trying to," I admit, confused about where she's going.

"I told her everything, Kash. I thought…I thought I made her up. My father and LeAnne made me think I was seeing things. The girl came and went, and no one even looked her way, let alone spoke to her."

I sigh. It was their plan all along. They set Eve up. Who was she going to tell? No one. Garrett never let her leave Carnage.

"I'm the reason Isabella tortured you the way she did during your training." Her eyes fill with fresh tears.

I frown. "What? No, Eve…"

"Yes." She sniffs. "I was down in the basement that night your father found you. I was…" She swallows. "I was in my cell when your mother killed herself." The first tear rolls down her cheek. "The following week, my imaginary friend showed up, and I told her I was in trouble for playing in the basement."

"Angel—"

"I told her everything, and she just sat there and listened. Don't you see?" She cries. "Vivian must have told LeAnne, who then told Isabella. That's why she threw you into the cell your mother was in. I did that…" She points to herself.

"Stop, Eve." I reach out and grab her, pulling her flush with my body. "That was not your fault."

"I'm so sorry." She buries her face in my shirt.

Grabbing her face, I push her away so I can look her in the eyes. "You are not responsible for their actions, Eve." She was a child when my mother died. I hate that she had to see that. But I will not let her blame herself. My wife wants to take responsibility for everything when she had no control. None of this is her fault.

"But—"

"But nothing. Do you hear me? It was not your fault. Say it," I command. "Tell me it's not your fault, Eve."

She sniffs. "It wasn't…my fault."

I pull her back into me, and she wraps her arms around my waist, clinging to me.

EVERETT

I stand in Kashton's bathroom painting my lips with Rouge Louboutin. Stepping back, I look over myself. I'm treating tonight as if I'm going to my rage room. Fuck, I miss destroying shit.

It had become my therapy. Then I replaced it with sex, but Kashton still hasn't fucked me. I get it. Devin hasn't cleared me, and he's afraid of hurting me. After seeing my identical twin dead in a casket, I realized exactly how hard it must have been for him.

But tonight, I get to be me. The girl who had no voice, no choice, no will to live. I take that back tonight.

Evan is the last person to stand in our way. No more shadows, no more nightmares, no more looking over our shoulders.

We get to move on with our life. Enjoy our marriage. Fight like cats and dogs about stupid shit and fuck like we hate one another, knowing damn well we love each other.

I have my hair off my face, pulled up into a high ponytail. I didn't want it to get in the way. I've got a black corset on that Charlotte had to cinch up for me since I couldn't do it myself. It's a halter, so I don't have to worry about my boobs falling out. My pants are high-waisted black leather that lace up the sides. And I topped it off with my platform boots.

I'm going to be getting bloody, so I went with all black. I walk through the bedroom and out the door. Getting in the elevator, I close my eyes and take a deep breath.

"That's a good dolly."

It doesn't matter what I do to Evan. I'll always hear his voice and see his face. But this will help. I've told myself for years that I had healed—moved on. I was only lying to myself. The fact that I self-medicated with alcohol was the first sign.

The elevator dings, and I open my eyes to step out into the basement. For once the coldness doesn't bother me.

Voices come to a stop when I push through the plastic curtains. Kashton turns to look at me and smiles. “Hello, angel.” He walks over to me and cups my face. I can see the hesitation in his eyes that he’s trying to hide. He’s nervous for me. “You ready?”

“Yes.” Every victim at Dollhouse deserves to do this. Make them pay for what they did to all the innocents.

“I brought your boxes down. They’re on the counter.” He nods over to the wall.

“Thank you,” I say, and he gives me a soft kiss on the forehead.

“Bring him in,” he calls out.

I walk over to the counter, and Sin leans up against it. He smiles at me while holding out his pocketknife. I thank him and slice open the boxes.

“Where do you want him, Eve?” Ryat asks.

“I’ll start with him on his knees. Hands cuffed behind his back,” I respond with a smile.

The sound of Evan struggling fills the room, and I don’t have to turn around to know he’s gagged. I’ll be removing that. The bastard will scream for me.

Grabbing what I want, I place it all out on a tray.

“You know…” Sin looks at what I’ve laid out. “I’m kind of an expert at piercing.” His eyes meet mine and he shrugs. “Just in case you want some help.”

I give a soft laugh and turn to face the room. Everyone is here. I wanted an audience. Evan allowed hundreds, possibly thousands to watch me get tortured on a live feed. They fucking paid to watch me beg for death.

So the more the merrier is my motto tonight. Slipping the black gloves over my hands, I grab what I want off the tray and stand in front of Evan. His narrow eyes glare up at me from his knees and I smile. My heart is racing but it’s with excitement.

Evan starts to struggle, and I look up at Sin. I could use a little help for this part. “Can you hold his head?”

“Of course.” He practically skips to stand behind Evan and wraps his arm around Evan’s neck from behind, forcing his head back. “Good enough?” he asks.

"Good enough," I agree.

Then I place the clamp on his nose, and he flinches. I shove the needle through his septum, having to force it. I feel a pop, and Evan closes his eyes tightly. "That was harder than it looks," I say. "But then again, I'm no expert. What do you think?"

Sin looks down at Evan's bleeding nose and smiles. "Looks good to me."

I remove the clamp and thread the piercing through the hole I just made. Stepping back, I turn to look at my husband. He's leaning up against the opposite wall, arms crossed over his chest. His pretty blue eyes appear sad, but there's a hint of a smile on his lips. He knows what I'm doing.

"Will you string him up for me?" I ask.

He pushes off the wall, stepping into me, and kisses my lips tenderly. "Of course, angel."

I grab a few more things and toss over my shoulder, "Remove his gag, too, please."

Seconds later, Evan spits out, "Fucking bitch."

I laugh and place what I want on the tray, throwing the used items into the sink. I'll pick that up later.

I return to Evan and begin to place his flaccid dick into its new home.

"What the fuck?" he shouts, trying to look and see what I'm doing, but Kashton connected the chain hanging from the ceiling to his new piercing. Just like Evan once did to me. "Eve," he growls.

I throw my head back and laugh. Does he think he can scare me? Make me stop? "The jailhouse chastity device," I announce, sliding the cold metal ring and over his cock and balls to lay behind his scrotum. It's a tight fit, so I have to shove them through it. Evan grunts and his hips thrust, trying to fight me, but he can't move far unless he wants to rip his septum.

Then I slide his dick into the unforgiving metal before lifting the chastity device to connect it to the ring. I use the padlock to secure the two sections together at the top.

"I hope that's not too uncomfortable. I went with the smallest size." Not that I want Evan to think he has a big dick, but it came with

three different sizes. I want it to be fucking painful.

"I think it fits well." Sin nods, encouraging me.

I smile at him and then unscrew the lid to the eye drop bottle. Taking a quick look at my husband, he frowns when he sees what I have in my hands but doesn't say anything. I was hoping it was down here, and as luck would have it, it was in the cabinet.

I hold the dropper upside down and squeeze the liquid onto Evan's chest and stomach until there's nothing left.

Then I take my glove-covered hands and rub it all over.

Stepping back, I remove the gloves. "Now we let that soak in. It should only take a few minutes."

Evan's body trembles even though he tries to look unaffected. I know the truth. The blood dripping from his nose and the way he pulls on the cuffs that secure his hands behind his back—he's in pain.

"Look at that," I say, staring at his dick. "It's starting to grow. Like a garden."

Fuck, revenge feels good. My body heats up more than it already was, and I can't help the smile on my face. I feel giddy.

"It reminds me of a can of biscuits." Sin observes Evan's dick with a frown.

He's not far off. "And what do you do with those?" I quiz him.

Sin looks at me and then at Ryat who shrugs.

"Anybody?" I ask, glancing around the room.

"Fuck you," Evan spits out.

"Nobody?" I ignore him, and the guys shake their heads. I walk over to the counter and pick up the knife. "You pop them."

Alex's face goes white. Ryat pushes off the wall, and Haidyn runs a hand down his face, all of them realizing what I'm about to do. My husband just stares at me.

Fuck, he turns me on, and he's just standing there. His eyes drop to my chest before they meet mine, and I lick my lips. Is it bad for me to want Kash to fuck me in front of Evan? For my husband to play with me. Show Evan what a good *dolly* I am for Kash? That I willingly want to be my husband's toy?

"Seriously?" Colton speaks softly, getting my attention. I glance at him talking to Alex, who looks like he's about to puke. "Keep it together, man."

I step back in front of Evan, and he glares down his nose at me. "You will pay for this, you fucking bitch."

I tilt my head to the side. "Pay? That's why we're here, Evan. I've already paid my dues. For a year, you tortured me. Punished me. Raped me. Now it's your turn. This is the first day of the rest of your life." I take the Olfa slimline knife and slice along the top metal rings, cutting through the protruding skin of his swollen dick.

His scream fills the basement, and I do the next. And the next. Then the next. Until I've made six horizontal cuts across his shaft that pushes through the rings.

Sin was right. It did look like a can of biscuits, but now it looks like an accordion that you want to squeeze together.

Blood drips from my hand and knife.

Evan pulls so hard, he rips his septum piercing out and falls to the floor. He scoots across the floor like a worm with nowhere to go while his screams continue.

My breathing is heavy and my skin tingles. "Fucking bastard." I slam the heel of my boot onto his caged dick, and he bucks wildly. "Use your dick now, Evan. Hmm? Be a good *dolly* and beg me to come."

I remove my boot and take a step back, needing to calm down. I'm wound up. I'm supposed to be levelheaded. Calculated. That's how Evan was with me.

"I'm impressed with your creativity," Sin compliments over Evan's wailing.

I smile and say, "Thanks, but I can't take all the credit." My attention drops to Evan to see the bastard sobbing.

Tossing the knife into the kitchen sink, I put on a new pair of gloves and grab the last two things I need. Returning to Evan, I squat down next to him and pop open the lid and pour the salt over his sliced dog.

Evan bucks and screams, so I sit on his thighs to try and keep him down, but he's wild. Sin helps me by holding his back down with a

knee to his chest. “I know that stings like a bitch.” I smile. “Now I have to apply pressure to help stop the bleeding.”

I rip the end of the tape from the roll and start at the base before wrapping the VHB tape all the way down and around his bleeding and salt-covered dick.

I wrap it five times to make sure it won’t slide off from the blood. Reviews said this was the stickiest tape on the market. We’ll see if they were telling the truth.

Tossing the roll to the side, I stand and turn to leave. “Leave him like that.”

A hand touches my shoulder, and I jump, spinning around. “You’re okay,” Kashton assures me. His eyes search mine and I glance at the floor.

I’ve got to get out of here. I’m so hot I’m suffocating. I take off toward the stairs.

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EIGHTY-SIX



KASHTON

"Eve?" I holler, but she's already gone. "Leave him the way he is and put him in a cell," I order and follow after her.

I shove open the door to the stairwell just when the closing door echoes from her exiting on the birdcage floor. I run up the stairs, barge into our bedroom, and find her in the bathroom. She's standing at the sink, vigorously washing off her arms and hands.

Leaning up against the doorway, I cross my arms over my chest and wait for her to face me.

Turning off the water, she bows her head and takes a deep breath. Then she straightens and speaks when her eyes meet mine in the mirror. "I got some of the drug on my skin."

"I know." I saw her demeanor change. Her anger grew, and her breathing accelerated. While everyone in the room was watching Evan, my eyes were on my wife.

She pushes off the counter and turns to face me. "I'll go see Devin."

I step into the bathroom, blocking her exit. "How do you feel?"

Her eyes drop to my jeans, and she licks her lips. "Horny." She lifts them to meet mine. "But we both know I've never needed drugs to beg you to fuck me."

I haven't touched her, afraid I'll hurt her. The night in the motel will haunt me until I die. When I step into her, her breath hitches, and I gently run my knuckles over her face and down her delicate neck. "Your pulse is racing, angel."

"Yeah," she breathes.

"You're burning up." Her skin is hot and flushed. I run the tips of my fingers over the top of her breasts that the corset shows off.

She leans into me, and I wrap my hand around her throat. Her eyes practically roll in the back of her head when she lets out a moan.

I want to tell her how proud of her I am. How good she did and how much I love her, but she won't hear me right now. So instead, I say, "I'm going to fuck you, angel."

"Please?" she begs, her hands gripping my shirt. "I need you to want me."

I brush my lips against hers, but my hand on her neck keeps her in place when she leans forward, wanting me to kiss her. "I always want you, Eve. Never doubt that."

Her black-painted lashes flutter open, and her plump red lips part. "Play with me."

Letting go of her neck, I step back. "Get undressed." Turning, I exit the bathroom and enter the bedroom, I grab what I want out of the nightstand and start setting things up.

She walks over a couple seconds later. "I can't get my top off."

"Turn around," I command. Brushing her ponytail to the front, I untie the black lace that runs up the back of the corset. Taking my time, I brush my knuckles against her heated skin, and she shivers.

I pull it loose, and it drops to her bare feet before she steps out. "Lie on the bed. Face up. Head at the end."

She crawls onto the mattress, lies down, and looks up at me.

"Arms out."

She fans them to her sides, and I reach underneath her, pulling her to the end so her head hangs off the foot.

She moans, licking her lips, knowing what I have in mind. I take my time, tying her wrists to each corner, dragging out the anticipation.

Then I slide my hand down her stomach to cup her pussy. She raises her hips and spreads her legs for me. I pull away and she groans. I smile, grabbing the toy and the lube. "Always so impatient."

I kneel between her shaking legs and lean over her body while my fingers play with her soaked cunt.

"Kash, please…" She trails off when I work the dildo into her.

She's panting when I move my fingers to her ass. I work them in and out while her heavy breathing fills the room.

"You're so beautiful," I tell her, and she arches her back when I begin to push the butt plug into her ass.

"Kashton," she cries, pulling on the rope that binds her wrists.

"Relax, Eve," I tell her, and she softens her body, letting out a long breath. There's still resistance, but I'm able to slide it into her. "Spread your legs," I command, getting off the bed, and she does as she's told.

I tie each ankle to the headboard and then move to stand at the end of the bed where her head is hanging off the end.

I unzip my jeans and pull my dick out. "Look how hard I am for you, Eve."

"Please…" She groans, her body trembling.

"How do you feel?" I ask again, cupping the back of her head.

"Fine." She swallows. "I'm fine, Kash. I just need you."

I run the thumb of my free hand over her painted-red lips, and she wraps them around it, sucking it into her mouth. I groan, my hips thrusting forward, imagining her mouth around my dick.

Pulling it free, I grab the base of my cock, and she opens wide, sticking out her tongue. "Good girl," I praise her, and she lifts her head, trying to suck my cock.

I readjust her head and slide my cock into her mouth, letting her suck me in. "So desperate," I say breathlessly when she swallows. "Goddammit, Eve…" I push my hips forward, sliding farther down her throat.

Her hips rise and I pull out, hearing her gasp before I push forward once more. Further this time, and her body jerks from lack of breathing.

Pulling out once more, spit covers her reddened cheeks. I give her a second and grab my cock, placing my balls over her face, and she licks them before sucking them into her mouth as well. "Fuck." I stroke my wet cock while she attends to my balls. "That's it, Eve. Fuck, that feels good."

She pulls away, and I slide my cock back into her mouth, needing more. I lean over her body, my fingers playing with her clit while I fuck her face.

"Open wide," I tell her, feeling the back of her throat. Her body jerks with each thrust. I grab a hold of the dildo and pull it free from her cunt and start to fuck her with it. "How's that feel, angel?" I ask. "Getting your throat and your pussy fucked?"

She's trembling, body arched, and I pull the toy out and see it's covered in cum. I smile. "That's my girl." I pull out of her mouth and grab the base of my dick, "Keep it open," I growl before I come all over her face.

She coughs and blinks rapidly to clear the cum from her mouth and eyes.

I quickly get undressed, crawl onto the bed, and undo both of her ankles before I kneel between them. She whimpers when I remove the dildo from her pussy and replace it with my still hard cock.

"You wanted this, Eve," I remind her. "I'm going to take my time fucking you tonight. Every hole is mine."

"Yours," she agrees through a gasp.

Leaning over her, I take the dildo covered in her cum and run it across her cheek and over her jaw, making sure to smear my cum over her face as well. "What did I say?" I growl, tapping the side of her slick face.

She moans, opening her pouty lips for me, and I slide the dildo into her mouth, and her arms yank on the restraints.

"Take it, Eve." I push it farther into her mouth, and her body shudders when she gags. "You're doing so well, angel." Spit and cum flies from her parted lips, and I let go of the dildo.

"You're going to hold this cock in your mouth. Understand?"

All she can do is whimper.

It's not too far that she can't breathe. More hangs out than not, but I want all her holes filled at the same time.

I slide my hands behind her shaking knees, spread them wide, and lean forward. Lowering my lips to her, I kiss her delicate neck while my hips start to move.

All my angel can do is lie here and take it.

EVERETT

I walk over to Saint and Ashtyn's door and take a deep breath before knocking. I'm going to swallow my pride and make nice. Well, as nice as I can be.

Saint opens it up and smiles at me. "Good morning, Eve."

I take a step back. "I'm sorry. I thought you'd be in the office with the guys." Kashton left me in bed over an hour ago.

"I'm headed there now." He holds the door open with his boot and turns to kiss his wife goodbye before stepping out into the hallway.

Ashtyn takes the door. "Did you need something?"

"May we talk?"

She steps aside, holding her arm out, gesturing for me to enter. I step in, and she lets the door close behind me. I follow her out onto their balcony. It's a nice day outside.

We both sit at the table, and she stares off into the distance.

"I'm not going to apologize for the things I've said or the way I've acted," I inform her.

She laughs softly. "I didn't think that was why you were here."

"I don't expect us to be besties, but since I married your husband's *brother*, I feel like we should be able to be in the same room together at the same time."

All the Spade brothers are on edge and there's tension. I'm not going to be the reason they're not getting along. I won't make Kashton choose between me and them. I know without a doubt he'd choose me, and that's not fair. They've been there for each other their entire lives. I want him to have a family, not take it away.

Ashtyn looks over at me and crosses her arms across her chest. I didn't think this would be easy. We're both very stubborn.

I go on at her silence. "I'm not going to pretend to know what you went through." We've all gone through our own personal hell. "But I never knew what it felt like to be cared for by someone until Kashton came along. It feels really good." I smile. "To be loved. To feel special. So I can only imagine what it must feel like when you had four men that felt that way about you." I'm including Adam, because even if she doesn't think so, that man loves her.

Her gaze drops to her lap.

"It must have been hard to return to things not being the same. To see they've all moved on. That you're no longer the center of their world."

She licks her lips.

"I was so protective of Charlotte because I didn't want to think my brother could be like all the other Lords that I was around growing up. I always thought he had a big heart, but I was afraid if tempted, he'd take it too far." Ashtyn is a beautiful woman, and the Spade brothers were raised like all the others—to use women. Loving any woman is a weakness. Plus, I didn't know if Saint was still sharing her or not.

"I'd never…" She stops herself from saying she'd never cheat on her husband, because she's done that. They were already married when she was on the run in Vegas. I know a part of her thought Saint was dead, and this life was behind her, so she had convinced herself it was okay. "I'd never do that to Charlotte," Ashtyn says instead and adds, "And Haidyn would never do that to his wife."

I rub my hands on my jeans and stand. "I'm sorry for bothering you." Stepping into the bedroom, I'm walking toward her door when she stops me.

"You're right."

I turn to face her as she steps inside.

"It's hard to have the life I had and then give it up only to be brought back." Her watery eyes scan the bedroom. "And it be…different." She rubs her hands together. "But that's no excuse for my behavior." She swallows and it looks like she wants to say more, so I stand where I am and wait.

"I, uh…there was this couple in Vegas…they would come into Glass while I was working. I always thought she was beautiful and she was usually high on drugs." Ashtyn sighs. "She would offer me some, and of course, I never turned her down." She rolls her eyes at herself. "There were a couple of times I went home with them." Tears fill her eyes, and she sniffs. "It was you."

I shake my head. "I never…"

She gives a rough laugh when I trail off. "Saint told me that you had an identical twin and that she had been following you."

"You thought it was me in Vegas, but…"

"It was her," she whispers. "Vivian."

Of course. It all makes sense that my twin was there because she fucked Adam. That bitch had been pretending to be me for years. Well, I guess she was me. She picked and chose when she wanted to play my life. She wanted to replace me. All because of Isabella.

Ashtyn continues at my silence. "When I saw you walk into Bill and Janice's wedding reception, I panicked. I asked Saint who you were, and he didn't know, but I thought I knew. So I was mean to you. I thought you were here to sabotage me and Saint. Using Kashton to do it."

"I love him," I tell her, and she nods, the first tear running down her cheek.

"He told me he's known you for six years."

I nod, wondering when they had that conversation. "I was in Las Vegas," I tell her, and she glances up at me with her tear-filled eyes. "I was there helping Adam spy on you."

She swallows.

I sigh. "Your brother was worried about you. After everything that happened and your mother being killed." Ashtyn sniffs. "I followed you to New York because Adam wanted to make sure Saint hadn't killed you."

Ashtyn chuckles, though I don't know why she finds that funny. Maybe he was close a few times. Who knows. I couldn't and didn't want to get inside of Carnage to watch her twenty-four seven after he brought her back.

"I've been trying to push you away, hoping you'd leave because I was afraid you'd tell Saint what I did while in Vegas. I'm ashamed of who I was. Of what I did to Saint while I was there on the run."

She had seen my twin and thought that I came here to tattle on her? I mean, I do know what she did, but I'm not that type of person. "That's not my story to tell."

It's not like I know every little thing. I know enough, but even I know that wouldn't change Saint's mind. She's his Lady. Me being a tattletale wouldn't do anyone any good.

She nods, licking her lips.

"And if he wanted to know, he'd ask you."

Her eyes meet mine, and her face drains of color. It's as if she just realized that he hasn't asked her about those four years she was on the run. Maybe he already knows. Or maybe he'd rather not.

Truth is, no one is perfect, and we all make mistakes that we must live with. You get to decide what you're going to tolerate and what you will kill for.

She wipes a tear from her cheek. "Then you died, and Kash…he was so hurt. And he left us. I knew Kashton loved you, and I was so mad when you showed back up with my brother." Her breathing picks up. "He was dead. I…I just want a chance to know him, and here you are, staying with him."

"Hey." I take her shaking hands in mine.

"I'm so sorry," she cries.

I pull her into my arms and hug her. As much as I don't like her, now I understand why she felt the way she did. I've done extremely irrational shit and said some horrible things to people who didn't deserve it.

"It's over." I rub her back. "Everything will be better."

She pulls away, and I let her go. Ashtyn rubs her tear-streaked face and gives a rough laugh. "Sorry, I'm an emotional wreck."

"You're fine. A lot has happened." But things are going to be different now. I feel like I can finally breathe. Evan is here trapped in a cell, my crazy twin sister is dead, and I'm married to the best man in the world.

It can't get any better.

Kashton and I were ushered into a room in the hospital wing. "What are we doing in here?" I wonder.

He shrugs. "No clue." His tatted hand holds mine, both resting on my thigh.

"Yeah, but what did he say?" I dig. "Word for word."

He looks over at me. "Just that they needed to see us."

The door opens and Devin enters, followed by Gavin.

"Is Eve okay?" Kashton lets go of my hand, jumping to his feet. "Did you find something?"

I had a checkup yesterday after my talk with Ashtyn, and they said I was healing nicely. The drug that I managed to get on my skin still lingers, but my husband is taking care of it now. He fucks me until I pass out. Plus, he's got Devin giving me IVs to help flush my system.

"She's fine," Gavin says, and Kashton falls back down beside me, picking up my hand again. I pat his arm to tell him it's okay, and he leans over, kissing my cheek.

Devin sits behind his desk while Gavin pulls up a seat on the other side of me. "You're scaring him." I try to laugh it off as a joke, like my husband is the only one worried, but I am too.

"When Bill was finally able to get you out of Dollhouse, Gavin called me, asking about your records. They both knew you had been here at Carnage." I nod and Devin continues. "But there were no records that I could find."

"What does that mean?" Kashton asks.

"At the time, I just thought Garrett had them destroyed. But after lots of digging, I've been able to locate the records of when you were here. And I found you were seeing a doctor…" Devin trails off picking up a piece of paper on his desk. "Dr. Kelly Fran."

I look at Kashton and then nod to Devin. "I'm not sure of her name. But, yes, I was forced to see a female doctor."

"What were you seeing her for?" Gavin asks me.

I sigh and answer, "I don't know." He frowns, and I feel the need to explain.

"I—"

Kashton holds up his free hand, cutting me off. "Why are you asking her this if you have the records?" he snaps. "You tell us what my wife was seeing her for."

"There are no records a Dr. Kelly Fran exists. That's why we need to know what Eve remembers."

Kashton huffs, and Gavin nods at me to continue. "Go on. What do you remember?"

"The first time Garrett took me to see her, she was here." I gesture to the room. "The hospital at Carnage. I was probably sixteen." The

days all ran together, and I didn't celebrate my birthday. "She seemed friendly enough, but I attacked her when she tried to touch me. My father choked me out, and when I woke up, I was back in my room."

"How did you feel?" Gavin questions.

"Sore for a few days."

"Sore where?"

"It…" I sigh. "It's hard to explain." My mind was foggy and my whole body hurt. Of course that could have been the fact that I was fighting her and my father choked me out.

"It's okay," Devin assures me. "Did you ever see her again?"

I nod. "Yes. The next time Garrett escorted me to the room, he ordered me to get naked and lie on the table. I noticed it had restraints on it that time, unlike the first."

Gavin nods and looks over the papers on the desk. "Keep going."

"She, uh, tied me to the table and started an IV…whatever she gave me made everything foggy. I fell asleep." I shrug it off to keep from alarming my husband. "It happened quite often after that."

Kashton looks away, but I can see his jaw ticking at my confession.

"Every time I would wake up in my room. I'd be sore for a couple of days, but it was nothing I couldn't tolerate." I look back at Devin. "Garrett never explained why or who she was. Just that it was required for me to see her."

He nods and looks at Gavin.

"What the fuck is that about?" Kashton demands, leaning forward, and I give his hand holding mine a reassuring squeeze. "Tell us what you know."

"Oocyte retrieval," Gavin says.

Kashton sighs. "Speak in terms I understand." He's on edge after what I said happened to me. I understand, but it's no reason to be mad at them. Devin never hurt me. If I ever needed to see a doctor, our fathers made sure it was someone else that came by. I think they were afraid that Devin would let my presence here slip to one of the boys.

There's still so much that I haven't shared about my past. Mainly because I've blocked it out.

Devin places his folded hands on the table. "Oocyte retrieval, also known as egg retrieval, is a procedure performed where the woman's eggs are retrieved from her ovaries. The patient is put under sedation. It's why you don't remember what happened."

I sit up straighter, and so does Kashton.

"I don't understand…" my husband says. "What are you implying?"

Devin gives me a soft smile. "Garrett had your eggs retrieved and froze them. With Kashton's sperm and a surrogate, you two can have children of your own."

Tears sting my eyes, and I try not to get excited, but this is what I want. To give him children. To be a mother to his kids.

"A surrogate?" Kashton goes on at my silence.

Gavin gets up and walks over to the door. Opening it up, Sin and Elli enter the room. Sin has his son strapped to his chest, and Elli is cradling their daughter.

Kashton stands and pulls me up with him. My hand is sweating in his, but he doesn't seem to mind. "What's going on?" he wonders.

Sin and Elli exchange a look, and she smiles when her husband starts to speak. "When I heard Devin say it wasn't completely true that Adam said Eve couldn't have children, I knew we had to do something. We've spoken to Saint and Haidyn," Sin adds. "And we want to help you guys."

I take my hand from Kashton and rub it on my legs nervously. "Help us how?"

Sin glances at me as he softly bounces the baby on his chest. "Devin and Gavin cleared Laura this morning to be your surrogate."

I look at Ellington. "No—"

"This is what you want, angel," Kashton interrupts me.

I search his hopeful eyes, and my heart hammers in my chest. How do I tell him what I'm feeling? As much as I want us to have children of our own, I don't deserve them. Not after what I did. "I…"

"I know what you're thinking." He speaks softly, and I swallow the knot in my throat. "Stop, Eve. You deserve this." Leaning down, he kisses my forehead and whispers, "You'll be a wonderful mother, angel."

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EIGHTY-SEVEN



EVERETT

I pace outside the door to the room. It's been a week since our conversation with Devin and Gavin about the possibility of us being parents.

Have you ever wanted something so badly, but you knew it was impossible, but then all of a sudden, it's not? It's terrifying.

In our world, we aren't allowed to dream. We are given what they think we deserve.

Bill's words in his office keep repeating in my mind. *"You'll get everything you want."*

I told him he *had jokes*, but he knew. He had to have. That's the only explanation as to why he allowed Kashton to marry me. To help out with my assignment. He knew that I'd get what I always wanted.

A family with a man who loves me.

So many things can still go wrong. I'm afraid to get excited or hopeful because it may not happen. Then what? I just go on with my life, knowing that it's within reach?

What if the eggs don't take and I run out? Devin said there aren't many, but that all we need is one.

Is this the Lords playing another game with me? Will this be how they force Kashton to leave me? By putting me through one last assignment that is going to break me? I put nothing past them.

Shaking out my hands, I let loose a deep breath and walk into the cold room, seeing the woman on the table. She's unconscious and lying under a white sheet. She's not dead, but I've wished she was so many times in the past.

Moving to stand next to her, I look at the woman that I begged to help me. The one person I thought would understand the situation I was in and could save me. She chose their side. She was the one who suggested Garrett place me on fertility drugs. That my body just needed a little help in order to produce children. I've hated her ever since. She recommended I see a doctor. It was her idea for them to retrieve my eggs. Garrett would have never thought of that on his own. Like Kashton's father once said, *What's the point of knocking up a woman if you can't fuck her?*

Is this what karma is? Am I supposed to be grateful or angry?

I run my hand over her dark hair. "You were right, Laura. We all must serve and have a purpose. I guess you finally found yours."

I'm sitting in my room, like every other day, when the door opens and my father enters along with the bitch who told him I'd bitten her.

My father once called her Laura.

She hates me. The feeling is mutual. It makes me so mad that my father listens to her and her nonsense.

"It's been long enough," he states. "It's time to test your theory."

"It's not a theory," she argues. "It's science."

"Here." My father pulls something out of his pocket, holding it to me. "Take this."

I just stare at him.

He huffs. "Everett—"

Laura places her hand on his arm, cutting him off, and then removes what he's holding. "It's okay, Eve. This isn't going to hurt. You just have to pee on it. That's all. I'll go with you."

All they do is hurt me. I'm covered in bruises from when they hold me down and give me the shots that they say I need.

"No." Why the fuck would they want me to pee on something? And why would she think I'd want her in the bathroom with me?

My father's face grows tight. Turning, she walks him to the corner and speaks in a hushed voice. He nods a few times, and then they both turn back to face me. "You will pee on this stick. One way or the other," my father tells me. "It's up to you."

"I'm not peeing on anything." I shake my head. Fuck them.

I will not bow down to them and their demands. I will not be the weak woman that Laura is trying to brainwash me to be. Raping your child isn't okay. Letting your friends rape your child is not okay.

I might be uneducated, but I know right from wrong.

"Have it your way." He rushes to the bed and grabs my ankle, yanking me off the mattress. I don't even have time to catch myself before I hit the floor. He picks me up by my hair and drags me out of the room while Laura follows behind.

I'm hauled into a room that I've seen before. He always brings me here to see the doctor that sedates me. I hate it because I wake up in my room afterward feeling groggy and sore for days.

He throws me onto a cold, hard surface. "Secure her arms," he orders Laura.

"Let me go," I scream while my father holds my forearms down to the metal table above my head.

"This is your way, Eve," he tells me. "Always have to do shit the hard way."

Something is wrapped around my wrists, tying them together, and after a few seconds, he releases my forearms.

I scream and kick when he grabs my sweatpants and pulls them down my legs. He takes one thigh while Laura comes to stand on the opposite side of the table and grips the other. Her nails dig into my skin, and my hips feel like they're going to pop out while they hold me wide open.

I'm sobbing, my body trembling, and I yank on my arms, but she tied them down above my head. I arch my neck to see rope wrapped around my wrists that she's connected to something under the table, making it impossible to even lift them.

The door opens and the female doctor that usually sedates me enters. I hate that she puts me out, but right now I'm praying for it.

"Will this work?" my father asks her.

"Blood work would be more efficient, but…" She nods, trailing off. "Yeah."

"Please…." I beg my father, licking my wet lips. "Don't do this." I don't even know what this *is, but I'm terrified. My heart is pounding,*

and my pulse is racing. I'm sweating and having a hard time catching my breath. "I'll…do it. I'll pee on it."

"It's too late for that," Laura says, gripping my leg tighter, making me cry out. I know this was her idea.

The doctor walks over to the table and leans over my waist, placing her hand between my legs. Her fingers are rough as she wipes something cold all over my vagina, cleaning me.

"I'll do it," I rush out. Whatever they want me to do, I'll do. "Please…let me do it."

They ignore me. The doctor picks up a little tube off her tray, and my father stops her when she pops the lid. "What is that?" he barks.

"Lubrication."

"Do it without," he commands.

She doesn't even question him, just drops it, then picks up a skinny yellowish tube and leans over me. Her hands are back between my shaking legs, and her fingers are rough as they enter my pussy.

I scream again as loud as I can, hoping someone hears me, but I know it's useless. No one is coming to save me.

"Relax," she tells me. "Tensing will just make it more painful."

"Please." I arch my back off the table, blinking through the tears. "Stop…just stop…"

"Hold her still," the doctor orders.

"I am," Laura growls, yanking on my leg while my father presses the other into the table.

As if I'm lit on fire, heat rushes over my body, and the pain takes my breath away for a second.

"It's in," the doctor calls out proudly and places something on my inner thigh. "This will hold it in place."

They release both of my legs, and I close them and turn to my side, shaking uncontrollably. I'm going to throw up. I feel dizzy, and the blurry room tilts. "It…burns," I manage through a sob.

They ignore me.

I'm quietly sobbing on my side with my arms still above my head. "Please…take it out." Whatever is inside me hurts. I try to rub my sweaty thighs together to remove it, but it doesn't do any good.

"It's working," Laura chirps excitedly. She picks up the end of the tube and holds it out to my father.

He rips open the package he tried to give me in my bedroom and holds it below the end of the tube. And my pee drips onto it.

"Get as much as you can," the doctor tells them.

The room is silent other than my cries. After what feels like forever, someone speaks over me.

"Now we wait." Laura drops the end of the tube to fall off the side of the table.

"Remove it," my father demands.

"Hold her legs," the doctor instructs them.

Laura places the stick on the counter, and they each grab a shaking leg. I whimper when her nails once again dig into my skin, and they spread my legs wide open again.

The doctor leans over me, and I feel pressure as something is being ripped from inside me. "Done."

They release my legs, and I curl into a ball, softly crying.

Laura slaps my father on the back while she holds the thing I peed on. "Congratulations, it's a baby."

"The treatment worked." The doctor nods proudly.

My father grunts.

"I told you. It just takes time," Laura assures him. "You've got a twenty-five percent chance you're the dad."

"W-what?" I ask breathlessly. A new kind of pain fills my chest. "No—"

He wraps his hand around my throat, cutting off my air and pinning my head to the table. I kick my legs and buck my hips, trying to breathe.

Lowering his face to mine, he growls, "It better be a fucking boy, or I'll set it on fire."

He lets go of me, and I suck in a breath that burns my lungs and sob. This can't be happening. I can't be pregnant. All this time, they've been raping me. I knew why, but I prayed it wouldn't work. That my body was incapable of carrying a child. I'm still one myself.

"If it's a girl, I'll take it off your hands." Laura shrugs.

My father snorts. "You already have a daughter."

She smiles at him. "Girls are more useful than you give them credit for." Her eyes slide to my tear-filled ones when she adds. "You catch more flies with honey."

He tilts his head, considering her words, and then smiles down at me. "Actually…now that I think of it, I hope it is a girl. Maybe she'll be useful and give me what you can't. I'll take either or really. A boy will give me another chance. I'll train him differently—like an animal. I'll make sure he only sees women as something to use. And I'll start by forcing him to fuck you. Maybe he'll have better luck. Either way, I'll get what I want out of you."

This woman put her daughter through hell. I know what she allowed to happen to Elli, and it makes me sick. She deserves to live a long, tortured life here in Carnage. She loved coming over here and was proud she was able to give my father what he wanted—my pregnancy.

The door opens behind me. "I thought I'd find you in here." Kashton comes up behind me. He wraps his arms around me, and I lean into him. "Devin said the procedure went well. Now we just wait."

I turn around and glance up at my husband. He smiles down at me, but it drops when he sees the look on my face doesn't match his. "Don't be nervous, Eve."

I lick my lips. *Nervous?* Is that what I am? Because I'm pretty sure I'm losing my mind. "I, I…"

"Stop." He cups my face in both of his hands. "Listen to me, angel. It's okay to be happy. To want this."

My throat closes and my vision gets blurry. "I don't deserve—"

"Bullshit," he interrupts me softly. "You deserve this. You didn't deserve what they did to you. But this…" His thumbs gently wipe the tears from my cheeks. "This is the future that they took from you, Eve, and I'll be damned if I let them do it again from their graves."

KASHTON

My brothers and I exit the Escalade and walk up to the door of the house. I knock before glancing at my watch. It's a little past noon, and he knows we're coming.

The door opens and Sin greets us with a bright smile. "Hey, my bitches."

Haidyn grunts, Saint laughs, and I shake my head with a smirk.

"Come in."

I enter first, followed by my brothers.

Sin closes the door and asks, "You guys want anything to drink?"

"No thanks," we say in unison.

We all sit down in the living room, and I lean forward with my elbows on my knees. "Is Elli going to try and shoot me?" I joke.

Easton laughs. "I can't make any promises, but I did hide my gun just in case."

Just then, Ellington enters the room. "Who was at the door…" She trails off when she sees us. Her large eyes go to her husband. "Sin, what's going on?"

"Come here." He reaches out to her, and she sits down beside him on the couch across from us.

She looks terrified, her face now pale and her breathing erratic.

"We want Easton to join the Spade brothers." I come right out with it. There's no reason to worry her. We're not here to threaten or drag anyone from their home. I know there was a time we showed up and made that threat to collect if Easton didn't deliver, but things have changed.

"What?" She shoots to her feet. "No—"

"Elli." Sin stands as well.

"You want this?" she asks with a hand on her chest. "Why?" Her voice rises. "They almost killed you."

"It wasn't like that," Sin argues.

"It was exactly like that," she shouts. "You were bleeding…your blood was all over their clothes. I watched Bill and Tyson carry your unconscious body out of that…dungeon. Gavin had to intubate you because he said your body deserved the break."

"It wasn't personal," Saint offers.

"It was to me," she growls at him. "How dare you come into my house? Two of you know what it's like to lose your wives, so have some Goddamn respect for my marriage."

"Elli." Sin grabs her hands. There's a smile tugging at his lips. He's proud of his wife for finding her voice, but he's also trying to con-

vince her this is a good thing. “It won’t be like last time,” he assures her.

“Yeah. We’ll sedate him for the brand,” Haidyn tells her.

She glares at him while Sin snorts. “I can handle it,” he tells Haidyn.

“Easton,” she snaps, “you can’t be serious.”

“Look—”

“He’s doing this for you. Your future,” I interrupt Sin. He’s not going to win with her, so I’ll explain it.

“Our future is fine,” she assures me. “We don’t need any of you.”

“If Sin dies tomorrow, you’re regifted,” I tell her.

She swallows, looking away from me.

“We didn’t come here to frighten you. We’re here to help you,” I go on at her silence. “If Sin becomes a Spade brother, he appoints one of us as your guardian.” I hold up my hand when she opens her mouth. “It’s nothing more than someone who takes care of you and the kids. There are no strings attached to it. It guarantees your safety and the children’s. The Lords can’t hand you over to another Lord.”

Ellington nibbles on her bottom lip for a second. “What about Carnage?”

“What about it?” Haidyn asks.

“We have to live there?”

“No,” I answer her. “We don’t have to live there. We just choose to.” But that’s changing soon. “You guys can stay here. Hell, you can move across the country if you want. Nothing will change.”

“But…” She falls down onto the couch, and Sin sits next to her. “Tyson told me that the Lords couldn’t find out that he was at Carnage. That’s why they had to replace his Lords crest with the original size that you guys removed when I offered to give him mine.”

“Being a Spade brother and being a prisoner at Carnage are two very different things,” I inform her.

Ellington looks at her husband. “This is what you want?”

He takes her hands in his. “I want you and the kids safe. That’s what matters.”

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EIGHTY-EIGHT



KASHTON

The guys and I are all sitting at our desks in the office when the door opens and Devin enters.

Haidyn looks up and stops what he's doing when he sees who it is. "I was about to come join you and Charlotte." He frowns and asks, "How was she?"

"Good." Devin nods. "She wasn't as dehydrated today, so it took her longer to finish her IV."

"Well, that's good." Haidyn nods to himself.

Charlotte has had one hell of a hard time, and she's not far along. The three babies are going to take it out of her for sure, and they're not even here yet.

"Here's that file you asked for, Kashton." He drops it onto my desk, and I stare at the folder. "It took a lot of digging, but it was there."

"What's in the file?" Haidyn asks.

I open it up and scan the document. Running a hand down my face, I sigh. "My father was a founder."

"A founder?" Saint asks.

I shut the file and sit back in my seat. "I started taking the enhancement after I found out Everett was one. It took me until after Eve returned to realize I wasn't having hallucinations."

"Because you already had the enhancement," Haidyn adds, and I nod.

"What about Eve?" he asks Devin. "Adam said she had a blood transfusion. Did that affect her founder gene?"

"No. She was given blood that was from a founder," Devin answers. "But she already had it, so there shouldn't have been any side ef-

fects."

"Whose?" I growl, knowing she hasn't hallucinated other than the one time the Lords forced it on her for her initiation.

Devin sighs and answers. "Adam's."

"Fuck." I want to kill that motherfucker. He gave my wife blood? I know I'm supposed to be thankful, but it pisses me off. I could have given her mine. I hate any connection that my wife has to him. Which is crazy because there was a time I would have done anything for Adam. Times have changed.

"I would have killed him," Haidyn says, reading my mind.

"Here's this one as well." He drops another file onto my desk, and I rip it open.

"What the fuck is this?" I ask, now pissy.

"These are Everett's medical records from when she was seeing the fertility doctor."

"What about the eggs?" I ask Devin, not understanding the words on the paper. I didn't want to ask this in front of my wife, but it didn't make much sense to me why Garrett had it done.

"From what I've read on her files, Eve was having a hard time getting pregnant."

They raped me for years, she said to me. It was because they weren't getting the results they wanted. Babies.

"So they placed her on fertility drugs thinking that would improve her odds. But when that wasn't working either, they decided to try in vitro fertilization."

"How does that work?" Saint asks.

"She was given hormones to stimulate the ovaries and produce the eggs. Once the eggs are matured, they are retrieved. They are then combined with whoever's sperm. Last, the healthy embryos are transferred back into the uterus." He frowns. "But from the records, they never made it far into the process. Eggs were retrieved, looks to be over two years' time, and Garrett had them frozen for future use."

"But why?" Saint asks. "They were raping her in hopes to get her pregnant while also retrieving the eggs? How many kids did they fucking want? I mean, if there were kids running around here, we

would have eventually noticed. Our fathers barely raised us. How the fuck were they going to raise all these babies?"

"Sell the eggs is my best guess," Devin answers.

"Fuck," Haidyn hisses, slamming his fist on the table.

Devin sighs. "At first it was to get her pregnant. Then they realized they could just take her eggs. Everett was extremely malnourished, which was probably why she was having trouble conceiving. When she finally started having a cycle, it was very irregular due to trauma and abuse, and her hormone levels were lower than ideal. Even if they were successful, she could only carry so many children at a time. Plus having to carry the child for nine months. All they needed were her eggs. She has founder and Spade-brother DNA. They could have sold them to any Lord…or Lady…for top dollar."

"Or to Dollhouse." Saint shrugs. "It makes you wonder, though…" He pauses, looking from me to Haidyn. "If we have siblings out there that we don't know about."

Haidyn glances at Devin. "Did they keep records? If my father paid to be with a breeder, maybe the others did too."

He shakes his head. "Not that I've found." Then Devin looks at me, and I nod that he can go. I've heard all I need to hear.

When he lingers, I bark. "What?" I'm on fucking edge right now.

"The last page," he says.

I turn to the last one and read over it. My stomach sinks as I skim over the information.

"What is it?" Haidyn demands.

Ignoring him, I continue reading, trying to comprehend it. My wife is going to take this hard. Can she catch a break? Everett deserves happiness and to move on with her life. The one I vowed to give her.

"Kash—"

The door opens, cutting off Haidyn. I shut the file, open my top drawer, and slam it shut.

Everett and Charlotte both enter with big smiles on their faces while giggling, and Devin slips out. I love to see my wife happy. She's always glowing, but there's something special about her loving life. I hate that I have to ruin her day.

Haidyn stands and walks over to Charlotte. “Devin said you were having a good day.”

“I am.” She throws her arms around his neck and stands up on her tiptoes to kiss him while he leans down to meet her.

“How about I take you to lunch?” he offers.

“Yes. Please.” She beams. “I could eat.”

“You guys want to join us?” he asks.

“I’ll check with Ashtyn,” Saint answers.

I shake my head. “We have plans with the contractor.” Eve walks over to my desk and sits on it, facing me.

We all bought the land across from Carnage and are each building a house. I’ve never had a problem living here with the guys, but I can’t wait to have a home to ourselves. My wife deserves a life that doesn’t include this place. It’s already bad enough that she chose me—a constant reminder of what our fathers did to her.

“Want us to bring you something back?” Charlotte questions, turning to face us.

“No thanks.” We’ll grab something after.

Everyone leaves the office, and my wife smiles at me, but it falls when I don’t return it. “Everything okay?” She places her hands on my face and leans into me.

I’m terrified of losing her. Those three weeks without my wife were fucking hell. I’ve spent all my life feeling alone, and having her with me has been heaven. Sometimes I wake up after a nightmare of burying her all over again. But this time, I don’t get to dig up a body that wasn’t hers.

“Kash—”

“I’m fine. Just tired,” I lie.

She gives me a sly smile and falls onto my lap while she slowly slides her sundress up. My hands go to her bare thighs, and my eyes drop to the nude-colored thong that covers her smooth pussy. “Well, maybe you should get some sleep tonight.”

I laugh at that. I’d much rather lose sleep fucking my wife than dream about a life without her. “Come on.” I slap her thigh, wishing I could toss her onto my desk and fuck her, but we don’t have time for me to play with her. “He’ll be there soon.”

She picks up her cell off my desk and smiles proudly, getting to her feet. "I've got my design ready."

Of course she does. I'm going to build my wife her dream home. It's the least I can do for the woman who showed me what living is all about.

The phone beeps in her hands and her smile grows, scanning the incoming text. "What is it?" I ask.

"Well…" She nibbles on her bottom lip. "Janice just messaged the girls in our group chat. She wants to throw a party—a big reception for all of us who eloped." Her hopeful eyes meet mine. "That's stupid, right? The other Ladies should have one. But we don't need—"

"Nothing about being married to you is stupid," I interrupt her. "I think it's a great idea." Seeing my wife dressed up, getting to show her off, celebrating a night with her friends and family. It's exactly what she deserves.

Her eyes drop to her cell, and she types back her response with the biggest smile on her pretty face.

I open the door to see Devin waiting to talk to her, and I allow him to step in, knowing her smile is about to go away.

EVERETT

"May I speak to you?" Devin asks.

My smile falters when Kashton shuts the door, closing the three of us inside the office.

I look between them. "What is it?" I ask, sitting down on the couch.

When Devin doesn't answer, I look at my husband, who walks behind his desk and opens a drawer, pulling something out. "Kash, seriously. What's going on?"

He comes to stand in front of me. "I had Devin do some digging."

"On what?" I lick my lips nervously.

"Your pregnancy."

I search his eyes, and a panic settles in my chest as it tightens. "Kash…what did you do?"

Sitting next to me, he takes my shaking hands. His pretty blue eyes search mine when he starts to speak softly. "You were never pregnant, Eve."

I rip my hands out of his. "What? Of course I was." I look up at Devin, and he just stares at me. "Tell him."

"Untie her," my father orders Laura, nodding to me.

Laura comes to the head of the table and undoes my wrists. I can't feel them. She tied them tight, and then I was pulling on them. They might as well have been cut off.

He yanks me off the table, and I fall to the floor, unable to stand on my shaking legs. A burning sensation takes over my chest, and saliva pools in my mouth. I get to my tingling hands and knees and open my mouth. The sour taste makes me gag before I vomit on the floor, unable to swallow it down.

They got me pregnant. One of the Spade brothers is the father. I can't let them do this to another child.

"Clean your piss up off the floor," my father barks at me, throwing the test and hitting me in the hair with it. "And the vomit as well." He huffs, tossing me a towel. "Pathetic." With that, they all three leave me in the room, kneeling in my own pee and vomit.

I sit up and fall back into the cabinets. My shaking hands go to my flat stomach. I won't let them do this to me. Or the baby. No one will stop them.

They are Lords. Spade brothers. They are untouchable. They keep me trapped here in this hell that no one even knows exists.

It's up to me. Picking up the test with two pink lines, I feel that burning sensation in my throat again. "I'll fix it," I promise and whisper, "I'll make sure they never hurt you."

I'll end both of our lives. It's the best outcome either one of us has at this point.

"It was a false positive," Kashton says, pulling me out of that memory.

"No." I give a rough laugh. "You're mistaken. I was pregnant." I stand, needing the movement.

"There's no record of blood work," Devin informs me.

"That's because they took a urine sample," I snap, glaring at him.

"You willingly peed on a pregnancy test?" Devin questions with a frown. "And if so, you saw that it was positive?"

"They tied me to a table and forced me to pee on a pregnancy test via a catheter," I say through gritted teeth. "And yes, I saw the test."

"Who fucking did that?" Kashton barks, reaching out to me, but I step back.

Devin goes on. "There's record of an ultrasound—"

"I did not dream this up." They're making me think I'm going insane. That it was all a lie.

"We're not saying you did, angel," Kashton says softly.

"Yes, you are," I shout, and my wide eyes meet his. "I was pregnant."

Kashton glances at Devin, who looks at me with sympathy, and I feel like I'm back in the room with LeAnne all those years ago when she and my father tried to convince me I was seeing a ghost, but the entire time it was my identical twin. And they knew it. They wanted me to think I was crazy. They were setting me up.

Devin sighs. "They were injecting you with fertility drugs to trigger ovulation. They contained hCG. That's why your body thought you were pregnant. Resulting in a false positive pregnancy test."

I give them my back and run a hand through my hair. "No." I spin to face them. "I wrecked my father's car, killing a man. It caused me to lose the baby and to need an emergency hysterectomy." I fist my trembling hands.

"Eve—"

"I know what happened, Kashton," I snap, interrupting my husband. "I was there. I went through it. That is not something you forget. No matter how much you want to." It was not a hallucination. That was real.

"After your accident, you were given an ultrasound." Devin's eyes soften. "There was no pregnancy detected. The hysterectomy was not the result of a miscarriage due to the wreck," Devin explains. "It was a punishment."

"Punishment?" I whisper, and my stomach drops. How many times have I heard that word in my life? More than I can count.

"You couldn't get pregnant, and after you tried to commit suicide, your father knew the odds of you getting pregnant were slim. By

then he had your eggs. That was all he needed. So he took the option of you having children away from you."

My legs begin to tremble in my heels.

Kashton walks toward me, and I take a step back, shaking my head. "I was pregnant." My throat closes. "I chose to…kill us…" I whisper.

"I'm so sorry, Eve." He reaches out and grabs my hand, gently pulling me into him. His tatted knuckles softly brush my hair from my face. "You were never pregnant, angel. It was just one more thing they took from you."

I sniff, and tears sting my eyes, clouding my vision. "But Dollhouse…the paperwork—"

"Fake," Devin says. "It was all fabricated documents the doctor forged for Garrett. He had them written strictly for Dollhouse. If the Lords knew that he had taken that option from you, he would have been punished, considering your status. Because to the Lords, there is always a chance, and you are a founder."

I allow Kashton to escort me over to the couch, and I fall down onto it. Pulling my hands from his, I lean over and bury my face into them.

I mourned a child who never existed? I blamed myself for years because I lived and killed my child. It was all a lie.

Was any part of my life ever real? My father controlled so much, and he still does. He wanted me to go crazy, and I hate to say that he's winning.

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EIGHTY-NINE



KASHTON

Devin exits the office, and I place my hand on my wife's knee. She looks up at me, and tears fall from her pretty green eyes. I hate this for her. I asked Devin to dig, and what he found was something I never thought of. I couldn't keep this from her. She deserves to know the truth. Better now than later. Eve hated herself long enough for something that never even happened.

"I…" She licks her red lips. "I didn't see any other option."

"I know, angel." I take her hands in mine. "You did what you thought you had to do." She was alone, confused, and terrified.

She frowns, taking her hands from mine. "It was a lie. I wasn't…" She trails off, unable to say it. "Do you know how scared I was?" She gets to her feet.

I can't even imagine. "Eve—"

"Laura told my father there was a twenty-five percent chance it would be his." She runs her hands through her hair nervously.

"Laura? She knew about this?" I demand.

She gives a rough laugh. "The percentage of my father being the father had to be higher than that, since your father preferred to fuck my ass while he reminded me how useless I was as a woman."

My teeth grind.

"My father told me he hoped it was a girl so she could give him what I couldn't—children. He was going to let his brothers rape her. He was going to rape her," she shouts, her wide eyes on mine. "And if it was a boy…he was going to train him to hate me. To rape me. Either way, he was going to get what he wanted. I couldn't do it."

She shakes her head. “Let them treat her how they treated me or turn a boy into them.”

“I know.”

“And it was a lie,” she chokes out and whispers, “I wasn’t pregnant.” Taking a deep breath, she places her hand over her mouth. “I felt so guilty that I survived.”

I step into her and wrap my arms around her shaking shoulders. What if she had died? Garrett would have won.

He wanted to control her mind and her body, and he would do anything to break her. To make her think so little of herself. Garrett hated the fact that she was willing to die to prevent her child from having the same fate she did, so he took the option away from her.

A woman in our world is meant to give her Lord an heir, and she already thought she was useless, so he made sure she remained that way. But my wife is tough, and she fought hard to forgive herself and live her life.

I will not let him continue to do this to her. She will bounce back. It will take time, but I’ll stand right beside her, reminding her she is enough. That she’s strong, worthy of love, and will be a great mother.

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NINETY



KASHTON

It's been a week since Eve found out she was never pregnant. It's been a rough seven days for her. We haven't left our bedroom at Carnage. The guys haven't even bothered us. They know the situation and that she's grieving the loss of the truth she thought she knew while reckoning with the fact that the guilt she carried all these years was baseless.

I look over to see her exit the bathroom. She's got her hair down and curled and is wearing a pair of skinny jeans, a black silk blouse, and a matching set of heels. Her makeup is done, and when her eyes meet mine, she smiles at me.

It's forced, but it's the first one I've seen all week.

"You need to get ready. We have to leave in fifteen," she says.

"Where are we going?"

Eve frowns. "You rescheduled our meeting with the contractor. Today is the day."

"I'll push it back."

"No. I want to go."

I stand and walk over to her. "Eve, it's okay to wait. He's not going anywhere."

She drops her gaze to my boxer briefs before meeting mine. "I don't even want to return to my house, and I want out of this hell before we're parents." She sighs. "I want a life. With you. A fresh start. Our place."

I nod and kiss her forehead. "I'll get ready."

Twenty minutes later, we're running late, making our way out the front, down to my car. We're pulling out of the gates of Carnage when she says, "Stop."

I slam on the brakes, and she gets out. "Eve? Where are you going? We're already late—"

She shuts the passenger door, and I do the same to see her walking over to the cemetery. "What are you doing?" I come up behind her.

"You took down the headstone," she observes, looking over the fresh grave we dug up.

"Yeah," I remark. "What did you want me to do with it?"

"I don't know. It was just so beautiful." She shrugs. "It's just weird, ya know…"

"Weird isn't the word I'd use to describe burying my wife, but sure." I laugh it off.

I've seen people shot and bleeding out, Haidyn playing dead, and Adam shooting himself until he was unrecognizable so he could put a body in his place. But with Eve it was different. There was no denying the dead woman looked like my wife.

"Why did you have it read *Everett Sinclair Pierce*?" she asks, looking up at me.

"Your father never gave you a middle name, and I didn't want to take away your mother's maiden name, so I made it your middle name." I shrug nervously. "It just felt right." My wife took my last name, dropping Sinclair. I knew how much that name meant to her, so I wanted her to keep it.

She nods to herself but goes quiet.

"Eve?" I step up to her to see her staring off. She does this from time to time, and I wonder where her mind goes. To the baby that didn't exist? To the future we're going to have?

She turns to look at me once more. "What is that?"

She points to a smaller fresh pile of dirt next to her grave.

My pulse races at her question, and I take a step back. "Uh, well…"

"Kashton." She places her hands on her hips, pushing one out. "What is it?"

I run a hand through my hair. “After I buried you, I had Sin help me with something.”

“What is it?” she demands as I try to avoid answering.

Rubbing the back of my neck, I sigh. “It’s your mother and”—I lower my voice—“the baby.”

Her face falls, and her arms drop to her sides. “Wh-what?”

“I wanted them to be here with you. So we went and dug up some dirt where you would sit at the cemetery, and I brought it back.” I step into her, and tears fill her eyes. “I’m so sorry, angel. I didn’t know about the baby at the time.” Her watery eyes search mine. “I’ve got a headstone coming for them. It should be here next week.” She stands stiff in my arms, and I swallow nervously. “I’m sorry, Eve. I didn’t mean—” She throws her arms around my neck, and I slowly wrap mine around her. “You’re not mad at me?”

She pulls back and sniffs. “No.”

I push the hair from her face. “I just wanted you to all be together.”

I buried my wife and wanted her to be with what little family she deserved to have in a different life. I know her mother wasn’t actually buried there at the abandoned cemetery, but to her, that was where she mourned a mother she never met and a baby that didn’t exist. That was where she sat and spoke to them. I wanted them to be with her.

“Thank you.” She kisses my cheek. “I love you.”

“I love you, angel.”

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EPILOGUE ONE

KASHTON

The clock on my dash shows almost ten p.m. I slam on my brakes and get out of the car, walking into the house like I own it.

A man comes rushing into the living room with his gun raised, dressed in slacks and a button-down. "Goddammit, Kash." He sighs, lowering it to his side. "What in the fuck are you doing here?"

"You texted me," I remind him. He sent me one last night, but I never responded. I was busy with my wife.

"I asked if you could meet me today at noon," he growls, checking his watch, knowing damn well it's late. "And you never responded."

"I'm here now."

Giving me his back, I follow after him.

Entering his study, I slam the door shut behind me and notice there are two other men already in here.

They both stand in front of the couch as if they were sitting but jumped up when they heard me enter. "Kashton, this is the Decker—"

"Can you give us a minute?" I ask them, interrupting Adam. Respectfully, I don't give a fuck who they are.

"Of course." One of them nods before they both exit.

"Did you find her tapes?" I demand.

"No." He answers with a shake of his head.

Of course not. That would be too easy, but I won't give up until they are all found and destroyed. "Well, since I'm here…" I don't even care why he called me here if he doesn't have what I want. I brought something of my own. I slam the file on his desk, getting to the point as to why I stopped by.

He sighs, opening it up, and his shoulders stiffen. He immediately slams it shut and leans back, glaring up at me.

"You fucking piece of shit," I say through gritted teeth.

He gets to his feet. "Kash—"

"No," I shout, interrupting him. "How long have you fucking known that Eve was never pregnant?"

"I just found out," he snaps defensively.

"Bullshit."

"I'm telling the truth."

I snort. "You're telling me that you didn't know she wasn't pregnant when we all stood in the basement at Carnage?" I arch a brow. "When you told her that she had a twin?"

He looks away, and I fist my hands. "Fucking knew it." He had a chance to fill us in then, and he chose not to. "At the very least you could have pulled me to the side and told me."

"It would have crushed her," he snaps.

"She deserved to know," I shout and take a deep breath. "I got what I wanted," I tell him. "Another thing you're keeping from us. It will never end." Adam opens his mouth to argue when I go on. "Stay the fuck away from my wife. She has a new phone number and, in case you haven't figured it out by now, she's no longer working for you." Eve isn't happy, but she doesn't want to fight me on this. She will live a life chained in our basement if that's what it takes to keep her from working for him.

He opens his top desk drawer and holds out a manila envelope.

I yank it from his grasp and open it up. "Dawson Hues." I read the name out loud. "What about him?" I shut the folder and slap it on his desk.

"You saved him."

I snort.

"He was kidnapped while he and his mother were at the grocery store when he was five. He's now nine."

"What does that have to do with me?" I growl.

"He was living with a man…a man he believed to be his brother. When that man didn't come home, Dawson went to a neighbor's

house who called the police, and one of the officers recognized him. Remembered his case."

I run a hand through my hair. I've already been here longer than I wanted to. "Who is his brother?"

"Christopher," he answers.

My neighbor kid? "So Christopher kidnapped him?"

He shrugs. "No one knows the specifics. Hell, it could have been my mother. But somehow, he ended up with Christopher."

I shake my head. I should have killed him more slowly. Without another word, I turn to leave, done with this conversation. But I stop and turn back around to face him. "How did you do it?" I have to know.

His jaw sharpens as he looks away. I begin to walk toward his desk. I'll beat the answer out of him if need be.

He picks up his cell, glances down at it, and taps away on the screen before he hands it to me.

I huff, yanking it from him. It's a video. I'm so fucking tired of watching my wife being raped and beaten. Not to mention the last one I watched where she was shot three times. "How the fuck did you get a video of it?"

"Body cam," Adam explains.

Making my way to the couch, I plop down on it and press Play. I sit motionless while watching my wife lying on the cathedral floor, all alone, bleeding out. I should have been there with her. I should have known that's where she was going.

The cathedral is filled with gunshots, Adam barking orders, and blood—so much blood. Eve's and Vivian's. Honestly, it's hard to tell the difference once the bitch is lying where my wife was, now wearing her bulletproof vest and my zip-up hoodie. Getting a closer look, I see the gunshot wounds weren't in the exact same places but close enough in order to make me think they were. Why would I even question it? A twin never even crossed my mind, but it should have. The signs were there.

I stop the video, having seen enough, and stand facing his desk. "What if she would have died while she was in your care?" I growl. "Would you have told me that I buried her sister?"

His eyes meet mine when he answers. “I wasn’t going to let that happen.”

All I can do is shake my head in disappointment and fucking rage that he took her from me. But as I look at him, I realize I shouldn’t have been surprised. He knew where Ashtyn was and never told Saint. Four years he kept that secret. I would have gone mad. Lost my fucking mind.

I start walking toward the door.

“For what it’s worth, I’m sorry,” he says.

I turn to face him so I can look him in the eyes when I say, “For what it’s worth, go to hell.” There are a lot of things I can forgive, but making me think I buried my wife for three weeks isn’t one of them.

“Kash—”

Exiting his office, I slam the door shut. I pass by the two guys standing in the living room when I hear Adam rushing after me.

“I did what I had to do. You would have done the same.”

I spin around. “No. I would never take someone you love from you.”

“You should be thanking me.”

“Thanking you?” He’s lost his fucking mind.

“Yes,” he snaps. “If I wouldn’t have stepped in, she would have been dead, Kash. I saved her.” He slaps his chest. “I fucking rushed to her side. I did that. For you.”

The fucking nerve of him. “You can say whatever you need to tell yourself. And you can believe whatever you want to believe.” I step closer to him. “I don’t give a shit if you speak to Haidyn and Saint, but you died,” I remind him through gritted teeth. “We buried our brother. And to me, you’ll always be dead.”

“And Bill?” He shoves his hands into the pockets of his slacks. “You going to cut him out of her life too? Where do you think I got my information from, Kash? You can’t cut us all out of her life.”

“Just you, Adam. Just you.” I turn and storm out of his house.

I barge into Bill's house. My second stop for the night. I'm just making my rounds while I have my chance.

"Kashton?" Bill greets me in the grand foyer with wide eyes. "Everything okay?" He looks behind me, searching for my wife.

"We need to talk."

He leans into Janice, whispering in her ear, and she nods before walking off. Turning, I follow him down the hallway and into his study. "It's late, Kash."

"You have some explaining to do." I get to the fucking point. Believe me, this is the last place I want to be tonight.

"About?"

"Whatever it is that you fucking know about my wife but have kept from me," I snap. "I just came from Adam's, and he said everything he knows about Eve he's heard from you. Why in the fuck would he know more about her than me? Her husband?"

He leans back in his chair. His eyes drop to a picture frame on his desk, and he picks it up.

"Start from the beginning. The night on the *Isabella*. My Lord was going to rape her. Was that a setup?"

"Coincidence," he answers.

I snort. "I don't believe in that shit."

"Just because you don't believe in something doesn't mean that it doesn't exist." He frowns at me and I roll my eyes. "She was still a doll at the time." Bill sighs. "Evan talked Isabella into letting him test her."

"What the fuck do you mean by test her?" My pulse quickens at his choice of words.

"She had never been out in public, Kash. Garrett kept her locked at Carnage. Then she was given to Dollhouse and remained caged. Evan had decided he didn't want to sell her, but clients wanted to see her. In person. To them, she had come so far in her training. So Evan convinced Isabella to let him take Eve to the party."

"How many?" I run my hand down my face, pacing his study.

"How many what?"

"How many was he going to sell her to that night?" I shout.

"Four," he whispers.

Evan was going to let four Lords pay to rape my girl. "I stopped him…" I trail off. "But the others?"

"As far as I know, it didn't happen."

I stop pacing and turn to face him.

"Everything became so chaotic that night. I found my best friend dead. Isabella was inconsolable when she found out Trent had been killed. And Charlotte…they needed me. I looked for Eve but couldn't find her anywhere." He sighs. "I had a deal with Trent. If something happened to him, I'd marry his wife to protect Charlotte, but Isabella didn't know that. So I went to her and told her I'd marry her to protect her from getting regifted to another Lord if she'd release Eve. It wasn't even a thought. She couldn't get rid of her fast enough, but we couldn't find Everett."

"What do you mean you couldn't find her?"

"Evan had her. It took me six weeks to track him down. He was holed up with her in a cabin. She was tied to a bed…severely beaten." He swallows. "I thought she was dead."

Eve told me there was lots of yelling and she thought she was in a cabin. Evan had drugged her, and she couldn't remember much. "You said you paid three million dollars for her," I say, trying to remember what I've been told.

"I did. I wired three million to Evan right then. But it wasn't for Everett. Isabella had already promised her to me, and she wouldn't go back on that. She wouldn't risk her life by being regifted to a random Lord who had the possibility to take down Dollhouse or overthrow her because of Eve. I paid him the money to walk away from Everett. I was walking out of that cabin with her either way. The money was an agreement I made with him to stay out of her life."

"He didn't," I grind out.

"I didn't know that," he snaps. "Eve never told me—"

"He fucking had her brainwashed," I shout, interrupting him. "You think he didn't have his claws in her? He took your money and still managed to be in her life. To him, he had the best of both worlds."

Bill looks away and I take a calming breath. "I thought I was doing the right thing."

I snort. "You abandoned her."

His eyes shoot daggers at me as he slowly gets to his feet with his hands on his desk. "I was there for her. She was in Gavin's clinic for three months recovering from broken bones, surgeries, and withdrawals."

I snort. "You're proving my point. You were playing house with that fucking bitch while you left Eve alone."

"I was there around the clock," he yells. "Do you think Isabella fucking cared that I was her husband? No. All she cared about was that she wasn't passed off to a Lord who was going to destroy her life." He huffs and falls down into his seat. "Trent let her do whatever the fuck she wanted to do. I promised to do the same." He lets out a long breath. "When Eve was ready for release, she wanted her own place. She found the house, and it wasn't much later that your fathers were killed, and Adam was on the run."

"How did she end up with Adam?" I demand. "Was that your doing too?"

His eyes meet mine. "You know how stubborn your wife is." I snort at that. "She wanted to help. Her exact words were she 'wanted to be useful.'" I get a pain in my chest at how many times I've heard her say she's useless. "The missing girls were all over the news, and she wanted to do something. I set her up with a friend who then connected her with Adam."

The detective from the private jet—Adam's boss. "And you let her go off to Vegas."

"It wasn't the best decision I've ever made."

I give a rough laugh at that and stand.

"You know how you felt when you thought your wife died?" he asks and I stiffen. "How helpless you were? That you failed her? That's how I felt when my wife was sentenced to be a breeder. I begged the Lords. I offered to trade places with her, but they wanted her. I vowed to devote my life to her kids. That I would save them." He slams his fists down on his desk. "And I failed at that too. Everett…I don't deserve the forgiveness that she's given me. And Charlotte…I had to try and save her from the future I knew Isabella had planned for her. She was hell-bent on making Haidyn pay for killing her husband. I had to choose—"

"So you chose to save the one who wasn't already broken," I growl.

"I couldn't fucking save everyone," he shouts. "I'm only one man." Taking a calming breath, his regretful eyes meet mine. "I gave her to you."

I frown, not understanding.

"While Eve was at Gavin's clinic recovering, she talked about a woman in Carnage. A woman who was caged and how her son would bring her food."

I swallow nervously.

"I knew who she was talking about—you and your mother. Then she mentioned you on the *Isabella*. She said she hadn't put two and two together at first, but that the man who saved her that night told her his name was Kash, and that was the same name of the boy—Kashton—who fed his mother." He gives me a soft smile. "I knew she needed you."

Taking a step back, I speak. "It was you. You arranged for Haidyn and me to pick up the Lord that night from the cathedral."

"I did." He nods. "The Lord was a sacrifice."

My brows pull down. "What do you mean?"

He sighs, running a hand through his hair. "Eve was in deep with Adam. I didn't know he was going to give her 'jobs.' I never stopped to think how far she would go. I had to step in. I had to stop her." His eyes plead with me to see his side. "Adam was going to get caught, and in doing so, they were going to catch Eve as well. I committed a crime and framed the Lord for it. He was sentenced to a confessional that I knew Eve would assist. I put her in your path. You had seen her. You had found her. I knew it was only going to be a matter of time before you made your presence known. But then everything with Haidyn and Isabella happened. When Sin was in my office and got the phone call for his assignment, I made the deal with Adam to save Eve. Just in case you didn't come through like I planned."

I nod in understanding. "If you controlled him, you controlled her. But I came to you…to marry her, and you acted like it was impossible."

"I wanted to see how far you'd go." He smiles. "Eve deserves a Lord who is willing to risk it all."

I run a hand down my face. "And her assignment with Dollhouse? Is that why the Lords had you help me?"

He crosses his arms over his chest. "I set that up."

"What do you mean?"

"The Lords never gave her an assignment, Kash," he admits.

I just stare at him.

"Think about it," he goes on. "Her assignment was a hallucination. It didn't make her prove her loyalty to anyone or anything."

Practically the same thing that Eve said to me the night we got married. She didn't think her assignment meant anything other than that the Lords wanted her to go crazy. "You put her through hell." My teeth grind. Son of a bitch.

"You said she could handle it," he counters.

"So what now? The Lords are going to force her to do another assignment?" I growl. She can't go through something like that again. My wife is strong, but she's been beaten down too many times. I've promised her a better life.

"No," Bill assures me. "She's been through enough. Eve gets to live a real life with someone who loves her." He smiles. "She gets to have the family she's always dreamed of."

Adam said he got his information from Bill. "How long have you known that Garrett was taking her eggs?" He fucking knew she could be a mom one day. Maybe not carry them, but have kids, nonetheless.

"Laura had a big mouth. I knew she had an in with your fathers. They had her husband, and they wanted her help with Eve. LeAnne, Isabella, they were all in their fucking pockets. If a woman wanted to be anything in our world, they started with the Spade brothers."

"Answer the question," I demand.

Looking away, he licks his lips. "I had a hunch" is all he says.

I run a hand down my face. "What about the Lords? Eve was working for them at the cathedral. How did that come about if Garrett kept her hidden all those years?"

"Also my doing." He nods. "Eve needed to appear busy. Devoted to the society. If she was working for them, then maybe they wouldn't look into her life and see she was helping Adam. So I had Isabella set it up with LeAnne for Eve to help out at the cathedral."

The doors to the study open behind me. "Bill, honey? I'm sorry to interrupt—"

"We're done," I inform Janice. I turn and give Bill my back, but he makes me pause.

"I'll be right there," he assures Janice.

I turn to him and she slips out.

He leans back in his chair and crosses his arms over his chest.

"Spit it out." He's going to tell me something that I don't want to hear.

"There's a rumor…" Glancing down at the picture on his desk he continues. "That there was another baby."

I frown stepping forward. "Who had another baby?"

"That Everett was a triplet."

"Who…who told you that?" I fall down into a chair, needing to sit.

"Vivian was allowed to run free. Word spread about the green-eyed blond-headed girl who was spotted at the cathedral from time to time with a woman. But I didn't believe it until bodies started popping up and they were targeting Eve."

"What's that have to do with a third baby?" Does this mean there's another one out there who's going to try and frame my wife?

"Supposedly Vivian talked…and, well, she mentioned another sibling." He shrugs carelessly and it just pisses me off. "Of course, you know how rumors go…"

I run a hand down my face. "Fuck." I stand and start to pace. "When is she going to catch a fucking break?" I give a rough laugh.

"I suggest you keep this between us."

I glare at him. "You can't be serious."

"I'm dead serious," he states, standing. "Eve is still recovering mentally from a past that was nothing but lie after lie. If she finds out she might have another sibling, she may spend the rest of her life looking for them. Is that what you want?"

"I—"

"What if it's a lie too?" He shrugs. "She could be chasing a ghost. She finally gets to have a family. Do you want to chance her giving that up on a rumor?"

"Fuck you." I shake my head and my voice rises. "For making me keep this from her."

Bill gets to his feet. "I just told you what I know, Kashton. What you do with that information is up to you."

I turn and exit his office, slamming the door. Starting up my car, my cell rings, and I see My Life light up my dash. I take a deep breath to calm my nerves and hit Answer. "Hello, angel."

"Hello, handsome," she responds playfully.

I smile. I wouldn't say my wife is a different person, but it's amazing how much someone can change when you show them what they deserve. Her training is going well. It's something that we work on every day.

"How was dinner with the girls?" She went out with all of them tonight. It's good for her to have relationships with the Ladies. To know what it feels like to have friends.

"Good, but my night will be better when you get home and crawl into bed with me."

"I'm on my way to Carnage—"

"I'm not there."

I frown. "Where are you?" She'd better not be at that damn biker bar. I do not want her anywhere near there.

"Your house."

"Why didn't you go to Carnage?" I ask, already knowing the answer.

"I want you to play with me."

I shift in my seat, my cock instantly growing hard in my jeans. "Well, why don't you get started?"

She laughs softly. "What do you have in mind?"

"Are you still dressed?"

"Yes."

Not for long. "Take off your clothes. Leave your heels on."

"Consider it done. Anything else?"

"I want you collared and your hands cuffed behind your back."

Her breathing picks up through the line, and I can't wait to bury my face in her wet cunt.

"Wait for me like the good girl you are at the door," I order. "Do you understand, Eve?"

"I understand."

Click.

She hangs up, and I look in the rearview mirror, relaxing in my seat. Life is going to be different now. Better than I ever imagined it could be.

Bill was right. If my wife knew she might have another sibling out there, she would dig until she found what she was looking for. That night we sat in the cemetery talking about her mother, Eve told me that she had dug into her mother's past after Bill saved her—Eve wanted to know if her mother had more children. I can't let her spend her life chasing an idea of something. And what if she tries to get Haidyn on her side? Eve needs someone to put all their focus on her and that's what I'm going to do.

I'm going to spend the rest of my life with the woman I love, and I'm going to make sure no one touches what's mine.

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EPILOGUE TWO

KASHTON

EIGHTEEN YEARS LATER

Bringing the car to a stop, I get out, grabbing the items off the passenger seat. Entering our house, I place the bouquet of flowers in the center of the kitchen island while I fill the vase with water.

I get my wife fresh flowers once a week. It's something that she once hated but now loves.

Placing them in the vase, I put it on the dining room table. The curtains are open, giving the room ample sun for them.

"MOM?" Kennedy hollers rushing into the kitchen.

"She's in the bedroom," I inform our daughter.

She huffs, tossing her hair over her shoulder. "I need to borrow her heels for tonight."

"Where are you going?" Kaidyn questions his sister, throwing his backpack onto the counter.

"I'm not telling you." She bites a piece off her banana. "Because you're not invited."

He snorts. "If there's a party, I'll be invited."

Rolling her eyes, she places her cell on the kitchen island.

"Did someone yell for me?" my wife asks, entering the kitchen. She's got her hair up in a messy bun and is wearing one of my T-shirts that hangs off one shoulder. The lack of bra makes my mouth water. My eyes drop to her tan legs, and she clears her throat to get my attention. I quickly glance at her neck to see if I left bruises last night. I smile when there's nothing there other than the necklace I gave her last year for our anniversary. "The flowers are beautiful. Thank you." She gives me a bright smile.

"You're welcome, angel." I kiss her cheek.

"I did." Kennedy turns to face her mother, answering her previous question. "Can I still borrow your heels? The red ones that appear to lace up the back?" She puts her hands in a praying position and sticks out her bottom lip.

"Of course. Whatever you want."

"Thank you. Thank you."

"You know she's just going to ruin them," Kaidyn tells his mother. "Why do you want Mom's anyway? You have an entire closet full of your own."

Kennedy ignores her brother, and he snatches a piece of her banana. "Hey. Get your own."

"See how that works?" he points out, and she shoves him.

I tune them out and focus on my wife. "Good morning, angel." I pull her into me and lower my lips to her neck, kissing her soft skin while my hands squeeze her ass. Her cell starts to ring, and I allow her to step back.

"Hello?" she answers and walks away. "Yes. We'll be there." Eve nods to herself. "Would you like me to bring you anything? I'll stop on my way…perfect. See you soon." Hanging up, she puts her cell on the counter.

"Who was that?" I ask.

Her eyes slide to our kids and then back to me before she checks her watch. "You two are going to be late for school."

"You're not riding with me," Kaidyn informs his sister.

"What?" She stomps her foot. "Why? I have to finish my makeup on the way."

"Because they're going to send you home. Your skirt is too short." He looks at Eve. "Tell her, Mom. There's a reason we wear uniforms."

"I just rolled it up a couple of times," Kennedy argues.

"I don't care. I'm not leaving school when they send you home," Kaidyn informs her.

"If they send me home, I can drive your car," she says in a *duh* voice. "And just go back and pick you up at the end of the day."

He shakes his head. "No. Last time you drove it, you blew two tires."

"That…was not my fault," she argues. Her phone beeps on the island.

Kaidyn looks down at it. "Why is Halston sending you a picture of his wiener?"

"What?" I bark, pushing off the counter.

Her eyes narrow on her brother, and she snatches her cell to hold it in my face. "It's Penny. Their dachshund. She had her puppies last week, remember? He sent me a pic of them." She rolls her eyes at her brother. "Don't go through my phone."

"I didn't," he points at it. "You left it on the table with the message open."

"You guys are going to be late," Eve reminds them and adds, "Kennedy, unroll your skirt. You can't afford another dress code violation before graduation."

"Fine." She shoots daggers at her brother as if her mother wouldn't have noticed had he not said anything.

Both walk over to Eve, giving her a kiss and hug goodbye before Kennedy gives me one as well. Kaidyn reaches out his fist, and I bump it with mine. "Have a great day at school," I call out.

"Be nice and make new friends," Eve adds with an encouraging smile.

Kaidyn snorts and Kennedy just smiles. It's the same thing Eve always tells them. In a world full of monsters, we've raised our kids to be kind and caring.

They hurry out the door, arguing, and I turn to my wife. "Where were we?" I ask, pulling her into me.

"That was Elli on the phone." She looks up at me, answering my previous question now that the kids are gone. "Calling to see if we're coming in today."

"Of course," I assure her.

Ellington finished school and became a licensed sex therapist years ago. My wife was her first patient and has been seeing her ever since.

"If you can't make it…"

"I'll be there." I've never missed a single appointment.

Ellington knows every intimate detail about our marriage. She's helped my wife a lot over the years.

It was rough when Eve first started seeing Elli. The more Everett talked about her past, the more she began to remember. My wife went so long denying herself pleasure due to years of being raped and abused. But she also craves physical intimacy. To know that not only do I love her, but I'm also sexually attracted to her. And there's nothing sexier than her on her knees begging me to fuck her. But that doesn't mean it was or still is easy for her. I may treat her like my dirty angel, but I show her all day every day that I love her.

My cell goes off, and she pulls away so I can remove it from my pocket. She glances at it and arches a brow when I hit Ignore. "I'll call him back."

She eyes me skeptically and I kiss her forehead. "Go get ready for me."

"Kash—"

"I'm going to play with you, angel." I inform her and watch her pretty eyes go heavy. "Go get ready for me," I repeat and slap her ass when she turns, exiting the kitchen.

Everett spent every day at Carnage with Laura throughout the pregnancy. At the same time, she was studying. Before our kids were born, she got her GED. I was so proud of her. Eve worked so hard and came so far. She didn't need it, but it was something she wanted for herself. I surprised her with a party at Janice's. I had never seen her happier to spend the night celebrating with her friends and family.

I exit the kitchen and walk down the hallway to our primary suite, passing all the photos that she's hung on the wall over the years.

Our kids know that their mommy didn't carry them in her belly, but that doesn't make her any less of a mother. It wasn't easy, and there were times we weren't sure we'd get to become parents. We might have two kids, but we've got a big family.

My wife has helped plan birthday parties, holiday dinners, and family vacations over the years with people that have always been there for us. Saint and I agreed a long time ago to never leave Ashtyn and Eve in a room alone. For the most part, they get along, but my wife

still has her temper, and Ashtyn is just Ashtyn. Better safe than sorry.

We have dinner with Haidyn and Charlotte at least once a week, but of course we see them every day since we live right next door to one another. I still make sure that she gets one-on-one time with her brother. They're very close, and I couldn't be more at ease knowing she has him in case something was to happen to me tomorrow.

I enter our bedroom and see Mini lying on the bed. She hisses as I walk by. Haidyn, being the nice big brother he is, got my wife an F1 Savannah cat. At first, I thought it was cute. Then it just continued to grow. Now I'm feeding it raw meat and watching my back when I get near it. I swear the thing is big enough to suffocate me while I sleep. It even has a leash for when we take it for walks. I remind Haidyn every day of how much I don't like him. And he reminds me that it's as close to a dog as you can get with a cat—it's trainable.

The bathroom door opens and my wife steps into the doorway, placing her hands on the trim, showing me what's mine.

She's fucking stunning.

She's dressed in nothing more than black thigh-high fishnets and a pair of designer heels. Her faint scars are a reminder of what I almost lost. "Come here," I order and she drops her arms, strutting toward me—one red bottom in front of the other, swaying her hips. She's teasing me, knowing I'm going to take my belt to her ass. The naughty smile on her face tells me she knows exactly what she's doing.

Coming to a stop, I brush her hair off her shoulder so I can see her breasts. Dropping my hand, I run my tatted knuckles over her hard nipples, and she pushes her chest into me, letting out a moan.

"I'm going to make you beg for it, angel."

She whimpers, her lashes falling to her cheeks. "Please?"

"Just like that," I assure her. Grabbing her hand, I walk her back through the bathroom and into our closet.

Going over to the far wall, I press in a code, and a secret door opens. Eve needed a place to be my dirty angel. With kids, we knew our sex life would be limited, but my wife isn't the kind of woman

who wants to make love. We've done it before, but she requires more than that. She needs to be owned. Used.

So while building this house, we added a basement. One that only we can access. A place where we can work on her training. Therapy helps, but my wife needs more than that.

The door pops open, and I hold it for her to enter first. I follow her down the stairs and flip the light on. We've accumulated a lot of devices over the years. I do my best to stay creative for her. There have been a few things that triggered her, but for the most part, she begs for more and lets me have my way with her.

She trusts me with her life, and Eve knows that I'd never risk that.

I walk over to the dresser that sits in the center of the room and open the top drawer. Belts of various sizes and lengths lie across the black felt. Picking one up, I face her. "Turn around. Hands behind your back."

Doing as she's told, I make her wait a few seconds while I look over her heels, fishnet-covered legs, and bubble ass. She stands perfectly still, waiting to be played with, and my mouth waters, wanting to put my lips all over her.

I lift the belt over her head and line it up with her breasts, making sure it covers her hard nipples, and then bring it around her arms. Sliding the leather through the buckle, I pull it tight and fasten it in place.

She whimpers, and I turn her to face me. "How does it feel?" I ask, pressing on the leather. They're made to be inside out due to the spikes that are pressing into her skin.

"Good." She licks her lips.

"I'm going to leave bruises on you, angel. I want you to remember who owns you."

She moans, leaning into me, wanting a kiss, but I turn and walk away. I told her she'd be begging. That is, if I allow her the courtesy of speaking. Going back to the dresser, I open the second drawer and grab the heavy collar, and her green eyes get heavier. I can't wait to see her on her knees and crying for me.

I wrap the cold metal around her neck and then sweep her hair out of the way before I lock it in place. It's thick and restrictive, allowing

very little movement. “On your knees, ass up in the air,” I order, stepping back.

Very slowly, she gets to her shaking knees and bends over, placing her cheek to the cold concrete floor and spreading her legs wide for me. I begin to undo my belt while I slowly circle her trembling body.

“Your cunt is soaked, angel. Ready for me to play with you?”

“Yes.” She moans, wiggling it back and forth.

I smile and slap my belt across it. Her cry of surprise fills the large space, and I do it again. She tries to wiggle away, and I slap her upper thighs in warning. “Don’t make it harder on yourself, Eve.”

Her hands fist and her tied arms fight the belt. I know the angle is forcing the rubber spikes to dig into her skin. That’s the point—to cause my girl pain.

I walk over to the dresser and pull out the lube along with two vibrators. Then I’m kneeling between her reddened thighs, holding her legs wide open with my knees.

Pouring it over her ass and cunt, I watch it drop to the floor. Then I coat the two toys. I hold the vibrator to her cunt and order, “Slide it in. Come on, angel. Rock back and forth. Fuck it. You know you want it.”

She moans, her body softly rocking back and forth because she doesn’t have much leverage. But she manages to do as she’s told, slowly taking a little at a time. “Look how greedy you are. Taking it like a desperate whore.” I give it a soft shove and watch it disappear into her pussy. “Good girl, angel. That’s my good girl.”

She’s trembling, body now covered in a thin sheen of sweat while she fights the position she’s in. “One more.”

“Kash,” she gasps. “Please?”

I gently rub the red welts on her ass while I run the butt plug through the lube that covers her soft skin. Coating my fingers with it, I start fucking her ass with one and quickly add two when she whimpers. “You’re doing great, angel. Take it like a good girl.”

“Ye-yes,” she agrees pushing back against me and I smile.

I pick up my pace, fucking her ass with two fingers until she’s panting. When I remove them, she slumps to the concrete, and I replace

them with the vibrating butt plug. She tenses, holding her breath as I watch it stretch her tight ass.

"Breathe, Eve. Nice and steady," I command, giving it more pressure.

She cries out, body shaking uncontrollably when I push it farther. "Almost there. You're doing great." I watch her ass close around the base once it's in. "Good girl." I tap her ass, and she flinches.

I stand up and grab her upper arms, carefully pulling her to a kneeling position. "I'm going to stand you up," I inform her, and she nods once.

Helping her to her shaking legs, I walk my wife over to the wall and order, "Kneel. Legs underneath you with your knees touching."

One leg at a time, she gets to her knees, gasping at the vibrators that fill her cunt and ass. "Sit up straight. Push your chest out." I walk behind her and pick up the chain that's bolted to the wall and connect it to her collar, making sure it's where I want it. She's not allowed much slack.

It forces her head up and arches her back. Getting the last couple of items, I kneel in front of her and slide the spiked-lined belt underneath her legs, securing it tight, holding her thighs together.

I reach up and run my thumb over her trembling lips. She parts them to suck it into her mouth. I pull it out. "Getting ahead of yourself. Don't worry, angel, I'm going to be fucking that pretty face soon enough."

She closes her eyes and her shoulders shake.

Standing, I let the gag hang from my hand. Her heavy eyes notice it and then lift to meet mine. They're begging me for it. She leans forward, pulling the chain connected to the collar, and parts her lips.

"Such a desperate toy," I say as she patiently waits for me to fill her mouth with the rubber. I gently slide the gag into her mouth, making sure not to pinch her lips. Then fasten it behind her head. Stepping back, I pull my cell from my pocket and pull up the app. I turn on the vibrator in her cunt, and she cries out through the gag.

"That's one."

She mumbles nonsense around it as drool already starts to drip onto her tied thighs. Then I do the same with the butt plug.

Her small body struggles in the belts, her eyes wide and her mouth clenching the gag. “That’s two.” I look her over and smile. “Perfect.”

I run my hand over her chin, smearing the drool over her cheeks and racing pulse. “Now sit there and look pretty while I return a phone call. Once I’m done, I’ll remove the gag and let you beg me to fuck your mouth like the dirty angel you are.”

THE END

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LORDS TREE

THE RITUAL

RYAT ARCHER — BLAKELY ANDERSON

REIGN ARCHER · ROYAL ARCHER · RYANN ARCHER

THE SINNER

EASTON SINNETT — ELLINGTON ASHER

BREXTON SINNETT · ANNALEIGH SINNETT

THE SACRIFICE

TYSON CRAWFORD — LAIKYN MINSON

HALSTON CRAWFORD · HARTLYN CRAWFORD

Carnage

SAINT CARTER — ASHTYN PRICE

TINSLEY CARTER · BERKELEY CARTER

Madness

HAIDYN REEVES — CHARLOTTE HEWETT

ADLER REEVES · KELLER REEVES · SAWYER REEVES

Chaotic

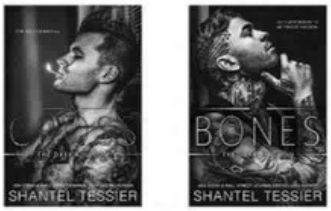
KASHTON PIERCE — EVERETT SINCLAIR

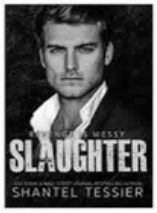
KAIDYN PIERCE · KENNEDY PIERCE

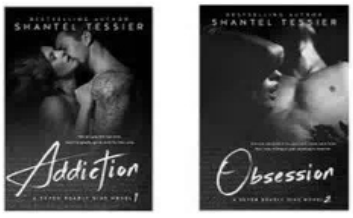
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WORLD CROSSOVERS









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Cross

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Bones

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